

A Foreword

By the Lord's mercy, in this life-study we come to the last book of the Bible, the book of Revelation. Due to the subtle enemy of God, the book of Revelation has been closed, and few Christians understand it. Hardly anyone has seen something of life, of God's economy, and of the testimony of Jesus in this book. Thus, we have been burdened by the Lord to have a life-study of this book.

Revelation is a book of prophecy (Rev. 1:3; 22:7), for the revelation it contains is in the nature of prophecy. Most of the visions refer to things to come. Even the seven epistles to the seven churches in chapters two and three, in the sense of signs, are prophecies regarding the church on earth until the Lord's coming back. Although this book is a book of prophecy, it is not prophecy merely in words, but in visions revealed to the seer. In the eyes of God, all the things prophesied in this book have already transpired and all have been shown to the seer in vision after vision.

In the book of Revelation, most of the verbs and predicates are not in the future tense, but in the past tense, indicating that the events recorded in this book have already transpired. Strictly speaking, Revelation is not merely a prophecy; it is a revelation of things which have already taken place. While they may not seem in our eyes to have transpired, in God's eyes they have transpired. In God's eyes, everything recorded in this book occurred nearly two thousand years ago. We all must believe this. Most Christians consider Revelation to be a book of predictions and they are curious to understand these predictions. Many of them read this book only for the sake of their curiosity. But we must say to the Lord, "O Lord, save us from this. We don't want to know this book in the way of curiosity." I say strongly, once again, that Revelation is not merely a book of prophecy, but a record of things which have already taken place.

In Revelation, two main things have transpired. The first is that the testimony of Jesus has been accomplished for eternity. Have you not seen the New Jerusalem? The apostle John saw it nearly two thousand years ago. Do you believe that you are in the New Jerusalem? If we appear to be crazy for saying this, we are crazy according to the Bible. The New Jerusalem, the ultimate consummation of God's work through the centuries, has been completely built up, and we are in it! According to the last two chapters of Revelation, the building of the New Jerusalem has been accomplished. This first item is on the positive side.

On the negative side, a second main thing has transpired — Satan, the enemy of God, has been dealt with. In the eyes of God and even in the eyes of our brother John, Satan has been cast into the lake of fire (Rev. 20:10). Satan, the serpent, is in the lake of fire, and we are in the New Jerusalem. Have you seen this? If we have seen that Satan is in the lake of fire, we shall not beg God to deal with him. Rather, we shall praise Him that the enemy has been dealt with. Whenever Satan troubles us, we must tell him, "Satan, you are in the wrong place. You should not be here. You belong in the lake of fire. Go back there and do not come here again." Have you ever done this? We all must do it.

The Bible is always consistent, even in the matter of Satan, God's enemy. In Gen. 3, Satan came to humanity in a very subtle way, coming in the form of a serpent. In Revelation, Satan is deliberately called "the old serpent" (Rev. 12:9; 20:2). In the book of Genesis, the serpent was not so old, but in the book of Revelation, he has become old, at least six thousand years old. With a definite intention, the book of Revelation purposely calls him "the old serpent." At the time of the book of Revelation, however, Satan is not only "the old serpent"; he has also become a dragon (Rev. 12:9; 20:2). According to Revelation, this dragon is firstly cast out of heaven and down to the earth (Rev. 12:7-9). Then, after three and one-half years, he is bound and cast into the abyss (Rev. 20:1-3). In Revelation 20 we see that, still being somewhat useful in the hands of God, the Lord will release Satan from the abyss at the end of the thousand years (Rev. 20:7). After his release, Satan will try his best to damage humanity, "to deceive the nations which are in the four corners of the earth, Gog and Magog, to gather them together to war" (20:8). But, shortly afterward, according to Rev. 20:10, the Devil will be cast into the lake of fire, which is his destiny and destination. The book of Revelation has been closed because it exposes Satan, disclosing his destiny and destination. But now, at the end of time, we believe that the Lord will open up this book and open up our hearts, spirits, and eyes that we may clearly see that God's enemy is now in the lake of fire. Hallelujah, Satan, the old serpent, is in the lake of fire and we are in the New Jerusalem!

The New Jerusalem is the testimony of Jesus. Today's church is also the testimony of Jesus. Today, we in the churches are the testimony of Jesus. We all must see this to the uttermost, forgetting ourselves, our weaknesses, our besetting sins, and even the fact that we are on earth. When someone asks you where you are, you must reply, "I'm in the New Jerusalem." In the New Jerusalem there are no bugs, frogs, scorpions, or serpents. Furthermore, in that city there is no sin, death, or world. There is nothing there except Christ and God's redeemed and transformed people. If we see this, we shall praise the Lord and shout, "Hallelujah!"

Revelation 1:1 says, "The revelation of Jesus Christ which God gave to Him to show to His slaves what must swiftly take place; and He made it known by signs, sending it by His angel to His slave, John." The revelation of this book is mainly composed of signs, that is, symbols with spiritual significance, such as the seven lampstands signifying the churches and the seven stars signifying the messengers of the churches (Rev. 1:20). Even the New Jerusalem is a sign, signifying the ultimate consummation of God's economy (Rev. 2, Rev. 22). This book, then, is a book of symbols through which the revelation is made known to us. John's Gospel is a book of signs signifying how Christ came to be our life to produce the church, His Bride. John's Revelation is also a book of signs showing how Christ is now caring for the church and how He is coming to judge and possess the earth and to bring the church, His Bride, into God's full economy.

I. A book of conclusion

Revelation is a book of conclusion. If the book of Revelation were deleted from the Bible, there would be a great shortage, for there would be a beginning but no ending. Although there is the beginning in the book of Genesis, without the book of Revelation there is no conclusion or consummation. After having a good start and after passing through so many works, there is the need for God to have a consummation. Without Revelation, there is no conclusion of God's economy. God is great; He is a God of purpose. For the fulfillment of His purpose, His economy must be accomplished. Many Bible students have neglected the matter of God's economy. If we did not have Revelation, we could not see the consummation of God's economy. In fact, we would even find it difficult to realize what God's economy is, because we would not see the result, the issue of His economy. But in this book the revelation of God's economy is so clear because it contains the conclusion of God's economy.

Without Revelation, we would also have no conclusion to the redemption of Christ. Christ came in the flesh and died on the cross to accomplish redemption. But what does redemption accomplish? To say that Christ's redemption only saves sinners and brings them to heaven is a very poor conclusion. This kind of conclusion is not so meaningful. But in Revelation we see that Christ redeemed us, purchasing us with His blood, to make us a kingdom and priests. Hence, this book discloses the conclusion of Christ's redemption.

Revelation 1:6 says that Christ has "made us a kingdom, priests to His God and Father." The believers redeemed by the blood of Christ have not only been born of God into His kingdom (John 3:5), but have also been made a kingdom for God's economy, which is the church (Matt. 16:18-19). John, the writer of this book, was in this kingdom (Rev. 1:9), and all the redeemed and reborn believers are a part of this kingdom (Rom. 14:17).

One of the main aspects of this book is that God is recovering His right over the earth to make the whole earth His kingdom (Rev. 11:15). When Christ came, He brought in the kingdom of God with Him (Luke 17:21; Matt. 12:28). This kingdom has been enlarged into the church (Matt. 16:18-19), which will bring in the consummation of the kingdom of God to the whole earth. On the one hand, the kingdom of God today is in the church, but on the other hand the kingdom of God is coming through the overcoming believers (Rev. 12:10). Then Christ and the overcoming believers will reign over all the nations in the millennial kingdom (Rev. 2:26-27; 12:5; 20:4, 6).

The redemption through Christ's blood has not only made us a kingdom to God but also priests to Him (1 Pet. 2:5). The kingdom is for God's dominion, while the priests, being those who express God's image, are for God's expression. This is the kingly, royal priesthood (1 Pet. 2:9) for the fulfillment of God's original purpose in creating man (Gen. 1:26-28). This kingly priesthood is being exercised in today's church life (Rev. 5:10). It will be intensely practiced in the millennial kingdom (20:6), and it will be ultimately consummated in the New Jerusalem (Rev. 22:3, 5).

The book of Revelation also presents a wonderful and marvelous consummation of the church. In this book we see God's economy, Christ's redemption, and the church's testimony. Without Revelation, we could read the Epistles again and again without realizing that the church is Christ's testimony. In which of the Epistles do we see the churches shining as lampstands in the dark night? Only in the book of Revelation do we see this. In Revelation, the churches firstly are the shining lampstands. Eventually, in eternity, the church will be the New Jerusalem, a golden mountain. This is the wonderful consummation of the church. The present situation is a lie, and we should not believe it. Do not just say, "How evil is the Catholic Church and how pitiful are the Protestant churches." We must look at the other side, the eternal side, where we see the New Jerusalem. Even today, during the dark night, we have the shining lampstands.

Along with God's economy, Christ's redemption, and the church's testimony, Revelation also discloses the enemy's destination. If we did not have the book of Revelation, we would not know what Satan's destiny is, and no one would be able to understand why God has been and still is tolerating the subtle, evil, dirty Satan. However, if we get into this book and see the conclusion of Satan's record, we shall be happy and laugh at the serpent. Therefore, in Revelation we have the conclusion of four major things — God's economy, Christ's redemption, the church's testimony, and Satan's destiny.

A. The conclusion of John's writings

The book of Revelation is the conclusion of John's writings. As we pointed out in the life-study of John, the writings of the apostle John are of three categories: his Gospel, his Epistles, and his Revelation. John's Gospel is for the imparting of life. In John 10:10 Jesus said, "I came that they may have life and may have it abundantly," and in John 12:24 He said, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless a grain of wheat falls into the ground and dies, it abides alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit." In these verses we see the imparting of life, which is the central thought of the Gospel of John. In John's Epistles is the fellowship for the growth of life. Although life has been imparted into us, it needs to grow. Life grows by fellowship. Therefore, in John's Epistles we see the fellowship for the growth of life. In the last category of John's writings, his Revelation, we have the reaping of life. Firstly, life is imparted, then it grows, and eventually it is reaped. Without Revelation, we would have the imparting of life and the growth of life, but not the reaping of life.

B. The conclusion of the New Testament

Revelation is also the conclusion of the New Testament, which is composed of the Gospels, the Acts, the Epistles, and Revelation. In the Gospels we see the sowing of the seed of life, for in the Gospels Jesus came to sow Himself into humanity as the seed of life, sowing Himself into a small number of people, such as Peter and John. In the Acts is the propagation of life. In the Epistles we see the growth of life. The central concept of all the Epistles written by Paul, Peter, John, and the others is the growth of life. We all need to grow in life. In Revelation we see, once again, the harvest of life. In chapter fourteen of Revelation we have a ripened field and a harvest. Rev. 14:15 says, "Another angel came out of the temple, crying with a loud voice to Him who sat on the cloud, Send forth Your sickle and reap, for the hour to reap has come, because the harvest of the earth is ripe." In Rev. 14, the whole field is harvested. By this we see that Revelation is the conclusion of the New Testament.

C. The conclusion of the entire Bible

As the last book of the Bible, Revelation is the conclusion, completion, and consummation of the entire divine revelation, the whole Bible. The Bible needs such a conclusion. The seeds of most of the truths of the divine revelation were sown in Genesis, the first book of the Bible. The growth of all these seeds is progressively developed in the following books, especially in the books of the New Testament, and the harvest is reaped in the book of Revelation. For example, in Genesis is the seed of the serpent, and in the book of Revelation there is the harvest of the serpent. Hence, most of the things covered in this book are not absolutely new, but refer back to the foregoing books of the Bible. In Genesis is the seed of the divine revelation, in the following books is the progressive development of the divine revelation, and in Revelation is the harvest of the divine revelation. Therefore, we all must get into this book and know it. If we do not know this book, we cannot be clear about God's revelation. In our travels, we often are not clear about the way, the road, until we have reached our destination. After we have reached our destination and look back upon the way we have taken, we become very clear. In Revelation we arrive at the destination of the whole Bible. Having arrived at this destination, we can understand this divine Book.

II. The contents

Now we come to the contents of Revelation. Do not think that the contents of this book are frogs, scorpions, locusts, horns, serpents, and horses. We should not even say that the contents are merely the seven seals, the seven trumpets, and the seven bowls. No, this book is not mainly concerned with these things. Revelation is firstly a book of Christ, secondly a book of the church, and thirdly a book of God's economy.

A. The revelation of Christ — unique and ultimate

The whole Bible reveals Christ. As the conclusion, completion, and consummation of the Bible, the book of Revelation especially is "the revelation of Jesus Christ" (Rev. 1:1). Although this book also reveals many other things, the focus of its revelation is Christ. Several aspects of Christ, such as the vision of Him as the High Priest in the midst of the churches, caring for them in love yet with a judging attitude (Rev. 1:13-16), the vision of Him as the Lion-Lamb in the midst of God's throne and of the four living creatures and in the midst of the twenty-four elders of the universe, opening the seven seals of God's universal administration (Rev. 5:1-14; 6:1), and the vision of Him as Another Mighty Angel coming down from heaven to take possession of the earth (Rev. 10:1-8; 18:1) have never been unveiled as they are in the book of Revelation. In this book, the revelation of Christ is unique and ultimate. In the Gospels, Acts, and Epistles we do not see that Christ has seven eyes, but this is revealed in the book of Revelation (Rev. 5:6). Christ, our Savior, has seven eyes. How terrifying! This revelation of Christ is unique. In Luke 4:22 we are told that "words of grace" proceeded out of Christ's mouth, but in Revelation 1:16 a sharp two-edged sword proceeds out of His mouth. Moreover, in his Gospel, John says, "Behold, the Lamb of God" (Rev. 1:29), but in Revelation one of the elders says, "Behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah" (Rev. 5:5). Hence, the revelation of Christ in this book is unique. In no other book is Christ unveiled as He is in Revelation. The first item of the contents of Revelation is this unique Christ.

B. The testimony of Jesus — particular and consummate

On one hand, this book gives us "the revelation of Christ," and on the other hand, it shows us "the testimony of Jesus," which is particular and consummate (Rev. 1:2, 9; 12:17; 19:10; 20:4). The testimony of Jesus is the church. Revelation presents the revealed Christ and the testifying church. In this book we have a particular and consummate record of the church. In no other book are the churches revealed as they are in the book of Revelation. The lampstands in chapter one, the great multitude of the redeemed in chapter seven, the bright woman with her man-child in chapter twelve, the harvest with its firstfruits in chapter fourteen, the overcomers on the sea of glass in chapter fifteen, the Bride ready for marriage and the fighting army of Christ in chapter nineteen, and the New Jerusalem in chapters twenty-one and twenty-two are all the testimony of Jesus. The testimony of Jesus is the spirit — the substance, the disposition, and the characteristic — of the prophecy (19:10). Christ is the Witness (1:5), the testimony, the expression of God, and the church is the testimony, the expression of Christ. As such, the church is the reproduction of the testimony, the expression of God in Christ. The particular revelation of the church in this book is very crucial, and we all must see it.

C. The economy of God — universal and eternal

The contents of Revelation also include the economy of God. God's economy is His universal and eternal administration. In the book of Revelation we see God's universal and eternal administration which is for the carrying out of His economy. Space-wise His administration is universal and time-wise it is eternal.

1. The seven seals

In God's administration the first group of items is the seven seals. A seal indicates that something is closed, concealed, and not open to the public. The first four seals cover the history of the world from Christ's ascension to the end of this age (Rev. 6:1-8). This history is briefly yet all-inclusively covered in these four seals. With the opening of these seals we see four horses, every one of which has a rider. The rider of the first horse is the gospel preaching, the rider of the second is war, the rider of the third is famine, and the rider of the fourth is death. Hence, in these first four seals we have the gospel, war, famine, and death. If you know the history of the world, you will realize that this has exactly been the situation during the past twenty centuries. Since Christ's ascension, the gospel has been preached.

Throughout the centuries, along with gospel preaching there has been war. Since the Roman Empire sent its armies to destroy the city of Jerusalem in A.D. 70, war has been intensified century after century. In the beginning of this century there was World War I and following that there was a greatly intensified war — World War II. War always causes famine, and famine brings in death. These four horses are the content of the first four seals.

The fifth seal covers the cry of the martyred saints (Rev. 6:9-11). This will occur close to the end of this age and near the beginning of the great tribulation. Due to the preaching of the gospel throughout the centuries, many saints have been martyred. Close to the end of this age these martyred saints will cry to God for revenge.

The sixth seal, taking place very near to the time of the great tribulation, covers the shaking of earth and heaven (Rev. 6:12-17). At the opening of the sixth seal, there will be a great earthquake (6:12) which will be a warning to earth's dwellers. Some evil ones say, "Who is God? We are God!" Although they may say that they are God, when the real God comes to shake their dwelling place, then they will know who God is. I have met some people who have argued with me, saying, "Mr. Lee, you preach about God. Don't you know that we are God?" I answered, "Let us see who is God. Although God has some amount of toleration, His toleration is limited. One day you will exhaust His toleration, and His little finger will shake the earth. Then you will know who is God." Before the great tribulation begins, God will send forth a warning to all the earth's dwellers reminding them that there is a God. At the time of the sixth seal, God will not only shake the earth but also the heavens. Revelation 6:12 and 13 say, "And there was a great earthquake, and the sun became black as sackcloth made of hair, and the whole moon became as blood; and the stars of heaven fell to the earth as a fig tree casts its unripe figs when shaken by a great wind." At that time, the earth will no longer be a suitable place for evil men to live boastfully.

The most difficult seal to understand is the seventh. The seventh seal, which will last for eternity, consists of the seven trumpets. Do not confuse the seals with the trumpets. The seals are secret, but the trumpets are public. When you seal something, you make it secret and private, but when you sound a trumpet, you make something public.

2. The seven trumpets — the contents of the seventh seal

The seven trumpets are the contents of the seventh seal. The first four trumpets are the judgments on the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the sun, moon, and stars (Rev. 8:7-12). As a result of the judgments in the first four trumpets, the earth will no longer be a suitable place for people to live in. The fifth trumpet, the first woe as judgment on men, will be the beginning of the great tribulation (Rev. 8:13; 9:1-11). As we shall see, the great tribulation will be terrible. The sixth trumpet, which is the second woe as a further judgment on men, is a part of the great tribulation (9:12-21). The seventh trumpet is quite complicated. It consists of the eternal kingdom of Christ, the third woe comprising the seven bowls, the judgment of the dead, the rewarding of the saints and of the God-fearing people, and the destruction of the earth's destroyers (Rev. 11:14-18). The third woe, which is the second item of the seventh trumpet, will be the closing of the great tribulation. After this, there will be the rewarding of the prophets, the saints, and those who fear God's name. Throughout the generations, these three categories of people have been produced. The prophets mostly come from the Old Testament, the saints mostly come from the New Testament, and those who fear the name of God will be produced during the great tribulation. The seventh trumpet includes the reward the Lord will give to these three classes of people. The seventh trumpet also comprises the judgment of the dead and the destruction of the earth's destroyers. The destroyers of the earth are Satan, the Antichrist, the false prophet, and all their followers. Hence, the seventh trumpet includes everything from the end of the tribulation to eternity.

3. The seven bowls

The seven bowls, a part of the negative contents of the seventh trumpet as the last plagues of God's wrath on men, will be the ending of the great tribulation (Rev. 15:1, 6-8; 16:1-21). The seven bowls, like the seven seals and the seven trumpets, are composed of a group of the first four and then the fifth, sixth, and seventh. This grouping is meaningful. Certainly the writer of the book of Revelation must be God. Who else would have had the wisdom required to write it? If this book was written according to John's imagination, then John must be God. The book of Revelation is surely composed in a marvelous way.

III. The sections

The book of Revelation has five sections: the introduction (Rev. 1:1-8), the things seen (Rev. 1:9-20), the things present (Rev. 2:1-29; 3:1-22), the things to come (4:1—22:5), and the conclusion (Rev. 22:6-21). In the introduction we have the revelation of Christ and the testimony of Jesus. Although Revelation includes God's economy, God's economy is not the crucial focus of this book. The two crucial items which are the focus of Revelation are Christ and the church, that is, the revelation of Christ and the testimony of Jesus. Following this introduction, we have the things seen — the seven lampstands and the Son of Man with the seven stars. Then, in chapters two and three, we have the things present — the seven local churches. The next section, covering the things to come, has two parts. The first part (4:1—11:19) consists of a general view of the things to come from Christ's ascension to eternity future. In the second part (12:1—22:5) we find the details of the important things covered in the first part. These two parts resemble Genesis chapters one and two. In Genesis 1 we have a general record of God's creation; in Genesis 2 we have the details of God's creation of man. In the same principle, in 4:1 to 11:19 we have a general view of all the things to come, and in 12:1 through 22:5 we have the details of the important things to come. Do not consider the last eleven chapters as a continuation of the first eleven chapters, for the general view of the things to come concludes at the end of chapter eleven. Following all the details of the things to come unveiled in the second part of this section, we have 22:6-21 as the conclusion to the book of Revelation.

The Revelation of Christ Unique and Ultimate

In this message we come to the revelation of Christ. In their reading of the book of Revelation not many Christians have paid their full attention to the revelation of Christ contained in it. This term, the revelation of Jesus Christ, is found in 1:1, and Bible students have held different opinions of its interpretation. Some say that this term means that the book of Revelation is a book given by Christ as a revelation. This interpretation, which makes the revelation of Christ very objective, is not accurate. If we read the whole book of Revelation, we shall see that this term indicates that Revelation is the unveiling of Christ Himself. It is a picture, a depiction, of Christ, not merely a revelation given by Christ. We must see that Christ is the center, the focus, and the predominant figure of the whole book of Revelation. Thus, we must take the term the revelation of Jesus Christ in a subjective way. It is not merely a revelation given by Christ, but a revelation which unveils Christ to us.

Christ is revealed in the prophecies, types, and clear words of the Old Testament. In a sense, we do not need the New Testament, for if we read the Old Testament, paying close attention to the prophecies, types, and clear words regarding Christ, we shall have a revelation of Christ. Through these revelations, we can visualize what kind of Christ is Jesus Christ. Nevertheless, however perfect are the revelations of Christ in the Old Testament, they are not complete. Hence, we must come to the New Testament which fully is a revelation of Christ. If we merely read the Gospels, the Acts, and the Epistles, we shall see many aspects of Christ, but we shall not see the aspects covered in the book of Revelation. In this message we must see the unique and particular aspects of Christ's revelation contained in this book.

I. Christ in His ascension

In the book of Revelation, Christ is revealed as the ascended One (Rev. 5:3-6, 8-14). In the four Gospels we see Christ incarnated, living on earth, crucified, and resurrected. However, we do not see very much concerning Christ in His ascension. Even in the Epistles we see little of Christ's ascension. Although the Gospels, the Acts, and the Epistles say something regarding Christ's ascension, in none of these books do we find a clear picture of the scene or state in the heavens after Christ's ascension. If we would see this picture, we must come to the book of Revelation where we have a portrait of Christ in the heavens after His ascension. In this book we have a full and clear picture of the very Christ who has ascended into the heavens. Furthermore, in this picture we see the scene, the sight, the state in the heavens after Christ's ascension. Only when we see this revelation will we worship Him in an adequate way.

A. The Lion-Lamb

In His ascension, Christ is the Lion-Lamb (5:5-6). In the Gospel of John, John the Baptist declared, "Behold, the Lamb of God" (John 1:29). But in the scene in the heavens after Christ's ascension, Christ is revealed mainly as the Lion, not as the Lamb. While John was weeping because "no one was found worthy to open the scroll or to look into it" (Rev. 5:4), one of the elders said to him, "Do not weep; behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has overcome to open the scroll and its seven seals" (5:5). Before the crucifixion, there might have been reason for John to weep. But it was foolish for him to weep after the ascension. Are you weeping today? If you are still weeping, it means that you have not seen the vision of the ascended Christ in Revelation 5. You need to behold the Lion of the tribe of Judah. Genesis 49:8 and 9 prophesy concerning Christ as the Lion of Judah, and only in Revelation are we told that Christ is the Lion of the tribe of Judah. The Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has overcome and is worthy to open the seals of God's economy. After John heard this declaration from one of the elders, he saw "in the midst of the throne and of the four living creatures, and in the midst of the elders, a Lamb standing as having been slain" (5:6). He saw the Lion as the Lamb. Is Christ the Lion or the Lamb? He is both.

Hence, we may call Him the Lion-Lamb.

Why is Christ both the Lion and the Lamb? Because we have two main problems — sin and Satan. Most Christians only take care of the sin problem and forget the Satan problem. Do not think that your husband is so difficult. Do not blame him, but blame Satan who is behind him. Likewise, every wife is good. The bad things which come out of our wives do not actually issue from them but from Satan who is behind them. The Lamb is versus sin and solves the problem of sin, and the Lion deals with Satan. As the Lamb, Christ has accomplished redemption, having washed us from our sins. As the Lion, He has dealt with Satan. He is adequate to meet our needs and to solve our problems. Now sin is over, Satan has been terminated, and we have been redeemed and rescued from the usurping hand of the enemy.

B. The worthy one

Our Savior is the Lamb as well as the Lion. We have a Lion-Lamb Savior. This One is worthy to open the scroll. Apart from Him, no one in the universe is worthy to open the secret, the mystery, of God's economy. But the Lion-Lamb is worthy because He has accomplished redemption and has won the victory over Satan. Whenever we Christians have said that Christ was worthy, our thought was that He was worthy of our praises and thanks and worship. When we said, "Lord Jesus, You are worthy," not many of us realized that He was worthy to open the seals of the secret of God's economy. We only had the concept that Christ was worthy to receive worship, praise, and thanks from us, His little creatures. But this is an inadequate concept of the Lord's worthiness. Yet most hymns on the worthiness of Christ express this inadequate concept of His worthiness. Not many hymns praise Christ for being worthy to open the secret of God's economy. This aspect of the Lord's worthiness is universal and immeasurable. Of course, Christ is worthy of our praises. He is even worthy of our lives. Nevertheless, we must realize that, according to Revelation 5, Christ's worthiness is a matter of His being worthy to open the secret of God's economy. The universe is a mystery which the scientists cannot unravel. They simply do not know the meaning or the purpose of the universe, because it is a secret kept from them. But Christ is worthy to open this secret for He is worthy to open the seals of God's economy.

Revelation 5:5 says that the Lion is worthy to open the scroll and its seven seals. A scroll is a roll of parchment paper or other material. Because a scroll is rolled up, it is difficult to determine just how long it is. The scroll in Revelation 5 is eternally long. Only Christ is worthy to open this eternally-long scroll. Do not think that you have seen everything contained in this scroll. No, we shall need eternity to see all that is included in it. When we are in the New Jerusalem, we shall still be reading the contents of the scroll. For eternity we shall say, "Now I see something more." God will give us an eternal surprise. The surprise of the opening of the scroll will last for eternity. When you are in eternity, you may say, "The Lord's surprise is eternal. Although we are now in eternity, we still cannot see the end." Christ is worthy to open this scroll of God's mystery.

C. Worshipped by the angels and all the other creatures

Because Christ is so worthy, here in this heavenly scene He is worshipped by the angels and all the other creatures. The angels are represented by the twenty-four elders, and all the other creatures are represented by the four living creatures. The angels have elders, the twenty-four angelic elders who take the lead to worship Christ. Here in this picture we see the twenty-four elders praising and all the angels praising, the four living creatures praising and all the other creatures praising. Together they render universal worship to God and the Lamb. The Christ in whom we believe is such a universal Christ.

II. Christ in His administration

Now we come to Christ in His administration. There is an administration in the universe. The universe does not operate in a nonsensical way; it operates according to God's administration. Although we cannot see this Administrator, He is nonetheless carrying out His divine administration. All earthquakes, such as the earthquake which recently hit North China, come from His administration. Christ is not only the Savior, the Lion, and the Lamb; He is also the Administrator of the whole universe.

A. Among the churches

Firstly, Christ is administering God's purpose among the churches, exercising a priestly care for the churches (Rev. 1:11-18). In chapter one, Christ is revealed as the Son of Man clothed in the robe of the High Priest. Today, in God's administration, Christ exercises His priestly care among the churches. Among the churches, He is clad in a priestly robe. Furthermore, He is "girded about at the breasts with a golden girdle" (Rev. 1:13). It is interesting to note that He is not girded about the loins but about the breasts. This indicates that all His work has been accomplished and that now He is exercising a loving care for His beloved churches. Today, Christ no longer works, but He cares for us. He even rebukes and chastises us in love. He is the loving Priest caring for His churches today.

B. In the heavens

Revelation clearly shows that, on the one hand, Christ is among the churches and that, on the other hand, He is in the heavens carrying out God's economy. The strongest proof of this is in 5:7, which, speaking of Christ's receiving the scroll, says, "And He came and took it out of the right hand of Him who sits upon the throne." The scroll of God's economy has been put into Christ's hands; He now holds God's economy and carries it out. We do not see this revelation in any other New Testament book. While Christ is in the heavens carrying out God's economy, which is mainly concerned with God's judgment of the earth, He takes care of God's people (Rev. 7:1-3; 8:3-5). This is fully revealed in chapters seven and eight. God has two peoples — the children of Israel and the redeemed saints. No matter how much this earth is judged by Christ in God's administration, He will take care of the chosen Israel and of the redeemed church. Hallelujah, we all are under Christ's care in His administration. I strongly believe that today Christ is caring for the nation of Israel. It does not matter what the other nations say or do, for the nation of Israel is under the care of Christ's universal administration. The other countries may try certain things, but all will be in vain because of the watchful concern of the universal Administrator. We all must worship Christ as the Administrator, as the One in the heavens administering all things for the fulfillment of God's economy.

III. Christ in His coming back

A. Secret as a thief

No book reveals Christ's coming back as clearly as the book of Revelation does. This book reveals that Christ's coming back has two aspects — a secret aspect and a public aspect. This is possible because Christ is wonderful. Firstly, Christ will come back secretly as a thief (Rev. 3:3b; Rev. 16:15). No thief tells you in advance the time of his arrival. In His secret coming as a thief, Christ will come to steal the precious things. No thief steals things that are without value. Thieves only come to steal what is valuable. Christ tells us to be watchful, saying, "If therefore you will not watch, I will come as a thief, and you shall by no means know at what hour I will come upon you" (3:3b). The time of His secret coming is unknown. We all must ask ourselves, "Am I precious? Am I worthy of being stolen by Christ in His secret coming?"

B. Open on the cloud

At the close of the great tribulation, Christ will come openly on the cloud (Rev. 1:7; 14:14). Among Christians, there are two concepts of Christ's second coming. According to one concept, Christ will come before the tribulation, and according to the other concept, His coming will be after the tribulation. Because many Christians have not seen the two aspects of Christ's coming — the secret aspect and the open aspect — they have been fighting amongst themselves. Both the coming before the tribulation and the coming after the tribulation have some basis in the Scriptures. But, having tunnel vision, most Christians have not seen the whole view of Christ's coming back. Firstly, Christ will come secretly and then He will come publicly. His secret coming will be for the overcoming saints, and His public coming will be for all the earth. Thus, 1:7 says, "Behold, He comes with the clouds, and every eye shall see Him." When Christ comes on the cloud, the earth will see Him. We must be clear that Christ's coming back will firstly be concealed and eventually it will be manifested openly and publicly.

IV. Christ in His judgment

In a very positive sense, the book of Revelation is a book of judgment. Christ, God's Administrator, will judge everything. Firstly, He judges the church, and afterwards, He will judge the world.

A. On all the world

Christ will judge all the world by the sixth seal, the seven trumpets, and the seven bowls (Rev. 6:12-17; 8:1-2, 12; 11:14-15; 15:1, 7-8; 16:1-21). During the more than nineteen centuries since Christ's ascension, the world has been punished by natural calamities. But from the opening of the sixth seal, the world will be punished by supernatural calamities. Revelation 6:12 and 13 say, "And I saw when He opened the sixth seal, and there was a great earthquake, and the sun became black as sackcloth made of hair, and the whole moon became as blood; and the stars of heaven fell to the earth as a fig tree casts its unripe figs when shaken by a great wind." The sun becoming black as sackcloth, the moon becoming as blood, and the stars falling to the earth are supernatural calamities. The seven trumpets will also be supernatural calamities. The first four trumpets will bring forth judgment on the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the sun, moon, and stars. The great tribulation will begin with the fifth trumpet, continue with the sixth trumpet, and be concluded with the seven bowls of the seventh trumpet. All these are the judgments executed by Christ on the world.

B. On the great Babylon

In Revelation 17 and 18 we see the judgment on the great Babylon, which is apostate Christendom. Besides His judgment upon the whole world, the Lord will execute a special judgment upon Christendom, Babylon the Great.

C. On Antichrist, the false prophet, Satan, and their followers

Christ's judgment will also be upon Antichrist, the false prophet, Satan, and their followers (Rev. 19:11-21; 20:1-3, 7-10). The Antichrist is the man of sin (2 Thes. 2:3) and the little horn (Dan. 7:8), and the false prophet is the one who works with the Antichrist. The Antichrist, the false prophet, and Satan are devilishly triune and form a counterfeit trinity. Because the Antichrist will be so enticing and attractive, he will have a great following. But all his followers will be destroyed along with the Antichrist, the false prophet, and Satan. Christ will judge the Antichrist and the false prophet by means of supernatural calamities: the earth will open and they will fall directly into the lake of fire. They will not die, be buried and resurrected, and then face the judgment at the great white throne. In their case, there will not be the need for these procedures. They will fall into the lake of fire supernaturally.

D. On the dead

Lastly, as God's Administrator, Christ will judge the dead (Rev. 20:11-15). Do not think that if you die everything will be all right. You may desire to die, but the Lord wants to make you alive. If you are not willing for Him to enliven you today for salvation, at the end of the old creation He will resurrect you for judgment. At that time, He will not resurrect you in a positive sense but in a negative sense. John 5:28-29 say, "An hour is coming in which all who are in the tombs shall hear His voice, and shall come forth...those who have done the evil to the resurrection of judgment." The unbelieving dead will not remain buried for eternity. They will be resurrected, judged, and then cast into the lake of fire.

V. Christ in His possession of the earth

At the completion of His judgment of the world, Christ will come back to take full possession of the earth (Rev. 10:1-7; 18:1). The whole earth will belong to Him; not one part of it will belong to anyone else. Today many nations are fighting to increase their territory, but they are fighting in vain, for whatever they gain will eventually belong to Christ. In His coming back to take possession of the earth, Christ will be like another Angel. A number of times in the book of Revelation the title, "another Angel," is used with respect to Christ (Rev. 7:2; 8:3; 10:1; 18:1). This title is used to denote Christ because, as God's Administrator, He behaves like an angel. In the Old Testament, Christ was called the Angel of the Lord (Gen. 22:11-12; Exo. 3:2-6) who was sent by God to carry out God's commission. When He comes to take over the earth, He will come as One who has been commissioned by God for this purpose. He will be another Angel with great authority and will come in His glory (18:1). In His coming, Christ will place "His right foot on the sea and the left on the land" (10:2). This indicates that He will tread upon the sea and the land, which means that He will take possession of them (Deut. 11:24; Josh. 1:3). In the Bible, whatever your feet tread upon becomes your possession. Since Christ will tread upon the sea and the land, both the sea and the land will belong to Him. After Christ possesses the earth, He will finish the mystery of God (Rev. 10:7). At that time, the economy of God will be fully manifested. It will no longer be a mystery, but an open secret.

VI. Christ in His reigning in the kingdom

After Christ takes possession of the earth, He will reign over the earth as the King in the kingdom, ruling over the nations with His overcoming believers (Rev. 20:4, 6; 2:26-27). None of us are happy with the rulers of this earth. As one who has traveled throughout the world and who has come to know the world situation, I realize that as far as ruling is concerned, the entire earth is poor. Where are the proper rulers? We are awaiting the day when Christ will come as the King to reign over the earth. Christ will reign in His kingdom, and we shall be His co-kings.

VII. Christ in His centrality and universality in eternity

Ultimately, in the book of Revelation we see Christ in His centrality and universality in eternity. In eternity, Christ will be everything. He will be the centrality and universality in the New Jerusalem (Rev. 21:9-10, 23) as the tree of life growing in the river of water of life (Rev. 22:1-2). In Rev. 21:23 we have a clear picture of the centrality and universality of Christ. Here we see that God is the light and that Christ, the Lamb, is the lamp. Light is always contained in a lamp. Thus, the light and the lamp should never be separated; they must remain one. God is the light, Christ is the lamp, and the New Jerusalem is the container of this lamp. God shines in and through Christ, and Christ shines in and through the New Jerusalem. By this we see that Christ will be the centrality and universality of the coming eternity. God in Christ and Christ in the redeemed ones will shine throughout eternity. This will be the scene in eternity when Christ will be the center, the circumference, and everything in the New Jerusalem. This is our Christ.

The Testimony of Jesus Particular and Consummate

The book of Revelation firstly reveals Christ, and secondly the testimony of Jesus. In other words, this book is concerned with Christ and the church. In Revelation, Christ and the church are revealed in a unique and particular way. In the last message we pointed out that many aspects of Christ which are not found in other books in the Bible are unveiled in Revelation. The same is true with the church. The book of Revelation unfolds the church in a very particular way. In this message we shall present a summary of the aspects of the church found in Revelation, while in later messages we shall cover the details.

I. The lampstands

Firstly, in Revelation the churches are unveiled as being the lampstands (Rev. 1:11-20). In no other New Testament book is this term used with respect to the church. In other books we are told that the church is the gathering of God's chosen ones, that it is the Body of Christ, and that it is the house of God. But apart from Revelation, we are not told that the church is the lampstand. As the lampstands, the churches shine in the darkness. The word lampstand enables us to understand much about the church and its function. The church is not the lamp; it is the lampstand, the stand which holds the lamp. Without the lamp, the lampstand is vain and means nothing. But the lampstand holds the shining lamp. As we saw in the preceding message, God is the light and the Lamb is the lamp (Rev. 21:23). Thus, Christ is the lamp, and the church is the lampstand holding the lamp. God is in Christ and Christ as the lamp is held by the stand to shine out God's glory. This is the testimony of the church.

A. Golden (divine) in nature

As the local churches, the lampstands are golden in nature. In typology, gold signifies divinity, the divine nature of God. All the local churches are divine in nature; they are constituted with the divine nature of God. To say this is absolutely scriptural, for the book of Revelation says that the local churches are golden lampstands (1:20). These stands are not built of clay, wood, or any inferior substance; they are constructed out of pure gold. This means that all the local churches must be divine. Without divinity, there can be no church. Although the church is composed of humanity with divinity, humanity should not be the basic nature of the local churches. The basic nature of the local churches must be divinity, God's divine nature. By these two simple words — golden lampstands — we realize a great deal about the church: that the church is something shining with Christ and that it is constituted with the divine nature.

B. Shining in darkness

The lampstands shine in the darkness. If there were no darkness, there would be no need for the shining of the light of the lamp. The shining of the lamp is quite particular. In order for the lamp to shine, it must have oil burning within it. If the oil burns within the lamp, the light will shine out through all the darkness. This is the function of the church. The function of the church is not simply to preach or to teach doctrine. In the dark night of this age, the church must shine out the very glory of God. This is the testimony of the church.

C. Identical with one another

All the lampstands are identical with one another. Many Christians, having taken in a mistaken concept, desire to be different from other Christians. When I came to this country fourteen years ago, I met some dear Christians who were troubled because the local churches were all the same. They told me that they would try their best to be different. This is not right. Everyone has a head, two shoulders, two arms, two hands, and ten fingers, and every human head has seven holes: two ears, two eyes, two nostrils, and a mouth. It is ridiculous to say, "I don't want to have the same appearance as others. In order to be different, I would like to have five holes in my head." How ridiculous this is! Those who claim that every local church should be unique base their concept upon the differences among the seven churches in Revelation 2 and 3. Some have said, "Look! All the seven churches are different." In the early years, when I was very young, I was influenced by this concept and I taught the same thing. But one day the light dawned upon me and I saw that all the differences in the local churches in Revelation 2 and 3 are negative, not positive. Ephesus lost her first love — negative; Pergamos is worldly — negative; Thyatira is demonic — negative; and Laodicea became lukewarm — negative. On the positive side, however, all the local churches are identical, because they all are seven golden lampstands. If you could place all the seven lampstands on a table before you, unless you numbered or labeled them, you would be unable to tell them apart. All the seven lampstands are the same.

Nevertheless, since 1962, some voices in this country have declared loudly that they will never be like the church in Los Angeles. Where are those voices today? They have faded away, and all the peculiar concepts they advocated have failed. I am not saying that all must follow the church in Los Angeles. But if Los Angeles has seven "holes," then it would be ridiculous for others to insist upon having five "holes." On the positive side, all the local churches must be identical. On the negative side, however, they are different. If the church in Los Angeles would worship idols, then we must refuse to follow them. In matters such as this, we must be different. But it is wrong to say that, on the positive side, the local churches should not be the same. We should not try to make ourselves peculiar or different — this is pride. One day the Lord showed me that the four sides of the New Jerusalem are exactly the same. Each side of the wall is built with the same material — jasper. It is not that one side is built with jasper and the other sides with brass. No, all four sides are the same. Likewise, universally, all the churches must be the same. They need not be the same in organization, but they must be identical in appearance. For example, the churches in New Zealand should be the same as the churches in Japan. Because we all are one church, all the churches on earth should be universally the same. Locally, we are the churches; universally, we are the church. This is the testimony of Jesus.

II. The great multitude

In Rev. 7:9-17 we see the testimony of Jesus as the great multitude. According to the record of chapter seven, this great multitude is the whole Body of God's redeemed ones, having been redeemed "out of every nation and all tribes and peoples and tongues" (7:9). All of them have passed through tribulation. This indicates that at no time nor at any place is there a church which has not passed through tribulation. The world always persecutes the churches (John 16:33). Wherever the church is, there will always be a certain amount of persecution. That the whole Body of the redeemed ones will pass through tribulation is indicated by 7:14, which says, "These are those who come out of the great tribulation." This great multitude has come out of tribulation in a victorious way, for they all hold palm branches which signify their victory over tribulation (7:9). Eventually, in eternity, they will be overshadowed by God with His tabernacle. As 7:15 says, "He who sits upon the throne shall spread His tabernacle over them." This is the destiny of God's redeemed ones. How wonderful! Furthermore, they will also be shepherded by the Lamb at the springs of waters of life for eternity (7:17).

Revelation 7:9-17 does not portray a particular group of believers. Rather, it presents a general record of the whole Body of God's redeemed ones and their state in eternity. In eternity, their state will be that of enjoying God's overshadowing and Christ's shepherding. This is our destiny. This portion of the Word reveals that while Christ is executing God's judgment upon mankind, He will take care of God's redeemed ones. All God's redeemed ones eventually will be raptured to the throne of God and will stand there enjoying God's overshadowing and the Lamb's shepherding.

III. The woman with the man-child

A. The woman

In Rev. 12:1-17 we see another symbol of the church: the woman with the man-child. The church is not only the lampstand and the great redeemed multitude; it is also the greater part of the woman with the man-child. No human mind would ever conceive of the church in this way. The woman in this chapter represents the whole Body of God's people, and the man-child represents the stronger part of God's people. As there is the man-child within the woman, so among God's people there is a stronger part. This woman, who is bright with the sun, the moon, and twelve stars (12:1) and who is persecuted by Satan, the great red dragon, represents God's people throughout all the generations. In every generation, a portion of God's people has always been persecuted by Satan. Nevertheless, during the three and a half years of the great tribulation she will be protected by God from the attack of the serpent.

B. The man-child

As we have seen, the man-child is the stronger part of the people of God. Among the people of God, even among us in the Lord's recovery today, there is the stronger part. This stronger part will be raptured to the throne of God before the great tribulation. In other words, the woman will be left on earth to pass through the tribulation, but the stronger part, the man-child, will be raptured to the throne of God before the tribulation. Why will the man-child be raptured prior to the tribulation? Because God needs the man-child to fight Satan in the heavens and to cast him down. Although God has many angels who will fight against Satan, the final victory over the enemy will not be gained by the angels but by the man-child. God needs the man-child. God will shame Satan by using the very man Satan corrupted to defeat him. God may say, "Satan, you have corrupted the man I created. But I have got a man-child out of this corrupted man to defeat you. And he will not mainly defeat you on earth but in heaven." The man-child will fight through and up, fighting up to the throne to cast Satan down from the heavens to the earth. This is a part of the testimony of Jesus. Although Jesus has defeated Satan on the cross, there is still the need for the church to execute His victory over the enemy. Because so many members of the Body have failed in this matter, only the stronger part of the Body, the man-child, will execute Christ's victory over Satan. The man-child will be raptured to the heavens to accomplish this job.

The rapture is not merely for our blessing. We should not just say, "How good it is for me to be raptured to the heavens!" We must realize that God has a need for us to be raptured — we must be raptured to heaven that we might fight against the enemy. If when you hear this you say, "I don't want to go there and be involved in a war," this means that you are not qualified to be raptured before the tribulation. If you do not go to heaven to meet Satan and cast him down, then he will come down to the earth to meet you and overcome you. We must be the man-child. I earnestly desire to be a part of the man-child. I am not satisfied simply to be a part of the woman. I want to be included in that stronger part. This also is an aspect of the testimony of Jesus.

IV. The firstfruits and the harvest

Now we come to the firstfruits and the harvest (14:1-5, 14-16). The church is not only the lampstand shining and the man-child fighting, but also a field growing a crop which must ripen and become mature. Any crop which is still green is too tender to be harvested. But once the crop has ripened in the field, it will be harvested immediately.

A. The firstfruits

That part of the crop which ripens first is called the firstfruits. The firstfruits will be raptured to Zion in the heavens before the great tribulation. As 14:4 points out, the firstfruits are those who "follow the Lamb wherever He may go." Being the firstfruits, they are raptured to the house of God in Zion as the fresh enjoyment to God. This is for God's satisfaction. According to the type in the Old Testament, the firstfruits of the ripened harvest were not taken to the barn but into the temple of God (Exo. 23:19). This indicates that all the early overcomers will be taken up to the house of God in heaven for God's enjoyment. The rapture is not mainly for our enjoyment but for God's enjoyment. The rapture is for defeating the enemy and for satisfying God. We must not only be today's lampstands but also today's man-child to fight against God's enemy and today's firstfruits to satisfy God's desire.

B. The harvest

Following the firstfruits, in chapter fourteen, we have the harvest. Verse 15 says, "Another angel came out of the temple, crying with a loud voice to Him who sat on the cloud, Send forth Your sickle and reap, for the hour to reap has come, because the harvest of the earth is ripe." The harvest will be reaped near the end of the great tribulation. It will be raptured to the air where Christ will be on the cloud. Why will the harvest be left to pass through the great tribulation? Because green, unripened fields need strong sunshine in order to ripen. In a sense, the great tribulation will be the strong sunshine which will ripen all the saints who will not be ready before the tribulation. To put it simply, if today you do not give up the world and live for Christ, Christ will leave you on earth to pass through the great tribulation. At that time, you will surely give up the world and realize that the best way to live is to live for Christ. All the children of God must do this; otherwise, they could never ripen. If you do not believe my word, I ask you to wait. Perhaps you feel that the world is too lovely to give up. If so, the Lord may say, "Since you love the world so much, I will leave you with the world and let you find out whether it is really lovely." Then the Lord will shake the world, and eventually you will say, "Lord, I repent." That repentance, however, may be rather late. Do not wait until the great tribulation comes to repent. Repent now! Sooner or later, every real Christian must repent. I have the full assurance that eventually every saved one will realize that the world is not lovely but poisonous. The more you love the world, the more you are poisoned by it. The world is at enmity with God, and we all must despise it. Sooner or later, the Lord will cause you to realize how much He hates this world. The day will come when all of us will be ripe. But do not say, "I don't care about being ripe. As long as I'm saved, everything will be all right." You may be able to argue against me with your strong, stubborn will, but the day will come when you will realize that you need to ripen. I advise you not to wait for the harvest. By His grace, come forward to be a part of the firstfruits.

V. The overcomers over the beast

In Rev. 15:2-4 we see the overcomers over the beast. God is sovereign. Even during the time of the great tribulation, there will be some overcomers, those whom we may call the late overcomers. These overcomers will pass through the great tribulation in which the Antichrist, the beast, will compel people to worship him as God and to worship his image in the temple of God. We expect to see the rebuilding of the temple in Israel, for this will be a sign that the Lord's coming back is very near. The Bible prophesies that Antichrist will erect his image in the temple of God and will force people to worship it (Matt. 24:15). During that time, many Christians will overcome the beast and be killed. I advise you to be an early overcomer and to love the Lord today. Do not wait to overcome by being killed during the great tribulation.

According to chapter fifteen, the later overcomers will be raptured to stand on the glassy sea, "a sea of glass mingled with fire" (15:2), and will praise God with the song of Moses and the song of the Lamb (15:3). Those on the glassy sea are those who have "the victory over the beast, and over his image, and over his mark, and over the number of his name" (15:2). These are they who overcome the beast, his image, and the worship of the idol of the Antichrist. Revelation 20:4 and 6 indicate that some of the co-kings of Christ will be these late overcomers. I say again that I prefer to be an early overcomer, not a late one. If you are sloppy, you will be left to pass through the great tribulation. We all must look to the Lord and say, "Lord, I want to be an early overcomer." We shall cover the details when we come to Revelation 15 in this life-study.

VI. The Bride

In Rev. 19:7-9 we see the church as the Bride. Eph. 5 reveals that the church is the Bride of Christ, but it does not reveal the Bride in such an intimate way. But in Rev. 19 we see how intimate is the church as the Bride. In this portion of the Word we see that the Bride will wear bright raiment, being clothed with bright and pure righteousness, and will be invited to the marriage feast of the Lamb (vv. 7-9). This is a very intimate matter. To God's enemy, we must be the man-child; for God's satisfaction, we must be the firstfruits; and for Christ, we must be the Bride. When we are eager to be the Bride, Christ will receive His satisfaction. Not only will Christ be satisfied, but we ourselves will be glad. Revelation 19:7 says, "Let us rejoice and exult." In principle, a bride is the most pleasant and happy person. Today, as the church, Christ's counterpart, we are suffering and undergoing many dealings. But the day is coming when there will be no more persecutions, sufferings, or dealings. I have never seen a bride who was dealt with on her wedding day. Oh, we must be the Bride! When we have become the Bride, all the difficult dealings will be over.

VII. The army

The church is also the army (Rev. 19:14-19; 17:14). The part of the church which will be the man-child to fight against the enemy in the heavens will also be the army to fight with Christ against Satan on earth. After all the raptures have been completed and after the believers have been judged at the judgment seat of Christ, all the overcomers will come back to the earth with Christ as His army to fight against the Antichrist and his army. Both Christ and Antichrist will have an army. Although one army is heavenly and the other is earthly, both will fight on the earth. In other words, Antichrist will fight against Christ and His army, and Christ will fight back with His army. The false Christ will be so bold as to fight against the real Christ, but the real Christ will war against the false one. In 17:14 we see that Christ's heavenly army will be composed of all the overcomers, those who have been called and chosen. Eventually, at the end of this war, Christ will defeat the Antichrist.

VIII. The New Jerusalem

Ultimately, the testimony of Jesus will be the New Jerusalem (Rev. 21:1-27; 22:1-5). Beginning with the lampstand and passing through the great multitude, the man-child, the firstfruits, the late overcomers, the Bride, and the army, all the saved ones will eventually be the New Jerusalem, which will be a living composition of all of God's redeemed ones, the ultimate consummation of God's building of His people. In and for eternity, the New Jerusalem will express God in the Lamb with the flow of the Spirit. When we come to chapters twenty-one and twenty-two, we shall see a clear picture of this ultimate consummation.

The Triune God in Revelation

The whole Bible is the revelation of God. In the book of Revelation we have the ultimate and complete revelation of who God is. God is triune. We all are familiar with the term the Triune God. This is a great matter in God's revelation. Throughout the centuries, however, most Christians have not fully realized the meaning of the term the Triune God. In the book of Revelation, the book which reveals things in an ultimate way, we see something deeper, higher, richer, and sweeter concerning the Triune God. We have seen that in Revelation, the revelation of Christ and the testimony of Jesus are ultimate. In this message, we need to see that here the revelation of the Triune God is also ultimate.

Revelation 1:4 and 5 say, "Grace to you and peace from Him who is, and who was, and who is coming, and from the seven Spirits who are before His throne, and from Jesus Christ, the faithful Witness, the Firstborn of the dead, and the Ruler of the kings of the earth." He "who is and who was, and who is coming" is God the eternal Father. "The seven Spirits" who are before God's throne are the operating Spirit of God, God the Spirit. Jesus Christ, who is to God "the faithful Witness," to the church "the Firstborn of the dead," and to the world "the Ruler of the kings of the earth," is God the Son. This is the Triune God. As God the eternal Father, He was in the past, He is in the present, and He is coming in the future. As God the Spirit, He is the sevenfold, intensified Spirit for God's operation. As God the Son, He is "the Witness," the testimony, the expression of God; "the Firstborn of the dead" for the church, the new creation; and "the Ruler of the kings of the earth" for the world. From such a Triune God, grace and peace are imparted into the churches.

I. The Almighty God

The book of Revelation tells us that God is the Almighty God (Rev. 1:8; 19:6, 15). In the Hebrew language, the title God means the mighty One, the One who is powerful. But in Revelation we see that God is not only mighty, but Almighty. He is powerful in every way, in every aspect, in everything, and with everyone. God's title means that He is the Almighty One.

A. The Lord

This Almighty One is the Lord. Being the Lord means that He is the owner of the universe. We may say that He is the landlord of the whole universe. He is the Ruler, the authority, in this universe. What we or others say means nothing. But what God says means everything because He is the Lord. When He says, "Yes," it means yes, and when He says, "No," it means no. God is not only the Lord, the owner, and the authority; He is also the Master. The whole universe, including the angels and all human beings, is under Him. We have a Master who possesses us. Before I was saved, I did not know to whom I belonged. But now I can shout, "God is my Master, the One who possesses me. Hallelujah, He is my Lord!"

B. The Alpha and the Omega

Rev. 1:8 says that the Lord God is the Alpha and the Omega. The eternal and Almighty God is the Alpha, the beginning for the origination, and the Omega, the ending for the completion of His eternal purpose. In the book of Genesis He was the Alpha, and now in the book of Revelation He is the Omega. Whatever He has originated He will complete. Governmentally, He continues His universal operation which He originated from eternity and will bring to completion (Rev. 21:6).

C. Who is, who was, and who is coming

God is also the One who is, who was, and who is coming. This is the meaning of the name Jehovah. In Hebrew, Jehovah means, "I am that I am." His being the I Am signifies that He is the One who exists from eternity to eternity. His title, I Am, not only indicates that He exists but that, in a positive sense, He is everything. He is life, light, and every other positive thing. Do you need life? God is life. Do you want light? God is light. Do you desire holiness? God is holiness. God exists from eternity to eternity and He is everything. This is our God.

As we have seen, our God is triune. His being triune means that He is the Father, the Son, and the Spirit. It is impossible for us to understand the Triune God thoroughly, for the divine Trinity far surpasses our mentality. Do not exercise your mentality so much. Rather, exercise your spirit to realize and experience the Triune God as the Father, Son, and Spirit.

II. The Father

Firstly, the very Almighty God is the Father. The Father is nothing less than God Himself. His being the Father means that He is the source. The Father is also the Lord, and, as 1:4 makes clear, He is the One who is, who was, and who is coming.

III. The Spirit

In Revelation, the sequence of the Triune God is different from that found in Matthew. In Matt. 28:19 the sequence of the Triune God is the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. But in Rev. 1:4-5 the sequence is changed. The seven Spirits of God are listed in the second place instead of the third. This reveals the importance of the intensified function of the sevenfold Spirit of God. This point is confirmed by the repeated emphasis on the Spirit's speaking in Rev. 2:7, 11, 17, 29; 3:6, 13, 22; 14:13; 22:17. At the opening of the Epistles, only the Father and the Son are mentioned, from whom grace and peace are given to the receivers. Here, however, the Spirit is also included, from whom grace and peace are imparted to the churches. This also signifies the crucial need of the Spirit for God's move to counteract the degradation of the church.

A. The seven Spirits of God

Let us now see why in Revelation the Spirit occupies the second place in the sequence of the divine Trinity. It is because in this book the age has been changed from the Son to the Spirit. In the book of Revelation, the age is the age of the Spirit, and in this age the Spirit has been intensified.

Because the Spirit in 1:4 is the intensified Spirit of God, He is called the seven Spirits. The seven Spirits are undoubtedly the Spirit of God because they are ranked among the Triune God in verses 4 and 5. We cannot understand the Bible according to our natural, limited mentality. According to our concept, the words seven Spirits denote seven individual spirits. But this is not the meaning. The number seven here does not refer to seven different spirits but to one sevenfold Spirit.

Seven is the number of completion in God's dispensational move, while twelve is the number of completion in God's eternal administration. For example, God created the earth in six days plus one Sabbath day. Furthermore, there are seven dispensations in the Bible. For God's move today, the church has the number seven. In the book of Revelation the seven seals, the seven trumpets, and the seven bowls are all for God's dispensational move. Thus, the sevenfold Spirit is the intensified Spirit in God's move today. He is the seven Spirits of God for God's move.

As seven is the number for completion in God's operation, so the seven Spirits are for God's move on the earth. In substance and existence, God's Spirit is one; in the intensified function and work of God's operation, God's Spirit is sevenfold. It is like the lampstand in Zechariah 4:2. In existence it is one lampstand, but in function it is seven lamps. At the time the book of Revelation was written, the church had become degraded and the age had become dark. Therefore, the sevenfold intensified Spirit of God was needed for God's move and work on the earth. We all are familiar with three-way bulbs, light bulbs that can be switched to three successive degrees of illumination. When we do not need very much light, we switch the bulb to the first degree, but when we need more illumination, we switch it to the second or third degree. In like manner, the seven lamps on the lampstand were the sevenfold, intensified light. In the four Gospels, the Spirit of God was onefold because at that time there was not the need for so much light. However, after the church had been degraded and the age had become exceedingly dark, there was the need for the Holy Spirit to be intensified sevenfold. In this way the one Spirit of God has become the sevenfold Spirit. In existence, the Holy Spirit, like the lampstand in Zechariah, is one, but in function the Holy Spirit is seven.

B. The seven eyes of the Lamb

The seven Spirits of God are the seven eyes of the Lamb (Rev. 5:6; Zech. 3:9; 4:10). Our eyes are for our moving. If we are blind, it is very difficult to move. In God's move today, Christ as the Lamb of God has seven eyes. The seven eyes of the Lamb are also for watching, observing, and transfusing. When I look at someone, something of me is transfused into him. We often talk about loving one another, but how can you realize that someone loves you? Love is transfused through the eyes. If you look at me in a loving way, your eyes will transfuse your love into me. When Christ looks at us with His seven eyes, we may be terrified at first. Eventually, however, these seven eyes will transfuse Christ's element into us.

The Holy Spirit today is the seven eyes of Christ. Many Christians argue that the Holy Spirit of God is separate from Christ, but the Bible says that the Holy Spirit is the eyes of Christ. Do you think of your eyes as being separate from you? It is ridiculous to say this. When I look at your eyes, I look at you, and when you look at me with your eyes, you look at me. The eyes of a person express that person. To say that the Holy Spirit is separate from Christ does not correspond with the pure revelation of the Holy Word. How can we say that a person's eyes are separate from the person himself? There is no room to argue about this. We have seen that the Bible says that the Spirit of God today is the eyes of Christ. This simply means that the Spirit is Christ. My eyes are me. When I look at you, my eyes look at you. If I had no eyes, I could never look at you. Hence, the Spirit, the eyes of Christ, is not separate from Christ. He is the eyes of Christ looking at us. Our experience proves this. Day by day, we sense that Someone is looking at us. This Someone is the Spirit, who is Christ Himself. If the Spirit were not Christ, we would sense that two, the Spirit and Christ, were looking at us. To say that the Spirit is separate from Christ is to pluck out the eyes of Christ and to separate them from Him. It is not scriptural to say that the Spirit is separate from Christ and that Christ is not the Spirit. Just as we and our eyes are one, so Christ and the Spirit are one. Our Christ is not a blind Christ. He is the Christ with the seven eyes. Often, He transfuses His element into us. At other times, He observes us like a flashlight, saying, "What are you doing? Are you fighting with your husband? Stop!" Have you not had this kind of experience? Day by day we experience this watching, observing, and transfusing Christ. This watching, observing, and transfusing take place through His eyes. His eyes are the Spirit, and the Spirit is simply Himself. If you do not believe it, you will miss the blessing.

C. The seven lamps of fire before the throne of God

The seven eyes are also the seven lamps of fire before the throne of God (Rev. 4:5; Zech. 4:2). This is difficult to understand. Christ carries out God's administration by the shining of the seven lamps of fire. This is true in the churches today. When Christ looks at and through us, He shines upon us and executes God's administration. Many times as the elders in the churches are discussing matters with one another, they have the sense that the seven lamps of fire are shining upon them. This is Christ's carrying out of God's administration through the shining of the seven lamps of fire.

D. Sent forth into all the earth

The seven Spirits of God have been sent forth into all the earth (Rev. 5:6). Wherever we go, the seven eyes will follow us. In fact, they will go before us and be waiting for us at our destination. Many dear saints who are unhappy with the church in a certain locality have moved to another locality, thinking that it would be much better for them in another place. But when they arrived at their new locality, they found that the Spirit was waiting for them. Some of us have gone places where we should not have gone, and when we arrived there, we were greeted by the Spirit, who said, "Go back. Don't stay here." Today the Spirit has been sent forth into all the earth. He now pervades every corner of the earth. This is the wonderful Spirit of the Triune God.

IV. The Son

After studying the book of Revelation again and again, I have discovered that it contains twenty-six items of what the Son is. Since there are twenty-six letters in the alphabet, we may say that Christ is every letter from A to Z. He is useful for composing any word. Do you want to compose the word light? He is l, i, g, h, and t. Would you like to compose the word love? He is l, o, v, e. With Christ we can compose any positive thing. After we have the words, we have sentences, paragraphs, and chapters, and once we have the chapters, we have the whole Bible. The entire Bible is composed with Christ. Let us now briefly consider each of the twenty-six aspects of Christ found in Revelation.

A. Jesus Christ

The Son is Jesus Christ. Jesus is Jehovah the Savior, and Christ is the One anointed of God to carry out God's economy.

B. The faithful Witness

The Son is the faithful Witness (Rev. 1:5; 3:14). He is God's Witness. Although He is God, He is also the Witness of God. Without Him, we cannot know, see, or gain God. God is testified by Him.

C. The firstborn of the dead

The Son is the Firstborn of the dead (1:5). In the universe, God has two creations: the creation by His first work and the creation by His second work. We all know God's first creation, but not many of us are familiar with His second creation. God's second work is resurrection. Firstly, God created all existing things; secondly, He resurrected some of these existing things and brought them into another sphere, another realm, which is the realm of resurrection. Are we in God's first creation or in His second creation? While our body remains in God's first creation, our spirit is in His second creation. Our spirit has been regenerated. This means that it has been recreated. Hence, it belongs to God's second creation. In both of God's creations, Christ is the first. Colossians 1:15 says that Christ is the Firstborn of all creation, and in Revelation 1:5 we are told that He is the Firstborn of the dead. He was the first to be resurrected from the dead, and we shall follow Him. Here the phrase the Firstborn of the dead indicates the creation of God in resurrection. This signifies a new beginning. In God's first creation there was a beginning, and in God's second creation in resurrection there was another beginning. When we were regenerated, we experienced a new beginning in God's second creation.

D. The ruler of the kings of the earth

The Son is the Ruler of the kings of the earth (1:5). Although the Communists are against Christ, they use His calendar without realizing that they are doing so. According to history, the one whose calendar you use is the one to whom you are in subjection. If any used the calendar of a certain king, he would have to be under the rule of that king. In like manner, the Communists are under Jesus Christ because they use His calendar. They call it the international calendar, but actually it is the calendar of Christ. In this way they unconsciously admit that He is their Ruler. In the universe, there is one unique Ruler. All mankind today uses the calendar of Christ and is under His rule. All the people on earth are His people, and He is the Ruler of all nations. Jesus might say to the Communists, "You are opposing Me, but I will cause you to be My people. I will cause you to use My calendar, and you will have no choice about being under My rule. I am the unique Ruler of the earth."

E. The Son of God

The Son is the Son of God (Rev. 2:18). As the Son of God, He is God Himself. He is the true God with divinity.

F. The Son of Man

The Son is also the Son of Man (Rev. 1:13). As the Son of Man, He is a genuine man with humanity. He is both the very God and the proper man.

G. , H., and I. the first and the last, the beginning and the end, the Alpha and the Omega

The Son is the first and the last (Rev. 1:17; 2:8; 22:13), the beginning and the end (Rev. 22:13), and the Alpha and the Omega (Rev. 22:13). When I was young, I was bothered by these terms, thinking that they were repetitious and that the beginning, the first, and the Alpha were the same and that the end, the last, and the Omega were the same. But this is not a matter of repetition, but of different aspects. Being the first does not necessarily mean that you are the beginning. Being the first simply means that you are the first and that prior to you there was nothing. However, to be the beginning does not only mean that you are the first, but also that you have begun something. What then is the difference between the Alpha and the beginning? A certain thing may be the beginning, but it may have neither the content nor the continuation. To be the Alpha and the Omega means that you are the complete content and continuation. For Christ to be the Alpha and the Omega, the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet, indicates that He is also every other letter in the alphabet. The first and the last simply indicate the first and the last without indicating either the beginning or the ending. In order to be the beginning and the ending, you must take a certain action. Christ is not only the first but also the beginning, the beginning of God's economy and God's operation. God's operation began and will end with Christ. This Christ is also the content and continuation of God's operation, because He is not only the beginning and the ending but also the Alpha and the Omega. In other words, the Son, Jesus Christ, is everything. He is the first and the last, the beginning and the ending of God's operation, and the content and continuation of whatever God is doing. Because the Greek letters from Alpha to Omega comprise all the letters of the Greek alphabet, we may say that Christ is every letter for us to compose words, sentences, paragraphs, chapters, and books. Hallelujah, He is everything!

J. The living One

The Son, the all-inclusive One, is the living One (Rev. 1:18). He died, became alive, and lives forever.

K. The holy One

This living One is the holy One (Rev. 3:7), the One who has God's holy nature that sanctifies.

L. The true One

Christ is also the true One (3:7), the One who is genuine and real in every way.

M. The faithful One

In Rev. 19:11 we see that Christ is the faithful One, the One who is worthy of our trust.

N. The Amen

The Son is also the Amen (Rev. 3:14). The title Amen has various meanings: reality, yes, let it be. His being the Amen means more than we can say. Thirteen years ago, I was invited to a meeting in Tyler, Texas. In that meeting I was somewhat cautious, not daring to say, "Amen," loudly. At the end of some of the prayers, I quietly said, "Amen." After a while, someone came to me, saying, "Brother Lee, you probably don't know the custom in this country. In this type of service, you must be silent." Deep within my heart, I said, "The most silent place is the cemetery. You people are trying to make your church service a cemetery." What is wrong with our saying, "Amen"? It is equal to calling on the name of the Lord. When we say, "Amen," we mean, "O Lord Jesus." Let us all learn to say, "Amen!"

O. The origination of the creation of God

In 3:14 we are told that the Son is the origination of the creation of God. This is an important concept. The translators have been troubled by this verse. Some have said that Christ is the originator, not the origination. However, the meaning here is not originator but origination. Christ is the origination of God's action to create the universe.

P. And Q. the Root and the Offspring of David

The Son is the Root and the Offspring of David (Rev. 5:5; 22:16). This means that He is both the root and the branch of David. Once again, we see that He is everything. As the root, He is the first, the beginning, and the Alpha, and as the branch, He is the last, the end, and the Omega.

R. And S. the Lion of the tribe of Judah and the Lamb

As we have pointed out in a previous message, Christ, the Son, is the Lion of the tribe of Judah (Rev. 5:5) and the Lamb (Rev. 5:6; 21:23; 22:1). He is the Lion-Lamb. To the enemy, He is the Lion; to us, the redeemed ones, He is the dear, precious Lamb.

T. And U. King of kings and Lord of lords

The Son is the King of kings and the Lord of lords (Rev. 19:16). The King of kings refers to His authority, and the Lord of lords refers to His headship. He is the authority and the head of the whole universe.

V. The Word of God

The Son is the Word of God (Rev. 19:13), the expression of God. Because Christ is the Word, He and the Bible are one. Do not read your Bible without reading Him, and do not contact the Bible without contacting Him. As we come to the Bible, we must realize that He Himself is the Word of God.

W. The morning star

In Rev. 22:16 we see that the Son is the morning star. In Malachi 4:2, He is revealed as the Sun, but here He is revealed as the morning star. His being the Sun is mainly related to the people on earth, but His being the morning star is related to His watchful, waiting believers. To those who watch and wait for His coming back, the Lord will appear as the morning star. Although I desire to see Him as the Sun, I am now waiting to see Him as the morning star. We all love Him in His aspect of being the morning star, and He will appear to us in this way.

X. The lamp

In Rev. 21:23 Christ is revealed as the lamp who contains God as the light. The light is the very essence of the lamp, and the lamp radiates the light. God is the essence of Christ, and Christ radiates God.

Y. The Husband

In Rev. 21:2 we see that the New Jerusalem is the wife of Christ. This implies that Christ is the Husband who takes God's redeemed people as His wife.

Z. The another Angel

Finally, Christ is another Angel (Rev. 7:2; 8:3; 10:1; 18:1) sent by God to carry out God's commission. In the Old Testament, Christ appeared as the angel of the Lord several times (Exo. 3:2-6; Judg. 6:11-24; Zech. 1:11-12; 2:8-11; 3:1-7), coming to take care of God's people for the fulfillment of God's plan. Now in this book He is again the Angel sent by God to carry out God's purpose.

If we put all twenty-six items together, we have a clear vision of what the Son is. The Father and the Spirit are one with the Son. Without the Son's being so many items, the Father could not be adequately expressed and the Spirit would not have so much to express.

The Coming Again of Christ

Most Christians hold the concept that the book of Revelation is a book of Christ's second coming. It is absolutely correct to hold this concept because Revelation does cover the second coming of Christ. However, throughout the years, Christians have not been clear about the Lord's second coming. Due to this lack of clarity, there has been much disputing and wrangling about it. The revelation regarding Christ's second coming is not simple; rather, it is quite complicated and has several aspects. Therefore, it has been difficult for most Christians to understand thoroughly the Lord's coming again.

During the past century and a half, many books have been written, especially by the Brethren, about the second coming of Christ. Some of the leading teachers among the Brethren held different opinions about the Lord's coming back, and the first division between them was the result of these different opinions. The so-called Brethren testimony was raised up in 1828 or 29 under the leadership of John Nelson Darby. Darby taught that Christ would come back before the great tribulation, while Benjamin Newton, another leading teacher, said that Christ would come back after the tribulation. Because these two great teachers held different opinions, there were many debates about this matter. Eventually, this brought about the first division among the so-called Brethren between those under the leadership of Darby and those under the leadership of Newton. I was associated with the Benjamin Newton group for seven and a half years during which time I learned all their teachings. They certainly had a strong ground for saying that the second coming of Christ would be after the great tribulation. If you read the best writings of all the great teachers during the past one hundred fifty years, you will find that some taught that Christ's coming would be before the tribulation and others taught that it would follow the tribulation.

During the past century, the Lord raised up some careful students of the Word, such as G. H. Pember, Robert Govett, and D. M. Pantton. These men discovered that Christ's second coming is not a simple matter. They saw that, on the one hand, Christ will come back after the tribulation, but that, on the other hand, He will also come back before the tribulation. These careful students of the Bible have supplied strong proof to substantiate the correctness of this view. Christ's coming back has at least two aspects — one before the tribulation and the other after the tribulation. Furthermore, these students of the Word also learned that the rapture of the saints will be of more than two categories. This means that some saints will be raptured before the tribulation and others after the tribulation. Do not react to such statements too hastily. I reacted that way when I was young, but eventually I was subdued and convinced. The Bible is not as simple as some think it is.

In this message, we shall consider the subject of Christ's coming again. We thank God for all the teachers of the Word who have gone before us. We are grateful to them, and whatever we see, we see as those who are standing upon their shoulders. If we would understand the second coming of Christ, we must study the Bible and also read the books written by these great teachers. Then we shall be able to have a comprehensive view of the matter. If we do this, we shall be fully convinced that Christ's coming has two aspects: the secret, private aspect and the open, public aspect.

I. The secret aspect

A. Coming as a thief

In both Matthew and Revelation we see the secret aspect of Christ's coming again. Rev. 3:3 and Rev. 16:15 both tell us that Christ will come as a thief and that we should be watchful. No thief comes openly or announces his coming. As we pointed out in a previous message, when the Lord comes as a thief, He will come to steal the precious things. In Matt. 24:40-41, the Lord spoke of His secret coming, saying, "Then shall two men be in the field; one is taken, and one is left. Two women shall be grinding at the mill; one is taken, and one is left." The Lord Jesus was very wise, using two brothers in the field and two sisters grinding at the mill as illustrations. Apparently the two brothers are the same and the two sisters are the same. But suddenly one of the brothers and one of the sisters are taken. After giving this illustration, the Lord said, "Watch therefore, for you do not know on what day your Lord comes. But know this, that if the householder knew in what watch the thief was coming, he would have watched and would not have allowed his house to be broken into. Therefore, you also, be ready, for the Son of Man comes in an hour that you think not" (vv. 42-44). As we are working, having no consciousness that Christ is coming, some of us will be raptured. Since He is coming as a thief, we must be watchful.

B. The time — unknown

The time of the Lord's secret coming is unknown (Rev. 3:3; Matt. 24:36, 42; 25:13). When Christ comes again, He will come as a Sent One. Because of this, in Revelation He is called the Angel, One who is sent by God. In His second coming, as in His first, Christ will come as One who has been sent by God. This is the reason that only the Father knows the time of Christ's secret coming (Matt. 24:36; Mark 13:32). The Father is the Sender and the Son is the Sent One. Only the Sender, not even the Sent One, knows the time.

Some people, seeming to know more than the Lord Jesus, have predicted the time of the Lord's coming. During the past century and a half, there have been many predictions, none of which has been fulfilled. Some predicted that the Lord Jesus would come on a certain date and charged people to prepare themselves by taking a bath and by putting on clean, white clothing. Others have climbed to a mountaintop to await the Lord's coming back. After World War I, many teachers published books about prophecy, especially concerning the Lord's coming back. Some of these writers also predicted the time of the Lord's coming. All these predictions about the time of the Lord's coming have been proved false. Be careful not to predict anything. According to the Bible, the time of the Lord's secret coming is unknown.

C. The place — in the cloud to the air

The place of the Lord's secret coming will be in the cloud to the air (Rev. 10:1; 1 Thes. 4:17). The cloud is related to the Lord's coming back. Christ went to heaven on a cloud, and He will come back to earth in the same way (Acts 1:9, 11; Matt. 26:64; Rev. 14:14). In Matthew 26:64, the Lord Jesus said to the high priest, "Henceforth you shall see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of power and coming on the clouds of heaven." Even with the Lord's coming in the cloud there are two aspects. Firstly, the Lord will come in the cloud. This means that He will be concealed by the cloud. Secondly, He will come upon the cloud. When He comes in the cloud, He will not come to the earth but to the air. Revelation 10:1 reveals that the Lord will come down out of heaven clothed with a cloud, indicating that He will be wrapped up with the cloud. Do not think that He will suddenly descend from the heavens to the earth. Christ is now on the throne in the third heaven. When the proper time comes, the Father will send Him from the throne in the heavens to the cloud in the air. As we shall see in later messages, before He leaves the throne in the heavens, some overcomers will have been raptured to the throne. Rev. 12 shows that the man-child will be raptured, not to the air but to the throne of God. This indicates that some overcomers will have been raptured even before the time of the secret coming of the Lord Jesus. In Rev. 14 we see the firstfruits on Mount Zion in the heavens. Mount Zion in the heavens is where God is in the third heaven; it is not in the air. That the firstfruits will be on Mount Zion in the heavens proves that some of the early overcomers will be raptured to the third heaven before Christ's secret coming. After these early overcomers have been raptured, Christ will descend from the throne to the air in the cloud secretly.

While He is in the air, the Lord Jesus will do many things. Mainly, He will take up all the believers who have not yet been raptured. After Christ comes to the air in the cloud, many saints will still not have been raptured. Thus, while He is in the air, He will rapture the Christians who have had to pass through the great tribulation. First Thessalonians 4:17 says that they who are alive and remain will be caught up to meet the Lord in the air. Then, in the air, Christ will set up His judgment seat. This judgment will not be for sinners but for all the saved ones, and it will not be concerned with salvation or perdition but with reward or punishment. After this judgment has been executed, some of the saints will be chosen to receive a positive reward.

According to the Bible, God has had two selections concerning us. Firstly, He selected us before the foundation of the world in eternity past (Eph. 1:4); secondly, after the Lord comes to the air and has raptured all the saints to the air, He will make a second selection. While the first selection in eternity past was for salvation, the second selection in the air at the judgment seat of Christ will be for reward. We all have been selected for salvation, but whether or not we receive a reward will depend upon the second selection at Christ's judgment seat. Those saved ones who do not pass this judgment will be put somewhere to suffer discipline. Christ will then bring the positive ones with Him to the earth as His army. At that time, He will no longer be in the cloud but upon the cloud. Thus, there will be at least two steps to the Lord's coming. In the first step, Christ will leave the throne in the heavens, come down to the air wrapped in the cloud, and remain there for a time. Then, from the air, He will take the second step of coming to the earth upon the cloud. This will be the second aspect of His coming back.

D. As a reward to the watching believers

Christ's secret coming will be a reward to the watching believers (Rev. 2:28; Matt. 24:42, 44). Revelation 2:28 says that Christ will appear as the morning star, and Mal. 4:2 reveals that He will appear as the sun. There is a great difference between the appearing of the morning star and the appearing of the sun. If you would see the morning star, you must rise up very early in the morning. If you sleep late, you will miss it. However, no matter how late you sleep, you will not miss the sunshine. Do you expect to meet Christ as the morning star or as the sun? The appearing of the morning star is secret, but the appearing of the sun is open. The Lord promised us that if we are watchful and wait for His coming, He will appear to us as the morning star. This is a promise of a reward. But if we are sloppy, we shall surely miss the morning star.

Do not think that Christ's coming back is a simple matter of His leaving the throne and coming immediately and directly to earth. He will be in the air for some time. The early overcomers will be raptured before the sixth seal which will be a preface, a warning, of the coming great tribulation that will last for three and a half years. No one can tell when Christ will leave His throne in the heavens and come down to the air. However, it should be somewhat before the great tribulation. There will be an interval between Christ's descending to the air and His descending to the earth. During this interval, He will complete the rapture of the saints and exercise His judgment upon all the saints to select the overcomers who are to be His army to fight against the army of the Antichrist.

II. The open aspect

A. Seen by all the tribes of the land

As we have seen, in the secret aspect of His coming again, Christ will come as a thief. But in the open aspect, He will come with power and great glory to be seen by all the tribes of the land (Rev. 1:7; Matt. 24:27, 30). Revelation 1:7 says, "Behold, He comes with the clouds, and every eye shall see Him, those also who pierced Him, and all the tribes of the land shall wail over Him. Yes, Amen." The Lord will appear as lightning which flashes across the sky from east to west. What a difference between this and His secret coming as a thief. Revelation 1:7 mentions "all the tribes of the land." The Greek word rendered land in this verse may also be translated earth. This has bothered the translators of this verse, for they have been uncertain whether to translate it as land or earth. Some versions say earth and others say land. After much study, I have concluded that in this verse the Greek word should be rendered land. In other verses it may be translated earth, but here it should be the land, referring to the Holy Land. All the tribes of the Holy Land shall see Him. The basis for saying this is Zechariah 12:10-14, which says that they shall look upon Him whom they have pierced and that the land shall mourn for Him. The tribes mentioned in 1:7 are the tribes of those who have pierced Him. Revelation 1:7 surely is a reference to Zechariah 12. According to the context of Zechariah 12, the tribes are not all the nations of the earth but the twelve tribes in the Holy Land. Based upon this, we may say that the tribes in 1:7 are the twelve tribes in the Holy Land. When the Lord appears as lightning, coming with power and glory to be seen by all in the Holy Land, the twelve tribes will behold Him and will weep.

B. The time — at the end of the great tribulation

While the day and hour of Christ's coming in its secret aspect are unknown (Matt. 24:36), the time of His coming in the second aspect is clearly revealed. It is at the last trumpet (the seventh trumpet), at the end of the great tribulation (Rev. 18:1; Matt. 24:15, 21, 27; 1 Thes. 4:16; 1 Cor. 15:52; 2 Thes. 2:1-4, 8). Matthew 24:15 says, "When ye therefore shall see the abomination of desolation, spoken of by Daniel the prophet, stand in the holy place." The "abomination of desolation" is an idol, the image of the Antichrist. According to Dan. 9:27, the Antichrist will make a covenant with the nation of Israel for seven years. In the middle of these seven years, he will break this covenant and begin to persecute the Jews. The Antichrist will be absolutely against God and will set himself up as God, putting an image of himself in the temple and compelling people to worship it. In the eyes of God, this will be the abomination that will cause great destruction. This will take place in the midst of the last of the seventy weeks mentioned in Dan. 9. In Daniel 9, a week denotes seven years. In Matthew 24:15 the Lord Jesus indicates that the Jewish believers will see this. As Matthew 24:21 reveals, this will mark the beginning of the great tribulation: "For then there shall be great tribulation, such as has not occurred from the beginning of the world until now, nor ever shall be." Hence, the great tribulation will begin at the time the Antichrist erects his image in the temple and forces people to worship it. By these verses we can see that the Lord's open coming will not precede the great tribulation. It must occur some time after the beginning of the great tribulation. According to the verses in Revelation, it will be very close to the end of the great tribulation. According to the New Testament, the Lord Jesus will leave His throne in the heavens and descend to the air before the great tribulation. From there, close to the end of the great tribulation, He will come down openly to the earth.

When Christ comes openly from the air to the earth, it will be at a time when the Antichrist will be attempting to exterminate the whole nation of Israel. For this purpose, the Antichrist will gather his army to a place called Armageddon (Rev. 16:16). This will be according to God's purpose, for God's plan is to assemble all the earthly armies together at Armageddon and there destroy them and rid the earth of them. The intention of the Antichrist will be to use his army to exterminate the nation of Israel. Israel will be surrounded by his army and have no way of escape. At that juncture, when escape is impossible, the Lord will appear as a flash of lightning and set His feet upon the Mount of Olives (Zech. 14:4). Before this time, the nation of Israel will not believe in the Lord Jesus, but the threat of the army of the Antichrist will force them to repent. When the Lord Jesus puts His feet upon the Mount of Olives, it will split in half. This will provide a way of escape for the persecuted Jews who will then repent, weep, and confess what they have done in crucifying the Lord.

If we put all the verses together, we can see that the Lord's open coming will probably be near the end of the great tribulation. As long as the temple in Jerusalem has not been rebuilt, it is impossible for the Lord Jesus to come back openly. Although we have some idea about the time of His open coming, we do not know the time of His secret coming. The Bible says that no one knows this. However, the New Testament reveals clearly that Christ's open coming will not precede the great tribulation, that is, it will not precede the time when the Antichrist will force people to worship his image. But we are not waiting for the Lord's open coming; we are waiting for His secret coming. The Lord is very wise in this matter, knowing that it will cause us to be watchful.

C. The place — on the cloud to the earth

The place of the open aspect of the Lord's coming back is clearly revealed — on the cloud to the earth (Rev. 1:7; 14:14; Matt. 24:30; Zech. 14:4; Acts 1:11-12). According to Acts 1:11-12, the Lord shall come in the same way as He went up into heaven. Since He ascended from the Mount of Olives, this means that He will come back to the Mount of Olives. Zechariah 14:4 says, "His feet shall stand in that day upon the mount of Olives, which is before Jerusalem on the east, and the mount of Olives shall cleave in the midst thereof toward the east and toward the west." As this verse makes clear, the Mount of Olives is outside the wall of Jerusalem, not far from the city. The Lord will descend to the very spot from which He ascended. However, we are not waiting to see Him on the Mount of Olives. We want to meet Him at the throne in the third heaven and then come back with Him to the Mount of Olives. He has ascended to the heavens, and we are waiting to be raptured to the heavens. We are not waiting to die and go to heaven. This is religious. We are waiting for our whole being to be raptured to the third heaven, to the throne of God, that we may come back with Christ, firstly to the air and then to the earth. This is the way we shall visit Jerusalem. We shall go there by way of the throne in the third heaven. However, if you are defeated, you will miss this visit to Jerusalem.

D. With the overcoming saints to fight against the Antichrist and his army at Armageddon

When the Lord Jesus comes openly, He will come with the overcoming saints to fight against the Antichrist and his army at Armageddon (Rev. 19:11-21; 17:13-14; 16:12-16; Zech. 14:3, 5; 2 Thes. 2:8). This will be to tread the winepress of the wrath of God (19:15; 14:18-20). At Armageddon, all the worldly armies will be gathered together, with some coming from the Far East, others from the North, and still others from Europe. This gathering together of all the earthly forces will be according to God's wisdom. Eventually, the riches of the world will be concentrated in the Middle East, and all the nations will be greedy to seize them. While the armies of the earth will be gathering at Armageddon, the Lord will be sitting in the air observing them, saying, "Are you ready?" When we come to chapter fourteen, we shall see that the gathering of the armies will be the gathering of the grapes into the great winepress. In the eyes of God, the earthly armies are likened to grapes, and Armageddon will be the great winepress. As the kings, generals, and leaders gather all the armies at Armageddon, they will be like grapes gathered into the great winepress. Then the Lord will descend to tread this winepress of God, and a great river of blood will flow out of it. What a huge number of evil people will be killed there at that time! This will occur at the time of the Lord's open coming to the earth. The purpose of the Lord's open coming will be to exterminate all the worldly forces. After this, war will cease from the earth.

III. A warning and a loving response

In Rev. 22:12 and Rev. 22:20 the Lord Jesus gives us a warning, saying, "Behold, I come quickly." Our loving response should be, "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus" (22:20; 2 Tim. 4:8). Our concern in these messages is not with mere teaching and doctrine concerning the so-called second advent. We are studying the heart's desire of the Lord, which is to gain a group of overcomers who are watching and waiting for His coming back.

Joint Partaker in the Tribulation, Kingdom, and Endurance in Jesus

In this message we need to consider 1:9, which says, “I John, your brother and joint partaker in the tribulation and kingdom and endurance in Jesus, was on the island called Patmos because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus.” The book of Revelation is composed in a marvelous way. It is quite significant that this verse comes shortly after the mention of the Lord’s coming in 1:7. This indicates that if we would be those who are watchfully waiting for the Lord’s coming back, we must be those who are joint partakers, not in outward blessing, but in the tribulation, kingdom, and endurance in Jesus.

I. Joint partaker in the tribulation in Jesus

The phrase in Jesus governs the words tribulation, kingdom, and endurance, and we must pay close attention to it. This phrase very rarely occurs in the New Testament. The phrase in Christ or in Christ Jesus, on the contrary, is used many times. In the New Testament, the truth is mainly in Christ, but here the phrase in Jesus is employed. This tells us that if we would be those who are waiting for the Lord’s coming back, we must be those who are joint partakers in the tribulation, kingdom, and endurance “in Jesus.” When we talk about salvation, grace, enjoyment, and all the other good things, we say that we are “in Christ,” for this phrase refers to everything on the positive side of God’s salvation. But to say that we are partakers of the tribulation, kingdom, and endurance in Jesus means that we are suffering. When Jesus lived on earth as a man, He suffered constantly. According to the facts of His life, His name, Jesus, denotes a suffering person, a man of sorrows (Isa. 53:3). Hence, when we say that we are in Christ, this means that we are saved, are enjoying God’s grace, have peace with God, and are under God’s blessing. But when we say that we are joint partakers of the tribulation, kingdom, and endurance “in Jesus,” this means that we are suffering and are being persecuted as we follow Jesus the Nazarene. In the book of Revelation, the in Christ is not used. In Ephesians, on the contrary, the term in Christ or in Him is used repeatedly, being found in every chapter of that epistle. The book of Revelation is for those who are suffering tribulation “in Jesus.” This means that those who are waiting for the coming of the Lord Jesus must be people who suffer tribulation in Jesus. In other words, those who wait for the Lord’s coming back are the suffering ones. In the eyes of God, we are the followers of Christ, but in the eyes of people, especially religion, we are the followers of Jesus.

A. Jesus having suffered persecution while he was on earth

While Jesus was on earth, He was persecuted by the Jewish religion (John 5:16; 15:20). He was not persecuted by a heathen, pagan religion, but by the typical religion formed according to God’s oracles. Religion is greatly utilized by God’s enemy. Religion is versus Christ, and Christ is versus religion. John 5:16 reveals that the Jews persecuted Jesus because He broke their Sabbath. Religious people cannot tolerate the breaking of their regulations. Any violation of their religious regulations will stir up persecution against the violators. The Jewish religion was established on three pillars, one of which was the Sabbath; the other two are circumcision and dietary regulations. When Jesus broke the Sabbath, He tore down one of the three pillars of the Jewish religion. Hence, they persecuted Him and even sought to kill Him. Eventually, religion succeeded and actually killed the Lord Jesus, sentencing Him to death according to their Scriptures. However, under the sovereignty of God, the Jews at that time did not have the right to kill anyone. Thus, they delivered Jesus over to the Roman government and the Roman government, using its method of executing criminals, crucified the Lord Jesus on the cross.

Just as religion persecuted Jesus, it will also persecute the followers of Jesus. We know from the book of Acts that the Jews in the synagogues in every city stirred up opposition against the apostles, and Paul suffered this type of persecution very much. John, the writer of the book of Revelation, also underwent this kind of persecution. When John received the revelation of this book, he was on the island of Patmos, having been exiled there for “the word of God and the testimony of Jesus.” In writing the book, he was encouraging the saints to wait for the Lord’s coming back, telling them that he was their brother and joint partaker, not in grace, life, peace, and light, but in the suffering, the affliction, in Jesus.

As we have seen, when Jesus was on earth, He suffered at the hands of religion. The Roman Empire paid very little attention to Him. It was the Jewish religion that asked the Roman government to execute judgment upon Him. Thus, the persecution against Him did not originate with the secular world but with the religious world. In the book of Acts we see that it was the same with the apostles. The opposition did not come mainly from the Gentiles but from the Jewish religion. The Jews followed Paul wherever he went, perhaps even picketing him. In like manner, a great many martyrs suffered persecution by the so-called Roman Catholic Church. As Foxe points out in his history of martyrs, the Roman Catholic Church killed more saints than the Roman Empire did. Who imprisoned Madame Guyon? The Roman Catholic Church. Who imprisoned John Bunyan? The Church of England. Religion always persecutes the genuine followers of Jesus.

Now it is our turn to undergo this persecution. During the years I was with Brother Nee in China, I saw how much he was persecuted by religion. The rumors, opposition, and condemnation came, not from the Gentiles, but from Christianity, even from some missionaries. The Devil is subtle. The secular world does not oppose us as much as the so-called religious people do. Many Christians think of religion as a good thing, but actually it is something used by the Devil. If you read the book of Galatians, you will see how intensely Paul persecuted the church when he was in the Jewish religion. Gal. 1 reveals that religion is against Christ and that Christ is versus religion. If we cooperate with religion, there will be a type of compromising peace. But how can we go along with religion? It is so subtle and false; it is a counterfeit of God’s economy. Anyone who sees that religion is a counterfeit of God’s economy will condemn it.

B. Jesus now suffering persecution with His followers

Because we do not cooperate with religion, it persecutes us. The persecution that we are suffering today is the persecution in Jesus. He is now suffering persecution with His followers (Acts 9:4-5). As we are suffering today, He is suffering in and with us. When Saul of Tarsus was traveling to Damascus with the intention of arresting all those who called on the name of Jesus, the Lord Jesus knocked him down to the earth, saying, “Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting Me?” (v. 4). When Saul said, “Who are You, Lord?” Jesus answered, “I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting” (v. 5). Saul never thought that he was persecuting Jesus. He thought Jesus was in the grave and that he was persecuting Stephen and other followers of Jesus. But according to the Lord Jesus, Saul was persecuting Him, because, at that time, He was in Stephen, Peter, John, and all His other members and was one with them. The same is true today. When the religious people persecute us, they are actually persecuting Jesus because Jesus is in us and is one with us. We may be comforted to realize that the suffering we are experiencing is the persecution in Jesus. We are joint partakers of tribulation in Jesus.

C. His followers also persecuted in this age, bearing His reproach

The followers of Jesus are also persecuted in this age, bearing His reproach (Rev. 2:10; John 16:2, 33; Acts 14:22; Heb. 13:13). Hebrews 13:13 says, “Let us therefore go forth unto Him outside the camp, bearing His reproach.” When the Lord Jesus was on earth, He suffered reproach from religion. Now, as His followers, we must bear His reproach, suffering reproach from religion. This is to be a joint partaker of tribulation in Jesus.

Some sufferings, however, may not be caused by our following Jesus, but by our foolishness. This suffering cannot properly be called the suffering in Jesus. None of us should cause trouble by acting foolishly. But we must be honest and faithful to the Lord’s testimony. If our honesty and faithfulness bring us suffering and persecution, that is the persecution in Jesus, and that is Jesus’ suffering with us.

It is impossible to avoid the persecution of religion. We cannot escape it because the enemy is utilizing religion more than ever before. Nothing is more frustrating to God’s economy than religion. Nothing blinds, covers, and veils people from seeing God’s economy more than religion does. Millions have been blinded by it. Throughout the whole world, religion is blinding and veiling people’s eyes from seeing God’s economy. Because of this, a warfare is raging. In this warfare, we must sound our trumpet, saying, “Get out of religion, tear away the religious veils from your eyes, and forsake your religious concepts.” Whenever we do this, opposition is aroused. Some good friends have come to me advising me to compromise a little. But we will never compromise. Those who wait for the coming of the Lord Jesus must partake of His suffering. Do not simply say, “Lord Jesus, I love You. Come quickly.” If you say this, the Lord will reply, “I want you to suffer for and with Me.” Do not try to avoid persecution. If we employ our cleverness to avoid persecution, then we are not good waiters of the coming of the Lord. If you mean business to wait for His coming back, the religious persecution will be stirred up against you. But we should not arouse persecution by acting foolishly. In this matter, we must be wise as serpents and innocent as doves (Matt. 10:16).

II. Joint partaker in the kingdom in Jesus

If we are joint partakers in the tribulation in Jesus, then we are joint partakers in the kingdom. To partake of the persecution in Jesus is to partake of the kingdom. If you do not know what persecution is, then you do not know what the kingdom is.

A. The kingdom being with Jesus when He was on earth

Many Christians have a mistaken concept of the kingdom. Some say that the kingdom has already come, but that it has been rejected and suspended. Those who hold this concept say that the kingdom came, that it was rejected and suspended, and that it will come down in the future. According to this teaching, when the Lord Jesus comes back, He will bring this suspended kingdom with Him. This is merely vain doctrine. The kingdom was with Jesus when He was on earth. The Lord Jesus said to the Pharisees, “The kingdom of God does not come with observation; Nor will they say, Look, here! Or, There! For behold, the kingdom of God is among you” (Luke 17:20-21). In this portion of the Word, we see that the kingdom was wherever Jesus was. In Matthew 12:28, the Lord said, “If I by the Spirit of God cast out demons, then the kingdom of God is come upon you.” This means that the kingdom was with the Lord while He was on earth.

B. His believers being born into the kingdom

The believers of Jesus have been born into the kingdom. John 3:5 proves this. In this verse, Jesus said to Nicodemus, “Truly, truly, I say to you, unless a man is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.” We were regenerated into the kingdom. How could we have entered into the kingdom by regeneration if the kingdom had been suspended? Into what, then, were we born again? As John 3 states clearly, we have been reborn into the kingdom.

C. The church life today being the kingdom

In Matthew 16:18 and 19 the Lord said to Peter, “On this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it. I will give to you the keys of the kingdom of the heavens.” This shows that, in a proper sense, the church is the kingdom. Rom. 14:17 also indicates that we in the church are in the kingdom. The proper church life is the kingdom life.

What is the kingdom? It is the heavenly rule in the divine nature. We all have been regenerated with the divine life. In this life there is the divine nature, and with this divine nature there is a ruling, a reigning, a governing. This governing is both divine and heavenly. We, the regenerated ones, are under this reign today; we are under this government and control. We need to exercise this rule over ourselves. If you still need someone else to rule over you, it means that you are fallen. We must be under the heavenly rule in everything we do. In a previous message we spoke about being the fighting army of Christ. But if you are not under the ruling of the divine life, you will never be selected to be in His army. Being chosen to be in this army depends upon obeying the heavenly rule in the divine nature. The divine life brings us into the divine kingdom. The kingdom into which we are reborn in John 3:5 is the very kingdom mentioned by John in Rev. 1:9. How could we ever be joint partakers in the kingdom if we had not been reborn into it? After we have been reborn into the kingdom, we should remain in it. If you still argue with your wife or husband, it means that you are an escapee from the kingdom. If you remain in the kingdom and live in it, you will never fight with your husband, your wife, or anyone else. Although the enemy may tempt you to fight, the ruling of the heavenly kingdom will restrain you.

D. His believers suffering persecution for the kingdom

To be in the kingdom in Jesus today is not a glory. When the kingdom in Jesus becomes the kingdom in Christ, that will be the time for glory. Today, the kingdom in Jesus is a kingdom of suffering. In Matt. 5:10-12 the Lord said that His believers suffer persecution for the sake of the kingdom. If we are suffering for righteousness' sake, then we are in the kingdom. There are certain things which we cannot do because they are unrighteous. All of humanity today is unrighteous. If we agree with this unrighteousness, people will welcome us. But if we stand for righteousness, people will oppose and persecute us. Suffering persecution for the kingdom proves that we are in the kingdom of God today. Do not think that it is a glory to be in the kingdom today. No, to be in the kingdom now is to bear shame and to suffer persecution. The more we are in the kingdom, the more we shall suffer and be persecuted. But praise the Lord this suffering is a strong sign that we are in the kingdom.

Being in the kingdom today is a matter of being in the suffering in Jesus. Although we are joint partakers in the kingdom in Jesus, we are not yet the co-kings in Christ. When He comes back, we shall be His co-kings in the kingdom in Christ. At that time, we shall no longer suffer. Do not say to others, “You must honor me. I am a partner in the heavenly kingdom, and one day I'll be a co-king with Christ in the kingdom.” The more you say this, the more you will be persecuted. Today is not a reigning day but a suffering day. Now we are not in the reigning kingdom but in the suffering kingdom. This is the reason that Paul said that we must enter into the kingdom of God through much tribulation (Acts 14:22). The way to enter into the ruling kingdom is through suffering. The tribulation Paul referred to in Acts 14:22 was mainly the persecution at the hands of the Jewish religion. All believers in Christ undergo this kind of persecution. Paul seemed to be saying, “You Christians, the believers of Jesus, must suffer persecution from the Jewish religion.” In principle, it is the same today. If there were no religion in the world today, we would not suffer as much persecution. As we have already pointed out, most of the troubles, persecutions, rumors, and oppositions can be traced to one source — religion. While we are suffering today, we are in the kingdom where we are being exercised, trained, prepared, and qualified to be Christ's army and to reign in His kingdom as His co-kings.

III. Joint partaker in the endurance in Jesus

In Rev. 1:9, John also said that he was a joint partaker in the endurance in Jesus. For both the tribulation and the kingdom we need endurance. Many saints, even among us in the Lord's recovery, lack endurance. Some have suffered persecution from their relatives, friends, and neighbors, but eventually they exhausted their supply of endurance. While they were able to withstand the persecution for a certain time, they lacked the endurance to bear it for a longer time. When the Lord Jesus was on earth, He endured persecution (Heb. 12:2-3), and He is still enduring men's opposition and reproach today. Consider how much, even today, people oppose and mock the Lord Jesus. On the one hand, He is sitting in the heavens; on the other hand, He is still being mocked, opposed, and persecuted. Many of us might expect the Lord Jesus to say to His mockers, “Repent or I will send a great earthquake to destroy you.” The Lord Jesus has been mocked for nearly twenty centuries, but He has not fought back. Rather, He has continuously suffered all these attacks. Some may say, “Jesus, I hate You,” but there is no response from Him. This is the endurance of Jesus.

Not many of us have heard of the endurance of Jesus. We have heard of the power of Jesus, the love of Jesus, the holiness of Jesus, the righteousness of Jesus, but not of the endurance of Jesus. Nevertheless, as we live in Christ, we not only partake of His life and holiness, but also of His endurance. When we abide in Christ, we partake of His endurance and have the endurance to bear suffering and opposition. The Lord's word is even called the word of endurance (Rev. 3:10). Today the whole world is opposing and rejecting Him, but He does not fight back. He simply endures it all. Now as we have fellowship with Him and abide in Him, we partake of His endurance. As His followers, we must follow Him on the same pathway with endurance (Heb. 12:1). In this way we also can endure persecution, rumors, rejection, and opposition. This is a strong proof that we are those who are waiting for the Lord's coming back. As we wait for His coming back by being a joint partaker in His tribulation, kingdom, and endurance, we are being disciplined, trained, prepared, and qualified to be His fighting army. Are you waiting for the Lord Jesus to come back? If you are, then you also must be a joint partaker in His tribulation, kingdom, and endurance.

The Local Churches

The book of Revelation is very well composed. Apparently, the various points included in chapter one are unrelated to each other. But if we approach them from the viewpoint of our experience, we shall see that they follow one another in a very good sequence. In the last two messages, we covered the matters of the coming again of the Lord Jesus and of our waiting for Him by being joint partakers in His tribulation, kingdom, and endurance. In this message we now come to the local churches. It may seem that this message on the local churches is unrelated to the two foregoing messages. But, according to our experience, we know that these three messages are all interrelated. The coming again of the Lord Jesus requires that some partake of the tribulation, the kingdom, and the endurance in Jesus. The best way to do so is to be in the local churches. Outside of the church, it is difficult for anyone to participate in these three things.

I. The progress of the divine revelation in the Scripture

We shall approach the local churches by the way of considering the progress of the divine revelation in the Scripture. The divine revelation in the Bible begins with God and consummates with the local churches. The first two chapters of Genesis, along with the entire Old Testament, are a revelation of God Himself, and the four Gospels are a revelation of Christ. This fact reveals the progress in the divine revelation from God to Christ. Following the four Gospels, we have the Acts and the Epistles, which mainly are a revelation of Christ as the Spirit. Hence, the revelation of the Spirit is the continuation of the divine revelation in the Bible. Following this, the church is revealed. Thus, there are four main sections of the divine revelation in the Bible: the section of God, the section of Christ, the section of the Spirit, and the section of the church.

The Jews have only the first section of this revelation, for the thirty-nine books of the Old Testament cover only the revelation concerning God. Most Christians have more than this, having the Old Testament plus the four Gospels. Although they have the whole Bible, in practicality they have little more than the Old Testament and the Gospels. They may know God as He is revealed in the Old Testament and they may know the stories in the Gospels about Christ, but they know nothing of either the Spirit of life or the church. In the concept of many Christians, the church is a physical building. On Sunday morning, many parents say to their children, "Let's go to church." According to their concept, the church is a bungalow, or a cathedral, with a high tower. They know hardly anything of the church as revealed in the Holy Word.

Thank God that during the past two centuries other Christians have progressed in their knowledge of the Bible, having not only the Old Testament and the Gospels but also the Epistles. These Christians know God, Christ, and the Spirit. Of course, they do not know much about the Spirit of life. They know the Spirit mainly as the Spirit of power for baptism. They know very little of the indwelling Spirit. Although these Christians may know a little concerning the church, they only see the universal church, not the local churches. However, the first three chapters of Revelation are not concerned with the universal church; they are emphatically concerned with the local churches.

Today, we in the Lord's recovery have the whole Bible: the Old Testament, the Gospels, the Acts, the Epistles, and the Revelation. I was with the Brethren Assembly for seven and a half years. During that time, we devoted considerable attention to the books of Daniel and Revelation. However, most of what I heard concerning Revelation was about the beasts and the ten horns. I had no impression that in the book of Revelation there were the local churches. I did not even hear much about the New Jerusalem. I was only told that it was a city in heaven with heavenly mansions, that its street was paved with gold, and that its doors were made of pearls. Praise the Lord that today our book of Revelation is not like this! In our book of Revelation, there are the local churches with the Son of Man in the midst, and there is the New Jerusalem with Christ as its centrality and universality.

A. Concerning God

Let us now consider the progress of the divine revelation in the Scriptures in more detail. Firstly, God reveals Himself to us (Gen. 1:1). In Gen. 1:26 God is revealed as Elohim, a Hebrew word meaning "the mighty One." The English word God is the translation of the Hebrew word Elohim. Following this, in Gen. 2:7 God is revealed as Jehovah, which means, "I am that I am." God is the great I Am, the ever-existing One. As the ever-existing One, He is the reality of every positive thing. This name, Jehovah, denotes God in His relationship with man. Concerning His creation, God is revealed as Elohim; concerning His relationship with man, He is revealed as Jehovah. Jehovah is the Old Testament form of the name Jesus, and Jesus is the New Testament form of Jehovah. In other words, in the Old Testament Jesus was called Jehovah, and in the New Testament Jehovah is called Jesus. The entire Old Testament, which comprises thirty-nine books, is mainly a revelation of the two divine titles, Elohim and Jehovah.

B. Concerning Christ

The second step in the progress of the divine revelation is the revelation concerning Christ (Matt. 1:1). At a certain time, God was incarnated as a man called Jesus Christ. Thus, following the Old Testament, we have the four Gospels which reveal a wonderful Person named Jesus Christ. The name Jesus mainly means the Savior (Matt. 1:21), and the title Christ mainly means the anointed One (Matt. 16:16). Jesus is not only our Savior but also God's anointed One or, using today's term, God's appointed One. God has appointed Him to carry out His eternal economy. He is not only Jesus to save us, but also Christ to carry out God's eternal plan.

In order for Christ to carry out God's eternal plan, He needs the church. And to produce the church there is the need of two things — redemption and the imparting of life. After redeeming the fallen, created man, Christ had to impart life into the redeemed ones. For this, there is the need of the Spirit of life, the life-giving Spirit. Therefore, following the four Gospels, we have redemption and the imparting of life in the Acts and the Epistles. In these books, the blood of Christ is frequently mentioned. Along with the blood, we have the Spirit. Blood is for redemption, and the Spirit is for the imparting of life. After being redeemed and regenerated, we become the living members of the Body of Christ, the church. As the church, the Body is the means by which Christ carries out God's eternal economy. By this we see that in God's economy the church is a very crucial matter. Without it, Christ cannot accomplish anything. If He would carry out God's eternal plan, He must have the church.

C. Concerning the Spirit

God is revealed as Elohim and as Jehovah, and Christ is revealed as Jesus and as Christ. The revelation concerning the Spirit, however, is not simple (Matt. 28:19); rather, it is a mystery. Few Christians have ever fought for the revelation of God, and not many have fought for the revelation of Christ. But when we come to the matter of the Spirit, there is much argument because the revelation of the Spirit is a mystery. The Spirit is mysterious because it is related to life. There are many aspects of the revelation of the Spirit: the Spirit of truth or reality (John 14:16-17), the Spirit of life (Rom. 8:2), the Spirit of power (Luke 24:49), the Spirit of God (Rom. 8:9), the Spirit of Christ (Rom. 8:9), the Spirit of Jesus (Acts 16:7), the Spirit of Jesus Christ (Phil. 1:19), the Holy Spirit (Acts 5:32), and the seven Spirits (Rev. 1:4; 4:5; 5:6).

Do you know the difference between the Spirit of life and the Spirit of power? Those in the so-called Pentecostal or charismatic movement talk about the Spirit of power. Only the Lord knows whether or not they have the genuine power. I have heard much so-called speaking in tongues, but I have not seen power in the work of these tongues speakers. The baptism of the Holy Spirit empowers people. But so many of the supposed tongues speakers today are just as powerless as the non-tongues speakers. They may have the power to babble incoherently, but they do not have the power to save souls. Although some never have spoken such "tongues," thousands of people have been saved through their preaching. That is real power. Not only is there no real power in the so-called charismatic movement; neither is there any life. After speaking in tongues, many will proceed to fight with their wives or to smoke cigarettes. Is this life? No! Life transforms people. We need both the Spirit of power and the Spirit of life.

We are here for the testimony of Jesus. This testimony is not a term or a form; it is a life. How we need to open up ourselves to Him that He may impart more life into us. If we truly have Christ as our life, we shall walk, live, and behave ourselves in Christ. Now we can understand why the Epistles repeatedly speak about the Spirit. As we have seen, the book of Revelation speaks of the seven Spirits of God. For the church life, there is the need of this intensified Spirit. Out of this intensified Spirit, the real church comes into being. While I do not oppose any genuine Pentecostal gifts, I can testify that in the past I have not seen one proper church built up by the so-called Pentecostal movement. Consider the Catholic charismatic movement today: it is saturated with the worship of Mary. If this movement is proper, how could it tolerate idol worship? That it tolerates idolatry proves that it is not proper. Dirt can be added to a snowball, but not to a diamond. The so-called charismatic movement is like a snowball to which unclean things can be added. Our eyes need to be opened to see that today God desires the real, living, and practical local churches.

D. Concerning the church

Now we come to the last section of the divine revelation, the revelation concerning the church. It is difficult to know the church because Satan, the subtle enemy, is not willing for Christians to see what the real church is.

1. The universal church

The church as the Body of Christ (1 Cor. 12:12-13) is universally one (Eph. 1:22-23; 4:4-6). Christ as the unique Head has one unique Body which is constituted with all His genuine believers.

2. The local churches

The universal church as the Body of Christ is expressed through the local churches. The local churches, as the expressions of the one Body of Christ (Rev. 1:12, 20), are locally one (Acts 8:1; 13:1; Rom. 16:1; 1 Cor. 1:2). Revelation 1:4 says, "John to the seven churches which are in Asia." Asia was a province of the ancient Roman Empire in which were the seven cities mentioned in Rev. 1:11. The seven churches were in those seven cities respectively, not all in one city. This book does not deal with the one universal church but with the local churches in many cities. The church is firstly revealed as universal in Matt. 16:18 and then as local in Matt. 18:17. In Acts the church was practiced in the way of local churches, such as the church at Jerusalem (Acts 8:1), the church at Antioch (Acts 13:1), the church at Ephesus (Acts 20:17), and the churches in the provinces of Syria and Cilicia (Acts 15:41). Except for a few written to some individuals, all the Epistles were written to the local churches. Not one was written to the universal church. Without the local churches there is no practicality and actuality of the universal church. The universal church is realized in the local churches. Knowing the church universally must be consummated in knowing the church locally. It is a great advance for us to know and practice the local churches. Concerning the church, the book of Revelation is in the advanced stage, for it is written to local churches. If we would know this book, we must advance from the understanding of the universal church to the realization and practice of the local churches. Only those who are in the local churches are rightly positioned with the right angle and the proper perspective to see the visions in this book.

In 1:11 the voice said to John, "What you see write in a book and send it to the seven churches: to Ephesus, and to Smyrna, and to Pergamos, and to Thyatira, and to Sardis, and to Philadelphia, and to Laodicea." This verse is composed in a very important way. In this verse we see that the sending of this book "to the seven churches" equals the sending of it to the seven cities. This shows clearly that the practice of the church life in the early days was that of one church for one city, one city with one church. In no city was there more than one church. This is the local church, local city-wise, not street-wise or area-wise. The jurisdiction of a local church should cover the whole city in which the church is; it should not be greater or lesser than the boundary of the city. All the believers within that boundary should constitute the one unique local church within that city. Hence, one church equals one city, and one city equals one church. This is what we call the local churches.

Rev. 1:4 speaks of "the seven churches." Seven is the number for completion in God's operation, such as seven days for God's creation (Gen. 1:31; 2:1-3), seven seals (Rev. 5:5), seven trumpets (Rev. 8:2), and seven bowls (Rev. 15:7) for God's move on the earth. Hence, the seven churches are for God's move in completion.

The church needs to have its expression. If we talk about the church without having the expression of the church, our talk is entirely theoretical; it is not practical. For the church to be real and practical, there is the need of the local churches. If you do not have the local churches, you do not have the church. Likewise, if you do not have the members, you do not have the Body. If you do not have the local church, you cannot have the universal church, for the universal church is composed of all the local churches just as the human body is composed of its many members. To have only the universal church is to be in a Vanity Fair. But we do have the local churches in practicality. If we are asked where the church is, we can point to the churches in Anaheim, San Francisco, Chicago, New York, and many other places.

Some Christian friends have argued with me, saying, "Why do you say that you are the church and that we are not the church?" Sometimes I have replied, "If you say that you are the church, please show that you are the church. Show me where the church is." Some have responded by saying that they have sent out many missionaries. Deep within, they know that they are not the church. The fact is the fact. If you are the church, then why do you not call yourself the church? You know what you are. Do not pretend or presume to be what you are not. Since I am a man, I must designate myself as a man. What else can I do? In 1963 I was asked to speak at a certain place in Missouri. At the end of the meeting, the host stood up and, in a nice, humble, polite way, said, "Brother Lee, please tell us why you call yourselves the church in Los Angeles." I replied, "Brother, if we don't call ourselves the church, then what should we call ourselves? We simply are the church. This is not only the truth but also the fact." We are what we are. Although we might pretend or presume to be something else, that is not what we truly are. Before the Lord's recovery came to the United States, no Christians said that they were the church in Los Angeles. Therefore, when we came to Los Angeles, we had to call ourselves the church in Los Angeles.

Rev. 1:20 says, “The mystery of the seven stars which you have seen on My right hand and the seven golden lampstands: the seven stars are messengers of the seven churches, and the seven lampstands are seven churches.” When John saw the seven stars in the right hand of Christ and the seven golden lampstands in the midst of which was Christ, it was a mystery to him. He did not realize the significance of the seven heavenly stars and the seven golden lampstands. Hence, the Lord unveiled the mystery to him, saying that “the seven stars are messengers of the seven churches, and the seven lampstands are seven churches.” The significance of this was not only a mystery to John, but also to believers today. All believers need the unveiling of this mystery to see the churches and their messengers.

The churches, signified by the golden lampstands, are “the testimony of Jesus” (Rev. 1:2, 9) in the divine nature, shining in the dark night locally, yet collectively. The churches should be of the divine nature — golden. They should be the stands, even the lampstands, that bear the lamp with the oil (Christ as the life-giving Spirit), shining in the darkness respectively and collectively. They are individual lampstands locally, yet at the same time they are a group, a collection, of lampstands universally. They are not only shining locally, but also bearing universally the same testimony both to the localities and to the universe. They are of the same nature and in the same shape. They bear the same lamp for the same purpose and are fully identified with one another, not having any individual distinctiveness. The differences of the local churches recorded in chapters two and three are all of a negative nature, not of a positive nature. Negatively, in their failures, they are different and separate one from another; but positively, in their nature, shape, and purpose, they are absolutely identical and connected one to another. It is easy for believers to see the universal church, but it is difficult for them to see the churches. The revelation of the local churches is the Lord’s ultimate unveiling concerning the church. It has been given here in the last book of the divine Word. To fully know the church, believers must follow the Lord from the Gospels through the Epistles to the book of Revelation until they are enabled to see the local churches as unveiled here. In Revelation the first vision is concerning the churches. The churches with Christ as their center are the focus in the divine administration for the accomplishment of God’s eternal purpose.

If there were no local churches, I could not bear to go on living. I would rather die. Suppose there were no local churches. What would we do? We would have no goal, no aim, and no purpose, and our Christian life would be meaningless. The local churches are the goal, the aim, and the meaning of our Christian life. As you are enjoying the local church life, you may not appreciate it very much. But if the churches were taken away, then you would realize that you have been stripped of every blessing. Without the church life, we cannot live, for we would lose the goal and meaning of being a Christian today.

I hope that we all, especially the young people, will see that the destination of God’s revelation is the local churches. God’s revelation continued progressively, only stopping when He had reached the local churches. The local churches are God’s destination. God has brought His revelation into the local churches. This is the reason that the churches are full of revelation, light, and truth. Outside the churches there is the shortage of light, revelation, and food. But the churches are full of revelation because they are the destination of God’s revelation. Thus, all the riches of the divine revelation are here.

If you would see this, then you would realize that we are not over-zealous for the church. Our spirit testifies to this. Whenever we do not testify of the local churches, our spirit abates. Whenever we try to be wise and not arouse opposition against us by avoiding discussion of the church, we are immediately deadened within. But when we boldly speak of the local church, we are stirred up, our spirit is living and burning, and we feel like shouting, crying, and even thundering. I realize that it is better not to offend people. However, when I try not to offend people, I offend the Lord. But when I strongly tell people that the local churches are the Lord’s destination, I sense that the Lord is with me. According to the whole Bible, the Son of Man, Christ, is walking in the midst of the local churches. If you are seeking Christ, then you must come to the local churches. The Son of Man is moving among the churches and caring for them. If you would participate in this caring, you must be in the local churches. Our burden today is to bring God’s people to His goal, and our purpose is to help the saints to reach God’s destination.

Before we came into the local churches, we were wanderers. We never had the sense that we had come home or that we had reached our destination. But the day we came into the local churches, we realized that we had come home. After wandering for years, we knew that we had finally reached our destination. When we first came into the local church life, something deep within said, “This is the place,” and we knew that we were home. Because we have arrived at our destination, we do not need to travel anymore. So many seeking Christians today are travelers; they travel from one denomination or group to another. But the day we came into the church life, our wanderings ceased. The local churches are what God desires today. This is the last station of His revelation. Our need is simply to live the local church life. Our testimony is that we are not an organization — we are the local expressions of the Body of Christ.

II. The progress of the manifestation of God

God is embodied and expressed in Christ (John 1:1, 14; 1 Tim. 3:16; Col. 2:9), and Christ is realized and experienced as the Spirit (John 14:16-17; 1 Cor. 15:45b; 2 Cor. 3:17; Rom. 8:10; Phil. 1:19). The Spirit is the very constituent of the church which is the Body of Christ, His fullness (Eph. 1:22-23; 1 Cor. 12:12). Now the Body of Christ is expressed in all the local churches, for the local churches are the expressions of the universal church (Rev. 1:11-12). The local churches are the expression of the Body, the Body is the realization of Christ as the life-giving Spirit, and Christ is the embodiment of God. Thus, in the local churches we have God, Christ, the Spirit, and the church. This is why the local churches are so rich. Where can you meet God with His purpose? In the local churches. Where can you gain Christ with all His riches? In the local churches. Where can you participate in the intensified life-giving Spirit? In the local churches. Where can you be a practical part of the Body? In the local churches. Oh, the local churches mean so much to us! Hallelujah! Amen! We are no longer wanderers — we are people in the local churches! We have reached our destination and have come home! We are home for eternity! Here in the churches we have God with His purpose, we have Christ with His riches, we have the intensified life-giving Spirit, and we have the proper church life. Here the Bible is not only open — it is real. Hallelujah for the local churches! We really have something to be excited about!

God’s revelation began with God Himself and continued with Christ and the Spirit until it reached its goal in the local churches. Without the local churches, we do not have the goal of the divine revelation. Here the shortage among the Jews, many Christians, and even many so-called spiritual people becomes evident. The Jews have God, most Christians have God and Christ, and the improved Christians also have the Spirit, but very few Christians have the proper church life in the local churches. Today, in the local churches, we have God, Christ, the Spirit, and the church.

The issue of the progress of the manifestation of God is the church. God is embodied in Christ, Christ is realized and experienced as the Spirit who imparts life to us, and the Spirit issues in the churches. When we experience and realize Christ as the life-giving Spirit, the issue is the church life. The church is the Body, the fullness of Christ. The progress of this revelation is God, Christ, the Spirit, the church, and the local churches. This is the revelation of God in His Holy Word. In this, we can see how God is realized by us and how He is actually expressed and manifested.

God firstly took the step of being incarnated, of being embodied in Christ. If you want to meet God, you must meet Christ. Do you want to come to God? Then you must come to Christ. Outside of Christ, it is impossible to touch God. God is embodied in a practical and real man by the name of Jesus Christ. When you meet Him, you meet God. When you touch Him, you touch God. When you gain Him, you gain God. When you receive Him, you receive God, because He is the very embodiment of God Himself. This Christ is realized and experienced by us as the life-giving Spirit. He is not only our Savior, our Redeemer, our Lord, our holiness, and our righteousness; He is the very life-giving Spirit. His being our Savior, Redeemer, and Lord is for Him to be the life-giving Spirit. What we actually and practically have today is the life-giving Spirit. Most Christians have missed this very crucial point, for the subtle enemy has done his best to hide this matter. In the past years, we have given many messages and printed a number of books concerning Christ as the life-giving Spirit, but some Christians do not see it. Rather, they oppose it. This is the subtlety of the enemy.

If Christ were only our Savior, Redeemer, and Lord, how could the church be practically produced? The Savior does not produce the church directly; neither does the Lord produce the church directly. In order for the church to be produced, there is the need for Christ to be the life-giving Spirit. In knowing Christ as the life-giving Spirit we must not rely upon our mentality, for it is too limited to comprehend this. Although we cannot understand it thoroughly, we can experience it. Check with your experience. Your daily experience testifies that the Christ whom you enjoy is the life-giving Spirit within you. Not only is Christ Himself wonderful, mysterious, unlimited, and unsearchable, but even the food we enjoy each day is beyond our understanding. Although we cannot know food by exercising our mentality, we can know its taste by our experience. By our experience, we know what food is. Do not pay attention to theological talk. Those who engage in this talk are snared by the over-exercise of their mentality. We just care for the pure Word in the divine revelation and for our personal, practical experience. Our experience testifies that the very Christ whom we enjoy each day is the life-giving Spirit. Do you not have the reality of the living One within you? This is the very Christ whom we are enjoying, experiencing, and partaking of in our spirit. This is the life-giving Spirit who is Christ Himself. Thus, God is embodied in Christ, and Christ is realized and experienced in us as the life-giving Spirit.

This experience issues in the church. The more we experience Christ in this way, the more we long for the church. This experience creates a hunger and a thirst deep within. Formerly, when we were not in the local churches, we could not specify what we were hungry and thirsty for. But after coming into the church, we realized that our experience of Christ had created a hunger and thirst for the church life. When we came into the church life, our hunger and thirst were satisfied. This satisfaction creates within us a deeper appreciation of Christ, and this in turn causes us to enjoy Him more and more. The more we enjoy Christ, the more we long for the church life; the more we long for the church life, the more we get into the church; and the more we get into the church, the more we appreciate and enjoy Christ. This is a glorious cycle, and we can testify that we are in it.

The purpose of this ministry is not to render knowledge to the saints. It is to help the saints open their eyes, mind, heart, and spirit to see God’s revelation. Whatever we minister matches our experience. Today we are here for the testimony of Jesus which issues from the genuine experience of Christ as the life-giving Spirit. Thus, I say, once again, that God is embodied in Christ, Christ is realized and experienced as the life-giving Spirit, and the experience of Christ as the life-giving Spirit issues in the church life. The church is the Body, the expression and the fullness of Christ. As such, it must have its local expressions. The universal church is the Body, the fullness, of Christ, and the local churches are the expressions of this universal church. We are in these expressions today. Hallelujah!

III. The way to see God’s revelation and to realize God’s manifestation

A. To be separated unto God

To see God’s revelation and to realize His manifestation, we need to be separated unto God. The apostle John was fully separated unto God on the island of Patmos (Rev. 1:9). He was also brought to the open door of heaven (Rev. 4:1) and to a great and high mountain (Rev. 21:10), and thus saw God’s revelation and realized God’s manifestation. Today, many Christians who are talking about the church do not see the local churches, mainly because they are not separated unto God.

B. To be in the human spirit

Revelation 1:10 says, “I was in spirit on the Lord’s day and heard behind me a loud voice like a trumpet.” The book of Revelation not only stresses the Spirit of God as the sevenfold intensified Spirit for God’s intensified move, but also our human spirit as the organ for us to realize and respond to God’s move. Only (our) spirit can respond to (God’s) Spirit. The book of Revelation is composed of four major visions: the vision of the churches (ch. 1—3); the vision of the destiny of the world (ch. 4—16); the vision of the great Babylon (ch. 17—20); and the vision of the New Jerusalem (ch. 2—22). To see these four visions, John was in his spirit (Rev. 1:10; 4:2; 17:3; 21:10), as mentioned in Eph. 3:5 (“by the Spirit” should be “in spirit,” Gk.) for the revelation of the mystery of Christ. We also need to be in our spirit to see the visions of this book. It is not merely a matter of mental understanding, but of spiritual realization. In the first vision of this book, the vision concerning the churches, both Christ and the messengers of the churches are unveiled with the churches as never before, and this in a most particular way. For this the believers need a particular vision in their spirits.

The Lord’s day in this verse should be the first day of the week, the day the Lord was resurrected (John 20:1). The early church used to meet on this day (Acts 20:7; 1 Cor. 16:2). It was on this day that John was in spirit to see the visions of God’s economy. To see the revelation of the local churches, we need to turn from our reasoning mind to our seeing spirit. Remaining in the reasoning mind confuses the vision of the churches.

C. To hear the Lord’s voice

If Christians only understand the doctrine concerning the local churches, they may not see the vision. All Christians need to hear the voice, the present and living speaking of the Lord. The Lord’s voice directs us to the vision of the local churches.

D. To turn to the Lord’s voice

Revelation 1:12 says, “And I turned to see the voice that spoke with me; and having turned I saw seven golden lampstands.” To see anything requires the right position with the right angle. The apostle John firstly heard the voice (v. 10), and when he “turned to see” the voice, he saw the golden lampstands. He was rightly positioned, but he still needed the right angle to see the vision concerning the churches; thus, he turned. It is the same with us today. Many Christians need to be adjusted in their position and turned that they may see the vision of the churches.

The Seven Lampstands

Since nearly everything in the book of Revelation is based upon the Old Testament, most of the items mentioned in this book are not new. Most of what this book reveals can be traced back to the Old Testament. Nevertheless, all the items found in Revelation have a new significance. For example, the city of Jerusalem, a city with twelve gates, is found in Ezek. 48, but at the end of Revelation we see the city of Jerusalem in a new way. Because Revelation is a book of conclusion, the fulfillment of the things in the Bible, nearly everything contained in it is presented in a new way. This is true of the lampstands in chapter one. The lampstand is mentioned in Exo. 25 and Zech. 4, but in Revelation it is mentioned in a new way. In this message we must consider the seven lampstands in Rev. 1.

The lampstands are the symbols of the local churches. Although we have seen that the local churches are the testimony of Jesus, it may be somewhat difficult for many to grasp the meaning of this. What does it mean to say that the local churches are the testimony of Jesus? It means that the churches are the lampstands.

Throughout the centuries, few Christians have touched the depths of the significance of the lampstand. In this message we must probe into the depths of this matter of the lampstands. Biblical symbols are difficult to comprehend, for we cannot understand a symbol like the lampstand according to our natural concept. According to our natural concept, a lampstand is simply an object holding a lamp that shines in the darkness. The lampstand in Exodus 25 is pure gold, and the lampstands in Zechariah 4 and Revelation also are golden. Substantially, the lampstand is golden. With the lampstand we see three important things: the gold, the stand, and the lamps. The lampstand implies the significance of the Triune God. Gold is the substance with which the lampstand is made, the stand is the embodiment of the gold, and the lamps are the expression of the stand. The gold signifies the Father as the substance, the stand signifies the Son as the embodiment of the Father, and the lamps signify the Spirit as the expression of the Father in the Son. Thus, the significance of the Triune God is implied in the lampstand.

On the walls of Jewish synagogues there is a symbol of the lampstand. Although the Jews have used this symbol for centuries, they do not know its real significance — the significance of the Triune God. Have you ever realized that the lampstand implies the significance of the Triune God?

Substantially, the lampstand is one, but expressively, it is seven because it is one lampstand with seven lamps. At the bottom, the lampstand is one; at the top, it is seven. Should we argue about whether it is one or seven? In substance, the lampstand is one piece of gold, but it holds seven lamps. This mysteriously indicates that substantially the Triune God is one. In substance, He is one, but in expression, He is the seven Spirits. The Father as the substance is embodied in the Son as the form, and the Son is expressed as the seven Spirits.

How can we prove that the seven lamps are the Spirit expressing Christ? The seven lamps are first mentioned in Exodus. If we only had the record in Exodus, however, it would be difficult to realize that these seven lamps are the Spirit. But as we proceed from Exodus to Zechariah, we see that the seven lamps are the seven eyes of Christ and the seven eyes of God (Zech. 3:9; 4:10). As we continue on to Revelation, we see that the seven eyes of the Lamb are the seven eyes which are the intensified Spirit of God. Hence, we have a strong basis for saying that the seven lamps are the sevenfold intensified Spirit as the expression of Christ.

We have seen that the lampstand implies the significance of the Triune God; it symbolizes the Triune God embodied and expressed. God the Father as the divine gold is embodied in Christ the Son and then is fully expressed through the Spirit. The expression differs from the embodiment. The embodiment must be uniquely one because our God is uniquely one. Thus, the embodiment must be one stand. The expression, however, must be complete, and complete in God's move. Recall that seven is the number for completion in God's move. Throughout the centuries, God has been expressed in His move. This is the reason that the seven lamps signify the intensified Spirit as the expression of Christ in God's complete move. This is the practical understanding of the Trinity. The Trinity is for the dispensing of God into humanity. God, the divine Being, is firstly embodied in Christ and then expressed through the sevenfold intensified Spirit. Now we not only have the Triune God; in the lampstand we have the Triune God substantially and solidly embodied and expressed. The gold has been formed into the solid stand. It once was just gold, but now it is the stand. The gold has been formed into a stand for the fulfillment of God's purpose. Without the stand, there is no way for God's purpose to be fulfilled. As we have seen, this stand, which is a type of Christ, is expressed through the seven lamps signifying the seven Spirits of God. The seven Spirits of God are not separate from God; they are the seven eyes of God and of the Lamb, the Redeemer. As we shall see, they are also the seven eyes of the building stone. Hence, they are the seven eyes with the redemption of Christ for God's building. Whenever these eyes look at people, they are redeemed and built into God's house. This is the Trinity.

In Exodus 25 the emphasis is upon the stand, in Zechariah 4 the emphasis is upon the lamps, and in Revelation 1 the emphasis is upon the reproduction. In both Exodus and Zechariah, the lampstand is one, but in Revelation it has been reproduced and has become seven. Firstly, in Exodus the emphasis is on the stand — on Christ. Secondly, in Zechariah the emphasis is on the lamps — on the Spirit. Eventually, in Revelation both the stand and the lamps, that is, both Christ and the Spirit, are reproduced as the churches. In Exodus and Zechariah there are just seven lamps, but here in Revelation there are forty-nine lamps, for every lampstand has seven lamps. Hence, the one lampstand has become seven and the seven lamps have become forty-nine. The lampstands with their lamps in Revelation are the reproduction of Christ and the Spirit. When Christ is realized, He is the Spirit, and when the Spirit is realized, we have the churches as the reproduction.

The church is not only universally one but also expressed locally in many cities. In the whole universe there is only one Christ, one Spirit, and one church. Why then are there the seven churches? Because of the need for an expression. For existence, one is sufficient, but for expression, many are needed. If we would know the church, we must know its substance, existence, and expression. Substantially, the church, and even all the churches, are one. In expression, the many churches are the many lampstands. What is the church? The church is the expression of the Triune God, and this expression is seen in many localities on the earth. The church is signified not by just one lampstand — but by seven lampstands. In Revelation 1 there are seven lampstands with forty-nine lamps shining in the universe. This is the testimony of Jesus. The church is the testimony of Jesus. This means that the church is the expression of the Triune God substantially and expressively. Substantially, it is of one substance in the whole universe; expressively, it is many lampstands with the lamps shining in the darkness to express the Triune God. The Father as the substance is embodied in the Son, the Son as the embodiment is expressed through the Spirit, the Spirit is fully realized and reproduced as the churches, and the churches are the testimony of Jesus. If we see this vision, it will govern us and we shall never be divisive. This vision will hold us, guard us, and keep us in the testimony of Jesus.

We have seen that the lampstand is the divine gold embodied into a substantial form to fulfill God's purpose in His move. The expression of the stand is in the shining of the light. As the expression shines, the shining fulfills God's eternal purpose. Thus, the lampstand not only signifies the Triune God, but also the move of the Triune God in His embodiment and expression. We also have seen that the local churches are the reproduction of the embodiment and expression of the Triune God. This is not a small thing. We should not be satisfied with saying that the local churches are the lampstands shining in the dark night. Although this is correct, it is rather shallow. We must see that the local churches are the reproduction of the embodiment and expression of the Triune God.

In the Bible, the lampstand is always related to God's building. The first time it was mentioned was in Exo. 25:31-40 when the tabernacle was built. The second instance was in the building of the temple in 1 Kings 7:49. The third instance had very much to do with the rebuilding of God's temple in Zech. 4:2-10. Here in Revelation it is related to the building of the churches. In Exodus 25 the emphasis is on Christ being the lampstand as the divine light, shining as the seven lamps with the Spirit (the oil). In Zechariah 4 the emphasis is on the Spirit (v. 6) shining as the seven lamps which are the seven eyes of God (vv. 2, 10). The seven eyes of God are the seven Spirits of God (Rev. 5:6) for God's intensified move. This indicates that the lampstand in Zechariah is the reality of the lampstand in Exodus, and the lampstands in Revelation are the reproduction of the lampstand in Zechariah, Christ is realized as the Spirit, and the Spirit is expressed as the churches. The shining Spirit is the reality of the shining Christ, and the shining churches are the reproduction and the expression of the shining Spirit to accomplish God's eternal purpose that the New Jerusalem as the shining city may be consummated. Christ, the Spirit, and the churches are all of the same divine nature.

I. The lampstand for the building of the tabernacle (temple)

We have seen that the lampstand is for God's building. The lampstand in Exodus 25 was for the building of the tabernacle, the lampstand in Zechariah 4 was for the recovery of God's building, and the lampstands in Revelation 1 are for the building of the church. This indicates that the Triune God is for God's building. While Christians talk a great deal about the Trinity, very few have seen that the Triune God is for God's building. The lampstand in Exodus 25 typifies Christ as the expression of God shining with the seven lamps, the seven Spirits of God.

The way the Bible presents the lampstands is very interesting. Firstly, the Bible reveals that for the building of the tabernacle there was the need of the lampstand. The lampstand was also necessary for the function of the tabernacle. The tabernacle had no windows, and its entrance was completely covered by a curtain. Since there were no openings, there was no way light could come in from the outside. Without the lampstand shining in the tabernacle, no one inside would have been able to function. Thus, the lampstand was not only for the building of the tabernacle but also for its function.

Likewise, without the lampstand, there is no building of the church and no function in the church. The church's function depends upon the shining lampstand. We in the church need the shining of the lampstand. Often, when you consider what to do or how to do it, you find yourself confused. The more you think, the more dense the darkness becomes. But when you come into the church meeting or fellowship with the saints, you are immediately enlightened and say, "Oh, now I see the way." No one gave you a message telling you what to do. You were made clear by the shining of the lampstand in the church. The lampstand shines upon us in the church.

The lampstand is not only for God's building, but also for the function in God's building. In order to function, we must have light. The light of the shining lampstand is in the church. This is why we cannot afford to stay away from the church. Do not say, "As long as I read the Bible and pray at home, everything will be the same." If you try this, you will rush back to the church after a few days. For this reason, we do not like to take a vacation unless we can go to a place where there is a church. The church not only has the lampstand but also is the lampstand.

II. The lampstand for the building of the recovered temple

The lampstand is needed even more for the recovery of God's building. Zechariah 4 reveals that the lampstand emphasizing the Spirit is for the recovery of God's building. Today, there is a greater need for the lampstand because we are not only in God's building, but also in the recovery of His building. We need the lampstand to shine upon us and to strengthen us.

A. Signifying the Spirit for God's move

For the recovery of His temple, God gave a vision to Zechariah that by it he might be able to strengthen Zerubbabel. In this vision, Zechariah saw a lampstand with seven lamps into which oil was flowing from two olive trees. Then the angel said to Zechariah, "This is the word of the Lord unto Zerubbabel, saying, Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit, saith the Lord of hosts" (Zech. 4:6). This indicates that the Spirit of God is for His move on the earth.

B. With seven lamps which are the seven eyes

The seven lamps on the lampstand in Zechariah are the seven eyes. Firstly, these seven eyes are the eyes of Christ as the stone for God's building (Zech. 4:2, 10; 3:9). Rev. 5:6 also speaks of the seven eyes of Christ, the Lamb, saying that they are "the seven Spirits of God sent forth into all the earth." The seven Spirits are the seven eyes of Christ. In Zechariah 3 and 4 Christ is the stone for God's building, and in Revelation 5 He is the Lamb for our redemption. This indicates that the redeeming Christ is the building stone. Both the Lamb and the stone have the seven eyes which are the seven Spirits of God. In Zechariah the seven eyes are the eyes of the stone, while in Revelation they are the eyes of the Lamb.

The seven lamps, which are the seven eyes of Christ, are also the eyes of God for His move (Zech. 4:10). Christ has the seven eyes, the seven Spirits of God, for God's move. Firstly, Christ is the redeeming Lamb and eventually He is the building stone. This is absolutely for God's move on earth, through redemption to the goal of building. Today we are enjoying redemption for the building. We enjoy Christ not only as the redeeming Lamb, but also as the building stone. Christ's redemption is for God's building. In Him we are redeemed, and in Him we are built up. He is accomplishing this by the seven Spirits of God which are for God's move today.

C. The lamps being for enlightening and the eyes being for transfusion by looking

The lamps are for enlightening, and the eyes are for transfusion by looking. These eyes are not only for searching, observing, and judging, but especially for transfusing. Whenever Christ looks at us with His seven eyes, we are spontaneously infused by Him. Whether we are being judged, enlightened, searched, or burned, He transfuses all that He is into us. Whenever Christ enlightens us, He shines into us, transfusing all that He is into us that we might become a transformed precious stone for God's building.

III. The lampstands being for the building of the local churches

A. Symbolizing the local churches as the testimony of Jesus

The lampstands in Revelation are the symbols of the local churches. Every local church is a lampstand shining forth the testimony of Jesus with the sevenfold intensified Spirit of God as the lamps in its locality.

B. Divine in nature

The lampstands are golden. As we have seen, gold signifies the divine nature of God. That the lampstands here are golden signifies that the churches are constituted with the divine nature of God. We have the Father's life and nature (2 Pet. 1:4), the Father's gold, possessing His golden divine nature. How wonderful that we have this divine substance.

C. Shining in the dark age with the seven Spirits of God

We may pay our attention only to the lampstands and neglect the lamps, but the lampstands are not for the lampstands; they are for the lamps. If the lampstands had no lamps, they would be meaningless. Therefore, we must point out what the lamps are. We see the lamps in chapter four: they are the seven Spirits of God burning before the throne (4:5). Thus, the seven Spirits of God are the seven burning lamps. Some have said that the lamps are Christ and that the church is the stand which holds Christ as the lamp. This is not bad, but Revelation does not say that the lamp firstly is Christ. Of course, when we come to chapter twenty-one, we see that Christ is the lamp in the New Jerusalem. However, Revelation does not say that Christ is the seven lamps today; rather, it says that the seven Spirits of God are the seven lamps.

We must be deeply impressed with how much the seven Spirits mean to us. If we are the churches as the lampstands, what should we hold? To say that we should hold Christ is too doctrinal. Who and what is Christ today? In our experiences for the church life, Christ is not merely Christ — He is the Spirit (2 Cor. 3:17). This Spirit, who is the life-giving Spirit, has been intensified in the book of Revelation into the seven Spirits which are the seven Spirits of God. These Spirits are the seven eyes, not only of God, but also of the Lamb. The church life is completely dependent upon these seven Spirits. It is not a matter of Christ doctrinally, but of the seven Spirits experientially. We must experience the Spirit. In our work, daily life, meetings, service, and testimonies, we must have the Spirit. If we lack the Spirit, we are empty and are nothing. The lampstands must hold the lamps which are the seven Spirits.

The seven Spirits are the expression of Christ. This is clearly indicated by the lampstand in Exodus 25. This lampstand, which was one piece of gold weighing a talent, is expressed through the seven lamps. This solid piece of pure gold signifies God the Father as our very substance. But if we only had God the Father, we would not have the form; we would have the gold, but no stand. To have only the Father without the Son is to have the substance without the embodiment. Only when the gold is beaten into the form of a stand do we have the embodiment. While the stand is the embodiment of the substance, without the seven lamps, this embodiment cannot have its expression. Hence, the substance is the Father, the embodiment is the Son, and the expression is the Spirit expressing God the Father in the Son. Since all that God the Father is in the Son is expressed through the seven lamps, the Bible later tells us that the seven lamps are the seven Spirits. Hence, the Spirit is the expression of the Triune God. Eventually, in the book of Revelation, we see that this expression is the expression of Christ, because the seven Spirits firstly were the seven eyes of God in Zechariah 4:10, and have become the seven eyes of the Lamb in Revelation 5:6. The seven eyes of the Lamb are the expression of Christ. Today, the Holy Spirit, who is the life-giving Spirit and also the seven Spirits, is the expression of Christ. Where is this expression today? It is with the churches, for the seven Spirits are the seven lamps held by the churches as the lampstands.

Many Christians today do not know the life-giving Spirit and the sevenfold intensified Spirit, or the seven Spirits as the expression of Christ held by the churches as the lampstands. If you would meet this Spirit, you must be with the churches. If you would touch, enjoy, and experience this Spirit, you must be a part of the church, for it is the churches as the lampstands which hold the seven Spirits of Christ who are the very expression of Christ. This Spirit is no more separate from Christ than your eyes are separate from you. Since a person's eyes are his expression, they cannot be separated from him. Likewise, since the seven Spirits are Christ's expression, they cannot be separated from Christ. The churches are the lampstands, and the lamps are the sevenfold intensified Spirit of God as the expression of Christ. This light is shining brighter and brighter, and the vision is becoming clearer every day.

The local churches as the golden lampstands shine with such a Spirit in the dark age of today. In today's dark age, the church really needs the sevenfold intensified Spirit of God to shine forth the testimony of Jesus.

D. The church being the embodiment of Christ and the reproduction of the Spirit

The church is the embodiment of Christ and the reproduction of the Spirit. The Spirit is the reality of Christ (John 14:17-20; 16:13-15), and the church is the reproduction of the Spirit (Rev. 22:17a). The church with the Spirit is the embodiment of Christ, the testimony of Jesus (Rev. 1:2, 9; 19:10). Therefore, the more Spirit, the more church and the more testimony of Jesus.

IV. The two lampstands for God's testimony in the great tribulation

In 11:4 we see the two lampstands, the two witnesses, for God's testimony during the great tribulation. The overcomers will be raptured before the tribulation, whereas the weaker ones, the green and tender ones, will be left on earth to pass through the tribulation. Due to this, there will be the need for the strengthening of God's testimony. To meet this need, God will send Elijah and Moses back to earth. Today, the testimony of the church mainly depends upon the stronger, more experienced ones. When the experienced ones have been raptured, the weaker ones will need to be strengthened. Although it may be quite good to be supplied by Moses and Elijah, I want to leave the earth before they return. In principle, the two witnesses in chapter eleven also are lampstands. The Bible describes them as the two olive trees which supply oil to the weaker ones (Zech. 4:3, 12). According to the parable of the ten virgins in Matthew 25, the five foolish virgins will need to buy oil. Once Brother Nee said that probably these foolish virgins would go to the two olive trees to gain the extra portion of the Spirit at a cost. These two olive trees are also called the two sons of oil, for they are full of the Spirit for God's testimony (Zech. 4:14) and are able to supply the weaker saints. During the great tribulation, many of the unripe ones will be strengthened and matured through their ministry.

The Son of Man in the Midst of the Churches

In chapter one of Revelation there are eight crucial points: the revelation of Christ, the testimony of Jesus, the Triune God, the second coming of Christ, the joint partakers in the tribulation, kingdom, and endurance in Jesus, the local churches, the lampstands, and the Son of Man. Having covered the first seven points, we come in this message to the eighth — the Son of Man in the midst of the churches (1:12-20). In this book, Christ is firstly revealed as the Son of Man. Whenever He is related to the church, He is revealed in His human nature because the church is composed of human beings. The Head of the church is not only the Son of God but also the Son of Man. That the Lord is still the Son of Man after His ascension indicates that He has not put off His human nature after resurrection and that His dealings with us are based upon His humanity. As a man, He succeeded in being God's testimony. Thus, we in the churches today, being human, can also be God's testimony. The Lord was victorious as a man, and we can be victorious also.

Christ today is "in the midst of" the churches. On the one hand, as the High Priest, He is interceding in the heavens for the churches (Heb. 9:24; 7:25-26; Rom. 8:34), and, on the other hand, He is moving in the churches to care for them. If we would participate in His move and enjoy His care, we must be in the churches.

I. In His humanity

Verse 13 says, "And in the midst of the lampstands One like the Son of Man, clothed with a garment reaching to the feet, and girded about at the breasts with a golden girdle." Christ is not only depicted here as the High Priest, as shown by His garments, but also unveiled "like the Son of Man." He is still both divine and human. As our High Priest, He is caring for the churches in His humanity.

Throughout the centuries, some so-called Christians have taught that Christ was not the Son of God. Even today, there are some so-called Christians who do not believe that Christ is the Son of God. To deny that Christ is the Son of God is heretical. Such a teaching is devilish and comes from Hades, and we must uncompromisingly stand against it. Some Christians, on the contrary, do not believe that Christ today is still the Son of Man. They say that Christ became a man by incarnation, but that in His resurrection He put off His humanity. Some of these Christians think that today Christ is merely the Son of God, no longer being the Son of Man. When about fifteen years ago I fought against this concept, some opposed me saying that it was erroneous to teach that Christ is still the Son of Man. While some Christians do not believe that Christ is the Son of Man today, we believe it. According to the pure Word, the Lord Jesus is still both the Son of God and the Son of Man. We cannot explain this adequately because our mind is so limited. Nevertheless, we believe and accept the fact that our Christ is both the Son of God with divinity and the Son of Man with humanity. In Him we have true divinity and proper humanity.

During the past nineteen centuries, especially during the first six centuries, Christology was a subject of intense controversy among Christians. Concerning the Person of Christ there have been differing opinions, and Christians have fought with one another about them. We must drop all these so-called theological schools. According to the Bible, we believe that our Christ is truly the Son of God and the Son of Man. He has two natures, divinity and humanity.

When Christ comes to deal with us in the churches, He does so not only in His divinity but also in His humanity. You may excuse yourself, thinking that the Lord could make it because He was the Son of God, but that since you are human the Lord must sympathize with you. As the Son of God, the Lord is quite capable, but you, as a mere son of man, are pitiful, and the Lord should not condemn you so much. But when He comes to us as the Son of Man, you have no excuse. He also was a man and made it as a man, not as the Son of God. Do not make any excuses for yourself. If you are defeated and fail in the church life, do not sympathize with yourself, saying that it is excusable because you are only a human being. Human beings are just the right material for the church life. Thus, in the midst of the churches, Christ is walking as the Son of Man. In Dan. 3 we are told that the Son of God was walking in the fire, but in Revelation 1 we see that it is the Son of Man who is walking in the midst of the churches. We all must worship Him as the Son of Man. Because He is both human and divine, He is such a wonderful One. Because He is both divine and human, He knows heaven and earth, God and man. In Him we have divinity and humanity. In Him we are in the heavens and also are on the earth. Today the Lord is both in the heavens and on the earth walking, in His humanity, in the midst of the local churches.

II. As the Priest

Verse 13 says that Christ is "clothed with a garment reaching to the feet." This garment is the priestly robe (Exo. 28:33-35) signifying the fullness of Christ's divine virtues and human attributes (cf. Isa. 6:1, 3). Although the word priest is not mentioned here, we know by His garment that Christ is depicted here as the High Priest. Today, the Son of Man, Jesus Christ, who is walking in the midst of the churches, is a Priest. Among the three offices of priest, prophet, and king, the most dear, intimate, precious, and lovely office is that of the priest. The priest is so dear and lovely because he takes care of the people. As Christ walks among the churches, He takes care of them.

III. Not working with strength, but caring for the churches in love

Verse 13 also says that Christ, the Son of Man, was "girded about at the breasts with a golden girdle." Have you ever seen someone girded about at the breasts with a girdle? This is quite meaningful. The priests in the Old Testament were girded at the loins for their ministry (Exo. 28:4). In Daniel 10:5 Christ is also girded with fine gold at His loins. But here Christ as our High Priest is "girded about at the breasts." The breasts signify love. To be girded at the loins is to be strengthened for work, whereas to be "girded about at the breasts" signifies care in love. Christ's work in producing the churches has been accomplished. Now He no longer needs to be girded at His loins for work. What He is doing now in the midst of the churches is to care for them in love. This requires Him to be "girded about at the breasts with a golden girdle." This "golden girdle" signifies divine strength. Christ is now exercising a divine care over the churches, moving among them in His humanity and caring for them with His divine strength. What a loving care He exercises over His churches today!

IV. Being ancient

Verse 14 says that "His head and hair were white as white wool, as snow." White hair signifies great age (Job 15:10). The black hair with which the Lord is depicted in S.S. 5:11 signifies His unfading and everlasting strength, but the white hair with which He is depicted here signifies His ancientness.

Although Christ is ancient, He is not old. In this chapter we see that His head and His hair were white as wool and as snow. White wool issues from the nature of life, and white snow comes down from the sky, from heaven. Wool is not made white; it is born white, and its whiteness comes out of its nature. White wool is the color of Christ's nature. His ancientness is of His nature. Snow is white because it comes from heaven and contains no earthly dirt or stain. Hence, white wool, both here and in Dan. 7:9, signifies that the ancientness of Christ is of His nature, not of His becoming old, while white snow signifies that His ancientness is heavenly, not earthly.

V. With watching, observing, searching, judging, and infusing eyes

In verse 14, we see that His eyes are as a flame of fire. In S.S. 5:12 the eyes of Christ are like doves. That is for the expression of His love. Here "His eyes" are "as a flame of fire." This is for Him to observe and search in His judging by enlightening. In this book His eyes are not two but seven (5:6). Seven is the number of completion in God's move. Hence, His eyes in this book are for God's operation. These seven eyes of His are the "seven lamps of fire burning before the throne, which are the seven Spirits of God" (Rev. 4:5; cf. Dan. 10:6). The "fire burning" equals the "flame of fire" and is for observing and searching. The seven Spirits of God which are sent forth into all the earth are also for God's move upon the earth. Thus, the eyes of Christ in this book are the seven Spirits of God for God's move and operation on earth today.

Christ's eyes are for watching, observing, searching, judging by enlightening, and infusing. We must experience all these different aspects of His eyes, especially the aspect of infusing. His eyes infuse us with all that He is. His infusing eyes are a flame of fire which is continually burning. This can be proved by our experience. Do not exercise your mind to understand this, but check with your experience. Since the day we were saved, Christ's eyes have been like a burning fire enlightening and infusing us. His eyes also stir us up to be hot. After Christ has looked at us, we can never be cold as we once were. By looking at us, He burns us and stirs us up in the Lord. Many times the Lord comes to us with His piercing eyes. Perhaps when we are trying to hide something from our wives, the Lord comes with seven shining eyes piercing into our being and exposing our true condition. I have had this kind of experience hundreds of times. When I was arguing with others, especially with my intimate ones, the shining eyes of Christ were upon me, and I could not go on speaking. His shining stopped my mouth.

The book of Revelation is a book with a judging nature. Fire is for divine judgment (1 Cor. 3:13; Heb. 6:8; 10:27). "Our God is also a consuming fire" (Heb. 12:29). His throne is like the fiery flame and its wheels as burning fire, and a fiery stream issues and comes forth from before Him (Dan. 7:9-10). All this is for judgment. The main significance of the Lord's eyes being as a flame of fire is for His judgment (Rev. 2:18-23; 19:11-12). When He comes to take possession of the earth by exercising judgment over it, even His feet will be like pillars of fire (Rev. 10:1).

VI. Having tried and shining feet

Verse 15 says, "His feet were like shining brass, as having been fired in a furnace." Feet signify the walk. In typology, brass signifies divine judgment (Exo. 27:1-6). When Christ was on earth, His earthly walk and daily walk were tried and tested. Because His walk was tested, He came out shining. Now the feet of Christ are as shining brass, as mentioned also in Ezek. 1:7 and Dan. 10:6, signifying that His perfect and bright walk qualifies Him to exercise divine judgment. To be "fired in the furnace" is to be tried by being burned. Christ's walk was tried by His sufferings, even by His death on the cross. Hence, His walk is bright as the shining brass, which qualifies Him to judge the unrighteous. As we have already pointed out, when He comes to possess the earth by judging it, His feet will be like pillars of fire (10:1).

VII. With a serious and solemn voice

Verse 15 also says that "His voice" is "as the sound of many waters." "The sound of many waters," a tumultuous sound, is the sound of the voice of the Almighty God (Ezek. 1:24; 43:2). It signifies the seriousness and solemnity of His speaking (cf. 10:3). Sometimes the Lord's voice is gentle and tender, but at other times His voice shocks us like thunder. Whenever we are sloppy or sleepy, the voice of the Lord will wake us up. His voice, which is that of the Almighty God, warns us and wakes us up.

VIII. Holding the messengers of the churches

Verse 16 says, "He had in His right hand seven stars." As verse 20 makes clear, "the seven stars are messengers of the seven churches." The messengers are the spiritual ones in the churches bearing the responsibility of the testimony of Jesus. Like stars, they should be of the heavenly nature and in a heavenly position. In the Acts and the Epistles the elders were the leading ones in the operation of the local churches (Acts 14:23; 20:17; Titus 1:5). The eldership is somewhat official, and, as we have seen, at the time this book was written the offices in the churches had deteriorated in the degradation of the church. In this book the Lord calls our attention back to spiritual reality. Hence, it emphasizes the messengers of the churches rather than the elders. The office of the elders is easily perceived, but the believers need to see the importance of the spiritual and heavenly reality of the messengers for the proper church life to bear the testimony of Jesus in the darkness of the church's degradation.

Both the lampstands and the stars are for shining in the night. A lampstand representing a local church is a collective unit, whereas a star representing a messenger of a local church is an individual entity. In the dark night of the church's degradation, there is the need of the shining both of the collective churches and of the individual messengers. As Christ walks among the churches, He holds the leading ones in His right hand. How comforting this is! The leading ones must praise Him that they are in His hands and that He is holding them. Since the leading ones are in His hands, there is no need for them shrink back, to be weak, or to be mistaken. Christ truly takes the responsibility for His testimony.

In the book of Revelation there are no elders in the churches; rather, there are messengers. At the time this book was written, the church had become degraded. Hence, in Revelation, the Lord repudiates all formalities. Being an elder may be somewhat legal or formal. Do not aspire to be an elder; desire to be a shining star. Do not be one with a mere position — be a shining star. Both the lampstand and the stars shine at night. Both the church and the leading ones in the churches must shine. All the leading ones must be stars.

IX. Out of His mouth proceeding the judging word

In verse 16 we are told that "out of His mouth proceeded a sharp two-edged sword." In Song of Songs 5:16, "His mouth is most sweet," and in the Gospels, "words of grace" proceeded out of His mouth (Luke 4:22); but here "out of His mouth proceeded a sharp two-edged sword." This is His discerning, judging, "and slaying word" (Heb. 4:12; Eph. 6:17). The "words of grace" are for His supply of grace to His favored ones, whereas the "sharp two-edged sword" is for His dealing with negative persons and things. We often say that the Spirit speaks to the churches. Remember that the speaking Spirit today is just this Christ who speaks with a two-edged sword. There is judgment here, and we all have experienced this. Because of the church's degradation, we all need a certain amount of judgment. Today all Christians need the judgment of the Lord by His word. Many times we have experienced this judgment because of our being mistaken and going astray from the Lord. Since we had wandered away from Him, He came to judge us. His speaking today is mainly a type of judgment. I can testify to you that if the Lord would speak to you, most of His words would be words of judgment. When He speaks, He judges. Every word out of His mouth in the churches today is like a sharp knife which judges us. The words which proceed out of the Lord's mouth are sharp, piercing into our being, dividing our soul from our spirit, and discerning the intents of our heart. This is the Christ we experience today in the church life.

In Christianity, there are numerous opinions and frequent debates and fights because of these opinions. I have seen this myself. I know of one case of some Christians who were serving as board members. Once, as they were meeting together, they were discussing and debating with one another; eventually the debate turned into a fight. At a certain point one of the board members even threw a Bible at another member. But in the Lord's recovery today we have One who is walking in our midst. He watches over us with His seven burning eyes, and out of His mouth proceeds a sharp two-edged sword. This sword has killed all the different concepts among us. This is the reason that there are almost no debates in the churches.

Recently, we completed our meeting hall in Anaheim. We can testify that during the months the building work was going on, we never fought with one another. One of the city inspectors told us that, according to his experience, whenever a church building is constructed, the building committee fights among itself. We could testify to this inspector that because of the killing sword, we did not fight with one another. This does not mean that we have no opinions or concepts. We are human and have many opinions. But, as we all can testify, every time an opinion rises up, the sword cuts it to pieces. The more you think about your opinion, the more you are cut. This is not doctrine — this is our experience. Whenever two brothers are close to fighting, the third party, the strongest party, appears, using the sharp sword to cut the opinions of both brothers. As we were building our meeting hall, the two-edged sword quelled all the turmoil. This third party is the very Christ, the Son of Man, who, as the High Priest, walks among the churches and cares for them in love. In the Old Testament, there was the need for the priests to trim the lamps. Today our Priest, the Son of Man, knows the right time to trim us. This is the reason that there is such calm among us. This is a secret of the church life which the outsiders do not understand, for they do not have the Priest trimming and dealing with the lamps on the lampstand. Now the Priest is walking among the churches caring for them by trimming all the lamps.

X. With a shining face

In verse 16 we are also told that "His face was as the sun shines in its power." In the S.S. 5:10, 13, His face appears lovely for His seeker's appreciation of Him, and in the Epistles, His face reflects God's glory (2 Cor. 4:6) for the imparting of life into His believers. Here, however, "His face" is "as the sun shines in its power," as in Dan. 10:6, for the judging enlightenment to bring in the kingdom. When He was transfigured and His face shone as the sun, that was His coming in the kingdom (Matt. 16:28; 17:1-2). When He comes to take over the earth for the kingdom, His face will be as the sun (10:1).

XI. Being the beginning and the ending, the First and the Last

Verse 17 says, "And when I saw Him, I fell at His feet as dead; and He laid His right hand on me, saying, Do not fear; I am the First and the Last." Christ is not only the First and the Last, but also the beginning and the ending. This assures us that, having started the church life, He will surely accomplish it. He will never leave His work unfinished. All the local churches must believe that the Lord Jesus is the beginning and the ending. He will accomplish what He has begun in His recovery.

XII. Being the living One

In verse 18 we see that the Lord is "the living One," the One who "became dead" and who is "living for ever and ever." The very Christ who walks in the midst of the churches, who is the Head of the churches and to whom the churches belong, is the living One full of life. Hence, the churches as His Body should also be living and full of life. Hallelujah, we have a living Christ who has overcome death! Our Christ, who is the resurrected Christ, is living in us and among us. He is living forever and ever. What a living Christ we have in the recovery! In the recovery, all the churches should be as living as Christ, full of life and overcoming death.

XIII. Having authority over death and Hades

In verse 18 the Lord also said, "I have the keys of death and of Hades." Due to the fall and sin of man, death came in and is now working on earth to gather up all the sinful people. Death resembles a dustpan used to collect the dust from the floor, and Hades resembles a trash can. Whatever the dustpan collects is put into the trash can. Thus, death is a collector and Hades is a keeper. In the church life today are we still subject to death and Hades? No! Christ abolished death on the cross and overcame Hades in His resurrection. Although Hades tried its best to hold Him, it was powerless to do it (Acts 2:24). With Him, death has no sting and Hades has no power. But what about us? It must be the same. In the church life, the keys of death and Hades are in His hand. It is impossible for us to deal with death; we simply do not have the ability to handle it. Whenever death enters, it will deaden many. But as long as we give the Lord Jesus the ground, the opportunity, and the free way to move and act among us, both death and Hades will be under His control. However, whenever the Lord Jesus does not have the ground in the church, death immediately becomes prevailing and Hades becomes powerful to hold the dead ones. Praise the Lord that Christ has the keys of death and Hades. Death is subject to Him and Hades is under His control. Hallelujah!

The Church in Ephesus — Love, Life, and Light

The book of Revelation is very well composed. Following chapter one, chapters two and three give us a clear view of seven practical churches. These seven churches are excellent illustrations, revealing the local churches, not in doctrine, but in actual practice. By considering these seven churches we can see clearly what a local church is and should be.

The seven epistles in chapters two and three are the record of the actual situation existing in the seven churches at the time these epistles were written. However, since this book is a book of signs with a prophetic nature, the situations of the seven churches are also signs, signifying prophetically the progress of the church in seven stages. The first epistle, to the church in Ephesus, affords a picture of the church at the end of the first stage, during the last part of the first century. The second epistle, to the church in Smyrna, prefigures the suffering church under the persecution of the Roman Empire, from the last part of the first century to the early part of the fourth century, when Constantine the Great, the Caesar of the Roman Empire, brought the church into imperial favor. The third epistle, to the church in Pergamos, pre-symbolizes the worldly church, the church married to the world, from the day Constantine accepted Christianity to the time the papal system was established in the latter part of the sixth century. The epistle to the church in Thyatira depicts prophetically the apostate church, from the ordination of the papal system in the latter part of the sixth century to the end of this age, when Christ comes back. The fifth epistle, to the church in Sardis, prefigures the Protestant church, from the Reformation in the early part of the sixteenth century to Christ's coming back. The sixth epistle, to the church in Philadelphia, predicts the church of brotherly love, the recovery of the proper church life, from the early part of the nineteenth century, when the brothers were raised up in England to practice the church life outside all denominational and divisive systems, to the second appearing of the Lord. The seventh epistle, to the church in Laodicea, foreshadows the degraded church life of the brothers in the nineteenth century, from the latter part of the nineteenth century until the Lord's return. In this message and the following six messages we shall treat each of these churches respectively.

In this message we come to the church in Ephesus (Rev. 2:1-7). The crucial words in this message are love, life, and light. The basic requirement for having the church life is our love toward the Lord. There is no problem, of course, with the Lord's love toward us. He has loved us and He continues to love us. The problem is with our love toward Him. Although we have loved Him in the past and may love Him now, there is the danger that our love for the Lord Jesus might fade. The epistle to the church at Ephesus warns us of this. This letter also gives us a clear revelation of the source of the degradation of the church life — the fading of the first love. As we shall see, love gives us the position, the ground, the right, and the privilege to eat of the tree of life. Love gives us the supply of life. If we love the Lord, we shall have the full right to enjoy Him as the tree of life, as our life supply. Light always follows life, issuing out of the abundant supply of life. Life gives us light. In the tabernacle the lampstand comes after the showbread table, indicating that when we enjoy Christ as our life supply, we shall have the light of life. It is vitally important that we love the Lord. If we have love, then we shall have the life symbolized by the tree of life and the light signified by the lampstand.

In brief, the problem with the church at Ephesus was the fading of the first love toward the Lord. Because of this, the Lord came in to deal thoroughly with this church, warning her that if she did not repent, she was in danger of having her lampstand removed. Anyone among them who would repent and return to his first love would be considered by the Lord to be an overcomer. The Lord promised the overcomer the right to enjoy Him as the tree of life. Of course, the lampstand will always remain among those who have overcome. However, if we would not repent of our fading love toward the Lord, we will miss the right to eat of the tree of life and the lampstand will be removed from us. If this were the case, we would be without love, and light. What a pitiful condition this would be!

I. The speaker

Revelation 2:1 says, "To the messenger of the church in Ephesus write: These things says He who holds the seven stars in His right hand, who walks in the midst of the seven golden lampstands." Each of these seven epistles begins with a description of the speaker. Before the Lord says anything to the churches, He declares who He is. In the first epistle, the Lord declares that He is the One who holds the seven stars in His right hand and who walks in the midst of the seven golden lampstands. These two items prove that the Lord is so normal, genuine, and proper. He cares for the churches by holding the leading ones in His right hand and by walking among all the churches. The messengers of the churches, the spiritual ones, signified by the shining stars, who bear the responsibility of the testimony of Jesus, are held in the right hand of the Lord, and the Lord is walking in the midst of the churches, signified by the seven golden lampstands. What a wonderful scene! While the Lord is sitting at the right hand of God as our High Priest interceding for us, the churches (Heb. 7:25), He is holding the messengers of the churches and is walking in the midst of the churches to care for them.

II. The church's virtues

The word Ephesus in Greek means desirable. This signifies that the initial church at its end was still desirable to the Lord; the Lord still had much expectation in her.

A. Works

Let us now consider the virtues of the church in Ephesus. Firstly, she did many works for the Lord. The church in Ephesus was neither idle nor sloppy; she was quite good in working for the Lord.

B. Labor

This church not only worked for the Lord but also labored for Him (vv. 2-3). We must differentiate between work and labor. Labor is higher than work. While work is ordinary, labor is special. Those who worked full time on our meeting hall in Anaheim not only worked — they labored. If we had hired a contractor and had used union workers, they would have worked without laboring.

C. Endurance

The church in Ephesus also had the virtue of endurance. This means that the church was afflicted and endured suffering.

D. Bearing not evil men

The Lord said to the church in Ephesus, "You cannot bear evil men" (v. 2). The word men is not found in the Greek. I believe that the Lord's word here regarding evil includes two things — evil men and evil matters. The church in Ephesus did not tolerate anyone or anything evil. It certainly was a good church.

E. Having tried the false apostles

The Lord also said, "You have tried those who call themselves apostles and are not, and have found them to be false" (v. 2). This church was very discerning, trying the false apostles and rejecting them. They discerned that the self-assumed apostles were false. Throughout the generations, there have been self-appointed apostles. This is also true today.

F. Hating the works of the Nicolaitans

In 2:6 the Lord said, "But this you have, that you hate the works of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate." The church in Ephesus hated what the Lord hates — the works of the Nicolaitans. As far as virtues were concerned, this church was good, pure, right, and normal.

The Lord hates the works of the Nicolaitans. If you want to understand what the works of the Nicolaitans are, read Brother Nee's book, *The Orthodoxy of the Church*. The works of the Nicolaitans refer to a hierarchy among the saints in which some set themselves to rule over others. This brings into being the so-called clergy and laity. In the church in Ephesus there was not the doctrine, the teaching, of the Nicolaitans. This was to develop later. But there were the works and activities of the Nicolaitans, that is, there was some type of hierarchy of clergy and laity. The word Nicolaitans is an equivalent of the Greek word Nikolaitai, the root of which is Nikolaos, composed of two Greek words — niko and laos. Niko means conquer or above others. Laos means common people, secular people, or laity. So Nikolaos means conquering the common people, climbing above the laity. Nicolaitans, then, must refer to a group of people who esteem themselves higher than the common believers. This was undoubtedly the hierarchy followed and established by Catholicism and Protestantism. The Lord hates the works, the behavior, of these Nicolaitans, and we must hate what the Lord hates.

God in His economy intended that all His people be priests to serve Him directly. In Exodus 19:6 God ordained the children of Israel to be "a kingdom of priests." This means that God wanted them all to be priests. However, because of the worship of the golden calf (Exo. 32:1-6), they lost the priesthood, and only the tribe of Levi, because of their faithfulness to God, was chosen to replace the whole nation of Israel as priests to God (Exo. 32:25-29; Deut. 33:8-10). Hence, there was a mediatorial class between God and the children of Israel. This became a strong system in Judaism. In the New Testament, God has returned to His original intention according to His economy in that He has made all believers in Christ priests (Rev. 1:6; 5:10; 1 Pet. 2:5, 9). But at the end of the initial church, even in the first century, the Nicolaitans intervened as the mediatorial class to spoil God's economy. According to church history, this became a system adopted by the Roman Catholic Church and was also retained by the Protestant churches. Today in the Roman Catholic Church there is the priestly system, in the state churches there is the clerical system, and in the independent churches there is the pastoral system. All these are a mediatorial class, spoiling the universal priesthood of all believers. Thus, there are two distinct classes — the clergy and the laity. But in the proper church life there should be neither clergy nor laity; all believers should be the priests of God. Because the mediatorial class destroys the universal priesthood in God's economy, the Lord hates it.

In Acts 6:5 among the seven serving ones was one named Nikolaos (Gk.). There is no trace in church history that this Nikolaos is the first of the Nicolaitans.

III. The origin of the church's degradation

Although the church in Ephesus had so many virtues, it was degraded because it had left its first love. In verse 4 the Lord said, "But I have this against you, that you have left your first love." The Greek word for first is the same as the word translated best in Luke 15:22. Our first love toward the Lord must be the best love for Him. The church in Ephesus had left this best love toward the Lord.

The church as the Body of Christ (Eph. 1:23) is a matter of life; as the new man (Eph. 2:15), it is a matter of the Person of Christ; and as the Bride of Christ (John 3:29), it is a matter of love. The first epistle to the Ephesians tells us that for the church life we need to be strengthened in our inner man that Christ may make His home in our hearts, that we, being rooted and grounded in love, may be able to know the love of Christ which passes knowledge, that we may be filled with all the fullness of God (Eph. 3:16-19); and that it is for the church life that grace is with all them who love the Lord Jesus (Eph. 6:24). Now the second epistle to the Ephesians reveals that the degradation of the church begins with our leaving the first love toward the Lord. Nothing but love can keep us in a proper relationship with the Lord. The church in Ephesus had good works, labored for the Lord, endured suffering, and tried the false apostles, but she left her first love toward the Lord. Leaving the first love is the source of all the degradation in the following stages of the church.

We in the local churches today must be warned of the possibility of losing our first love for the Lord. We may work and labor for the Lord and we may be pure doctrinally and correct scripturally, yet not have the first love for the Lord. Perhaps in the coming years we shall not love Him as much as we do now. Beware of this. It is better to lose some of our work than to fail in our love for the Lord. Our love for Him must be the first love. We all must say, "Lord, I love You. I do not love the works I do for You, and I do not appreciate the labor I spend for You. Lord, I love You. If my labor for You frustrates me from loving You, I will cease laboring." Do not allow anything to separate you from the love of the Lord. We must take care of the first love and constantly love the Lord.

I can never forget a short paragraph concerning John Nelson Darby. This paragraph reveals that when Darby was very old he was traveling and stayed in a hotel for the night. As he was going to bed, he prayed in a simple way, saying, "Lord Jesus, I still love You." It is precious for an old saint to say this. John Nelson Darby began to love the Lord during his youth. After more than sixty years, he still loved Him. We all must daily tell the Lord, "Lord Jesus, I still love You. I may change in everything else, Lord, but I would never change in loving You. Rather, I want my love for You to increase all the time." I read this paragraph about Darby more than twenty years ago, and I cannot tell you the help it has rendered me throughout the years.

We must constantly say, "Lord Jesus, I still love You." Once we have fallen from our first love, our degradation has begun. We may remain the same in everything else — in work, labor, and in other things — but we are degraded because we have left our first love. Eventually, the church at Ephesus had more work but less love. Today, we all must say that we want more love and less work. If we would do any work, it must be out of our love for the Lord. Love should motivate everything we do for the Lord. If we cannot do a certain thing because we love Him, we should not do it. Our work should simply be an expression of our love for Him. We must be like this; otherwise, we shall not be kept in His presence.

IV. The consequence of the church's degradation

In verse 5 we see the consequence of the church's degradation: "Remember therefore whence you have fallen and repent and do the first works; but if not, I am coming to you and will remove your lampstand out of its place, unless you repent." The consequence of the church's degradation is losing the testimony. To lose the testimony simply means to have the lampstand removed. If we leave our first love toward the Lord and do not repent, we shall lose the testimony of the Lord and the lampstand will be removed from us. Years ago, the testimony with the Brethren was quite bright, but it is not so today. There is no doubt that the lampstand has been removed from most of the so-called Brethren assemblies. When you enter into their assemblies, you do not sense any shining there. There is no light, no testimony. We must be careful and constantly on the alert to avoid this consequence. Do not think that because we are the local churches as the lampstands and are the testimony of Jesus that we cannot lose our testimony. The day we lose our first love toward the Lord will be the day we lose the testimony. On that day, the lampstand will be removed.

V. The Spirit's speaking

The first part of 2:7 says, "He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches." At the beginning of each of the seven epistles in chapters two and three, it is the Lord who speaks (Rev. 2:1, 8, 12, 18; 3:1, 7, 14). But at the end of all seven epistles it is the Spirit speaking to the churches (Rev. 2:7, 11, 17, 29; 3:6, 13, 22). Once again, this proves that the speaking Christ is the Spirit. Whatever Christ speaks, that is the speaking of the Spirit. No one can argue with this. Who was speaking to the church in Ephesus? Christ, the Son of Man holding the messengers in His right hand and walking in the midst of the churches. As verse 7 indicates, the speaker eventually is the Spirit. This proves that Christ is the speaking Spirit. This not only indicates that the Spirit is the Lord and the Lord is the Spirit; it also emphasizes the vital importance of the Spirit in the darkness of the church's degradation as indicated by the sevenfold intensified Spirit in Rev. 1:4. The same emphasis is also seen in Rev. 14:13 and Rev. 22:17. It is foolish to say that Christ today is not the speaking Spirit, and it is ridiculous to separate the speaking Spirit from Christ. The two are one.

If the speaker were only Christ without being the speaking Spirit, He could never speak some words into our spirit, and His speaking would not be very subjective and touching. But, as our experience testifies, if, as we read these epistles, we are open in our spirit to Him, the Spirit will immediately speak something of Christ into us. Because the speaker is not the objective Christ but the subjective Spirit, He speaks not only in the black and white letters of the Bible, but also in our spirit. Once we hear His speaking, something indelible is wrought into us, and nothing can take it away. Our Christ today is the speaking Spirit. I rejoice over this fact and I boldly proclaim it.

A. To the churches

On the one hand, each of the seven epistles is the word of the Lord to a particular church; but, on the other hand, it is the word of the Spirit to all of the churches. Every church should not only give heed to the epistle written to her particularly, but also to all the epistles written to the other churches. This implies that all the churches, as the Lord's testimony in the Spirit, should be the same. Since the Spirit today is speaking to the churches, we must be in the churches to be rightly positioned to hear the Spirit's speaking. How else can we hear what the Spirit is saying?

The Spirit is speaking to the churches, not to any religion, denomination, or group of seeking Christians. This is the reason that not many Christians can hear the speaking of the Spirit. The Spirit does not even speak just to one church, but to the churches. Although some supposed churches want to be unique, we should not be a unique or particular church. If we are, we shall miss the speaking of the Spirit because the Spirit is speaking to the churches. In none of the seven epistles does the Spirit speak to a particular church. All the churches should be common, not unique. During the past years, I have heard many say that every church must be distinctive. Those who hold this concept say that every church must have its local uniqueness. Although this thought sounds attractive, actually it is quite repulsive. To make your local church unique is to separate yourself from all the other churches. If you do this, you are through with the Spirit's speaking. Which is better — to be unique or to be common? Although you may say that it is better to be common, the fact is that everyone likes to be unique. In your heart, you want the church in your locality to be unique. Nevertheless, in the local churches, do not try to be unique. We all must be common because the Spirit speaks to the churches, not to any unique church. When we are in the church and among the churches, we have the right position and the right angle to hear the Spirit's speaking.

B. Requiring a proper ear to hear

In spiritual things, seeing depends upon hearing. The writer of this book firstly heard the voice (Rev. 1:10) and then saw the vision (Rev. 1:12). If our ears are heavy and cannot hear, then we cannot see (Isa. 6:9-10). The Jews would not hear the word of the Lord, so they could not see what the Lord was doing (Matt. 13:15; Acts 28:27). The Lord always wants to open our ears to hear His voice (Job 33:14-16; Isa. 50:4-5; Exo. 21:6) that we may see things according to His economy. The heavy ears need to be circumcised (Jer. 6:10; Acts 7:51). The sinner's ears need to be cleansed with the redeeming blood and anointed with the Spirit (Lev. 14:14, 17, 28). To serve the Lord as priests also requires our ears to be cleansed with the redeeming blood (Exo. 29:20; Lev. 8:23-24). In this book, as the Spirit is speaking to the churches, we all need an opened, circumcised, cleansed, and anointed ear to hear the Spirit's speaking.

Although our angle and position may be right, we still may not have the proper ear to hear. Chapter one emphasizes seeing and chapters two and three emphasize hearing. We need to both see and hear. Among our physical senses, which is more important — seeing or hearing? Suppose you had the choice of losing either your sight or your hearing. Which would you choose? We may say that seeing is more important than hearing, but hearing is deeper than seeing. Thus, we must tell the Lord, "Lord, I need to both see and hear. Have mercy on me, Lord, and grant me eyes to see and ears to hear." We may have to struggle with the Lord, telling Him that we must be able to both see and hear.

Hearing is more intimate than seeing. Our closest friends will speak intimately to us. If you lose your hearing organ, you will be unable to enjoy this intimacy with your loved ones. In chapter one, John saw; in chapters two and three, he heard. We need to see the church life and we need to hear the intimate contents of the church life. To see the church is one thing, and to hear the intimate contents of the church life is another. Although many of us have seen the church, not many have heard the intimate contents of the church life. Hence, we need an ear to hear. "He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches."

VI. The promise to the overcomers — eating of the tree of life

Now we come to the promise to the overcomer: "To him who overcomes, to him I will give to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God" (v. 7). To overcome in these seven epistles means to overcome the degraded situation of the churches. In this epistle, it means to recover our first love toward the Lord and to hate the works of the Nicolaitans, the hierarchy which the Lord hates.

In 2:7 the Lord said that to him who overcomes He will give to eat of the tree of life. Religion always teaches, but the Lord feeds (John 6:35). The apostle Paul did the same thing, feeding the believers (1 Cor. 3:2). For the proper church life and the recovery of the church life, that is, for the proper growth in the Christian life, what we need is not merely the mental apprehension of teachings, but the eating in our spirit of the Lord as the bread of life (John 6:57). Even the words of the Scripture should not be considered as merely doctrines to teach our mind, but as food to nourish our spirit (Matt. 4:4; Heb. 5:12-14). Here in this epistle the Lord promises to give the overcomer "to eat of the tree of life." This refers back to Gen. 2:8-9, 16 concerning the matter of eating ordained by God. In the epistle to the church in Pergamos, the Lord promises the overcomer to eat of "the hidden manna" (2:17), which refers to the eating of manna by the children of Israel in the wilderness (Exo. 16:14-16, 31). And in the epistle to the church in Laodicea, the Lord promises to dine with the one who opens the door to Him (Rev. 3:20). To dine is not merely to eat one food, but to eat the riches of a meal. This may refer to the eating of the rich produce of the good land of Canaan by the children of Israel (Josh. 5:10-12). This indicates that the Lord desires to recover the eating by God's people of the proper food, as ordained by God and typified by the tree of life, the manna, and the produce of the good land, all of which are types of the various aspects of Christ as food to us. The degradation of the church distracts God's people from the eating of Christ as their food to the teaching of doctrines for knowledge. In the church's degradation are the teaching of Balaam (Rev. 2:14), the teaching of the Nicolaitans (Rev. 2:15), the teaching of Jezebel (Rev. 2:20), and the teaching of the deep things of Satan (Rev. 2:24). Now the Lord comes in these epistles to recover the proper eating of Himself as our food supply. We must eat Him not only as the tree of life and the hidden manna, but also as a meal full of His riches.

The word for tree here, as in 1 Pet. 2:24, is wood in Greek, not the usual word used for tree. In the Bible, "the tree of life" always refers to Christ as the embodiment of all the riches of God (Col. 2:9) for our food (Gen. 2:9; 3:22, 24; Rev. 22:2, 14, 19). Here it refers to the crucified (implied in the tree as a piece of wood — 1 Pet. 2:24) and resurrected (implied in the zoe life — John 11:25) Christ who is in the church today, the consummation of which will be the New Jerusalem, in which the crucified and resurrected Christ will be the tree of life for the enjoyment of all God's redeemed people for eternity (Rev. 22:2, 14).

It was God's original intention that man should eat of the tree of life (Gen. 2:9, 16). Due to the fall, the tree of life was closed to man (Gen. 3:22-24). Through the redemption of Christ, the way to touch the tree of life, which is God Himself in Christ as life to man, has been opened again (Heb. 10:19-20). But in the church's degradation, religion crept in with its knowledge to distract the believers in Christ from eating Him as the tree of life. Hence, the Lord promises to grant the overcomers to eat of Himself as the tree of life in the paradise of God as a reward. This is an incentive for them to leave the knowledge of religion and to return to the enjoyment of Himself. This promise of the Lord restores the church to God's original intention according to His economy. What the Lord wants the overcomers to do is what the whole church should do in God's economy. Due to the church's degradation, the Lord comes to call the overcomers to replace the church in the accomplishment of God's economy.

The eating of the tree of life not only was God's original intention concerning man, but will also be the eternal issue of God's redemption. All His redeemed people will enjoy the tree of life, which is Christ with all the divine riches as their portion for eternity (Rev. 22:2, 14, 19). Because of religion's distraction and the church's degradation, the Lord in His wisdom makes the enjoyment of Himself in the coming kingdom a reward to encourage His believers to overcome religion's distracting knowledge of teachings and return to the enjoyment of Himself as the life supply in the church today for the accomplishment of God's economy.

A. In the paradise of God

As we have seen, the promise to the overcomers in the church in Ephesus was to eat of the tree of life. The tree of life is in the paradise of God. If we know the Bible, we shall realize that the paradise of God in Rev. 2:7 is not the garden of Eden but the coming New Jerusalem. The paradise in Luke 23:43 is the pleasant and restful place where Abraham and all the dead saints are (Luke 16:23-26). But, as we have pointed out, "the paradise of God" in this verse is the New Jerusalem (Rev. 3:12; 21:2, 10; 22:1-2, 14, 19) of which the church is a foretaste today. Adam was in the garden of Eden, and Abraham and all the dead saints are in paradise. We are waiting to enter into another paradise, the paradise of God in the New Jerusalem. As we are waiting for this, we have a miniature of the New Jerusalem today — the church life. In the church we enjoy the Lord Jesus as the tree of life. We are enjoying the crucified and resurrected Christ as the tree of life, the food supply in our spirit, as a foretaste today in the church. This enjoyment of the foretaste will usher us into the full taste of the crucified and resurrected Christ as the tree of life, our nourishment of life in the New Jerusalem for eternity. The promise of eating the tree of life given to the overcomers in Ephesus indicates that they shall eat Christ in the church life today and eat Him as the tree of life in the New Jerusalem for eternity. Our experience confirms this.

Strictly speaking, "to eat of the tree of life...in the paradise of God" in this verse refers to the particular enjoyment of Christ as our life supply in the New Jerusalem in the coming millennial kingdom, because this is a promise of reward made by the Lord to His overcomers. The enjoyment of Christ as the tree of life in the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and new earth will be the common portion of all God's redeemed people, whereas the particular enjoyment of Him as the tree of life in the New Jerusalem in the coming millennial kingdom is a reward only to the overcoming believers. If we overcome all distractions in the church's degradation to enjoy Christ as the tree of life in the church today, we shall be thus rewarded. Otherwise, we shall miss this particular enjoyment in the coming kingdom, though we still shall enjoy Him as the tree of life in the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and the new earth for eternity. All the Lord's promises concerning the reward and all His predictions concerning the loss at the end of each of the seven epistles refer to His dealing with His believers in the coming millennial kingdom. These promises have nothing to do with eternal destiny — eternal salvation or eternal perdition.

B. Back to the beginning

This matter of eating the tree of life brings us back to the beginning (Gen. 2:9, 16) because at the beginning there was the tree of life. The tree of life always brings us back to the beginning where there is nothing but God Himself. There is no work, labor, endurance, or anything else — only God Himself. In the church life, again and again we need to be brought back to the beginning, forgetting all other things and enjoying God Himself as the tree of life.

C. Enjoying Christ as the life supply

When we are back to the beginning with the tree of life, we enjoy Christ as the life supply. Eating the tree of life, that is, enjoying Christ as our life supply, should be the primary matter in the church life. The content of the church life depends upon the enjoyment of Christ. The more we enjoy Him, the richer the content will be. But to enjoy Christ requires us to love Him with the first love. If we leave our first love toward the Lord, we shall miss the enjoyment of Christ and lose the testimony of Jesus; hence, the lampstand will be removed from us. Loving the Lord, enjoying the Lord, and being the testimony of the Lord go together.

If we would be brought back to the beginning, we should forget everything and simply enjoy Christ as the life supply. For this, we must love Him above all things, above our work for Him and whatever we have for Him. By simply loving Him, we shall be brought back to the beginning where we care for nothing except God Himself as our life supply in the tree of life. This is the proper way to maintain the church life and to be kept in the church life. Here we have the best love, the tree of life as our life supply, and the lampstand with the shining light. How marvelous! The more we love Him, the more we have the right to eat of Him and to enjoy Him as the tree of life. Then, as a result of this, the light of His testimony will shine brightly.

The Church in Smyrna — the Resurrection Life and the Crown of Life

The Lord was sovereign in selecting the churches to fulfill His purpose. He chose seven cities in Asia Minor:

Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamos, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea. According to the Greek, the name of each city is very meaningful, exactly matching its spiritual significance. As we have pointed out, Ephesus means desirable, indicating that the church in Ephesus was precious to the Lord and desirable in His eyes. In Greek Smyrna means myrrh. Myrrh is a sweet spice which, in figure, signifies suffering. In typology, myrrh signifies the sweet suffering of Christ. Thus, the church in Smyrna was a suffering church, prefiguring the church under the persecution of the Roman Empire from the latter part of the first century to the early part of the fourth century. This persecuted church suffered in the sweetness and fragrance of Christ. In other words, this church was in the tribulation of Jesus and in the fellowship of His sufferings. The church in Smyrna suffered as Christ Himself did, having become a continuation of His suffering. In Colossians 1:24 Paul said that he filled up “that which is lacking of the afflictions of Christ in my flesh for His Body, which is the church.” Paul was completing the sufferings of Christ. Although no one can continue Christ’s redemption, His sufferings must be completed by all His followers both individually and collectively. In the church in Smyrna we see the collective continuation of the sufferings of Jesus. Because this church was a continuation of Jesus’ suffering, it was truly the testimony of Jesus.

I. The speaker

A. The First and the Last

Let us now consider the speaker to the church in Smyrna. In verse 8 the Lord says, “These things says the First and the Last, who became dead, and lived again.” The Lord told this suffering church that He was the First and the Last. This means that no matter how great were the sufferings through which He passed, those sufferings could not terminate or damage Him. He was the First and eventually He was also the Last. In suffering, the church must know that the Lord is the First and the Last, the ever-existing, unchanging One. Whatever the environment may be, He remains the same. Nothing can precede Him, nor can anything exist after Him. All things are within the limit of His control.

When the Lord told the church in Smyrna that He was the First and the Last, He was indicating that the church had to be victorious. The church should not be frustrated by any type of suffering. She must pass through all the sufferings and come to the end, because the Lord, who is the life and Head of the church, is the First and Last.

B. The One Who Became Dead and Lived Again

In this verse the Lord also said that He is the One “who became dead, and lived again.” “Lived again” means resurrection. The Lord suffered death and lived again. He entered into death, but death could not hold Him (Acts 2:24) because He is the resurrection (John 11:25). The suffering church also needs to know Him as such a One that she may endure all kinds of suffering. However severe the persecution may be, the church will still be alive, for the resurrection life of Christ within her can endure death. The most suffering or persecution can do is kill us. Following the death from persecution, there is resurrection. Therefore, the Lord seemed to be telling the suffering church, “You must realize that I am the One who was persecuted to death. But that death was not the end — it was the gateway into resurrection. When I entered into death, I came into the threshold of resurrection. Do not be frightened by persecution, nor terrified at the prospect of being killed. You must welcome death and be happy, for once you have passed into death you also will be on the threshold of resurrection. Remember, I am the One who became dead and lived again.” Whatever we need, the Lord is. His qualifications exactly match our need. To the suffering church, the Lord is not only the First and the beginning but also the Last and the end. Whenever you are undergoing persecution, you must rise up and declare, “Hallelujah, I am going to the end, to the last. I am about to enter into the gateway of resurrection.”

II. The church’s suffering

A. Tribulation

In verse 9 the Lord said to the church in Smyrna, “I know your tribulation.” The content of this epistle is nothing but tribulation, suffering, and persecution. To the church, tribulation is a test of life. The extent to which the church experiences and enjoys the resurrection life of Christ can only be tested by tribulation. Moreover, tribulation also brings in the riches of the resurrection life of Christ. The Lord’s purpose in allowing the church to suffer tribulation is not only to testify that His resurrection life overcomes death, but also to enable the church to enter into the riches of His life. Hence, tribulation is precious to the church.

B. Poverty (yet being rich)

The Lord said, “I know your tribulation and poverty, but you are rich.” The Lord did appraise this suffering church. The suffering church was poor in material things, but rich in the Lord with the riches of His life. Thus, the Lord seemed to be saying, “You are suffering tribulation and poverty, yet you are rich. You are poor physically, but you are rich spiritually. You are poor in earthly things, but you are rich in heavenly things.” Suffering persecution is the means to bring us into the riches of Christ. The more we are persecuted and suffer poverty, the richer we are in Christ.

C. Slander of the unbelieving Jews of the synagogue of Satan

In verse 9 the Lord also said that He knew “the slander of those who call themselves Jews and are not, but are a synagogue of Satan.” According to this epistle, the persecution came from religion, from the unbelieving Jews of the synagogue of Satan. The slander of the Judaizers toward the suffering church was their evil criticism of her. The Judaizers were Jews in flesh, but not Jews in spirit (Rom. 2:28-29). Merely being the seed of Abraham in the flesh did not constitute them true Jews. “Those who are the children of the flesh are not the children of God” (Rom. 9:7-8). Therefore, the Lord said that they “call themselves Jews and are not.” These Judaizers stubbornly insisted upon keeping their Judaistic system consisting of the Levitical priesthood, the sacrificial rituals, and the material temple, which were all types now fulfilled and replaced by Christ. Since the Church under the new covenant in God’s economy had no part in their religious practice, the Judaizers slanderously criticized her. In principle, it is the same today in that religious people slander the churches in the Lord’s recovery which seek the Lord and follow Him in spirit and in life and do not care for any religious system or practice.

The Lord said that those who call themselves Jews and are not are “a synagogue of Satan.” This term, a synagogue of Satan, is a terrible term. A synagogue was a place where the Jews worshipped God mainly by studying their scriptures, the Old Testament. However, due to their stubbornness in clinging to their traditional, religious concepts, they became one with Satan in opposing God’s way of life to fulfill His purpose. The synagogue was under the manipulating, maneuvering hand of Satan, for he was the power at the back of the synagogues at that time. The synagogues persecuted the Lord Jesus (Matt. 12:9-14; Luke 4:28-29; John 9:22), the apostles (Acts 6:9; 13:43, 45-46, 50; 14:1-2, 19; 17:1, 5-6), and the churches (Rev. 3:9). Therefore, the Lord called them the “synagogue of Satan.” Even when He was on earth, He considered the synagogues to be of Satan, as implied in Matt. 12:25-29 and John 8:44. Apparently they were worshipping God; actually they were opposing God. They persecuted and killed God’s true worshippers, yet they considered themselves to be offering service to God (John 16:2). When the Lord was on earth, the Jews could not deal with Him directly because at that time they did not have the right to kill the Lord Jesus by stoning Him. Instead, they utilized the Roman government to sentence Him to death and to crucify Him. In the same principle, the Jewish synagogues stirred up the Roman government to persecute the suffering church. Through all the centuries since then, religious people have followed in their steps, persecuting the genuine seekers and followers of the Lord in spirit and life while still considering themselves to be defending the interest of God. Religion always utilizes politics to damage the church. Religion has no power to cause physical damage to the Lord’s lovers, but it does use politics and the government to damage the church. Roman Catholicism and Protestantism, as well as Judaism, all fall into this category, becoming an organization of Satan as his tool to damage God’s economy.

D. Imprisonment by the Devil

In verse 10 the Lord says, “Do not fear what you are about to suffer. Behold, the Devil is about to cast some of you into prison that you may be tried.” Verse 9 mentions Satan and verse 10 mentions the Devil. Satan in Greek means adversary. He is not only the enemy of God from without, but also His adversary from within. The Greek word diabolos, translated Devil, means “accuser,” “slanderer” (12:9-10). The Devil, who is Satan, the adversary of God, accuses us before God and slanders us before men. The persecution suffered by the church began from the religious synagogue of the Jews instigated by Satan, the adversary. It was consummated by the Roman government used by the Devil, the slanderer, to put the saints into prison. The imprisonment of the suffering church was a cooperation of devilish politics with Satanic religion.

E. Tribulation full yet short

In verse 10 the Lord also said that they would have tribulation ten days. Ten is a number for fullness, such as the ten commandments, which express God’s demand in full, and the tithes of the offerings, which show that ten parts constitute the full offering. Ten days in the Bible signify a period of time which is full, yet short (Gen. 24:55; Jer. 42:7; Dan. 1:12-13). Hence, it signifies that the tribulation of the suffering church was full, yet short. However long the persecution may seem to us, in the eyes of God it is short. It is not a thousand days or even a hundred days but just ten days. Praise the Lord! This suffering is only a temporary suffering.

As a sign, these ten days indicate prophetically the ten periods of persecution which the church suffered under the Roman emperors, beginning with Caesar Nero in the second half of the first century and ending with Constantine the Great in the first part of the fourth century. However severe the persecutions instigated by the Devil, Satan, through the Roman Caesars, who did their utmost to destroy and eliminate the church, they were unable to subdue and terminate her. History demonstrates that the church of the living Christ “who became dead and lived again” withstood the persecutions victoriously and multiplied flourishingly by the indestructible resurrection life.

III. The resurrection life — able to endure unto death

In verse 10 the Lord also said, “Be faithful unto death, and I will give you the crown of life.” In this epistle we see some indications that resurrection life is in the church. When the Lord revealed His qualifications in verse 6, saying that He became dead and lived again, He was indicating that His resurrection life is in the church. The Lord seemed to be saying, “I, the One who is the Resurrection, am living in you. Because you have resurrection life in you, there is no reason or excuse for you to fail. You need not be defeated by persecution. Rather, you must suffer this persecution victoriously by My resurrection life.” Because of this resurrection life, the church is able to suffer tribulation even unto death. The church is always qualified to be a marvelous, victorious, and glorious martyr. We all are qualified to be victorious martyrs because we have resurrection life within us.

IV. The Spirit’s speaking

Even the Lord’s word in this epistle to the suffering church is the speaking of the Spirit to all the churches. This indicates that all the churches may experience the same suffering. Actually, in all the churches there have been some saints who have undergone the same kind of persecution. They all have had to listen to the speaking of the Spirit to this suffering church. Through the Spirit’s speaking again and again, the word of the Lord in this epistle has been for all the saints who have suffered persecution for the Lord’s sake throughout the generations.

V. The promise to the overcomer

A. The crown of life

In verse 10 we see the promise to the overcomer — the crown of life. Eventually, life will become a crown. It will be the glory of the victorious martyrs. A crown in New Testament usage always denotes a prize in addition to salvation (Rev. 3:11; James 1:12; 2 Tim. 4:8; 1 Pet. 5:4; 1 Cor. 9:25). The crown of life as a prize to those who are faithful unto death in overcoming persecution denotes the overcoming strength which is the power of the resurrection life (Phil. 3:10); it also signifies that these overcomers have attained to “the out-resurrection from among the dead,” that is, the outstanding resurrection (Phil. 3:11, Gk.).

B. Not hurt of the second death

In verse 11 the Lord says, “He who overcomes shall by no means be hurt of the second death.” To overcome in this epistle means to overcome persecution by being faithful unto death. The promise to the overcomer in this epistle has both a positive side — receiving the crown of life — and a negative side — not being hurt of the second death.

Verse 11 has been a great problem to the expositors of the book of Revelation. Due to the fall and the entering in of sin, every man must die once (Heb. 9:27). This first death, however, is not the final settlement. All the dead, except those who through faith in the Lord Jesus have been recorded in the book of life, will be resurrected and pass through the judgment of the great white throne at the close of the millennium, that is, at the conclusion of the old heaven and the old earth. As a result of this judgment, they will all be cast into the lake of fire, which is the second death as the final settlement (Rev. 20:11-15). The second death is God’s dealing with man after man’s death and resurrection. Since the overcomers have overcome death through their faithfulness unto death under persecution and have left nothing requiring further dealing by God after their resurrection, they will be rewarded with the crown of life and will not be touched, or “hurt,” anymore by the death after resurrection, which is the second death.

Nearly every Christian teacher has a problem here, thinking that after the believers are resurrected there will be no further settlement required of them. Let me ask you this question: If you were to die today, could you say that you have nothing which requires the Lord’s further dealing? Probably you cannot say this. This means that if you died today, you would still have something which requires the Lord’s further dealing. This does not mean that you would be lost. Nevertheless, this further dealing would not be something positive; it would surely be negative. Every negative thing comes from death. Thus, if you require a further negative dealing, it means that you can still be touched by death. This does not mean that you will perish, but it does indicate that you will suffer something. We must hear the word of the Lord. If we overcome persecution, on the positive side, we shall receive the crown of life and, on the negative side, we shall not be hurt by the second death.

We all need to be overcomers. If you are not an overcomer in this age, you will be hurt by the second death in the next age. It is difficult for anyone to say clearly what it means to be hurt by the second death. Nevertheless, one thing is clear: if you do not overcome persecution, something will hurt you. I say again that this does not mean that you will be lost, that you will suffer perdition. No, every saved one is saved for eternity. John 10:28-29 show that no saved one can ever perish again. However, after we have been resurrected, we may suffer some dealing from the Lord. Do not hold to the traditional theology which teaches that after you have been resurrected everything will be all right. After the unbelievers are resurrected, they will be dealt with by God regarding their eternal destiny. In the same principle, after our resurrection, there will still be some dealings from the Lord. It all depends upon how we live and walk today. If we live and walk in an overcoming way, this will indicate that we have overcome death and that nothing remains requiring a further dealing from the Lord.

We must take the Lord’s clear word. Do not accept the teaching which says that if you fail after being saved you will be lost again and perish. This is not true. At the other extreme is the teaching which says that after you have been saved you can have no problems with the Lord. However, a person who has been eternally saved may still need to be dealt with by Him. This is the full gospel. The full gospel is the whole New Testament, not just John 3:16. Here in Rev. 2:11 is a portion of the full gospel which says that we must overcome all persecution. If you do not overcome, you will not receive the crown of life; instead, you will be hurt by the second death. If you do overcome persecution and tribulation by the resurrection life within you, you will receive the crown of life positively and you will not be touched by the second death negatively. This is the Lord’s clear promise with His clear word, and we all must take it. Whether we understand it or not, we all must accept the word of the Lord. If you believe John 3:16, then you must believe Revelation 2:11. Both are the Lord’s word. I say again that this is the full gospel.

This matter has been veiled for a long time, and few Christians dare to touch it. Since they have been unable to understand it, their practice has been always to neglect it, to ignore it. But the Lord will never ignore His word. He will follow through with whatever He says. Therefore, be warned that we must overcome tribulation, suffering, and persecution, that we may receive a crown of life and not be hurt by the second death. If we overcome in this way, we shall have nothing remaining that will require the Lord’s further dealing in the future.

The Church in Pergamos — Eating for Transformation

In this message we come to the third church, the church in Pergamos (Rev. 2:12-17). As we have pointed out, the name of each of the seven cities is very meaningful. In Greek Pergamos means “marriage,” implying union, and “fortified tower.” As a sign, the church in Pergamos prefigures the church which entered into a marriage union with the world and became a high fortified tower, equivalent to the great tree prophesied by the Lord in the parable of the mustard seed (Matt. 13:31-32). When Satan failed to destroy the church through the persecution of the Roman Empire in the first three centuries, he changed his strategy. He sought instead to corrupt her through Constantine’s welcoming her as the state religion in the first part of the fourth century. Through Constantine’s encouragement and political influence, multitudes of unbelieving ones were baptized into the “church,” and the “church” became monstrously great. Since the church is a spouse to Christ as a chaste bride, her union with the world is considered spiritual fornication in the eyes of God.

I. The speaker — He who has the sharp two-edged sword

Verse 12 says, “These things says He who has the sharp two-edged sword.” In this epistle, the Lord as the speaking Spirit declares that He is the One with the sharp two-edged sword. Such a worldly church is qualified to receive the Lord’s judgment in His sharp word.

II. The church’s marriage to the world

In the epistle to the first church, the Lord advised the church in Ephesus to repent and to recover her first love. We must believe that His advice was heeded, for the second church, the church in Smyrna, truly loved the Lord and suffered persecution and became a suffering church. According to the facts of history, during the first three centuries, the church suffered a great deal as the Roman government tried its best to damage her. Eventually, the enemy, Satan, realized that persecution did not work very well. Therefore, being the subtle one, he changed his strategy from persecuting the church to welcoming her. In the early part of the fourth century, Constantine the Great accepted Christianity and made it a state religion. From that time onward, Christianity became a type of Roman state church. This welcoming of the church by the Roman Empire ruined her, because it caused the church to become worldly. As we all know, the church has been called out of the world and has been separated from the world to God. However, by being welcomed by the Roman Empire, the church went back to the world and, in the eyes of God, even married the world. God considers this type of worldly union to be spiritual fornication.

Due to this marriage, the church lost her purity and became worldly. Because the church had entered into union with the world, many worldly things came into the church. Worldly things are related to idol worship, for worldliness is always associated with idolatry. The church in Pergamos firstly became worldly and then idolatrous. Satan saturated her with the world and with idols. As a result, the church became absolutely different from what God intended her to be. God desires a church which is outside of the world, having nothing to do with the world. The church must be a golden lampstand, the pure expression of the Triune God, and must have no connections with the world. But after the Roman Empire had made the church a worldly religion, she became altogether impure, worldly, and idolatrous.

A. Where Satan dwells

In verse 13 the Lord said of the church in Pergamos, “I know where you dwell, where Satan’s throne is.” Satan’s dwelling place is the world. Since the church has entered into union with the world and has become worldly herself, she now dwells where Satan dwells — in the world.

B. Where Satan’s throne is

The church in Pergamos also dwells where Satan’s throne is. This also refers to the world. The world is not only Satan’s dwelling place, but also the sphere wherein he rules. Now the church is not only one with the world but even one with Satan. This is dreadful! The worldly Christianity of today is still in union with the world and is still being saturated with the thoughts, concepts, theories, and even the practices of Satan. We must see the seriousness of this.

The enemy, Satan, is subtle. His welcome is more serious than his persecution. Firstly, Satan stirs up persecution, and then, when this fails, he changes his tactics and welcomes us instead. We have seen this very thing in the past. Firstly, religion persecuted us, and then, changing its strategy, tried to lure us into compromising with it. This is Satan’s subtlety. If we are snared by it, we shall eventually become worldly and not only be in union with Satan, but also one with him. The Lord has included the seven epistles in the book of Revelation that we may see the true situation of so-called Christianity and also see where and what the church should be. The church should be a pure golden lampstand outside of the world. The church must have nothing to do with the world and must not yield an inch to Satan’s evil and subtle saturation. The church must constantly stand against this.

The two meanings of the word Pergamos — “marriage” and “fortified tower” — correspond to two of the parables in Matthew 13, the parable of the great tree (Matt. 13:31-32) and the parable of the leaven (Matt. 13:33). In the parable of the great tree, a tiny mustard seed became a tree. This undoubtedly signifies monstrous Christianity, for Christianity has certainly become a great tree. In the parable of the leaven, we read of a woman who put leaven into three measures of fine flour. Leaven signifies all the sinful, worldly, evil, satanic, demonic, and devilish things. All these wicked things were put into the fine flour. In the Bible, the fine flour used in the meal offering signifies Christ as food for God’s people. The great tree is the equivalent of the high tower, and the woman with the leaven is the equivalent of the apostate church which has married the world. The meaning of the Bible in this matter should be very clear to us all. In the eyes of God, Christendom is a great whore, an evil woman who has mixed worldly, demonic, satanic, and devilish things with the good things of Christ to produce a hellish mixture. We must absolutely abandon this great tree, escape from this high tower, come out of this evil system, and be separated to God, returning to His original intention that the church be a pure golden lampstand having nothing to do with worldliness, idolatry, or Satan’s saturation. We are not in the place where Satan dwells, in the place where Satan sits on his throne. No, in the church there is no ground for Satan. Here there is no place for Satan to do anything.

In the first three epistles we see three churches — the desirable church, the persecuted church, and the worldly church. We certainly want to be a desirable church and a persecuted church, but we must refuse to be a worldly church. We must reject anything worldly. Be careful! After the enemy has persecuted you, his strategy may change. Instead of persecution, there might be a welcome. Do not regard this welcome as a good thing. Rather, you must fear being welcomed more than being stung by a scorpion. It is good for us to suffer persecution, opposition, and attack. But whenever people extend us a warm welcome, that is a most dangerous time. When you are attacked and are undergoing persecution, do not be discouraged, for that is a strong sign that you are on the right track and that you have not been distracted from following the Lord’s steps. But beware of a warm welcome. It is better to suffer persecution than to receive a warm welcome. The epistle to the church in Pergamos teaches us that we should not be in union with the world in any way, sense, or aspect. We must have nothing to do with the world. During the past fifty years, a warm welcome was extended to us quite a number of times in a subtle way, but thank God that we rejected it every time. As a result, throughout the years we have been preserved by being persecuted. We have never received a good name, because Satan will not allow you to have a good name unless you enter into union with him. This is why we in the Lord’s recovery are constantly involved in a battle and are continuously attacked. A war is raging all the time. The Lord’s recovery is not carrying out a common Christian work. No, this testimony is a warfare.

III. The testimony of Antipas

This testimony was with Antipas. In verse 13 the Lord says, “You hold fast My name, and you have not denied My faith, even in the days of Antipas, My witness, My faithful one, who was killed among you, where Satan dwells.” In Greek, the name Antipas means “against all.” This faithful witness of the Lord stood against all that the worldly church brought in and practiced. Hence, he became a martyr of the Lord. In Greek the word martyr is the same word as witness. As an anti-witness, Antipas bore an anti-testimony, a testimony against anything that deviated from the testimony of Jesus. It must have been through this anti-testimony that in his day the church in Pergamos still held fast the Lord’s name and did not deny the proper Christian faith. Antipas took the lead to fight against the worldly church, pioneering the way for us to fight against the worldly church today. Whatever the worldly church was, had, and did, Antipas fought against it.

A. Holding fast the Lord’s name

In verse 13 the Lord says, “You hold fast My name.” The Lord’s name denotes His Person; the Person is the reality of the name. The church in Pergamos still held fast the name of the Lord, the reality of His Person. The deviating tendency of the worldly church is to give up the reality of the Lord’s Person. But in the Lord’s recovery we must fight against this, that the church may hold fast the Lord’s name, the reality of the Lord’s Person, for eternity.

B. Not denying the Lord’s faith

The Lord also said, “You have not denied My faith.” The faith of the Lord denotes all that we must believe in of His Person and work. It is not the subjective faith within us of believing, but the objective faith of the things we believe in. Because the church entered into union with the world, she began to disregard the Lord’s name and to deny the proper Christian faith.

C. Faithful unto death

Antipas was faithful in his anti-testimony, even unto death. Because of his testimony against the worldliness of the church, he was killed and became a martyr. To testify against the worldly church we need the spirit of martyrdom. We need to be faithful for the Lord’s testimony against the worldliness of the church even unto death.

We have seen that Antipas was an anti-witness and an anti-testimony. Today, we in the Lord’s recovery are also an anti-testimony. Ever since Protestant Christianity went to China in 1830, it has been, with some exceptions, rather worldly. Beginning in 1922, the Lord raised up the testimony of the local churches. This testimony did an excellent job for the Lord’s recovery. Although many Christians opposed the recovery, they nevertheless were positively influenced by it, and, as a result, they changed in many ways. They would not take the way of the Lord’s recovery, but they did feel its influence and they took from us many of our teachings. If you check with the missionaries who were in China between 1922 and 1936, they would tell you that the Lord’s recovery exercised a great influence upon Christianity. I was born and raised in Christianity, but I had never heard the word fellowship. But due to the influence of the Lord’s recovery, nearly every denomination began to use this word. Formerly, on their bulletin boards they had the words worship time. But because of our influence they changed the words to meeting time. There is a great difference between “worship time” and “meeting time.” Under the influence of the Lord’s recovery, during the past forty years Christianity in the Far East has become more fundamental and has come back to the Bible. They even use our books as the basis for much of their teaching and preaching. However, some of them dare not admit that they have learned from us. They take the teachings but oppose the way of the Lord’s recovery and criticize our testimony. Nevertheless, the Lord has gained something. I have been told that in Taipei the outsiders always purchase a good quantity of books from our bookroom.

A certain missionary was giving a report about Taiwan. When he was asked about our work on that island, he said that, except for a dead fly in the ointment, it was a good work. Do you know what that “dead fly” was? It was the church ground. According to his concept, if we would drop the church ground, our ointment would be purified. But he did not realize that for us to drop the church ground is to drop our life.

Three years ago, during a visit to Taipei, I met a Christian of high social standing. He said that one preacher had told him that they cannot understand why there is always so much new light in the churches. The reason is that the Spirit is speaking to the churches. The light is neither on the street nor in the outer court; it is in the Holy Place, that is, in the church. This is why we always have something fresh from the Lord.

We are here for all Christians. Thirteen years ago I had a talk with the brothers in Los Angeles about the human spirit, the church practice, and mingling. I said, “Brothers, wait for a period of time and you will see that the outsiders will begin to use these terms.” This is exactly what has happened. Some of the things we have been preaching and teaching have been taken up by others. On the one hand, they oppose us, but, on the other hand, they secretly use our materials. I know of a certain preacher who openly opposes me, yet he teaches people from the book, The Economy of God.

During a visit to Tyler, Texas, I gave a series of messages on transformation. One of the attendants, who took notes on every message, was a noted preacher in South America. At the end of the conference he asked for permission to use some articles from our Stream magazine. I granted him this permission. After several months, I returned to Tyler and was greeted by a brother who said, “Here is a book by Witness Lee.” As I looked at that book, I did not see the name Witness Lee; rather, I saw the name of that preacher who had attended our conference and had taken notes on all the messages. He had gone to another place, had delivered the messages, and then had them published as a book, under his name. What should we say about this? As long as God’s people are helped, we do not care about it. However, we are not standing here for this help — we are standing here for the testimony of Jesus. We must be today’s Antipas.

IV. The teaching of Balaam

In verse 14 the Lord says, “But I have a few things against you, because you have some there who hold the teaching of Balaam, who taught Balak to put a stumblingblock before the sons of Israel, to eat idol sacrifices and to commit fornication.” In these epistles, the Lord desires, according to God’s economy, that we should eat Him as the tree of life (Rev. 2:7), the hidden manna (Rev. 2:17), and the rich produce of the good land (Rev. 3:20). But the worldly church turned from life to mere teachings, thus distracting the believers from the enjoyment of Christ as their life supply for fulfillment of God’s purpose. The enjoyment of Christ builds up the church, whereas the teachings issue in a religion.

This verse mentions “the teaching of Balaam.” Balaam was a Gentile prophet who caused God’s people to stumble. For the sake of reward (2 Pet. 2:15; Jude 1:11), he brought fornication and idolatry to God’s people (Num. 25:1-3; 31:16). In the worldly church, some began to teach the same things. Today, in Protestantism as well as in Catholicism, the same teaching prevails. Idolatry always brings in fornication (Num. 35:1-3; Acts 15:29). When the worldly church disregarded the name, the Person, of the Lord, she turned to idolatry, which issued in fornication.

In today’s Christendom, many of the hired preachers do not teach people to take Christ as their life supply. Rather, they subtly teach people to eat idol sacrifices, that is, to take in evil, devilish, and demonic things. These teachings cause people to deviate from the Person of Christ, leading them into spiritual fornication. Christ should be the unique Husband to the church, the unique Bridegroom to all the saints. But so many teachings in today’s Christianity cause people to take in the demonic things and to be related to things other than Christ. This indeed is to eat idol sacrifices and to commit fornication.

What does it mean to deny the Lord’s name and to deny the faith of the Lord? As we have seen, faith here does not denote the subjective faith, the believing ability; it denotes the objective faith, the items in which we believe. The faith of the Lord includes what He has done for us in His redemptive work, His death and resurrection, and all the items which we must believe in order to be saved. These things constitute our faith. The name denotes the Lord’s Person. We should neither deny the name nor the faith of the Lord. We must always hold on to His name and believe in Him.

When I was young, I was baptized in a Chinese Presbyterian Church where there were some Balaams. On a particular Sunday morning, one of these Balaams delivered a lecture on sanitary education, talking specifically on how to kill flies. Later, someone proposed that a particular object be set up in the church building and that everyone in the congregation bow down to it. When some of us opposed this, that Balaam said, “Even if Jesus Christ would rise up from the tomb and tell me not to bow down to this object, I would still do it.” By this remark he revealed that he did not believe in the resurrection of the Lord Jesus. This is an example of denying the Lord’s Person and of denying our faith in Him. If you read history and study today’s Christianity, you will discover many things like this. In many so-called churches modernism is prevailing. The modernists do not believe that Jesus is God, that He was born of a virgin, or that He died on the cross for our redemption. They merely believe that He was crucified as a martyr, and they do not believe that Jesus Christ was resurrected. The teachings of Balaam always cause people to enter into union with the worldly things. This is to eat idol sacrifices and to commit spiritual fornication.

V. The teaching of the Nicolaitans

In verse 15 the Lord says, “Thus you also have those who hold in like manner the teaching of the Nicolaitans.” The worldly and degraded church holds not only the teaching of Balaam, but also the teaching of the Nicolaitans. The teaching of Balaam distracts believers from the Person of Christ to idolatry and from the enjoyment of Christ to spiritual fornication, whereas the teaching of the Nicolaitans destroys the function of believers as members of the Body of Christ, thus annulling the Lord’s Body in expressing Him. The former teaching disregards the Head, and the latter destroys the Body. This is the subtlety of the enemy in all religious teachings.

In the church in Ephesus only the works of the Nicolaitans were found (Rev. 2:6), whereas in the church in Pergamos their works progressed into a teaching. Firstly, they practiced the hierarchy in the initial church; now they taught it in the degraded church. Today, in both Catholicism and Protestantism, this Nicolaitan hierarchy prevails in both practice and teaching. The Lord hates the Nicolaitan hierarchy because it kills the function of the members of the Body and builds up an organization in place of an organism. Consider the situation of today’s Christianity: there is no organism; rather, there is a strong organization. This hierarchy is evil and satanic, and the Lord hates it. In arranging the services of the church, we must be careful not to build up an organization. If we would have the proper church life, we must develop the function of all the members, encouraging them to function according to life in a living way that the Body might be built up as an organism. This vision must govern the church life, and we must never stray from it. However, if we are even a little negligent, we shall leave the organism and return to organization. Always be on the alert against the formation of any type of organization. We must come back to the organism that all the members of the Body may have the opportunity to function.

VI. The coming and warring of the Lord

In verse 16 the Lord says, “Repent therefore; but if not, I come to you quickly, and I will war with them with the sword of My mouth.” Here the Lord says that He will come quickly and war with the sword of His mouth against some in this worldly church. This should not refer to the Lord’s coming back, but to His coming to war with the Nicolaitan teachers in the degraded church with the slaying word out of His mouth. The worldly church, signified by the church in Pergamos, issues in the Roman Catholic Church, signified by the church in Thyatira, and the worldliness and evil brought in by this degraded church will continue in the Roman Catholic Church until the Lord comes back to exercise His full judgment.

VII. The Spirit’s speaking

The degraded worldly church has a great need for the speaking of the Spirit. It has the Bible in dead letters, but it lacks the speaking of the Spirit. Mere Bible knowledge without the Spirit’s speaking cannot supply what is needed to a deadened Christianity. Its deadness in its degradation must be judged by the sharp sword out of the Lord’s mouth. The worldly church needs the sharp speaking with the living word by the Lord Spirit.

VIII. The promise to the overcomer

In verse 17 the Lord says, “To him who overcomes, to him I will give of the hidden manna, and I will give him a white stone, and on the stone a new name written, which no one knows but he who receives it.” To overcome here means specifically to overcome the church’s union with the world, the teaching of idolatry and fornication, and the teaching of the hierarchy.

A. To eat the hidden manna

The Lord promises to give of the hidden manna to the overcomer. The promise to the first church concerned the eating of the tree of life, and the promise to this church concerns the eating of the hidden manna. The worldlier the church becomes, the greater is the need for some to stand up and testify and to maintain intimate fellowship with the Lord. These will be privileged to enjoy the Lord as the hidden manna. Manna is a type of Christ as the heavenly food enabling God’s people to go His way. A portion of that manna was preserved in a golden pot concealed in the ark (Exo. 16:32-34; Heb. 9:4). The open manna was for the enjoyment of the Lord’s people in a public way; the hidden manna, signifying the hidden Christ, is a special portion reserved for His overcoming seekers who overcome the degradation of the worldly church. While the church goes the way of the world, these overcomers come forward to abide in the presence of God in the Holy of Holies, where they enjoy the hidden Christ as a special portion for their daily supply. This promise is fulfilled today in the proper church life and will be fulfilled in full in the coming kingdom. If we seek the Lord, overcome the degradation of the worldly church, and enjoy a special portion of the Lord today, He, as the hidden manna, will be a reward to us in the coming kingdom. If we miss Him as our special portion today in the church life, we shall surely lose the enjoyment of Him as a reward in the coming kingdom.

The hidden manna was placed in a golden pot. Gold signifies God’s divine nature. Thus, placing the hidden manna in the golden pot signifies that the hidden Christ is concealed in the divine nature. The open manna is for all the people of God, but the hidden manna is for those who are intimate with the Lord, those who have forsaken the world and every separation between them and God. They come into the very intimacy of God’s presence and here in this divine intimacy they enjoy the hidden manna in God’s divine nature. This is deep. It is not outward; it is absolutely inward. It is so inward that those who eat of the hidden manna are actually in the divine nature enjoying the hidden Christ.

How can we eat the hidden manna? This is something absolutely outside of the world. While the worldly church is going down into union with the world, we are coming up from Egypt to the wilderness, from the wilderness to the good land, from the good land to the tabernacle, from the outer court to the Holy Place, from the Holy Place to the Holy of Holies. After we have entered into the Holy of Holies, we must still dive into the ark, touch the golden pot, and enjoy Christ as the manna hidden there. The more the church becomes worldly, the more we need to enter into the Holy of Holies to eat the hidden manna. The manna is in the golden pot, the golden pot is in the ark, and the ark is in the Holy of Holies. By this we can see how inward it is. If we would enjoy it, we must abide in the deep intimacy of God’s presence. We must be in His divine nature where there is nothing worldly or distracting and where there is the intimate fellowship between us and God. Here we enjoy Christ as the hidden manna. Some of us have had this experience of the hidden Christ. We have said, “Lord, I don’t care for the world. I only care for You, Lord, not for any human relationship or friendship. Lord, I am willing to drop every tie. Lord, now I’m thoroughly free, and I love You from the depths of my being. I love You without anything frustrating me.” When we say this to the Lord, we are immediately in the golden pot, in the intimacy of the divine nature, partaking of the hidden Christ. Oh, we must eat such a Christ!

This promise of eating the hidden manna is also prophecy. In the millennium some overcomers will have a special portion of Christ for their enjoyment. That special portion is what is promised here as the hidden manna. However, in principle, even today we can enjoy Christ in such an intimate and hidden way. We enjoy Christ in a way in which those who only enjoy the open manna cannot understand.

B. To receive a white stone with a new name written on it

The Lord also promised the overcomer, saying, “I will give him a white stone, and on the stone a new name written, which no one knows but he who receives it.” Enjoying Christ as the hidden manna produces transformation. How can we say this? Because after referring to the hidden manna, the Lord speaks of a white stone. A stone in the Bible signifies material for God’s building. Man was not made with stone but with dust (Gen. 2:7). In a sense, man is just clay, and Rom. 9 reveals that man is simply a clay vessel. However, when the Lord first met Simon Peter, He immediately changed his name from Simon to Cephas, which means “a stone” (John 1:42). Recall Jacob’s dream in Gen. 28. When he awoke from that dream, he took the stone which he had used for a pillow and called it the house of God. In 1 Corinthians 3 Paul indicates that precious stones are to be used for the building of the church, and in Rev. 21 we see that precious stones are materials in the New Jerusalem. As we put all these verses together, we see that a stone signifies a transformed person. We cannot understand a verse like Rev. 2:17 by itself; we must consider it in the context of the whole Bible. The Lord promises the overcomer to eat of the hidden manna and to give him a white stone. This indicates that if we eat the hidden manna, we shall be transformed into white stones.

In our natural being we are not stones, but clay. Because we have received the divine life with its divine nature through regeneration, we can be transformed into stones, even precious stones, by enjoying Christ as our life supply (2 Cor. 3:18). By eating Jesus as the hidden manna we shall be transformed into white stones for God’s building. If we do not follow the worldly church, but enjoy the Lord in the proper church life, we shall be transformed into stones for the building of God. These stones will be justified and approved by the Lord, as indicated by the color white, while the worldly church will be condemned and rejected by Him. In the book of Revelation the color white denotes approval. When we are transformed into a stone, we shall be approved by the Lord. This will make Him very happy. The white stone is for God’s building. God’s building, the building of the church, depends upon our transformation, and our transformation issues from the enjoyment of Christ as our life supply.

The Lord said that “on the stone” would be “a new name written, which no one knows but he who receives it.” A name designates a person, and the new name here is the designation of a transformed person. Every transformed believer as a “white stone” bears “a new name...which no one knows but he who receives it.” Such a “new name” is the interpretation of the experience of the one being transformed. Hence, only he himself knows the meaning of that name. A certain brother may still be quite muddy. Nevertheless, he loves the Lord, has forsaken the world, and has given up every separation. Thus, the Lord would say to him, “I shall give you to eat of the hidden manna.” The more this brother eats the hidden manna, the more he will be transformed into a white stone. As this brother eats the Lord Jesus as the hidden manna, he will have certain experiences and the Lord will write a new name upon him. This new name is simply the new designation of what this brother is. Since this new name is based upon what this brother is according to his experiences, others cannot know what it is.

Revelation 2:17 is a word spoken by the Lord to us. Do not take it objectively but as your biography. Consider it as a word for you. In a sense, we are living in the age of Pergamos, for the so-called church has become worldly. But, being an anti-witness, we are here fighting for the Lord’s recovery. Therefore, the Lord gives us this word in verse 17, and we all need to understand it and say, “Amen, Lord. Thank You for this promise. I may eat of You as the hidden manna, and this eating will transform me from clay into a stone which will please You, be approved by You, and be used by You for the building up of Your dwelling place. Lord, I agree with Your promise. From now on, I shall eat You in a hidden way and be transformed to become a white stone for Your building.” Is this not a wonderful promise from the Lord? Yes, the church may become worldly, but the Lord has promised that we may become a white stone for God’s building.

The Church in Thyatira — Authority and Morning Star

In this message we come to the fourth church, the church in Thyatira (Rev. 2:18-29), the church in apostasy. Thyatira in Greek means “sacrifice of perfume,” or, “unceasing sacrifice.” As a sign, the church in Thyatira prefigures the Roman Catholic Church, which was fully formed as the apostate church by the establishment of the universal papal system in the latter part of the sixth century. This apostate church is full of sacrifices, as demonstrated in her unceasing mass.

I. The speaker

A. The Son of God

Verse 18 says, “These things says the Son of God, who has eyes as a flame of fire, and His feet like shining brass.” The apostate Catholic Church strongly emphasizes Christ as the Son of Mary. Thus, here, the Lord, protesting against the apostasy of the Catholic Church, says that He is the Son of God.

B. Who has eyes as a flame of fire and whose feet are like shining brass

In dealing with the worldly church, the church in Pergamos, the Lord referred to Himself as the One who has the sharp two-edged sword. In dealing with this apostate church, the church in Thyatira, He refers to Himself as the One who has “eyes as a flame of fire, and feet like shining brass.” The worldly church requires the dealing of His smiting and killing word, whereas the apostate church needs the judging of His searching eyes and treading feet. The Lord’s eyes search the inward parts and the heart, and His feet judge and give to everyone according to his works (Rev. 2:23).

II. The church’s virtues

In verse 19 the Lord says, “I know your works and love and faith and service and your endurance, and that your last works are more than the first.” The apostate Catholic Church has many works and services. Her works in the last days are more than in the past.

III. The woman Jezebel

One of the crucial points in the epistle to the church in Thyatira concerns the woman Jezebel. The Lord refers to her in verse 20, where He says, “But I have this against you, that you tolerate the woman Jezebel, who calls herself a prophetess, and she teaches and leads My slaves astray to commit fornication and to eat idol sacrifices.” As we shall see, the woman here is the very woman prophesied by the Lord in Matt. 13:33, who added leaven (signifying evil, heretical, and pagan things) into the fine flour (signifying Christ as the meal offering for the satisfaction of God and man). This woman is also the great prostitute of Rev. 17, who mixes abominations with the divine things. The pagan wife of Ahab, Jezebel, was a type of this apostate church. The apostate church is filled with all manner of fornication and idolatry, both spiritual and physical.

A. Calling herself a prophetess

Here the Lord indicates that the apostate church is a self-appointed prophetess. A prophet is one who speaks for God with God’s authorization. The apostate Catholic Church presumes to be authorized by God to speak for God. She demands that people listen to her rather than to God.

B. Teaching and leading the Lord’s slaves to commit fornication and to eat idol sacrifices

The church in Pergamos had the teachings of Balaam and of the Nicolaitans, and these are continued in this apostate church. Furthermore, the Catholic Church herself teaches, causing her people to listen to her rather than to the holy Word of God. Her adherents are all drugged by her heretical, religious teaching, not caring for Christ as their life and life supply, as indicated by the tree of life and hidden manna promised by the Lord to the churches in Ephesus and Pergamos (Rev. 2:7, 17).

Matthew 13:33 says, “Another parable He spoke to them: The kingdom of the heavens is like leaven, which a woman took and hid in three measures of meal until the whole was leavened.” The sound teachers of the Bible agree that the Jezebel in Rev. 2 is undoubtedly the woman prophesied by the Lord in Matthew 13:33. These two women actually are one. The great harlot in Rev. 17 is also the same woman. Thus, the woman in Matt. 13 is the Jezebel in Revelation 2, and Jezebel becomes the great harlot who is called the great Babylon in Revelation 17. If she is not the harlot, then who is? The Jezebel in the Old Testament was a prefigure of “the woman Jezebel” in Revelation 2. When the Lord spoke to the church in Thyatira, He said that there was a present-day Jezebel. According to history, this present-day Jezebel undoubtedly is the apostate church, the Roman Catholic Church. In using the name Jezebel, the Lord was reminding us of what Jezebel, the wife of Ahab, did: she came from a heathen background and brought pagan things into the worship of God by His people. This is the crucial and most central point in the epistle to Thyatira. The principle of the apostate church is to mix the heathen, pagan things with the worship of God by His people. She helps God’s people to worship Him, but she does not do so in God’s way; she does it in her own pagan, heathen way. Ever since the apostate church began, she has been absorbing paganism. Wherever she goes, she assimilates things related to the worship of idols.

One of the most striking examples of the deeds of this apostate church is the so-called Christmas. We want Christ, but we do not need a mass. Originally, December 25, the so-called Christmas Day, was the day the ancient Europeans worshipped the sun. They said that December 25 was the birthday of the sun. When the apostate church spread to Europe, she assimilated this ancient custom because she had taken in thousands of unbelievers into the church. These unbelievers still wanted to celebrate the birthday of their god. Therefore, to accommodate them, the apostate church declared December 25 to be the birthday of Christ. This is the source of Christmas. The book, *The Two Babylons*, exposes the origin of the evil, demonic, pagan things that were brought into the apostate church. If we see this picture on the negative side, then we shall know what we must be on the positive side.

From the very beginning of the Bible, God’s intention has been to feed His people with the life supply. Thus, in the garden there was the tree of life as the life supply. After man’s fall, God, in His redemption, did not give up this thought of feeding His people. When He instituted the Passover, God commanded His people to strike the blood of the lamb on the doorpost and, under the covering of the blood, to eat the meat of the lamb. After the children of Israel had been delivered from Egypt and were traveling through the wilderness, God gave them heavenly manna as their life supply (Exo. 16:14-15). Eventually, the children of Israel entered into the good land of Canaan. On the day they entered into the land, the manna ceased, and they began to eat the rich produce of the land (Josh. 5:12). The New Testament confirms that all these are types of Christ, not only as our Redeemer but also as our life supply. As the Lamb, Christ has two elements — the blood for redeeming and the meat for feeding. In John 6 the Lord Jesus revealed that He is the heavenly manna on whom God’s people may feed. We know that the rich produce of the land signifies the riches of Christ. Christ is not only our Lamb and our manna; He is also our good land. As the Lamb, He has the meat, and as the good land, He has all the riches for our life supply. In the Old Testament there were also the offerings which came from the produce of the good land. Among the five main offerings, the second was the meal offering which was for the feeding of God’s people. All the serving priests fed upon the meal offering. This signifies that Christ is the life supply for God’s priests. All God’s serving ones should feed on Christ.

Although this is clear in the Holy Word, most Christians have missed it. When I was in Christianity, I never heard a message telling me how to eat Christ. Nevertheless, the crucial point in the Holy Word is that Christ is our life supply and that we must eat Him (John 6:57). In Matthew 13:33 the Lord indicated that He was the fine flour. His word regarding the meal, or fine flour, in this verse refers to the meal offering which was primarily composed of fine flour. Hence, the fine flour is a full and complete type of the Lord Jesus as our life supply. As the meal offering, Christ in His humanity is the fine flour for our food. In Matthew 13 the Lord Jesus predicted that an evil woman would add leaven to this fine flour. This is exactly what the apostate church does, taking in the pagan leaven and adding it to the fine flour of Christ to form an evil mixture. In this, the apostate church is very evil and subtle.

Some in the apostate church would say, “Don’t you think we have something real? Don’t you think we have God, Christ, and the Bible?” Yes, they do, but it is not pure; it is a mixture. The apostate church has the fine flour, but within the flour there is leaven. When I was in Manila, I visited a Catholic cathedral. At the entrance of this cathedral was a statue of Mary. Noticing that one of the hands of the statue was almost completely worn out, I asked the people what had happened. They said that everyone who entered the cathedral firstly touched the hand of the statue and that, through the years, this had worn out the hand. When I asked them about the need for such a statue, they said, “If people do not have statues, they cannot understand what you are saying when you talk about the Bible. They need something solid to grasp.” This is their justification for having statues of Jesus and Mary. What subtlety! That is not Jesus or Mary — that is an idol. Apparently, they worship Jesus; actually, they worship an image of stone. This is the subtlety of the enemy. Now we can see the evil of the apostate church — it absorbs pagan things and adds them to the fine flour. How wicked this is!

Due to this evil mixture, there is much idol worship in the apostate church. The Lord said that Jezebel teaches people to commit fornication and to eat idol sacrifices. Jezebel teaches her people to worship idols. In the Roman Catholic Church the worship of idols is taught. In Manila, I saw many people purchasing candles at the candle counter and placing them before the images and idols on the walls. Wherever there is idolatry, there is also fornication. Jezebel not only brought in paganism and idolatry; she also brought in fornication. This is abominable, and we cannot tolerate it. It is not a matter of doctrinal debate — it is a matter of idolatry and fornication.

In 1937, when I was traveling in North China, a case of demon possession was brought to my attention. A certain Christian sister had become possessed. When I was asked the reason for this, I said that, in principle, either sin or some idols or images in that sister’s home would give ground for the demon to possess her. I was told that there were no idols or images in her home. Nevertheless, the demon came again and again to trouble her. I told her that since she was not involved in anything sinful, there must be some sort of idol or image in her home and that she should search thoroughly for it. Eventually, I learned that on her wall was a picture of the so-called Jesus, and I told her to burn it. From the moment she burned that picture, the demon departed. In this, we see the subtlety of the enemy.

C. Not willing to repent of her fornication

In verse 21 the Lord Jesus said, “I gave her time that she might repent, and she is not willing to repent of her fornication.” History proves that this is true of the apostate Catholic Church. Even up to this day, she will not repent of her evil deeds.

D. Sick in bed

The Lord also said, “Behold, I will cast her into a bed.” A bed is normally used for sleep and rest, and abnormally for sickness. The Lord indicates here that the apostate church is incurably sick and will remain so until her final judgment. Jezebel’s evils have made her sick; she is not at all healthy. The entire apostate church is in a sick condition. Look at her situation: some things are heavenly and others are earthly; some things are of God and more things are of Satan; some things are holy and other things are secular, common, and worldly. This leaven is not only in that apostate church, but has spread into the so-called reformed church. Jezebel is demonic, satanic, devilish, and even hellish. It is not a small thing for us to have our eyes opened to see the devilish and demonic things in the Catholic Church. We simply cannot imagine how deplorable this apostate church is.

E. Her lovers suffering great tribulation

In verse 22 the Lord not only said that He would cast Jezebel into a bed but also “those who commit adultery with her into great tribulation, unless they repent of her works.” The great tribulation here is different from that in Rev. 7:14 and from the great tribulation in Matthew 24:21. The great tribulation in 7:14 is the tribulation which the church suffers throughout the centuries of persecution. The one in Matt. 24:21 is the great tribulation in the last three and a half years of the age which will fall upon all the dwellers of the earth. But the great tribulation here is the affliction which the Lord will cause the apostate church to suffer, probably through the attacks of the Antichrist on her at the end of this age.

F. Her children being killed with death

In verse 23 the Lord said, “And I will kill her children with death.” This may refer to God’s destroying the Roman Catholic Church through the Antichrist and his followers at the end of this age. If we read Revelation carefully, we shall see that at the end of this age the Antichrist will damage the Catholic Church. The Antichrist will rebel against every religion, set himself up as God (2 Thes. 2:4), forbid the Jews and the Catholics to worship their God, and compel people to worship him. At that time, he will persecute the Jews and kill many of those in the Catholic Church.

IV. The deep things of Satan

Verse 24 says, “But I say to you, the rest in Thyatira, (as many as do not have this teaching, who have not known the deep things of Satan, as they say) I place no other burden upon you.” “Deep things” means depths as in Ephesians 3:18. It figuratively denotes mysterious things. The Roman Catholic Church has many mysteries or deep doctrines. Against the suffering church there was the synagogue of Satan (2:9); with the worldly church there was the throne of Satan (2:13); and within the apostate church there are “the deep things of Satan.” The religion of the synagogue, the world under Satan’s throne, and the philosophy of the satanic mysteries are all used by Satan to damage and corrupt the church.

We have seen that the church suffered persecution from the synagogue of Satan and that she eventually became worldly, dwelling in the place where Satan dwells and where his throne is. All this is the subtlety of the enemy. It all originates with Satan. But here in the fourth church there is something more serious than this. It is not merely a matter of the synagogue of Satan, the place where Satan dwells, or where Satan’s throne is. Now Satan has come into the church and has saturated the church with himself. In the apostate church are the deep things of Satan, the mysterious teachings of Satan. This is the satanic philosophy. The apostate church does teach the satanic mysteries. This indicates that the deep thought of Satan, Satan’s concept, has saturated the apostate church. Eventually, this church becomes the embodiment of Satan. The proper church is the Body of Christ, but the apostate church is the embodiment of Satan. Christ indwells the church, but Satan indwells the apostate church in a subtle way. Satan always acts in a subtle way. When he first came to man, he came in the form of a beautiful serpent. Yet that was not merely a serpent — it was Satan. Satan always takes on a good form. No one would imagine that Satan could put on the “church” as his form. But in the epistle to the church in Thyatira we see that this is the real situation of today’s Christendom. Christendom has become an organ of Satan. Although it has the name Christ in it, actually within it there is Satan himself. We all must see this.

The deep things of Satan, being the satanic philosophy, are subtle. In the apostate church there are many so-called mysteries. All the mysteries taught by this evil church are satanic philosophies. One of their philosophies is that if you do not add things to the truths of the Bible, it will be difficult for people to accept them. The Lord, being wise, likened this to the leaven put into the fine flour that makes the bread easy to eat. The apostate church says that if people do not have a Christmas, it will be difficult for them to accept the truth regarding the birth of Christ. The mass is the leaven added to the fine flour. This is subtle and evil.

If you think that it is too strong to say that this evil woman is the embodiment of Satan, I would ask you to consider Rev. 17:4-5. Verse 4 says, “And the woman was clothed in purple and scarlet, and gilded with gold and precious stones and pearls, having in her hand a golden cup full of abominations and the unclean things of her fornication.” This evil woman does have a good appearance: she is gilded with gold, precious stones, and pearls, the very materials with which the New Jerusalem is built. While the New Jerusalem is solidly built with these three precious materials, this evil woman is merely gilded with them. To be gilded means to wear a facade, to be superficially attractive, to have a pleasing or showy appearance that conceals something evil. Her appearance is attractive outwardly, but she is detestable inwardly. This woman also has a golden cup full of abominations and the unclean things of her fornication. In typology, gold signifies the divine nature. Apparently, this evil woman holds something of God, but actually she is inwardly full of abominations. In the Bible abomination mainly denotes two things — idolatry and fornication. These two things are abominations in the eyes of God. Apparently, this woman is very attractive, being gilded with gold, pearls, and precious stones and holding a golden cup. If you have no insight, you will be cheated by her. But we must have the insight to see through her. When we see what this woman is inwardly, we realize that she is filled with abominations and filthiness.

Verse 5 says, “And upon her forehead a name was written, Mystery, Babylon the Great, The Mother of the Prostitutes and the Abominations of the Earth.” The Lord searches the hearts of people and knows what is within them. He has insight and sees inside this evil woman. The Lord calls her, “The Mother of the Prostitutes,” meaning that she is the source of all spiritual fornication. Therefore, it is fair to say that she is the embodiment of Satan. We need the insight to see through her outward appearance. This is why we have the two-edged sharp sword, the word of the Holy Bible.

We thank the Lord for His sovereign grace. Because His grace is sovereign, He can save us in any environment. Many have been saved even in the evil environment of the apostate Catholic Church. No one can say that the Catholic Church does not preach the Bible. In China, many heathen Chinese learned the name of God, the name of Jesus, and a few verses from the Bible through the teaching of the Catholic Church. The evil thing, however, is this: after people are helped by this apostate church, they are frustrated from going on to know the Lord in a genuine way. Some who, through the Lord’s sovereign grace, were saved when they were in the apostate church spontaneously loved that evil thing. Many of them would say, “If this is evil, then how could I have been saved through it?” Therefore, although many former Catholics have come into the church life, deep within, some of them may still sympathize with this evil woman. They do not hate her as the Lord does. Read the epistle to Thyatira once again. The Lord has no sympathy with Jezebel because that evil woman has been thoroughly saturated with Satan, the evil one. Satan is in every fiber of that wicked woman.

We should have nothing to do with this apostate church. It is not the Body of Christ. It is not the church of God — it is the embodiment of Satan. It is subtle and evil. If you would see even more about the apostate church, read Brother Nee’s book, *The Orthodoxy of the Church*. Anyone who has a heart for the Lord and for His recovery must thoroughly know this apostate church. Once we know her, we would not appreciate anything related to her. Rather, we must declare that she is the great harlot, the great Babylon, and that we must desert her.

As we shall see, the book of Revelation indicates that this great harlot has some daughters. We must be thoroughly enlightened about the apostate church. Once we are enlightened, we shall know where we must be as far as the church is concerned. We are in the Lord’s recovery. We are in the Body of Christ, the church of God, and we have nothing to do with Jezebel, the evil woman, the harlot, the great Babylon. And we have nothing to do with her daughters.

In this epistle the Lord indicates that He will judge Jezebel. In 17:16 we are told that during the great tribulation the Lord will allow the Antichrist to kill and to damage this apostate church. At that time, religious Babylon will be torn down. But before that time, this apostate church will go on according to prophecy. Verse 25 indicates that the apostate Catholic Church will remain until the Lord comes back.

V. The overcomers — the rest in Thyatira

In verse 26 the Lord says, “And he who overcomes, and he who keeps My works until the end, to him I will give authority over the nations.” To overcome here means to overcome Catholicism. The overcomers, the rest in Thyatira, do not have Jezebel’s teaching (v. 24), have not known the deep things of Satan, hold fast the Lord’s testimony until He comes (v. 25), and keep the Lord’s works until the end (v. 26). “My works” in verse 26 refers to the things the Lord has accomplished and is doing, such as His crucifixion, resurrection, intercession, etc., in contrast to the works of the apostate church under the influence of Satan.

VI. The promise to the overcomer

A. To receive authority over the nations

In verse 26 the Lord says that to the one who overcomes He will give authority over the nations. This is a prize to the overcomers of reigning with Christ over the nations in the millennial kingdom (Rev. 20:4, 6). This promise of the Lord strongly implies that those who do not answer His call to overcome degraded Christianity will not participate in the reign of the millennial kingdom.

B. To shepherd the nations with an iron rod as the Lord has received from the Father

In verse 27 the Lord says, speaking of the overcomer, “And he will shepherd them with an iron rod, as vessels of pottery are broken in pieces, as I also have received from My Father.” In the millennial kingdom, the ruler is a shepherd. In Psa. 2:9, God gave Christ authority to rule over the nations. Here, Christ gives the same authority to His overcomers.

C. To have the morning star

Finally, in verse 28 the Lord gives a promise to the overcomer, saying, “I will give him the morning star.” At Christ’s first appearing, the wise men, not the Jewish religionists, saw His star (Matt. 2:2, 9-10). At His second appearing, He will be the morning star to His overcomers who watch for His coming. To all the others, He will appear only as the sun (Mal. 4:2).

VII. The Spirit’s speaking

Once again, in verse 29, the Lord says, “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.” All those in the apostate church, which demands that people listen to her rather than to God, need more of the speaking of the Spirit. If anyone listens to the speaking of the Spirit, he will hear the living word of the Lord to deny all the apostate items taught by the apostate church and become an overcomer for the satisfaction of the Lord.

At the end of each of the first three epistles, the ear for hearing is mentioned first, and then the call for overcoming. At the end of each of the last four epistles, the order is reversed. This proves that the first three of the seven churches are one group and the last four are another. The number seven in the Bible is composed either of six plus one, such as six days plus one day equaling one week; or three plus four, as in these two chapters where the seven churches are divided into one group of three and another group of four. Six plus one is in God’s creation, whereas three plus four is in God’s new creation, the church. Since all things were created in six days, the number six signifies the creation, especially man, who was created on the sixth day; and since the seventh day was the conclusion of the six days as the one day of God’s rest, the number one signifies the unique Creator. Hence, six plus one means that all things were created unto God for the accomplishment of His purpose. The unique Creator, God, is triune, as signified by the number three. Since the creation is represented before God by four living creatures (Rev. 4:6-9), the number four signifies creatures, especially man. Hence, three plus four means that God is added to His creature, man, and thus His purpose is being accomplished. The church is not only the creature, but the creature with the Creator, the Triune God, dispensed into her. She is the real number seven; the real three, the Triune God, added to the real four, the created man. Therefore, the number seven denotes the completion in God’s move, firstly in the old creation, and then in the new creation, the church.

The Church in Sardis — White Garment and Name Confessed by the Lord

It is truly sovereign of the Lord that the situation and condition of the seven churches in Rev. 2 and Rev. 3 match the stages of church history. The history of the church from the first century to the present is clearly divided into seven stages: the initial stage, the suffering stage, the worldly stage, the apostate stage, the stage of Reformation, the stage of the recovered church, and the stage of the degradation of the recovered church. In this message we must consider the church in Sardis, the church in reformation (Rev. 3:1-6).

Sardis in Greek means the remains, the remainder, or the restoration. As a sign, the church in Sardis prefigures the Protestant Church from the time of the Reformation to the second coming of Christ. The Reformation was God's reaction to the apostate Roman Catholic Church, signified by the degraded church in Thyatira. It was accomplished by a minority of the believers, the remainder. Hence, it was the restoration by the remainder.

I. The speaker — He who has the seven spirits of God and the seven stars

In 3:1 the Lord says, "These things says He who has the seven Spirits of God and the seven stars." The seven Spirits of God are for the church to be living intensely, and the seven stars are for her to be shining intensely. To the church in Ephesus, Christ is the One who holds the seven stars and walks in the midst of the seven lampstands. The initial church needed the care of Christ, and her leaders needed His keeping grace. To the church in Smyrna, He is the One who became dead and lived again. The suffering church needed the resurrection life of Christ. To the church in Pergamos, Christ is the One who has the sharp two-edged sword. The degraded, worldly church needed His judging and slaying word. To the church in Thyatira, He is the One who has eyes like flaming fire and feet like shining brass. The apostate church needed His searching and judging. Now to the church in Sardis, He is the One who has the seven Spirits of God and the seven stars. The dead reformed church needs the sevenfold intensified Spirit of God and the shining leaders.

If we examine the situation of Protestant Christianity today, we shall see that it lacks the seven Spirits. Their deadness is due to the lack of the seven Spirits. Because of their organization, they also need the shining stars. This is all they need — the intensified Spirit and the shining stars. However, they do not pay attention to the seven Spirits. The seven Spirits are the full intensified realization of Christ as the Spirit. This is not a matter of the so-called Pentecostal or charismatic movement, but of the indwelling sevenfold intensified Spirit. This is what dead Protestantism needs today. It also needs the shining stars, not the positions or the organization. Their leading ones must be shining ones.

II. The church's condition

A. Living in name, but dead in actuality

To the messenger of the church in Sardis the Lord says, "I know your works, that you have a name that you are living, and you are dead. Become watchful and establish the things which remain, which were about to die; for I have not found your works completed before My God." These two verses present a full picture of the so-called Protestant Church. The reformed Protestant Church has been considered to be living, but the Lord says that she is dead. Hence, in her dead condition, she needs the living Spirits and the shining stars.

B. The remaining things being about to die

In verse 2 the Lord says to "establish the things which remain, which were about to die." "The things which remain" are the things lost and restored by the Reformation, such as justification by faith and the open Bible. Though these things were restored, they "were about to die." Hence, the Protestant Church needs revivals to keep things alive. This is the actual situation of the Protestant churches.

C. Having no work completed

The Lord also said, "I have not found your works completed before My God." Nothing begun in the Reformation has ever been completed. Therefore, the church in Philadelphia is needed for the completion. In the eyes of God, there are no complete works in the so-called reformed churches. Do not think that justification by faith is completed among them. If you have the inner sight, you will see that the justification by faith recovered by Martin Luther was quite shallow, for Luther did not touch justification very much in the way of life, but mainly in the way of doctrine, in a superficial way. We thank the Lord for this great servant of God, but he was not perfect. None of the work under his hand was completed. The things recovered in the days of Luther have been dying and are still about to die. This is why so many Protestant churches have frequent revivals.

The crucial point about the fifth church is that it is dead and dying. While it has a name that it is living, actually it is dead. Many of us can testify that when we were saved, we were quite living. But after getting into a denominational church, we were put into the refrigerator and, after a few months, we cooled down and died. The reformed churches are deadening. I was raised in a so-called Protestant church and I know that there is absolutely no life there. In nearly every way, it is filled with death.

III. The Lord's charge

In verse 3 the Lord says, "Remember therefore how you have received and heard, and keep it and repent." In both this verse and in verse 2, the Lord charges the church in Sardis to be watchful, to establish the things which remain and which are about to die, to keep what she has received and heard, and to repent.

IV. The Lord's coming

In verse 3 the Lord also says, "If therefore you will not watch, I will come as a thief, and you shall by no means know at what hour I will come upon you." A thief comes to steal precious things at an unknown time. Since the reformed Protestant churches are dead, they will be unaware of the Lord's coming as a thief in His secret appearing to His seekers. Hence, there is the need of watchfulness.

The revelation in the New Testament regarding the Lord's second coming is not according to our natural understanding. According to our natural thought, the Lord will suddenly descend from the throne in the heavens to the earth. This thought has caused much difficulty to the students of the Bible, and we must drop it. In understanding anything found in the Bible, we should have no trust in our thoughts, and we should never apply our natural concepts. This is why we need a clear, renewed mind when we come to the Word of God. We must drop the colored eyeglasses of our concepts and come to the pure Word. The Lord's coming back is a process. His coming back will begin from the throne and will pass through a process until He descends to fight the battle at Armageddon. As we have pointed out, the Lord will descend from the throne to the air where He will accomplish many things: the rapture of the majority of the saints, the judgment at the judgment seat, and the wedding of the Lamb. After all this has been accomplished in the air, the Lord will descend to the earth. The rapture of the early overcomers, including the man-child (ch. 12) and the firstfruits (ch. 14), will occur at the start of the process of the Lord's coming back. In other words, when they are raptured, the process of the Lord's coming back begins.

In Rev. 3:3 and Matt. 24:43 we are told that the Lord will come as a thief. Suddenly, some of the believers who are the early overcomers will be taken away. No one knows the time of the beginning of the process of the Lord's coming back and of the rapture of the early overcomers. When it comes, there will be no time for you to prepare yourself. You must be thoroughly prepared before that time. Therefore, we must be prepared, ready, and watchful.

V. The overcomers — a few names in Sardis

A. Not having defiled their garments with death

In verse 4 the Lord says, "But you have a few names in Sardis who have not defiled their garments." Garments in the Bible signify what we are in our walk and living. To defile the garments means particularly to stain them with deadness. Death is more defiling before God than sin (Lev. 11:24-25; Num. 6:6, 7, 9). In this verse, the defilement denotes anything of the death nature. The defilement in Sardis was not the defilement of sin; it was the defilement of death. Death is dirtier than sin. According to the Old Testament, if anyone sinned, he could be forgiven simply by offering the sin offering (Lev. 4:27-31). However, anyone who touched the dead body of a man had to wait seven days before he could be cleansed (Num. 19:11, 16). This indicates that the defilement of death is more serious than that of sin. Christians today have no consciousness of death. If you go to Las Vegas to gamble in a casino, you will sense that you have sinned. But if you came to a meeting in a dead way, you may not sense the seriousness of it. But in the eyes of God, this death situation is more serious than gambling in a Las Vegas casino. Although Christians condemn sin, they do not condemn deadness. People sit in the meetings like corpses and they see nothing wrong with it. I do not like to be near anything dead. One day, my mother died. Although we all loved her, none of us dared to stay near her dead body overnight. If your dear wife would dirty herself while doing something for you, you would love her more than ever before. But if she were to die, you would not want to be near her dead body. The Lord hates death. However, most Christians in the reformed churches do not have this concept of death. They may say, "What is wrong with the denominational churches?" They are not only wrong — they are filled with death. Though there may be nothing wrong with the corpses in a mortuary, they are full of death. Death is the greatest problem. How ugly it is! It is a stench to God, and He cannot tolerate it.

In the local churches, we all must hate death. I would rather see the people in the churches wrong than to see them dead. Many times I have asked the brothers and sisters why they do not function in the meetings. Often their reply was, "I'm afraid of making a mistake." To this, I responded, "The more mistakes you make, the better. Living children make many mistakes. But the dead children in the cemeteries make no mistakes at all." If you simply sit in the meeting without doing anything, you will never be wrong. Although you may be right, you will be dead right. I would rather be livingly wrong than dead right. I may make mistakes, but everyone will know how living I am. Which do you prefer — to be dead right or livingly wrong?

B. Walking with the Lord in white

Speaking of these who have not defiled their garments, the Lord says that “they shall walk with Me in white for they are worthy” (v. 4). White not only signifies purity, but also approvedness. White garments here signify the walk and living which are unspotted by death and which will be approved by the Lord. It is a qualification for walking with the Lord, especially in the coming kingdom.

VI. The promise to the overcomer

If you read the context of Revelation 2 and 3, you will see that every time the Lord gives a promise in these seven epistles, strictly speaking it refers to the coming kingdom. It never refers to eternity, to our eternal destiny. Rather, it refers to our future in the coming kingdom. This is the basic and governing principle in understanding all the promises in these seven epistles. In verse 4 the Lord promises that the living ones, those who have not defiled their garments, will walk with Him in white. When will this be? In the wedding day of Christ which will last for a thousand years. To walk with the Lord in white means to walk with Him during these thousand years. In principle, this must also be applied to our walk with the Lord today.

In verse 5 the Lord says, “He who overcomes, he shall be clothed in white garments, and I will by no means erase his name out of the book of life, and I will confess his name before My Father and before His angels.” To overcome here means to overcome the deadness of the Protestant churches, that is, to overcome dead Protestantism. The whole of verse 5 is the Lord’s promise to the overcomers. It will be fulfilled in the millennial kingdom after He comes back.

A. To be clothed in white garments, walking with the Lord

Firstly, the Lord promises the overcomer that he will be “clothed in white garments.” To be “clothed in white garments” in this promise will be a prize to the overcomers in the millennial kingdom. In what they have been walking in this age, will be a prize to them in the coming age. Every Christian needs two garments. The first is the garment of salvation signifying Christ as our righteousness objectively. In Luke 15, when the prodigal son returned home, the father had the best robe prepared for him. The first thing the father did was to have the best robe placed upon him. Wearing that robe, the prodigal son was justified in the presence of the father. He had been a pitiful beggar, no longer worthy to be with the father. But once he had the robe upon him, he was justified and approved. This means that he was justified in Christ and that Christ became his justifying covering. He was covered by Christ as his righteousness. Thus, the garment of justification is for salvation. However, besides this, we need another garment to make us approved and well-pleasing to the Lord. The “fine linen, bright and pure” in 19:8 denotes this second garment. According to typology, the queen in Psa. 45 has two garments, one for salvation and the other for her to be with the king in His reign. After we have been saved, we need to mature and overcome all frustrations and distractions. We must run the race and reach the goal. As we are running the race, there are many things which would frustrate us from reaching the goal. We must overcome all these frustrations. Yes, we have been saved and justified and have the first robe for our salvation. But we must go on to maturity and reach our destination. If we do so, then we shall receive a reward. This is not a matter of Christ as our objective righteousness, but of experiencing Christ as our subjective righteousness. Christ as our objective righteousness has been put upon us, whereas Christ as our subjective righteousness comes out of us. We must live out Christ as our second garment. This garment is for the reward. The white garments mentioned in verse 5 refer to this second garment. When we have this second garment, we are well-pleasing to the Lord and shall receive the reward.

B. Name not to be erased out of the book of life

To the one who overcomes the Lord promises that He “will by no means erase his name out of the book of life.” We cannot understand this verse by itself. It is dangerous to do this. In order to understand a verse such as this we need to be safeguarded by the whole Bible. The name being “erased out of the book of life” indicates that that name was already written in the book of life. “The book of life” is a divine record of the names of those who partake of the blessings God has prepared for them. The names of all the saints chosen by God and predestinated to partake of these blessings are written in this book (Luke 10:20). These blessings are in three stages: the church, the millennial kingdom, and eternity. The blessings in the stage of the church, such as forgiveness, redemption, regeneration, eternal life, and the divine nature are all the initial portions. All God’s chosen ones whose names are written in the book of life have a share in these initial portions to begin their spiritual life. If they cooperate with God’s supplying grace, they will mature in life in the church age, and this earlier maturity in life will constitute a prize with which the Lord will reward them at His coming back. That prize will be the entrance into the millennial kingdom and participation in the divine blessings in that stage, such as the joy and rest of the Lord (Matt. 25:21, 23; Heb. 4:9-11) and the reign over the nations (Rev. 2:26-27; 20:4, 6) which God has prepared as an incentive for His chosen ones to go on with Him in the church age. However, many of His chosen ones, after receiving His forgiveness, redemption, eternal life, divine nature, etc., will not cooperate with His grace and go on with Him. Hence, they are unable to mature in life in the church age and thus will not be ready at the Lord’s coming back to enter into the millennial kingdom and share in the divine blessings of that age as a prize. Therefore, during the millennial kingdom their names will be erased from the book of life. After being disciplined by the Lord and growing in life unto maturity during the millennial kingdom, they will share in the divine blessings in the stage of eternity, such as the eternal service with God’s eternal presence, the eternal kingship (Rev. 22:3-5), the New Jerusalem, the tree of life (Rev. 22:14), and the water of life (Rev. 22:17). Then their names should be written in the book of life again. This means that all God’s chosen ones whose names are written in the book of life and who have been brought into the participation of the divine blessings in the stage of the church shall “by no means perish forever” (John 10:28), that is, they shall by no means lose the divine blessings of eternity. But some, who will not cooperate with the Lord in the church age, will be dispensationally disciplined by the Lord during the millennial kingdom and will miss the divine blessings in that stage.

We face the danger of having our names erased from the book of life during the thousand years. If you are defeated and refuse to be an overcomer by the Lord’s grace, your name will not be there in the book of life when He is reigning during the thousand years. This means that you have been called but that you have not been chosen. In Rev. 17:14, we can see that, at His coming back, after all the saints have been raptured, the Lord will make a selection. This selection will depend on how we have lived our Christian life. If we have lived in a defeated way, the Lord certainly will not select us. But if we have lived in a victorious way, we shall be selected, and our names will be there during the thousand years. This is similar to graduation from school. Although all the names of the students may be on the class list, only a few names will be on the list to receive a reward. To erase the name of a believer from the book of life does not mean that he shall perish for eternity. It only means that during the thousand years of the coming kingdom his name will not be there. This means that he will lose his birthright in the millennial kingdom, having no right to share what God originally intended to give to all of His chosen ones.

God’s original intention is that all His chosen ones should enjoy Christ to the uttermost today that they might also have the right to enjoy Christ in the coming age. Since many are unwilling to do this now, when the kingdom comes, they will lose their birthright. Only those who cooperate with God’s original intention will be in the kingdom enjoying Christ as their special portion. Their names will be in the book of life at that time, but the names of many others will not be there. Because not many Christians have seen this vision, they cannot understand the verses concerning this matter.

God’s intention is to work Christ into us for our enjoyment. The church age is the time for this to be accomplished. But whether or not we are willing to cooperate with God in this matter depends on us. Because many will not cooperate with God, in His wisdom He has decided to make the enjoyment of Christ in the coming kingdom age a reward. This reward is an incentive encouraging us to cooperate with God and to enjoy Christ today. If we do not cooperate, we shall miss the kingdom age. The book of life is a record of all the names who have a share in the enjoyment of Christ. During the church age all our names are there. But in the kingdom age, the names of the sloppy ones will be erased from this book. After the millennial kingdom, their names will then be put back into the book of life. It is good to see that God’s blessing in His salvation is of three ages: the church age, the kingdom age, and the age of eternity. Whether or not we will be in the kingdom sharing the full enjoyment of Christ depends upon whether we are willing to enjoy Christ today in the church life. Do not miss the opportunity today. If we enjoy Christ today, we shall be rewarded in the coming kingdom. Those who miss the special enjoyment of Christ in the coming kingdom will be dealt with by God that they might be brought into the full enjoyment of Christ. Therefore, eventually, when we all have passed through these two ages, the church age and the kingdom age, we all shall be ripe in the enjoyment of Christ and shall enter into the age of eternity.

C. Name to be confessed by the Lord before the Father and the angels

If we are overcomers, the Lord will not erase our names out of the book of life; rather, He will confess our names before the Father and His angels. This indicates that since the names of those believers who are unwilling to be overcomers will be erased out of the book of life, their names will not be confessed by the Lord before the Father and His angels.

VII. The Spirit’s speaking

The dead reformed church needs the speaking of the living Spirit. The knowledge of the dead letters can never replace the speaking of the intensified Spirit. The letter kills (2 Cor. 3:6). It is the Spirit who gives life (John 6:63). All those in dead Protestantism must listen to the speaking of the Spirit.

The Church in Philadelphia — Rapture Before the Great Tribulation and a Pillar in God's Temple

In this message we come to the church in Philadelphia, the church in recovery (Rev. 3:7-13). In Greek, Philadelphia means brotherly love. As a sign, the church in Philadelphia prefigures the proper church life recovered by the brothers who were raised up by the Lord in England in the early part of the nineteenth century. Just as the reformed church, prefigured by the church in Sardis, was a reaction to the apostate Catholic Church, prefigured by the church in Thyatira, so the church of brotherly love is a reaction to the dead reformed church. This reaction will continue as an anti-testimony to both apostate Catholicism and degraded Protestantism until the Lord comes back.

I. The speaker

A. The holy One, the true One

Verse 7 says, “These things says the holy One, the true One.” To the church of brotherly love, the Lord is “the holy One, the true One” by whom and with whom the recovered church can be holy, separated from the world, and true, faithful, to God.

B. He who has the key of David

To the recovered church, the Lord is also the One who has “the key of David” (v. 7), the key of the kingdom, with authority to open and to shut. Not many know the meaning of the term the key of David. According to Genesis 1, when God created man, He gave him dominion over all creatures. This indicates that, in God's intention, man is to be the power representing God on earth. Due to the fall, however, man lost this power and has never fully recovered it. Man has not regained dominion on earth to represent God. In the lives of Adam, Abel, Enosh, Enoch, and Noah we do not see this power. Neither do we see it in the lives of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. We do not see this power until God's chosen people, the children of Israel, entered into the good land and built the temple. Apparently, the temple was built by Solomon; actually, it was built by David, for he was behind the building of the temple. Remember what is revealed in Genesis 1:26. God made man in His own image that he might express Him and with His dominion that he might represent Him. The temple is related to God's image because, being God's house, it is His expression. The temple was built in the city. The temple signifies God's expression, and the city signifies God's dominion. The image and dominion revealed in Genesis 1 are, to some extent at least, fulfilled in the temple and the city. In the temple we have God's presence for His expression, and in the city we have God's dominion. God's king is in the city representing Him as he rules on earth.

This is a necessary background for understanding what the key of David is. The key held by David is the key of God's entire dominion. God's dominion includes the whole universe, especially mankind. This dominion has a key which is possessed by the person who fought the battle for the kingdom and who made preparations for the temple. The name of this person is David. David represented God in establishing God's kingdom on earth. Hence, he has the key of God's dominion in the universe. David, however, was just a type, not the reality. The real David is Christ, the greater David. He is the One who built God's temple, the church, and established God's kingdom. Therefore, in the church today, which is both a house and a kingdom, we have God's expression and representation. As the greater David, Christ has built up the house of God, the real temple, and He has set up the kingdom of God, the dominion in which He exercises full authority to represent God. Thus, He holds the key of David. The key of David is something representing God to open the whole universe for God. This is the key of David held by Christ. This term signifies that Christ is the center of God's economy. He is the One who expresses and represents God, the One who holds the key to open everything in God's dominion.

C. He who opens and shuts

Verse 7 also says that Christ is the One who “opens and no one shall shut, and shuts and no one shall open.” Because the universal key, the key of God's economy, is in His hand, He opens and shuts.

As we have pointed out, nearly everything found in the book of Revelation is not new but a fulfillment of things revealed in the Old Testament. This is also true of the key of David. Isa. 22:22-24 is a prophecy concerning Christ as the One who holds the key of David. The deep thought in Christ's holding the key of David is found there. In Isa. 22 it was prophesied that Christ would not only be the One holding the key of David, but that He would also be a nail or peg. Very few Christians have heard that Christ is a nail. If you consider the context of Isaiah 22 and if you read the context of the word regarding Christ as the One holding the key of David in Rev. 3, you will realize that Christ's holding the key of David is for God's house, for God's building. The crucial subject in Isaiah 22 is the house of God. And the epistle to the church in Philadelphia eventually speaks of the New Jerusalem. The overcomers in Philadelphia will be pillars in the temple of God, and the temple of God will ultimately be enlarged into the New Jerusalem. According to Rev. 21:22, there is no temple in the New Jerusalem, for, in eternity, the temple will be enlarged into a city, which, having three equal dimensions (Rev. 21:16), will be the enlargement of the Holy of Holies. This is the ultimate consummation of God's house. Christ's holding the key of David, fighting the battle for God, and building the temple and establishing the kingdom of God are all for God's building.

Christ holds the key of David and He opens and shuts, not that we might be holy or spiritual, but that we might be built up. He does not care for so-called holiness or spirituality. During the past two centuries, certain people claimed to be holy and spiritual. Although they saw something, they were rather short-sighted. Holiness is not for holiness, and spirituality is not for spirituality. Both holiness and spirituality are to enable us to be pillars in the temple of God. Eventually, we shall not bear the name of holiness or spirituality but of the New Jerusalem. In 3:12 the Lord did not say, “I will write holiness upon you,” or, “I will write spirituality upon you”; He said, “I will write upon him the name of My God and the name of the city of My God, the new Jerusalem, which descends out of heaven from My God, and My new name.” What we have here is neither holiness nor spirituality but God and the New Jerusalem. God's purpose is not to make us holy or spiritual; it is to make us part of the New Jerusalem. God already has all the holiness He needs, but He does not yet have the New Jerusalem. God's desire is not for more spirituality. He is seeking the New Jerusalem. God desires a built church. He wants today's Bethel, the house of God which will consummate in the New Jerusalem. Are you willing to see this?

When I saw this light eighteen years ago, I made a strong declaration in my message that God does not want spirituality. Some opposers took this sentence out of context and said, “Listen, Witness Lee says that we don't need spirituality and that God does not want spirituality.” In that message I said again and again that any spirituality which is not for God's building is not genuine. Our spirituality must be tested by the church life. If our spirituality does not fit into the church life, it is an abnormal spirituality. It does not supply the Body; rather, it is a cancer. Many so-called spiritual persons are cancers. Cancer is a disease of the cells in the body. Unlike germs, cells are constituents of the body, and there is nothing wrong with them. But if the cells are not properly balanced and become too concentrated, they will develop into a cancer. The so-called spirituality that cannot be tested, adjusted, or balanced and that cannot fit into the building of the church is a cancer.

The Speaker to the church in Philadelphia holds the key of David, not to make us holy or spiritual, but to deal with us that we might be transformed and built up. Once we have been built up, He will become a nail to us, and we shall be the vessels hanging on Him. Firstly, Christ holds the key of David and eventually He holds us. Christ used the key to open the door of our prison. Before we came into the church life, we were all imprisoned. For example, some were imprisoned in the dungeon of Catholicism. But wherever we were, Christ, the One who holds the key of David, opened our prison and released us. According to our experience, all the doors opened for us by Christ are prison doors. Although the opposers are trying their best to imprison us, and to make the church a prison, we are released by the key held in the hand of Christ. As today's David, He has the key to open whatever God desires to open. Once He opens the door and we are released, we enter into the house of God where we become the household with many vessels held by Christ as the nail. If we remain in our mentality, we shall not have the realization or the sense of being held by Christ in this way. Nevertheless, Christ is the nail in God's house, and by this nail, we all are held up from the earth.

Firstly, Christ uses the key to release us from prison. After we have been released and have entered into the house of God, He becomes the nail holding us off the ground. The purpose of His doing this is that we might be transformed into a pillar in God's house. Eventually, we, the pillars, will become parts of the New Jerusalem. As we shall see, Christ's writing the name of the New Jerusalem upon us means that we have been transformed into a part of the New Jerusalem. If you see this, your view will be changed. In the past, you might have pursued holiness or spirituality, but you sought holiness and spirituality in an aimless way. You did not have God's goal in view. You did not see that both holiness and spirituality are for God's building. Today, Christ, the real David, uses the key to release us from prison. He then brings us into God's house that we might be transformed to be pillars and parts of the New Jerusalem. This is the church life, and this is the temple of God. Within this temple our Christ is a great nail holding us off the ground for God's building.

II. The church's condition

A. Having a little power

In Rev. 3:8 we see the condition of the church in Philadelphia. Firstly, this church had “a little power.” Many times we estimate the church in Philadelphia too highly, thinking that this church was strong and prevailing. Actually, it was not so. Some may think that when the Lord raised up the brothers in England one hundred fifty years ago, every one of them must have been like David. While we estimate the church in Philadelphia very highly, the Lord says that she had “a little power.” What pleases the Lord is not that we are strong, but that we use our little power to do the best we can. Do not try to be strong. The strong ones may not please the Lord as much as those who do their best with the little power they have. You can never surpass what the Lord gives you. Simply spend what you have received from Him. Do not usurp the Lord's grace. None among us can say that he has received nothing from the Lord. Even the least among us has received a certain amount of grace from Him. You must spend that grace, using it to do your best. If you do this, the Lord will appreciate you and say, “Good. You have a little power, yet you have kept My word with the power you have.” Do not seek to be a giant. The Lord is not happy with giants; He is happy with the little ones who have an amount of grace. Although that grace may be limited in its capacity, as long as we use it, spending it to do as much as we can to keep the Lord's word, He will be pleased.

B. Having kept the Lord's word

In verse 8 the Lord said that the church in Philadelphia kept His word. One outstanding feature of Philadelphia is that she kept the Lord's word. According to history, no other Christians have kept the Lord's word as strictly as these in the church in Philadelphia. Likewise, by His grace, we are keeping His word today. Although many condemn us, saying that we are heretical, among today's Christians no one regards the Lord's word more than we do. We keep the Word of God, not in the traditional way, but in the way of the pure Word. This offends those who want to hold the traditions of their forefathers. The church in Philadelphia does not care for tradition; she cares for the Word of God.

C. Having not denied the Lord's name

In verse 8 the Lord also said that the church in Philadelphia did not deny His name. Since the brothers were raised up in England in the early part of the eighteenth century, they have not taken any name other than the name of the Lord. The word is the Lord's expression, and the name is the Lord Himself. The apostate church has deviated from the Lord's word and become heretical. The reformed church, though recovered to the Lord's word to some extent, has denied the Lord's name by denominating herself with many other names, such as Lutheran, Wesleyan, Anglican, Presbyterian, and Baptist. The recovered church has not only returned to the Lord's word in a full way, but has also abandoned all names other than that of the Lord Jesus Christ. The recovered church belongs to the Lord absolutely, having nothing to do with any denominations (any names). To deviate from the Lord's Word is apostasy, and to denominate the church with any name other than the Lord's is spiritual fornication. The church as the chaste virgin espoused to Christ (2 Cor. 11:2) should not have any name other than her husband's. All other names are an abomination in the eyes of God. In the recovered church life we have no teachings of Balaam (Rev. 2:14), no teachings of the Nicolaitans (Rev. 2:15), no teachings of Jezebel (Rev. 2:20), and no mysterious doctrines of Satan (Rev. 2:24); we have only the pure Word of the Lord. Amen! The recovered church has no denominations (names), but the unique name of the Lord Jesus Christ. The deviation from the Word to heresies and the exaltation of so many names other than that of Christ are the most striking signs of degraded Christianity. The return to the pure Word from all heresies and traditions and the exaltation of the Lord's name by abandoning every other name are the most inspiring testimony in the recovered church. This is why the church in the Lord's recovery has the revelation and presence of the Lord and expresses the Lord in a living way, full of light and with the riches of life.

Because we have an all-sufficient name, the name above every name, we do not need the names Lutheran, Methodist, Baptist, Episcopalian, Presbyterian, or any other names. We have only one name — the name of our Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God. It is a serious matter to take a name. Suppose you are Mrs. Smith. If you take the name of Mrs. Jones, it indicates that you have committed fornication. The church should have only one husband, only one name, the name of Jesus Christ. In the past, some friends in the denominations have asked me, “Why do you call yourselves the church? Why do you say that we are not the church?” I answered, “You call yourselves Presbyterian. Don't blame me for this — you have designated yourself in this manner. If you are the church, why do you designate yourself in this way? Are you Mrs. Smith? Then why do you call yourself Mrs. Jones? When I call you Mrs. Jones and say that I am Mrs. Smith, you are jealous. Don't blame me for this, for you have called yourself Mrs. Jones.” After this, all their mouths were shut. Do not think that a name is a small thing. We are saved in the Lord's name. Besides His name, we should never take any other name. George Whitefield, a contemporary of John Wesley, once declared that besides the name of Jesus Christ he would have no other name. Although Whitefield was an Englishman, he renounced the name of the Church of England, not belonging to that name anymore. The church in Philadelphia does not deny the Lord's name; she has no name other than His.

Sometimes people have argued with us, saying, “We have never denied the Lord’s name.” We replied, “Yes, you have never denied His name, but you have taken another name in addition to and even above His name. Now you have two names. Why don’t you drop the other name you have taken? If you would drop this other name, then we could be one. All other names cause divisions. You call yourself a Presbyterian. I hate that name because taking it makes me a fornicator. Since you like it and I hate it, if you still hold on to it, how can we be one? But if you drop this name, we shall immediately be one in the unique name of the Lord Jesus Christ.” Some have said that the name on the outside of their so-called church building is merely an outward sign, and that they do not really care about it. If they do not care about it, then they should prove their honesty in this manner by removing that sign. But some have said that it is too difficult for them to do that because the “church” board would hinder them. To this I replied, “Then you must bear the responsibility for division.”

D. Having an open door

In verse 8 the Lord said, “Behold, I have put before you an open door which no one can shut.” As the One who has the key of David and who opens and no one can shut, the Lord has given the recovered church “an open door which no one can shut.” Since the recovery of the proper church life began, in the early part of the nineteenth century, until now, a door has always been wide open to the Lord’s recovery. The more that organized Christianity tries to shut the door, the wider it is open. In spite of much opposition, the door today is open worldwide. The key is in the hand of the Head of the church; it is not in the hand of the opposers. Hallelujah, we have an open door! During the past fifty years, the denominations have tried their best to close this door. But the more they attempted to shut it, the more the Lord has opened it. No one can deny that there is an open door for the Lord’s recovery today. The Lord has the key. As long as we are in His recovery, the door will always be open to us.

III. The subduing of the Jewish religion

Verse 9 says, “Behold, I will make them of the synagogue of Satan, those who call themselves Jews and are not, but lie; behold, I will cause them to come and worship before your feet, and they shall know that I have loved you.” The Jewish synagogue holds on to Judaism, which comprises the mediatorial priests, the ordinances of letters, the material temple, and the earthly promises. The recovered church has subdued Judaism by exposing its error and stubbornness in holding on to the above four things and has made the Jews know that the Lord has loved her. As we pointed out in message eleven, the Judaizers were Jews in flesh but not in spirit. Due to their stubbornness in clinging to their traditional religious concepts, they became one with Satan in opposing God’s way of life to fulfill His purpose. Hence, the Lord calls them “the synagogue of Satan.” Nevertheless, according to the epistle to the church in Philadelphia, the opposing Jews are subdued before the church, and the Lord’s love toward the church is made known to them.

All denominations are actually today’s synagogues. Do you know what a synagogue is? As revealed in Deuteronomy chapters twelve, fourteen, fifteen, and sixteen, God’s economy is to have one unique temple on earth. The Lord charged His people in Deuteronomy not to have any place as their worshipping center other than that place which He would choose. That chosen place was Jerusalem, and on the selected site God had the temple built. This unique temple not only signifies that the testimony of God must be one; it also maintains the oneness of God’s people. Eventually, however, God’s people became degraded, and, due to this degradation, division came in. As a result of this division, the people of God were scattered, having lost their unity. But since they still had to worship God and since they had no right to build the temple except on the designated site in Jerusalem, they established worshipping centers called synagogues wherever they went. A synagogue is a degraded worship center. There can be only one temple, but there are many synagogues, all of which are divisive. This is a type of the degradation of the church. As we apply this type to the church situation, we see that in God’s economy the church is uniquely one. But due to the degradation, the church was divided. In every division there is a worshipping center. These worshipping centers have become today’s synagogues. Just as the temple was unique, but the synagogues were many, so the church is unique and the denominations and free groups are many.

When the epistles to the seven churches were written, the church was being slandered by the Jewish synagogue (Rev. 2:9). But eventually, the synagogue realized that the Lord loved the church in Philadelphia. In typology, this is a sign of the real church in Philadelphia that the Lord raised up about one hundred fifty years ago. In the late 1820’s the brothers were raised up in England as the fulfillment of the church in Philadelphia. At that time, they were surrounded, not by Jewish synagogues, but by the synagogues of the denominations which criticized and slandered them. During the past fifty years, we also have been the subject of slander and rumors, and even today many rumors and slanders are circulating about us. The source of these rumors and slanders is today’s synagogues. Nevertheless, it is undeniable that the Lord loves the recovery, and eventually all the slanderers will acknowledge this fact.

While some slander us, some say, “We cannot explain why they are so strong,” others testify, “They truly understand the Bible,” and still others confess, “They always have new light.” Any light and understanding we have come from the blessing from the One who holds the key of David. Although I do not boast of myself, I may boast of the Lord’s blessing. The Lord’s recovery in this country is not the work of man. Who could do such a work? I certainly cannot. Eventually, all the critics of the Lord’s recovery will be subdued and realize that Jesus Christ loves us. Wait for another period of time and you will see more of how much the Lord loves His churches. He will vindicate His church before all the denominations. Our work is not the common work of Christianity, nor a work under human control. No, it is the work of His recovery. It is the Lord’s heart’s desire, and He loves it. When people touch this matter, they touch the apple of His eye. The Lord loves Philadelphia, and the opposing Jews of the synagogue of Satan were subdued before the church because the Lord’s love for the church was made known to them.

IV. The Lord’s charge

In verse 11 we see the Lord’s charge: “I come quickly; hold fast what you have that no one take your crown.” The recovered church has gained a crown already. However, if she does not hold fast what she has in the Lord’s recovery until the Lord comes back, her crown may be taken away by someone.

V. The Lord’s promise to the overcomer

Let us now consider the promise to the overcomer in Philadelphia (Rev. 2:10-12). To overcome in this epistle means to hold fast what we have in the recovered church.

A. To keep him out of the hour of trial

Verse 10 says, “Because you have kept the word of my endurance, I also will keep you out of the hour of trial which is about to come on the whole inhabited earth, to try them who dwell on the earth.” “The word of My endurance” is the word of the Lord’s suffering. The Lord today is still suffering rejection and persecution with His endurance. We are the joint partakers, not only of His kingdom, but also of His endurance (Rev. 1:9). Hence, His word to us today is the word of endurance. To keep the word of His endurance we must suffer His rejection and persecution.

“Trial” in this verse undoubtedly denotes the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21) “which is about to come on the whole inhabited earth,” as indicated by the fifth, sixth, and seventh trumpets with the seven bowls (Rev. 8:1-13; 9:1-21; 11:14-15; 15:1; 16:1-21). The Lord promises the recovered church that He will keep her “out of the hour of trial” (not just out of the trial, but out of the hour of trial) because she has kept the word of His endurance. This promise of the Lord, like His promise in Luke 21:36, indicates that the saints who have kept the word of the Lord’s endurance will be raptured before the great tribulation, implying that those who have not kept the word of His endurance will be left in the great tribulation.

B. The Lord’s coming quickly

In verse 11 the Lord tells the recovered church that He will come quickly. In this epistle the Lord brings the church in His recovery into the sensation of His coming because she loves Him. All the churches in the Lord’s recovery should love the Lord under the inspiration of His coming back. The Lord’s coming back quickly should be precious to us while we are testifying of Him in His recovery.

C. Crown

A crown has been given by the Lord to the recovered church. Being a reward from the Lord, this must be kept until He comes back.

D. To make him a pillar in God’s temple

In verse 12 the Lord says, “He who overcomes, I will make him a pillar in the temple of My God, and he shall by no means go out anymore.” In 2:17 the overcomer becomes a transformed stone for God’s building, but here the overcomer will be made a pillar built into the temple of God. Because he is built into God’s building, “he shall by no means go out anymore.” This promise will be fulfilled in the millennial kingdom as a prize to the overcomer. To overcome in the church in Philadelphia is not to get anything or to overcome other things; it is to keep what we have received in the Lord’s recovery to the end. If you do this, the Lord will make you a pillar in God’s temple. This reminds us of Jacob’s dream in Genesis 28. After Jacob had that dream, he set up the stone which he had used for a pillow to be a pillar. That pillar was for God’s building. The overcomers in Philadelphia will be pillars in God’s temple. The principle is exactly the same today. The Lord has set up a good number of stones to be pillars in His recovery. Praise the Lord that there are many pillars among us. Once a stone has been set as a pillar into the building, it can never be removed, for it has been built in. Some stay in the church for a short while or for several months and then go away. However, if you have been built into the temple as a pillar, you could not leave even if you wanted to. If you can still go out of the church, it means that you have never been built in.

E. To write upon Him

1. The name of God

In verse 12 the Lord also promises the overcomer, saying, “I will write upon him the name of My God and the name of the city of My God, the New Jerusalem which descends out of heaven from My God, and My new name.” Firstly, the Lord says that He will write on the overcomer the name of God. A name is a designation. Your name designates who you are. For the overcomer to bear the name of God means that God has been wrought into him. Only when God has been wrought into us are we worthy to bear His name. This does not mean that we become God; it means that God has been wrought into us and that we are one with Him. Therefore, the Lord gives us a designation — God. “God” is upon the overcomer, indicating that he has been saturated with God. When you see him, you see God.

2. The name of the city of God, the New Jerusalem

Secondly, the Lord promises to write upon the overcomer the name of the city of God, the New Jerusalem. For the overcomer to bear the name of the New Jerusalem means that he is a part of the New Jerusalem. This indicates that the coming New Jerusalem has been wrought into his being. Thus, the overcomer also bears the designation of the New Jerusalem. The Lord’s writing always corresponds to the facts. It would be ridiculous to write the word lion upon a monkey, or to write the word lamb upon a cat. When the Lord writes the names of God and the New Jerusalem upon us, it reveals that we are one with God and are a part of the New Jerusalem.

3. The Lord’s new name

Finally, the Lord promises to write upon the overcomer His new name. This new name will be according to our experiences. I cannot tell you what the Lord’s new name will be because it is according to our personal experiences of Him. In other words, what we experience of the Lord will become us. We experience God, and God becomes us. We experience the New Jerusalem, and that also becomes us. We experience the Lord in an intimate, personal way, and that becomes us. Therefore, the Lord will rightly designate us, writing upon us the name of God, the name of the New Jerusalem, and His new name. This will indicate that we have become a person who is one with God, who is a part of the New Jerusalem, and who has experienced the Lord Himself as the One who makes Himself us.

The name of God, the name of New Jerusalem, and the Lord’s new name written upon the overcomer indicate that the overcomer is possessed by God, by the New Jerusalem, and by the Lord; that God Himself, His city, the New Jerusalem, and the Lord Himself all belong to him; and that he is one with God, with the New Jerusalem, and with the Lord. The name of God means God Himself, the name of the New Jerusalem means the city itself, and the name of the Lord means the Lord Himself. To write the name of God, the name of the New Jerusalem, and the name of the Lord upon the overcomer indicate that what God is, the nature of the New Jerusalem, and the Person of the Lord have all been wrought into the overcomer. The mentioning of the New Jerusalem as a prize to the overcomer indicates that this promise will be fulfilled in the millennial kingdom. The New Jerusalem in the millennial kingdom will be a prize only to the overcoming saints, whereas the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and new earth will be the common portion of all the redeemed for eternity.

VI. The Spirit’s speaking

The recovered church also needs to take heed of the Spirit’s speaking. The more we love the Lord and the more we are in His recovery, the more we need the rich speaking of the intensified Spirit.

The Church in Laodicea — to Dine with the Lord and to Sit on His Throne

Now we come to the church in Laodicea, the church in degradation (Rev. 3:14-22). In Greek Laodicea means the opinion, the judgment, of the people or of the laymen. The church in Laodicea as a sign prefigures the degraded recovered church. Less than a century after the Lord recovered the proper church in the early part of the nineteenth century, some of the recovered churches (“assemblies”) became degraded. This degraded recovered church differs from the reformed church signified by the church in Sardis, and also differs from the proper recovered church signified by the church in Philadelphia. It will exist until the Lord comes back.

Some Christian teachers consider the church in Laodicea as the cold reformed church. Strictly speaking, this is not so. According to the context and according to history, the church in Laodicea must be a sign of the degraded recovered church. Approximately one hundred fifty years ago the recovered church began in England. According to what we have read, it was wonderful. It was a real recovery of the church life. However, it did not last very long. If you read the history of the Brethren and if you visit them today, you will see that many of the Brethren assemblies have become the church in Laodicea. As we shall see, although they are proud of their Bible knowledge, they are poor in the enjoyment of the riches of Christ and blind in spiritual things.

I. The speaker

A. The Amen

In 3:14 the Lord says, “These things says the Amen, the faithful and true Witness, the beginning of the creation of God.” To each of the seven churches the Lord refers to what He is and what He does respectively according to their situation and condition. Here, to the church in Laodicea, He refers to Himself as the Amen. In Greek amen means firm, steadfast, or trustworthy. The Lord is the firm, steadfast, and trustworthy One.

B. The faithful and true Witness

Because the Lord is the firm, steadfast, and trustworthy One, He is the faithful and true Witness. This indicates that the degraded church in Laodicea is not firm, steadfast, trustworthy, or faithful and true as the Lord’s witness.

C. The beginning of the creation of God

In verse 14 the Lord also refers to Himself as “the beginning of the creation of God.” This refers to the Lord as the origin or source of God’s creation, implying that the Lord is the unchanging and ever-existing source of God’s work. This indicates that the degraded recovered church is changing by leaving the Lord as the source.

II. The church’s condition

A. Neither cold nor hot — lukewarm

In verses 15 through 17 we see the condition of the church in Laodicea. In verses 15 and 16 the Lord says, “I know your works, that you are neither cold nor hot; I wish that you were cold or hot. So because you are lukewarm and neither hot nor cold, I am about to vomit you out of My mouth.” Once the recovered church becomes degraded, it is lukewarm — neither cold nor hot. This is the actual condition of so many Brethren assemblies today. This should be a warning to us. Once we become lukewarm, we are not fitting for the Lord’s move and shall be vomited out of His mouth.

B. Proud of being rich

In verse 17 the Lord says, “You say, I am rich and have become rich and have need of nothing.” The degraded recovered church (“assembly”) boasts of her riches (mainly in the knowledge of doctrines). She does not realize that she is poor in life, blind in sight, and naked in conduct. Therefore, as we shall see, she needs gold for her poverty, eyesalve for her blindness, and white garments for her nakedness, as mentioned in the following verse.

The most outstanding feature of those in the degraded assemblies is their pride. They think they know everything. Undoubtedly, they have much knowledge in doctrine. They do know the Bible better than those in the denominations. Although, in a sense, they know the Bible, what they have is mere knowledge. Because they have this knowledge, they consider themselves rich. But the Lord says that they actually are poor. They are not poor in knowledge, but they are poor in the riches of Christ. They have the knowledge concerning Christ, but they are poor in the enjoyment of the riches of Christ. Shortly after coming to this country, I was invited to speak in three Brethren assemblies. After speaking there and hearing what they said in response, I was completely convinced of the truth of the Lord’s word to the church in Laodicea. If you were to stay with them for a short while, you would sense that they are proud of their knowledge. In their conversation they condemn the ignorance of others, thinking that they know everything. However, after staying with them, you would realize the poverty among them. They simply do not realize the riches of Christ or even talk about them.

C. Wretched

In the eyes of the Lord, the degraded assemblies are wretched because they are proud of being rich in the vain knowledge of doctrines, but are sorely poor in the experience of the riches of Christ.

D. Miserable

The degraded recovered church is also miserable because she is naked, blind, and full of shame and darkness.

E. Poor

The proud degraded church is poor in the experience of Christ and in the spiritual reality of God’s economy. She mostly cares for vain knowledge, but scarcely cares for the living experiences of Christ. This is real poverty, the poverty that makes her wretched and miserable.

F. Blind

In the eyes of the Lord, the church in Laodicea is not only poor in the riches of Christ, but also blind in genuine spiritual things. She does not have true spiritual insight. Although she has some amount of knowledge about spiritual things, she has no insight.

G. Naked

We Christians have all received Christ as our objective righteousness to cover us like a robe. This is for our justification before God. After being justified in Christ, we need to live by Christ and to live out Christ, that He may be our subjective righteousness as another splendid robe to cover our daily walk. Due to the lack of the subjective experience of Christ, the degraded recovered church is naked in the eyes of the Lord. The vain knowledge of doctrines vanishes under the flaming eyes of the Lord, leaving those who hold them nakedly exposed. Only the experienced Christ can be our covering under His judging eyes.

H. About to be vomited out of the Lord’s Mouth

In verse 16 the Lord says, “Because you are lukewarm and neither hot nor cold, I am about to vomit you out of My mouth.” When the recovered church becomes degraded, she is in danger, unless she repents to be hot in seeking the rich experiences of the Lord, of being vomited out of the Lord’s mouth. To be vomited out of the Lord’s mouth is to lose the enjoyment of all that the Lord is to His church.

I. The Lord standing at the door and knocking

In verse 20 the Lord says, “Behold, I stand at the door and knock.” “The door” is not the door of individuals, but the door of the church. The church in Laodicea has knowledge, but she does not have the presence of the Lord. The Lord as the Head of the church is standing outside the degraded church, knocking at her door. The degraded recovered church must realize this!

III. The Lord’s counsel

In verse 18 we see the Lord’s counsel to the church in Laodicea: “I counsel you to buy from Me gold refined by fire that you may be rich, and white garments that you may be clothed and that the shame of your nakedness may not be manifested, and eyesalve to anoint your eyes that you may see.” To “buy” requires the paying of a price. The degraded recovered church needs to pay a price for the gold, white garments, and eyesalve, which she desperately needs. After having contact with the Brethren assemblies, I realized that probably no one among them understands what it means to pay a price. Perhaps they have never heard that they must pay some price in order to experience the riches of Christ. They know the knowledge and doctrine, but they do not know how to pay the price. They know how to learn, but they do not know how to buy. They know certain “truths,” but they do not know the cost of experiencing the riches of Christ.

A. To buy from the Lord gold refined by fire

Firstly, the Lord counsels the church in Laodicea to buy “gold refined by fire.” In the Bible, our working faith (Gal. 5:6) is likened to gold (1 Pet. 1:7), and the divine nature of God, which is the divinity of Christ, is also typified by gold (Exo. 25:11). We partake of the divine nature of God by faith (2 Pet. 1:1, 4-5). The degraded recovered church has the knowledge of the doctrines concerning Christ, but not much living faith to partake of the divine element of Christ. She needs to pay the price to gain the golden faith through the fiery trials that she may participate in the real “gold,” which is Christ Himself as the life element to His Body. Thus, she may become a pure golden lampstand (Rev. 1:20) for the building of the golden New Jerusalem (Rev. 21:18).

If we have experience, we shall realize that all three things which the Lord counsels the church in Laodicea to buy — gold, white garments, and eyesalve — are just the Lord Himself. As we have seen, in typology, or in biblical figure, gold signifies two things: God’s divine nature and the living faith by which we appreciate and appropriate the divine nature. These two things are combined. If we do not have the living faith to appreciate and apply the divine nature, it cannot be ours. The divine nature can only become our enjoyment through our living faith. Christ is the embodiment of the divine nature, and He is also our living faith. If we have faith, then we can participate in the divine nature. This means that we must have Christ. We must pay the cost and tell the Lord, saying, “Lord, I have much knowledge of the Bible truths, but I admit that I don’t have much of You. Lord, I would rather have You than mere knowledge or vain teachings. Lord, You are the real gold, the embodiment of the divine nature. In order to appreciate and apply this divine nature, I need living faith. Yet, Lord, I don’t have this living faith, but I look unto You. Lord, be my living faith. I want to live by You as my faith, the faith of the Son of God” (Gal. 2:20). If you speak to the Lord in this way, He will immediately say, “All right, if you would gain Me, you must pay the price. There is a certain thing that I want you to drop because it is a hindrance and a frustration from My becoming your enjoyment.” Dropping these things is the paying of the price. Many of us have experienced the Lord in this way. Often the Lord has said, “I am here. Do you want Me, or do you want that thing? If you want to keep that thing, then I shall stay away. Your hands are full of many things. You must drop them, empty your hands, and then grasp Me. Then you will have Me as your enjoyment.” Only when we pay the price can we gain Christ.

Consider the words of the apostle Paul in Philippians 3:8: “But surely I count also all things to be loss on account of the excellency of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord, on account of whom I have suffered the loss of all things and count them refuse that I may gain Christ.” For Paul, there remained nothing except Christ. He spent everything for Christ, paying the full price. Whatever Paul had, he spent it to gain Christ. Today, we must follow this spirit to pay any price, even the cost of our lives, in order to gain Christ.

We can never separate living faith from the divine nature. Although this is difficult to explain doctrinally, we know experientially that when we have the living faith, we enjoy the divine nature. And when we are in the divine nature, we surely have this living faith. Hence, these two things are combined and are both signified by gold. The church in Laodicea needs this gold — the divine nature applied, appropriated, by the living faith which is Christ Himself. If we would gain this, we must pay the price.

B. To buy from the Lord white garments

Secondly, the Lord counseled the church in Laodicea to buy “white garments” that they “may be clothed and that the shame” of their “nakedness may not be manifested.” In figure, garments signify conduct. “White garments” here refer to conduct approvable to the Lord, which is the Lord Himself lived out of the church, and which is required by the degraded recovered church to cover her nakedness. We pointed out in message fourteen that these white garments are not Christ as our objective righteousness for justification. Rather, the white garments are Christ as our subjective righteousness, Christ lived out of our being. The Christ who is lived out of us will be our second garment for us to be approved by the Lord. This is not for salvation but for being chosen. We all need this second garment. When we have living faith and participate in the divine nature, this divine nature will eventually come out of us to be our living. This living is Christ lived out of our being, and this is the second garment which gives us the standing and the qualification to be approved by Christ. This garment will cover our nakedness. Yes, we all have been justified and have been covered by the first garment, the best robe put on the prodigal son in Luke 15. But after being justified, we must love the Lord, be on fire, and be absolutely for the Lord. If we are this kind of Christian, then we shall have the living faith to participate in the rich, divine nature, which will become the Christ lived out of our being as the second garment to cover our nakedness.

If, after being justified, you do not love the Lord and live by, for, and with Him, you are naked. It is difficult to explain this doctrinally, but experientially we all may realize that a brother who does not love the Lord or live by the Lord is shameful and is naked. He does not have the lovely Christ as his covering. He believes in Christ and he belongs to Christ, but since he neither loves Him nor lives by Him, he is naked in both the eyes of the Lord and in the eyes of other believers. He does not have Christ as his beautiful covering. We must pay the price for this second garment, the Christ lived out of our being. This is the subjective Christ, the very Christ experienced by us in a subjective way. Do not try to understand this by the exercise of your mentality. Check this word with your experience. Although this is foreign to your mentality, it is more than familiar to your spirit and to your experience. According to your experience, you can testify that, on the one hand, you may have the assurance that you are justified, but, on the other hand, have the sense that you are naked. Undoubtedly, as a child of God, you have been justified, redeemed, saved, and regenerated, and you are a member of Christ. But, on the other hand, you sense that you are naked, not having Christ lived out of you to be your beautiful covering. Inwardly, you condemn yourself for this. If you check this word with your experience, you will see that it is true. Thus, we all must pay the price, saying to the Lord, “Lord, whatever the cost, I’ll pay the price to have You live out of my being. Lord, I want to have You as my living. I don’t want to behave myself, correct myself, or improve myself. Lord, I like to have You lived out of me. Day by day, I want You to live out of my being to be my outward living. Lord, be not only my inward life but also my outward living.” If you pray this way to the Lord, He will become your outward covering, the second garment for you to be approved and chosen by Him. There is no need to wait for the coming day. Even today you may have the assurance that you have been approved and chosen. Therefore, when that day comes, He will surely say, “Well done! Come with Me to enjoy your portion and to fight with Me against the army of the Antichrist.”

C. To buy from the Lord the eyesalve

Thirdly, the Lord counsels the church in Laodicea to buy from Him eyesalve to anoint their eyes that they may see. The “eyesalve” needed to “anoint” their eyes must refer to the anointing Spirit (1 John 2:27), who is also the Lord Himself as the life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45). Because she has been distracted by the dead knowledge of letters, the degraded recovered church also needs this kind of eyesalve for her blindness. For all three items the Lord counsels her to buy, she must pay the price. We have pointed out that the eyesalve is the anointing Spirit. Spiritual insight is always related to the Spirit. We need more Spirit, not more knowledge. We do not need many doctrines — we need more Spirit to anoint our eyes and the depths of our inner being that we may have insight to see things from within. With this eyesalve, this anointing, we may have both foresight and deep insight to see things thoroughly. Then we shall say, “Lord Jesus, because I now see what a treasure You are, I am ready to pay any price.” Suppose the cost of an item in a department store is one thousand dollars. If this item is a valuable diamond worth five thousand dollars, you would not think that the price is too high. Rather, you would think that it is cheap. Why are so many Christians unwilling to pay the price for Christ? It is because they do not see what a treasure Christ is. They do not see the preciousness, the worth, and the value of Christ. But once our eyes have been anointed by the divine, spiritual eyesalve, we shall say, “It is worthwhile for me to pay any price for Christ. The price is too low. My self, my future, and my life are all worth nothing. I actually pay nothing to gain Christ who is everything.” If we would see this, we need eyesalve.

Now we realize that the gold, the garment, and the eyesalve are all Christ. Christ is everything. Our need today is Christ. Yes, in His recovery the Lord has given us a great deal of light. Our intention, however, is not to give knowledge to people. Our intention in these messages is to help the Lord’s people to be enlightened that they might see the value, worth, and preciousness of Christ and, by having this insight, they might be willing to pay any price to gain Him. It is worthwhile for me to pay the cost of my family, my future, my destiny, and my whole life for Christ. If I would pay all this, the price is still too cheap. Paul said that all the things he counted loss for Christ were just dung, dog food (Phil. 3:8). In the church life in the Lord’s recovery we are not for doctrine or merely for the so-called truths. We are here for the rich Christ. In all these messages we are not dispensing vain doctrines. The goal of these messages is to minister some ointment that people’s eyes may be anointed to see the preciousness of Christ and be attracted to Him. The degraded church does not need doctrine; she needs eyesalve. She needs revelation, vision, and great grace.

IV. The Lord’s rebuke and discipline

In verse 19 the Lord said, “As many as I love I rebuke and discipline.” If she is willing to take it, the Lord’s rebuke in love will be an eyeopener to the degraded church. But her pride may frustrate her from receiving it. When we become lukewarm and feel rebuked by the Lord, we need to look to Him for His mercy that we may be willing to be humble to receive His rebuke in love. This may bring the proper remedy to the degraded church.

Discipline is a further step taken by the Lord to deal with His degraded church after He has rebuked her. If she is willing to receive the Lord’s rebuke, He may not need to exercise His discipline over her. The Lord’s discipline is exercised over her in love.

V. The Lord’s charge

In verse 19 the Lord charged the church in Laodicea, saying, “Be zealous therefore, and repent.” Dead knowledge has made the degraded church lukewarm. She needs to become crazily burning by dropping the deadening and cooling knowledge, and she even needs to break the bondage of her doctrinal forms. She needs to be boiling rather than to be dead right according to dead doctrine. She needs to love the Lord and pay any price to gain Him, even at the cost of sacrificing the “doctrines.” A lukewarm church needs to be hot, to be burning at any cost. She needs to repent of her lukewarmness, not to be proud of her knowledge any longer. She has been appreciating her dead knowledge too much. She needs to depreciate all her knowledge and repent of being satisfied with the vanity of knowledge and not with the reality of Christ.

VI. The Lord’s promise to the overcomer

In verses 20 and 21 we see the Lord’s promise to the overcomer: “Behold, I stand at the door and knock; if anyone hears My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and dine with him and he with Me. He who overcomes, to him I will give to sit with Me on My throne, as I also overcame and sat down with My Father on His throne.” To overcome in these seven epistles does not mean to overcome our weaknesses and besetting sins; it means to overcome the fallen condition of the deviant churches. To overcome in the epistle to Laodicea means to overcome the lukewarmness and pride of the degraded recovered church, to buy the needed items, and to open the door for the Lord to come in.

A. The Lord’s coming in

In verse 20 the Lord said that if anyone hears His voice and opens the door, He will come in to him. As we have pointed out, the Lord is standing outside the degraded church, knocking at her door. The door is the door of the church, not of individuals, but the door is opened by individual believers. The Lord is dealing with the whole church, but the acceptance of the Lord’s dealing must be a personal matter. The Lord’s dealing is objective, but the believers’ acceptance must be subjective. If we hear the Lord’s voice to the church and personally open the door, the Lord will come in to us, and His presence will be our portion.

B. To dine with the Lord

In verse 20 the Lord also said that, after He comes in to him who opens the door, He will dine with him and he with Him. According to the Greek, the word dine signifies the principal meal of the day at evening. To dine is not merely to eat one item of food, but to partake of the riches of a meal. This may imply the fulfillment of the type of the children of Israel eating the rich produce of the good land of Canaan (Josh. 5:10-12). The dining promised here is not only for the future but also for today. If you are an overcomer, when the Lord comes in the kingdom, you will have the special privilege of eating with Him. Before that day, however, you may enjoy His dining with you.

Many Christians borrow verse 20 for preaching the gospel in an inadequate way. They tell the sinners that Christ is knocking at the door of their heart and that if they open the door, He will come in. This is all they say. Have you ever heard a message telling you that, if you open the door, Christ will come in to you and dine with you?

If we have an overall view of the seven epistles in Revelation 2 and 3, we shall see that the Lord exalts the eating of Himself, the taking in of Himself as our life supply, that we may grow, be transformed, and be the same as He is. This is absolutely a matter of eating Jesus as the tree of life, the manna, and as the biggest meal of the day. As the Lord exalts the eating of Himself, He simultaneously repudiates four kinds of teaching: the teaching of Balaam (Rev. 2:14), the teaching of the Nicolaitans (Rev. 2:15), the teaching of Jezebel (Rev. 2:20), and the teaching of the depths of Satan (Rev. 2:24). If you do not have the ability to discern counterfeit currency from genuine currency, it is better not to accept any currency at all; rather, accept only genuine gold. Likewise, it is better not to accept teachings, but only to take the living Christ.

In the Old Testament, we see three stages of the eating of Christ: the tree of life in the garden, the manna in the wilderness, and the rich produce of the good land. We have been in these stages. We were created in the garden. Then, due to the fall, we found ourselves in Egypt. After we were saved, we made our exodus out of the world and were on our way to meet the Lord. As we were journeying to meet the Lord, we were in the wilderness where there was manna. Recall that the promise of the hidden manna is given to the overcomers in the worldly church, indicating that Pergamos had returned to Egypt. Manna was not available in Egypt; it was only in the wilderness, and the hidden manna was only found within the Holy of Holies. The church in Pergamos became a worldly church, a church in Egypt where there was no manna. If we would eat manna, whether open or hidden manna, we must come out of Egypt. We must escape from that place where Satan dwells and where his throne is and go out into the wilderness where we may firstly eat the open manna and then come forward into the Holy of Holies and dive into the ark to eat the hidden manna. It seems that eventually the seven epistles bring us into the good land, which is Christ. Here, in the good land, we feast on Christ. During the yearly feasts, the children of Israel feasted with God and God feasted with them. This may be a type of the promise to the overcomer in Laodicea. The Lord’s promise to dine with whomever opened to Him may imply the thought of enjoying the rich produce of the good land of Canaan during the annual feasts. Hence, the epistle to the church in Ephesus refers to the eating of the tree of life, the epistle to the church in Pergamos points to the eating of the hidden manna outside of the world, and the epistle to the church in Laodicea alludes to the enjoyment of the rich produce of the good land of Canaan at the time of the yearly feasts. Whenever the Israelites had a feast, they ate with God, offering what they were eating to God and letting God eat with them. In like manner, the Lord says that He will dine with us and that we shall dine with Him. If we have this overview, then we shall know what we must emphasize today. We are not for teachings — we are for the full enjoyment of Christ as the tree of life, as the manna, and as the rich produce of the good land.

C. To sit with the Lord on His throne

In verse 21 the Lord said, “He who overcomes, to him I will give to sit with Me on My throne, as I also overcame and sat down with My Father on His throne.” To sit with the Lord on His throne will be a prize to the overcomer that he may participate in the Lord’s authority in the coming millennial kingdom. This means that the overcomers will be co-kings with Christ ruling over the whole earth. Once again I say that, strictly speaking, all the promises in these seven epistles concern the coming kingdom. Any negative word regarding loss or suffering refers to a loss during the coming kingdom, and any positive word regarding gain or enjoyment refers to the enjoyment of Christ as our special portion during the age of the kingdom. We must have the insight to understand these promises in a proper way. Nevertheless, in principle, these promises may also be applied today and we may pre-taste them now. There is no need to wait until we enter into the kingdom age to enjoy all these special portions. Today in the church life we are privileged to enjoy the kingdom. Praise the Lord for the church life!

VII. The Spirit’s speaking

The lukewarm church is filled with cooling knowledge, but lacks the burning Spirit. She desperately needs the speaking of the living Spirit; she no longer needs dead knowledge. If she forgets all her dead knowledge and listens to the speaking of the living Spirit, she will be delivered from her degraded condition.

As we have seen, the seven churches not only signify prophetically the progress of the church in seven ages, but also symbolize the seven kinds of churches in church history: the initial church, the suffering church, the worldly church, the apostate church, the reformed church, the recovered church, and the degraded recovered church. The initial church had its continuation in the suffering church; the suffering church turned into the worldly church; and the worldly church became the apostate church. Hence, the first four churches eventually issued in one kind of church, that is, the apostate church, the Roman Catholic Church. Then, as a reaction to the apostate church, the reformed church came into existence as another kind of church, a church not fully recovered. Following this, the recovered church was raised up as a full recovery of the proper church life. This may be considered the third kind of church. By the degradation of the recovered church, the degraded recovered church came into being. This may be counted as the fourth kind of church. All these four kinds of churches will remain until the Lord comes back. Undoubtedly, only the recovered church can fulfill God’s eternal purpose, and only she is what the Lord is after. We must take the Lord’s choice.

The Scene in Heaven After Christ's Ascension

All Christians know that Christ has ascended into heaven and that He is in heaven today. However, not many are familiar with the scene in heaven after Christ's ascension. This scene is quite particular, and we need to see it very clearly.

Revelation 4:1 says, "After these things I saw, and behold, a door opened in heaven, and the first voice which I heard was like a trumpet speaking with me, saying. Come up here, and I will show you what must take place after these things." God's plan is hidden in heaven. When God finds a man on earth after His heart, heaven is opened to him. It was opened to Jacob (Gen. 28:12-17), to Ezekiel (Ezek. 1:1), to Jesus (Matt. 3:16), to Stephen (Acts 7:56), and to Peter (Acts 10:11). Here, and in Rev. 19:11, it is opened to John, the writer of this book, and it will be opened to all believers in the Lord in eternity (John 1:51).

I. A throne in heaven

Verse 2 says, "Immediately I was in spirit; and behold, there was a throne set in heaven." In heaven, there is firstly a throne, and the book of Revelation is focused upon it. Beginning with chapter four, this book unveils God's universal administration. The throne of God in Revelation is the center of God's administration. While the throne in the Epistles is the throne of grace from which we receive mercy and find grace (Heb. 4:16), the throne here is the throne of judgment from which the world receives judgment. This is God's throne in heaven. The whole universe, especially the earth, is under this throne. Whatever Satan does in the air and whatever man does on earth is under God's throne in heaven. Today, man may do anything he likes, but the throne of God in heaven is still the authority over all men and all things. No one can do anything and nothing can happen outside of the rule of God's throne. Apparently, this throne is invisible and is not realized by man, but actually it is behind the scene ruling over everyone and everything. In God's time and for the fulfillment of God's purpose, the appropriate judgment always comes out of this throne to mankind and upon the things transpiring on earth. In the book of Revelation, the consummate issue comes from the completion of the execution of God's judgment. This judgment proceeds from the throne and clears up the confusion both in heaven and on earth caused by Satan's rebellion and man's fall.

A. A rainbow around the throne in appearance of an emerald

In verse 3 we see that there is "a rainbow around the throne like an emerald in appearance." The rainbow is a sign of God's covenant with man and living creatures that He will not destroy them again with the flood (Gen. 9:8-17). In this book, God will judge the earth with all its inhabitants. The rainbow around His throne signifies that God is the covenanting God, the faithful God, who will keep His covenant while executing His judgment upon the earth in that He will not judge mankind again with a flood nor destroy all mankind, but will keep some to be the nations of the earth for His glory (21:24, 26). This rainbow indicates that God is faithful in His administration toward mankind. In this chapter, God is about to judge mankind, but in exercising His judgment, He will remember His covenant with Noah. He is the judging God and He is also the covenant-keeping God.

This rainbow is "like an emerald in appearance." An emerald is a precious stone having a grass green color, which signifies the lives on earth. This indicates that while God executes His judgment upon the earth, He will still remember His covenant and spare some of the lives on earth as indicated in Genesis 9:11. An emerald, being a precious stone, is solid. God's reminder to keep His covenant is solid. There is this solid reminder around the throne.

B. Out of the throne coming forth lightnings, voices, and thunders

In verse 5 we are told that "out of the throne come lightnings and voices and thunders." All these signify God's wrath in His judgment. In the Epistles, out of the throne of grace come the mercy and grace of God for anyone who approaches Him through the redeeming blood of Christ. But here, out of the throne of judgment come forth lightnings, voices, and thunders as warnings to the sinful world. In the book of Revelation, after all God's judgments have been executed, the throne of God will be the throne of eternal life supply, out of which will proceed the river of water of life with the tree of life growing in it. All the believers who are participating in God's mercy and grace today by approaching God's throne of grace will enjoy the river of life and the tree of life out of God's throne as their life supply for eternity, while the unbelievers, who will be judged by God's throne of judgment, will have no share in the eternal enjoyment issuing out of God's eternal throne.

C. Seven lamps of fire burning before the throne

Verse 5 also tells us that "seven lamps of fire are burning before the throne, which are the seven Spirits of God." This indicates that God will touch the earth by the seven lamps, by His seven Spirits which are burning, shining, observing, searching, and judging. The seven lamps here refer to the seven lamps of the lampstand in Exodus 25:37 and the seven lamps of the lampstand in Zech. 4:2. The seven lamps of fire which are the seven Spirits of God signify the enlightening and searching of the sevenfold intensified Spirit of God. In Exo. 25 and Zech. 4, the seven lamps, signifying the enlightening of the Spirit of God in God's move, are for God's building, either for the tabernacle or the building of the temple. Here the seven lamps are for God's judgment, which will issue also in God's building — the building of the New Jerusalem. While God executes His judgment, His sevenfold intensified Spirit will carry out God's eternal building by searching, enlightening, judging, and infusing. This is fully developed in the following chapters. The issue is the consummation of the holy city, New Jerusalem.

D. A glassy sea before the throne

Verse 6 says, "And before the throne there was as it were a glassy sea like crystal." The glassy sea is a collector and container of everything judged by God. This sea is not of water, but of fire (Rev. 15:2). Since the deluge, God, in accordance with His promise not to judge the earth and living creatures again with water (Gen. 9:15), always exercises His judgment upon man with fire (Gen. 19:24; Lev. 10:2; Num. 11:1; 16:35; Dan. 7:11; Rev. 14:11; 18:8; 19:20; 20:9-10; 21:8). God's throne of judgment is like the fiery flame out of which a fiery stream issues (Dan. 7:9-10). The flame of God's judging fire sweeps all negative things in the entire universe into this glassy sea, which eventually becomes the lake of fire (Rev. 20:14). The glassy sea, being the aggregate of all God's fiery judgment, is "like crystal," signifying that every negative thing under God's judgment is crystal clear. Whatever is judged and kept in the glassy sea is fully exposed; nothing is hidden. In this chapter we have the rainbow around the throne of God, signifying that God will keep His promise in Gen. 9:8-17, and we also have the glassy sea of fire, indicating that God will still judge all negative things with fire.

II. God sitting on the throne

A. In appearance of a jasper stone and a sardius

When John saw the throne set in heaven, he saw "One sitting upon the throne, and He who was sitting was like in appearance to a jasper stone and a sardius, and there was a rainbow around the throne like an emerald in appearance." God on the throne has the appearance of a jasper stone. According to Rev. 21:11, jasper is "a most precious stone...clear as crystal." Its color must be dark green, which signifies life in its richness. Jasper here, as 21:11 indicates, signifies God's communicable glory in His rich life (John 17:22, John 17:2). It is the appearance of God, which will also be the appearance of the holy city, New Jerusalem (21:11). The city's wall and first foundation are built with it (Rev. 21:18-19). In the Bible green signifies life. Thus, the color of jasper indicates that the God who is sitting on the throne is the very God of life. God's color firstly is green, testifying that He is the source of life.

God on the throne is also in the appearance of a sardius stone. Sardius is a most precious stone, red in color, which signifies redemption. Today, God is not only the God of life, but also the God of redemption. While jasper indicates God as the God of glory in His rich life, sardius signifies God as the God of redemption. Because we, His created ones, fell, He came in to redeem through the blood of Christ. Therefore, He has two colors — the color of life and the color of redemption. He is the life-giving God and also the redeeming God. On the breastplate of the high priest in the Old Testament, the first stone was sardius and the last jasper (Exo. 28:17, 20). This signifies that God's redeemed people have their beginning in God's redemption and their consummation in God's glory of life.

B. On his right hand a scroll

According to 5:1, in the hand of Him who sits upon the throne there was a scroll. This life-giving and redeeming God has a mystery which is held in His hand. This mystery concerns the destiny of the universe and is sealed with seven seals. The mystery, the secret, of the universe is held by the God of life and redemption.

III. Twenty-four elders sitting on twenty-four thrones around the throne

Verse 4 says, “And around the throne were twenty-four thrones, and on the thrones twenty-four elders sitting, clothed in white garments, and golden crowns on their heads.” The elders in this verse are not the elders of the church, but the elders of the angels, because here, before the Lord’s second coming, they are sitting on thrones already (cf. Matt. 19:28; Rev. 20:4). In God’s creation, angels are the most ancient ones. In the Bible there are different types of elders: the elders of the Israelites, the elders of the churches, and, as here, the elders of the angels. The elders of the angels are the elders of the whole creation of God. That they sit on thrones with golden crowns on their heads indicates that they must be the rulers of the universe until the millennial kingdom, when the authority to rule the earth will be given to the overcoming saints (Heb. 2:5-9; Rev. 2:26-27; 20:4). The white garments with which they are clothed reveal that these angelic elders are sinless, having no need of the washing by the blood of the Lamb as do the redeemed saints (Rev. 7:14).

These twenty-four elders are clothed in white garments and have golden crowns on their heads. That they are clothed in white garments and have “a harp and golden bowls full of incense” (5:8) indicates that now they are also priests before God, whereas, in the millennial kingdom, the reigning overcomers will be the priests of God and of Christ (20:6). These twenty-four angels must be the universal priests. Their golden crowns indicate that they are also ruling ones. They are priests serving God and kings reigning over His creation. Before the creation of man, God had the leading angels as His priests and ruling instruments. According to Ezekiel 28, before Satan fell, he was such a one. He was God’s priest and also a king. Even when the Devil, Satan, tempted the Lord Jesus, showing Him “all the kingdoms of the inhabited earth in a moment of time,” he said, “To You I will give all this authority and their glory, because to me it has been delivered, and to whomsoever I want I give it” (Luke 4:5-6). The world was given him before the Adamic age. Thus, there was an age during which God gave authority to Satan, making him a king to reign over that universe. Likewise, these twenty-four elders were God’s priests and kings.

The number of the angelic elders, twenty-four, is composed of two times twelve. Twelve is the number of the completion of God’s administration (Matt. 19:28). David divided both the priests and the Levites into twenty-four groups (1 Chron. 24 and 1 Chron. 25) to carry out God’s administrative service. The number twenty-four indicates that, before the church is installed to replace them, the angelic elders are the ones who carry out God’s administration. Twelve times two signifies strengthening by doubling, indicating that the divine administration carried out by the angelic elders is strong.

IV. Four living creatures in the midst of and around the throne

In the Bible, the number of the living creatures, four, always stands for the four ends that cover the whole universe or the whole earth. In Gen. 2:10 the one river became four heads to reach the entire earth. In Jer. 49:36 are the four quarters of heaven, and in Isa. 11:12; Rev. 7:1 and Rev. 20:8 are the four corners of the earth. Hence, the number of the living creatures reveals that they represent all the creatures on earth and in heaven except the angels, who are represented by the twenty-four elders.

A. Full of eyes in front, behind, and within

Verse 6 says that “in the midst of the throne and around the throne” there were “four living creatures full of eyes in front and behind.” According to verse 8, they are also “full of eyes around and within.” The most striking feature of the four living creatures is their eyes. They are full of eyes in front, behind, and within, and they can see in any direction without turning. Eyes are for living things to receive light and vision. That the four living creatures are full of eyes indicates that they are absolutely not opaque, but are crystal clear on every side and in every aspect. Christians should be like that, full of eyes. When we are full of eyes, we are transparent. If a person has no eyes, he is completely opaque. Our eyes make us transparent. If we had hundreds of eyes over our body, both within and without, our whole being would be transparent. In the presence of God, we, the redeemed people, should be like this.

B. Having each six wings

Verse 8 says, “And the four living creatures, each one of them having six wings.” In appearance, the four living creatures resemble the cherubim in Ezek. 1:5-10 and Ezek. 10:14-15. According to their six wings, they are like the seraphim in Isa. 6:2. (The cherubim in Exo. 25:20 and 1 Kings 6:27 have two wings, and the cherubim in Ezekiel 1:6 have four wings.) They must be a combination of the cherubim and the seraphim. As the seraphim, they are for God’s holiness (Isa. 6:3), referring to God’s nature, and as the cherubim, they are for God’s glory (Ezek. 10:18-19; Heb. 9:5), referring to God’s expression. Hence, they stand for God’s nature and expression.

C. In appearance of a lion, a calf, a man, and a flying eagle

Verse 7 says, “And the first living creature was like a lion, and the second living creature like a calf, and the third living creature having the face like that of man, and the fourth living creature like a flying eagle.” Around the throne of God, the twenty-four elders represent all the angels, whereas the four living creatures represent all other living creatures. The first living creature, like a lion, represents the beasts; the second, like a calf, represents the cattle; the third, like a man, represents mankind; and the fourth, like an eagle, represents the fowl. Of the six categories of living things created by God (Gen. 1:20-28), two are not represented here — the creeping things on earth and the living things in the water. The head of the creeping things is the serpent, a symbol of God’s enemy, Satan, who, having been cast into the lake of fire, will have no place in the new heaven and the new earth; and the living things in the water are in the water of God’s judgment which will no longer be in the new heaven and the new earth (21:1). Hence, these two categories are not represented before God for eternity.

Among the four living creatures, the calf is clean, but the lion and the eagle are unclean (Lev. 11:3-8, 13-19). Having been redeemed, they have all become clean (Acts 10:11-16). Among them, the calf and the man are meek and gentle, but the lion and the eagle are wild and fierce. Through redemption, they can dwell together (Isa. 11:6-9). Christ’s redemption is not only for man but for “all things” (Col. 1:20), because He died on behalf of “everything” (Heb. 2:9).

V. The worship of God

In Rev. 4:8-11 we see the worship of God. Here we do not yet have the worship of the Lamb, for the Lamb does not appear until the next chapter. This chapter only presents the scene into which Christ ascended. The worship of God here is by the four living creatures representing all the creatures (vv. 8-9) and by the twenty-four elders representing all the angels (vv. 10-11). In this scene, all the creatures are worshipping God. In verse 8 the living creatures say, “Holy, holy, holy, Lord God the Almighty, who was, and who is, and who is coming.” The mention of “holy” three times as in Isaiah 6:3 implies the thought of God being triune. Also, the mention of God’s existence with three tenses implies the thought of His being triune. The praises of both the four living creatures (v. 9) and the twenty-four elders (v. 11) are composed of three things, implying that they are praising the Triune God. The first two things, “glory and honor,” are the same in both places, but the last one is different. In the praises of the four living creatures, the last one is “thanks,” because they are redeemed and are grateful for the redemption of God’s grace, whereas, in the praises of the twenty-four elders, the last one is “power,” because, as the rulers of the universe and not the redeemed creatures, they appreciate the power of God by which they rule.

In verse 11 the twenty-four elders say, “You are worthy, our Lord and God, to receive the glory and the honor and the power, for You have created all things, and because of Your will they were and have been created.” God is a God of purpose, having a will of His own pleasure. He created all things for His will that He might accomplish and fulfill His purpose. This book, unveiling God’s universal administration, shows us the purpose of God. Hence, in the praise of the twenty-four elders concerning His creation, His creation is related to His will.

As the ones who carry out God’s administration in the universe, the twenty-four angelic elders speak out in their praises the will of God’s creation. People can easily realize the creation of God, but they scarcely know the will, the purpose, of God’s creation. The praise of the angelic elders is an introduction to the contents of this book, which unveil the will, the purpose, of God’s creation — to have an eternal habitation for God’s satisfaction and expression. This is the holy city, New Jerusalem. In the New Jerusalem, God’s will in creation will be completely revealed and fulfilled. God will be fully satisfied and wholly expressed in and through the New Jerusalem. This is God’s will in His creation and it is the goal of the book of Revelation. The praise of the angelic elders points us to this, and Revelation proceeds on toward this and eventually brings us to this, the ultimate consummation of God’s will in His creation.

The Worthy Lion-Lamb

In chapter four we see the scene in heaven after Christ's ascension. The throne of God is the center of the scene in chapter four, and God is sitting on the throne ready to execute His universal administration for the fulfillment of His eternal purpose. In chapter five we have the same scene after Christ ascended there. As we shall see in this message, the center of this scene is the worthy Lion-Lamb.

I. The secrecy of God's administration

Revelation 5:1 says, "And I saw on the right hand of Him who sits upon the throne a scroll, written within and on the back, sealed with seven seals." God's administration is a secret, a mystery. Throughout the centuries, many wise men have earnestly tried to learn what the secret of this universe is. Because they did not have the revelation, they failed. In the book of Revelation, the last book of the Bible, we have an unveiling of God's economy.

In 5:1 the One sitting on the throne has a scroll in His hand sealed with seven seals. These seven seals are actually the contents of the scroll and the contents of the book of Revelation, for this book is the opening, the unveiling, of the seven seals. The scroll itself must be the new covenant, the grand title deed enacted with the blood of the Lamb. The new covenant is a scroll covering the redemption of the church, Israel, the world, and the universe. The book of Revelation is a record of God's thought concerning the church, Israel, the world, and the universe. When Christ died on the cross, He tasted death not only for man, but for everything (Heb. 2:9). Here we see the secrecy of God's administration in the universe. While the New Testament was enacted by the death of Christ, it has been a mystery to mankind. The new covenant is the secret of the universe and the content of the book of Revelation. As we read Revelation, we must realize that in vision after vision we are seeing what is included in this new covenant, what is contained in this secret and sealed scroll.

Now, after Christ's ascension, there should no longer be a secret, for it has been unsealed by Christ's death, resurrection, and ascension. Before His death, there was a mystery that no man knew anything about. But by His death, resurrection, and ascension, He has fulfilled all of God's requirements. Thus, as we shall see, He has opened the mystery and revealed it to John, charging him to commit it to writing. Therefore, this book is just the opened secret, or scroll, in God's hand. It is no longer a secret — it is an open mystery. Now, as we are reading the book of Revelation, we are reading the contents of the scroll that has been unsealed by the ascended Christ. This is a great matter, and few Christians are aware of it. Most Christians have the book of Revelation, but not many have the unsealed scroll, because they do not realize that Revelation is the unsealed scroll.

II. No one worthy

In Rev. 5:2-4 we see that no one in heaven, on earth, or under the earth was worthy to open the scroll or to look into it. When John first saw the scroll, it was still sealed. If we had been there, we, like John, certainly would have been desirous to see what was contained in that scroll. But John "wept much because no one was found worthy to open the scroll or to look into it." If actually no one worthy was found in the whole universe, we would surely need to weep, for the whole universe would be vanity, with none qualified to unveil its secret. If there were no Christ in this universe, the whole universe would weep. But there is Christ, and we do not need to weep.

III. The worthy Lion-Lamb

A. The Lion of the tribe of Judah

While John was weeping, one of the elders said to him, "Do not weep; behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has overcome to open the scroll and its seven seals." This refers to Gen. 49:8-9, where Christ is portrayed as a lion, which is a symbol of Him as a strong fighter against the enemy. We have pointed out that nearly everything in Revelation is a fulfillment of what is mentioned in the Old Testament. Christ is the fighting, victorious, and overcoming Lion. He has won the battle. Hence, His overcoming qualifies Him to open the scroll and its seven seals.

Although the angel told John to behold the Lion of the tribe of Judah, verse 6 says, "I saw in the midst of the throne and of the four living creatures, and in the midst of the elders, a Lamb standing as having been slain." The angel recommended Christ as the Lion, but John saw Him as the Lamb. As the Lion, He is the Fighter against the enemy; as the Lamb, He is the Redeemer for us. He has fought to redeem us, and He has won the battle over the enemy and accomplished redemption for us. To the enemy, He is a Lion; to us, He is a Lamb. Although the angels do not need redemption, they need someone to defeat the enemy of God, for one among them became God's enemy. Thus the angels realize that there is a need for someone to defeat this rebel. To the angels, Christ was the Lion who defeated the rebel, but to us, including the apostle John, Christ is the Lamb, the redeeming One. We need Christ's redemption. As we have already pointed out, in the universe there are two main problems — Satan and sin. As the Lion, Christ has defeated and destroyed Satan, and as the Lamb, He has taken away our sin. He has won the victory and He has accomplished redemption. Now He is the Lion-Lamb.

Verse 6 reveals that the Lamb is standing in the midst of the throne. As far as redemption is concerned, Christ sat down after His ascension at the right hand of God in heaven (Heb. 1:3; 10:12), whereas, regarding the carrying out of God's administration, He is still standing in His ascension.

B. The root of David

In verse 5 Christ is given the title, "the Root of David." This title (He is also the root of David's father Jesse, Isa. 11:1) signifies that Christ is the source of David. Therefore, as His forefather, David called Him "the Lord" (Matt. 22:42-45). He is the root of David. In our concept, Christ was born of David, so He was a descendant of David. But here it says that Christ is the root of David, meaning that David grows out of Christ. The Bible also says that Christ is the branch of David (Jer. 23:5). Hence, He is both the root and the branch. In Isaiah 11:1 and 10 we see that Christ is also a branch and root of Jesse.

We have seen that Christ is both a descendant and the root of David. In the eyes of God, David was the unique person who fought the battle and gained authority, fighting the battle for God and gaining His full authority. That Christ, the Lion-Lamb, is the root of this person means that He is greater than David. This is why He holds the key of David (3:7). Whatever David was, had, and did was altogether out of this root. Therefore, as the root of David, Christ is more powerful and more victorious than David and has more of God's divine authority.

C. The slain Lamb

In verse 6 John said that he saw "a Lamb standing as having been slain." According to the Greek, "having been slain" indicates that the Lamb has just recently been slain. When John saw Christ as the Lamb, He had been freshly slain. This also indicates that the scene in heaven depicted in this chapter is immediately after Christ's ascension into heaven.

D. Having overcome

As the Lion of the tribe of Judah, Christ has overcome Satan, the enemy of God. He has solved this problem for God and has removed the hindrances to the fulfillment of God's purpose. Hence, He is worthy to open the scroll concerning God's economy.

E. Worthy to open the scroll and its seven seals

God's purpose needs someone to carry it out who can solve all the problems of God. The problems which God had were the rebellion of Satan and the fall of man. As the Lion, Christ has defeated the rebellious Satan, and as the Lamb, He has taken away the sin of fallen man. Since He has solved these two problems for God, He is worthy to open the scroll of God's economy.

F. Having seven horns

In verse 6 John says that the Lamb has seven horns. Horns signify strength in fighting (Deut. 33:17). Christ is the redeeming Lamb, yet with fighting horns. He is the fighting Redeemer, and His fighting is complete in God's move as signified by the number seven.

G. Having seven eyes

Verse 6 also says that the Lamb has "seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God, sent forth into all the earth." The Lamb's eyes are for observing and searching. As the redeeming Lamb, Christ has seven observing and searching eyes for executing God's judgment upon the universe to fulfill God's eternal purpose, which will consummate in the building up of the New Jerusalem. Therefore, in Zechariah 3:9 He is prophesied as the stone, which is the topstone (Zech. 4:7, Heb.), with seven eyes for God's building. These seven eyes are "the seven Spirits of God sent forth into all the earth," running "to and fro through the whole earth" (Zech. 4:10).

In his Gospel John said that Christ was the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world (John 1:29). But here in Revelation 5 John sees the Lamb as having seven eyes. Although John saw the Lamb that had been slain, he did not see blood flowing. Rather, he saw seven eyes which are the seven Spirits of God. These seven eyes are surely not for redemption. The Lamb in the Gospel of John shed His blood and out of His side flowed water. But the Lamb in Revelation has seven flaming eyes that shine out and reach far to touch people. According to the black and white letters, this is for judgment, but actually it is for God's building. You may wonder what my basis is for saying that the seven searching, enlightening eyes are for God's building. The Bible tells us clearly that these seven eyes are the seven lamps (Zech. 3:9; 4:2, 10). The seven lamps are first mentioned in Exo. 25. There, the lamps are neither for searching nor for judging but for God's building. The seven lamps mentioned there are for the building up of the tabernacle, God's dwelling place among men on earth. Apparently, the seven flaming eyes of the Lamb are for searching and judging. However, this searching and judging is a procedure to attain the consummate goal of building. Eventually, the book of Revelation is not just for judgment but for building. Most expositions of Revelation say that it is a book of judgment. But this judgment is a procedure which will consummate in the New Jerusalem. What appears after the judgment has been executed? The New Jerusalem. The New Jerusalem issues out of God's judgment which is carried out by the seven eyes.

As we have already pointed out, a person's eyes cannot be separated from him, for a person's eyes are his expression. Our inner being is mainly expressed through our eyes. In like manner, the seven Spirits are the seven eyes of Christ by which Christ expresses Himself. If anyone says that the Spirit is separate from Christ, then he must lack knowledge and be shortsighted. How can anyone say that a person's eyes are separate from him? This is ridiculous! Are not the seven Spirits the Holy Spirit, and are not the seven Spirits the eyes of Christ? Then how can anyone say that the Holy Spirit, who is the seven Spirits, is separate from Christ? The Son is the embodiment of the Father, and the Spirit is the expression of the Son. The seven eyes of Christ, the seven Spirits of God, are Christ's expression in a judging way in God's move for God's building. Even now, Christ's burning eyes are flaming over us to enlighten, search, refine, and judge us, not that we might be condemned, but that we might be purged, transformed, and conformed to His image for God's building. The Lord's judgment is motivated by love. Because He loves the church, He comes to search, enlighten, judge, refine, and purify us in order to transform us into precious stones. Eventually, this book consummates in the New Jerusalem which is built with precious materials. Where do these materials come from? They come from the seven eyes of Christ, that is, from the life-giving, transforming Spirit.

In the book of Revelation the Spirit is not called the life-giving Spirit or the transforming Spirit, but the seven Spirits which are the seven burning, searching, judging lamps. For the degraded church, the Spirit who gives life must be the sevenfold burning Spirit. Today, the life-giving Spirit must be the flaming Spirit, and the transforming Spirit must be the searching and judging Spirit. His searching and judging are His purifying and transforming. No one can be transformed into a precious stone without being searched by Him. How I look to the Lord that He would search us all. We are not here for doctrine and teaching; we are here under the enlightening of the pure Word and under the searching of the seven Spirits. We all need to be thoroughly searched, purified, and refined. If we are, we shall never be the same.

In Exodus 25 the seven lamps are for the building of God's dwelling place on earth, and in Zechariah 3 the seven eyes are the seven eyes of the stone. In Revelation we have the Lion-Lamb, and in Zechariah we have the stone. Because in Revelation the seven eyes are on the Lamb and in Zechariah they are on the stone, we may say that the Lamb is the Lamb-stone. The Lamb-stone is for God's building. That Christ, the Lamb of God, is the building stone with the seven eyes proves that the seven eyes of Christ are for God's building. In the Lord's recovery, everyone is under the searching, judging, and purifying of the Spirit of Christ, and today the Spirit of Christ is the sevenfold flaming Spirit. Although He is the life-giving and transforming Spirit, to the degraded church He is the seven burning Spirits. We are not only preaching the Lamb in John 1, but also ministering the Lamb in Revelation 5. We are ministering this Lamb as the building stone with seven Spirits. Our Savior is such a One, having the seven Spirits to spread Himself, express Himself, and infuse Himself into all His members to transform us into precious material for God's building.

IV. The worship and praise of the four living creatures and twenty-four elders to the Lamb

A. Having harps and golden bowls full of incense

In verses 8 through 10 we see the worship and praise of the four living creatures and the twenty-four elders to the Lamb. The four living creatures and the twenty-four elders have harps and golden bowls full of incense. In verse 8, the word which refers to bowls, not to incense. The bowls are "the prayers of the saints" brought to God by the angelic elders (cf. 8:3-4), whereas the incense is Christ added to the saints' prayers. That these worshippers are holding the bowls means that they, as priests, are ministering to God by bringing the saints' prayers to Him. This reveals that before the Christians become priests in the millennial kingdom, the twenty-four elders are priests today. Eventually, we shall replace them. This is proved by 4:10 where we are told that the twenty-four elders "shall cast their crowns before the throne," indicating that they will resign from their posts. When the redeemed saints have been perfected and glorified to be the proper priest-kings, the temporary priests, the elderly angels, will resign. At the time of the millennium, the overcoming saints will be the perfected, completed, and proper priests and kings to God. When that time comes, the temporary priests and ruling ones will resign. But here in chapter five they are still priests offering the saints' prayers with Christ as the incense to God.

B. Singing a new song, praising the Lamb

In verses 9 and 10 we see the elders singing a new song of praise to the Lamb. Verse 9 says, "And they sing a new song, saying: You are worthy to take the scroll and to open its seals, for You were slain and did purchase to God by Your blood men out of every tribe and tongue and people and nation." The song here is new because the Lamb whom it praises has been recently slain. This new song praises the worthiness of the Lamb. As we have seen, in the whole universe no one is worthy to open the mystery of God's economy but Christ, the overcoming Lion and redeeming Lamb. As the overcoming Lion He has defeated Satan for God, and as the redeeming Lamb He has put away sin for us. He is the only One qualified to unveil the mystery of God's economy and to carry it out.

Speaking of those who have been purchased to God by the Lamb's blood, the twenty-four elders sing in verse 10, "And made them to our God a kingdom and priests, and they shall reign on the earth." The word them in this verse proves that the praising elders are not of the church but of the angels. Kingdom is for kingship to exercise God's authority, and priests are for the priesthood to accomplish the divine ministry.

V. The universal praise to God and to the Lamb

In verses 11 through 14 we see the universal praise to God and to the Lamb by the angels under the leadership of the twenty-four elders (vv. 11-12) and by all the creatures under the leadership of the four living creatures (vv. 13-14). The many angels, represented by the twenty-four elders, render to the Lamb the angelic praise. Every creature, represented by the four living creatures, follows them to give the Lamb the universal praise of all creatures other than the angels.

God's economy with His redemption is for the accomplishment of His eternal dwelling place, the New Jerusalem. God's anointed One, Christ, is the Lion, the Lamb, and the stone. He has destroyed the enemy, has redeemed us, and has become the stone. In Matt. 21:42 the Lord said to the Pharisees who were opposing Him, "Have you never read in the Scriptures, The stone which the builders rejected, this has become the cornerstone; this was from the Lord, and it is marvelous in our eyes?" Here the Lord indicated that His redemption was for Him to be the cornerstone. We find the same thought in Acts 4:11-12. Acts 4:12 says that "neither is there another name under heaven given among men in which we must be saved." That this name is the name of Christ, the cornerstone, is revealed in the previous verse which says that "the stone which was despised" by the builders "has 'become the cornerstone.'" Thus, the name of the cornerstone is the name by which we are saved. What are we saved for — for going to heaven? No, we are saved to become a stone for God's building. The concept in Revelation is that of Christ's being the Lion to defeat and destroy the enemy, the Lamb to redeem us, and the stone to build God's eternal dwelling place. In what way does Christ build up God's dwelling place? By the way of the seven Spirits as the seven burning, enlightening, searching, judging, and infusing eyes. By means of the seven Spirits He transforms us into precious stones to be built up into the New Jerusalem.

World History from Christ's Ascension to the End of this Age — Seals One Through Four

In this message we come to the first four seals with the four horses and the four riders (Rev. 6:1-8).

I. The opening of the secrecy of God's administration by the Lamb

Revelation 6:1 says, "And I saw when the Lamb opened one of the seven seals, and I heard one of the four living creatures saying as with a voice of thunder, Come." The opening of the seven seals by the Lamb transpired immediately after Christ's ascension to the heavens. Through His incarnation, crucifixion, and resurrection, Christ is fully qualified in His ascension to open the mystery of God's economy which is contained in the seven seals. Because God's economy concerning the creatures is contained in the seven seals, the four living creatures are interested in announcing the opening of the first four seals respectively.

II. A four-horse race constituting world history

The first four seals comprise four horses with their riders in a four-horse race. All four riders are not real persons but personified things. It is evident that the rider of the second horse, the red horse, is war (v. 4); the rider of the third horse, the black horse, is famine (v. 5); and the rider of the fourth horse, the pale horse, is death (v. 8). According to historical facts, the rider of the first horse, the white horse, must be the gospel, not, as some interpret, Christ or Antichrist. Immediately after Christ's ascension, these four things — the gospel, war, famine, and death — began to run like riders on four horses and will continue until Christ comes back. Beginning with the first century, the gospel has been spreading throughout all these twenty centuries. War has also been proceeding simultaneously. War always causes famine, and famine issues in death. All these will continue until the end of this age.

A. The rider of the white horse

The rider of the white horse is the preaching of the gospel. White signifies clean, pure, just, and approvable. The white horse is a symbol of the preaching of the gospel, which is clean, pure, just, and approvable both to men and to God.

Some have said that the rider on the white horse is Christ, and others have claimed that the rider is the Antichrist. After much study, we learned that neither of these concepts is right. In interpreting the Bible we must follow the principle. The principle here is that the riders on the four horses are not persons but personified things. The rider on the second horse is war, the rider on the third is famine, and the rider on the fourth is death. None of these are persons but rather are personified things. Following this principle, the rider of the first horse must also be a personified thing. Therefore, the rider can be neither Christ nor Antichrist. According to the principle, this rider must also be a personification. After much consideration, we have seen that this rider must be the preaching of the gospel.

1. Having a bow signifying that the battle was fought

Verse 2 says, "I saw, and behold, a white horse, and he who sits on it having a bow; and a crown was given to him, and he went forth conquering and that he might conquer." A bow is for fighting with an arrow. But here there is a bow without an arrow. This indicates that the arrow has already been shot to destroy the enemy, and the victory has been won for the constitution of the gospel of peace. Now the fighting is over, and the gospel of peace is proclaimed in a peaceful way. On the cross, the arrow was shot into the heart of the enemy, the battle was fought, and the victory was won. Therefore, the bow without an arrow is a declaration that the war is over and that the victory has been won.

2. Given a crown signifying the glory of the gospel

Verse 2 also says that "a crown was given to him." A crown is a sign of glory. The gospel has been crowned with "the glory of Christ" (2 Cor. 4:4, Gk.), and it is called the gospel of the glory of Christ. The gospel we preach is the gospel crowned with the glory of Christ. We not only preach the gospel of grace, but also the gospel of glory.

3. Going forth conquering

Verse 2 also says that the rider on the white horse "went forth conquering and that he might conquer." Throughout all the centuries, wherever the gospel is proclaimed, it has conquered and has overcome all kinds of opposition and attack and it is still conquering today. We are not told that the riders on the second, third, and fourth horses went forth conquering. Only the rider on the first horse, the preaching of the gospel, has been conquering continuously. Wherever the preaching of the gospel goes, there is this conquering.

B. The rider of the red horse

Verses 3 and 4 say, "And when He opened the second seal, I heard the second living creature saying, Come. And I saw, and behold, another, a red horse went forth; and to him who sits on it, to him it was given to take peace from the earth, and that they should slay one another; and a great sword was given to him." Red here signifies the shedding of blood. Thus, the red horse is a symbol of the raging of war, which is altogether a matter of shedding blood. "To take peace from the earth," "they should slay one another," and "a great sword was given to him" all clearly indicate war. Since Christ's ascension, the preaching of the gospel has been followed by war.

C. The rider of the black horse

Verses 5 and 6 say, "And when He opened the third seal, I heard the third living creature saying, Come. And I saw, and behold, a black horse; and he who sits on it having a balance in his hand. And I heard as it were a voice in the midst of the four living creatures saying: A choenix of wheat for a denarius, and three choenixes of barley for a denarius; and do not harm the oil and the wine." Here, black, indicating the dearth (Jer. 14:1-4), signifies the color of the visage of famished people (Lam. 4:8-9; 5:9-10). The black horse is a symbol of the spreading of famine, which causes a black visage. A balance is a scale used to weigh precious things. But here it is used to weigh food, as mentioned in verse 6, thus showing the scarcity of food (Lev. 26:26; Ezek. 4:16). Oil and wine are for man's pleasure (Psa. 104:15). They are always short and become precious in famine. During a famine, oil and wine should be preserved and not harmed. Famine always follows war, for war causes food to be scarce. If there were another war today, the world would have a food shortage.

D. The rider of the pale horse

Verses 7 and 8 say, "And when He opened the fourth seal, I heard the voice of the fourth living creature saying, Come. And I saw, and behold, a pale horse, and the name of him who sits upon it is Death; and Hades followed him. And authority was given to them over the fourth part of the earth to kill with sword and with famine and with death and by the beasts of the earth." The rider on the fourth horse is clearly identified as death. The word translated pale may also be rendered pale green, signifying the color of the appearance of those stricken with the plague. Thus, the pale horse is a symbol of the killing of death, causing a pale appearance. Hades is the place under the earth where the souls of the unsaved dead are kept before being resurrected for the judgment of the white throne (Rev. 20:11-15). After this judgment, the unsaved will be cast into the lake of fire for eternity. Hades may be likened to a temporary jail, and the lake of fire to a permanent prison. Here Hades follows death to receive those whom death kills. The killing by beasts mentioned in verse 8 is God's judgment (2 Kings 2:24; 17:25; Num. 21:6; Exo. 23:28; Josh. 24:12).

In these four seals we see the gospel preaching, war, famine, and death. During the past twenty centuries, these four things have marked the history of mankind. Everything else that has transpired during this time can be included in these four things. Immediately after Christ ascended to the heavens, the preaching of the gospel began. The white horse began to run the race, and the rider on this horse was the gospel of the glory of Christ. In A.D. 70 Titus, the prince of Rome, destroyed Jerusalem with his armies. Since then, throughout the centuries, there has been one war after another. Following war, there has been famine, and famine causes disease and death. Hence, in the history of the past two thousand years, there has been nothing except gospel preaching, war, famine, and death. This is the way to study world history.

Revelation, which was written at the end of the first century, is a prophecy of things to come. If, as some say, the rider on the white horse is either Christ or Antichrist, then all the four seals would refer to the future. If this is the case, then there is no prophecy to cover the last twenty centuries. This would indicate that the prophecy in this book is not complete, because it would not show anything of the history during the past two thousand years, that is, from the first century down to the appearance of the Antichrist or to Christ's coming back. In principle, there should not be such a great gap in the prophecy of this book. Therefore, based upon this principle, these four seals must be a history of the world from Christ's ascension to the end of this age.

We should not care for mere doctrine; we must take care of history and of experience. History is experience. We must apply prophecy to history. If we do this, we shall immediately realize that since Christ's ascension there has been a four-horse race among gospel preaching, war, famine, and death. Today the whole world is preparing for war. Even the diplomats in the United Nations are preparing for it. While they are fighting among themselves, we are preaching the gospel, for the gospel is on the leading horse. For example, in the past two centuries it was not war that first went to China; it was the gospel. The preaching of the gospel was then followed by war, famine, and death. This has been the course of world history throughout the past twenty centuries.

Christ has opened these four seals, and the four-horse race has been revealed. Do not try to understand the prophecy of the Bible simply according to your mentality. We must take care of experience. In order to understand the prophecy of the Bible, we must take care of history because the prophecies are predictions of things to come. What has occurred during the past twenty centuries? Four things — gospel preaching, war, famine, and death.

After His incarnation, Christ accomplished redemption through crucifixion, entered into resurrection, and then ascended into the heavens. No human history gives us such a record. But this is genuine world history. In my study of history, I discovered that the world history I was taught had a great shortage — there was no incarnation, crucifixion, resurrection, and ascension. If you took these four things away from the history of the world, what kind of world would we have? In God's account of history, these four things are crucial. After the ascension of Christ, the whole course of world history was changed. By opening God's economy, Christ has written the history of mankind during the past twenty centuries.

We see the proper human history in the pure Word. This record of history in the Word carries out God's economy. After Christ's ascension and before His coming back, there is a history of the world. This history is summarized in a race of four horses. As we have seen, the rider on the first horse is gospel preaching. God's economy is for nothing except the gospel preaching that will fulfill His eternal purpose. Where does the preaching of the gospel come from? It comes from Christ's incarnation, crucifixion, resurrection, and ascension. These four items are the source of the gospel. The history of the past twenty centuries has been for gospel preaching. This is God's wisdom. Gospel preaching takes the lead in the four-horse race. What is our generation for? It is for gospel preaching. And gospel preaching is for the carrying out of God's economy. How can the church be produced? Only through gospel preaching. How can the New Jerusalem come into being? Only through gospel preaching.

Three negative things — war, famine, and death — help to advance the preaching of the gospel. A runner in a race does not run as fast alone as he does when others are running with him. War, famine, and death are terrible things, but they speed the preaching of the gospel. During the early days in China, it was difficult to open the door of the gospel. Do you know what opened the door? It was war. The door was opened, not only by civil war but also by the international war initiated by the Japanese invasion of China. After the last war between China and Japan, thousands of Chinese were saved. Moreover, through the civil war in the 1940's, many Chinese went to Taiwan from mainland China, and thousands of them were saved. If they had stayed on the mainland, they never would have believed in the Lord Jesus. But, having been forced to migrate to the island of Taiwan, thousands of people flooded into the church for salvation in the years 1949 and 1950. During those years, we preached the gospel in the park every Sunday afternoon. Every Sunday approximately three thousand people heard the preaching of the gospel. Many were saved, and some of them eventually became elders and deacons in the churches in Taiwan and co-workers in the Lord's work. War brought them to the gospel. Therefore, war has been and still is a good helper of the preaching of the gospel.

God's wisdom is to make this age, the age from the ascension of Christ to His coming back, an age of gospel preaching. Everything on earth today is for the preaching of the gospel. Factories, printing, airplanes, radio, television, and even nuclear weapons are for the preaching of the gospel. This is the gospel preaching age. The history of the world since the ascension of Christ is a history of gospel preaching. What are we doing today? We are preaching the gospel. And we are not preaching a partial gospel but a whole, complete gospel, a full gospel. Do you realize that the full gospel includes the church life, the kingdom, and even the New Jerusalem? The full gospel encompasses everything from Matthew through Revelation. In these days we are preaching the full gospel, the gospel that includes the church today, the kingdom in the coming age, and the New Jerusalem in eternity. Whatever happens today, including the opposition against us, is a help to preaching the gospel. This is the vision of the first four seals. We should not be like a frog in a narrow well who has a very limited vision of the sky. Rather, we must have an overall vision to see the significance of the first four seals. Instead of having the view of a frog in a well, we should have a bird's-eye view. The rider on the first horse is neither Christ nor Antichrist; it is the preaching of the gospel of the glory of Christ. This is the crucial factor of this age, and the three other horses are helping this one horse to run the race. We are not with the riders on the last three horses; we are with the rider on the first horse. We have a bow without an arrow, for we are preaching the gospel of peace, a gospel in which the victory has been won, in a peaceful way. Hallelujah, this glorious preaching of the gospel is riding on throughout the earth. Praise the Lord that we are on the first horse!

The Cry of the Martyred Saints and God's Answer to It — Seals Five and Six

In this message we shall consider the fifth and sixth seals (Rev. 6:9-17). According to the record of Revelation, the first four seals are not consecutive. Rather, they are simultaneous. They all began to take place at nearly the same time and they will conclude at the same time. It is very similar to a four-horse race where the horses begin and end at almost the same time. The seven seals may be divided into two groups consisting of the first four seals and the last three seals. While the first four seals are not consecutive, the last three seals are consecutive.

As we have seen, the first four seals unveil the new testament age, which is an age of gospel preaching. Between Christ's ascension and His coming back, the preaching of the gospel will continue. The other main things — war, famine, and death — work together for the advancement of the preaching of the gospel. God has a unique purpose in this age — to have the gospel preached that the church might be produced and built up for the fulfillment of His eternal plan. We need to have this overall view. But the great men on earth do not have this view. Not even the kings and the presidents of the nations know what they are doing. But we know. Everything these rulers do helps the preaching of the gospel. God is sovereign in this matter.

The book of Revelation begins with the local churches with Christ in their midst and it ends with the New Jerusalem with Christ as its centrality and universality. Between these two ends of Revelation, we have the church age and the kingdom age. In the church age, the new testament age, God is doing one thing: He is producing the churches through the preaching of the full gospel. All twenty-seven books of the New Testament are included in the full gospel. God's purpose is not merely to save a group of pitiful sinners. This concept is too low, and many of the philosophical people refuse to accept it. They need to see that the preaching of the gospel has a much higher purpose and that it is on the highest plane — producing the churches for the composition of the New Jerusalem. After the church age, the kingdom age will come. In the kingdom age God will accomplish what has not been completed and perfected in the church age. After the age of the kingdom, God's purpose will be thoroughly and absolutely completed. Then there will be eternity with the new heaven, the new earth, and the New Jerusalem composed of all the redeemed saints. This is a general view of the whole universe.

As we have already pointed out, through the first four seals, we have a view of what is taking place between Christ's ascension and His coming back. Four things are transpiring: the preaching of the gospel, war, famine, and death. The second, third, and fourth horses help to speed up the preaching of the gospel. If there had been no war, I would not be in this country. In the past, none of us in the Lord's recovery in China intended to come to the western world. We thought that perhaps after we had finished a certain amount of recovery work, the Lord would then use some other people or means, perhaps missionaries or the translation of the books, to bring the recovery to the western world. But suddenly, in 1949, mainland China was lost. As a result, the Lord's recovery was brought to this country. Having been sent to Taiwan by the work, I was deeply troubled by the loss of the Lord's recovery in mainland China. Day and night, I asked the Lord, "What is this? Why has the work been lost?" Eventually, the sovereign Lord brought His recovery to this country. This reveals that, in the sovereign hand of the Lord, there is only one thing in this age — the preaching of the full gospel to produce the local churches for the building up of God's eternal dwelling place, the New Jerusalem. When we have this overall view, we can look into the book of Revelation and understand it adequately and properly.

I. The cry of the martyred saints — the fifth seal

The seven seals are firstly divided into four and three, and secondly into six and one. The number four signifies the creatures, as symbolized by the four living creatures, and the number six signifies creation, since creation was finished in six days. The number three signifies the Triune God, and the number one the unique God. Hence, both four plus three and six plus one indicate that the seven seals, through God's judgment, bring God's creation with all the creatures to God.

The fifth seal discloses the Christian martyrdom from the first century to the time near the end of this age. (It may include the martyrdom of the old testament saints — Matt. 23:34-36.) While the gospel is being preached, as indicated by the first seal, there is always the martyrdom of the faithful saints.

A. The martyrdom

During the age of gospel preaching, many saints have been martyred because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus. Stephen, Peter, and nearly all the other apostles were martyred. The apostle John was exiled, and Paul was imprisoned and later sentenced to death. Throughout the centuries, wherever the preaching of the gospel has gone, there has been martyrdom. Thousands of those who have been faithful to the Lord's testimony have been martyred. In a sense, even Brother Nee was martyred. Nearly all my older co-workers suffered martyrdom during the past twenty-six years by being kept in prison until they died.

The martyrdom of the saints is not because of their opposition to any human rules, but because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus. The word of God is the glad tidings, the gospel, they proclaim to people. The testimony of Jesus is the life they live. Human society with human culture is wholly under the evil influence of Satan, as it says in 1 John 5:19, "the whole world lies in the evil one." Both the preaching of the word of God and the life of the testimony of Jesus are against the satanic trend in the world. Certainly Satan hates this. Hence, whenever and wherever the saints preach the word of God and live the testimony of Jesus, Satan instigates people to persecute them, even to death. This is a fighting, not between men and the saints, but between Satan and God. The time will come when God will avenge the saints by exercising His righteous judgment over the earth which is under Satan's evil influence.

B. The cry

Revelation 6:10, speaking of "the souls of those who had been slain because of the word of God and because of the testimony which they held," says, "And they cried with a loud voice, saying, How long, O sovereign Lord, holy and true, will You not judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?" In 6:9 we see that the souls are underneath the altar. This points to the sacrifices killed on the altar. When a sacrifice was killed on the altar, its blood flowed down to and under the bottom of the altar. The soul of the flesh is in the blood (Lev. 17:11). That the soul of the martyred saints are under the altar indicates that, in the eyes of God, they have all been offered to God as sacrifices on the altar and that their blood, their life, was shed there. Now their position is under the altar. In figure, the altar is in the outer court of the tabernacle and the temple, and the outer court signifies the earth. Hence, "underneath the altar" is underneath the earth, where the souls of the martyred saints are. It is the paradise where the Lord Jesus went after His death (Luke 23:43). It is in the heart of the earth (Matt. 12:40), and should be the comfortable section of Hades, where Abraham is (Acts 2:27; Luke 16:22-26).

Today, the martyred saints are in paradise underneath the altar, that is, underneath the earth. It is altogether erroneous to say that these saints are in heaven. The original Scofield Reference Bible has a note on Luke 16:23 that indicates that paradise was under the earth before Christ's resurrection, but that by and with Christ's resurrection it was transferred from under the earth to the third heaven. However, on the day of Pentecost, fifty days after the Lord's resurrection, Peter said, "David did not ascend into the heavens" (Acts 2:34). Even at the time of the day of Pentecost, David was still not in heaven. In his book, *Firstfruits and Harvest*, on page 54, G. H. Lang, a late teacher among the Brethren, says that "the Scripture nowhere declares" that after Christ's ascension paradise was transferred from under the earth to the third heaven, "but is wholly against it." He also pointed out the verse in Acts 2 where Peter said that David was not in heaven. I mention this that we might realize that all the martyred saints are still in paradise underneath the altar.

Many Christians do not know that paradise is in Hades. The strongest proof that paradise is in Hades is the Lord's word to the saved thief in Luke 23:43, "Truly I tell you, today you shall be with Me in Paradise." Acts 2:27, 31 reveal that after the Lord Jesus died He went to Hades. Matt. 12:40 indicates that Hades is in "the heart of the earth" where the Lord Jesus went for three days and nights after His death. In Hades there is a pleasant section likened to Abraham's bosom where Lazarus went (Luke 16:23). This is not the paradise in the heavens, but the paradise in Hades. Using 2 Cor. 12:2-4, some have argued that when Paul was "caught away into paradise" he was "caught away to the third heaven." But 2 Corinthians 12:2-4 does not prove that paradise is in the third heaven; rather, it proves the opposite. The word and at the beginning of verse 3 proves that Paul's being "caught away to the third heaven" and his being "caught away into paradise" mentioned in verses 3 and 4 are two different things. The Greek word rendered caught up in verses 2 and 4 (KJV) may be translated caught away. On the one hand, Paul was living on earth, but on the other hand, he was "caught away" to the heavens and into "the paradise." In this way, Paul received a full vision of the entire universe. As far as mankind is concerned, the universe is of three sections: the heavens, the earth, and under the earth (cf. Phil. 2:10). Paul came to know the things on earth, the things in heaven, and the things in paradise. He had the greatest revelation of the universe as it relates to man.

When the saved saints die, they all become naked, no longer having a body. For a human being not to have a body means that he is naked, not in a normal condition. No one can be in the presence of God in the third heavens in this naked, abnormal condition. Hence, the dead saints must be kept in a pleasant place until the time of their resurrection, when God will clothe them with a resurrected body and they will be a complete person in a normal condition.

Some may wonder about Phil. 1:23, where Paul said that he had a desire "to depart and be with Christ." Paul seemed to be saying, "If I die, I will be with Christ." To be with Christ is not an absolute matter; it is a relative one. Even now, we are with Christ. Wherever we are, we are with Him. Of course, while we are in this physical body, we are not as close to Christ as we are when we die, pass out of this world, and enter into another realm. But this does not mean when the believers die they are taken to the heavens. That will not occur until the day of resurrection and rapture.

Others may use 1 Thes. 4 to argue that the dead saints are with Christ in heaven. They say that when Christ comes back, He will bring the dead believers with Him, and that this proves that they must be with Him now in heaven. But read this chapter carefully. It says that "the dead in Christ shall rise first" and that those who "are living, who remain, shall be caught up at the same time together with them in clouds" (1 Thes. 4:16-17). According to 1 Thessalonians 4, the dead saints will be resurrected and, along with the living ones, will be caught up to the air to meet with Christ. We should read the Bible carefully and not follow today's traditional, superficial teachings. We must be clear that the saved saints are not in the heavens, but in a pleasant place which the Bible calls paradise, the place the Lord Jesus visited after He died.

After waiting for a long time, near to the end of this age, the martyred saints cry out for revenge, urging the Lord to judge and avenge their blood "on those who dwell on the earth."

C. The Lord's approval

Verse 11 says, "And to each of them was given a white robe; and it was said to them that they should rest yet a little while, until the number of their fellow slaves and their brothers who are about to be killed even as they were should be completed also." The white robe here signifies that their martyrdom has been approved by God. Those "who are about to be killed" refers to those who will be martyred during the great tribulation (Rev. 20:4).

According to the word, "yet a little while until the number...should be completed," this cry of the martyred saints should transpire near the end of this age. We are still in the first four seals. The fifth seal has not yet come. However, I believe that we are close to the time of the fifth seal.

II. God's answer — the sixth seal

A. The beginning of supernatural calamities

The sixth seal (Rev. 6:12-17), which marks the beginning of supernatural calamities, is God's answer to the cry of the martyred saints in the fifth seal. After the opening of the sixth seal, the Lord comes in to shake the earth and the hosts of the heavens. The earth will quake greatly, the sun will become black as sackcloth made of hair, the moon will become as blood, the stars of heaven will fall to the earth as a fig tree casting its unripe figs when shaken by a great wind, the heaven will recoil as a scroll being rolled up, and every mountain and island will move out of its place (6:12-14). This great shaking will be a warning to the dwellers on the earth. It will warn them to repent and return to God. God may seem to be saying to them, "You earth dwellers are only for yourselves. You don't care for Me. Now is My time to shake the earth as a warning to you." While some people have blasphemously said that they are God, the Lord will shake the earth and the heaven as a reminder to them that He is God. What a terrible shaking this will be! The earth, the sun, the moon, and the stars will all be affected.

B. The reaction of the earth's dwellers

In verses 15 through 17 we see the reaction of the earth's dwellers. They will hide themselves in the caves and in the rocks of the mountains and they will beg the mountains and rocks to hide them from the face of God and from the wrath of the Lamb. Verse 15 reveals the feeling of their conscience, for they fear the coming of the judgment of God, considering that the great day of the wrath of God and of the Lamb has come. However, the sixth seal is not the proclamation of God concerning the coming of His judgment. Rather, it is a warning to the dwellers of the earth. The kings and all the great, rich, and noble men of the earth will be shocked by this earthquake and will think that the day of the wrath of God and of the Lamb has come. Actually, this will not yet be that day, it will be just a foretaste and a warning to them to repent. In this warning God seems to be saying, "Return to Me. Do not say that you are God. You are the poor dwellers on the earth created by Me. I created the sun, the moon, and the stars for your living. But you forget Me and oppose and blaspheme Me. Now is the time for you to be warned in order that you might repent."

C. The significance of this calamity

The significance of this calamity is that it is a warning to the earth's dwellers. It is not yet the actual wrath of the Lord. It is God's answer to the cry of the martyred saints in the fifth seal and it reveals that God is soon to come in to avenge them and to vindicate Himself. God is coming to avenge the blood of His dear saints.

III. The warning being before the day of the Lord

The sixth seal, being an introduction to the great tribulation, is a warning before the day of the Lord. According to Joel 2:30-31, there will not be much difference in time between the sixth seal and the first five trumpets (Rev. 8:6-11). Joel 2:30-31 firstly has the blood of the first and second trumpets, the fire of the first, second, and third trumpets (Rev. 8:7-10), and the smoke of the fifth trumpet (Rev. 9:1-3), and then the sun and the moon of the sixth seal. Chapter Rev. 9:4 compared with Rev. 7:3 indicates that the fifth trumpet is very close to the sixth seal.

There will be two calamities in the shakings and changes of the earth and of the hosts in heaven. The first will occur before the day of the Lord, before the great tribulation (Joel 3:11-16; 2:30-31; Luke 21:11). And the second will occur after the day of the Lord, after the great tribulation (Matt. 24:29-30; Luke 21:25-26). What is covered in the sixth seal is the first calamity. It may be considered not only as a warning but also as an introduction to the coming great tribulation. Following the sixth seal, at the opening of the seventh seal, are the first four trumpets as indicators that the great tribulation is coming (Rev. 8:1-2, 6-13). Then the great tribulation will be carried out in the last three trumpets (Rev. 9:1-21; 11:14-19).

God's Preservation of His People

In the book of Revelation there are a number of insertions, and chapter seven is the first of them. This chapter is not the continuation of chapter six. It is an insertion between the sixth and seventh seals, showing how God cares for His people while He is about to execute His judgment upon the earth. Chapter eight is the continuation of chapter six. At the end of chapter six we have the sixth seal, and in the beginning of chapter eight we have the seventh. The opening of the seventh seal will bring in the seven trumpets, the last three of which constitute the great tribulation (Rev. 8:1-2). But before this transpires, God will seal the Israelites whom He intends to preserve (Rev. 7:3).

God will preserve His two peoples — the Israelites and the redeemed saints. Why does this insertion regarding God's preservation of His people come here? Because in the sixth seal we see the warning of the coming tribulation. As we have seen, the fifth seal is the cry of the martyred saints for revenge, and the sixth seal is God's answer to this cry, which is also a warning to the dwellers on the earth that the tribulation will soon come. Since the ascension of Christ, there have been a great number of earthquakes and other calamities. All these have been natural calamities. However, beginning at the opening of the sixth seal, the calamities will no longer be natural but supernatural. Both natural and supernatural calamities are God's punishment upon the earth. This rebellious earth deserves God's punishment, and the punishing hand of God has never been removed from it. To a certain extent, God punishes the earth for His purpose. Since the ascension of Christ, God has been punishing the earth.

One aspect of God's punishment is seen in the destruction of the city of Jerusalem by Titus and his armies. That destruction was prophesied by the Lord Jesus in Matthew 24:2 where, speaking of the temple, He said to His disciples, "See ye not all these things? verily I say unto you, There shall not be left here one stone upon another, that shall not be thrown down." Jerusalem was destroyed by Titus for two reasons: because the Jewish religion was rebellious against God's economy and because this religion was a negative influence on the church in Jerusalem. In Acts 21 we see how much the old Jewish religion influenced the church. By the time of A.D. 70 the Lord could no longer tolerate the rebellion of the Jewish religion and its influence upon the church, so He sent the Roman army to destroy Jerusalem and the temple. That destruction was a terrible punishment which was accompanied by famine, pestilence, and death. After that, throughout the centuries, natural calamities have been and will be used by God to punish the earth until the sixth seal.

At the time of the sixth seal, the calamities will be changed from natural calamities to supernatural ones. The earth will be shaken, and the sun, moon, and stars will be damaged. These calamities will be a preface to the seventh seal. When the seventh seal is executed, the situation will be terrible and no one will be able to bear it. Shortly after the opening of the seventh seal, the first trumpet will be sounded, and "the third part of the earth" will be burnt up (Rev. 8:7). At the sounding of the second trumpet, "the third part of the sea" will become blood (Rev. 8:8). At the sounding of the third trumpet, a great star will fall upon "the third part of the rivers and upon the springs of waters" and "the third part of the waters" will become wormwood (Rev. 8:10-11). At the sounding of the fourth trumpet, "the third part of the sun and the third part of the moon and the third part of the stars" will be smitten "so that the third part of them might be darkened" (Rev. 8:12). God made the earth for man to live on. The sun, moon, and stars all help to maintain life on earth. But because the dwellers on earth have been so insolent toward Him for centuries, the time will come when God will no longer endure it. He will come in to judge the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the sun, moon, and stars. The earth is for human existence, and every form of life on earth is for man's benefit. The animals, vegetables, and minerals are all for the existence of mankind. These did not come into being by accident, but were planned and created by God. For example, there is no air on the moon, but there is air on earth. Around the globe is a layer of air which the Bible calls the firmament (Gen. 1:7). The earth is the planet with a firmament. God created it in such a way so that it would produce the supplies for maintaining human life. The air, sunshine, and water are all necessary for man's existence. But after God judges the earth and heaven, the earth will no longer be a suitable place for man to live on.

In Matt. 24:6-7 the Lord prophesied that two kinds of wars would come — wars of people against people and wars of nation against nation, that is, civil wars and international wars. After Christ's ascension, these wars began to take place. The Lord also prophesied in Matthew 24 that there would be "earthquakes in various places" (v. 7). A recent article said that each year there will be approximately five to six thousand earthquakes ranging from two to eight on the Richter scale. This is the fulfillment of the Lord's prophecy. In His prophecy the Lord seemed to be saying, "Don't live on this earth so complacently, not caring for God's purpose. You must realize that God has a purpose on this earth and that you must turn to Him for the fulfillment of His purpose." God will warn people again and again with wars and earthquakes until the time of the fifth seal when the martyred souls can no longer tolerate the situation. The martyred saints will then cry out, saying, "How long, O sovereign Lord, holy and true, will You not judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?" (6:10). God's answer comes in the sixth seal when the earth will be shaken and the heavenly hosts will be smitten as an introduction to and warning of the coming tribulation. The sixth seal and the first five trumpets are closely related to one another in time.

At this juncture we need to consider the second chapter of Joel. Joel 2 says that certain things will occur before the day of the Lord. If you read New Testament prophecy along with the Old Testament prophecies, you will see that there is a time called the day of the Lord. This is the great tribulation. The day of the Lord means the day of the Lord's wrath, the day of His coming in to interfere with the world by means of supernatural calamities. The day of the Lord will be terrible. Several prophets of the Old Testament mention the day of the Lord, and they all indicate that it will be a dreadful day (Joel 1:15; 2:1, 11, 31; 3:14; Zech. 14:1; Mal. 4:5). The sixth seal will be before the day of the Lord, meaning that it will be before the great tribulation. The great tribulation will begin at the sounding of the fifth trumpet. The first four trumpets are the preliminary to the great tribulation. It is similar to starting an automobile. First the ignition is turned on, the motor starts, and then the car will run. In like manner, after the warning of the sixth seal, the first four trumpets will be the preliminary to the great tribulation. But, like an automobile which is warming up but has not yet moved, the four trumpets are the preparation for the great tribulation. But even these trumpets will cause severe suffering. The damage to the earth, waters, and the heavenly hosts will be greater than that caused by the earthquake of the sixth seal. From the time of the sixth seal, there will be nothing good for man on earth.

The New Testament indicates that the early overcomers, such as the man-child and the firstfruits, will be taken away from the earth shortly before the sixth seal. However, we cannot calculate the exact time. But according to Revelation, Matthew, and other portions of the Word, we can say that the first kind of rapture, the raptures of the man-child and the firstfruits, will take place before the sixth seal. Recall that the Lord promised to the church in Philadelphia to keep them out of the hour of trial which will come upon all the inhabited earth (3:10). The Lord's lovers and seekers will be taken away before the sixth seal. Immediately after the opening of the sixth seal, we have chapter seven, an insertion revealing that before the great tribulation God will do two things to preserve His people: He will seal the chosen remnant of Israel and He will begin the rapture of the redeemed ones of the church.

I. The sealing of the chosen remnant of Israel

Revelation 7:1 says, "After this I saw four angels standing at the four corners of the earth, holding fast the four winds of the earth, so that no wind should blow on the earth nor on the sea nor on any tree." This is the insertion between the sixth and seventh seals, showing how God cares for His people while He is about to execute His judgments upon the earth. The winds here are for God's judgments (Jonah 1:4; Isa. 11:15; Jer. 22:22; 49:36; 51:1). The next verse says, "And I saw another Angel ascend from the rising of the sun, having the seal of the living God; and He cried with a loud voice to the four angels to whom it was given to harm the earth and sea." The "another Angel" here refers to Christ, as also in Rev. 8:3; 10:1 and Rev. 18:1. In the Old Testament Christ was called "the Angel of the Lord," who was God Himself (Gen. 22:11-12; Exo. 3:2-6; Judg. 6:11-24; Zech. 1:11-12; 2:8-11; 3:1-7). Here in the New Testament He is again called the Angel.

Although I love Israel, I feel very sad for them because, according to prophecy and their present situation, they have returned to the land of their fathers in unbelief. They still cling to their old religion, and they do not believe in God according to His new testament economy. They are actually in rebellion against Him. When the Lord Jesus came, God changed the dispensation from that of keeping the law to that of believing in the Lord Jesus. But the Jews would not accept this change and they refused to turn from keeping the law to believing in the Lord Jesus. This was their rebellion, stubbornness, and disobedience. God has borne with them for centuries, and according to His sovereignty, they have returned and have been restored as a nation again, but they are still in unbelief. They do not believe in the Lord Jesus. According to some reliable information I have received, the government of Israel is doing everything possible to exclude any type of Christian activity. They do not want any Christian missionaries to carry on mission work. The prophecies regarding Israel indicate that they will remain in unbelief until the last day. God, however, is sovereign and He will always take care of the nation of Israel, not for their sake but for His economy. He knows that among the unbelieving Jews there are some faithful ones, and before He will actually judge the earth with supernatural calamities, He will seal them.

A. Before the first four trumpets

The first trumpet is to harm the earth and the trees (Rev. 8:7), the second trumpet is to harm the sea (Rev. 8:8-9), the third trumpet is to harm the rivers (Rev. 8:10-11), and the fourth trumpet is to harm the heavenly hosts (Rev. 8:12). Before the executing of the first four trumpets, God will seal His chosen Israelites to preserve them from the supernatural calamities which will be carried out by these trumpets.

B. Preserved on earth especially from the torment of the fifth trumpet

The first four trumpets will harm only the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the heavenly hosts. It is the fifth trumpet that will torment men directly. God's sealing of His chosen Israelites is especially to preserve them from the torment of the fifth trumpet (Rev. 9:4).

C. Twelve thousand of each of the twelve tribes sealed

In Rev. 7:4-8 we see that God will seal one hundred forty-four thousand "out of every tribe of the sons of Israel," sealing twelve thousand out of each of the twelve tribes. These are the Israelites who will keep the commandments of God during the great tribulation (Rev. 12:17; 14:12). Altogether, one hundred forty-four thousand faithful Israelites will be sealed on their foreheads. I do not know what kind of seal this will be, but it will be a mark recognizable to the angels sent to judge the earth. This is God's way of preserving His chosen Israelites while He is executing His judgment upon the earth.

D. Joseph gaining double portions

In verses 6 and 8 we see that Joseph gains double portions (cf. 1 Chron. 5:1-2; Ezek. 48:4-5). Because Manasseh, one of the two sons of Joseph (Gen. 48:5), and Joseph (Gen. 48:8) stand for two tribes, Joseph will still have the double portion of the birthright (1 Chron. 5:1-2) during the millennium (Ezek. 48:4-5).

Reuben was the firstborn of Israel, but due to his sinfulness he lost his birthright and Judah prevailed above his brothers (1 Chron. 5:1-2). Hence, the tribe of Judah is mentioned here first.

E. Dan being omitted

In Rev. 7 Dan is omitted. In the account here, as in 1 Chronicles chapters two through nine, the tribe of Dan is omitted because of their idolatry (Judg. 18:30-31; 1 Kings 12:29-30; 2 Kings 10:29; cf. Gen. 49:17). However, Dan will still be counted during the millennium (Ezek. 48:1) because of Jacob's blessing upon him, that Dan might still be one of the tribes by the salvation of the Lord (Gen. 49:16-18).

II. The rapture of the redeemed ones of the church

In addition to the chosen remnant of Israel, God has another people — the redeemed saints of the church (Rev. 7:9-17). In this insertion we see a vision revealing how God preserves His redeemed saints throughout all the tribulations. The way God preserves the chosen remnant of the children of Israel is to seal them and to leave them on earth. While the Israelites are God's earthly people, the Christians are God's heavenly people. God promised to give Abraham people like the stars of the heavens and like the sand of the seashore (Gen. 22:17). The heavenly people, the Christians, are the stars, and the earthly people, the Israelites, are the sand of the seashore. In order to preserve His earthly people, God seals them and keeps them on earth. He will not take them from the earth to the heavens. However, God's way of preserving His redeemed saints is not to keep them on earth but to take them away by means of rapture. The rapture will not only occur once or be just of one kind. There will be at least two or three kinds of raptures. Eventually, all the redeemed saints in the church will be raptured from earth to heaven. The insertion in this vision concerning the church gives us an overall view from the time of rapture until eternity. In other words, Revelation 7 ends with eternity. For eternity, the whole church will be under God's care and under the Lamb's shepherding.

A. Beginning before the sixth seal

God's rapture of His redeemed saints will begin with the first overcomers, comprising the man-child in 12:5 and the firstfruits in Rev. 14:1-6. This should be before the sixth seal, because the sixth seal will be the beginning of supernatural calamities executed by God as the "trial which is about to come on the whole inhabited earth, to try them who dwell on the earth" (Rev. 3:10). God's rapture of His redeemed saints will continue with the two witnesses in Rev. 11:12, the late overcomers in Rev. 15:2, and the harvest in Rev. 14:14-16 (the majority of the believers who will pass through most of the great tribulation), until all the saints will be raptured to participate in God's care and the Lamb's shepherding for eternity.

B. A great, innumerable multitude

Verse 9 says, "After these things I saw, and behold, a great multitude which no one could number." The great multitude consists of the redeemed ones throughout all generations from the nations, who are innumerable and who constitute the church (Rev. 5:9; Rom. 11:25; Acts 15:14, 19).

C. From nations, tribes, people, and tongues

This great multitude consists of those who have been purchased with the blood of the Lamb from every nation, tribe, people, and tongue (Rev. 7:9; 5:9) to be the constituents of the church.

D. Having come out of the great tribulation with palm branches in their hands

Speaking of the great multitude mentioned in verse 9, one of the elders said, "These are those who come out of the great tribulation and have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb" (v. 14). The great tribulation here is different from the great tribulation mentioned in Matt. 24:21. The great tribulation here is tribulation in a general sense. All of God's redeemed people have passed through certain tribulations, sufferings, persecutions, and afflictions. No Christian can avoid these things. In our spirit, we Christians are a people of enjoyment. But, on the physical side, we are a suffering people. But one day we shall come triumphantly out of the great tribulation and stand before the throne and before the Lamb. All those in the great multitude in this chapter have palm branches in their hands, signifying their victory over tribulation (cf. John 12:13), which they have undergone for the Lord's sake (v. 14). Palm trees are also the sign of satisfaction through watering (Exo. 15:27). Palm branches were used for the feast of tabernacles, in which the people of God rejoiced for the satisfaction of their enjoyment (Lev. 23:40; Neh. 8:15). The feast of tabernacles was a type which will be fulfilled by this great multitude of God's redeemed ones enjoying the eternal feast of tabernacles. This multitude "shall flourish like the palm tree" in the temple of God (Psa. 92:12-13).

E. Standing before the throne and before the Lamb

"Standing before the throne" indicates that the great multitude of the redeemed ones must have been raptured to the presence of God. "Standing before the Lamb" corresponds to "stand before the Son of Man" (Luke 21:36), which clearly indicates the rapture. Since this is mentioned immediately after the opening of the sixth seal, it also implies that the rapture of the believers should begin to transpire before the sixth seal. The record in verses 9 through 17 composes in a general way a scene from the rapture of the believers to their enjoyment in eternity.

F. Clothed in blood-washed white robes

In verse 9 we see that this great multitude is "clothed in white robes," for they "have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb" (v. 14). Robes, being plural, signify the righteousness of their conduct. White indicates that their conduct is pure and approved by God through the washing in the blood of the Lamb.

G. Praising God and the Lamb

Verse 10 says, "And they cried with a loud voice, saying, Salvation to our God who sits upon the throne and to the Lamb." The loud praise mentioning only salvation indicates that the praisers are the saved ones. The great multitude, those who are saved, are grateful for God's salvation.

H. Serving God day and night in His temple

Verse 15 says, "Therefore they are before the throne of God, and serve Him day and night in His temple." This great multitude has come out of the great tribulation into a heavenly state, into the temple of God where they serve Him day and night.

I. God spreading His tabernacle over them

Verse 15 also says that "He who sits upon the throne shall spread His tabernacle over them." The great multitude will enjoy God and His care. He will spread His tabernacle over them, meaning that He will make His dwelling place their dwelling place. God will cause all His redeemed ones to dwell together with Him. In a very positive sense, God will even be our dwelling place, our tabernacle. As He spreads Himself over us as a tabernacle, we shall enjoy Him to the uttermost. Christ is the tabernacle of God (John 1:14), and the New Jerusalem as the ultimate enlargement of Christ will be God's eternal tabernacle (Rev. 21:2-3) where all God's redeemed ones will dwell with Him forever. God will overshadow them with Himself as embodied in Christ. Christ, as the embodiment of God, will be their tabernacle. The portrait in verses 15 through 17, similar to what is portrayed in Rev. 21:3-4 and Rev. 22:3-5, is of eternity.

J. The Lamb shepherding them and guiding them to springs of waters of life

Verses 16 and 17 say, "They shall not hunger any more, neither shall they thirst any more, neither shall the sun beat upon them, nor any heat; for the Lamb in the midst of the throne shall shepherd them and shall guide them to springs of waters of life." Here we see that the Lamb will shepherd them and guide them to springs of waters of life. Shepherding includes feeding. Under the shepherding of Christ, "I shall not want" (Psa. 23:1). The Lamb will also lead us to springs of waters of life. In eternity, we shall drink of many springs and enjoy many different waters. How good this is!

K. God wiping away every tear from their eyes

Verse 17 also says that "God shall wipe away every tear from their eyes." Tears are a sign of dissatisfaction. Waters of life are for satisfaction. Because the Lamb will supply them with waters of life for their satisfaction, they will have no tears of dissatisfaction. The waters of life shall be supplied, and the water of tears shall be wiped away. There will be no tears, hunger, or thirst — just enjoyment.

L. The angels, the elders, and the four living creatures worshipping God

Verses 11 and 12 say, "And all the angels stood around the throne and the elders and the four living creatures, and fell on their faces before the throne and worshipped God, saying, Amen, blessing and glory and wisdom and thanks and honor and power and strength be to our God forever and ever. Amen." This is similar to the word in Luke 15:7, where there is joy in heaven over one sinner who repents. Here the angels say, "Amen" to the redeemed ones' praise of salvation.

In this chapter we see how God takes care of His people. When He is about to judge the earth, He will seal His earthly people and rapture His heavenly people. While the chosen remnant of Israel is sealed, the believers are regenerated, for God has put Himself into us as life. He does not simply put a mark on our forehead; He puts Himself into us as life. Thus, we are not His earthly people but His heavenly people. Would you rather be a regenerated Christian or a sealed Israelite? We Christians do not have this seal — we have God in us, which is much better. Unlike the chosen remnant of Israel, we shall not remain on earth. Rather, we shall be preserved by being taken away to the presence of God. We shall be in that eternal state enjoying God's divine and eternal care and also enjoying the Lamb's eternal shepherding. How pleasant that will be! The sealed remnant of Israel will be the better people, but we shall be the best people.

However, if we would be taken away to God's presence, we must be mature. If we are still tender and unripe, God will not take us away. Instead, He will leave us in the field to suffer until we have ripened. While all the church people will be taken away, there is nonetheless a condition, the condition of maturity and of ripeness. We all must ripen and mature. This is the condition of our being taken away from this earth by God. This is fully and adequately revealed in the book of Revelation. In chapter fourteen, for example, we clearly see the firstfruits and the harvest. In that portion of the Word, we are told definitely that after the field has ripened, the harvest comes. Thus, we all need to grow. It is impossible for people to grow in religion because there is no food or nourishment there. In a sense, there is not even a field there. The only place where Christians can grow today is the church, for in the church is the pasture — Christ — for the flock to feed on and receive nourishment for growth. By the Lord's sovereign grace, we are enjoying this pasture. We all can testify that since coming into the church life, we have been in the green pasture with the tender grass. Day by day we are feeding on the tender grass which is Christ Himself. Here in the church life we feed on Christ and grow. Here we take all the tender nourishment into our being. Thank the Lord that we are growing day by day. Praise the Lord that we are growing and that He is preparing us for our rapture. We do not expect to face the tribulation. We are growing into maturity, growing into rapture, growing into His presence. One day, we shall be there.

The Seven Eyes of the Lamb for the Building of God

Many Christians realize that, according to Rev. 5, Christ, the slain Lamb, is worthy, and a number of Christian hymns praise the Lord for His worthiness. However, most hymns on the worthiness of the Lamb praise Christ for being worthy because of His redemption. It is difficult to find a hymn on the Lord's worthiness that goes beyond redemption. It is absolutely scriptural to say that the Lamb is worthy because He has redeemed and purchased us. However, according to Revelation 5, the worthiness of the Lamb is not mainly due to His redemption, but to His being able to open the secret of God's economy. Christ is worthy to open the seals of God's economy because He has defeated the enemy and has redeemed us. As the One who has brought God's authority to the earth, He is the victorious, overcoming Lion of the tribe of Judah and the Lamb who has accomplished a full redemption for God's chosen people. Therefore, He is completely qualified and positioned to open the mystery of God's economy. This is one of the crucial points in Revelation chapter five.

The seven eyes, the seven lamps, and the seven Spirits

Another major point in Revelation 5 is that Christ as the Lion-Lamb has "seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God" (v. 6). These seven eyes are also the seven lamps burning before the throne of God (4:5). Hence, in these chapters we have the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits. Revelation is the only book in the Bible that mentions the seven Spirits. But here we see that these seven Spirits are the seven eyes of Christ, and that the seven eyes of Christ are the seven lamps before the throne of God.

The first mention of the seven lamps is in Exo. 25, where we see seven lamps on the one lampstand. But if we only had Exodus 25, we would not know the meaning of the lampstand and its seven lamps. According to our human understanding, we would simply say that the seven lamps are for the intensification of the light. Although this is both right and logical, the significance of the seven lamps is much deeper than this. Why did the lampstand not have six or eight lamps? In Zechariah we see something further regarding the seven lamps, for in Zech. 3 and Zech. 4 we see that the seven lamps are the seven eyes (Zech. 3:9; 4:2,10). Although Zechariah 4:10 speaks of the seven eyes of the Lord, the connection between the eyes, the lamps, and the Spirit is not made clear. Thus, we need to proceed further to the book of Revelation, where we see the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits. We need to see the progression from Exodus through Zechariah to Revelation. In Exodus we have the seven lamps, in Zechariah we have the seven eyes, and in Revelation we have the seven Spirits. In Exodus the seven lamps are mentioned, but nothing is said of the eyes or of the Spirits. In Zechariah we have the seven lamps and the seven eyes with an obscure mention of the Spirit. But in Revelation we have the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits.

As we pointed out in message eight, the lampstand is a symbol of the Triune God. The gold symbolizes the divine substance of the Father; the stand, which is the embodiment of the gold, symbolizes Christ as the embodiment of the Father; and the seven lamps symbolize the Spirit as the expression of Christ who is the embodiment of the Father. Therefore, we have the Father (the gold) as the substance, the Son (the stand) as the embodiment, and the Spirit (the lamps) as the expression. We have the substance, the embodiment, and the expression. In Exodus we cannot see that the seven lamps are the seven Spirits of God. We must go on to Zechariah and eventually to Revelation before we can see this. As a recovery of divine revelation, this is absolutely new.

God's building

The lamps in Exodus 25 are for the building up of the tabernacle, especially for the move in the tabernacle. Without light, it is impossible to move. The light is for the move, and the move is for God's building. The seven lamps, therefore, are for the building up of the tabernacle, God's dwelling place on earth.

The seven lamps in Zechariah 3 and 4 are for the recovery of God's building. The principle is the same in the rebuilding of the temple as it was in the building of the tabernacle. The same is true of the book of Revelation. If we approach this book with a shortsighted view, we shall be unable to see that the seven Spirits, which are the seven eyes of the Lamb and the seven lamps before God's throne, are for God's building. But if we have an overall view, we shall see that the seven Spirits are absolutely for God's building. Revelation begins with the seven local churches and it ends with the New Jerusalem. Although this book contains the judgment of God, this judgment is not the goal. Judgment is not for judgment; it is for God's building. The New Jerusalem, God's eternal dwelling place, issues out of this judgment. Thus, the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits are all for God's building. We are here for the realization of God's eternal goal in His divine building.

The seven eyes for God's building

Zechariah 3:9 says, "For behold the stone that I have laid before Joshua; upon one stone shall be seven eyes: behold, I will engrave the graving thereof, saith the Lord of hosts, and I will remove the iniquity of that land in one day." This verse reveals that the seven eyes are not only the seven eyes of the Lord, but also the seven eyes of the stone. This stone was engraved in one day for the iniquity of God's people. The engraving of the stone was its being dealt with by God's righteousness on the cross for our redemption. Christ, the redeeming Lamb, is also the stone on which are the seven eyes. These seven eyes are the seven lamps for God's building. When we come to the book of Revelation, we see very clearly that the seven lamps are the seven eyes of the Redeemer, and that the seven eyes of the Redeemer are the seven Spirits of God for the building of God.

According to the book of Revelation, the Lord Jesus has seven burning eyes. Although these eyes are for searching, judging, refining, and enlightening, they are ultimately for transfusing us with His essence, His divine element. How can the Lord's divine essence be wrought into our being? By the transfusing of His seven eyes. Whenever we are searched, purged, purified, refined, and judged by the flaming eyes of Christ, we gain something of Him. Not only is some element of ourselves purified, but some element of Him is transfused into us. The natural things are purged, and the divine things are transfused into us. Through this process, the Lord builds us together and carries out God's building. The book of Revelation is not mainly for searching and judging; it is for producing and building up the New Jerusalem, the ultimate issue of this book. As a result of the transfusing of the seven eyes of Christ, the New Jerusalem will be built up. The seven eyes of Christ look at God's chosen people, enlightening, searching, judging, purifying, and refining them, and ultimately infusing them with whatever He is. By infusing us with His essence, He makes us the same as He is and, by so doing, He transforms us from being natural into being the same as He. Then we become the transformed material for the building up of the New Jerusalem. We all must see that the seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God and of the Lamb, are absolutely for God's building.

The Spirit being the eyes of Christ

These seven Spirits are the Holy Spirit. Being the Holy Spirit, They are not separate from Christ. According to doctrine, the Spirit and Christ are two separate individuals, but according to experience, They are one. Just as a person and his eyes are one, so Christ and the Spirit are one. When someone looks at you, he looks at you with his eyes, and when his eyes look at you, he looks at you. It is ridiculous to say that the eyes are separate from the person himself. In our experience, the Spirit is the eyes of Christ. Those who attempt to argue about this may hold mental doctrines, but they lack experience. If they put all their doctrines into experience, they will find that it is wrong to separate Christ from the Spirit. The Triune God is not experienced in a doctrinal way. While some may attempt to define or explain Him, when we experience the Triune God, we realize that the Son is the embodiment of the Father and that the Spirit is the expression of the Son. They are one. The Father is embodied in the Son and the Son is realized, expressed, and experienced as the Spirit.

The experience of the Triune God for God's building

The Triune God is for God's building. In order for God to have the building, the Triune God must be dispensed into us. This is fully revealed in the book of Revelation. The controlling view in the Bible is God's building. If you have not seen God's building, it will be difficult for you to rightly understand the Bible. The whole Bible is related to God's building, and God's building is accomplished by the Triune God being dispensed into us. As we come to the book of Revelation, we must hold this view. If we do, we shall be able to understand this book and see that it is not mainly a book of judgment but a book for God's building.

God's judgment for His building

The accomplishment of God's building requires His judgment. God's judgment is carried out by Christ's being the One with seven flaming eyes to burn, enlighten, search, purify, and refine us. Eventually, these flaming eyes infuse us with all that He is, metabolically transforming us into His being. The whole city of New Jerusalem will have the same essence and appearance as God. As we have pointed out several times, the appearance of God sitting on the throne in chapter four is of jasper (Rev. 4:3), and the appearance of the New Jerusalem, especially its wall, in chapter twenty-one is also of jasper (Rev. 21:11, 18-19). Thus, the essence and appearance of God and of the city are the same. How can this be? Only by having the very God wrought into us. The essence of God is wrought into us by means of transfusion.

Do not ignore the seven eyes, the seven Spirits. Revelation is not a book of one Spirit; it is a book of the seven Spirits, the seven eyes of Christ, whereby the redeeming, overcoming, and building Christ transfuses Himself into all His members. While He is transfusing Himself into us, He is searching, enlightening, judging, purifying, and refining us. In this way He transforms us. How we need to see this vision! This is God's recovery today.

The governing vision in the Bible

Although the Bible cannot be improved, the truth in the Bible is progressive, and the recovery of the divine truths in the Bible is even more progressive. Four hundred years ago, very few of the truths in God's Word had been recovered, but this is not so today. The recovery of the truths is richer now than it was just twenty years ago. This does not mean that the Bible changes or that we change the Bible, for no one has the right to do that. It means that the Lord is moving on in the recovery of His truths.

God's recovery of the truths in the Bible is absolutely for His building. The first year I was opposed was 1958, the very year that I was first burdened to minister on God's building. That was the cause of all the opposition and criticism. Nevertheless, I only care for God's building. I thank the Lord that He has vindicated the recovery. Man's word means nothing; only what God says counts. God has said that He is for His building. The entire Bible is for this. At the very beginning, in the book of Genesis, we have the tree of life and the flowing river producing gold, bdellium (pearl), and precious stones (Gen. 2:9-12). At the end of the Bible, in Revelation, we have a city built with these precious materials, with gold, pearl, and precious stones (Rev. 21). Hence, the whole Bible is for God's eternal purpose of securing His eternal dwelling place by dispensing Himself as life into His chosen ones. This is the governing vision.

God's desire

If we have any other view, it means that we are shortsighted. God is not seeking holiness or spirituality. He is seeking the building. In 1958 I said that our spirituality must be tested by God's building, that is, by the church life. When I said that God does not care for our spirituality, the opposers took this sentence out of context and condemned me, saying, "Listen! Brother Lee says that God does not care for spirituality. Isn't this heretical?" If you keep this statement in its context, it is not at all heretical. God does not care for our spirituality; He cares for how much we have been built into His church. Individualistic spirituality is cancerous. Any individualistic member of the church is a cancer in the Body of Christ. You may say that you are spiritual or holy, but your spirituality and holiness must be tested by the church life. Perhaps your holiness is individualistic. If it is, then it is not healthy, for true holiness is for God's building.

God does not want a group of individualistic spiritual persons; He wants the building. He does not desire a heap of precious stones for exhibition. God, of course, needs individuals, but He needs them as the material for the building. All the individual stones must be put into the building. This is not a mere doctrine but a serious fact. Have you been built into God's building? Or are you one who is saved, who fears God, who loves the Lord, and who prays, but who says, "I don't care about the church"? Do you say, "It is not good to talk so much about the church; it is better to be alone with the Lord and read the Bible"? You may enjoy this, but God is not as fond of it as you are. He wants you to lose yourself. You must be enlightened, searched, purified, refined, and then infused with all that He is that you may be transformed into a precious stone for God's building. This is God's desire today.

Why did God call the Israelites out of Egypt? It was for the building up of His dwelling place on earth. Eventually, the tabernacle as God's dwelling place on earth became the center of the people of Israel. Whenever they were wrong with the tabernacle, they lost all their wars. But whenever they were right with the tabernacle, they were victorious. After the Israelites entered into the good land, they built the temple as the center of their life as God's people. When they were right with the temple, they were right with God, and when they were wrong with the temple, they were wrong with God. This is a brief abstract of the Old Testament. What do we have in the New Testament? We have the church today and the New Jerusalem in the future. Therefore, a brief abstract of the whole Bible is God's building.

The need for an intensified infusion

Because of the darkness and degradation of this age, God has been forced to exercise Himself as the sevenfold intensified Spirit to enlighten us. We need the searching and enlightening of the seven Spirits. Perhaps you have been clinging to doctrines for years. What good have they done for you? The degraded recovered church has so much doctrine, but what did the Lord say of them? He said that they were neither hot nor cold, but rather that they were lukewarm and therefore qualified for being vomited out of His mouth (Rev. 3:16). This is the condition of the church in Laodicea.

We thank the Lord that the light concerning His building is brighter today than it has ever been. The light is shining over us. It is not a matter of being an individualistic overcomer in some minor things, but of being an overcomer in the major things for God's building. Many Christians do not understand the meaning of overcoming in Revelation. To overcome in this book means to overcome degraded Christianity. We must overcome the degraded situation of the so-called church for the sake of God's building. Read the book of Revelation again and again and you will see that its governing view is the building of God. We must keep this before us. Everything is for God's building. The revelation of Christ in chapter one is for the building; the seven epistles to the seven churches in chapters two and three are for God's building; and the scene in heaven after Christ's ascension and the vision of Christ as the Lion-Lamb in chapter five are also for God's building. Christ's having the seven eyes which are the seven lamps and the seven Spirits of God is not that we might be individualistically holy, but is absolutely for God's building. May the Lord have mercy on us. In this age, we are in a dark night and we need the intensified sevenfold Spirit as the seven shining lamps to enlighten, search, purge, and refine us. Ultimately, what we need is the Lord's intensified infusion. We need to be infused with all that He is so that we might become transformed stones for God's building.

The Scene in Heaven After the Opening of the Seventh Seal and the Judgment Upon the Earth, the Sea, the Rivers, the Sun, the Moon, and the Stars — the First Four Trumpets

We come in this message to Rev. 8:1-12. In this chapter we have the opening of the seventh seal (vv. 1-2), the scene in heaven after the opening of the seventh seal (vv. 3-5), and the sounding of the first four trumpets (vv. 6-12).

I. The seventh seal

The seventh seal, which will begin before the great tribulation, consists of the seven trumpets, for the seven trumpets are the content of the seventh seal. If we would understand the prophecy of this book, we must realize that the secret of God's economy is sealed with seven seals. As we have pointed out, the scroll in chapter five is the new testament enacted by Christ with His precious blood. This new testament is the scroll of God's economy sealed with seven seals which are the contents of the scroll. We have seen that the first four seals are not consecutive but simultaneous and that the fifth and sixth seals are consecutive. The seventh seal includes everything from after the sixth seal to eternity future. Thus, the seventh seal, consisting of the seven trumpets, is all-inclusive. As we shall see, the seven bowls are a part of the seventh trumpet. The seventh seal consists of the seven trumpets, and the seventh trumpet consists, in part, of the seven bowls. Both the seventh seal and the seven trumpets run to eternity. The seventh trumpet will close this age and usher in the kingdom, the new heaven, and the new earth.

Some may have the concept that the seven trumpets follow the seven seals and that the seven bowls succeed the seven trumpets. This concept is natural. In understanding the Word, we should have no trust in our natural concepts. Rather, we must forsake them and come to the Lord, saying, "Lord, show us Your way." Since 1933, I have been helped by Brother Nee's study on the book of Revelation. Due to the natural concept which was deeply embedded in my thinking, I believed that the seven trumpets were the continuation of the seven seals and that the seven bowls followed the seven trumpets. This concept constantly troubled me. I studied and studied until one day the light came and I saw that the seventh seal contains the seven trumpets. The seven trumpets are the equivalent of the seventh seal. They actually are the seventh seal. The content of the first four seals is the four horses, the content of the fifth seal is the cry of the martyred saints, the content of the sixth seal is God's answer to the cry of the martyred saints, and a warning to the dwellers on the earth, and the content of the seventh seal is the seven trumpets.

Like the first four seals, the first four trumpets, which are not yet the direct judgment on men, form one group. The first trumpet consists of a judgment on the earth with the trees and all the grass, as occurred in Egypt (Exo. 9:18-25); the second, a judgment on the sea with the living creatures and ships; the third, a judgment on the rivers and springs of waters, as occurred in Egypt (Exo. 7:17-21); the fourth, a judgment on the sun, the moon, and the stars, to darken them, as also occurred in Egypt (Exo. 10:21-23). By the judgments of these four trumpets, the third part of the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the hosts in the heavens are damaged, thus causing them to be no longer good for man's living. Before the seven trumpets, there will already have been a judgment on the earth and on the hosts of the heavens at the sixth seal (Rev. 6:12-14). The extent of the damage of that judgment will not be as definite as the damage of the first four trumpets. At the fifth trumpet Satan and Antichrist will collaborate to torment men; at the sixth trumpet there will be a further judgment on men as the two hundred million cavalry kill the third part of men; and at the seventh trumpet there will be many things — the eternal kingdom of Christ, the third woe comprising the seven bowls, the judgment of the dead, the giving of reward to the prophets, to the saints, and to the Godfearing people, and the destruction of the destroyers of the earth. At the seventh trumpet, there will be further judgments on the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the sun through the seven bowls (Rev. 16:1-21). These will be the most severe judgments of God upon the earth and heaven.

We must forsake the concept that the seven seals, the seven trumpets, and the seven bowls are consecutive. No, to repeat, the seven trumpets are the content of the seventh seal, and the seven bowls are a part of the seventh trumpet. This is the key to understanding the prophecy of this book. Only God could have written the book of Revelation because only He has the wisdom to compose it in such a marvelous way. Who else has the wisdom to write a book with such signs and symbols as that of the four horses which fully cover the history of the past twenty centuries? That the seven seals, the seven trumpets, and the seven bowls are not consecutive reveals God's wisdom in writing this book. If we do not have the light to see this arrangement, although we may read Revelation again and again, we shall still be confused.

II. The scene in heaven after the opening of the seventh seal

In 8:1-2 we see the seven trumpets brought in as the answer to the saints' prayer in the fifth seal. The seals are opened secretly, whereas the trumpets are sounded openly.

A. Silence in heaven about half an hour

When the Lamb "opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven about half an hour" (v. 1). This silence indicates solemnity. At the opening of the seventh seal, all heaven becomes silent because the age is about to be changed. The period before the opening of the seventh seal was the age of God's toleration. For the sake of His purpose of preaching the gospel to produce the churches to fulfill His eternal plan, God has been tolerating the sinful situation on earth. But with the opening of the seventh seal, the age of toleration is terminated and another age is brought in. This is the age of God's wrath. God is now coming in to intervene in the rebellious and sinful situation on earth. Because this occasion is so solemn, heaven becomes silent, an indication that something serious is about to take place.

B. Christ ministering in heaven as the high Priest

1. As "another Angel"

In the midst of this solemn scene, another Angel appears (v. 3). This angel is Christ. When Christ was revealed as walking in the midst of the churches, He was revealed as the Son of Man, and when He spoke to the churches, He declared all His qualifications. But in the administration of God's judgment upon the earth, Christ is the Angel standing on the position of One who has been sent by God. In a very positive sense, Christ is everything; He is whatever the economy of God needs. Revelation specifically describes Christ as "another Angel," indicating that He is not a regular or common angel but a special Angel. As we pointed out in message twenty-one, in the Old Testament Christ was called the "Angel of the Lord," who was God Himself (Gen. 22:11-12; Exo. 3:2-6; Judg. 6:11-24; Zech. 1:11-12; 2:8-11; 3:1-7). In Genesis 22 the Angel of the Lord spoke to Abraham, and in Exodus 3 the Angel of the Lord appeared to Moses. Christ is another Angel; He is the unique, special Angel.

2. Offering the saints' prayers to God

Verse 3 says, "And another Angel came and stood at the altar, having a golden censer, and much incense was given to Him that He should add it to the prayers of all the saints upon the golden altar which was before the throne." The first altar in this verse refers to the altar of burnt offering (cf. Exo. 27:1-8), and the golden altar before the throne refers to the incense altar (cf. Exo. 30:1-9). The golden censer signifies the prayer of the saints, which is brought to God by Christ as the other Angel. The incense signifies Christ with all His merit to be added to the prayers of the saints that the saints' prayers might be acceptable to God upon the golden altar. At the opening of the seventh seal there will still be "saints" praying on the earth.

In this scene in heaven after the opening of the seventh seal, Christ appears as another Angel to execute God's administration over the earth in the way of ministering to God as the High Priest with the prayers of His saints. As He offers the prayers of His saints to God, He adds His incense to them. Verse 4 says that "the smoke of the incense went up with the prayers of the saints out of the hand of the Angel before God." The "smoke of the incense" indicates that the incense is burnt to God with the prayers of the saints. This implies that by the incense which is added to them the prayers of the saints become effective and acceptable to God.

3. Casting fire to the earth to execute God's judgment upon the earth

Verse 5 says, "And the Angel took the censer and filled it with the fire of the altar and cast it to the earth; and there were thunders and voices and lightnings and an earthquake." This implies the answer to the prayers of the saints, especially the prayer in the fifth seal mentioned in Rev. 6:9-11 and the prayer mentioned in Luke 18:7-8. The prayer of the saints in this chapter must be for the judgment of the earth which opposes God's economy. The answer to the saints' prayers is the execution of God's judgment upon the earth by the following seven trumpets. To cast fire to the earth is to execute God's judgment upon the earth. Therefore, the thunders, voices, lightnings, and the earthquake come as signs of God's judgment.

God's judgment upon the earth is the answer to the prayers of the saints with Christ as the incense. Although the sixth seal has been opened and the seven trumpets are ready to be sounded, nothing happens until Christ comes to offer the saints' prayers to God with Himself as the incense. At that time, there are thunders, voices, lightnings, and an earthquake. This indicates that while God has the intention of executing His judgment upon the earth, there is still the need of the saints to cooperate with Him with their prayers. God needs His saints to pray that He might execute His judgment. If you read Luke 18, you will see that the Lord Jesus says that at a certain time the saints on earth will cry to God to come in to deal with the situation and to vindicate Himself. At the end of this age, people will be so rebellious against God that they will even declare to the whole universe that they are God. While God has been tolerating this, some of the faithful saints will no longer bear it and will pray, "O sovereign Lord, how long will You bear with this? Will You tolerate this rebellion forever? How long will it be before You come in to vindicate Yourself and avenge us? How long will it be until all the earth will know that You are the Lord?" Eventually, there will be a need for this kind of prayer. I believe the time is coming when we shall all be pressed to pray like this. I cannot charge you to pray this way today because you are not under this kind of pressure. But one day the pressure will be upon us and we shall be burdened to pray in this way. This will indicate that the end is at hand because our spirit will not tolerate the situation any longer. Then we shall pray to the Lord to vindicate Himself and to let all the rebellious ones know that He is God. When we pray like this, the Angel sent by God will minister to God with our prayer, adding to it Himself as the incense. God will certainly answer this prayer, and there will be thunders, voices, lightnings, and an earthquake. That will simply be the beginning of God's judgment upon this rebellious earth. This will take place at the opening of the seventh seal when Christ, the other Angel, will minister as our High Priest to bring to God our prayers mingled with His incense, and will be the One sent to execute God's judgment on earth.

Verse 6 says, "And the seven angels who had the seven trumpets prepared themselves to trumpet." The seven trumpets were given to the seven angels (v. 2). But it is after the prayers of the saints in verses 3 through 5 have been answered that the seven angels are prepared to trumpet. God's will in heaven requires the saints' prayer to carry it out on earth. The offering of the saints' prayers to God by Christ brings in the seven trumpets.

III. The first trumpet — the judgment upon the earth

Verse 7 says, "And the first trumpeted: and there was hail and fire mingled with blood, and it was cast to the earth; and the third part of the earth was burnt up, and the third part of the trees were burnt up, and all green grass was burnt up." When the angels begin to trumpet, everything in the universe will be turned upside down. The first trumpet will damage "the third part of the earth." Note that this verse does not say "a third," but "the third part." This means that a certain part of the earth, "the third part," will be damaged. While the whole earth is sinful, some parts of the earth are particularly hellish, devilish, satanic, demonic, and evil. I do not believe that the third part of the earth will include the United States. The United States is sinful, but, unlike other parts of the earth, it is not devilishly sinful. Those regions of the earth that are so sinful will be "the third part." Many people need to hear this word and be warned by it not to be so evil against God that their region becomes "the third part" of the earth, the region that will be fully damaged by God's judgment. According to Revelation 9, God's judgment of "the third part" will still be used to warn the rebellious world to repent.

IV. The second trumpet — the judgment upon the sea

In verses 8 and 9 we see the second trumpet: "And the second angel trumpeted: and as it were a great mountain burning with fire was cast into the sea; and the third part of the sea became blood, and the third part of the creatures which were in the sea and which had life died, and the third part of the ships were destroyed." Here we see that the second trumpet will damage "the third part of the sea." Some powerful nations are developing their navies in order to expand their ocean territory. Their aim in doing so is to commit evil against God. In the same principle as the judgment upon the earth in the first trumpet, God will judge the third part of the sea. Verse 9 especially mentions the destruction of the third part of the ships. That part of the sea which is defiled by evil against God will be damaged by God's judgment.

V. The third trumpet — the judgment upon the rivers and upon the springs of waters

Verses 10 and 11 describe the third trumpet: "And the third angel trumpeted: and a great star fell out of heaven, burning like a torch, and it fell upon the third part of the rivers and upon the springs of waters. The name of the star is called Wormwood; and the third part of the waters became wormwood, and many men died from the waters because they were made bitter." Again we see that the third part of the rivers and springs of waters will be damaged. Water is crucial to human life. The opposers of God and those who practice evil against Him still enjoy God's creation. Although they partake of the water of God's creation, they continue to oppose God. One day, God will seem to say, "Now I shall cause wormwood to fall out of heaven into your water and it will become bitter." God's judgment here still has a limitation, for it is limited to the third part of the rivers and springs.

VI. The fourth trumpet — the judgment on the heavenly hosts

In verse 12 we read of the fourth trumpet, the judgment on the heavenly hosts: "And the fourth angel trumpeted: and the third part of the sun and the third part of the moon and the third part of the stars were smitten, so that the third part of them might be darkened and the day should not appear for the third part of it, and the night likewise." After the judgment of the earth, the sea, and the rivers, God's judgment will smite the third part of the heavenly hosts, damaging the third part of the sun, the moon, and the stars. The part of the sun to be damaged will be that part which shines upon the evil nations. God knows this part, and it will be darkened.

The Judgment Upon Men — the Fifth Trumpet

My burden in this message concerns the great tribulation. Rev. 8:13 says, “And I saw, and I heard an eagle flying in mid-heaven, saying with a loud voice, Woe, woe, woe, to those who dwell on the earth because of the remaining sounds of the trumpet of the three angels who are about to trumpet.” The three woes of the last three trumpets (Rev. 9:12; 11:14) will be the woes of the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21). As we shall see, they will occur in the last half of the seventieth week (Dan. 9:27), a period of three and one-half years (Dan. 7:25; 12:7 Rev, 12:14), forty-two months (Rev. 11:2; 13:5), or twelve hundred and sixty days (Rev. 11:3; 12:6).

I. The beginning of the great tribulation

Many Christians think that the great tribulation will last seven years. Some believe this because they understand the Bible in a careless and traditional way. But the word of the Bible is very accurate, and we must understand it in the way of being enlightened. No word in the Bible is wasted; every word is meaningful and accurate.

Let us now consider Dan. 9:24-27. Verse 24 says, “Seventy weeks are determined upon thy people and upon thy holy city, to finish the transgression, and to make an end of sins, and to make reconciliation for iniquity, and to bring in everlasting righteousness, and to seal up the vision and prophecy, and to anoint the most Holy.” The people mentioned here are Daniel’s people and the holy city refers to Jerusalem. According to the Bible, a week here does not mean seven days but seven years. If you say that the seventy weeks refer to seventy periods of seven days, you will never have the proper interpretation of this passage.

Verse 25 says, “Know therefore and understand, that from the going forth of the commandment to restore and to build Jerusalem unto the Messiah the Prince shall be seven weeks, and threescore and two weeks: the street shall be built again, and the wall, even in troublous times.” Here we see “seven weeks” and then “threescore and two weeks.” Verse 26 continues, “And after threescore and two weeks shall Messiah be cut off, but not for himself: and the people of the prince that shall come shall destroy the city and the sanctuary; and the end thereof shall be with a flood, and unto the end of the war desolations are determined.” The reference to Messiah’s being “cut off” points to Christ’s being crucified on the cross. The destruction of the city and the sanctuary refers to the destruction of the temple and of the city of Jerusalem under Titus in A.D. 70.

Verse 27 concludes, saying, “And he shall confirm the covenant with many for one week: and in the midst of the week he shall cause the sacrifice and the oblation to cease, and for the overspreading of abominations he shall make it desolate, even until the consummation, and that determined shall be poured upon the desolate.” Here we see that the prince will confirm the covenant for one week and that in the midst of the week, that is, after three and one-half years, he will cause the sacrifice and oblation to cease. This means that he will discontinue the worship of God.

These seventy weeks constitute four hundred ninety years beginning from the twentieth year of Artaxerxes, who issued the decree to rebuild the wall of Jerusalem (Neh. 1:1; 2:1). The first seven weeks, forty-nine years, were for the finishing of the rebuilding of the street and wall of Jerusalem. From then until Christ was “cut off” were sixty-two weeks, four hundred thirty-four years. Since the end of the sixty-nine weeks, there has been a long period of suspension. Eventually, the time of the last week, the last seven years, will come. This is the source of the thought that the great tribulation will last seven years.

As we shall now see, this concept is not accurate. The last seven years, the last week, will be the time when Antichrist will make an agreement with the Jewish people. During the first half of these seven years, Antichrist will be friendly to the Jews. But after three and one-half years, he will change his mind. Although he formerly agreed that the Jews could worship God in the temple by offering the sacrifices, he will change his mind, set himself up as God, erect an image of himself in the temple, and force people to worship him and his image. Then he will begin to mistreat the Jews. Thus, the first half of the seven years will not be a time of tribulation, for during that time Antichrist will be friendly to the Jews. According to Daniel 9:27, “in the midst of the week” Antichrist “shall cause the sacrifice and the oblation to cease,” commanding the Jews to cease worshipping God and offering sacrifices to Him. Antichrist will also erect the abomination of desolation in the Holy Place. According to Revelation, the abomination of desolation will be the image of Antichrist set up as an idol in the temple.

Let us now turn to Matt. 24, a chapter which covers this matter of the great tribulation. In verse 15 the Lord Jesus said, “When therefore you see the abomination of desolation, spoken of through Daniel the prophet, standing in the holy place.” When will this be? It will not be in the beginning of the seven years but in the middle of the seven years, at the time when Antichrist will discontinue the worship of God, set himself up as God, and put his image in the temple, which, in the eyes of God, is the abomination. Then in verse 21 the Lord predicted, “For then there shall be great tribulation, such as has not occurred from the beginning of the world until now, nor ever shall be.” By this we see that the great tribulation, which begins in the middle of the last seven years, will be only three and one-half years long. The traditional teaching that it will be seven years long is inexact, and we should not follow it. It does not provide the proper details for the study of prophecy. Those who hold the traditional teachings speak of the seven years, neglecting that it is in the midst of the seven years that Antichrist will change his mind and that this will bring in the great tribulation lasting three and one-half years, the second half of the final week.

We also need to consider some verses from Revelation 12. Verses 5 and 6 say, “And she brought forth a son, a man-child who was about to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod; and her child was caught up to God and to His throne. And the woman fled into the wilderness, where she has a place prepared by God, so that they might nourish her there a thousand two hundred and sixty days.” The one thousand two hundred and sixty days are the equivalent of three and one-half years. After the man-child is raptured, there will be a period of three and one-half years, the last half of the seventieth week, the time during which the image of Antichrist will be set up in the temple. Then verses 7 through 13 reveal that there will be war in heaven, that the dragon and his angels will be cast out of heaven to the earth, and that the dragon will persecute the woman who brought forth the man-child. Verse 14 says, “And the two wings of the great eagle were given to the woman that she might fly into the wilderness into her place, where she is nourished for a time, and times, and half a time from the face of the serpent.” This “time, and times, and half a time” refers to the final three and one-half years. In this portion of the Word we see that Satan will be cast down from heaven to earth at the beginning of the last half of the seven years. This also proves that, strictly speaking, the great tribulation will last three and one-half years and not seven years.

Further proof of this is in Revelation 11:2, which says, “And the court which is outside of the temple cast out and do not measure it, because it has been given to the nations, and they will trample under foot the holy city forty-two months.” In this verse we are told that the city of Jerusalem will be trodden by the Gentiles for forty-two months. The Gentiles who will trample the holy city will be Antichrist and his armies. This corresponds to the prophecy in Daniel 9 where Antichrist breaks the covenant, sets himself up as God, and commands people to worship him. That will also be the time when he will trample the holy city. This will be during the great tribulation. Therefore, the great tribulation will start at the beginning of the last three and one-half years when Satan is cast down from heaven to earth. As we have seen, this is mentioned clearly in chapter twelve.

II. Satan fallen out of heaven to the earth

With this as a background, we come now to the fifth trumpet. Revelation 9:1 says, “And the fifth angel trumpeted, and I saw a star out of heaven fallen to the earth, and to him was given the key of the shaft of the abyss.” The star here refers to Satan, who will be cast down from heaven to earth. The angels are likened to stars (Job 38:7; Rev. 12:4). As the archangel, Satan was the daystar (Isa. 14:12, Heb.). In Luke 10:18 we see the judgment upon him. Here, and in Rev. 12:9-10, we see the execution of that judgment. The abyss is the dwelling place of the demons (Luke 8:31, translated deep in KJV).

When will Satan fall out of heaven to earth? The answer to this question is in chapter twelve. That chapter reveals that after the man-child is raptured to heaven, he will fight against Satan and seem to say to him, “Satan, now that we are here, there is no place for you. You must be cast down.” According to that chapter, Satan will fall from heaven at the beginning of the last three and one-half years. We have pointed out that this is a strong proof that the great tribulation will not begin before then, for, prior to this, Satan will still be in heaven.

When Satan falls from heaven to earth, the key of the abyss will be given to him that he may open the abyss to release the demon-possessed locusts to torment man for five months.

III. The locusts

Because the great tribulation begins with the first woe at the sounding of the fifth trumpet, it includes neither the sixth seal nor the first four trumpets. The sixth seal will be a supernatural calamity, and the first four trumpets will be judgments upon the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the heavenly hosts. But these judgments are not a part of the great tribulation. The first four trumpets are very severe, but they do not injure man directly. Following them will come the great tribulation which will directly torment man. Prior to the fifth trumpet, man will not be touched directly; only the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the heavenly hosts will be directly damaged. This may be considered as a preliminary to the coming great tribulation. God's judgment of the earth, the sea, the waters, and the heavens is a warning to man. At the time of the fifth trumpet, man himself will be directly tormented.

Verses 3 through 5 say, "And out of the smoke came forth locusts to the earth, and authority was given to them as the scorpions of the earth have authority. And it was said to them that they should not injure the grass of the earth, nor any green thing, nor any tree, except men who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads. And it was given them, not that they should kill them, but that they should be tormented five months; and their torment was as the torment of a scorpion when it strikes a man." The locusts here are not like the locusts in Exo. 10:12-15, because they have tails like scorpions and stings and they injure man (v. 10). They must be demon-possessed ones, because they come out of the smoke which issues from the dwelling place of the demons (v. 2). The plagues of the first four trumpets are not directly upon man, whereas the woes of the last three trumpets are. Those who will not be injured by the demon-possessed locusts are the Israelites who have the seal of God on their foreheads (Rev. 7:3-8).

In verses 7 through 10 we see the characteristics of these locusts. Verses 7 and 9 are very similar to Joel 2:4-5, 25, and 1:6, words spoken concerning Israel. This, with the fact that the Israelites need to be sealed by God to escape the injury of the locusts, may indicate that the woe of the fifth trumpet is especially upon the Israelites. Verse 7 says, "And the likenesses of the locusts were like horses prepared for war, and on their heads as it were crowns like gold, and their faces were as faces of men." These locusts are like an army, similar to the locusts mentioned in the book of Joel, where we are told that God will send an army of locusts. While the locusts in Revelation 9 are not to be identified with the locusts in Joel, they are related. The likenesses of the locusts are like horses prepared for war, and they have crowns like gold on their heads. Their hair is as the hair of women, and their teeth are like the teeth of lions (v. 8). They have breastplates as breastplates of iron, and "the sound of their wings" is as "the sound of the chariots of many horses rushing into battle" (v. 9).

Verse 10 says that "they have tails like scorpions, and stings." In the Bible, scorpions signify demons, the evil spirits that follow Satan. In Luke 10:19 the Lord said, "Behold, I have given you the authority to tread upon serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy." We, the believers in Christ, have overcome the scorpions, Satan's demonic servants. Verse 10 also says that "in their tails is their authority to injure men five months." Although the torment of the first woe will damage man directly, the time will still be limited by God to a period of five months. The torment will be so excruciating that "in those days men shall seek death and shall by no means find it; and they shall long to die, and death flees from them" (v. 6). During these five months, those who are tormented by these dreadful, demon-possessed locusts would rather die than live. Surely the shaking of the earth and the blackening of the sun are nothing compared to this. This is the first of the three woes announced by the eagle from mid-heaven in 8:13.

IV. The Antichrist

Speaking of the locusts, verse 11 says, "They have a king over them, the angel of the abyss: his name in Hebrew is Abaddon, and in Greek he has the name Apollyon." The angel of the abyss is the beast, the Antichrist, who will come out of the pit of the abyss (Rev. 11:7; 17:8). In Hebrew the angel of the abyss is called Abaddon, which means destruction, as in Job 26:6; 28:22 and Proverbs 15:11. In Greek he will have the name Apollyon, which means destroyer. The Antichrist will do much destroying (Dan. 8:23-25).

Antichrist is a special person, being the composite of two persons: the spirit of Caesar Nero and the body of another Caesar of the Roman Empire. Nero began the persecution of the Christians in the first century, and his is the spirit that is kept in the abyss until the day it will be released to enter into the body of another Caesar. The Caesar into which this spirit will enter will be killed and will be resurrected with the spirit of Caesar Nero. This will be Antichrist. Satan will then release the locusts which will be organized as an army under the rule of the beast, Antichrist, who will be their king. The locusts will proceed to torment for five months those who do not have the mark of God on their foreheads.

According to the Bible, the universe is composed of three sections: the heavens, the earth, and the region under the earth (Phil. 2:10). At the beginning of the great tribulation, that is, after the first half of the last seven years, Satan will be cast down from heaven to earth and, simultaneously, Antichrist, the king of the devilish, demon-possessed locusts, will be released from the abyss and ascend to meet with Satan. Thus, a devilish spirit will meet a devilish man. Although they will come from two directions, Satan from above and Antichrist from beneath, they will have one goal — to torment the mankind created by God. These two figures will come together and will collaborate in tormenting mankind as much as possible. We shall consider Antichrist in more detail when we come to chapters thirteen and seventeen.

As we have seen, the great tribulation will last three and one-half years. Before that time, there will be the supernatural calamities of the sixth seal and the first four trumpets. But according to Matthew 24:22, the great tribulation will be limited to a short time which will begin only after Antichrist erects the abomination of desolation in the Holy Place.

Where will you be when the great tribulation is taking place? Do not say, "As long as I am among the heavenly people, I will be all right." As God's heavenly people, we do not have the mark that is on the chosen remnant of the Israelites. The heavenly people should not be there, for God has no intention of leaving us on earth with the remnant of Israel. God's intention is to rapture us to the heavens. However, if we would be raptured to the heavens, there is a condition to fulfill — we must be mature. God's way of dealing with the Israelites differs from His way of dealing with the believers. If I were an Israelite, I might cry to God, and He might have mercy on me and put a mark upon my forehead. Then I would be preserved during the tribulation. But God does not seal the believers; instead, He raptures them away to the heavens. But for this, they must be mature.

My burden in this message is to point out when the great tribulation will begin and what will bring it about. As we have seen, Satan will be cast from heaven to earth and will have the key to open the abyss and release the demon-possessed locusts. At the same time, the beast, Antichrist, the king of the locusts, will be released from the abyss. The army of locusts will then torment people for five months. The torment will be so severe that people will want to die, but death will flee from them. Today, people seek to avoid death, yet death pursues them. At that time, they will desire death, but it will elude them. What suffering that will be! What great tribulation! However, this is only the first woe, the beginning of the great tribulation. The two other woes are yet to come.

The three woes of the last three trumpets constitute the great tribulation. The first woe will be the fifth trumpet, the second woe will be the sixth trumpet, and the last woe will be the seven bowls of the seventh trumpet. The three woes are introduced very solemnly. As we have seen, 8:13 says, "Woe, woe, woe, to those who dwell on the earth because of the remaining sounds of the trumpet of the three angels who are about to trumpet." Revelation 9:12 says, "The first woe is past; behold, two woes are yet to come after these things." Finally, introducing the last woe, 11:14 says, "The second woe has passed; behold, the third woe is coming swiftly." The sixth seal and the first four trumpets are merely a preliminary to the suffering of the great tribulation.

This great tribulation probably along with the supernatural calamities of the sixth seal and the first four trumpets is the "trial which is about to come on the whole inhabited earth, to try them who dwell on the earth" (3:10). The Lord promised the church in Philadelphia that He would keep them out of this hour. If you would be kept from the hour of trial, you must be ready to be raptured from this earth. We should not talk lightly concerning the Lord's coming or the rapture of the saints. According to the pure Word, if we want to be raptured before the tribulation, we must be mature and ready for Him to take us from this earth. If we are mature and ready, then whatever happens on earth will not affect us. Praise the Lord that we have a way of escape.

Further Judgment Upon Men — the Sixth Trumpet

Apart from the introduction (Rev. 1:1-8) and the conclusion (Rev. 22:6-21), the book of Revelation has three main sections. In 1:19 the Lord said to John, “Write therefore the things which you have seen, and the things which are, and the things which are about to take place after these things.” Thus, these three main sections are “the things seen” (1:9-20), “the things present” (2:1—3:22), and “the things to come” (4:1—22:5). In chapter one, there are the seven golden lampstands with Christ in their midst, which are “the things seen,” and in chapters two and three there are the seven churches, which are “the things present.” The section on “the things to come” begins with the scene in heaven in chapter four. As chapter five reveals, Christ comes into this scene as the unique One worthy to open the secret of God’s economy. As we have pointed out, the first four seals give a brief history of the world from Christ’s ascension until His coming back, portraying it as a four-horse race. Near to the end of this age, at the time of the fifth seal, the martyred saints will cry to God. The sixth seal will be God’s answer to their cry. He will shake the universe as a warning to those who dwell on the earth and as an introduction to the coming great tribulation. Following this, the seven trumpets will come in as the content of the seventh seal. The first four trumpets will be God’s judgment upon the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the heavenly host. Due to this judgment, the earth will no longer be a suitable place for man to dwell. Because the calamities of the sixth seal and the first four trumpets do not directly injure man, but only damage the earth, making it no longer suitable for man to live in, they are not a part of the great tribulation. As we pointed out in the last message, the fifth trumpet marks the beginning of the great tribulation. The great tribulation mentioned in Matt. 24:21 is composed of the three woes of the fifth, sixth, and seventh trumpets.

In the fifth trumpet mankind will be directly tormented. At the sounding of the fifth trumpet, Satan will come down from heaven to earth and Antichrist will come up from the abyss, and together they will cause men to be tormented for five months. Unlike the foregoing calamities, the torment of the demon-possessed locusts will directly touch man’s being. As we have seen, at the beginning of the last three and one-half years, Antichrist will change his mind about the Israelites, will discontinue the worship of God, and will torment the man created by God for Himself. This will be the beginning of the great tribulation. This torment, as the first woe, will be so severe that no one will be able to bear it. Following this, there will be the second woe, which is the sixth trumpet.

I. The loosing of the four angels

The second woe is more complicated than the first. It is not as clear cut as the woe of the fifth trumpet, which is caused by the collaboration of Satan and Antichrist. Revelation 9:13 and 14 say, “And the sixth angel trumpeted, and I heard a voice out of the four horns of the golden altar which is before God, saying to the sixth angel who had the trumpet, Loose the four angels which are bound at the great river Euphrates.” The blood of the atonement was put upon the four horns of the golden altar, the incense altar, for atonement, that is, for redemption (Lev. 16:18). The voice which comes “out of the four horns of the golden altar” indicates that God’s judgment upon man is based on the redemption of Christ; it is because men do not believe in Christ’s redemption that God sends His judgment.

Verse 12 says, “The first woe is past; behold, two woes are yet to come after these things.” Since it is at the fifth trumpet that Satan falls from heaven to earth to damage the earth and persecute the people of God for three and one-half years (6, Rev. 12:10, 12-17) and that at the same time (the last three and one-half years — Rev. 13:5-7; 11:7), Antichrist comes up out of the abyss to collaborate with Satan to torment people, persecute the saints, and blaspheme God, and since it is also in the same last three and one-half years that the holy city Jerusalem is given to the Gentiles for destruction (Rev. 11:2), the woe of the fifth trumpet must be the beginning of the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21). The second woe of the sixth trumpet and the third woe of the seventh trumpet (Rev. 8:13; 9:12; 11:14) must also be parts of the great tribulation, which, probably with the damage caused by the sixth seal and the first four trumpets, will be the trial on all the earth’s dwellers (Rev. 3:10). The two woes spoken of in verse 12 are the sixth and seventh trumpets (Rev. 9:13-20; 11:14-15).

Undoubtedly, the four angels “which are bound at the great river Euphrates” are four evil, fallen, rebellious angels who followed Satan. The Bible does not indicate how long they have been bound there. Verse 15 says, “And the four angels were loosed who had been prepared for the hour and day and month and year, that they might kill the third part of men.” Many understand this word according to their natural concept, thinking that “the hour and day and month and year” refer to the specific year, month, day, and hour when the killing of the third part of men will take place. But this is not the meaning. “For the hour and day and month and year” means that the four angels have been prepared unto the hour, plus the day, plus the month, plus the year — altogether thirteen months, one day, and one hour — for the killing of men. The killing will firstly last one hour, then one day, then one month, and then one year. It will be so severe and terrifying that, firstly, people will not expect it to last more than an hour. When, after an hour, it has not ended, they will expect it to last only for a day. After that, they will expect that surely it will not be prolonged more than a month. After a month transpires, then people will think that it could only continue for a year. Altogether, the time of this horrible killing will be thirteen months, one day, and one hour.

During World War II many of us suffered. When that war broke out on July 7, 1937, I was traveling in China. The next morning I read an express edition of the newspaper which said that war had broken out the previous night. From that time on, we began to suffer the war, firstly for four years. Then came the bombing of Pearl Harbor and the United States entered the war. As our suffering continued, we expected the war to end at any time. The news came again and again that after a certain period of time the war would probably end, but it still dragged on and we kept counting the days. During the war, I was imprisoned by the invading army for thirty days. As I suffered there in prison, I not only counted the days but also the hours, expecting surely that the next hour would see my release. After thirty days I was released, but I still had no freedom, and we continued to count the days. From this experience we can understand the meaning of “the hour and day and month and year” in 9:15. When the dreadful killing mentioned in chapter nine comes upon man, people will expect the slaughter to cease in an hour, then in a day, then in a month, and then in a year. The four angels that are bound by the river Euphrates are prepared to kill man for such a long period of time — for an hour, a day, a month, and a year.

II. Two hundred million cavalry troops

Verse 16 says, “And the number of the cavalry troops was two hundred million. I heard their number.” In order to kill the third part of men, the four angels will use two hundred million cavalry troops. The number of these horsemen is nearly that of the total population of the United States. The two hundred million horsemen will come from the rising of the sun (Rev. 16:12), that is, from the east. The place on earth that produces the most horses is Mongolia. The Western world has invented so many modern methods of transportation, but these cavalry from the east will not use them. Instead, they will use horses. Travel on horseback does not require modern roads or railways. Perhaps each horseman will bring an extra horse for food and drink. It would be easy for these cavalry troops to hide themselves or to scatter when some would attack them by bombs, and it would be quite difficult to trace them. These troops will move westward, killing as they go. The riders on these horses will have “breastplates of fire and of hyacinth and of sulphur” (v. 17), and the heads of the horses will be as the heads of lions, and out of their mouths proceed fire, smoke, and sulphur (v. 17). Verse 19 says, “For the authority of the horses was in their mouth and in their tails; for their tails are like serpents having heads, and with them they injure.” The horses’ tails here, being like serpents, are more poisonous than the locusts’ tails, which are like scorpions (v. 10). The locusts will only torment men for five months (vv. 5, 10), whereas the horses will kill the third part of men (vv. 15, 18). This means that the woe of the sixth trumpet will be more severe than that of the fifth.

As we have seen, the four angels will be loosed to stir up the two hundred million cavalry troops. These troops will move from east to west and, passing through the Euphrates, will come to the richest region on earth — the Middle East. Rev. 9:14 says that the four angels were bound at the great river Euphrates, and Rev. 16:12 says, “And the sixth poured out his bowl upon the great river Euphrates; and its water was dried up, that the way of the kings from the rising of the sun might be prepared.” These two hundred million cavalry troops from “the rising of the sun” will join the war at Armageddon (Rev. 16:10-16; 19:17-18).

Revelation 16:13 and 14 say, “And I saw, out of the mouth of the dragon, and out of the mouth of the beast and out of the mouth of the false prophet, three unclean spirits like frogs; for they are spirits of demons, doing signs, which go forth to the kings of the whole inhabited earth, to gather them to the war of the great day of God Almighty.” As verse 16 of the same chapter says, “And they gathered them to the place which in Hebrew is called, Armageddon.” This drying up of the Euphrates will be the result of the pouring out of the sixth bowl. By the mention of the river Euphrates in chapters nine and sixteen, we see that the two hundred million cavalry troops of the sixth trumpet are related to the sixth bowl of the seventh trumpet for the gathering of the earthly armies to Armageddon. These two hundred million cavalry troops from the east and the armies from the north and the west will be gathered together there. God will assemble all the armies on earth to one place. This will be His wisdom. This will occur at the sixth bowl, which is a part of the woe of the seventh trumpet. At the same time, Satan will be doing His best to damage people, and Antichrist will be persecuting God’s people and even fighting against God, doing everything possible to corrupt the earth. Thus, God will send His judgments upon the earth. During the last three and one-half years, Satan and Antichrist will do their best to injure people, and God will judge the earth. What a dreadful place the world will be at that time!

After the Euphrates has been dried up, the eastern kings and their armies will cross over it on their way to Armageddon. Armageddon is quite close to Jerusalem. As we have seen, all the armies of the world will be gathered there to seize the riches that are in that region. Many of the nations in this area are rich because of the oil resources. But this is God’s divine arrangement, and it will be His way of gathering the grapes into the winepress (Rev. 14:17-20; 19:15). As Rev. 19:15 says, Christ will tread “the winepress of the wine of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty.” In chapter fourteen, we firstly have the firstfruit (Rev. 14:1, 4), secondly, the harvest (Rev. 14:15, 16), and, thirdly, the treading of the winepress (Rev. 14:18, 19). Verse 20 says, “And the winepress was trodden outside the city, and blood came out of the winepress up to the bridles of the horses for a thousand six hundred stadia.” (A stadion, the singular of stadia, was equal to about six hundred feet.) The assembling of the armies of the world at the place called Armageddon is likened to the gathering of grapes into a winepress. All the grapes will be gathered into the great winepress of God’s wrath. When Christ comes back to earth, He will destroy these evil fighters, treading the winepress of the fury of God. The result will be a river of blood as high as a horse’s bridle and approximately two hundred miles long.

We have seen that the thirteen months, the one day, and the one hour will probably be the traveling time of the two hundred million cavalry men from the “rising of the sun” to the Middle East. As they travel, they will kill the third part of men. This slaughter will be terrible. When these cavalry troops reach the Euphrates, immediately prior to the battle at Armageddon, the sixth bowl will be poured out. This record is most serious. It is an account of history written before it happens. The writers of this world are shortsighted, superficial, and ignorant. The Lord Himself has written this account of human history. I do not say this lightly.

I have been saved for more than fifty years. During the years since 1918 I have spent much time observing the world situation and studying the prophecies in the Bible. I can testify that no time has been closer to the fulfillment of the New Testament prophecy than today. Today’s world news is focused on the Middle East. Much of the daily news concerning the Middle East matches what is spoken in the Bible. This means that the Lord is keeping His word and that prophecies are now being fulfilled. Undoubtedly, we are very close to the time of the sixth seal, the main aspect of which is the great earthquake. In this life-study, however, we are not interested in merely satisfying our curiosity in knowing prophecy. The Lord is opening our eyes for the sake of His recovery. We are not blind, veiled, or covered. If there are any Christians who know the will of God and the economy of God, we must be they. What then should we do? We should simply say, “Amen, Lord. Amen to Your Word, Your doings, Your economy, and Your move. Lord, Amen to the secret You have shown us.”

As an elderly brother, let me say a word to the young people: You are much blessed to be brought into the Lord’s recovery in your youth. In your lifetime surely many things prophesied in the Bible will come to pass. Once we have considered all the matters covered in these life-study messages, none of us can say that he has not seen something, or that he does not know about the coming days. Young people, although fifty years ago I spent much time to study books on prophecy, I did not have the clear vision that you have today. Praise the Lord that the veils have been taken away, that God’s economy has been made manifest to us, and that we now have a clear view of what is coming. In these days the view, the light, and the vision are so clear. We know what will take place in the fifth seal, what will transpire at the sixth seal, and what will be the first four trumpets. We know that the fifth trumpet as the first woe will mark the beginning of the great tribulation and that the sixth trumpet as the second woe will be the continuation of the tribulation. We have seen that the sixth trumpet will be related to the sixth bowl. In brief, we have been given a clear view of the future. After the time of the sixth seal, there will be nothing good for us on the earth. Be prepared! The earth will be shaken, the sea will be damaged, the rivers will be made bitter, and the heavenly hosts will be darkened. Eventually, Satan and Antichrist will collaborate to torment people for five months. Following this, at the sounding of the sixth trumpet, the two hundred million horsemen will begin to ride through a great part of the earth, killing the third part of mankind as they gallop along their way. Finally, all the armies of the world will be gathered together at a place called Armageddon. Then the grapes, the armies of the world, will be trodden by Christ in the winepress of God’s wrath.

III. The continuation of the great tribulation

It has been clear that the second woe of the sixth trumpet is a continuation of the great tribulation (Rev. 14:11:14). Verse 20 says, “And the rest of men, who were not killed by these plagues, did not repent of the works of their hands, that they should not worship demons and idols of gold and silver and brass and stone and wood, which can neither see nor hear nor walk; and they did not repent of their murders, nor of their witchcrafts, nor of their fornication, nor of their thefts.” (Notice that verse 20 does not say that the idols here cannot speak, as in Psa. 115:5 and Psa. 135:16, because, according to Rev. 13:15, the image of the Antichrist will speak.) These verses indicate that the intention of God’s judgment is that men may repent. Although God intends that, through His judgment, men would repent, these verses show that they will not repent.

Christ Coming to Take Possession of the Earth

In the past several messages we have been considering the content of the seven seals. In the book of Revelation, the number seven is composed two ways: four plus three and six plus one. Both the seven seals and the seven trumpets are composed this way. With the number seven there is addition but no multiplication. The number twelve, however, is the product of three times four. The seven seals mean that in God's complete move His creatures will be brought to the Triune God. God's creature — man — will also be brought to the unique God. Thus, the seven seals indicate God's complete move. The seven seals, which are God's complete move on the earth and in the universe, are the content of God's economy. The purpose of God's move is to bring His creatures, signified by the number four, to the Triune God, and to bring man, signified by the number six (man was created on the sixth day), to the unique God. The seven seals actually bring God's creation to Himself. The fall of man, which was caused by Satan, has kept man from God. While the fall was a subtraction, God's economy today is an addition. The fall caused man to go away from the unique God, but God's economy and His move bring man back to Himself.

Many Christians do not understand the matters pertaining to the sixth seal and the first four trumpets. The sixth seal and the first four trumpets of the seventh seal are mainly concerned with the shaking and the judgment of the earth and the heavenly host. As a result of this shaking and judgment, the earth will no longer be a suitable place for man to live in peacefully. The sixth seal and the first five trumpets are closely related to one another in time, for there is not much of an interval between them. Some, counting from the time of the first horse, say that the great tribulation will last seven years. Those who do have not seen that Revelation covers the whole history of mankind since Christ's ascension. Their interpretation leaves a great gap between the ascension of Christ and the end time. To have such a gap, approximately two thousand years in length, is altogether illogical according to the Lord's prophecy, because it was in the first century that He prophesied of the things to come (Rev. 1:19). Furthermore, the scroll in chapter five is a full revelation of God's economy. As such, it must include the preaching of the gospel. The preaching of the gospel for the producing of the church is a great item in God's economy. Because it is illogical for there to be such a great gap in this book, we believe that the four horses of the first four seals are an outline of human history from Christ's ascension until the end of this age.

By careful study we have also seen that the last seven years will probably not begin with the time of the sixth seal, because the period from the sixth seal until the fifth trumpet, which is the beginning of the great tribulation, will be a very short time. It will not be three and one-half years. The great tribulation will last three and one-half years, the second half of the last seven years. If you count the last seven years from the sixth seal, then the time from the sixth seal to the fifth trumpet must be at least three and one-half years. Logically speaking, this is too long. Between the sixth seal and the fifth trumpet there will be four trumpets, the judgments on the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the heavenly hosts. Although it is less severe, the sixth seal, which will be the shaking of the earth and the damaging of the heavenly host, is the same in principle as that of the first four trumpets.

The sixth seal and the first four trumpets are an introduction, a preliminary, to the great tribulation. In none of these calamities will God directly touch man. This will not occur until the torment of the woe of the fifth trumpet and the slaughter by the two hundred million cavalry troops of the woe of the sixth trumpet. After the woe of the sixth trumpet, there will be the seven bowls as the last woe and as a part of the content of the seventh trumpet. The sixth bowl, which is related to the sixth trumpet, will be for the gathering for war at Armageddon. That war will be the great winepress of the fury of God trodden by the Lord (Rev. 14:19-20; 19:15) when He comes down to earth to fight against Antichrist and to cast him into the lake of fire (Rev. 19:11-21). This should be at the same time the seventh bowl will be poured out upon the air to bring in the greatest earthquake and the greatest hail which will be the last plague and the end of the great tribulation.

In this message, we come to Rev. 10:1-11, an insertion between the sixth and seventh trumpets. If we would understand the book of Revelation, we must know which sections are continuations and which are insertions. When we were on chapter seven, we pointed out that it is an insertion between the sixth and seventh seals, showing God's preservation of His people. That chapter shows the vision of the marking of the remnant of Israel and the vision of the rapture of God's redeemed ones. Chapter ten is part of an insertion between the sixth and seventh trumpets. This insertion is composed of three visions: the vision of Christ coming to take possession of the earth (Rev. 10:1-7), the vision of the treading of the earthly Jerusalem by Antichrist and his armies (Rev. 11:1-2), and the vision of the two witnesses (Rev. 11:3-12).

We must read and study the book of Revelation until we know and are able to recite all the main facts. We should be able to summarize every chapter. In chapter one there are the seven lampstands with Christ walking among them; in chapters two and three the seven churches; in chapter four the heavenly scene; in chapter five Christ as the One worthy to open the scroll; in chapter six there are the six seals; in chapter seven an insertion showing two visions regarding God's preservation of His people; in chapter eight there are the first four trumpets; in chapter nine the fifth and sixth trumpets; in chapter ten Christ coming to take possession of the earth; in chapter eleven the two witnesses; in chapter twelve the man-child; in chapter thirteen the beast; in chapter fourteen the firstfruit, the worship of the beast, the harvest, and the winepress; in chapter fifteen the overcomers on the glassy sea; in chapter sixteen the seven bowls; in chapter seventeen the religious Babylon; in chapter eighteen the material, political Babylon; in chapter nineteen the wedding feast of the Lamb and the war at Armageddon; in chapter twenty the binding of Satan, the millennial kingdom, the last rebellion of mankind, and the judgment at the great white throne; and in chapters twenty-one and twenty-two the new heaven and the new earth with the New Jerusalem.

I. Christ as another Angel

Let us now consider the details of Rev. 10:1-11. In this portion of the Word we have a clear vision of Christ coming to take possession of the earth. In this chapter Christ is "another strong Angel," like the One in Rev. 7:2; 8:3 and Rev. 18:1.

A. Coming down out of heaven

Verse 1 says that John saw another Angel "coming down out of heaven." Christ is now coming down out of heaven. This vision is a hint that, before the seventh trumpet, Christ is still on His way to earth.

B. Clothed with a cloud

Verse 1 also says that Christ is "clothed with a cloud." He is not yet "on the cloud," as in Rev. 14:14 and in Matt. 24:30; 26:64 (Gk.). To be "on the cloud" is to come openly, whereas to be "clothed with a cloud" is to come secretly. This indicates that even after the sixth trumpet, which will be in the midst of the great tribulation, Christ will still be coming secretly, not openly, until He will be seen by all the tribes of the earth, as mentioned in Rev. 1:7 and in Matt. 24:30. By the time of chapter ten, Christ's coming is still secret. Even at the time of the sixth bowl, during the gathering at Armageddon, Christ will give the warning that He is coming as a thief (Rev. 16:15). He will be wrapped in the cloud until chapter fourteen, when He will sit on the cloud and His coming will become public. By this we see that the general teaching that Christ will come before the great tribulation is inaccurate.

C. The rainbow upon His head

In this vision Christ has a "rainbow" upon "His head." Here the rainbow indicates that Christ in His judgment upon the earth and in His coming to take possession of it will keep the covenant God made with Noah concerning the earth (Gen. 9:8-17). It also indicates that He is the One who will execute judgment according to the One sitting on the throne with the rainbow round about it.

D. His face like the sun

Verse 1 also says that "His face was as the sun." Surely here, close to His coming to the earth openly, He will not be like the morning star which appears before the darkest time prior to dawn.

E. His feet like pillars of fire

When Christ comes to take possession of the earth, His feet will be "as pillars of fire." Here, pillars indicate steadfastness (Jer. 1:18; Gal. 2:9). Fire indicates the holiness of God (Exo. 19:18; Heb. 12:29), according to which Christ will execute His judgment upon the earth.

F. Having in His hand a little open scroll

In this chapter Christ has "in His hand a little opened scroll" (vv. 2, 8). This "little opened scroll" is the scroll in Rev. 5:1, which only Christ is worthy to open and which He took out of the hand of God (Rev. 5:5, 7). Now it is in His hand. In Rev. 5:1 it was sealed; in Rev. 10:2 and Rev. 10:8 it is opened. The scroll has been opened because all the seals have been loosed. Here, being only a part of the scroll, it is called a little scroll. Because the main part of the scroll has been revealed, the last part is considered a little scroll.

G. His right foot placed on the sea and the left on the land

Verse 2 also says that “He placed His right foot on the sea and the left on the land.” To place His feet on the sea and on the land is to tread on them, and this means to take possession of them (Deut. 11:24; Josh. 1:3; Psa. 8:6). This indicates that Christ is coming down to take possession of the earth. Only He is worthy to open the scroll of God’s economy, and only He is qualified to possess the earth. In Joshua, God told the people that they would possess whatever part of the land the sole of their foot would tread upon. They were to walk through the good land, and wherever they set their feet, that would be their possession. Based upon the same principle, Christ, as another Angel sent by God, will come to tread upon the sea and the earth, for the earth and the sea have both been given to Him as His inheritance (Psa. 2:8). Although the earth and sea have been usurped by His enemy, and although He has been tolerating this for centuries, one day He will tolerate it no longer. He will come to claim His rightful inheritance.

H. Crying with a loud voice as a lion

Verse 3 says that Christ “cried with a loud voice as a lion roars.” A lion’s roaring is like the wrath of a king (Prov. 19:12; 20:2). This indicates that as the King of the earth Christ is provoked to wrath. In the Gospels, Christ spoke like a lamb, but here He roars like a lion. Chapter three mentions the word of the Lord’s endurance. Endurance means toleration. But by the time of chapter ten the Lord no longer exercises endurance. Rather, in His coming to take possession of the earth, He roars like a lion.

I. Seven thunders sealed

When Christ cried with a loud voice, “The seven thunders uttered their own voices.” The seven thunders should be the ultimate utterances of God’s wrath in full. Verse 4 says, “And when the seven thunders spoke, I was about to write; and I heard a voice out of heaven saying, Seal the things which the seven thunders spoke, and do not write them.” Today, we do not know what the seven thunders said, but one day we shall know.

J. No more delay in time

Verses 5 and 6 say, “And the Angel whom I saw standing on the sea and on the land lifted up His right hand to heaven and swore by Him who lives forever and ever, who created heaven and the things in it, and the earth and the things in it, and the sea and the things in it, that there shall be delay no longer.” The main item of the things in heaven is the angels, the main item of the things in the earth is men, and the main item of the things in the sea is the demons. After the sixth trumpet, there will be no more time of toleration in God’s judgment upon the earth. Hence, the seventh trumpet is the most serious of God’s judgments. It is God’s answer in full to the martyred saints’ prayer in 6:10.

II. The completion of God’s mystery

A. At the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet

Verse 7 says, “But in the days of the voice of the seventh angel when he is about to trumpet, the mystery of God also is finished, as He announced the good news to His own slaves the prophets.” Here we see that the completion of God’s mystery will be at the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet.

B. The trumpeting of the seventh trumpet lasting a period of days

The mention of “days” in verse 7 indicates that the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet will last a period of days.

C. The ending of the mysteries

When the seventh angel is about to trumpet, the mystery of God will be finished. In the dispensation from Adam to Moses, and from Moses to Christ, everything was unveiled, manifested, and there was no mystery. It will be the same in the dispensation of the millennial kingdom and in the new heaven and the new earth — everything will be unveiled and there will be no more mystery. But in the dispensation from Christ to the millennial kingdom, everything is a mystery. The incarnation of Christ, as the beginning of this dispensation of mystery, is a mystery (1 Tim. 3:16). Christ Himself (Col. 2:2), the church (Eph. 3:4-6), the kingdom of the heavens (Matt. 13:11), the gospel (Eph. 6:19), the indwelling of Christ (Col. 1:26-27), and the coming resurrection and transfiguration of the saints as the ending of this dispensation of mystery (1 Cor. 15:51-52) are all mysteries which were hidden in times of the ages (Rom. 16:25; Eph. 3:5; Col. 1:26). All these mysteries will be over, completed, and finished at the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet. At the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet, not only God’s judgment of wrath upon the earth, but also “the mystery of God also is finished.”

Today, the indwelling Christ and the church are a mystery. The outsiders cannot understand us because we are mysterious to them. When we say, “Praise the Lord! We have Christ in us,” people may say, “Show us.” To this, we can only reply, “I cannot show you, but I know that Christ is in me.” Christ’s dwelling in us is a mystery. When non-Christians receive too much money in change from a cashier in a restaurant, they are pleased and consider it a bargain. But when we receive extra change, we return it. This is mysterious to the cashier. The unbelievers cannot understand what kind of people we are. Do not try to check me out, for I am a man of mystery. Although today is a time of mystery, when the seventh trumpet is sounded, the mystery will be over. At the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet, Christ will be manifested and the whole earth will recognize Him. Then the cashiers will know why we, the mysterious ones, returned the extra change. Perhaps they will say, “We thought they were foolish, but now we understand.” Although they cannot understand this mystery today, one day they will understand it.

While the seals are private and concealed, the trumpets are an open, public declaration. In the opening of the seals, Christ is silent, but in the sounding of the trumpets, He is no longer silent.

D. As the good news announced to the prophets

In the seventh trumpet, “the good news” which God “announced to His own slaves the prophets,” as in Isa. 2:4; 11:1-10; 65:17-20; 66:22, will be fulfilled; that is, the kingdom in its manifestation will come (Rev. 11:15), and the new heaven and new earth with the New Jerusalem will follow (Rev. 21:1-3).

III. John prophesying again

A. Taking and devouring the little open scroll

Verses 8 and 9 say, “And the voice which I heard out of heaven was again speaking with me and saying, Go, take the little scroll which is opened in the hand of the Angel who is standing on the sea and on the land. And I went to the Angel, saying to Him to give me the little scroll. And He said to me, Take it and devour it, and it will make your stomach bitter, but in your mouth it will be sweet as honey.” The writer of this book not only received the scroll but also devoured it. To devour anything is to receive it into one’s entire being. We must receive the divine revelation, especially the book of Revelation, in this way. Both Jeremiah and Ezekiel did this (Jer. 15:16; Ezek. 2:8; 3:1-3).

B. Sweet in his mouth but bitter in his stomach

Verse 10 says, “And I took the little scroll out of the hand of the Angel and devoured it, and it was sweet as honey in my mouth; and when I had eaten it, my stomach was made bitter.” When we receive the divine revelation by devouring it, it is “sweet” in our eating, but it becomes “bitter” in our digestion, in our experience. As we read these life-study messages, they may be sweet to our taste, but in our experience they will all become bitter. Eventually, however, there will be no tears in our eyes, for we shall only enjoy the waters from the “springs of waters of life” (7:17). Today, we know the water of tears. But ultimately there will be no more tears. Instead, we shall drink of the waters from the wonderful springs. Praise the Lord that eventually there will be no bitterness, only eternal sweetness.

C. The prophecy concerning Christ’s possession of the earth

Verse 11 says, “And they said to me, You must prophesy again over many peoples and nations and tongues and kings.” After John saw the little scroll, the last part of God’s economy, and ate it, finding it sweet in his mouth but bitter in his stomach, he was charged to prophesy again. The prophecy of this book is composed of two sections. The first section is from the first seal to the sixth trumpet; it is in secret. The second section is from the seventh trumpet to the new heaven and the new earth; it is openly manifested. John has prophesied in the first section. Now he “must prophesy again,” that is, to prophesy in the second section of the prophecy of this book. John’s second prophecy concerns Christ’s possession of the earth (11:15; 12:5). This prophecy is simply the seventh trumpet which includes the bowls; the rapture of all the saints; the judgment seat of Christ; the wedding of the Lamb; Christ’s coming back with His selected army to defeat Antichrist and the false prophet; the binding of Satan; the millennial kingdom; the last rebellion of mankind under the instigation of Satan; the judgment of the dead at the great white throne for their eternal destiny; and the new heaven and new earth with the New Jerusalem. This is the seventh trumpet and John’s second prophecy. It is also the content of the little scroll, the last part of God’s economy.

The Treading of Jerusalem and the Testimony of the Two Witnesses

Chapter ten and the first part of chapter eleven are an insertion between the sixth and seventh trumpets. In chapter ten we have a clear vision of Christ coming back to take possession of the earth. In chapter eleven we have a vision crucial to the prophecy of this book. As we consider this vision, three main items must be kept in mind: the time, the place, and the people. The length of time covered in this vision is forty-two months (v. 2). These forty-two months are twelve hundred and sixty days (v. 3). Undoubtedly, this is a reference to the verses in the book of Daniel where there is mention of the three and a half years, the second half of the last of the seventy weeks (Dan. 12:7; 7:26; 9:27). In Revelation we have the fulfillment of what is mentioned in Daniel. The place in this vision is the city of Jerusalem, which, according to the book of Daniel, will be given over to the Gentiles, mainly to Antichrist. When Antichrist breaks the agreement made with Israel for seven years (Dan. 9:27), he will persecute the Jews and force them to discontinue the worship of God (Rev. 13:7; Dan. 7:21; 8:11-12). From the side of Antichrist, he will seize control of Jerusalem, but from God's side, God will give Jerusalem over to him. This means God will allow Antichrist to do whatever he desires to the city of Jerusalem.

During these forty-two months in the city of Jerusalem, there will be the two witnesses, who are the two olive trees and two lampstands and who, clothed in sackcloth (vv. 3-4), will prophesy. As we shall see, these two witnesses will not be new people, but two who were present in Old Testament times — Moses and Elijah. In Revelation 11 these two witnesses “stand before the Lord of the earth” (v. 4). As we come to this portion of the Word, we must keep these three things in mind — the time, the place, and the witnesses.

I. During the great tribulation

Verse 2 says that the nations “will trample under foot the holy city forty-two months.” At the end of this age, Antichrist will make a firm covenant with the Jews for a week (seven years), which will be the last week of the seventy weeks God appointed for the Jewish nation in Dan. 9:24-27. In the middle of the last week (that is, after the first half of the seven years), Antichrist will break the covenant and will destroy the worship of God (Dan. 9:27). Then he will blaspheme God and persecute His people for three and a half years (Rev. 13:5-7; Dan. 7:25; 12:7), which will be the forty-two months, the twelve hundred sixty days, mentioned here and the last half of the last week in Daniel 9:27, when Antichrist will also destroy the holy city Jerusalem. According to Matt. 24:15, 21, these last three and a half years must be the time of the great tribulation.

II. The treading of Jerusalem

In verses 1 and 2 we read of the treading of Jerusalem: “And there was given to me a reed like a rod, and he said, Rise and measure the temple of God and the altar and those who worship in it. And the court which is outside of the temple cast out and do not measure it, because it has been given to the nations, and they will trample under foot the holy city forty-two months.” A reed is for measuring (Rev. 21:15; Ezek. 40:3; 42:16-19), whereas a rod implies punishment (Prov. 10:13; Isa. 10:5; 11:4). Hence, “a reed like a rod” here indicates measuring with punishment. To measure is to sanctify, to preserve, and to possess (Num. 35:2, 5; Ezek. 45:1-3; 42:15, 20; 48:8, 12, 15). The altar in verse 1 refers to the golden altar of incense, because it is with the temple, not the brass altar of sacrifice in “the court which is outside of the temple” (v. 2). The court in verse 2 is on the earth. The holy city here refers to the earthly Jerusalem (Isa. 52:1; Matt. 27:53).

The apostle John was told to measure the temple of God and the altar. Undoubtedly, this is the temple and altar in the heavens. This measuring indicates that the heavens will be preserved from being damaged. During these three and a half years, heaven will be preserved because Satan will be cast out of heaven and down to earth. Because the man-child will have been raptured to heaven, there will no longer be any place for Satan there. Wherever the overcomers are, there is no room for Satan. The overcomers will fight upward into heaven, and, once there, war will rage between them and Satan. Satan will be defeated and cast down to earth. Then Christ and the overcomers will fight downward to the earth until they reach Armageddon and destroy the army of Antichrist. In the last three and a half years there will be no trace of Satan in heaven, and heaven will be wholly preserved. At that time, Satan, Antichrist, and the false prophet, a devilish company, will be on earth doing everything possible to corrupt it.

While the temple of God in heaven will be measured, “the court which is outside of the temple” will be “cast out” and not measured (v. 2) “because it has been given to the nations, and they will trample under foot the holy city forty-two months.” Here we see that the earthly temple, Jerusalem on earth, will be given over to destruction by Antichrist and the nations.

III. The testimony of the two witnesses

A. The two witnesses

Now we come to the testimony of the two witnesses (Rev. 11:3-12). All Bible students agree that one of the two witnesses is Elijah. But there is some disagreement over the identity of the other, whether he is Enoch or Moses. Some argue in favor of Enoch because, besides Elijah, he is the only one who never died. According to Heb. 9:27, it is appointed to man to die once. These who hold this view say that since Enoch and Elijah never died, they must be the two witnesses who will die once during the great tribulation. Because Moses already died, he cannot die the second time. But what about Lazarus? Contrary to this way of thinking, he died, was resurrected, and then died again. Why do we say that the two witnesses are Moses and Elijah? We say this because this claim is strongly based upon the facts of the Bible. The Bible reveals that Moses and Elijah are the two witnesses of God. What they do in 11:5 and 6 is just like the deeds of Moses and Elijah (Exo. 7:17, 19; 9:14; 11:1; 2 Kings 1:10-12; 1 Kings 17:1). Moses changed water into blood, and Elijah called down fire from heaven. Therefore, according to their ministry, the two witnesses must be Moses and Elijah. Furthermore, they appeared before the Lord on the mount of transfiguration (Matt. 17:1-3). Moses, representing the law, and Elijah, representing the prophets (Luke 16:16), both testify for God. The Old Testament is composed with writings representative of these two men, the law and the prophets. The law was given through Moses, and Elijah was the leading prophet. Hence, the Old Testament was called “the Law and the Prophets” (Luke 16:16). These two ministries have always been God's testimony. For centuries, the law represented by Moses and the prophets represented by Elijah have been God's witnesses on earth. Elijah's mission was predicted (Mal. 4:5; Matt. 17:11).

1. The two olive trees, the two lampstands, and the two sons of oil standing before the Lord of the earth

These two witnesses are the two olive trees, the two lampstands, and the two sons of oil standing before the Lord of the earth (v. 4; Zech. 4:3, 11-12, 14). Verse 4 says, “These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands which stand before the Lord of the earth.” The olive trees mentioned in verse 4 produce oil for the lamps, and the lampstands give light with the oil of the olive trees. Zechariah 4:14 says that they are the “two sons of oil, that stand by the Lord of the whole earth” (Heb.). They are called the sons of oil because they are full of oil; they are full of the Spirit. Hence, they have several names — the two witnesses, the two lampstands, the two olive trees, and the two sons of oil. In the church age, the churches are the lampstands for God's testimony (1:20), but in the last three and a half years of this age, the two witnesses will be the lampstands for God's testimony.

The thousand two hundred and sixty days in verse 3 are the forty-two months mentioned in verse 2, the period of time when Antichrist blasphemes God (13:5-6) and persecutes His people (12:6, 14). While he exercises his evil power and persecution, the two witnesses prophesy, speak for God, and testify against the evil doings of Antichrist. During the great tribulation, the persecution will be severe and fierce. Because of this, God will send back Moses and Elijah who, being full of the Spirit, will strengthen the Jews who will be forced by Antichrist to give up their religion. They will also strengthen the saints left in the great tribulation. According to Revelation 14, immediately after the rapture of the firstfruit, Antichrist will persecute God's people and compel them to worship him and his image (14:9-12). At this time, the two witnesses will strengthen God's people. Simultaneously, an angel “flying in mid-heaven” will preach “an eternal gospel” (14:6). This gospel, which is different from the gospel of life or the gospel of the kingdom, will charge people to fear God, implying that they should not persecute His people, and to worship Him, implying that they should not worship Antichrist. Thus, during the great tribulation, there will be two kinds of strengthenings: the strengthening by the two witnesses and the strengthening by the preaching of the eternal gospel.

2. Clothed in sackcloth

Verse 3 says, “And I will give authority to My two witnesses, and they shall prophesy a thousand two hundred and sixty days, clothed in sackcloth” (v. 3). Sackcloth is a symbol of mourning (2 Sam. 3:31). These two witnesses will wear funeral clothes as a warning to people. They will not preach the gospel of gladness, but will warn people to stay away from God's judgment and from the worship of Antichrist.

3. Burning and killing their enemies

Verse 5 says, “And if anyone desires to injure them, fire proceeds out of their mouth and devours their enemies. And if anyone desires to injure them, thus must he be killed.” Unlike them, we do not have this power, and in our preaching we do not kill people or burn them. But these two witnesses will be able to say, “If you attempt to injure us, you will be burned and killed.”

4. Having authority to shut heaven, to turn the waters into blood, and to smite the earth with every plague

Verse 6 says, "These have the authority to shut heaven that no rain may fall during the days of their prophecy; and they have authority over the waters to turn them into blood, and to smite the earth with every plague as often as they desire." To shut heaven that no rain may fall resembles what Elijah did (1 Kings 17:1; Luke 4:25). To turn the waters into blood and to smite the earth with plagues resembles what Moses did (Exo. 7:17, 19; Exo. 9:14; 11:1).

5. Killed by Antichrist

In His wisdom, God will allow these two witnesses to be defeated temporarily. Verse 7 says, "And when they have completed their testimony, the beast who comes up out of the abyss shall make war with them and shall overcome them and kill them." The beast here is Antichrist, who will come up out of the abyss (17:8) and out of the sea (13:1) and who will make war with the two witnesses and with the saints (13:7). Eventually, even the two strongest witnesses will be killed by the persecution under Antichrist. At that time, Antichrist will not only be fighting against man but also against God. He will continue to fight against God until Christ comes with His overcomers to fight against him directly. There will actually be a person on earth who will fight directly against God. Christ, the embodiment of God, will descend with an army of overcomers to fight against Antichrist, "the man of lawlessness" (2 Thes. 2:3). The last three and a half years will be a war between rebellious mankind under the leadership of the beast, "the man of lawlessness," and the Creator. This will force God to come and fight directly, physically, in Christ with all His overcomers.

6. Their corpses being left in the street of Jerusalem for three and a half days

Verses 9 and 10 say, "And those of the peoples and tribes and tongues and nations see their corpses three and a half days, and they will not allow their corpses to be placed in a tomb. And those who dwell on the earth rejoice over them and make merry; and they will send gifts to one another, because these two prophets tormented those who dwell on the earth." Their corpses will not be buried but will be left on the street of the great city, where their Lord was crucified, for a show of shame. The "great city" refers to "the holy city" in verse 2, which is the earthly Jerusalem and which will spiritually become Sodom and Egypt, where their Lord was crucified. In the restoration of the nation of Israel, which began in 1948, the Jews returned to their father's land in unbelief. They will become as sinful as Sodom (cf. Isa. 1:9-10; 3:9; Jer. 23:14) and as worldly as Egypt (cf. Ezek. 23:3, 8, 19, 27) until the return of Christ, their Messiah, when "all Israel will be saved" (Rom. 11:26). The most worldly people are found in the little nation of Israel. At the end of this age, in the eyes of God, Jerusalem will be as sinful as Sodom and as worldly as Egypt. Because of this, God will give up this city for the last three and a half years. God will seem to say, "Let her go. I will give her into the hands of Antichrist that he may do whatever he pleases to this sinful and worldly Jerusalem."

In A.D. 70 Titus, the prince of Rome, destroyed the city of Jerusalem. Both in Daniel and in the New Testament, that prince was a type of Antichrist. Daniel 9:26-27 considers the two as being one. If you read Daniel 9 carefully, you will see that there will be two destructions of Jerusalem. The first was by Titus and the second will be by Antichrist. In the prophecy of Daniel, the two are mentioned seemingly as one, but actually they are not one. Antichrist will destroy Jerusalem in a way similar to what Titus did. According to principle, the fulfillment of a type is always more complete than the type. This is why the Lord said that the great tribulation will be more severe than anything that has preceded it or that will follow after it. Even in Matthew 24 and Luke 21, the Lord's prophecy did not clearly distinguish the destruction of Jerusalem under Titus from that under Antichrist. The two are combined. For this reason, the seventy weeks have a long gap between the sixty-ninth and seventieth weeks. There is a long period of suspension until the time of the seventieth week arrives. After the sixty-ninth week, there was a destruction under Titus, and after the gap between the sixty-ninth and the seventieth weeks, there will be the destruction under Antichrist. But in the Bible these two destructions are mentioned nearly as one. At the time of Titus, Jerusalem was sinful, and at the time of Antichrist, it will be even more sinful. Revelation chapter eleven does not even call the city Jerusalem but "the great city," referring to it as the place where the Lord was crucified (v. 8). The Lord, of course, was crucified neither at Sodom nor at Egypt; He was crucified at Jerusalem. At the time of the persecution and destruction by Antichrist, Jerusalem will have become as sinful as Sodom and as worldly as Egypt. How we need to pray for the Jews that they might repent. Among them there will be the faithful ones — the one hundred forty-four thousand. After the rapture of the two witnesses, the time will be close to the Lord's coming with His army to defeat Antichrist in the war at Armageddon.

7. Resurrected

Verse 11 says, "And after the three and a half days, the spirit of life out of God entered into them, and they stood on their feet; and great fear fell upon those beholding them." That "they stood on their feet" indicates that they were resurrected. Their resurrection is separate from that mentioned in 1 Thessalonians 4:16. The Lord Jesus was resurrected after three days, and Lazarus was resurrected after four days. But these two witnesses will be resurrected after three and a half days.

8. Raptured to heaven

Verse 12 continues, "And they heard a loud voice out of heaven saying to them, Come up here. And they went up into heaven in the cloud, and their enemies beheld them." That "they went up into heaven" indicates that they were raptured. Their rapture is also separate from that predicted in 1 Thessalonians 4:17.

B. Their testimony

Verse 7 says that the two witnesses "completed their testimony." Their testimony will be for God as the Lord of the earth (v. 4) and against Antichrist. During the great tribulation, the two witnesses will give an adequate testimony for God and against Antichrist (Deut. 17:6; 19:15; Matt. 18:16).

While many will see the resurrection and rapture of the two witnesses, they will not repent. This indicates that we should not trust in miracles. Many hold the wrong concept that others will be convinced by miracles. But these two witnesses, who will be physically killed, will be suddenly and miraculously resurrected and raptured to the heavens. Nevertheless, the people will not repent.

IV. A great earthquake

Verse 13 says, "And in that hour there was a great earthquake, and the tenth part of the city fell; and the names of the men who were killed in the earthquake were seven thousand and the rest became terrified and gave glory to the God of heaven." The city here refers to "the great city" in verse 8, which is Jerusalem. The tenth part of the city of Jerusalem will fall because of this earthquake, and the rest of the city will be divided into three parts at the last earthquake in 16:19.

Verse 13 says that "the names of the men who were killed in the earthquake were seven thousand." The phrase "names of men" implies people of renown. They will be seven thousand famous people. At that time, many among the nation of Israel will be people of renown. Seven thousand of them will be killed by this earthquake because they take the lead not to believe in the Lord Jesus. Today, so many Jewish philosophers, doctors, political scientists, and financiers are sinful and worldly, not believing in the Lord Jesus. Today the nation of Israel is absolutely under the control of these people of renown. Nearly none of the Israelites who have a name will believe in the Lord. Recently, I heard that the government of Israel has decided to frustrate all Christian missionary work in Israel. This decision was made by the people of renown. When this earthquake strikes, it will mainly be the famous people who will be killed by it.

This portion of the Word is a window through which we can see the deplorable situation among the Jews at the end of this age. This is why a great persecution will transpire. In whatever the Arab nations attempt to do to destroy the nation of Israel today, they will not succeed, because the Lord takes care of Israel. But this does not mean that the Jews are truly for the Lord. No, they will continue to be sinful and worldly until one day God will say, "I shall give you up. Heaven will be measured, but I shall leave Jerusalem to the hands of Antichrist. He will damage this city more than Titus did." According to Zechariah 12, this persecution will bring the persecuted Jews to the point of looking to the One whom they pierced. At this juncture, Christ will come back, and all the tribes of the Holy Land will see the very Redeemer they pierced two thousand years ago. When they look upon Him, they will mourn for Him and repent (Zech. 12:10-14). But this mourning will be somewhat late, for, prior to it, many will be slaughtered by Antichrist. This is the word of prophecy. What can we do except pray for them and be prepared for that hour when the Lord will take us away?

After the seven thousand men of renown are killed by this earthquake, the rest of the people will be terrified and will give glory to God. A number of them, if not all, will repent and, at His return to them, will receive the Lord whom they pierced.

The Seventh Trumpet

In Rev. 11:14-18 there is the seventh trumpet. Without the seventh trumpet, God's economy and His move cannot be finished. By reading chapters eight through eleven, we see that the seven trumpets are truly a great thing. When the seventh trumpet sounds, many things will happen. This trumpet will sound for a period of time, and it will last for eternity, declaring, announcing, and proclaiming God's eternal plan. In each of the first six trumpets, only one item will transpire, but in the seventh trumpet many things will take place.

The seventh trumpet, as the last one (1 Cor. 15:52), comprises both negative and positive things. The negative things are the wrath of God, which consists of the last plagues of the seven bowls (Rev. 15:1; 16:1-21) as the last woe to the dwellers on the earth (Rev. 8:13; 9:12; 11:14), and the destruction of the destroyers of the earth, which transpires at the Lord's coming back to earth (Rev. 17:14; 18:1-2; 19:19—20:3). The positive things are the eternal kingdom of Christ, which is the kingdom in its manifestation (11:15, 17); the judgment of the dead, which occurs before the resurrection of the saints (v. 18); and the giving of rewards to the prophets and to the saints, which transpires at the judgment seat of Christ (2 Cor. 5:10) after the resurrection and rapture of the saints (1 Cor. 15:23, 52; 1 Thes. 4:16-17), and at the throne of Christ's glory (Matt. 25:31-34), to those who feared God's name (Rev. 14:6-7). Hence, the seventh trumpet comprises all things from the end of the great tribulation to eternity future: the last plagues of the seven bowls (ch. 16); the resurrection and rapture of the saints; the rewarding of the saints; the coming back of Christ to the earth; the destruction of the great Babylon (17:1—19:6); the marriage of the Lamb (Rev. 19:7-10); the destruction of Antichrist, the false prophet, Satan, and their followers (Rev. 19:11-21; 20:1-3); the millennial kingdom (Rev. 20:4-6); the final judgment upon the earth and Satan (Rev. 20:7-10); the final judgment of the dead (Rev. 20:11-15); and the new heaven and new earth with the New Jerusalem for eternity (Rev. 21:1-27; 22:1-5).

I. Ending the great tribulation

Revelation 11:14 says, "The second woe has passed; behold, the third woe is coming swiftly." The third woe, consisting of the seven bowls of God's wrath (Rev. 16), is a part of the negative contents of the seventh trumpet. Since the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet is recorded after the vision concerning the destruction of Jerusalem for the last three and one-half years (Rev. 11:2), and since the seven bowls will be the last plagues of the consummation of God's wrath (Rev. 15:1; 16:1), the woe of the seventh trumpet must be the end of the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21).

II. Closing the age

At the sounding of the seventh trumpet, not only will the great tribulation be ended, but also this age will be closed. The mystery of God will be finished (Rev. 10:7) and the kingdom of the world will become the kingdom of our Lord and of His Christ (Rev. 11:15). Then another age, the age of the kingdom, the millennium, will begin.

III. Bringing in the kingdom for eternity

The seventh trumpet will bring in the kingdom for eternity. Verse 15 says, "And the seventh angel trumpeted; and there were loud voices in heaven, saying, The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of His Christ, and He shall reign forever and ever." The phrase "He shall reign forever and ever" refers to the Lord's reign for eternity in the new heaven and the new earth (22:5). This indicates that the seventh trumpet covers the new heaven and new earth with the New Jerusalem.

IV. Consisting of:

A. The seven bowls of the wrath of God as the third woe

The seventh trumpet will include the seven bowls of the wrath of God as the third woe (Rev. 11:14,18; 15:1, 7-8; 16:1-21). Verse 18 says, "And the nations were wroth, and Your wrath came." "Wrath" here refers to the wrath of the seven bowls in chapter sixteen, which are a part of the negative contents of the seventh trumpet. The last woe consists of the seven bowls of the seventh trumpet. The seven bowls will be the intensification of God's wrath. With the pouring out of these bowls, His wrath will be exhausted. The bowls will be poured out, not upon the earth or heaven, but upon man, especially upon Antichrist and his kingdom. At the time of the last woe, Antichrist will be fighting against God, and Christ will descend to earth to fight against him with His overcoming army. The seven bowls of the third woe will be like seven bombs dropped from heaven and used by God to demolish Antichrist and his kingdom. Probably all seven bowls will be poured out within a short time. With the pouring out of these seven bowls, the great tribulation will be finished and the age will be closed.

B. The eternal kingdom of Christ

The seventh trumpet also consists of the eternal kingdom of Christ (Rev. 11:15, 17). Verse 15 says that the kingdom of the world will become the kingdom of our Lord and of His Christ and that He will reign forever and ever. The kingdom of the world becomes the kingdom of Christ at His coming back after His judgment upon the nations (Dan. 7:13-14; 2:44-45). At this time, the twenty-four elders will fall on their faces and worship God, saying, "We thank You, Lord God the Almighty, He who is and who was, because You have taken Your great power and have reigned" (v. 17).

C. The judgment of the dead

During the course of the seventh trumpet, Christ will judge the dead. Verse 18 says, "The time came for the dead to be judged." The judgment of the dead mentioned in this verse does not refer to the judgment at the great white throne. Since "for the dead to be judged" is mentioned before "to give the reward to Your slaves," it cannot refer to the judgment of the dead at the great white throne after the millennium (Rev. 20:11-15). It means that at the close of this age, before the millennium, according to John 5:27-29, the dead will be judged as to who should share in the resurrection of life before the millennium (1 Cor. 15:23; Rev. 20:4-6) and who should be left to the resurrection of condemnation after the millennium (20:11-12). Before Christ resurrects the saints, He will firstly make a judgment among the dead regarding the first resurrection of life and the second resurrection of condemnation. After He makes this decision, the resurrection of the saints will take place.

Once the saints have been resurrected, they will be raptured. First Thessalonians 4 indicates that the dead saints will rise up, not come down. Many Christians hold the mistaken concept that the dead saints are in heaven and that when the Lord Jesus comes, they will descend with Him. Read your Bible again. The saints will not come down; they will rise up and, with the living ones, will be caught up to meet the Lord in the air. It is not scriptural to say that the dead saints are now in heaven.

D. Giving reward

1. To the prophets and to the saints

Verse 18 also says that the time has come "to give the reward to Your slaves the prophets, and to the saints and to those who fear Your name, to the small and to the great." The reward will be given by the Lord to His faithful ones at His coming back (Rev. 22:12; Matt. 16:27). The judgment of the prophets and the saints will take place at the judgment seat of Christ (2 Cor. 5:10). Its purpose will be to determine who among the saved persons will be worthy of a reward and who will need further discipline. The giving of the reward to the prophets and to the saints will occur after the resurrection and rapture of the saints (1 Cor. 15:23, 52; 1 Thes. 4:16-17).

The seventh trumpet of Rev. 11 is the last trumpet of 1 Cor. 15. At the last trumpet, the dead saints will be resurrected and, with the living ones, will be caught up into the air. It is not scriptural to say that the rapture of the majority of the saints will take place before the tribulation. How can anyone say that Christ will come back openly before the tribulation? The Bible is very clear about this. Paul says that the living saints will not precede the dead ones, and that at the last trumpet the dead saints will be resurrected. Everyone must admit that the last trumpet is the seventh trumpet. After the seventh trumpet, there will be no other trumpets. Before the seventh trumpet, there are the fifth and sixth trumpets as the main parts of the great tribulation. Since so many saints will be raptured at the seventh trumpet, which is at the end of the great tribulation, how can anyone say that the rapture of the majority of the saints will be before the tribulation? Do not follow today's traditional teachings, which are shallow and inaccurate. We need to take the accurate word of the Bible. At the time of the seventh trumpet, the dead saints will be resurrected and the living saints will be raptured with them to the air. Thus, even at that time, Christ will not have come. At the beginning of the sounding of the seventh trumpet, He will still be in the air. After this rapture, Christ will set up His judgment seat to decide who will receive the reward and be a part of His overcoming army and who will need further discipline and punishment.

2. To the God-fearing people

Christ will also reward the God-fearing people. Rev. 11:18 also specifically mentions that a reward will be given “to those who fear Your name.” These God-fearing people are those who heed the eternal gospel to fear God and worship Him, and not to worship the beast or his image (Rev. 14:6-7), and to care for the Lord’s needy people (Matt. 25:33-40). Then, after Christ comes back to earth and establishes the throne of His glory in Jerusalem, the center of His kingdom, He will judge the nations, all the living unbelievers. The New Testament says that Christ has been appointed to judge the living and the dead (Acts 10:42; 2 Tim. 4:1). When will He judge the living? It will be after He fights the war at Armageddon and destroys Antichrist, the false prophet, and their followers (Rev. 19:11-21). At that time, there will be a large number of unbelievers still living on earth. According to Matt. 25:31-46, Christ will gather all the nations to His throne in Jerusalem and judge them.

Many think that this judgment refers to the judgment exercised upon Christians to determine who is real and who is false. But consider what Matthew 25:31 and 32 say, “When the Son of Man comes in His glory, and all the angels with Him, then He shall sit on His throne of glory; and all the nations shall be gathered before Him.” In the New Testament the word nations refers to the Gentiles. Matthew 25:32 also says, “He shall separate them from one another, as the shepherd separates the sheep from the goats.” This judgment will be neither according to the law nor according to the gospel of grace; it will be according to the eternal gospel preached by the angel in Revelation 14:6-7. During the three and one-half years Antichrist will force people to worship his image, an angel in mid-air will proclaim the eternal gospel, telling the people on earth not to worship the image but to fear God and worship Him. Some of the inhabitants of the earth will heed this eternal gospel and they will fear God and worship Him, will not worship the image of the beast, and will also care for the needy Jews and Christians who will be suffering under the persecution of Antichrist. Therefore, in Matthew 25:34-36, the King shall “say to those on His right hand, Come, you who are blessed of My Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world: for I was hungry, and you gave Me to eat; I was thirsty, and you gave Me drink; I was a stranger, and you took Me in; naked, and you clothed Me; I was sick, and you visited Me; I was in prison, and you came to Me.” When these righteous ones shall ask the Lord how they could have done this to Him, He shall answer, “Truly I say to you, in so far as you did it to one of these, the least of My brothers, you did it to Me” (Matt. 25:40). These “sheep” will then be transferred into the kingdom to become the nations during the millennium (2:26; 12:5). During these thousand years, the overcoming Christians will be Christ’s co-kings, the saved Jews will be the priests, and these righteous ones will be the people over whom the overcomers shall rule. The “goats,” the evil ones who followed Antichrist and refused to heed the eternal gospel, will be cast into the lake of fire “prepared for the Devil and his angels” (Matt. 25:41). This will occur during the seventh trumpet, taking place after the whole earth has become Christ’s kingdom.

E. Destroying the destroyers of the earth

The seventh trumpet also includes the destroying of the destroyers of the earth. Verse 18 says that Christ will “destroy those who destroy the earth.” The destroyers of the earth include the great Babylon (Rev. 17:2; 18:3), Antichrist (Rev. 13:3), the false prophet (Rev. 13:14), Satan (Rev. 20:7-9), and the people who follow them (Rev. 17:12-24; 19:19; 20:8-9). All of them will be destroyed during the seventh trumpet.

The great Babylon, the false religion, the Roman Catholic Church, must also be considered as a destroyer of the earth. Revelation 17:2 says that “the kings of the earth have committed fornication” with her, and “they who dwell on the earth have been made drunk with the wine of her fornication.” Since she is a destroyer of the earth and the whole earth has been corrupted by her, the Lord will destroy her.

After destroying the great Babylon, the Lord will destroy Antichrist, the false prophet, and their followers at the war of Armageddon. Antichrist and the false prophet will be cast into the lake of fire, and Satan will be destroyed. Actually, the Lord will deal with Satan twice — firstly by binding him and casting him into the abyss before the millennium and secondly by casting him into the lake of fire after the millennium. Antichrist will be the first to be put into the lake of fire. Antichrist, the false prophet, and their followers, a part of whom will be the “goats” in Matthew 25, will be thrown into the lake of fire prior to Satan (Rev. 19:20; Matt. 25:41), who will be kept in the abyss for a thousand years and who will ultimately be cast into the lake of fire. At the end of the millennium, all the dead unsaved people will also be thrown into the lake of fire (Rev. 20:15). At that time, every negative thing in the universe will have been cleared away.

V. The scene in heaven after the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet

If we would understand prophecy, we must be familiar with the entire content of the seventh seal. This is the secret to knowing the prophecy of this book. When I was young, I thought that the seventh trumpet merely consisted of the seven bowls and that the seven trumpets were the unique content of the seventh seal. Holding that concept, I found it difficult to grasp the whole book of Revelation. However, after a number of years, I saw that the seven trumpets are the unique content of the seventh seal, but that the seven bowls are simply a part of the content of the seventh trumpet. The seventh trumpet includes a great deal more than just the seven bowls. As we have pointed out, the seventh trumpet includes both negative and positive things.

Verse 19 unfolds the scene in heaven after the trumpeting of the seventh trumpet. This verse says, “And the temple of God which is in heaven was opened, and the ark of His covenant was seen and His temple; and there were lightnings and voices and thunders and an earthquake and great hail.” Four earthquakes are predicted in this book. The first (6:12) is in the sixth seal, the second (8:5) is before the seven trumpets, the third (11:13) is between the sixth and seventh trumpets, and the fourth (v. 19) is both here in the seventh trumpet and in the seventh bowl (16:18-20), which constitutes the close of the negative content of the seventh trumpet.

Here in this verse, which is continued by 15:5, we see that the temple of God was opened. The throne with the rainbow in 4:2-3 is the center of all the judgments executed over the earth in chapters six through eleven on the negative side; whereas the temple with the ark is the center of all God’s accomplishments in the universe carried out in chapters twelve through twenty-two on the positive side. The throne with the rainbow, the center of the first section, is for God’s judgment. The temple with the ark, the center of the second section, is for God’s building. Firstly, on the negative side, we have God’s judgment, and secondly, on the positive side, we have God’s building. For God’s judgment, the throne with the rainbow is the center, and for God’s building, His temple with His ark is the center.

God’s judgment is fully accomplished in the first section of the book. The main thought of the second section is God’s building. Who will be the temple? God’s people, mainly the church. Who is the ark? Christ. Therefore, the center of God’s building in eternity will be Christ and the church. We are not under the throne with the rainbow — we are in the temple with God. We are not under God’s judgment — we are in God’s building. Antichrist and the unbelievers will all be under God’s throne with the rainbow, but we are here in the temple with the ark, in God’s building with Christ.

What light the Lord has shown us! After the sounding of the seven trumpets in the first section, all the mysteries will be over, all the judgments will be carried out, and all the exercise of God’s administration will be completed. Only one thing will remain to be continued — God’s building. Because of this, the view, the scene, the sight, in heaven is changed from the throne with the rainbow to the temple with the ark. What do you see today — the throne with the rainbow or the temple with the ark? We see the temple with the ark. We see Christ and the church. This vision is not for us to be holy or spiritual; rather, it is for us to be built up. We all must see the temple with the ark for God’s building.

When the temple of God in heaven is opened and the ark of His covenant is seen in His temple, there are lightnings, voices, thunders, an earthquake, and great hail (v. 19). This is the same as what will transpire after the pouring out of the seventh bowl (Rev. 16:17-21). Lightnings, voices, and thunders are solemn declarations of God’s wrath in His judgment. The earthquake and the great hail are the actual judgment. By the earthquake, which will be the greatest in history, the cities, including the earthly Jerusalem and Rome, Babylon the Great, will be shaken and will fall (16:19). By the great hail, men will suffer the exceeding great plague (16:21). This will be the end of the great tribulation.

The book of Revelation is divided into two sections. The first section, consisting of chapters one through eleven, affords us a brief sketch, a general view of things. Since it is merely a sketch, it does not contain the details. Therefore, the following section, consisting of chapters twelve through twenty-two, gives us the details of the main items contained in the first section. Every chapter contains some details. For example, without chapters twenty-one and twenty-two, we would never know the details of the New Jerusalem mentioned in 3:12. The two sections of Revelation resemble the first and second chapters of Genesis. Genesis 1 gives a general record of God’s creation, especially of the creation of man. Genesis 2 supplies the details concerning God’s creation of man. Just as we need Genesis 2 to supplement the general picture of Genesis 1, so we need the second section of Revelation to supply the details of the crucial items mentioned in a general way in the first section.

The Rapture of the Believers

(1)

During the past one and a half centuries, the rapture of the saints has been a troublesome matter for many seeking Christians. Mainly, there are three schools of understanding concerning the rapture: the school of pre-tribulation, the school of post-tribulation, and the school of the so-called partial rapture. Those in the school of partial rapture say that the overcomers will be raptured earlier than the majority of the believers. In each of these schools there have been some very spiritual saints who knew the Bible quite well. Because of conflicting opinions, there has been much debate about the rapture. Soon after I was saved, I began to study prophecy and, as a result, I became quite familiar with all these schools. As the fruit of many years of study, observation, and consideration, I wish to present in this message and in the message following a clear and simple word on the rapture according to the pure word of the Bible. Let us forget about all the schools and care only for the pure Word.

I. The rapture of the overcomers

In the Bible we see two aspects of the rapture: the rapture of the overcomers and the rapture of the majority of the saints. That there are two aspects of the rapture does not mean there are only two raptures. With the rapture of the overcomers there are at least three categories. For instance, the rapture of the firstfruit differs from the rapture of the man-child. The man-child (Rev. 12:5) is composed of the dead overcomers in resurrection, and the firstfruit (Rev. 14:1-5) are the living overcomers, those who have never passed through death. When we come to chapter twelve, we shall see that the man-child, like the woman clothed with the sun, is a symbol. The man-child in Revelation is begotten, brought forth in birth. Consider the Lord Jesus. He was begotten of God to be the Firstborn Son in resurrection (Heb. 1:5; Acts 13:33). The man-child will also be begotten in resurrection. The resurrection of the man-child will be his birth. Rev. 12:11 says that the overcomers who are a part of the man-child are faithful unto death, overcoming the enemy by the blood and by the word of their testimony, and not loving their soul lives unto death. This indicates that all those included in the man-child are faithful unto death. Many of them have been martyred. Hence, the man-child, which includes all the dead overcomers, is different from the firstfruit, who are the living overcomers. In addition to the man-child and the firstfruit, there is another company of overcomers in chapter fifteen: the late overcomers who overcome Antichrist, his mark, the number of his name, and his image, and who will be raptured to stand on the sea of glass to praise the Lord. Therefore, with respect to the overcomers, there are at least three different raptures. Besides this, there is the individual rapture of the two witnesses in chapter eleven.

The rapture of the overcomers is the first category of rapture, and the rapture of the majority of the saints, considered in Revelation as the harvest (Rev. 14:15), is the second. In Lev. 23:10 we see a type of the rapture — the type of the crops ripening in the field. Some crops ripen earlier and others ripen later. Those that ripen first are considered the firstfruit. In Old Testament times, the firstfruit was always brought, not to the barn, but into the temple of God. Exo. 23:19 clearly says, “The first of the firstfruits of thy land thou shalt bring into the house of the Lord thy God.” The firstfruit was brought from the field into the temple of God for God’s enjoyment and satisfaction. When the field was completely ripe, that was the time of the harvest. After the harvest was reaped, it was brought into the barn. This is a type. The crop is God’s people (1 Cor. 3:9), and the first of the crop to ripen is the firstfruit which will be brought directly to God’s temple in the heavens. After that transpires, the sunshine will become brighter, and the unripened crops, which are still green, will begin to ripen. When all the crop has ripened, the majority of the saints will be harvested and taken to the air. The air corresponds to the barn. On most farms the barn is between the field and the farmhouse. The harvest is stored in the barn, but the firstfruit is brought into the farmhouse for the farmer’s first taste. While many teachers have written concerning the rapture, most of them have not taken care of this matter of God’s crop. In Matthew 13 the Lord Jesus revealed that He came to sow seed into the field. In 1 Corinthians 3 Paul tells the Corinthians, “You are God’s farm.” Finally, in Revelation 14, we have the firstfruit and the harvest. This gives us the basic concept with respect to the rapture.

Many Christians are too shallow and shortsighted. They do not read or study the Bible in a thorough way. Rather, selecting a few verses as their basis, they teach that all Christians will be raptured before the tribulation. They say that we were sinners who have been washed by the Lord’s blood, who have been regenerated by the Spirit, who have been saved, and who are now waiting for the coming back of the Lord Jesus, at which time we will all be raptured. Generally speaking, this is correct, and there is nothing wrong with it. However, it is a brief, careless, and superficial consideration of the matter. As an illustration of the vagueness and generality of the traditional teachings concerning the rapture, let me use the example of my former apartment on Arden Place in Anaheim. Everyone unfamiliar with the area had difficulty locating Arden Place. Some who knew that it was in the vicinity of Ball and Euclid have spent as much as an hour looking for Arden Place. They knew how to get to the corner of Ball and Euclid, but they did not have the detailed directions to get from there, by means of many small streets, to my apartment. Although it was correct to say that we lived near Ball and Euclid, the precise spot, Arden Place at Juno, was somewhat hidden. In order to get there, one had to travel through a maze of small streets.

Understanding the matter of the rapture in the New Testament is also like driving through a maze. It is very difficult to know this matter precisely. Perhaps the Lord meant it to be this way in order to arouse our watchfulness. Do not be confident that you know all about the rapture, for you may be like those who thought that they knew where I lived, but only knew the general vicinity of Ball and Euclid. Perhaps you know the rapture in a general way, but you are not familiar with the details. What we need is not a general map, but a detailed map. Most of the talk among Christians regarding the rapture is too general. It is like knowing the corner of Ball and Euclid without knowing the specific directions to my apartment. During the past fifty years, I have spent much time studying the rapture. Since 1925, whenever I could read or hear about this matter, I seized the opportunity to do so. Concerning the matter of the rapture, I have the assurance to say that the Lord has shown us the minute details, and in these two messages we need to examine some of these details.

The Lord Jesus will definitely come back before the millennium. Once there was a school of theology which taught that the Lord’s coming back would be after the millennium. Although this school was still there fifty years ago, it may be out-of-date by now. When I was young, I studied both the school that said the Lord would come before the millennium and the school that said He would come after the millennium. During the past fifty years, the second school has faded away, and hardly anyone seems to care for it. Perhaps you have never even heard of it. To say that Christ will come back after the millennium is absolutely unscriptural. Thus, only one school remains — that Christ will come before the millennium. This, however, is very general. We need to be much more exact and specific. It is absolutely correct to say that the Lord Jesus will come back before the millennium and that all Christians will be raptured, but we must still become familiar with the details.

I am concerned for some of the readers of this message. Whatever first enters into our mind is difficult to extract. Once anyone has taken in the thought that all the believers will be raptured before the tribulation, it is difficult for him to be delivered from it. Nevertheless, all the old, inaccurate concepts must be cleared away.

A. The need

1. The great tribulation is coming

Let us firstly consider the need of the rapture of the overcomers. Matthew 24:21 reveals that the great tribulation is coming. Matt. 24:22 says, “And except those days were cut short, no flesh at all would be saved; but because of the elect, those days shall be cut short.” The great tribulation will be so severe that its days must be shortened if any are to be saved.

2. A snare on all the earth’s dwellers is coming

Another need for the rapture is that a snare on all the earth’s dwellers is coming (Luke 21:34-35). Just as a fisherman spreads a net to snare fish, so Satan is spreading his net to snare us. In Luke 21:34 the Lord mentions three things related to the snare spoken of in verse 35: “And take heed to yourselves lest at some time your hearts be weighed down with dissipation and drunkenness and anxieties of life, and that day come upon you suddenly as a snare.” In this verse the Lord mentions dissipation (eating), drunkenness (drinking), and the anxieties of life. Since World War II, nearly everyone on earth has been occupied with these three things. Industry, for example, is altogether for the cares of this life. The same is true of finance. All the universities are for industry, industry is for money, and money is for the cares of this life. Consider the billions of people on the earth today: their only concern is the cares of this life. Everything they are involved in — education, industry, politics, warfare — revolves around the cares of this life. Eating, drinking, and the cares of this life are the three main elements of the devilish snare, the net used by Satan to trap everyone on earth. In these verses in Luke, the Lord Jesus is saying that the time will come when all the dwellers on earth will be snared. I have been alive for more than seventy years and I have been observing the world situation for nearly sixty years. I know what human life is. I have studied human history, I have read the newspapers, and I have observed the world situation. I have discovered that, especially since World War II, people care for nothing except their physical life. God did not create the earth in a haphazard way. No, His creation is beautiful and contains many fine things. However, if we are snared by any of these things, we shall be caught by them. For instance, it is necessary and proper to maintain a suitable dwelling place for ourselves, but we must be on the alert not to be snared by it.

Although there is the grave danger of being snared by eating, drinking, and the cares of this life, we still need to live a normal human life. The young people need to obtain a good education, for this is necessary in order to earn a living. Do not excuse yourself by saying, “I don’t care for this life. Since I only love the Lord, I will give up studying and just praise the Lord all day long.” If you do this, you will be a burden to others. You may be all right, but others will not be. You may claim to have faith, but your so-called faith will force others to labor for you. No, you must study diligently and do well in school. However, do not do this for the purpose of making a name for yourself or of becoming a person of renown. Although you must study, do not allow education to be your snare. Still some may say, “Because I don’t want to be snared, I won’t go to school. It’s better to spend all my time reading the Bible and fellowshiping with all my young colleagues. Wouldn’t this be wonderful?” Many young people have this mistaken concept, saying, “The Lord Jesus might come tomorrow. Why then should we study so much? This is a waste of time.” Although the Lord might come tomorrow, because of your laziness, He may tarry until you have learned to study and have graduated from school.

As fallen people, we are unbalanced. Matthew 24:40 speaks of two being in the field. It does not say that two are sleeping, fellowshiping, or living wholly for the Lord without engaging in any work. Some might say, "Since the Lord might come back tomorrow, why must we work in the field? If necessary, we could even fast for three meals until He comes." I once heard a message in which the speaker said, "How wonderful it would be if, when the Lord comes, my wife and I would be praising and praying." But the Bible does not indicate that we shall be doing these things when He appears. Rather, Matthew 24:41 speaks of two women grinding at the mill. In ancient times, the most difficult work for women was grinding wheat. If I were one of the women in those days, I might have said, "The young brothers have helped us to know that the Lord Jesus might come back tonight. What then is the need to labor at grinding wheat? This is a waste of time. Why must we still grind flour if the Lord is coming tonight? Let's just sit here and wait for His coming." This is an illustration of one extreme.

On the other extreme are those Christians who care for nothing except making money and spending it. They say, "Oh, we shouldn't be so spiritual. We must be practical and take care of our wives and children. I must support my family and care for many other things. I don't have the time to attend the church meetings. Can't we worship God at home?" To those at this extreme, the Lord may say, "I will come as a thief. I will come at the time when you least expect Me. Perhaps I'll come when you are engrossed with making money." But to those on the other extreme, He may say, "Because of you, I will delay My coming. You are too earnest for My coming back. You are so earnest that you don't do anything. You don't even take care of your cooking. I will delay My coming until you learn to cook, make money, and take care of yourself and others." I mean what I am saying and I am serious about it. This is the poor situation among Christians today.

We all must do our duty to earn a living, yet we must do it without being snared by it. We may have many things, but we must never allow them to rule us. Learn to be balanced, falling neither into the extreme of idleness nor into the extreme of being occupied with the affairs of this life. With this matter, as in so many other things, there are two sides. Consider the example of the apostle Paul. Was he not waiting for the Lord's coming back? If you examine his writings, you will see that all of them were for the long run. He never said, "Dear saints, because the Lord Jesus might come tomorrow, you don't need to do so many things. You should just sit around and pray." No, in his epistles Paul seemed to be saying, "While we are waiting for the Lord's coming back, we must still live in a normal way." Although we do not know when the Lord will come, we do know that as long as we are on earth, we must have a normal living to be the proper testimony of the Lord Jesus. We must obtain the best education and have a balanced daily living. We also must maintain our houses and, in every respect, be normal people.

As those who are waiting for the Lord's coming back, we must have a proper living without being snared by anything. Our heart is on nothing but the Lord Jesus. However, this does not mean that we do not study, conduct business, and take care of daily chores, such as cleaning. Do not say, "Why must I keep my clothes neat and clean? It is a waste of time and money to do the laundry. The Lord doesn't care for the flesh; He only cares for my spirit. As long as my spirit is clean, everything is fine." I have the assurance that many young people still have this attitude. They do not even make their beds in the morning, considering it to be a waste of their time. As long as they have a place to lie down, they are satisfied, thinking that they can spend their time reading the Bible or spiritual books. They do not know why they must work to keep their room neat, clean, and orderly. Their sloppiness may delay the Lord's coming back. The Lord may tell them, "You must learn to make your bed early in the morning, comb your hair, and shine your shoes. Then you must arrange all your books in a good order. Don't put the New Testament before the Old Testament." No elder who is careless can be useful in building up the church. We must learn to be diligent, keeping everything in good order. However, we should not dream about those things at night. Rather, when the Lord says, "Behold, I come quickly," we must be able to forget everything. Some keep their things in good order, but this becomes a snare to them. This is a test to determine where we are. We are here as the testimony of Jesus. We are normal people living a normal life, but nothing of this life can touch us. We are not sloppy, idle, lazy, or careless. Yet, nothing in this world has any control over us. These two sides of the matter will force us to be one with the Lord.

What is the meaning of rapture? It is to be taken into the Lord's presence. If you would be taken into His presence, you must be in His presence today. Much of your praising and fellowshiping may not be in His presence, but may simply be according to your own choice. You are not in the presence of the Lord, but in your preference and taste. When you desire to fellowship, the Lord may say, "Go to work or study."

3. The trial on the whole inhabited earth is coming

Another aspect of the need for the rapture of the overcomers is that the trial is coming on the whole inhabited earth (Rev. 3:10). This trial will be the great tribulation, consisting of the three woes of the last three trumpets probably with the supernatural calamities of the sixth seal and the first four trumpets. Those woes and calamities will be the most severe trial to the earth's dwellers. To be saved from this trial, we need to be raptured before it comes.

4. Destruction as the birth-pang on the peace - and - safety talkers is coming

First Thessalonians 5:3 says, "Whenever they say, Peace and security, then sudden destruction comes upon them, as birth pangs to a woman with child, and they shall by no means escape." This verse indicates that destruction will come as birth pangs upon those who talk of peace and safety. Those in the United Nations take the words peace and safety as a slogan. While people are talking about peace and safety, sudden destruction will come upon them.

5. The Devil coming down to earth with great wrath as a woe to the earth and the sea

Another aspect of the need for the rapture of the overcomers is that the Devil will come down to earth with great wrath as a woe to the earth and to the sea (Rev. 12:12). By then, he will know that his time is short and thus he will do everything possible to torment man to the uttermost. We surely need a rapture to keep us away from his evil torment.

6. The great dragon — Satan — being angry with the woman and going to war with the remnant of her seed

After the great dragon, Satan, has come down to earth, he will be angry with the woman and will go to war with the remnant of her seed (12:17). The woman in chapter twelve is the totality of God's people, including both the church and the children of Israel. Her children are of two categories: those who keep the law and those who have the testimony of Jesus. The one hundred and forty-four thousand chosen remnant of Israel will certainly be faithful to the law, and the redeemed ones, the believers, will be faithful to the testimony of Jesus. The great dragon, who will be angry with this woman, will war with the remnant of her seed, with the Jews who keep the law of Moses and the Christians who have the testimony of Jesus. An early rapture is needed before this.

7. The beast — Antichrist — warring with the saints and overcoming them

Speaking of Antichrist, Revelation 13:7 says, "And it was given to him to make war with the saints and to overcome them." The saints are God's people as signified by the woman in chapter twelve. This indicates that in the great tribulation a number of believers, against whom Antichrist will war and whom he will overcome, will still be there. This means that he will persecute the believers during the great tribulation. How much we need a rapture before that time!

Because all these terrible, horrible things are coming, there is the need for us to be taken away. We are not waiting for these dreadful events to take place. We are waiting for the Lord to take us away before any of these things come to pass. Thus, there is definitely the need for the rapture of the overcomers.

B. The promises

1. To be accounted worthy to escape all these things and to stand before the Son of Man

Now we come to the promises with respect to the rapture of the overcomers. Luke 21:36 says, "But be watchful, at every time beseeching, that you may prevail to escape all these things which are about to take place, and to stand before the Son of Man." According to the Greek, the words be accounted worthy may be rendered "fully strengthened." In Greek this phrase has both meanings. When we are fully strengthened, we are counted worthy. We must be fully strengthened in order to escape the snare and to stand before the Son of Man. Before the Lord comes back, He, the Son of Man, will be in the third heaven. Luke 21:36 reveals that the overcomers will stand before the Son of Man. This means that they will be raptured to the presence of the Lord in the heavens. While the snare is about to come, we must be fully strengthened to escape it. If you are familiar with fishing, you will realize that some stronger fish are able to escape the net. Likewise, the overcomers will be fully strengthened to escape the snare and to stand in the presence of the Lord in the heavens. This is a promise of being raptured before the great tribulation.

2. To be kept out of the hour of trial

Another promise regarding the rapture is found in Revelation 3:10. "Because you have kept the word of My endurance, I also will keep you out of the hour of trial which is about to come on the whole inhabited earth, to try them who dwell on the earth." Some say that all Christians will be raptured after the tribulation. This concept is found among the so-called Newton group of the Brethren which separated from Darby's group. The Newton group teaches that all Christians will pass through the tribulation. Once I asked one of the leading teachers in the Newton group about Revelation 3:10, and he admitted that this verse was a problem to them. According to this verse, the overcomers will not only be kept out of the trial but also out of the hour of the trial, meaning that they will be raptured before the great tribulation. Hence, the rapture of the overcomers will precede the great tribulation.

The Rapture of the Believers

(2)

I. The rapture of the overcomers

C. The facts

1. The One Being Taken and the Other Being Left

In Matt. 24:39-42 we see the fact of the rapture. Verses 40 and 41 say, “Then shall two men be in the field; one is taken, and one is left. Two women shall be grinding at the mill; one is taken, and one is left.” Here we see two brothers in the field and two sisters at the mill. One of the brothers and one of the sisters are taken and the others are left. Some among us, especially the young people, may love the Lord and think that they need not care for their human living. But in these verses we see two brothers working in the field and two sisters grinding at the mill. This is for eating. As long as we live on earth, we cannot ignore the need of eating. We must work in order to eat. Therefore, if you truly love the Lord, you must realize that while you are loving Him, you must still earn a living for yourself. While two are working in the field for their living, one will be taken and the other left. Outwardly they are the same, but inwardly they are different. If you read the context, you will see that one is watchful and ready and the other is not. While one is getting ready, the other is not watchful.

2. The man-child being caught up to God

The fact of the rapture of the overcomers is also found in Revelation 12:5. This verse says, “And she brought forth a son, a man-child, who was about to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod; and her child was caught up to God and to His throne.” Notice that the man-child is not caught up to the air but to the throne of God. The throne of God is in the third heaven. This rapture will transpire before the three and one-half years of the great tribulation (Rev. 12:6, 14).

3. The hundred forty-four thousand becoming the firstfruit to God and to the Lamb

The fact of the rapture is also found in 14:1-5, where we read of the one hundred forty-four thousand becoming the firstfruit to God and to the Lamb. Being firstfruit, they are brought into God’s house, the temple of God in the heavens, not to the air. The hundred forty-four thousand will be raptured to Zion in the heavens before Antichrist forces people to worship him during the great tribulation.

These facts regarding the rapture of the overcomers cannot be denied. The one in the field and the one grinding at the mill are taken before the others, the man-child is caught up to the throne of God before the last three and one-half years, and the firstfruit is taken before the harvest. No one can say that the harvest will be taken at the same time as the firstfruit. As Revelation 14 makes clear, the firstfruit is raptured first and the harvest is raptured later.

D. The time

Now we come to the time of the rapture of the overcomers. According to Revelation 3:10, it will precede “the hour of trial.” Moreover, chapter twelve indicates that the man-child will be caught up to the throne of God before the last three and one-half years, that is, before the great tribulation (12:5-6, 14, 17). Furthermore, the one hundred forty-four thousand firstfruit will stand on Mount Zion before Antichrist forces people to worship him and his image at the time of the great tribulation (14:1-5, 9-12). If you read chapter fourteen carefully, you will see that after the firstfruit is taken to Mount Zion in heaven, on earth Antichrist will erect his image in the temple and force people to worship it. Unless you do not believe the Bible, there can be no argument about this. If we believe what the Bible says, then we must admit that some Christians will be raptured to the third heaven, not to the air, before Antichrist persecutes God’s people.

E. The place

1. To stand before the Son of Man

The place to which the overcomers will be raptured is before the Son of Man in the heavens (Luke 21:36). At the time of the rapture of the overcomers, Christ will not yet have left heaven and have come down to the air. Much less, will He have come down to earth. The overcomers who have overcome the snare of the Devil will stand before the Son of Man in the heavens.

2. To be caught up to the throne of God

As 12:5 indicates, the man-child will be caught up to the throne of God in the heavens. Probably most Christians know that 1 Thessalonians 4 says that those who are alive and remain will be caught up to the air. But here we see that the man-child will be caught up to the throne of God in the heavens.

3. To stand on mount Zion

The fact that the firstfruit will stand on Mount Zion in the heavens also proves that the place to which the overcomers will be raptured is the heavens. All these verses indicate that the overcomers will not be raptured to the air but to the third heaven. Therefore, with respect to both time and place, the rapture of the overcomers is absolutely different from the rapture of the majority of the believers.

F. The conditions

1. Watch and pray always

Now we come to the conditions of the rapture of the overcomers. By conditions we mean the terms and price we must pay for this early rapture. Firstly, we must watch and pray always (Luke 21:36). To watch and pray always does not mean that we only pray and do not work, sleep, or eat. It means that while we are working, we have a praying spirit and are constantly praying. To have this constant prayer does not require that we cease working. If you cannot pray while you are working, then your prayer must not be very genuine; rather, it must be a formal, religious performance. The best prayer is that while you are busy working, you constantly and simultaneously look unto the Lord with a living spirit. This is real and genuine prayer. We all can pray constantly. Even when I speak, I am praying. While you are fellowshiping with others, you should be praying. We need to be a praying people with a praying spirit. We need to pray all the time. This is what it means to pray always.

2. Watch and be ready

A second condition is that we must watch and be ready (Matt. 24:40-44; Luke 12:35-40). We should be able to say, “Lord, I’m busy working, but I’m ready to go. Lord, here I am cleaning my things and keeping them in order, but I don’t want to live here forever. Lord, I’m ready to be taken.” Can you tell the Lord this? To be ready does not mean that we stop working and do nothing. In the last century, some people did this. A certain teacher told them that at a particular time Christ would come. After hearing this, they bathed thoroughly, put on white garments, and did nothing except pray. This is not the proper way to wait for the Lord’s coming back. The proper way is to live a normal life. The Bible nowhere tells us to take a shower, put on white clothing, and wait for the Lord to come back. Rather, the Lord Jesus says that no one will know the time. As two brothers will be working in the field, much to their surprise, one will suddenly be taken away and the other will be left.

We must not understand the Bible according to our human concept. Many Christians who care for the Lord’s coming back hold the concept that since the Lord is coming soon, it is better for them to do nothing. No, everything depends upon a normal living and upon contacting the Lord all the time with a living spirit. Tell the Lord, “Lord, I have no ties on earth. I’m ready to go anytime You want to take me.” This is the way to watch and to be ready.

3. Loving the Lord’s appearing

A third condition is to love the Lord’s appearing. In 2 Timothy 4:8 Paul said, “Henceforth, there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous Judge, will award to me in that day; and not only to me, but also to all those who have loved His appearing.” Paul said that the crown of righteousness is laid up for all those who love the Lord’s appearing. We must tell the Lord, “Lord Jesus, I love You and I love Your appearing. Because I love You, I love Your appearing.” However, to love the Lord’s appearing does not mean that we should not live a normal life. Rather, the more we love His appearing, the more we need to live a normal life today.

4. Keeping the word of the Lord’s endurance

Still another condition is keeping the word of the Lord’s endurance (Rev. 3:10). In order to be the testimony of Jesus, we must keep the word in the Bible. But if we do this, we shall be persecuted. Throughout the centuries, the saints were persecuted and martyred because they were faithful to the Lord’s word. Today, we also must be faithful to the Lord’s word. We do not follow the traditions or care for religion. We only take care of the word of the Lord which is the word of His endurance. Due to this, we are suffering persecution. For this we need the endurance of the Lord. We must endure the persecution of religion. The word we keep is the Lord’s word of endurance.

5. Overcoming and keeping the Lord’s works

Lastly, if we would share in the first rapture, we must overcome degraded Christianity and keep the Lord’s works. In 2:26 the Lord said to those in Thyatira, “And he who overcomes, and he who keeps My works until the end, to him I will give authority over the nations.” No one can dispute the fact that the Roman Catholic Church has denied the Lord’s works. What are the Lord’s works? Firstly, His death on the cross. The Roman Catholic Church even denies this, for it does not teach people to trust in the Lord’s death for their salvation. Rather, it teaches them to pray to certain saints, to donate money, to behave themselves, and even to suffer. In doing this, those in the Roman Catholic Church forsake the Lord’s work in His crucifixion for our redemption. The Roman Catholic Church also denies the Lord’s resurrection; it absolutely forgets whatever the Lord has done. Catholicism even teaches that by offering a financial gift you can shorten the time that a relative will spend in purgatory. This is an example of ignoring what the Lord has done through His resurrection. In the epistle to Thyatira the Lord seemed to be saying, “You must overcome Catholicism and keep My works. You must keep all that I have done for you. You must not worship Mary, but rather keep My redemption, My ascension, and My indwelling. These are My works. Don’t trust your good deeds — your contributions, your prayers to the saints, your fastings, and your sufferings.” Nevertheless, in spite of the Lord’s word, those in the Roman Catholic Church still fail to keep the works of the Lord.

We must overcome devilish Catholicism and keep all that the Lord has done for us. We would never worship Mary. Although she is a sister and we would speak of her as such, we would never address her as “Mother Mary.” She is not the mother of God, and it is terrible to say that she is. Catholicism teaches that Christ is the Son of Mary, but in the epistle to Thyatira, the Lord Jesus said that He is the Son of God (2:18). Since Catholicism has ignored the works of Christ, those in Catholicism will not be raptured before the tribulation. Rather, according to Revelation 17:16, God will use Antichrist and his ten kings to kill many of those in the Roman Catholic Church. In 2:23 the Lord Jesus said of those in Thyatira, “I will kill her children with death.” Hence, they will not be raptured. We must overcome degraded Catholicism and come back wholly to the works of the Lord Jesus, the One who died for us, who resurrected and ascended, and who will come back for us. We must keep His works until the end.

II. The rapture of the majority of the believers

Now we come to the rapture of the majority of the believers.

A. The fact

The fact of the rapture of the majority of the believers is that “the harvest is reaped” (14:14-16). In 14:1-5 we see that the firstfruit is taken to Mount Zion in the heavens. In verses 6 through 13 there is the persecution under Antichrist, who will set up his image and force people to worship it. After this, we are told that the harvest is ripe. Hence, according to Revelation 14, there are two kinds of rapture: the rapture of the firstfruit and the rapture of the harvest.

B. The people raptured

1. The resurrected saints

The people who are raptured in the rapture of the majority of believers firstly are the resurrected saints (1 Thes. 4:15; 1 Cor. 15:23). First Thessalonians 4:15 says that those who “are living, who remain unto the coming of the Lord, shall by no means precede those who have slept.” At the sound of the last trumpet, which will be the seventh trumpet, the dead saints will be resurrected and, with the living saints, will be taken to the air to meet the Lord there.

2. The believers who are alive and remain

First Thessalonians 4:15 and 17 speak of those who are “living, who remain.” This phrase suggests a great deal, for it implies that there will be some living ones who no longer remain on earth. If it were not so, the apostle Paul would never have used the word remain; he simply would have used the word alive. This indicates that the living saints will be of two categories: those who are alive but who do not remain on earth, and those who are alive and still remain on earth. Those who are alive and do not remain are those who have already been raptured. At that time, some of the living saints will already have been taken up to the throne of God in the third heaven.

C. The time

1. At the last trumpet

The time of the rapture of the majority of the believers will be at the last trumpet, that is, at the seventh trumpet near the end of the great tribulation (1 Cor. 15:52; 1 Thes. 4:16; Rev. 10:7; 11:14-15). Some say that the last trumpet in 1 Thessalonians 4 and 1 Corinthians 15 is not the seventh trumpet of Revelation 11, but that it is another trumpet, perhaps resembling the trumpet sounded for the movement of the Jewish army. This is a strange interpretation. I do not see how anyone could accept it, for it is not an interpretation according to the Bible. When the apostle Paul wrote 1 Corinthians 15, he spoke of the last trumpet. Do you believe he meant the last trumpet of the Jewish army? How ridiculous! Where do people get this concept? What a mistaken way of interpreting the Bible! Some propound this interpretation because they teach that all the saints will be raptured before the tribulation. But they know that the last trumpet, the seventh, will be sounded near the end of the tribulation. Thus, in order to say that all the saints will be raptured before the tribulation, they must say that the last trumpet in 1 Corinthians 15 and 1 Thessalonians 4 must be a different trumpet from the seventh and last trumpet in the book of Revelation. They keep away from the truth of the Bible which unveils that the majority of the believers will be raptured at the sounding of the seventh trumpet, the last trumpet, which will be toward the end of the great tribulation. This is a strong proof that the majority of the believers will pass through most of the great tribulation. Therefore, the teaching that all the believers will be raptured before the tribulation is absolutely not according to the Scriptures.

2. After the man of sin, Antichrist, is revealed

The rapture of the majority of the believers will be after the man of sin, Antichrist, is revealed (2 Thes. 2:1-4). Second Thessalonians 2 gives us a strong basis for saying that the rapture of the majority of believers will be at the end of the great tribulation. This portion of the Word clearly says that before the saints are raptured, the man of sin, Antichrist, will be revealed and that he will sit in the temple of God “proclaiming himself that he is God” (2 Thes. 2:4). This idol worship will transpire before the rapture of the majority of the believers. Whenever those in Newton’s group placed these verses before those in Darby’s group, those in Darby’s group were embarrassed. Darby taught that all the believers would be raptured before the tribulation but, as the Newton group pointed out, Antichrist must first be revealed and set up his image in the temple and force people to worship it before the Lord comes back and the saints are gathered to Him. Whenever this portion of the Word is brought up, the mouths of the teachers who say that all the believers will be raptured before the tribulation are silenced.

3. After the beast, Antichrist, forces people to worship him and his image in the great tribulation

The rapture of the majority of the believers will be after the beast, Antichrist, forces people to worship him and his image in the great tribulation (14:9-16). This is revealed clearly in the fourteenth chapter of Revelation.

4. After Satan’s war with the remnant of God’s people

This rapture will also be after Satan’s, the great dragon’s, war with the remnant of God’s people at the time of the great tribulation (12:17, 14, 5). This will be after the rapture of the man-child. According to Revelation 12, the man-child will be caught up to the throne of God prior to the last three and one-half years. Approximately three and one-half years later, the majority of the seed of the woman will be taken up. This means that after the man-child has been taken away, the remnant of the seed of the woman will suffer Satan’s persecution. Hence, the majority of the believers will still remain on earth and will be raptured at the end of the great tribulation.

5. At the completion of the age

The rapture of the majority of the believers will be at “the consummation of the age” (Matt. 13:39). The completion of the age is the end of the great tribulation. According to Matthew 13:39, this will be the time of harvest. Christ came to sow the seed into the field to produce a crop for God. This crop will be harvested at the completion of this age. The completion of this age will be the last three and one-half years. Starting from the rebuilding of the city of Jerusalem, a period of seventy weeks has been determined. The first sixty-nine weeks, extending from the decree to rebuild Jerusalem until the crucifixion of Christ, spans a time of four hundred eighty-three years. After Christ’s crucifixion, there is a long gap. Eventually, the gap will be closed, and the last week, the last seven years, will begin. The last half of this last week will be the completion of the New Testament age, which extends from the cross to the end of the great tribulation. No one knows how long will be the gap between Christ’s crucifixion and the beginning of the seventieth week. But Daniel 9 does reveal clearly that the end of this age will be the seven years of the last week. The completion of the age is the last half of these seven years. Toward the end of these three and one-half years, the majority of the saints will be taken away. The overcomers will be raptured some time prior to the last three and one-half years. The time of this is unknown. While the time of the rapture of the overcomers is unknown, the time of the rapture of the majority of believers is known, for we are told that it will be at the seventh trumpet, which is near the end of the great tribulation.

D. The place

Now we come to the place to which the majority of the believers will be raptured. First Thessalonians 4:17 reveals that the place is “in the air,” and Revelation 14:14-16 indicates that it will be “on the cloud.” The overcomers will be raptured to the throne, to the presence of the Son of Man in the third heaven. But 1 Thessalonians 4 tells us plainly that the majority of the believers will be caught up to the air, and Revelation 14 reveals that the harvest will be reaped to the cloud. At that time, Christ will no longer be clothed with the cloud, but will be sitting on the cloud in the air.

E. The condition

The condition of the rapture of the majority of the saints is that the harvest is ripe. Revelation 14:15 says, “And another angel came out of the temple, crying with a loud voice to Him who sat on the cloud, Send forth your sickle and reap, for the hour to reap has come, because the harvest of the earth is ripe.” Hence, ripeness is the condition of the rapture of the majority of the believers.

III. Two other raptures

Besides these two kinds of raptures, the rapture of the overcomers and the rapture of the majority of the believers, there are two other kinds of raptures: the rapture of the two witnesses (11:12) and the rapture of the saints who will overcome the beast, his image, and the number of his name (15:2).

Four Aspects of the Experience of the Lampstand

Genesis is the field into which nearly all the seeds of the truths were sown. In Revelation we have the harvest of the truths sown in the beginning of the Bible. In this book of consummation, the local churches are crucial. The local churches are also the focus of this book. We have seen that the local churches are the destination of God's progressive revelation and manifestation. In the Bible we not only have God's revelation but also His manifestation. Revelation may be considered as being close to doctrine, but manifestation is definitely related to experience. Therefore, the Bible not only gives us the doctrine but also the experience, not only the revelation of God, but also the manifestation of God. If there were no local churches, there would be no destination for God's revelation and manifestation.

The subtle enemy, Satan, hates the local churches. Throughout the centuries, many good Christian teachers have devoted their attention to many other things. We admit that some of these things have been important. Nevertheless, most of these teachers have still missed the mark, missing the destination of the local churches. We must worship and praise God for being the Lord. He would never let this matter go. After recovering so many items during the past several centuries, in our time He has come to this destination. This is the reason that, day and night, our only burden is to build up the local churches. All the attack and opposition that we undergo are simply because of our stand for the local churches.

The lampstand as a type of the church

Everybody knows that the term church is not found in the Old Testament. The first time it is used is in Matthew 16:18, where the Lord Jesus said, "I will build my church." However, in the Old Testament there are many types that foreshadow the church. For instance, in Genesis 2 we have the bride as a type of the church being Christ's counterpart. Furthermore, both the tabernacle and the temple are types of the church being God's dwelling place among men on earth. The children of Israel as a corporate people signify that the church is also a corporate people to express God. None of these types, however, is as all-inclusive as the lampstand.

The lampstand is first mentioned in Exo. 25. If we only had this chapter, we would be unable to realize that the lampstand is related to the church or to the churches. Near the end of the Old Testament, we find the lampstand mentioned again in Zechariah 4. Zechariah shows some progress and improvement over Exodus. In Exodus we only have the lampstand with the seven lamps; there is no mention of what the seven lamps refer to. But in Zechariah we are given a definite interpretation of the seven lamps, for in this book we are told that the seven lamps are the seven eyes of God (Rev. 4:10) and the seven eyes of the stone (Rev. 3:9). Zechariah tells us two main things regarding the lampstand — that the seven lamps of the lampstand are the seven eyes of God and the seven eyes of the stone. Consider the picture presented in Zechariah. That the stone has seven eyes, which are the seven eyes of God, indicates that these seven eyes infuse what God is into us. God is light, life, love, holiness, etc. All that He is as the life element is infused into us through His seven eyes. This is even true of us as human beings, for as we look at others something of us is infused into them through our eyes. What is the significance of the seven eyes of God also being the seven eyes of the stone? Undoubtedly, the stone is for building. Thus, these seven eyes not only infuse God as the life element into our being; they also infuse Christ into us as the building material, making us the material for God's building. Zech. 4:2-6 and 10 also imply that these seven eyes of God, which are the seven lamps of the lampstand, are the Spirit. In answering the question, "What are these?" it says, "Not by might nor by power, but by my spirit, saith the Lord" (4:6). This verse indicates that it is only through the Spirit that we can be prevailing in God's building. Hence, we can see that the lampstand in Zechariah 4 reveals a definite development beyond the lampstand in Exodus 25. However, Zechariah is not the book of consummation, and we must continue until we come to the last book of the Bible, the book of Revelation.

In Revelation there are seven golden lampstands. This book also reveals that the seven lamps are the seven Spirits of God and the seven eyes of the Lamb (Rev. 5:6). Therefore, the lampstand includes God, Christ, the Spirit, the Redeemer, and the building material.

Four aspects of the lampstand for our experience

As we consider Exo. 25, Zech. 3 and Zech. 4, and the book of Revelation, we see four aspects of the lampstand that we must experience. Firstly, we must participate in the essence, the golden element, of the lampstand. Secondly, we must experience the forming of this golden substance into a definite form — the stand. The gold in the lampstand is not a lump; rather, it is formed into a stand. Thirdly, along with the form, we must experience the expression of the lampstand through the shining of the seven lamps. Fourthly, there is the matter of the reproduction of the lampstand. Hence, we must experience four aspects of the lampstand — the element, the form, the expression, and the reproduction.

Experiencing the golden element

We all need to experience the golden element of the lampstand. If we only have an ounce of gold, how could we form a lampstand? This would be impossible. We might be able to make a ring, but certainly not a lampstand. In order to have a lampstand, there must be a talent of gold (Exo. 25:39). (A talent equals approximately one hundred pounds, or sixteen hundred ounces.) We need more gold, more of God. If we would have the church as the lampstand, we must have something substantial — the gold, which is the substance, the essence, the element, of God Himself. If we do not have this substance, all our talk about the church is vain. How pitiful is the situation among so many Christians today. They have so little of the substance, of the divine gold; instead of acquiring the substance, they discuss vain doctrine. Even if our doctrine is sound, right, fundamental, and scriptural, it is not God Himself. Only God Himself is the element. How we need God as the golden element!

What is God? In John 4:24 the Lord Jesus clearly said, "God is Spirit." In Greek, there is no article before the word Spirit. Thus, we should not say that God is a Spirit, but that God is Spirit. To say that God is Spirit is like saying that the table is wood. Just as the element of the table is wood, so the element of God is Spirit. According to John 4:24 in order to worship God we must worship Him in spirit. To worship God is not simply to bow down to Him; it is to reach Him, to contact Him, and to receive Him. According to the context of John 4, to worship God is to drink of Him as the living water (v. 14), which is the very Spirit flowing into our being. How can we receive Him into us as this living water? We receive Him by opening our whole being to Him and by exercising our spirit. We must receive God Himself as the golden element into the depths of our being. Day and night, we need to open ourselves. Never close yourself to Him or shut any part of your being to Him. Rather, tell Him, "O God, I am absolutely open to You. I exercise my spirit to contact You, the divine Spirit. O divine Spirit, come into me and saturate me." This is the way to gain more gold.

If we all gain more gold, among us there will not only be one talent but perhaps a hundred talents. We shall be exceedingly rich in the divine element, in the material for the lampstand. All the brothers and sisters will be full of God and wherever we go, we shall see gold. When we enter into the saints' homes, we shall see nothing but gold. When I visit the brothers and sisters, I shall see gold. When I come to the young ones, I shall see gold, and when I contact the older ones, I shall see even more gold. The sisters should not be wooden or muddy; they should be golden. I always feel shameful when I hear some sisters gossiping. Although I do not condemn them, I experience the sense of shame, for sisters in the church must be golden. A gossiping sister is not truly in the church. Likewise, I also feel shameful whenever I see a brother exchanging words without love with his wife. Where is the gold in this brother? If he is a brother in the church, he should be full of gold. When I see such things, I turn away. I do not like to see the muddy condition of the saints. Rather, I enjoy seeing the gold in them. We all need more gold. The church must be full of gold, full of God. When I see this, I feel glorious and I am in the third heaven.

The experience of the gold being beaten to form the stand

However, it is not adequate merely to have a large quantity of gold. We may have a thousand talents of gold and not yet have the lampstand, for we may just have the substance without the form. How can we have the form? All fundamental students of the Bible agree that the lampstand was made by beating the gold. One brother may have ten pounds of gold, another may have seven pounds, and still another may have five pounds. How can all this gold be formed into a stand? Only by its being beaten together. All the gold must be brought together into one. This refers to the building. Firstly, we need the substance and then we need the building by beating. It is a shame to the Lord if today He cannot see any building. Many people argue with us about the church, asking how we can say that we are the church and that they are not the church. But the question is: where is the building? You may even have a great deal of gold, but if you do not have the form, by the way of the building, you do not have the lampstand. This means that you may be rich in gold but poor in the lampstand — the building.

If you would have the stand, you must be beaten together with others. You need to lose your identification. Do not say, "This is my gold. I'm spiritual." For you to be spiritual as an end in itself is meaningless as far as the lampstand is concerned. Your experience and enjoyment of God must be beaten together with that of others. Our gold must be put together, beaten, and built up as one entity, as one unit. Then we not only have the gold, but are also built into a golden lampstand. This is the church.

If those in the church in Anaheim are merely several hundred individual units, we are finished. God does not desire hundreds of individual units of gold. He wants all the gold put together and beaten to form the lampstand. What a need there is for the building! If we have seen the building, we will never be individualistic. Rather, we would realize that whatever we gain or receive of the divine element is for the building of the lampstand. Because God's desire is for the building, we have given message after message saying that we need God in Christ as our very substance that we might be built together. It is good to have a large quantity of gold and thereby to be rich in God. But are you still individualistic, or are you part of a corporate entity? We need the building.

Experiencing the seven lamps as the expression

Even though we may have the gold and are beaten together and are built into one as a lampstand, we still need the seven lamps, the seven Spirits of God as the expression. If we do not have the seven Spirits of God, we shall be unable to shine to express God. Whether we are young or old, we daily need to be filled with the sevenfold Spirit of God. Whenever we are filled with God's sevenfold Spirit, we are living and shining. Because we are filled with the seven Spirits of God, we cannot be dead or dim. Being filled with the sevenfold divine pneuma, we can never be like a flat tire. Nothing can suppress us. Because we are full of the Spirit of God, the more we are pressed down, the higher we bounce up. I can testify that the more difficulties I have, the higher I rise up. Many times, others have advised me not to say certain things, but I could not keep from speaking about them because of being filled with the seven Spirits of God. Someone once asked me this question: "Why are you so living, fresh, and evergreen? Please tell me your secret." My secret is that I have the Spirit.

There is no need to prepare yourself to function in the meetings. If you do this, your function will be a performance. To function is simply to be what you are. Sometimes the leading brothers strongly encourage the saints to function in the prayer meetings. But all such functions are not genuine functions but performances, because the saints are not filled with the Spirit. Rather, they are deflated like flat tires. They are deflated before they come to the meeting. But the leading ones may still insist that these flat tires roll around a little in the prayer meeting. This kind of activity does not come from the infilling and indwelling pneuma but from the pushing of the elders. After a brother or sister has been forced to function, he may not pray for two weeks. I can testify of this from my experience. Pushing never helps. When a tire becomes flat, it is better not to roll it around, for the more you roll it, the more damaged it will become. However, none of us should be a flat tire. Instead, we must be filled with pneuma. We have a "station" in the third heaven, and we can always be filled with the heavenly pneuma. When we are filled with the Spirit, we can function at any time. This function is not a performance — it is our living. When I am filled and bubbling over with the Spirit, I am active, aggressive, and youthful. I can even deliver a message to the demons. If the Devil would come to me, I would give him a good teaching. When we all are filled with the sevenfold Spirit of God in the built-up church, this sevenfold Spirit of God will become the very expression of God in Christ.

The reproduction of the lampstand

Now we come to the fourth aspect of the experience of the lampstand — the reproduction. Both in Exodus and Zechariah the lampstand was uniquely one. But in the book of consummation, there are seven lampstands signifying seven local churches. This indicates that Christ as signified by the lampstand in Exodus and the Spirit of God as signified by the seven lamps of the lampstand in Zechariah are not only for the production of the universal church, but also for the reproduction of the local churches. One lampstand is reproduced in the seven lampstands. All the local churches as the many lampstands are the reproduction of Christ and the Spirit as the one lampstand. The more the critics oppose the local churches, the more reproduction there will be. Opposition simply lays the tracks for further reproduction. Do not care about the opposition. Simply care for the substance, the building up, and the expression. The more we have of these three things, the more we shall see the reproduction. What is this reproduction? It is actually a multiplication of the wonderful expression of Christ as the life-giving Spirit in a practical way. This is the reproduction of the church. I am glad to say that I have the full assurance that this reproduction will pave the way for the Lord to come back. By means of this reproduction, the Lord will have a beachhead on which to place His feet for His coming back to possess the whole earth.

Experiencing the Transforming and Building Life of Christ

In 1925 I began to read, study, and research the book of Revelation. The most difficult thing that faced me was getting through the first three chapters, especially the two chapters concerning the seven churches. In the seven epistles to the seven churches there are many difficult verses which hardly anyone can explain. One of the most difficult verses is Rev. 3:12, where the Lord said, “He who overcomes, I will make him a pillar in the temple of My God, and he shall by no means go out anymore, and I will write upon him the name of My God, and the name of the city of My God, the New Jerusalem, which descends out of heaven from My God and My new name.” When I read this verse fifty-one years ago, I had a very difficult time understanding it. What does it mean to say that the Lord will make us a pillar in the temple of God and that He will write the name of God, the name of the New Jerusalem, and His new name upon us? None of the books I consulted regarding this matter could answer my question. Although even a fourth grader can understand the words, it is most difficult to apprehend the true significance of this verse. Revelation 3:12 has been a difficult verse for all expositors because none of them has had the adequate experience. Through the years, I eventually have come to realize that this promise is the greatest among the seven promises in the seven epistles in Rev. 2 and Rev. 3. In this message we need to consider this promise of the Lord to the overcomer in the church in Philadelphia.

The greatest blessing

We cannot understand 3:12 unless we have the necessary experience. The Lord’s promise here is not to give us something but to make us something. Whenever we think of the Lord’s promises, we always think that He will give us something. According to our concept, a promise is related to a blessing. To us, without a blessing, there can be no promise. But in 3:12 the Lord did not say, “I will give him”; He said, “I will make him.” In 3:12 the Lord does not promise to give us holiness or a heavenly blessing. No, here He promises to make us become something — a pillar in the temple of God.

Becoming a pillar in the temple of God involves two things — transformation and building. Since I came to this country, my burden has been on these two matters. The greatest blessing the Lord can render us is to transform us and to build us into His temple. Most Christians have been unable to understand what it means to be made a pillar in the temple of God. What does this mean? And what does it mean to have the name of God, the name of the New Jerusalem, and the new name of the Lord written upon us? But those who have reached the level of the church in Philadelphia have the proper understanding within them. If we are on this level, then we are ready for the Lord to transform us. If we use the little power we have received of the Lord on His word and mean business with Him, then we are ready to be transformed and are in the proper position for the Lord to make us a pillar. This requires that we firstly be transformed into precious material and secondly that we be built into a pillar. How can we, who are clay, become a pillar in God’s temple? There is no way except to be transformed from clay into precious stone and then to be built into God’s building. Prior to 3:12, we have the Lord’s promise in 2:17 that indicates that we can be transformed into a white stone by eating Him as the hidden manna. This is truly the greatest blessing. This involves our very being, for it is related to what we are. The greatest blessing is not what the Lord gives us, but what the Lord makes us.

Suppose I am a mass of clay. No matter what you give me, whether it be gold or diamonds, I am still clay. Even if you would bring me into heaven and place me in front of God Himself, I would still be clay. The greatest blessing is that the Lord would transform me into something related to God’s dwelling place. In the church life we should not expect objective blessings. Rather, we must realize that the Lord’s blessing is always to make us something, to transform us into precious material, and then to build us into God’s building. If you take this word into you, it will absolutely revolutionize your concept. If you have seen this vision, would you still expect the Lord to bless you with outward things? No, we would drop this expectation. If we have truly seen this vision, we shall realize that in the church life the Lord’s intention is not to do something outside of us, but something altogether related to our very being. He will make us into another being.

The three names written upon us

The Lord will not only make us into pillars, but He will write three names upon us: the name of God, the name of the New Jerusalem, and His new name. To write a name on something is to give it a designation. If I were to ask you your name, what would you say? Would you have the boldness to say, “My name is God”? To say this is not blasphemous, because the Lord promised to write the name of God upon us. Suppose I am the one on whom the Lord has written God’s name, and you ask me my name. I would say, “Please read what is written upon me — G-o-d. This is my name, my designation.” Some of the opposers may criticize me for saying this. But do not accuse or blame me of being blasphemous. I am just one who is being written upon — He is the Writer. You must blame Him.

The Lord will also write upon us the name of New Jerusalem. How much of the New Jerusalem is written upon you? Perhaps others can only see upon you the letters N-e-w J-e-r. But eventually, after a certain period of time, every letter of the name New Jerusalem will be written upon you.

Finally, the Lord will write His new name upon us. Because the Lord is always new, He certainly does not have an old name, but a new name. What is this new name of the Lord? It is the very Christ whom we experience. Only after we have had the adequate experience will we receive this new designation. By all this we can see that the greatest blessing is for the Lord to make us like God, to make us a part of the New Jerusalem, and to make us an expression of Christ in a new way.

The Lord’s way of writing upon us

We in the churches must see that the Lord’s greatest blessing is that He promises us to make us become something. The way in which He accomplishes this is to work Himself into us. The writing of the name of God, the name of the New Jerusalem, and the new name of the Lord upon us actually refers to the working of God into us, to the working of the New Jerusalem into our being, and to the working of the attributes of Christ into us as His new expression. Eventually, through this working, these three new names will be written upon us. The working of His element into us is the writing of these names upon us.

Consider the example of petrified wood. Firstly, we have a piece of ordinary wood. As water flows through it, it carries away the natural wooden element and replaces it with a solid mineral element. As this process transpires, the wood is gradually petrified. After the completion of this process, we may write upon that piece of wood the words petrified wood. This designation describes what has been wrought into the very fiber of the wood.

I say again that the writing of these three names describes the working of the divine element into our being. Therefore, the greatest blessing in the church life is not that the Lord will give us something, but that He is now working Himself into us to make us a part of the New Jerusalem. Through this working, we may have something of God as well as some new experience of the all-inclusive Christ. We may not have outward blessings. Although the Lord takes care of us, we do not consider this outward care to be the real blessing. The true blessing is that He is making us a pillar in the temple of God on which are written three wonderful names.

The ultimate consummation

Most Christians cannot tell you what the significance of 3:12 is because throughout the centuries the matter of God’s eternal purpose being carried out through God’s building has been greatly neglected. Even today in Christianity you can hardly hear a word about God’s building. Many misunderstand the word building, taking it to mean the same as edification. For many, to build up is simply to edify. Although many stress edification, no one cares for the practical building of the church of God which issues in His eternal dwelling place. Nevertheless, what is the ultimate consummation of the Bible? When we come to the last two chapters of the Bible, we do not find religion, morality, ethics, or edification — we see a city, the New Jerusalem. Many Christians think that the New Jerusalem is a heavenly mansion. Apparently they have never noticed that this city will come down from heaven (21:2). While most Christians are eager to go to heaven, God’s desire is to come down from heaven. The New Jerusalem is the ultimate consummation of God’s working in both the old creation and in the new. Every book must have a conclusion. Although a book may contain many things, the final word is the most important word. What is the conclusion of the Bible? It is God’s ultimate consummation, the holy city, New Jerusalem, as God’s eternal habitation. The epistle to the church in Philadelphia is the highlight among the seven epistles. This epistle reaches the high point of God’s eternal purpose, the New Jerusalem. It reaches the ultimate consummation of the entire Bible, for both the Bible and this epistle consummate with the New Jerusalem. Hence, this epistle is not only the highlight of the seven epistles, but also comes up to the high point of the whole Bible.

Our need for transformation and building

When the apostle John ate the little scroll, it was sweet in his mouth but bitter in his stomach (10:10). Our experience is the same. When we saw the vision, we were happy because the vision was so sweet. But after seeing this vision, throughout the years we have had a bitter feeling in our experience. This bitter feeling concerns the poor situation among Christians today. Even among us who are so close to the Lord's ministry there are many who do not care for God's building. They care for their blessings and their personal spirituality. Others care for being fundamental and doctrinally correct, but they do not care for God's building. They need to be revolutionized and transformed. May I say a frank, honest, and loving word to these dear ones? Forget about doctrine and look at yourself. Who and what are you? It matters little whether the doctrine is correct or not. What truly matters is what you are. For years you have been concerned with doctrine, but has there been any change in you? Are you still the same as you were twenty-five years ago? Perhaps you have never experienced any transformation and building. You may consider yourself to be spiritual, scriptural, fundamental, and right. But in what part of your being have you been transformed, and with whom have you been built up? Day by day, you embrace the Bible, endeavoring to be fundamentally correct in doctrine, but what about your being? Has there been a change in you?

Being transformed through God's dispensing Himself into us

What is God's building? God's building is to dispense Himself into us and to work Himself into our being. Consider again the illustration of petrified wood. The wood is natural, having no mineral element whatsoever to give it the substance of stone. There is no wood in God's eternal building. In His building there are only precious stones, gold, and pearls. The twelve foundations of the New Jerusalem are layers of precious stones (21:19-20), and the entire wall is built with jasper (21:18). In the New Jerusalem there is nothing of mud or wood. By nature we all are either muddy or wooden. Everyone would rather be wooden than muddy, thinking that wood is superior to mud. Nevertheless, neither mud nor wood is useful in God's building hand. We need transformation. The muddy people need to be transformed into precious stones, and the wooden ones need to be petrified. The way for a piece of wood to be petrified is to allow the living water to flow through it to carry away the wooden substance and to replace it with a solid mineral element. The process of petrification in the physical world is a symbol of the spiritual reality. Today God is truly "petrifying" us by the flow of His divine life. This flow is clearly revealed in Revelation 22:1, which says, "And he showed me a river of water of life, bright as crystal proceeding out of the throne of God and of the Lamb." This river flows throughout the whole city.

I constantly have a bitter taste within me, a bitter feeling concerning today's Christians. They appear to know much, but actually they are more than ignorant and know nearly nothing. It does not matter what you know. You may know many things, but every part of you may still be mud or wood, indicating that you have not been transformed. We must be transformed by God's dispensing Himself into our being. Forget your knowledge of the Bible and forget your religion, and just take care of one thing — how much you have been transformed by the living God's dispensing Himself into you. This is what truly matters. You may be able to recite so many verses in the Bible, yet you yourself mean nothing. Nothing counts in God's economy but Himself dispensed into your being. I hope that many of you will be able to say, "I don't know very much about the Bible. I only know one thing: day by day God is dispensing Himself into me. Every day, something of God flows in to carry away my natural element and to replace it with His divine essence."

I am deeply burdened! It does not matter whether you are good or bad, holy or unholy, spiritual or unspiritual. The only thing that matters is whether or not you have been touched by the Lord and have been transformed. We must be willing to open ourselves and say, "Lord, get through. Lord, flow in, through, and out of me and carry away every particle of my natural element. Lord, I hate the outward improvement and am tired of being corrected outwardly. I am tired of religion and Bible knowledge. I am tired of being individually spiritual. Lord, I am desperate about my condition because I have so little of Your divine essence. I have been taught and 'edified' for years. But still I am what I am."

True brotherly love

The church in Philadelphia has been greatly misunderstood. Yes, it is the church of brotherly love. But what kind of love is this? Is it a mere outward embracing of one another? Is that genuine brotherly love? No, brotherly love is Christ Himself wrought into our being and lived out of us. In typology, our natural love is like honey and will never be accepted by God. The natural life and the natural love are not frankincense; they are the honey that is hateful in the eyes of God. Natural brotherly love is just as hateful to God as leaven is. Real brotherly love is the expression of the Christ who has been wrought into our being. Our natural essence and element must be carried away by the flow of the divine life and replaced with God's divine element.

The significance of being made a pillar

What is the significance of being made a pillar and of being written upon by the Lord? How can the Lord make us, who are so natural, being wood or mud, into pillars? The only way is by transforming us, that is, by carrying away our natural element and by replacing it with His divine essence. The meaning of the word make in 3:12 is to constitute us into something, to construct us in a creative way. This is transformation. As the Lord's testimony in His recovery today, it is inadequate merely to be scriptural. For the fulfillment of God's eternal purpose, we all must say, "Lord, I am here. I have seen the vision that I need Your petrification. I am wood and need to be petrified by You. Lord, flow through me and carry away all my natural being and replace it with Yourself."

The epistle to the church in Philadelphia has never been as open to the Lord's children as it is today. Throughout the years, Christians have lacked the genuine experience of God's transformation and building. Due to this lack, there has been no understanding of 3:12. Again I say that it is only through experience that we have begun to realize the significance of this verse. Today in the proper church life the Lord is making us, mere pieces of wood, into pillars in the temple of God. This sentence is simple, but its significance is profound. In the church in Philadelphia the Lord is not correcting us or even just burning us. He is in the process of making us, old ones and new ones alike, into a pillar in the temple of God. This certainly means something. The only way the Lord can accomplish this is by being the divine flow within us. Not even the Lord can do a quick work in this matter. He patiently works Himself into us as the divine flow, not to correct our outward behavior but to carry away our natural essence. God does not desire the mere improvement of our behavior. Today the Lord desires the proper church life. For this, He is eager to get into us at this very moment. Do not wait until tomorrow and do not wonder about others. Look at yourself. The Lord's work in the church is to work Himself into you as the divine flow to carry away your natural being and to replace it with His divine substance that you may gradually be processed by His transforming element. This is all we need. As God is transforming us, we shall become something else — the precious material for His building. The more we become this material, the more He will build us into His building. Ultimately, this building will become the New Jerusalem.

The Lord is labeling His work, writing a suitable designation upon it. After a carpenter has finished a certain object, he may put a label on it. That label is the designation of the very thing he has made. Likewise, the Lord is making us a pillar in His temple. In some future messages we shall see that the temple will be enlarged into a city. The whole city will be an enlarged temple. Hence, to be a pillar of the temple eventually is to be a part of the New Jerusalem. In 3:12 we are told that the overcomer in Philadelphia will be made a pillar of the temple, yet the designation the Lord puts upon him is not "the temple of God," but "the New Jerusalem." Ultimately, we shall not be part of the temple, but part of the New Jerusalem. What the Lord is making us in a creative way is the New Jerusalem. Sooner or later, the Lord will write the name of the New Jerusalem upon us. He will label us according to what He has made us.

Experiencing the transforming and building life of Christ

All this is based upon a new realization and experience of Christ. Your experience of Christ may be too old. Whenever you stand up to testify of your experience of Christ, it is old. We all need some new, up-to-date experience of Christ. This new experience of Christ must be His making us a pillar and His writing the name of New Jerusalem upon us. This is a new experience, and because of it we have His new name. Only you know what this name is, for only you have had the experiences that produced it. We all must have these new experiences of Christ that we might become a pillar. I hope that many of us who have known the Lord for so long will say, "Lord, I praise You. I have never realized that I need Your transformation. Lord, I have been an individualist for all these years. But now I ask You to flow through me and carry away my natural individuality and to replace it with Your essence. I want to be transformed and built by You with other members in Your Body. Lord, I hate being natural and individualistic. I want to have some new experiences of the transforming and building Christ. I want to experience the transforming and building life of Christ." Perhaps you have experienced the saving life of Christ. His life has saved you from sin and worldliness. But perhaps you have never experienced Christ's transforming and building life. Although you have been saved from sin and the world, have you been transformed and have you been built up with others? Through the years, you have been natural and individualistic. May the Lord have mercy on us. We need to pray, "Lord, open my eyes that I may see a vision and experience You in a new way as the transforming and building life, that You may have the opportunity to make me a pillar in God's temple and that I may become a part of the New Jerusalem."

The Stone with the Seven Eyes for God's Building

The engraved stone

Zechariah 3:9 says, "For behold the stone that I have laid before Joshua; upon one stone shall be seven eyes: behold, I will engrave the graving thereof, saith the Lord of hosts, and I will remove the iniquity of that land in one day." The reference to engraving the stone indicates that this stone is Christ. It is difficult to understand this matter of engraving the stone. In brief, it means that the Lord Jesus, as the building stone, was engraved, dealt with, by God on the cross for the iniquity of God's people. In one day, by that engraving on the cross, the Lord Jesus took away all the sins of God's people. This is the equivalent of John 1:29, which says, "Behold, the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world!" By the latter half of Zechariah 3:9 we know that the stone with the seven eyes is Christ.

The seven eyes and the seven lamps

Zechariah 4:2 says, "What seest thou? And I said, I have looked, and behold a lampstand all of gold, with a bowl upon the top of it, and his seven lamps thereon, and seven pipes to the seven lamps, which are upon the top thereof" (Heb.). In Zechariah 3:9 the building stone has seven eyes, and in this verse the lampstand has seven lamps. If we exercise our spirit in this matter, we shall surely understand that the lampstand equals the stone. Both the stone and the lampstand are Christ. Obviously, the stone is for the building, and the lampstand is for light, for enlightening. On the stone there are seven eyes, and on the lampstand there are seven lamps. Hence, the seven lamps of the lampstand must be the seven eyes on the stone.

Proceeding to Zechariah 4:10, we read, "For who hath despised the day of small things? for they shall rejoice, and shall see the plummet in the hand of Zerubbabel with those seven; they are the eyes of the Lord, which run to and fro through the whole earth." This verse begins with a reference to "the day of small things." In the eyes of men, the recovery of the building was not a great thing. Nevertheless, no one should despise it. Likewise, the recovery of the church life today is not a great thing in the eyes of men. Rather, it is a small thing. But no one should despise it. This verse also speaks of "those seven," which refers to the seven lamps in verse 2. Then we are told that "those seven" are "the eyes of the Lord, which run to and fro through the whole earth." This proves that the building stone with the seven eyes is simply Jehovah, the Lord God Himself.

The seven Spirits of God

Having this understanding, we come to the book of Revelation. I say again that most of the symbols and other crucial points found in Revelation are not new; they are further developments of items found in the Old Testament. In Revelation chapters four and five, we have a new and further development of the seven eyes and the seven lamps. Revelation 4:5 says, "And out of the throne come forth lightnings and voices and thunders; and seven lamps of fire are burning before the throne, which are the seven Spirits of God." Notice that the seven lamps here are not on the lampstand, but are burning before the throne. The seven lamps that are burning before the throne are the seven Spirits of God. In Zechariah 3 and 4 we have the seven eyes and the seven lamps but not the seven Spirits. In Revelation, however, the seven lamps have developed into the seven Spirits. Here we have a new and further development of the seven lamps as the seven Spirits. In 4:5 we are told clearly that the seven lamps are the seven Spirits of God.

Revelation 5:6 says, "And I saw in the midst of the throne and of the four living creatures, and in the midst of the elders, a Lamb standing as having been slain, having seven horns and seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God, sent forth into all the earth." The Lamb here has seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God. In 4:5 the seven lamps are the seven Spirits of God, and in 5:6 the seven eyes of the Lamb are the seven Spirits of God. Here we have a further development over Zechariah, for the seven eyes are not only the seven eyes on the stone, but also the seven eyes of the Lamb. These seven eyes of the Lamb are the seven Spirits of God sent forth into all the earth. This is a reference to Zechariah 4:10, where we are told that the seven eyes of the Lord "run to and fro through the whole earth." In Zechariah 3 and 4 we see the seven eyes of the stone, the seven lamps of the lampstand, and the seven eyes of the Lord. Thus, the Lord is the stone, and the stone is also the lampstand. The stone is both the lampstand and the Lord God Himself. These three — the Lord, the lampstand, and the stone — are one. In Zechariah, we see that the seven eyes are the seven lamps. But as we come to the further development in Revelation, the seven lamps are no longer just on the lampstand, but are also burning before the throne. These seven lamps are the seven Spirits of God. Eventually, these seven Spirits are the seven eyes of the Lamb who is in the very center of God's administration. May we all be deeply impressed with this picture.

Everything for God's building

According to the context of both Zechariah and Revelation, all this is for God's building. The stone and the lampstand are mentioned in Zechariah at the time when Zerubbabel was rebuilding the temple. In Revelation, we firstly have the seven lampstands symbolizing the seven local churches. Later, we have the throne before which the seven lamps are burning. Ultimately, this throne is the center of the New Jerusalem. This reveals that the New Jerusalem comes into existence by means of the seven Spirits burning before the throne. By all this we can see that the seven eyes, the seven lamps, the seven Spirits, the stone, the lampstand, the Lord, God, and the Lamb are all for the building. This building is the temple, the church today and the New Jerusalem, God's eternal habitation, in eternity.

Suppose we had only two books, the Gospel of John and Revelation, both written by the apostle John. If we read these books again and again, what would we see? Let us begin with John chapter one. Verse 1 says, "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God," and verse 14 says, "And the Word became flesh and tabernacled among us...full of grace and reality." Verse 29 says, "Behold, the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world!" According to John 1, many words are used to describe this One: the Word, God, the flesh, and the Lamb. Verse 4 says, "In Him was life, and the life was the light of men." With Him there were also grace and reality. When Peter was brought to this wonderful One, He changed his name from Simon to Cephas, which means a stone (v. 42). When Nathanael met Him, He said to him, "Truly, truly, I say to you, you shall see heaven opened and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man" (v. 51). This word reminds us of Jacob's dream, the center of which is Bethel (Gen. 28:10-22). John chapter one, extending from eternity past to eternity future, covers a great deal. In eternity past there was the Word, and in eternity future there will be Bethel, the house, the dwelling of God. This will be the New Jerusalem. This one chapter reaches from eternity to eternity. Of course, John takes another twenty chapters to develop all the points covered in the first chapter.

After many years, when John was old and had been exiled to the Isle of Patmos, the Lord charged him to write Revelation, not only the last of his writings but also the last book of the whole Bible. Revelation 1:4 and 5 say, "John to the seven churches which are in Asia: Grace to you and peace...from the seven Spirits who are before His throne." In chapters four and five we see that the seven Spirits are the seven lamps and the seven eyes mentioned in Zechariah. The seven lamps, which, according to Zechariah, are both the seven eyes of the stone and of the Lord are now the seven Spirits of God, and these seven Spirits of God are the seven eyes of the redeeming Lamb. Revelation 5:5 and 6 reveal that this redeeming Lamb is the overcoming Lion. As the overcoming Lion, He has absolutely defeated the enemy of God. All the enemies — the serpent and the scorpions — have been swallowed up by the Lion. Because He overcame all the enemies, He was qualified to be the redeeming Lamb. As the Lamb, He took away all the sins, the iniquity, of God's people on the day God engraved Him on the cross. Because He accomplished this as the redeeming Lamb, He eventually became the building stone. In the eyes of God, when the Jewish builders rejected Him, they not only rejected the Lamb, but also the cornerstone of God's building. On the day of His death, He was the Lamb, but in resurrection God made Him the head cornerstone. Thus, after His death and resurrection, He is now the Lion-Lamb-stone. All the enemies have been defeated, all the sins have been removed, and He has become the stone for God's building. On this stone there are seven eyes, shining and burning before the throne of God to carry out God's eternal economy. Today, it is not just a matter of the Lion or the Lamb, but of the stone. Where are we today? Are we just with the Lion and the Lamb, or are we with the stone? Most Christians are only with the Lamb; very few are with the Lion. Many hymns say, "Worthy the Lamb," but I would like to hear a hymn that says, "Worthy the Lion!" We also need hymns that say, "Worthy the stone," and "Worthy are the seven eyes." What a shortage there is in today's Christianity! Many fight, argue, and debate, but are ignorant of Christ's being the building stone.

Experiencing the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits

We must proceed further to the seven eyes of the stone. We have seen that the seven eyes are the seven Spirits of God sent forth throughout all the earth. These seven eyes, as the seven lamps, are burning before the throne. Undoubtedly, burning is for enlightening, searching, exposing, and judging. While the lamps are for judging, the seven eyes are for transfusing and for infusing. As long as my eyes are upon you, whether I am happy or sad, they will transfuse something of me into you. My eyes are not lamps for burning, but for transfusing. A brother who is a typesetter by trade uses in his business a machine called a phototypesetter. This machine copies characters from a master character disc onto sensitive photopaper. Four burning lamps, which resemble four eyes, transmit intense beams of light through the disc and reflect them off two mirrors onto the photopaper. In this way the exact image of the original characters on the disc is burned into the photopaper. We may say that through this process the image on the disc is transfused into the paper. In like manner, through the seven eyes, something of Christ is transfused into us.

We not only have the seven lamps for burning, searching, exposing, and judging and the seven eyes for transfusing, but also the seven Spirits for the imparting of life. Since the Spirit is the Spirit of life (Rom. 8:2), the seven Spirits are mainly for imparting life. If we only had the seven lamps and not the seven eyes or the seven Spirits, we would be consumed. The seven lamps are not only the seven lamps, but also the seven eyes transfusing and infusing us and the seven Spirits imparting life into us. Praise the Lord that His enlightening, searching, exposing, and judging are for the impartation of life. He is not only the seven lamps, but also the seven Spirits.

Consider your experience. When we came into the church life, we all sensed that there was something shining within, over, and around us. That shining searched, exposed, and judged us. Everyone in the church life has experienced this shining that searched out and judged things that were concealed in the depths of our being. When these hidden things were exposed, we were condemned. But praise the Lord that through this judging, life was imparted into us. Although we might not have had the word infusion, we definitely experienced it. From that time onward, the Lord Jesus became so lovable to us. Due to this infusion, we began to love the Lord more than ever before.

This experience is for the building. There is only one place where we can have this kind of experience — in Bethel. I have the full assurance to say that if your intention is not for God's building, you will surely be kept from having this experience. When some hear this, they may say, "The Lord is not as narrow as you are." In some respects, the Lord is even narrower than I am; He is more strict. You cannot experience the things we are describing in this message unless you are in Bethel. Even if we have just the intention to go up to Bethel, we, like Jacob, will experience these things. Only in the local church can we experience the things concerning God's dwelling place. This experience simply cannot be had anywhere else.

Experiencing the Triune God for God's building

We come again to the matter of the Trinity. According to the traditional teaching of the Trinity, the Father, the Son, and the Spirit are three separate and distinct Persons. In a good and positive sense, I agree with this. I have even used these terms myself. For example, one of my hymns says, "What mystery, the Father, Son, and Spirit, In person three, in substance all are one." I am familiar with all these things. In the traditional teaching, the Son is the second Person, and the Spirit is the third Person. In the book of Revelation the Holy Spirit has become the seven Spirits. Have you ever realized that these seven Spirits are the seven eyes of the second Person? How, then, can the seven Spirits be a separate Person? Are the second Person and the seven Spirits, the eyes of the second Person, two separate Persons? We simply cannot understand the Trinity by using traditional terms. The more we use these terms, the more entangled we shall become. To say that the seven Spirits are the seven eyes of the second Person is not my definition or interpretation; it is my figuration, my reading of the verses in Revelation. Those at the Nicene Council probably were not clear about the seven Spirits. Since they were not clear, how can we follow their creed? If we follow it, then we must be blind. We do not follow anything blindly. Our opposers say that they believe the creed, but we believe the pure word of the Bible. If the early church Fathers had seen that the Holy Spirit is the seven Spirits, which are the eyes of the second Person, they would have been reluctant to formulate a creed. They would have realized that it was impossible for them to make a creed. Any creed that lacks a sentence found in the Bible is incomplete. For more than fifty years, we have been declaring that we do not want any creed. Our only creed is the Holy Bible with its two testaments. Of course, when we declared this more than fifty years ago, we did not see the seven Spirits. We saw this less than twenty years ago. Gradually, during the past twelve years, this matter has become very clear.

I would like to address a question to our opposers: Do you not believe that the Holy Spirit, who is the third Person, is in the book of Revelation the seven Spirits? But the seven Spirits are the eyes of the second Person. Are They, then, two separate Persons? I am not debating doctrine; rather, I am speaking the reality for God's building. For us today, the Trinity should not be a doctrinal matter; it must be the experience of the Triune God dispensing Himself into us.

We have seen that, according to the Gospel of John, the eternal Word, who is God, became flesh, and that this flesh was the Lamb of God. In Revelation we see that this Lamb was the Lion. The Lamb is also the stone with the seven eyes, and these eyes are the seven enlightening, searching, exposing, and judging lamps. The seven lamps are also the seven Spirits of God imparting life into those who have been judged. Furthermore, the seven Spirits are the seven eyes of the Redeemer, transfusing and infusing what He is and what He has accomplished into our being that we may become, in His nature, a stone for God's building. Do not remain content with traditional teachings and do not stay attached to any doctrinal understandings. We must see that the Triune God is too wonderful. He is the Word, the very God, and He became flesh to be the Lamb of God. In John 14 He indicated that He and the Father are one and that the Spirit is He. This wonderful One is the Lion, the Lamb, and the stone with seven eyes. With these seven eyes He gazes at us and transfuses what He is and what He has accomplished, attained, and obtained into our being to make us the material for God's building. These seven eyes are the seven Spirits sent by God from His throne throughout all the earth.

We should not have a Trinity in doctrine, but experience the wonderful, mysterious, and excellent riches of our God. All these riches are not only for our redemption and regeneration, but also for our transformation and building up. Oh, how we need the light to see these things! We should not be superficial, and we should never be distracted by today's Christianity. Rather, we should ignore what the opposers are saying and hold to the Bible, with the pure word and the up-to-date light. We all must see this light. Whenever we attempt to understand the Bible in a "theological" way or come to the Bible seeking theology, we shall be killed. We cannot know the Bible in a so-called "theological" way.

Ten crucial items

Let us now consider further some of the crucial terms found in the Gospel of John and in the book of Revelation. Firstly, in John 1:1, we have the eternal Word. The "beginning" in this verse certainly refers to eternity past, indicating that the Word is the eternal Word. As this verse makes clear, the Word was God. One day, this Word, who was God, became flesh (John 1:14). According to the theological mentality, we are accustomed to saying that the Son of God was incarnated. This, of course, is correct. However, if you read the New Testament, you will not find a word saying that the Son of God was incarnated. Although this fact is true, the New Testament does not express it this way. This is the traditional theological teaching of the incarnation. But do not misunderstand me and think that I do not believe that the incarnation was of the Son of God. I believe it at least as much as you do. I believe that the incarnation was of the Son of God. But the New Testament says that the Word, which was in the beginning, became flesh. It was not only the Son of God who became flesh; it was the very God who was incarnated. John the Baptist, the forerunner of Christ, said of this Word who had become flesh, "Behold, the Lamb of God!" Thus, in the first half of John chapter one we have the Word, God, the flesh, and the Lamb.

In Revelation, we see that the Lamb of God is the Lion. One of the angelic elders, not a human being, introduced Christ in this way, recommending Him as the Lion of the tribe of Judah (5:5). Revelation 5:6 says that on this Lamb there are seven eyes. The mention of the Lion refers to Genesis 49, and the word about the seven eyes points back to the book of Zechariah, which speaks of the seven eyes on the stone. Hence, the Lamb is also the stone. In other words, the Redeemer who took away the sin of the world has become the building stone, the building One.

This concept is not new. Before the Lord Jesus was crucified, He indicated to the Jewish builders that they were not only rejecting the Redeemer but also the cornerstone (Matt. 21:42). I believe that as the Lord Jesus was talking to them, He fully realized that He was the stone spoken of in Zechariah 3:9, the stone that had seven eyes and that, by being engraved, would remove the iniquity of the people in one day. He knew that He would be engraved by God to take away the iniquity of God's people in one day so that God could have His building.

Both the Lamb and the stone, redemption and building, are connected by the seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God and the seven lamps burning before His administrating throne. Therefore, we have the Word, God, the flesh, the Lamb, the Lion, the stone, the seven eyes, the seven Spirits, and the seven lamps. Ultimately, we have the building, God's eternal habitation, the New Jerusalem. None of these words are my interpretation; rather, they are my quotation. I am simply pointing out ten crucial terms found in the Bible: the Word, God, the flesh, the Lamb, the Lion, the stone, the seven eyes, the seven Spirits, the seven lamps, and the New Jerusalem. When we put all these terms together, like the pieces of a jigsaw puzzle that are scattered here and there in various books of the Bible, we really see something. If we would pray over these ten items, we would see the vision that the New Jerusalem is the consummate enlargement of God.

The age of the stone

In the beginning was the Word, the expression, of God. One day, the very God, expressed as the Word, became flesh. This was His first step to enlarge Himself. This flesh was the Lamb of the righteous God, the God who judges and condemns sin. The Lamb took away sin to fulfill God's righteous requirements. This was the second step of God's enlargement. When He was crucified, He was engraved, and this engraving removed the iniquity of God's people in one day. In addition to this, He is also the Lion, indicating that He has defeated all the enemies. As the Lion He has accomplished an absolute defeat of the enemy. He is both the redeeming Lamb and the overcoming Lion for the enlargement of God. This Lion-Lamb is now the stone. Do you know what the Lord Jesus is today? He is the stone. He is the Lamb and the Lion in order to be the stone. Having removed the iniquity and having defeated all the enemies, He is now building. This age is not the age merely of the Lamb and of the Lion; it is mainly the age of the stone. Now we can understand why, in His last visit to Jerusalem, the Lord Jesus indicated to the Jewish builders that they were rejecting not only the Lamb, the Redeemer, and the Lion, the Overcomer, but also the stone, the head cornerstone. After His death and resurrection, the age became the age of the church, which is God's building. For the building of the church, Christ is the rock. As He Himself told Peter, "You are a stone, and on this rock I will build My church" (Matt. 16:18, lit.). After the crucifixion and the resurrection, the age became the age of the rock, the age of the stone. This is the age of building.

Christianity, having missed the mark, nearly makes this age simply an age of redemption. Some of the so-called inner life Christians have proceeded a little further and speak about the overcoming Lion. It seems that throughout the centuries no one has ever realized that this age is not merely the age of redemption and of overcoming, but mainly of the building. Christ today is the stone. We all must see that this age is the building age. Praise the Lord that He is now the Lion-Lamb-stone. His victory and His redemption both were for Him to be the stone. If He had not defeated the enemy and removed iniquity, there would have been no way for Him to accomplish God's building work. Hallelujah, our Lord Jesus is now the Lion-Lamb-stone!

This stone has seven eyes. This is the crucial point. These seven eyes are the seven Spirits of God, and the seven Spirits of God are the seven burning, flaming lamps. What is the function of the eyes? Certainly, it is seeing. The seven eyes of Christ, however, are not for seeing things but for Him to see us, to look at us. Undoubtedly, the seven eyes of the building stone are for transfusing and infusing. Whenever He looks at us, we can understand if He is happy or unhappy. There is no need for Him to say anything. By looking at us, He transfuses all that He is into our being. Hence, the eyes are for transfusing and infusing. As we have already mentioned, the seven Spirits of God are for the imparting of life because, in the Bible, the Spirit is the Spirit of life. The seven lamps are for enlightening, searching, exposing, and judging in God's move. This is for God's administration. The transfusing by the eyes, the imparting of life by the Spirits of God, and the enlightening, searching, exposing, and judging by the seven lamps are all found in the book of Revelation. All this is for the New Jerusalem. Before we came into the church, we never heard anything like this. But after we were in the church, we experienced something shining in us to search out every secret of our entire life.

A personal testimony

Before I came into the church, I was saved and was loving the Lord. I did not love the world. Rather, I was a clean, young Christian who sought the Lord, studied the Bible, and prayed every day. However, after I came into the church, I was thoroughly searched, not by any teacher, but by something within. At that time, I did not have the terms we have today. Nevertheless, I experienced the searching and made a thorough confession to the Lord. Before coming into the church meetings, I used to make a thorough confession of item after item. What a searching and digging that was! Many of us have had a similar experience. This was the experience of the enlightening, the searching, the exposing, and the judging of the Lord. I can still recall the judgment I underwent as I came to the meetings. I hated myself, my nature, my old man, and my disposition. Oh, how I hated and judged myself! I especially experienced this at the Lord's table. On the one hand, I was remembering the Lord, but, on the other hand, I was under His judgment. He seemed to be saying, "You are so fleshly, so natural, and so much in yourself. You are still too much in the old creation." As I sat at the Lord's table, I was under this inner judgment. This was the work of the flaming lamps in the church. I had never experienced this before.

As a result of this flaming of the seven lamps, the Lord Jesus became so precious, so dear, and so lovable to me. Never before had I had such a deep sense of the Lord's preciousness and loveliness. This was the transfusing and infusing of the Lord Jesus Himself into my being. How dear, precious, and available the Lord was to me! He was a lovely treasure to me. I loved Him more than ever before. I had truly been infused with Him. I can testify that during that time I was in the third heaven and that every sin and weakness was under my feet. I had no need to try to overcome anything.

Following this infusing, there was the impartation of life. The seven lamps became the seven eyes, and the seven eyes became the seven Spirits. The enlightening, searching, exposing, and judging issued in the transfusing of the Lord Jesus into me, and this transfusion resulted in the impartation of life. I received more life, the life which is just Christ Himself. More of Christ was added into my being. He was imparted deeply into my whole being. In those days I did not have the terminology, but I did have the experience. As a result, I had some transformation, and I loved the church and all the saints meeting with me. This was the building.

The seven lamps becoming the flow of living water

Ultimately, this building will consummate in the New Jerusalem, which will be the ultimate and eternal enlargement of our wonderful God. If you would understand the Gospel of John and the book of Revelation, and even the whole Bible, you must see the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits of God. Eventually, the New Jerusalem comes into existence, in which the seven Spirits before the throne of God's administration will become the flow of the river of water of life proceeding from the throne. In the New Jerusalem, the seven lamps before the administrative throne will become the water of life flowing out of the life-imparting throne, and the stone Himself will be the lamp shining God through the city for eternity. These are the crucial points of the revelation in the Bible. May we all see them.

The Universal Bright Woman

The first section of the book of Revelation, composed of the first eleven chapters, covers all things to eternity. The second section, comprising the last eleven chapters, gives details of the important things and crucial matters from the last three and a half years of the present age, which will be the period of the great tribulation, to the eternal age of the new heaven and new earth. The first of these important things and crucial matters revealed in this section is a woman with a man-child (Rev. 12:1-18).

The first eleven chapters of this book cover the seven seals and the seven trumpets. The seven seals and the seven trumpets give us a brief yet inclusive sketch of the contents of this book. The first four seals (Rev. 6:1-8) cover the nearly two thousand years of history from the time of Christ's ascension until the end of this age. We are now living at the very end of this age, very close to the time of the fifth seal. The fifth seal (Rev. 6:9-11) consists of the prayer of the martyred saints. When this seal is opened, the thousands of martyred saints who have been slain for the Lord's testimony will cry to God for vengeance, beseeching Him to intervene and deal with rebellious mankind. The sixth seal (Rev. 6:12-17) will be God's answer to the cry of the martyred saints. The supernatural calamities of this seal will be a warning to those who dwell on this earth. These six seals bring us to the end of this age.

The seventh seal, which includes the seven trumpets, is all-inclusive. Since the seven trumpets are the content of the seventh seal, the seventh seal equals the seven trumpets. The first four trumpets (Rev. 8:7-12) are supernatural calamities, God's judgment upon the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the sun, moon, and stars. These four trumpets will damage heaven and earth, causing the earth to no longer be a suitable place on which mankind can dwell. The heavens are for the earth, and the earth is for mankind to dwell on. However, since mankind has continually disappointed God, rebelling against Him, God will eventually declare that His toleration has come to an end. The great earthquake and the shaking of heaven in the sixth seal will be a warning to earth's dwellers. This warning will be an introduction to the supernatural calamities to follow. After the first four trumpets have been sounded, the time of the great tribulation will be at hand. The sixth seal and the first four trumpets of the seventh seal will be a preliminary to the great tribulation. The fifth trumpet (Rev. 9:1-11), which will bring damage directly to man, will be the beginning of the great tribulation. The fifth trumpet is the first of the three woes mentioned in 8:13. The sixth trumpet (Rev. 9:12-21), a further judgment on men, will be the second woe. The third woe (Rev. 11:14), part of the negative content of the seventh trumpet, will consist of the seven bowls of God's wrath poured out upon Antichrist, his people, and his kingdom (Rev. 16:1-12, 17-21). These seven bowls included in the seventh trumpet will close the great tribulation. After this, the Lord Jesus will come down to earth to fight Antichrist at the war of Armageddon. Antichrist will be defeated and, with the false prophet, will be cast into the lake of fire (Rev. 19:19-21). Following this, the millennial kingdom, lasting a thousand years, will be ushered in. Then will come the new heaven and the new earth with the New Jerusalem for eternity. The seventh trumpet will last for eternity. This is a brief sketch of the book of Revelation.

The scroll of God's economy which Christ has opened needs eternity to be fully opened. Today, we can only see a portion of it. When we get into the new heaven and new earth and live in the New Jerusalem, we shall have a much fuller vision than we have now. The scroll which we shall see in eternity will be eternally long. The seventh trumpet, which continues into eternity, includes many significant things: the last part of the great tribulation, the resurrection and rapture of the majority of the believers, the reward to the saints, the fall of Babylon the great, the marriage of the Lamb, the seven bowls, Christ's descent to the earth with His overcomers as His army to fight Antichrist at Armageddon, the binding of Satan, the millennial kingdom, the last rebellion of mankind, Satan's being cast into the lake of fire, the judgment at the great white throne, the new heaven, the new earth, and the New Jerusalem.

Brother Nee conducted a study of the book of Revelation when he was young. After that study, he saw more and more light concerning this book. In 1933, we asked him to give us a thorough study of the book of Revelation. He told us that he would not give us the study we had requested unless we had read this book so many times that we knew every chapter and could almost recite the entire book. At the time, I thought that this demand was too great. But through the years I have gradually learned that if we would understand this book, we must be fully acquainted with all the points and details it contains. We must be thoroughly familiar with every chapter.

We have seen that the first eleven chapters of Revelation are a general sketch and that the last eleven chapters give us the details of certain important things and crucial matters. Do not consider the last eleven chapters as the continuation of the first eleven chapters. No, in a sense, the last eleven chapters are a retracing of the first eleven chapters. Reading the book of Revelation is similar to reading a map of a city. First we look at the main streets and see a general sketch of the city. Then we go back to consider the smaller streets, lanes, and other details. After gaining a general understanding of the map, we proceed to consider it section by section.

The first important detail and crucial matter in the second half of Revelation is the woman mentioned in 12:1. This verse says, "And a great sign was seen in heaven: a woman clothed with the sun, and the moon underneath her feet, and on her head a crown of twelve stars." Here, the woman is revealed in the heavens and is called "a great sign." This great sign is not of a strong man, but of a woman. The woman in this tremendous vision is not on the earth but in the heavens. She is clothed with the sun, underneath her feet is the moon, and on her head is a crown of twelve stars. She is under the shining of the twelve stars, above the shining of the moon, and enveloped with the shining of the sun. Because of this, she is fully emancipated. Anything that is in darkness is bound and imprisoned, but anything that is in the light is released and emancipated.

Would you like to be a part of this woman? Let me ask you this question: Are you a male or a female? All the sisters, of course, find this question easy to answer. But what would the brothers say? If they say that they are males, then they have no part in the woman of this vision. Does this woman include you? If it does, then, in the eyes of God, you are a female.

From the beginning of the Bible to the end, in the eyes of God, God's people are considered as a woman. Isaiah 54:5 says, "Thy Maker is thine husband." In Jeremiah 3:14 the Lord tells His children that He is married to them, and in Jeremiah 31:32 He says that He is a husband to them. Moreover, in Hosea 2:19 and 20 the Lord says that He will betroth His people unto Himself forever. Although, as we all know, the Lord Jesus came as the Savior and as the Lamb, one day He indicated to His disciples that He came as the Bridegroom (Matt. 9:15; John 3:29). Furthermore, in 2 Corinthians 11:2 Paul says, "I have espoused you to one husband, that I may present you as a chaste virgin to Christ." Brothers, do you have a husband? Praise the Lord that our husband is Christ. Naturally, we brothers are males, but spiritually, we are, in a sense, females in God's eyes. In God's eternal economy there is one unique man — Christ. Adam was a symbol, a type, of Christ as the Bridegroom, and Eve, the wife of Adam, was the symbol, a type, of God's people being the counterpart, the wife, of Christ. Therefore, in His economy God's redeemed people are always considered by Him as His wife, and God considers Himself as their husband. In Revelation 12 we have the woman and her child, but here we are not told who her husband is. Nevertheless, this chapter reveals that she is pregnant and is about to deliver her child. By whom did she become pregnant, and who is the source of her child? By reading the whole Bible, we see that the husband is God in Christ.

I. A symbol of the totality of God's people

It is difficult to understand the book of Revelation. If we would rightly interpret this book, we need all the other sixty-five books of the Bible. Hence, in order to understand who this woman is, we need the whole Bible. Some Christian teachers have held the concept that this woman is Mary, the mother of Jesus, and that the man-child is Jesus. This concept, however, does not suit the context of this chapter because Jesus ascended to the heavens nearly two thousand years ago. But in 12:5 and 6 we are told that the man-child will be raptured to the throne of God and that, following this, the woman will be nourished for "a thousand two hundred and sixty days" (v. 6). These twelve hundred sixty days are three and a half years or forty-two months (12:14; 11:2-3; 13:5), which will be the period of the great tribulation. This proves that the man-child is not the Lord Jesus and that the woman is not Mary. Mary was just a single woman on earth, but this woman is universally corporate and is revealed in heaven.

Others say that this woman is Israel, the Jewish race. Some of those who hold this view take Genesis 37:9 as their basis. According to this verse, Joseph had a dream in which "the sun and the moon and the eleven stars made obeisance" to him. Since the woman wears the sun and the twelve stars and stands upon the moon, apparently corresponding to Joseph's dream concerning his family, it is said that the woman in Revelation 12 must signify Israel, the Jewish people. But 12:17 proves that this woman does not only comprise those who "keep the commandments of God," but also those who "have the testimony of Jesus." Those who "keep the commandments of God" are Jews. However, those who "have the testimony of Jesus" must be New Testament believers, not Jews. This is a strong proof that the woman is not only composed of Jews but of two classes of people: the Jews who keep the commandments of God and the believers who have the testimony of Jesus. Therefore, to say that this woman is merely Israel does not fit the whole context of this chapter.

The woman in this chapter is the totality of God's people. According to the vision, this totality is in three sections: the section of her head with the twelve stars, the section of her body clothed with the sun, and the section of her feet on the moon. Hence, this woman is universal, composed of the twelve stars, the moon, and the sun. In Joseph's dream, the sun, the moon, and the eleven stars plus Joseph himself signified the total composition of God's people on earth. Based upon the principle of that dream, the sun, the moon, and the twelve stars here must signify the totality of God's people on earth, which in this chapter is symbolized by a woman.

Most of her being is clothed with the sun. The sun signifies God's people in the New Testament age. Before Christ came into the world, it was the dark night of the Old Testament age. When Christ came, it was the sunrising from on high (Luke 1:78 KJV, margin), the beginning of the age of the sun. Before that, it was the age of the moon, which signifies God's people in the Old Testament time. The moon is under the feet of the woman, for the age of the moon was the age of the law, which should not be exalted as the stars. The stars, which signify the patriarchs, God's people before the law was given, are on her head as a crown. All God's people in these three ages, who together constitute this woman, are light bearers. Hence, she is the bright woman shining throughout all generations.

A. The patriarchs symbolized by the twelve stars

If we read the Bible carefully, we shall see that God's people are grouped into three sections. Firstly, there are the patriarchs, who lived from the time of Adam until the time of Moses; secondly, there are the people under the law, from Moses until Christ's first coming; thirdly, there are those from Christ's first coming to His coming the second time, the believers who compose the church. Those in the third category are the majority of God's people in the universe. The patriarchs are symbolized by the twelve stars (Dan. 12:3) shining individually in the night with heavenly light. All the patriarchs were individual stars. They dwelt in the nighttime because, in their age, Christ had not yet come and day had not dawned. As individual stars, they are a crown for this universal woman, symbolizing the glory of God's grace and His economy exalted. The number twelve signifies completion in God's eternal economy. The patriarchs, who are in the principle of God's grace, were not under the law; hence, they were a crown exalted above the head of the woman. All the patriarchs, such as Abel, Enosh, Enoch, Noah, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, are considered to be a crown.

B. The children of Israel symbolized by the moon

After the patriarchs, we have the children of Israel, symbolized by the moon, reflecting the sun (Christ) and shining collectively in the light of Christ. The children of Israel were in the night under the law. Although the law was good, it was not exalted. Rather, in this chapter it is pictured as the moon underneath the feet of the woman. According to this vision, the moon is not upon her head but underneath her feet. The moon is bright and shining, but it is underneath her. This means that the principle of the law is not exalted in the eyes of God.

C. The church composed of all the believers symbolized by the sun

This woman is clothed with the sun, with Christ. According to Luke 1:78 and 79, when Christ came, that was the sunrising. Matthew 4:13-16 says that Christ came as a great light to shine upon the people in darkness. This means that before Christ's coming it was nighttime. The church composed of all the believers symbolized by the sun shines collectively in the day with the glory of God (Phil. 2:15; 2 Cor. 3:18). That the church is the major part of God's people is indicated by the fact that the sun clothes the woman's body. Since Christ has come, we live in the day. Although, in a sense, the age in which we live is the night and we shall have a greater day when the Lord comes back, this day that began at Christ's first coming is at least a small day. The millennial kingdom will be a greater day because at that time the light of the sun will be seven times stronger than it is today (Isa. 30:26). We live in a small day expecting the coming of a greater day. We are in the onefold sunshine expecting a day with sevenfold sunshine. Some may argue with me, pointing out that Romans 13:12 says that the night is far advanced and that Revelation 22:16 says that Christ is the bright morning star. I am familiar with all these verses. Remember that the truths in the Bible have two aspects. We must take both aspects, both sides, into account. Since Christ has come, we are not in the night — we are in the day. What are we — a star or a part of the sun? On the one hand, we are the stars in the night (1:20); on the other hand, we are a part of the sun in the day.

How wonderful is this great sign! This is another proof that the Bible was inspired and written by God Himself. No one else could have had the wisdom to use the symbol of the woman to signify all of God's people. Moses, David, Solomon, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Daniel, etc. were all part of the moon. But praise the Lord that we, the New Testament believers, are part of the sun because we are a part of Christ. This is the vision of the universal bright woman.

II. Universal

The woman in this chapter is universal both in time and in space. She is universal in time, from the creation of Adam to eternity. She is also universal in space, on earth and in heaven. This is a strong proof that she is not Mary, but Mary is included in her, as we all are. How can people say that this universal bright woman is Mary? Mary is too small. She is not that bright and she certainly is not universal. Mary does not wear a crown of twelve stars. Neither is this woman merely the race of Israel, for Israel is represented by the moon. Look at this woman once again: on her head are twelve shining stars representing the patriarchs. Surely Abel, Enoch, Noah, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were all stars. The children of Israel are represented by the moon. No matter how evil and defeated they sometimes were, comparatively speaking, they were a people on the moon. Only the children of Israel, not the heathens or the pagans, were a people standing on the shining moon. Were the Egyptians, Babylonians, Greeks, Romans, or Chinese people standing on the moon? Certainly not. They might have stood on a lump of coal, but not on the shining moon. All other races have been and still are standing on the dark things. Among the human race, only one people, the children of Israel, stand on the moon. However, they do not realize that the moon is a sign that the sun, Christ, will come. Praise the Lord that today we are the sun. Although there are some Jewish believers among us, they are no longer a part of the moon but a part of the sun. The church is the sun because Christ is the sun and we are a part of Christ. Christ is the head sun and we are the body sun. Praise the Lord that we are in the major part of this bright universal woman.

III. Bright in celestial light

The woman in chapter twelve is not only universal both in time and in space, but is also bright in celestial light. She stands upon the bright moon and under the bright stars and is clothed with the bright sun. She is altogether bright, not being in any darkness. Her brightness is celestial, heavenly. We, the church, as her greatest part, must be like this.

IV. A universal war

In Genesis 3, the little serpent came in through the woman. Throughout the centuries, the expositors of the Bible have said that the serpent came in through the woman because she was weaker than the man. In my early ministry I also said the same thing. But now I realize that in fulfilling God's economy we must firstly be the female, not the male. The serpent, the subtle one, knew whom he had to poison. Today, we are not a part of Adam but a part of the universal bright woman. Satan came in to damage the female because he knew that she would be used by God to accomplish His purpose. Anyone who does not firstly consider himself as a female in the eyes of God can never fulfill God's economy. You must firstly consider yourself as a female, saying, "Lord, I am not the man. Lord, You are the man, and I am part of the woman. Since You are the male and I am a part of the female, I must take You as my husband and my head and submit to You."

After the serpent damaged the woman, God intervened to judge the serpent, saying, "I will put enmity between thee and the woman, and between thy seed and her seed; it shall bruise thy head, and thou shalt bruise his heel" (Gen. 3:15). Revelation 12 must be interpreted by Genesis 3. In Genesis 3:15 we have the woman, the serpent, and the seed of the woman. In Revelation 12 we have the same three things, although on a larger scale. The woman is now much greater, the serpent has become a great dragon, and the seed of the woman has also developed into the man-child. The woman in Revelation 12 began with the woman in Genesis 3:15. We need the vision to see in this universe the sign of a great universal bright woman travelling in birth to bring forth a child. In front of this woman is a dragon fighting against her and seeking to devour the child as soon as he is born. This enmity, which is first seen in Genesis 3:15, is of God; it was God who put enmity between the serpent and the woman. In the universe today just one war is raging — the war between God's people as the woman and the serpent as the dragon. Have you seen this vision? Today, we all are the greatest part of the woman, and in front of us is a dragon.

How did the serpent in Genesis 3 become the dragon in Revelation 12? It was by eating a great deal. Through his eating the serpent has been continually increasing. Many have been feeding him, and now he is trying to devour us. But we will never be devoured by him; rather, we will give him a death blow. When the Lord cursed the serpent, He assigned him to eat dust (Gen. 3:14). As long as we are dusty, earthy, we are food for the serpent. But if we are heavenly, the serpent cannot devour us. We are not dusty or earthy; we are a part of the heavenly, bright woman.

We must see the vision that in the universe a warfare is raging between the woman and the dragon. Whoever persecutes the church is one with the dragon. Because the Catholic Church persecutes the Lord's lovers, she is one with the dragon. In chapter seventeen, we see a beast with seven heads and ten horns, the same number of heads and horns that the dragon has (12:3; 17:3). On this beast sits a woman clothed in purple and scarlet and gilded with gold and precious stone and pearls (17:3-4). The apostate Catholic Church, being the prostitute riding on the beast, is one with the dragon in persecuting the bright woman. When the apostle Paul was Saul of Tarsus, he persecuted the church. At that time, was he a part of the moon, a part of Israel? We say strongly that he was not. Likewise, the Pharisees, although they were Jews, were not a part of the moon. The Lord Jesus called them "serpents" and the "generation of vipers" (Matt. 23:33). They were "the seed of the serpent," as mentioned in Genesis 3:15. Along with Saul of Tarsus, they had become part of the great dragon. But praise the Lord that Saul was converted!

It does not matter whether or not you are religious, for as long as you persecute the church, you are part of the dragon or at least one with the dragon. The ancient Jews thought that they were fighting for God. But they did not realize that they were fighting together with the dragon to persecute God's people and to damage and frustrate God's economy. Christians today must be careful. Their attitude towards the church determines what they are and where they are. Any Christians who persecute the church are one with the dragon, taking sides with him against God's economy. If we have this vision, we shall see that there can be no neutral ground. There are only two parties — the woman or the dragon. To which party do you belong? With which do you stand? Some so-called Christians hate the church and are eager to see it collapse. They speak lies about the church and spread rumors concerning the church. They oppose the church and do everything possible to frustrate and damage her. This is of the evil spirit of the dragon. These people are one with the dragon. If they are not a part of the dragon, they at least take sides with the dragon. You may ask, "Are they not Christians?" I would reply with this question: Were not the Pharisees the Jewish religionists? Certainly they were. They held to their Scriptures. According to their opinion, everything they did, including sentencing Christ to death, was according to their Scriptures. But what were they in actuality? They were vipers, snakes, part of the great dragon, doing things to destroy God's economy. Until the sovereign Lord intervened as Saul was on the way to Damascus, Saul also was actively a part of the dragon. When the Lord appeared to him, knocking him to the ground, He seemed to say, "Saul, what are you doing? I, Jesus, have come to visit you." At that time, Saul was converted and translated out of the darkness of Satan into God's kingdom of light. At the time of his conversion, the Lord charged Saul, telling him to open people's eyes "that they may turn from darkness to light and from the authority of Satan to God, that they may receive forgiveness of sins and an inheritance among those who have been sanctified by faith in Me" (Acts 26:18). By the example of Saul of Tarsus we see that whoever persecutes the church today is part of the dragon or at least one with him.

The dragon is now persecuting the church and plotting to damage it. The opposition is active in Orange County and throughout this country. The dragon is everywhere on earth, seeking to devour whatever the church would bring forth. Have you seen this revelation? It is not a small thing. We are for the Lord's recovery. We face the attack of the dragon, but who will be victorious? Hallelujah, the dragon will be cast down, and we shall be victorious. Firstly, the dragon will be cast down from the heavens to the earth, then from the earth to the abyss, and finally from the abyss to the lake of fire. We can declare, "Satan, go to your destination in the lake of fire. Do not remain on earth any longer. The earth is for Christ, not for you. Our Christ is coming to possess the earth, and you must go. Satan, you have no choice — go to the lake of fire!"

Revelation, the last book of the Bible, unveils Satan's destiny. Among all the important things and crucial matters in the second half of Revelation, the first is the universal bright woman in chapter twelve. We are the topmost item, the most crucial thing. Now is not the time to sleep; it is the time to fight. Wherever we are, we must say to the opposition and persecution, "Go to the lake of fire!" We are the woman, and Satan is in the lake of fire.

The Woman and the Man-Child

In the Bible there are some crucial signs. One of them is Jacob's dream at Bethel (Gen. 28:10-22). In that dream Jacob saw heaven opened and a ladder set up on earth extending from earth to heaven. This sign needs the whole Bible for its development. Another sign is Nebuchadnezzar's dream (Dan. 2:1-45). In that dream he saw a great image symbolizing the power of the Gentiles. Although that sign appears simple, it covers the Gentile powers from Babylon to the coming kingdoms of the revived Roman Empire. If we would understand that sign fully and adequately, we need to consider the whole of world history. In Revelation 12 there is still another sign — the great sign of the bright woman with the man-child. In this message I am burdened to give a further word on this great sign.

The view that the woman in Revelation 12 is Mary is entirely too narrow. To say that the woman is merely Israel, the race of the Jews, is also inadequate, for the woman in this vision is not local but universal. The woman in this chapter is not limited to any locality on earth; rather, she occupies the universe. As we have seen in the last message, she represents the totality of God's people from Adam until the end.

God's need for the woman and the man-child

Before God's people can be the man-child, they must firstly be a woman to Him. This indicates that we in the church today must firstly be the woman to God and then the man-child. By the sign in Revelation 12 we see that God's intention is to bring forth a man-child through this woman. The woman has been and still is the means by which God can bring forth this man-child, the one whom God will use to defeat His enemy and to bring in His kingdom. In other words, God will use this man-child to fulfill His economy and to accomplish His purpose. This is a great matter. In order to accomplish His purpose, God not only needs the individual Christ but also a corporate Christ, the church, God's people. We do not agree with the concept that this woman is merely the mother of Jesus or the nation of Israel. She is the universal, corporate body of God's people. God needs the man-child to defeat His enemy and to bring in His kingdom that His eternal purpose might be accomplished. In order for Him to have such a man-child, there is the need of the woman.

The position of the woman

Now we need to see a few crucial matters relating to the position of the woman in the Bible. The Bible reveals that in God's eyes His people are His wife. In Isaiah 54 God even refers to Himself as the husband to His people. According to the Bible, in order for a woman to be a proper wife, she must submit to her husband. In this universe the unique husband, the unique man, is God. God, the universal man, the universal husband, is our husband. Whether we are males or females by birth, being God's people, we are females in God's eyes. God is our husband, and we are His counterpart. As His wife, we must submit ourselves to Him. Although we may say that we are a wife to Christ, we still have our own way and intention. Often, we do not take His will and intention as ours. This means that we do not actually take Him as our husband or submit to Him.

A wife must also receive something from her husband in order to become pregnant. The Bible reveals that submission is to receive something of Christ, just as the woman submits to her husband, not to do something for him but to receive something of him. Nothing that a wife does for her husband is more important than receiving something of her husband. Actually a wife's duty is not to do things for her husband; it is to receive something of her husband that she may bring forth something for her husband. In the great sign in Revelation 12, the woman is not portrayed as doing anything for her husband; she is pictured as being pregnant. She has been impregnated by her husband in order to bring forth something for her husband. The church's duty is not mainly to do something for Christ. Her duty is to receive something of Christ that she may be made pregnant of Christ and may bring forth something for Christ.

The woman in this chapter firstly indicates submission to God. Secondly, she indicates that we do not need to do anything for God. What we need is to receive something of God. He does not need anything of us, but we need something of Christ to enter into our being that we might be made pregnant and might bring forth something for Him. The church today needs Christ. This vision is altogether lacking in today's Christianity. When Christians speak about submission, their concept is to do something for Christ, to perform some work for God. But as the proper woman, we must firstly submit ourselves to our husband, not to do something for Him, but to receive something of Him. If we do this we shall be made pregnant, and something will be brought forth through us.

The meaning of fornication

Now we need to consider what fornication is. Fornication is to have a husband and to submit yourself to another man. Many Christians today, perhaps including some of us, are committing fornication. We commit fornication when, on the one hand, we admit that Christ is our husband, while, on the other hand, we submit to so many other things. Submitting ourselves to anything other than Christ is fornication. If we have the light, the vision, we shall see that Christianity today is full of this kind of fornication. As a chaste wife, you should not submit to anyone other than your husband, and you should not receive anything from anyone else. To receive something from someone other than your husband is fornication. But look at today's Christianity! Week after week and day after day, Christians are receiving things other than Christ. We in the church life should be careful not to receive anything other than Christ. We should not receive teachings, doctrines, practices, or forms. To receive something other than Christ, even if that thing is good or even scriptural, is to commit spiritual fornication. We should receive only Christ and allow only Him to make us pregnant.

The way to produce the man-child

Only by receiving Christ into our being can we bring forth the man-child. The man-child is formed wholly of the constituent of Christ. In order to produce the man-child, we must first be one with Christ and receive something of Him. When we receive something uniquely of Christ, we shall be made pregnant of Christ to bring forth the man-child. If you see this vision, you will feel sorrowful about the situation in today's Christianity. Where is the man-child? Christianity has produced many things, but there is nearly no man-child. Because Christianity has been impregnated of things other than Christ, hardly anything that it brings forth is the man-child.

God does not intend for the woman to fight the dragon. God intends to use the man-child to fight against the dragon. The dragon is still active in the heavens because the man-child has not yet been brought forth. Now we can see that this life-study of Revelation is not accidental; it was planned and timed by God that we all might see that we must be the unique woman submitting ourselves only to Christ, not to anything or anyone else, and that we must only receive what is of Christ. When, as this woman, we receive something uniquely of Christ, the man-child will be brought forth.

The difference between the woman and the man-child

The man-child is the stronger part of the woman. On the one hand, we firstly must be the woman; on the other hand, we must also be the man-child. It is not adequate simply to be bright and heavenly. We must be fully constituted with the element of Christ. The difference between the woman and the man-child is this: not much of the element of Christ is constituted into the being of the woman, but the entire being of the man-child is saturated and permeated with the element of Christ. Hence, the man-child is the very constitution of Christ. How can this man-child be brought forth? He is brought forth by Christ's getting into part of the woman to constitute that part of her with all the rich element of Christ. Do not consider this merely as an interpretation, but apply it to your daily experience. Even if you submit yourselves to Christ and receive something of Him, you are still the woman and are not yet the man-child. You will not be strong until you have allowed the element of Christ to be worked into your being. The more the element of Christ is worked into you, the stronger you will become. This is the man-child.

Becoming part of the man-child by following the Lamb

Do not understand the man-child in just a doctrinal way as consisting of the dead overcomers resurrected. Doctrinally speaking, this is correct. But we do not like to understand the Bible simply in a doctrinal way. Rather, we must know the Word in a practical way. Even today, before the time of resurrection, we can be the man-child. If you are not a part of the man-child today, then how do you expect to be a part of the man-child in resurrection?

The principle in becoming the firstfruit or the man-child is the same: we must follow the Lamb wherever He goes (14:4). However, in my early ministry I did not realize that following the Lamb is not an outward matter. We should not say, "Oh, the Lamb was patient and humble, and we must imitate His patience and humility. The Lamb was absolutely for God, and we must also be absolutely for Him. The Lamb is our example, and we must follow Him." Forty years ago, I gave messages along this line. But later I realized that this is a natural understanding of following the Lamb. If the element of the Lamb does not get into us, we shall be unable to follow Him. We are not a lamb; we are "monkeys" or "donkeys." How could a "monkey" or a "donkey" follow the Lamb? It is impossible. To follow the Lamb means to allow the Lamb to get into you. When the element of the Lamb is constituted into your being, you will actually be a part of the Lamb. You will be unable to be what you were before because you have been transformed. Our transformed being is the man-child. Now we are the woman submitting to our husband and receiving something of Him into our being. If we allow the element that we have received of our husband to saturate and permeate our being, constituting us with this element, we shall no longer be simply the woman, but the man-child.

Although we need to pray more, if we simply pray in a common way, we shall not be supplied. We need to constantly be open to our husband. We must permit the element of Christ, the divine constituent of Christ, to work in us continually to saturate and permeate our whole being. Today, the Lord's desire is that many of His children realize that, as God's people, we are His wife for the purpose of bringing forth the man-child. We cannot produce or manufacture this man-child; we must receive something of Christ and be made pregnant of Him. Something of our Christ must enter into our being. It is not a matter of our being humble, patient, nice, or good. It is absolutely a matter of opening our being to His divine element and of allowing this element to be worked into us. For this, we need "nine months." It takes this long for the man-child to be developed within us.

The apostle Paul said in Galatians 4:19, "I am again in travail until Christ is formed in you." This indicates that he realized that he was part of this travailing woman to bring forth the man-child, which is Christ formed in us. Then in Philippians 1:21 he said, "For to me to live is Christ." This indicates that he became a part of the man-child by experiencing Christ. On the one hand, he was a part of the travailing woman and, on the other hand, he was a part of the man-child. Paul was set up by God as a pattern for the believers (1 Tim. 1:16). We all must be like him. On the one hand, we should be part of the woman to travail for the birth of the man-child and, on the other hand, we should be the man-child to defeat God's enemy and to bring in His kingdom for the fulfilling of His purpose.

The dragon's hatred of the woman

The enemy hates this woman and is seeking to devour the man-child. The warfare is due to the enemy's desire to put this woman out of function. Even today, we in Anaheim are small in number. Sometimes I wonder why people oppose us so much and are doing everything possible to exterminate us. Humanly speaking, it is very difficult to understand this. Even many of the opposers and critics do not know the reason. But the great dragon knows. He realizes that some of God's people are resuming the true position of the woman. Once we have resumed this position, God has the opportunity to bring forth the man-child. Satan, the subtle one behind the opposers, knows that some of God's people have taken the position of this woman and that they will be made pregnant of Christ to bring forth the man-child. In this warfare we must touch the throne, call upon the highest authority, and exercise our spirit to fight the battle.

The importance of seeing this great sign

Today, it is crucial for us to realize that we are the woman. As the woman, we must submit to our husband, open to Him, and receive something of Him that His element might be wrought into our being. As a result, we shall not only become pregnant, but, eventually, we shall bring forth a man-child. This is God's economy. I hope that we all see this simple yet profound sign of the bright woman with the man-child opposed by the great dragon. If we see this vision, our concept regarding our Christian life will be radically changed. What is the significance of being humble, nice, holy, or spiritual as long as the man-child, or even the woman, is not with us today?

The way to be one

As individuals, you and I are not the woman. Only together, as a corporate unit, are we all the one woman. Since there is only one woman, whoever of God's people is dissenting is finished with this woman. The only way we can be one is to submit ourselves to Christ and to receive something of Christ. If we do not submit to Him, we cannot be one. True oneness only comes from submitting ourselves to our one husband, to the unique headship. Furthermore, we must only receive the unique element of Christ. Although we may have different concepts, we should not receive anything of our concept. If you receive something of your concept, you will be divided immediately.

Satan, the serpent, is very subtle. It has not been easy for me to pass through nearly fifty years in the church life. How many subtle imaginations and concepts there are! At times, even the dear saints are utilized by the enemy to cause questions, to make proposals, and to raise doubts. None of these things is of Christ. Whenever you take these things into your being, you will be divided. But if you have seen the vision, you will never accept any concept, proposal, criticism, suggestion, or doubt. You will only receive something of Christ. Although thousands of concepts may be presented to you, you will say, "I will receive nothing of these concepts. I will only receive something of Christ. If I receive anything other than Christ, I commit fornication." If we submit ourselves to our one husband and only receive something of Him, we shall be chaste and we shall be one. Otherwise, we shall be fornicators and we shall be divided. Fornication is confusion caused by division. We need to see this controlling vision. Then we shall be one and shall bring forth the man-child to defeat God's enemy and to bring in God's kingdom.

The Man-Child and the Rest of the Woman's Seed

We have seen that the woman in Rev. 12 is not an individual woman, but a collective, universal woman symbolizing the totality of God's people. In Gen. 3:15 the woman was local and individual; the seed, Christ, was also individual; and the serpent was a small snake. All three, the woman, the seed, and the serpent, were individual and on a small scale. But in Revelation 12 the woman is universal and collective, symbolizing all of God's people: the patriarchs represented by the twelve stars; Israel represented by the moon; and the church, the New Testament believers, represented by the sun. In Revelation 12 the serpent has become a dragon. While the serpent creeps on earth, the dragon flies through the air. Now Satan not only moves on the earth, but is also exceedingly active in the air. The seed in this chapter is not just the individual Christ but is a corporate entity, the corporate Christ, including Christ as the Head and all His overcoming believers as the Body. Hence, the three items found in Genesis 3:15 are seen in a highly developed form in Revelation 12. In this message we need to consider the man-child and the rest of the woman's seed.

I. The man-child

A. The stronger part within the woman

Verse 2 says that the woman was with child, and verse 5 says that "she brought forth a son, a man-child." The child here, being a man-child, signifies the stronger part of God's people. Although in verse 2 this child was in the woman, the Word does not call him a baby, but a man-child. By reading and praying over this portion of the Word, we realize that man-child here does not indicate a baby. Rather, it indicates the stronger part within the woman. The woman represents the totality of God's people. But throughout all generations there have been some stronger ones among God's people. These are considered in the Bible as a collective unit fighting the battle for God and bringing God's kingdom down to earth.

History proves that not everyone among God's people is a strong one. No, only a minority of God's people are strong ones. This was true during the time of the patriarchs. Do you not believe that during Noah's time there were others who belonged to God besides Noah? I believe that God had hundreds of people. Noah, however, was a strong one. During the time of Israel, there were hundreds of thousands who belonged to God, but only a few of them were strong. For example, Elijah and Jeremiah were strong ones. Undoubtedly, the majority of God's people were genuine, but they were not strong. We find the same thing in the New Testament. Although there were thousands of Christians in the early days, not that many were truly strong. Even at present there are thousands, even millions, of Christians, but not many are strong. I encourage you all to be strong.

We should not only be part of the woman, but also part of the man-child. In the Bible woman signifies the weaker one, and man signifies the stronger one (1 Pet. 3:7). The man-child, the stronger part, is within the woman, the weaker part. Although the woman is bright and universal, she is not altogether strong. Only a part within her is strong. This is true in the local churches, even here in Anaheim. Not all those in Anaheim are strong ones. Rather, I believe that in Anaheim there are more weak ones than strong ones. How about your locality? Everywhere the strong ones are few, and the weak ones are many.

There is a proverb that says that if we do not have quantity, we can never have quality. Quality comes out of quantity. Suppose God had a hundred thousand people. If one per cent of this number were strong ones, then there would be one thousand strong ones. Firstly, we have quantity, then quality. God's way is always wise. Firstly, He gains the quantity. He calls many, but chooses few. As Matthew 22:14 says, "Many are called, but few are chosen."

Although we all have come into the Lord's recovery, we should not say that everyone in the recovery will be an overcomer. We have no warrant for saying this. We can only say that those in the recovery have a greater possibility of being overcomers. Whether or not you will be an overcomer depends upon you; it depends upon how much you share of God's grace. How much you share of God's grace will determine whether or not you will be a strong one among God's people in the Lord's recovery. I thank the Lord that we all are part of the woman, but I dare not say that we all are also part of the man-child. We must look to the Lord that we may be enriched, strengthened, and become more solid so that we might grow from the woman into her stronger part. But no matter how strong you become, do not prematurely separate yourself from the woman. If you do that, you will have a miscarriage. Be careful not to be "too strong." If you are too strong, you will come out of the woman too soon. Stay in the woman as part of the man-child until the time of delivery has come.

How can we be the man-child? If you would be part of the man-child, you must eat more, grow more, and become stronger. To put it into practical terms, you must pray more, spend more time with the Lord, eat more of the Word, experience the Lord more, grow in life more, and have more dealings with the negative things. If others would gossip, you would not gossip. If others would not pray, you would pray more. Although you should not be separate from the woman, you should be somewhat different from others. The woman is too general. Those who are part of the man-child are somewhat particular. Many of the dear ones in the Lord's recovery are indifferent. They have little appetite and do not like to eat very much. But if you would be in the man-child, you should not be indifferent. You must be particular, sober, and serious. You must have a good appetite and have a personal, direct moment by moment dealing with the Lord. If you are like this, then it is possible that you will be the stronger part in the Lord's recovery, the stronger part within the woman. Whether or not you will be in the man-child depends upon how you react to God's desire, God's move, and God's eternal economy. If, day and night, you cannot go on until you have given yourself wholly and thoroughly to God's economy, then it is likely that you are a part of the man-child.

Not only the Lord's economy but even His recovery today depends upon the stronger ones, not upon the indifferent ones. There might be thousands in the Lord's recovery, but not all are strong ones. Praise the Lord for the strong ones. The Lord's recovery today absolutely depends upon them. Not all those in the Lord's recovery in the United States are strong. Some say, "Oh, I love the Lord's recovery, but I just can't make it." Such a one means business and loves the Lord's recovery, but he is not absolute. Thank the Lord for the honest and faithful ones. They are absolute, saying, "This is it! I will be absolutely for it. I don't like to be neutral." We should be either cold or boiling hot, but not lukewarm. If we are lukewarm, we are only good for being vomited out of the Lord's mouth (3:16).

Firstly, the Lord's economy is with His people represented by the woman. But the Lord's economy cannot be carried out merely by the woman. There is the need of the strong ones. This is always the principle. We must be absolute and strong. If we would take this way, we would take it absolutely. But if we would not take it, then we would forget about it. We must not only be part of the woman, but also part of the man-child within the woman. It is not adequate simply to be in the Lord's recovery. We have to be among that part in the Lord's recovery which is strong. Whatever tests and trials may come, we would stand against them. You are all familiar with Brother Watchman Nee. He was imprisoned for over twenty years. During that long trial, he was daily tempted to fail. But praise the Lord that for more than twenty years he stood without changing. He was truly among the stronger part. Do not excuse yourself. Rather, you should say to yourself, "Poor self, get away. I have no heart for you and I don't care for you. I care for the Lord and for His testimony and recovery." We all must be absolute and strong.

If you are absolute, and strong, your appetite will be enlarged. Some think that the three messages put out each week by the ministry station are too much to digest. When I was young, I could have taken in thirty messages a week. How easy it is to take in just three messages a week. We only need to read six pages a day. However, if you do not have any appetite, even a small piece of candy would be too much for you to take in. How much we eat depends upon our hunger. Do you have a big appetite? If you do, you would like to devour the whole Bible. Three messages a week are not too much. Even three messages a day would not be excessive. Many of you have time to gossip, but you do not have time to read a few pages of the life-study messages. Are you in the man-child? If you are, then you will be hungry. Mothers know that if a child does not have a good appetite, he will not grow and be strong. If you do not eat, you cannot grow, and if you do not grow, you will not be strong. The Lord's recovery depends upon the hungry ones. Whether or not you are part of the man-child depends upon how hungry and thirsty you are. If you are truly thirsty, you will hate gossip and nonsensical talk. You will say, "I am here to be trained, strengthened, nourished, and built up. I have neither the heart nor the time for gossip. I have no appetite for idle conversation." If you are like this, it is a proof that with you there is the possibility of being part of the man-child. We are here for the Lord's recovery and for nothing else. Remember that the Lord's recovery is the practicality of His economy today. His economy can only be carried out by the man-child.

It is difficult for most Christians to understand Revelation 12. Many cannot understand who the woman is and who the rest of her seed are. You cannot apprehend this according to your natural mind. The woman is composed of all her seed. If she had one thousand children, these one thousand, put together, would equal the woman. Do not consider the woman as being separate from all her children. The woman, the mother, is her children, and the children are the woman.

This chapter is not just for the future, for it began in Genesis 3:15. Abel was a seed of the woman. As a seed of the woman, he was part of the woman and was persecuted by his brother Cain, who was part of the serpent. The serpent who damaged Eve in Genesis 3 subtly crept into Cain in Genesis 4, making him a part of the serpent. It was not Cain who murdered his brother, but, according to John 8:44, it was Satan, the serpent, who murdered Abel. In Genesis 4 we have the woman represented by Abel and the serpent represented by Cain. As we continue on through the Old Testament, we see that Elijah and Jeremiah were part of the woman and that those who opposed them were part of the serpent. The Lord Jesus certainly was the seed of the woman. In front of Him stood the seed of the serpent, the "generation of vipers" (Matt. 23:33), the Pharisees. All those who opposed the Lord Jesus were part of the serpent. When the apostle Paul was Saul of Tarsus, persecuting the church and laying it waste, he was part of the serpent. But the Lord called him, and Saul became part of the woman. All the synagogues of Satan (2:9) were also part of the dragon. At the time of the New Testament, the serpent had become a great dragon. All the Jewish synagogues had become one with the serpent in persecuting the woman.

This has continued throughout all the centuries until the present time. Today, in one sense, we are the woman, but, in another sense, some of us are the man-child. Directly in front of us is the dragon. Even as I am speaking, I can see the dragon before me. Do not be afraid of him, for we have One who is stronger than he (1 John 4:4). The dragon may send forth the waters, but God will use the earth to swallow them (12:15-16). The first one to be part of the man-child was Abel. All the martyrs are also part of the man-child. As we shall see, all the dead overcoming saints are included in the man-child.

The period of the woman's pregnancy is not nine months; rather, it is approximately six thousand years. It will last from the death of Abel until the time of the great tribulation when Satan will be one with Antichrist to persecute the believers left on earth during the great tribulation. Those Christians who will refuse to worship the image of Antichrist will be the later overcomers mentioned in Revelation 15. From the time of Abel until Revelation 15 will be about six thousand years. This is the period of the woman's pregnancy with the man-child.

In front of the woman who is about to bear the man-child stands a serpent who has become a dragon. This subtle one has been constantly fighting to damage God's people throughout the centuries. He has used every means to accomplish this, including both Judaism and Catholicism. In his history of martyrs, Foxe says that the Roman Catholic Church has killed more saints than the Roman Empire did. If you go to Spain, you will not have the same liberty to speak as we have in this country. If you speak out, you will probably be persecuted by the religious people. Although they would persecute you for the sake of preserving their religion, they would not realize that they are part of the great dragon. Today, this war of persecution is raging. Sometimes I am asked why we have so much opposition and why we do not receive a good name. As long as we are standing for the testimony of Jesus, there will be opposition. Satan never sleeps. Day and night, he is working to oppose and damage the Lord's testimony. But praise the Lord that His recovery is here! The real woman is here, and within her there is the man-child.

Do not think that Revelation 12 is merely for the future. No, it began in Genesis 3:15 and has been continuing ever since. In Galatians 4:29 Paul says that those who are fleshly persecute those who are spiritual. The fleshly are one with the dragon, and the spiritual are those in the woman with the man-child. In this age and on this earth, the woman is here. Within her, there is the stronger part, the man-child. This is the reason that we experience so much opposition and fighting. This opposition is a sign that we are the woman, for if we were not the woman with the strong man-child within her, there would be no opposition. Praise the Lord for this opposition! It is an indication that we are the woman with the man-child within her.

B. The resurrected overcomers throughout all generations

The man-child consists of the resurrected overcomers. That the man-child "was about to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod" (v. 5) indicates that the man-child consists of the overcomers as mentioned in 2:26-27. These overcomers are those who have already died.

1. "Brought forth"

Verse 5 says that the woman “brought forth” the man-child. “Brought forth” here signifies resurrection, as in Acts 13:33-34. The man-child is composed of the overcoming saints who have died and who have been resurrected. This is proved by the words unto death in verse 11. The Lord Jesus was brought forth in resurrection to be the Firstborn Son of God. To Him that was a birth. Acts 13:33 and 34, a quotation of Psalm 2:7, reveal that when He was resurrected, He was begotten as the Firstborn Son of God. Prior to that, He was the Only Begotten Son of God with divinity, but through His resurrection He was begotten as the Firstborn Son of God with both divinity and humanity. All the overcomers who die will be part of the man-child. By resurrection, the man-child will come into full existence. Abel, the apostles, and so many martyrs and deceased overcomers are waiting for the time of resurrection. The resurrection of all the dead overcoming saints will be the delivery of the man-child. Hence, the man-child is composed of all the overcoming saints who die before the time of this resurrection. If you are an overcomer today and live until the Lord comes back, you will not be a part of the man-child. Instead, you may be among the firstfruit mentioned in chapter fourteen. But if you are an overcomer and die before the Lord comes back, you will be resurrected to be part of the man-child. Therefore, the man-child does not represent the overcomers who live until the Lord comes back, but represents all the dead overcomers who will be resurrected immediately before the Lord comes back. This resurrection will be their delivery as the man-child.

2. Composed of the “brothers”

The man-child brought forth in verse 5 is composed of the “brothers” in verse 10 who have been opposed and accused by Satan, the enemy of God. They overcame him by the blood of the Lamb, by the word of their testimony, and by loving not their soul life even unto death (v. 11).

3. Unto death

“Unto death” (v. 11) surely indicates martyrdom. A number of the brothers of whom the man-child is composed were martyred for the Lord’s testimony. This proves that the man-child brought forth by the woman will be the dead overcoming saints resurrected.

4. Overcoming the Devil, Satan

We have seen that war is raging between the dragon and the woman. The woman, however, does not fight the battle. The battle is fought by the man-child. Today, the war is between the dragon and the Lord’s recovery. But, the battle is being fought by the strong ones, by the man-child. The brothers who constitute the man-child fight Satan and eventually overcome him. They overcome Satan by three things: by the blood of the Lamb, by the word of their testimony, and by loving not their soul life even unto death.

a. By the blood of the Lamb

The blood of the Lamb, which is for our redemption, answers before God all the accusations of the Devil against us and gives us the victory over him. We need to apply this blood whenever we sense the accusation of the Devil. If you wage war against Satan, the accuser will constantly condemn you. Many of us can testify that when we were indifferent, there were no accusations. But when we woke up and began to war against Satan, then the accusations came. Satan said, “Look at yourself — you are not very good. You are not right with your wife or with your brothers.” Some of these accusations are accurate, but others are falsehoods fabricated by the accuser. Day after day we need the blood, not only to cleanse us but also to cover us. We not only have the redeeming blood, but also the prevailing, overcoming blood. If you have done wrong, you need to clear it, but do not take the accusations of the enemy. Whenever you wake up and take your standing against the dragon as a stronger part of the woman, the dragon will immediately accuse you in your conscience. Do not listen to those accusations. Rather, you must say, “Lord, cover my conscience, thoughts, and realizations with Your prevailing blood. Your blood defeats the enemy.” You need to make your conscience strong under the covering blood. The brothers overcame the accuser by the blood of the Lamb.

According to our experience, when we turned to the Lord for His purpose, the accusations came immediately. But we did not know that those accusations came from the enemy. We thought that it was the working of our conscience being enlightened. Satan, the serpent, is the subtle one. He always does things in a subtle manner, pretending to be something that he is not. Satan often pretends to be us. When we were indifferent toward God’s purpose, we had no trouble with this. But once we had turned to the Lord for His purpose, it seemed that our conscience was continually working to tell us of the things in which we were wrong. That was not you — it was Satan. How can we prove that it was Satan? If your conscience is truly working under the light of God, then once you confess and apply the blood, that condemnation will cease and you will have genuine peace. If this is your experience, then the condemnation is from your enlightened conscience working within you. But many of us can testify that after we confessed and applied the blood, the so-called condemnation lingered on. This is not the condemnation of our conscience, but the accusation of the Devil. Condemnation comes from God, but accusation comes from the accuser. Any apparent condemnation that does not stop after we have confessed and applied the blood must be of the Devil. Once we realize this, we should tell Satan, “Stop! I will not confess anymore. This is not me; it is you. Devil, this is not God’s enlightenment — it is your accusation. I am not perfect, but you must realize that I am under the blood of the Lamb, and the blood is my perfection. Don’t you realize that I am under the blood? I am one of the brothers who overcome you, not because of my perfections, but by the blood of my Redeemer.”

None of us knows how much the blood implies. Only God knows this. The Devil also knows more of what the blood implies than we do. In the early years of our ministry we had experience in casting out demons. During that time, we did a great deal of gospel preaching in China and often we had to conquer cases of demon possession. Many times as we were praying to cast out the demon, sharp accusations came against us. The demon said, “Will you pray to cast me out? Don’t you remember that last night you lost your temper with your wife? Now you want to cast me out?” Immediately, our praying conscience was weakened and our praying mouth was shut. Instead of praying, we declared, “Yes, last night I lost my temper with my wife. But, demon, don’t you know that now I am under the blood?” When you mention the blood, the demons will be defeated. The demons know more about the power of the blood than we do. A number of times, demon-possessed females took scissors and, as we were praying, threatened to cut us with them. Then we declared, “We are under the blood. Demons, you must realize that your king and leader, Satan, the Devil, has been crucified and that you and he have been judged.” Whenever you say this, the demon-possessed person will relax. Through experience we have come to see the power and authority of the blood of the Lamb. We must always apply the blood, telling the Devil that although we are not perfect, we are under the perfect blood. It is not your perfection that silences the demons — it is the blood. None of us has a complete perfection. Rather, our perfection is punctured. Do not trust in your perfection and do not fight the battle by your perfection. Even now as I am ministering, I do not minister by my perfection. I have come here to minister by the blood. Hallelujah, the blood is here! We all must see the blood and declare that we are under its covering. This blood is the prevailing blood, and it speaks and implies a great deal. Only God and, to some extent, the Devil know how much the blood implies. But whether or not we know all that the blood implies, as long as we apply it, we shall have all it implies.

b. By the word of their testimony

They also overcame the enemy by “the word of their testimony.” This is their word testifying that the Devil has been judged by the Lord. Whenever we sense the Devil’s accusation, we should verbally testify how the Lord has already dealt with him. We must declare the Lord’s victory over him with the uttered word. We need to testify not only to men but also to the demons, saying, “Demons, you must be reminded that Satan, your king, has been defeated by my Lord Jesus Christ. You should not be here troubling me.” Along with testifying to the demons, you need to preach to Satan, saying, “Satan, don’t you know that you have been crucified on the cross? You have been judged, and your destination is the lake of fire.” This is the testimony of your verbal word. Do not simply keep these thoughts in your mind — you must utter them to Satan. Although no one may be with you in your room, Satan is there. I have preached to the demons and to Satan. That preaching was not for their repentance; it was a repellent. By spraying the heavenly poison through our verbal testimony, all the “bugs” are killed. You may not see any demons, but they are there. Some brothers have wondered how I can be so strong. The reason is that by preaching to the “bugs” I am strengthened. But my strength is not in what I am — it is in what the blood is. I am not the poison. The demons are not afraid of what I am, but they are afraid of what the blood is. We need to apply the blood.

Shortly after we moved into our new house, we were troubled by gophers. Some brothers put poison into the gopher holes, and all the troublesome gophers were exterminated. Our “poison” today is the blood of Jesus and the word of our testimony.

We need to send out the word of our testimony. At times, you may need to preach to Satan for several minutes, saying, “Satan, I was deceived by you for years. One day, my Lord came to me and said that I was redeemed at the cross. Satan, don’t you know this?” You need to speak to him like this. Many of us have never preached to Satan, but now we all must learn to do this. If you would preach prevalently, the first person to whom you must preach is Satan. This preaching to the enemy is the word of our testimony.

Our testimony is that we were sinners but that the Lord is our Redeemer. He died on the cross for our sins, and now we have His blood. Tell this to Satan! After you have spoken to him about this, say, “Satan, you should not be here. Your destiny is firstly the abyss and then the lake of fire. But I want you to stay here awhile until I have finished my message to you. Only then will I allow you to be released.” If you preach to Satan like this, the accuser will not dare to trouble you because you trouble him. After you have finished your message, say to the enemy, “Satan, don’t come back again. If you do, I’ll give you a longer sermon.”

The brothers overcame him not only by means of the blood, but also by the word of their testimony. The blood is the fact, and the word is our preaching. The blood implies the fact that our sins have been forgiven and taken away, that we have been crucified, that Satan has been judged, and that his head has been bruised. When we apply the blood, we apply all these facts. After applying the blood, we must declare the facts to Satan. This is the way to overcome the enemy.

If you apply the blood and preach to Satan, he will be threatened. He accuses you, troubles you, and makes you of none effect. He would destroy you by his accusations. I am afraid that many dear ones are still under the destruction of the Devil’s accusations. They say, “Oh, I love the Lord, but I am not perfect. I have made so many mistakes and blunders.” The result of these accusations is to make you of no effect. Through the crippling effect of his accusations, the enemy confiscates you. But you must tell him, “Devil, my standing is not my perfection. My standing and my covering are the blood.” Anyone who is still under Satan’s accusations should preach a long sermon to him. If you do this, you will immediately be strengthened.

c. By loving not their soul life

The brothers also overcame the enemy by not loving their soul life. Due to Adam’s fall, Satan has joined himself to man’s soul life, man’s self (Matt. 16:23-24). Hence, to overcome him we should “not love our soul life,” but rather hate it and deny it (Luke 14:26; 9:23). The overcoming believers who constitute the man-child do “not love their soul life even unto death.” Those who do not love their soul life are willing to be martyred. We must hate our self. As long as we love our soul life, we are dust, good to be food for Satan. But if we do not love our soul life, our self, there will be no dust, and Satan will be killed. When our soul life is killed, Satan is killed also. This is the way for us, as the stronger part of the woman, to overcome Satan.

If you preach to Satan, he will leave you. Then you should be prepared to say, “Satan, even if you hate me, I would die to you. I would like to lose my soul life, for when I die, I have a glorious graduation.” If you are willing to lose your soul life, Satan will have no way with you. If he bothers you, you may preach to him; if he hates you, you die to him. What then will he be able to do? He will be able to do nothing and he will quit. This is the way to overcome the enemy.

5. Brought forth by the suffering woman

The man-child is brought forth by the suffering woman, by the suffering people of God (Rev. 12:2, 4-5). The words cried out in verse 2 signify that she was praying. “Being in travail and in pain to bring forth” signifies that throughout all generations God’s people have been suffering the travail of delivery (Isa. 26:17-18; Jer. 6:24; 13:21; 30:6; Micah 4:9-10; 5:3; Gal. 4:19) to bring forth the man-child to fight for God’s kingdom.

6. To rule all the nations

Verse 5 says that the man-child “was about to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod.” This is the authority of Christ (Psa. 2:9) which He gives to the overcomers (Rev. 2:26-27). The man-child, the resurrected overcomers, will exercise the authority of Christ over the nations and rule them with Christ in the millennial kingdom (Rev. 20:4, 6).

C. Caught up

Verse 5 also says that the man-child “was caught up to God and to His throne.” To be “caught up” is to be raptured. The rapture of the man-child differs from that of the majority of the believers as mentioned in 1 Thessalonians 4:17. There, the rapture of the majority of the believers will be to the air and at the last trumpet (1 Cor. 15:52; 1 Thes. 4:16), which will be the seventh trumpet (Rev. 11:15). But here, the rapture of the man-child will be to the throne of God and before the “thousand two hundred and sixty days,” which will be the time of the great tribulation of three and a half years (forty-two months, Rev. 12:14; 13:5; 11:2), beginning from the fifth trumpet (Rev. 9:1).

II. The rest of the woman’s seed

The rest of the woman’s seed mentioned in verse 17 is the weaker part of the woman, which includes the Israelites who keep the commandments of God and the believers who have the testimony of Jesus. Both the Israelites and the weaker believers will be left to go through the great tribulation. They will be persecuted and attacked by the dragon.

The Great Red Dragon and His Persecution

There are three main figures in Rev. 12: the woman, the man-child, and the great red dragon. Throughout the centuries, there has been war between the woman and the serpent. Actually, the battle has not been fought by the woman, but by the man-child. This chapter covers all the generations from Genesis 3:15 until the end of this age. But it especially gives a more detailed portrait of Satan's activity during the last three and a half years. This warfare began in Gen. 3:15, and it will consummate in the last three and a half years. The woman with the man-child and the serpent, which has become the great dragon, will fight until the time of the resurrection of the dead overcomers. When all the dead overcomers are resurrected as one entity, the man-child will come into full existence. This single entity, the stronger part of God's people, will be raptured before the great tribulation, not to the air, but to the throne of God. After the rapture of the man-child, there will be the final three and a half years, or the twelve hundred sixty days.

After the man-child has been raptured to the throne of God, there will be war in the heavens. This indicates that the overcoming saints will exert a great influence upon the coming warfare in the heavens. This war will not begin until the overcoming saints have been resurrected and raptured. After this, there will be war between Satan and his angels and Michael, the archangel, and his angels. (Before Satan fell, he was also an archangel.) After the man-child has been raptured to the throne, there will no longer be any place there for the dragon. Rather, the dragon will be defeated and cast down to the earth. When he comes to earth, the great tribulation will begin. During this period of time, the dragon will do everything possible to damage the man created by God for His purpose. Because up until now God has not yet gained the man-child, He has not had a way to cast Satan from heaven to earth. God needs a corporate man to accomplish this for Him.

The picture in Revelation 12, which concentrates on the last three and a half years, portrays a complete picture of the enmity between the serpent and the woman. When Satan has been cast down to earth, he will cause great damage to the woman, who will still be on earth. In this message we need to consider the great red dragon and his persecution.

I. The dragon

Verse 3 says, "And another sign was seen in heaven: and behold, a great red dragon, having seven heads and ten horns, and on his heads seven diadems." While the serpent is the subtle one, the dragon is the cruel one.

A. Great

Verse 3 says that the dragon is great. In Gen. 3, Satan was a serpent, a smaller creature. Here he has become a dragon, much greater than a serpent. Because the serpent has been eating a great deal throughout the centuries, he has been enlarged into a great dragon.

B. Red

This great dragon is red. Red here signifies the shedding of blood caused by Satan's murders (John 8:44). Abel was the first martyr murdered by the dragon. In Matt. 23:35 the Lord Jesus spoke of the blood of Abel the righteous. The dragon is not only great because of his eating, but is also red because of his murdering so many overcomers throughout the years.

C. Seven heads

The great red dragon has seven heads, which are the seven Caesars of the Roman Empire (Rev. 13:1; 17:10-11). When we come to 13:1, we shall see that these seven heads are the heads of the beast and that the beast will not only be the Roman Empire but also Antichrist. In Rev. 17:9-10, we are told that the seven heads are seven Caesars. That the dragon has seven heads, which are the heads of the seven Caesars and of the beast, Antichrist, indicates that the dragon and the beast are one. This means that the seven Caesars of the Roman Empire are the heads of Satan. By this we see that the Roman Empire, especially Antichrist, is the embodiment of Satan.

D. Ten horns

The dragon also has ten horns. According to Rev. 17:3 and Rev. 17:10, these ten horns will be the ten kings under Antichrist. In the future, the Roman Empire will be restored and will have ten kings. These ten kings equal the ten toes of the great image seen by Nebuchadnezzar in his dream (Dan. 2:42-44). The Roman Empire, like the two legs of this great image, was divided into two sections — the western Roman Empire and the eastern Roman Empire. The ten toes, which are yet to come, will be the ten kings under Antichrist. These ten kings will be the ten horns of the great dragon. This indicates that the Roman Empire, Antichrist, and the ten kings will all be one with Satan.

E. Seven diadems

On the seven heads of the dragon are seven diadems indicating the glory of the seven Caesars' kingship. All these seven Caesars have an extraordinary kingship. This kingship is their crown. Because the seven Caesars are one with Satan, their crowns are also the crowns of the dragon. Each of these Caesars assumes deity, claims to be God, and forces the people to worship him as God. In doing this, they are one with Satan.

F. His tail dragging away the third part of the stars of heaven

Verse 4 says, "And his tail drags away the third part of the stars of heaven, and he cast them to the earth." "The stars of heaven" signify the angels (Job 38:7; Isa. 14:12). "The third part of the stars of heaven" should be the fallen angels who followed Satan in his rebellion against God. Satan drags all of them away. After the man-child has been raptured to the heavens, he will no longer tolerate Satan's presence in the heavens. Then heaven will be cleared up, and Satan will be cast down to the earth. When Satan is cast down to the earth, all the fallen angels will be cast down with him (v. 9). At that time, the earth will be filled with fallen angels who will damage the dwelling place of rebellious man. What a dreadful place it will be! I do not want to be on earth at that time.

Have you noticed that in the word dragon there are the words drag-on? The dragon drags things on. Any dragging in the church life is a sign of the dragon. The dragon not only drags away the angels, but sometimes he drags the saints.

G. Standing before the woman

Verse 4 says that "the dragon stood before the woman who was about to bring forth, so that when she brings forth he might devour her child." That the dragon stood before the woman signifies that Satan is always against the people of God. From the time of Genesis 3:15 to this day, Satan has been continually fighting against the woman with the intention of devouring her child. During the last three and a half years, Satan will oppose that part of God's people who will be left on the earth during the great tribulation.

Do not accept the wrong teaching that all Christians will be raptured before the great tribulation. There is no verse that teaches this. I have been studying this matter of rapture for over fifty years. In my study I have learned that the deep, sound Christian teachers agree that it is wrong to say that all Christians will be raptured before the great tribulation and that no believers will pass through the great tribulation. This concept is a wrong teaching. If you accept it, you may be left in the great tribulation. In 12:5 we see that the man-child will be caught up to God before the last three and a half years. After the rapture of the man-child, the remainder of the woman's seed, including the Jews who keep the commandments of God and the Christians who have the testimony of Jesus, will be left on earth. On the one hand, the man-child will be raptured before the three and a half years and, on the other hand, the seed of the woman, including both Jews and Christians, will be left to pass through most of the great tribulation. After Satan has been cast down to earth, he will do his best to persecute God's people who are still on earth after the rapture of the man-child.

H. The ancient serpent

The ancient serpent is the subtle, deceiving one. Whenever the Bible speaks of the serpent, it denotes the subtle one (Gen. 3:1). By the time of Revelation 12, the serpent is not new; he is ancient, being close to six thousand years old.

I. The Devil

Verse 9 says that the great red dragon is called the Devil. The Greek word for Devil is diabolos, meaning accuser, slanderer. The Devil accuses us before God and slanders us before men. The Devil accused Job (Job 1:9; 2:4-5) and Joshua (Zech. 3:1-2) and is now accusing the believers "before God," even "day and night" (v. 10). The Devil not only accuses us to God, but he also slanders God to us. When the Devil goes to God, he accuses us before God. But when the Devil comes to us, he slanders God to us. Do not think that his slander is apparent, for often he slanders God in a subtle way. For example, he may slander God by raising within you the question, "Why does God do this to me?" This questioning is a form of slander. Something in you may ask why God treats you in a certain way. Do not think that this issues from you. No, it is the speaking of the Devil in you. Any question about the word of God in the Bible is also a slander. If you take a small slander, the Devil will give you a greater one. Then you would say God probably is not faithful. What slander this is! The significance of the title Devil is that he is the accuser and the slanderer.

J. Satan

The great dragon is also called Satan (12:9). In Greek, the word Satan means "adversary." Satan is not only God's enemy outside of God's kingdom, but also God's adversary rebelling against God from within God's kingdom. The enemy denotes the foe outside of God's realm; the adversary denotes the foe within God's realm. Satan was once within God's realm; he was not an outsider. Hence, he was and still is the adversary. Where is this adversary? He is inside of you. He is not only the outside enemy, but also the inside adversary. It is easy to defend yourself against an enemy, but it is difficult to defend yourself against an adversary because he is within you. The adversary is in your house.

You need to realize that this adversary is inside of you. Many times he will pretend to be you. Not realizing that it is he, you may think that it is you. Often when you are wrong, you should not blame yourself that much. Rather, you should say, "Satan, you must bear the blame because this is not I, but you." Dare you say this to Satan? You may not be bold to say this because you have been deceived. Before 1936, I was deceived for over eleven years. When filthy thoughts entered my mind, I confessed them, telling the Lord how bad I was and asking Him to forgive me. But the more I confessed, the more these unclean thoughts came in. One day, in 1936, I saw that I was being cheated. These thoughts were not mine; they were the thoughts of the evil one. From that time onward, I have not confessed these things anymore. Instead, I say, "Satan, take this away. I refuse to be cheated by you. This is not my thought; it is yours. Now get rid of it. Satan, you must be condemned." Do not be kind to Satan and do not be cheated by him. Be bold to speak this way to him. Satan is within you. Because of this, he pretends to be you. Thus, you must say to him, "Satan, this is not I — it is you. I don't care whether you are outside of me or inside of me — you are you. You are the adversary." Learn to say this to him. Do not be cheated into believing that you are that bad. Satan, not you, is the bad one. Before we repented, we did not admit that we were bad. Rather, we were arrogant, saying, "I'm not sinful — I'm perfect." But after we repented, were saved, and received grace, the adversary subtly came to us, causing us to think that we were so dirty and so bad. That is the thought of the adversary.

For many years, I did not know the difference between the enemy and the adversary. As the adversary, Satan is even in the church pretending to be something that he is not. In Matthew 16:22 we see that Peter was cheated. Peter thought that he was speaking, but actually it was Satan. The Lord exposed the adversary, saying, "Get behind Me, Satan" (Matt. 16:23). Likewise, in our experience, many times it is not we who do certain things; it is Satan, the adversary.

K. The deceiver of the whole inhabited earth

Verse 9 says that the great dragon, who is called the Devil and Satan, "deceives the whole inhabited earth." No one is an exception; everyone has been cheated by him. Everyone on earth, from the highest to the lowest and from the greatest to the least, is being deceived by Satan. If we would know who the great dragon is, we must know all these aspects regarding him.

II. His persecution

A. Being cast down from heaven to the earth

Now we must see the dragon's persecution. Verse 13 says, "And when the dragon saw that he was cast to the earth, he persecuted the woman who brought forth the man-child." The dragon will be cast down from heaven to earth (vv. 9-10, 13). As we have seen, this has not yet taken place because the man-child has not yet been brought forth and raptured to the heavens. But one day the man-child will be resurrected and raptured, and Satan will be cast down.

B. Knowing he has a short time

After Satan has been cast down to the earth, he will know that "he has a short time" (v. 12). The short time here will be the three and a half years of the great tribulation (v. 14; 13:5; 11:2).

C. Having great rage

The dragon will also have great rage (v. 12). He will be angry because of losing his territory in the heavens and in the air. He will be cast down and limited to the earth. This will enrage him.

D. Persecuting the woman

The dragon will persecute the woman who brought forth the man-child. Satan will concentrate his hatred upon God's people. Due to this, I encourage you to be prepared to be among the overcomers. Otherwise, you will be part of the woman left to pass through the major part of the last three and a half years. During that time, you will have to face the angry dragon.

E. Casting water like a river out of his mouth after the woman

Verse 15 says, "And the serpent cast water like a river out of his mouth after the woman that he might cause her to be carried away by its current." "Water" here signifies armies which will be sent by Satan to destroy the people of God (Isa. 8:7-8; 17:12-13; Jer. 46:7-9; 47:2-3). Satan will speak a word to the kings of this earth to gather their armies to persecute the people of God. Three unclean spirits like frogs will proceed out of the mouth of the dragon, the beast, and the false prophet (16:13). These unclean spirits will "go forth to the kings of the whole inhabited earth, to gather them to the war of the great day of God the Almighty" (16:14). These spirits will instigate the rebellious kings to send their armies to persecute God's people, which will include the loyal Jews and the faithful Christians. If you are left to pass through the great tribulation, you may have to suffer this.

F. Making war with the rest of the woman's seed

Verse 17 says, "And the dragon was angry with the woman and went away to make war with the rest of her seed, who keep the commandments of God and have the testimony of Jesus." The "rest of her seed" signifies the people of God other than the man-child. Among them, some will be the Jews "who keep the commandments of God," and some will be the believers who "have the testimony of Jesus." Satan will not only persecute the woman, but will make war with the rest of her seed, with the weaker part of the woman.

III. God's preservation of the woman

A. Giving her the two wings of the great eagle to fly into the wilderness

Verse 14 says, "And the two wings of the great eagle were given to the woman that she might fly into the wilderness into her place." The "great eagle" signifies God, and the "two wings" signify His strength to rescue (Exo. 19:4; Deut. 32:11-12). As God brought the children of Israel out from Pharaoh's persecution, so will He bring His people away from Satan's persecution in the great tribulation. The mighty God will afford His people divine strength to escape Satan's persecution.

Some may wonder what the wilderness is. I cannot answer this question definitely, but I do have my own realization of what it might be. Although I do not wish to interpret this verse, I am willing to share with you my realization of what the wilderness is. Since its beginning, the United States has been a land to which people who desire a free conscience toward God might escape. We are all familiar with the story of the Mayflower. The pilgrims fled from persecution and escaped to this country. For more than three hundred years, America has been used by God as a refuge for His escapees. The symbol of this country is an eagle. When the persecution comes, many of God's people may escape to the United States by airplane. Hallelujah, there will be a wilderness on earth for God's escapees! Even today, the United States is still a refuge for escapees.

B. Swallowing the river by opening the earth

We have seen that the dragon will "cast water like a river out of his mouth after the woman." Verse 16 says, "The earth helps the woman, and the earth opened its mouth and swallowed the river which the dragon cast out of his mouth." At that time, just as in Numbers 16:31-33, the earth will open and swallow the armies sent by Satan. This means that during those three and a half years there will be many earthquakes. God will use these earthquakes to open the earth to swallow the armies sent by Satan. Do not be on earth at this time. Rather, we should watch this from the heavens. When God sends the earthquakes during the great tribulation, earth will no longer be a good place on which man can dwell peacefully. God will shake the earth, not only to warn the earth dwellers, but also to swallow up Satan's armies. Satan will send his frogs to stir up the kings of the earth to send their armies, but God will move His little finger to shake the earth that the earth might swallow up the armies. This will be God's way to deal with the situation.

C. Nourishing her in the wilderness a thousand two hundred and sixty days

Verse 6 says, "The woman fled into the wilderness, where she has a place prepared by God, so that they might nourish her there a thousand two hundred and sixty days." Moreover, verse 14 says that the woman will "fly into the wilderness into her place," where she will be "nourished for a time, and times, and half a time from the face of the serpent." After the rapture of the man-child, the woman will be left on earth to suffer persecution (v. 13). During the time of the great tribulation, God will prepare a place to nourish her for "a time, and times, and half a time," or "a thousand two hundred and sixty days," the three and a half years of the great tribulation. God will nourish her before He brings His people into the millennial kingdom. This is similar to the time when Pharaoh persecuted the children of Israel and God brought His people to the wilderness, where He nourished them before bringing them into the good land. The United States is so rich in food that it can nourish nearly any number of people. No country on earth is as rich in food as the United States. Praise the Lord that there will be such a nourishing place on earth!

We have seen a general picture of the coming days. Since Genesis 3:15, both the woman and the serpent have been present, fighting against one another. Throughout the years, this fighting has increased and intensified. It will continue to do so until the time of the end when all the martyred saints will be resurrected and raptured to the heavens as the man-child. When they reach the throne, they will say, "Satan, here we are. Now that we have come, you must go down to earth." Then Michael, the archangel, and his angels will war against the dragon and his angels. The dragon will be cast to the earth and the great tribulation will begin. During that time, the dragon will persecute and make war against the people of God who are still on earth. This will last three and a half years. But God will still be sovereign. On the one hand, He will swallow up Satan's armies by opening the earth. On the other hand, He will afford a way for His people to escape and He will nourish them in a special place. God will preserve His people. However, I do not want to enjoy that preservation. I prefer to be taken away before the great tribulation. How about you? Praise the Lord for this clear picture of the coming days.

War in Heaven

I am burdened that we would all see the vision in Rev. 12. Do not think that the portrait here is a small picture showing a few insignificant matters. No, it is a great vision regarding what is taking place in the entire universe. The woman in this vision has been representing the people of God since the fall of man in Genesis 3. The woman not only represents God's people, but also God Himself. In front of the woman is a dragon signifying God's enemy. Throughout the centuries, the war has been between the woman and the serpent, the dragon.

This vision unveils the true situation in the universe. The worldly people can only see the obvious outward things: commerce, politics, industry, education, war. If you ask them the meaning of all this, they would say that they do not know. They only know to obtain an education that they may have a good job to earn a good living. They do not have the vision of what is taking place in the universe. But we see clearly what is going on. A woman symbolizes God's people and represents God. In a positive sense, the wife always represents her husband. If your wife does not represent you properly, you will be shameful. But it is wonderful to have a wife to represent you in a good way. This signifies that we, the people of God, are His wife and that we need to represent Him adequately. God is the unique husband, and we, the unique wife, represent Him. But God has an enemy. Firstly, this enemy was a little serpent. Eventually, however, it became a great dragon who is now in front of us. If you do not have this vision, you will be blind, not knowing what is taking place on earth or in the universe. Praise the Lord that it is not simply a matter of education, industry, commerce, diplomacy, etc., but a matter of warfare between the people of God and God's enemy. This war has been raging throughout the centuries and it is still raging today.

We all must be aware of the fight between the woman and the dragon. Actually, it is not the woman who fights, but the stronger part within her. Of those in the Lord's recovery, some belong to this stronger part. This stronger part must bear the responsibility to fight the battle. The way to fight is by praying. Through the past four messages the dragon has been exposed and now he is naked. Hallelujah, we know what and who he is, and we know what his destination will be. We all need to preach to Satan about this. This will terrify him.

Most Christians mainly see that man fell, that God so loved the world and sent His only begotten Son to be the Savior, and that sinners need to hear the gospel, repent, and be forgiven of their sins and saved, so that one day they will go to heaven. But we must see something higher. The book of Revelation unveils a universal scene, a universal view. It is not simply that man has fallen — it is that God's enemy is fighting against Him. In His economy God has selected a people to be a glorious woman. Once we were sinners, but now we are part of this glorious woman. Before I was saved, I was a poor sinner, but after I was regenerated, I became a part of the glorious woman. Look at how bright she is. In her there is no darkness at all. With her, everything is light — the light of the sun, the moon, and the stars. In front of this glorious woman is a blood-shedding, murderous dragon. We have no choice except to fight against him. But, according to the vision, the whole woman does not fight; the stronger part within her does the fighting against the dragon.

I. Because of the man-child's rapture to heaven

There will be war in heaven because of the man-child's rapture to heaven. Many Christians have a poor concept of the rapture, thinking that rapture is merely for the purpose of giving them a happy time, of taking them to a pleasant place. The rapture is not only for us; it is for God's economy and for God's strategy. God's enemy is still in the heavens. This enemy has been judged and his sentence has been pronounced, but during the past nineteen centuries God has not had those who could execute His sentence upon the enemy. Satan, the enemy of God, was judged by the Lord Jesus on the cross (John 12:31; 16:11). Following that, there is the need of the overcoming believers to carry out that judgment, to execute that sentence. The fighting waged by the overcoming believers against Satan is actually the execution of the Lord's judgment upon him. Eventually, through their fighting, he will be cast out of heaven (v. 9). Who will go to heaven to execute God's judgment and command the condemned, judged, and sentenced enemy to depart? The angels will not do this, for they are not qualified. The angels lack the position to do this because, being angels, they are on the same level as Satan who formerly was among them. God needs a man to accomplish this. This man has a Head — the man Jesus. He is the Head of the man-child, the Pioneer of all the overcomers. God needs such a man to execute His sentence upon Satan. God has been waiting a long time for this man. Although God does not have him yet, one day He will have him.

We must be raptured to the heavens to fulfill God's need. We should not care that much for our own happiness. To care for our happiness is a Babylonian concept. This is also the concept of Catholicism derived from Babylonianism and resembling Buddhism. Religion is for human happiness, for having a good life in a merry land after we die. This thought is devilish. But, alas, this concept has infiltrated all of Christianity. Christians only care for their happiness, saying, "We like to have joy and a happy life. We want to go to heaven when we die, for we shall be happy there." In Christianity you probably never heard that God has an eternal purpose and that we must fulfill God's purpose. We need to be raptured to heaven, not for our happiness, but for the fulfilling of God's purpose. We must go there to execute God's judgment upon His enemy. God is waiting for this.

A. The overcomers having fought unto death against Satan on earth

Verse 7 says, "And there was war in heaven." Immediately after the man-child is raptured to heaven, a war commences with Michael and his angels against Satan. This indicates that the man-child, the stronger part of God's people, is always engaged in fighting God's enemy, Satan. The overcomers have been fighting Satan continually, even unto death, and have defeated him on earth. But heaven is still waiting for them to arrive there that a war may be waged to cast Satan out of heaven.

The Lord has shown us the most effective way to defeat the enemy. What we need to do is to take the covenant, the word of God, and preach to Satan regarding what the Lord has accomplished for us. For example, whenever we were troubled by our temper in the past, we firstly confessed it, then asked the Lord for forgiveness, prayed to the Lord to help us, and finally made up our mind never to lose our temper again. I experienced this many times. But we should not do this anymore. When our temper is aroused, we should forget it and preach to Satan. Go to the source of the problem — Satan — and preach to him, saying, "Satan, you have been crucified on the cross." The more you preach to Satan, the more you will be released.

When the man-child is delivered and is raptured to the throne, he will say, "Satan, you were defeated by me on earth. Are you still here hiding in the heavens? Now I have come here to preach to you! Don't you remember the messages I gave you on earth?" I am not joking about this. When we get there, this will be the situation. Then the man-child will say, "Satan, you should no longer be here! Get out!" As soon as this word is uttered by the man-child, Michael the archangel will lead all his angels to war against the dragon. After the executor gives the word, all the policemen will come to carry it out. God is waiting in the heavens for this executor. Who will be the executor? We, the man-child. Let us go there to preach to Satan. Before we can do this, however, we must first defeat him on earth. After defeating Satan on earth, we shall fight upward to heaven and eventually we shall fight downward to earth. Now as we confront Satan, we must give him many messages. Later, we shall go to the heavens, meet him there, and preach to him again. Then, after he has been cast down to earth to damage it, we shall descend and say to him, "Satan, are you still here? Let me give you another sermon. Now is the time for you to go to the abyss." Then after the millennium there will be the fourth sermon given to Satan. At that time, Satan will instigate mankind to rebel against God. But we shall say, "Satan, listen to us. This is our last sermon. Now you must go to your destination — the lake of fire."

If you would be qualified to participate in this, you must fight now. Do not be indifferent. I hope that after you read this message you will give a strong word to the enemy, saying, "Satan, you have deceived me for years. But by reading these messages, my eyes have been opened and I see that I must no longer be indifferent. Satan, you are not only God's enemy — you are also my enemy. From now on, I will be absolute for my Lord and I will never listen to you." The longer you make your message, the better it will be. Also, it is better for us to do this preaching individually. If you preach to Satan like this, you will become another person and will probably soon be included in the stronger part of the woman. Begin now to be qualified, equipped, and perfected to be among those who will be raptured to heaven to execute judgment upon Satan. We must tell the enemy, "Satan, I will preach to you on earth today. Later, I will also give you a message in the heavens. After that, I will see you on earth and preach to you once more. Finally, I will give you one more message, and then you will be cast into the lake of fire."

I say again that the rapture is not for our happiness; it is for God's purpose. Our God is waiting for the overcomers, the man-child, to go to heaven to execute His judgment upon the enemy. What a privilege it is to share in this! The angels are not positioned to share this privilege, but we are. Now we have the ground to say, "Praise the Lord that I am in the position to be an overcomer!"

We have seen that as soon as the man-child is raptured to heaven, the war begins. When I was young, I sought to understand why this war will start immediately after the man-child is raptured to the throne. I also wanted to know why the man-child did not actually fight but that the fighting was done by Michael and his angels. The reason is that the man-child is the executor, and the executor does not need to fight. Rather, he simply gives the word. After we, the executor, give the word, the angels who serve us will fight for us. The angels are our servants. When we say, "Satan, go away," Michael will take the lead to fight against him. When the executor gives the word, all the policemen will carry it out. Are you willing to be in the stronger part of the woman? If you are, then you must learn to preach to Satan. Satan has constantly been troubling you, but after you decide to preach to him, he may run away, for he knows what you intend to do. Thus, you need to say, "Satan, don't go yet. You are not allowed to leave until I command you to do so. Stay here until I am through speaking to you."

The angels are ready to war against the dragon. Michael might even be saying, "Man-child, come up here and give us the word. We'll carry it out." But if we would be qualified to be there in the heavens to execute judgment upon Satan, we must begin to execute the judgment upon him now on earth. Say, "Satan, I will not let you go. I will bind and defeat you."

B. Having wrestled against the spiritual power of wickedness in the heavenlies

This is what Paul meant when in Ephesians 6:12 he spoke of wrestling, not with flesh and blood, but with principalities, powers, and spiritual wickedness in the heavenlies. These powers are Satan's angels. Satan is a usurping, self-enthroned king. Under him, there are many angels who are the princes, the principalities, and authorities in the air. According to the Bible, the principalities, powers, and authorities under Satan, rule over the countries on earth. For example, Daniel 10:20 speaks of "the prince of Persia" and "the prince of Grecia." All heathen countries are under the ruling of these satanic princes in the air. In Daniel chapter ten, Daniel prayed for three weeks. Although he was burdened to pray, he did not receive an answer. Eventually, a heavenly visitor said to Daniel, "From the first day that thou didst set thine heart to understand, and to chasten thyself before thy God, thy words were heard, and I am come for thy words. But the prince of the kingdom of Persia withstood me one and twenty days" (Dan. 10:12-13). This heavenly one had been sent to Daniel, but he was frustrated by the prince of Satan. However, as Daniel 10:13 continues, "Michael, one of the chief princes, came to help me." Ancient Persia and Greece both were under principalities in the air. The nation of Israel, however, was not under a satanic prince, but under Michael, the defender of Israel. While Daniel was praying those three weeks, a war was raging in the heavenlies. If we would be the overcomers, the stronger part of the woman, we must pray. All the rumors, criticisms, and opposition do not come from any human beings, but from Satan, who is behind them. If you pray like this, you are qualified to be an overcomer. Do not spend time dealing with your temper or your besetting sin. These things are little "bugs." Rather, tell Satan, "Satan, I have been distracted for years with paying attention to my temper and to my besetting sin. But now I shall pass this on to you. I will not pay attention to these things, but I will pay attention to preaching to you. I don't have the time to pray about my temper, but I do have the time to give you another sermon." We all have been deceived, saying, "Oh, my temper and my besetting sin! If I don't overcome them, how can I be holy, see the face of the Lord, and have the proper church life?" Leap out of your besetting sin and give Satan a sermon. According to my experience, I can testify that if you try to overcome your temper, your temper will be enlarged. Do not pray to overcome your temper — pray to overcome "the prince of Persia" and "the prince of Greece." Pray that there may be a way for Michael to come. Pray that many in the Lord's recovery may not only remain part of the woman but also become part of the man-child. If we pray like this, then one day the man-child will come into existence, and the archangel Michael will take the lead to wage war in the heavens against the dragon and to cast him down to earth.

C. Being resurrected and raptured to heaven and not tolerating to see Satan in the heavens

After the man-child has been resurrected and raptured to heaven, he will not tolerate to see Satan in the heavens. Even today, we should not tolerate to see Satan in the church, but should fight against him. If you fight against Satan today, you will be qualified to fight against him in the heavens. After we have been raptured to the throne of God, we shall see Satan, and he will be terrified of us. When we see him, we shall not tolerate his presence there and we shall say, "Satan, are you still in our God's sanctuary? This is not your place. Satan, you must go." Immediately, Michael will act on our word and war against him.

II. The archangel michael and his angels warring with the dragon

Why will Michael and the angels not fight the dragon now? The reason is that they are not the legal and qualified executors. They are simply the policemen. We, the man-child, will be the legal and qualified executors. As we have seen, after we have spoken our executing word, the captain and his policemen will fight against the enemy.

A. Having contended with the Devil about the body of Moses

The Bible reveals the names of two angels — Michael and Gabriel. Gabriel is a reporter bringing news to God's people (Dan. 8:16; 9:21-22; Luke 1:19, 26), whereas Michael is a fighter contending for God's people (Dan. 10:13, 21; 11:1; 12:1; Jude 1:9; Rev. 12:7). Jude 1:9 reveals that Michael the archangel contended with the Devil about the body of Moses. God had a purpose for Moses' body. Moses had to be present on the Mount of Transfiguration and, according to chapter eleven, he must return to be one of the two witnesses. Hence, God had to preserve his body. Satan, however, wanted to destroy it. But Michael fought against Satan regarding this.

B. Having fought the princes of Satan for the people of Israel

Daniel 10:13, 21 and 11:1 have unveiled that Michael has fought the princes of Satan for the people of Israel. Michael has always been a fighter for the interests of God.

C. Now fighting the dragon to cast him out of heaven to earth

Michael has been fighting throughout the centuries. When the man-child is raptured to heaven and gives Michael the word, he will fight once more against the dragon to cast him out of the heavens to the earth. I want to be there to see this take place, to execute the word, and to see Michael act upon it. I hope that many of us will be there.

III. The dragon and his angels warring

A. Having not prevailed

Verses 7 and 8 say, "And the dragon warred and his angels; and they did not prevail." "His angels" should be the fallen angels who follow Satan to rebel against God (Matt. 25:41). Satan will never be victorious against Michael and his angels. He will be defeated.

B. Having no place any longer in heaven

Verse 8 also says of the dragon and his angels that "neither was their place found any longer in heaven." Having been defeated, there no longer will be any place for the dragon and his angels in heaven.

C. Being cast with his angels out of heaven to earth

Verse 9 says, "And the great dragon was cast out, the ancient serpent, he who is called the Devil and Satan, he who deceives the whole inhabited earth; he was cast to the earth, and his angels were cast out with him." We see here that the dragon and his angels will be cast down to the earth. This will take place at the beginning of the fifth trumpet. Revelation 9:1 says, "And the fifth angel trumpeted and I saw a star out of heaven fallen to the earth and to him was given the key of the shaft of the abyss." The "star" in this verse is Satan. After he has fallen from heaven to earth, he will use the key to the abyss to cause the torment of the fifth trumpet. At that time, the shaft of the abyss will be opened and demon-possessed locusts will emerge from it. We have already pointed out that these locusts will torment men for five months. Recall that the fifth trumpet will mark the beginning of the last three and a half years. After Satan, the heavenly star, has been cast down to earth, his time will be very short, only three and a half years.

IV. The coming of the kingdom of God

After the dragon and his angels are cast out of heaven, there will be a loud declaration in heaven. Verse 10 says, "I heard a loud voice in heaven saying, Now is come the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God and the authority of His Christ, for the accuser of our brothers has been cast out, who accuses them before our God day and night." The fighting of the overcoming believers against Satan is to usher in God's kingdom. The Lord teaches us to pray for the coming of the kingdom (Matt. 6:10). Along with our prayer for the kingdom's coming, we need to fight for it.

The rapture of the man-child to heaven, the casting of Satan to earth, and the declaration in heaven signify that the man-child will bring the kingdom to earth. When the man-child is raptured to heaven and Satan is cast down from heaven to earth, that will be the time for the kingdom of God to come. Not only will the kingdom come, but also the salvation of our God. Although we have God's salvation today, we do not yet enjoy it in full, to the uttermost. But when the kingdom of God comes, we shall enjoy God's salvation in full. It is the same with the power of God and the authority of Christ. We have participated in God's power and Christ's authority today, but our full enjoyment of them will be in the kingdom age.

We have seen that there are two aspects to the kingdom of God: the aspect of the reality of the kingdom (Matt. 5:3) and the aspect of the manifestation of the kingdom. Today, in the proper church life, there is the reality of the kingdom. However, in the church life we do not have the manifestation of the kingdom. The manifestation of the kingdom, which will be brought in through the overcoming believers, will come after the man-child has been raptured to heaven. The words, "Now is come...the kingdom of our God" denote the manifestation of the kingdom of God. If we are the overcomers, then we are living in the reality of the kingdom today. Since we are in the reality of the kingdom now, we shall certainly be in the manifestation of the kingdom in the future. Being in the manifestation of the kingdom requires us to be in the reality of the kingdom.

In these messages we have seen a vision regarding what is taking place in the universe. We are sober and know what is transpiring. We are not viewing things from the earth — we are viewing them from the heavenlies. We see a bright woman representing God and a dragon signifying God's enemy. We also see that these two are fighting. Praise the Lord that we are not only part of the woman, but we are also becoming part of the man-child, the stronger part of the woman that fights against the dragon. We are fighting the dragon today and one day we shall be there in the heavens to give him the word to leave heaven. No human mind could have devised such a picture. Once again, we are forced to believe that this is the divine revelation. Who could have written such a record? No one, including Plato or Confucius, is wise enough to compose this. This record is simple, wonderful, profound, and all-inclusive. It affords us a universal view of what is taking place in the universe. From now on, none of us can say that we do not know what is happening. We all must say, "I have seen the vision and I know what is going on." Hallelujah for this vision! I am glad that among the many crucial matters in the second section of the book of Revelation the first is this vision of the universal bright woman with her man-child warring against the dragon. This must be a governing vision. As long as we see it, we shall know where we are, what we must do, and where we shall be. We are in the church, we must be in the man-child, and our destiny is to be raptured to heaven that we may issue the order to Michael to cast Satan and his angels out of heaven. If we see this vision, we shall surely be beside ourselves.

The Actuality and Practicality of the Bright Woman

When I was young, I was told that there were at least one hundred different expositions of the book of Revelation. Later I spent a great deal of time to study this book. I eventually came to realize that the Bible cannot be understood simply by studying its language. If we would understand the Scriptures, we also need experience.

The need of experience

Let us consider, for example, the matter of the pillars in 1 Kings 7:13-21. In message eighty-three of the Life-study of Genesis, I pointed out that the height of each of the two pillars, which was eighteen cubits, was half of three complete units of twelve cubits. I did not get this point from a commentary. Rather, I read various versions of the Bible in order to obtain the correct understanding of the language concerning all the points related to the building of the pillars. Second Chron. 3:15 says that the height of the pillars was a total of thirty-five cubits. Immediately I asked myself, "Why does 1 Kings 7:15 say that the height of each pillar was eighteen cubits, but 2 Chronicles 3:15 says that the height of both was thirty-five cubits?" I could immediately see that this thirty-five cubits was the total height of both pillars. This confirms my saying that eighteen cubits was half of three complete units. But the total should have been thirty-six. What about the missing cubit? By a note in one version I was helped to conclude that the joint in the capitals no doubt accounts for the missing cubit. The whole pillar measured eighteen cubits, but half a cubit was lost in the joint between the pillar and the capital. In order to gain the proper understanding, we need to study various versions of the Bible. But the versions of the Bible do not give us the significance in life. In order to know this, we must have experience. Only by experience could I apprehend that eighteen cubits indicate half of three complete units and that we need others to match us.

With this in mind, let us now come to the book of Revelation. We all agree that Revelation is a book of prophecy. But to understand prophecy there is still the need of experience. The prophecies do not simply teach objective doctrines. The Bible is a book of life. Everything in the Bible, whether it is a narrative, a history, a type, a shadow, a prophecy, or a plain word, must be related to life. If we lack the experience in life, we shall be unable to apprehend the significance in life of many portions of the Word. In order to understand Revelation, we need the experiences in life.

The bright woman being the totality of God's people

In this message I am burdened to share more concerning the universal bright woman. Some of the expositions of the book of Revelation say that this woman is Israel. Of course, they have a ground to say this. When Brother Nee was very young, in the years before 1933, he conducted a study of this book. At that time, he followed the concept that the woman in chapter twelve was Israel. However, afterward he saw something further — that this woman signifies God's chosen people (see *The Glorious Church*, pp. 73-77). As I have pointed out, this woman is neither Mary, the mother of Jesus, nor merely the children of Israel. She is the totality of God's people. When I was in Taiwan, I did not use the expression "the totality of God's people." This utterance has come to me during this last period of my ministry. Some may ask, "How can you prove that this woman is the totality of God's people?" I have said that in order to understand this book we must check whether our apprehension of it corresponds to our life experience. Is there any confirmation from our life experience of a particular interpretation? If we would rightly interpret the woman in Revelation 12, we must check any proposed interpretation with our experience in life.

To say that this woman is Mary, the mother of Jesus, is altogether too objective and has nothing to do with our experience. If this is the case, then the entire twelfth chapter of Revelation is not for us. It is merely an account of a woman named Mary who brought forth Jesus and later suffered persecution. If this were the proper understanding of the woman in chapter twelve, then, as far as we are concerned, this chapter has no purpose. What would be the point of its being included in the book of Revelation? This interpretation is groundless and, according to the experience of life, has no standing whatever. It is somewhat an improvement to say that this woman is Israel. But even if she were merely Israel, she would not be related to us, for this chapter would then simply be a record of Satan's fighting against the children of Israel.

I would remind you that the book of Revelation, composed of twenty-two chapters, is divided into two main sections of eleven chapters each. The first section gives a complete sketch of the events from Christ's ascension unto eternity. In chapter four we see the scene in heaven after the ascension of Christ, and in chapter eleven we see the eternal kingdom. While the first section affords a general sketch, the second section gives the details of some important things and crucial matters which transpire during the period of time between Christ's ascension and eternity future. At the very beginning of this second section, we have the first of these important and crucial matters — a bright woman opposed by a red dragon. Just as the second section begins with a woman, so at the ending, in chapter twenty-two, we also see a woman. Hence, both the first and last crucial matters are a woman. This is significant.

Who is this woman? If we look at chapter twelve with a narrow view, we may think she is Mary or the nation of Israel. But if we have a broad view which encompasses a wide span, we shall see that she is not Mary or merely the nation of Israel, but the totality of God's people. If we have a panoramic view, we shall say, "This woman is not Mary or even the nation of Israel. She must be all the people chosen and saved by God for His economy." Once you have this realization, you will begin to see that the stars indicate the Patriarchs, that the moon under her feet must signify those under the law, and that the sun must represent the church people. Such an understanding fills our entire view and causes us to say, "This woman is certainly a universal woman, including all the people from the Patriarchs to the last member of Christ's Body." This understanding is confirmed by the vision of the woman at the end of Revelation, where we see that the New Jerusalem is the wife of the Lamb (21:9), composed of both the Old Testament saints, represented by the names of the twelve tribes, and the New Testament saints, represented by the names of the twelve Apostles.

The content of the second section of revelation

What is between these two ends of the second section of Revelation? In chapters twenty-one and twenty-two we have the New Jerusalem as the Lamb's wife, and in chapters nineteen and twenty we have the bride and the wedding feast of the Lamb. In chapter twenty the bride will be those reigning with Christ during the thousand years. Hence in chapters nineteen and twenty the woman is the bride, and in chapters twenty-one and twenty-two she is the wife. In chapters seventeen and eighteen we see Babylon the Great, the counterfeit of this woman, the counterfeit of Jerusalem. This view is not only logical but also very meaningful.

What about chapters thirteen through sixteen? The link that connects chapters twelve and thirteen is the three and a half years, or the one thousand two hundred sixty days. In 13:5 we are told that Antichrist will be given authority to act forty-two months, which are three and a half years or the one thousand two hundred sixty days. In 12:6 and 14 we are told that the woman will be nourished in the wilderness for a thousand two hundred and sixty days, or for a year, two years, and half a year “from the face of the serpent.” Therefore, chapter thirteen is an addition to chapter twelve describing what will happen when the red dragon persecutes the woman. During this period of time, a beast, Antichrist, will emerge from the sea and will be one with the dragon to war against the saints, God’s people. In chapter fourteen God warns the people, including the saints, not to worship this beast, and He warns the people on earth not to follow Antichrist to persecute His people. In chapter fifteen we see a vision of a number of the saints who overcome the beast and his image and stand on the glassy sea to sing and praise the Lord. Chapter sixteen covers the end of this period of time, when God will drop seven bombs, the seven bowls of the last plagues, to destroy the entire kingdom of the beast. This is a summary of the second section of this book.

A history of the woman

The second section of Revelation is virtually a history of this woman. It seems that the last eleven chapters relate a series of isolated things — the dragon, the two beasts, the glassy sea, the seven bowls, the great Babylon, the wedding feast. It may appear that some of these isolated items are very important and that others are less important. But to consider the matter in this way indicates that you lack vision and do not have the proper view. When you have the proper view, you will say, “This is not a section composed of various isolated things. It is a section giving a full history of God’s people. It tells how God’s enemy is fighting against His people and how His people are producing the stronger part, the man-child, to defeat the enemy. We see that God’s enemy will instigate Antichrist, the false prophet, and their followers to war against God’s people. But God’s people will overcome them. Eventually, we see that God will exercise His judgment by means of the seven bowls to destroy the kingdom of Satan under the power of Antichrist. Following this, He will overthrow the prostitute, Babylon the Great. Then Christ will come to marry God’s people, to defeat Antichrist with the chosen ones among God’s people, and to reign with them over the nations for a thousand years. After this, there will be the new heaven and the new earth with the New Jerusalem, the ultimate consummation of God’s people as the wife of the redeeming Lamb for eternity.

The proper standing of God’s people

Although you may be one of God’s people, the crucial question is whether or not you are standing here as God’s people. Let us use, once again, the illustration of the Jewish people today. There may be thirteen or fourteen million Jews on earth, but less than three million of them are in the nation of Israel. Are not the millions of Jews in New York City genuine Jews? Yes, they are. However, although they are Jews and although their number exceeds the number of those in the nation of Israel, they are not the nation of Israel. Actually and practically, the nation of Israel is composed only of those Jews who have returned. Of the thirteen or fourteen million Jews, at least eleven million have lost the ground of the nation of Israel. As a result, though they are typical Israelites, they are not the nation of Israel. Only those Israelites who returned to the land of their forefathers and who stand, live, and fight there are the nation of Israel. Likewise, all Christians are God’s people, but the vast majority of them have lost the ground of being God’s people.

Many are offended when we say that we are the church. They say, “What! Are we not also blood-redeemed and Spirit-regenerated?” We realize that there are a great many blood-redeemed and Spirit-regenerated Christians and that some of them are rich in the Lord; yet they have lost the ground of God’s people as the church. There are some Jews in New York City who are millionaires; they are much richer than the poor Jews who returned to Palestine. But those poor Jews are the nation of Israel and the rich ones in New York are not. Some wealthy Jews in New York City have donated a lot of money to the nation of Israel. But no matter how much they donate, still they are not the nation of Israel; they are citizens of the United States. They may say, “I love the nation of Israel and I am for the nation of Israel.” Although we would thank the Lord for this, nevertheless this does not make them the nation of Israel. The only way for them to be the nation of Israel is to return to the land of their forefathers to stand and fight alongside those poor Jews who have already returned. Only then will they be an actual part of the nation of Israel. Only then will they be not only for the nation of Israel; they will be the nation of Israel.

Likewise, it is not the Christians in the denominations, sects, and free groups who will bring forth the man-child. To bring forth the man-child there is the need for at least a portion of God’s people to come back to the proper standing of the woman. Those who have this standing have God alone and nothing else. They are the woman on the proper ground to bring forth the man-child.

Once again I say that if we would understand the Bible, especially the prophecies, we must understand it by life and for life. The interpretation the Lord has given us is not only by life and with life — it is, much more, for life. We all must actually and practically be a part of the woman. If you can only say, “I have been redeemed by the blood and regenerated by the Spirit and filled with the Spirit,” you are a real Christian — thank the Lord for this — but you are not actually and practically part of the woman who is bringing forth the man-child. You are like the Jews in New York City who declare that they are Jews and that they are for the nation of Israel. They are Jews, but they cannot say that they are the nation of Israel. They help the nation of Israel and they are for the nation of Israel, but they are not the nation of Israel in a practical way. In like manner, today it is not the scattered children of God, those who have lost their ground, who will bring forth the man-child. Only that part of God’s redeemed people who have seen His economy and who are willing to return to the standing, the ground, of the chaste woman will bring forth the man-child.

Returning to the unique ground

If we would be included practically in this chaste woman, we must forsake all things other than God and Christ and return to the unique ground to have Christ as our only husband. We refuse to become impregnated by anything other than Christ. We will only be made pregnant of Christ, for He is our unique husband. In addition to Him, we have no one and nothing. Today, we have the standing of this woman. However, if you are the wife of Mr. Smith, why are you living with Mr. Jones? You may say, “I am the wife of Mr. Smith. We were properly married in a certain year, month, and day.” This is correct, but with whom are you living? Do you live only with Mr. Smith, or also with someone else? Perhaps you do not stay with another man, but you stay with your pet dog alone in your house. By doing this, you lose the ground of being Mrs. Smith. Doctrinally, you are the wife of Mr. Smith, but actually and practically day after day you are not Mrs. Smith. You have lost this ground and are still losing it. If you would return to the ground of being Mrs. Smith, you must drop every other man and every other thing, and return purely, singly, and uniquely to be one with Mr. Smith. Then you will actually, practically, and absolutely be the wife of Mr. Smith. It is this wife who will bring forth children, not only for Mr. Smith but of Mr. Smith. May the Lord have mercy on us. This is not a doctrine; it is very practical. We thank the Lord that He has opened His Word to us and that He has opened our eyes to see this vision. Now our need is to be faithful to this vision. “O Lord, we thank You for bringing us back to the proper standing of Your people. Thank You, Lord, that we are actually the woman who will bring forth the man-child. Lord, not only are we the woman, but we expect to eventually become the man-child.”

The Beast Out of the Sea

(1)

In this message we come to the beast out of the sea (Rev. 13:1). Chapters twelve and thirteen seem to stand alone, and for many years I did not know the connection between them. The connection is the sea mentioned in Rev. 12:18 and Rev. 13:1. Revelation 12:18 (13:1 in KJV) says, “And he [the dragon] stood on the sand of the sea.” Following this, 13:1 says, “And I saw a beast coming up out of the sea.” The sea both in 12:18 and in 13:1, as well as the great sea in Dan. 7:2, refers to the Mediterranean Sea. (Mediterranean means “the sea within the land.”) Hence, the sea is the link connecting chapters twelve and thirteen.

In chapter twelve, the dragon was defeated and cast out of heaven to the earth. After coming to the earth, immediately he begins to stir up the beast from the sea. The sand of the sea here no doubt indicates the seashore of the Holy Land, the very edge of the nation of Israel. The dragon will stand there and cause the beast, Antichrist, to come up out of the sea. The fact that the dragon stands on the sand of the sea and the fact that the holy city, Jerusalem, will be trampled under foot forty-two months (Rev. 11:2) indicate that Satan’s persecution in the great tribulation will be carried out mainly in the land of Israel.

In these messages on Rev. 13 I am burdened to point out all the various aspects of Antichrist, as revealed to us in detail in Daniel, Revelation, and 2 Thessalonians, so that the saints may have a clear understanding concerning this evil person.

Hardly anything in the book of Revelation is altogether new. Rather, nearly all the items here are mentioned in the Old Testament. If we would understand the book of Revelation, we must trace the items found here back to their first mention in the Old Testament. In this way we shall see both the original revelation and the development of the revelation. This is the case, in principle, with Antichrist. Antichrist is revealed in Daniel, but Revelation gives a further development regarding him.

Many of us are somewhat familiar with the prophecies in the book of Daniel. In these messages we need to consider four chapters in Daniel: chapter two, an account of Nebuchadnezzar’s dream; chapter seven, a revelation of the four beasts out of the sea; chapter eight, the ram and the goat fighting against each other; and chapter eleven, the northern and southern kings. In chapter eight a little horn comes out of one of the four horns of the goat, and something also issues from the northern king in chapter eleven. These two are the same.

The great image in chapter two is of four parts: the head, the breast and the arms, the belly and the thighs, and the legs, including the ten toes. The fourth part is subdivided firstly into two legs and then into ten toes. The periods of history signified by the first three parts of the image and the two legs have been fulfilled, but the ten toes have not yet been fulfilled. The four beasts in chapter seven correspond to the four parts of the great image in chapter two. The first beast corresponds to the head, the second to the breast and the arms, the third to the belly and the thighs, and the fourth to the legs with the toes. Eventually, according to the vision in chapter seven, the fourth beast will have ten horns. These ten horns of the fourth beast will actually be the ten toes of the fourth section of the great image.

The two animals in chapter eight, the ram and the goat, are equal to the second and third beasts mentioned in chapter seven. Hence, the goat equals the third beast and the third section of the great image. According to chapter eight, upon the goat there are four horns, and out of one of them sprouts a little horn.

In chapter eleven of Daniel we have the two kings, the southern king and the northern king. The northern king is a shadow of Antichrist, and he comes out of the horns of the goat in chapter eight.

Please note the connections between these four chapters in Daniel. The four beasts in chapter seven equal the four sections of the great image in chapter two. The ram and the goat in chapter eight equal the second and third beast in chapter seven. The northern king in chapter eleven comes out of one of the four horns of the goat in chapter eight. Eventually, the northern king will be a shadow, a type, of Antichrist, who is the little horn spoken of in chapter eight.

In Daniel 9:24-27 we have the prophecy concerning the seventy weeks. According to this chapter, seventy weeks have been assigned by God in the history of Israel. Each week denotes a period of seven years. After the sixty-ninth week, a prince, who was Titus, came to destroy Jerusalem, and Jerusalem was trodden under the feet of the Gentiles. During that time, the desolation came with the abomination (Dan. 9:27). In A.D. 70 Titus destroyed the city of Jerusalem. From that time until 1967 Jerusalem was under Gentile control. The return of Jerusalem to the Jews in 1967 is an indication that we are very close to the end time. Through Antichrist the desolation with the abomination will soon come in full.

I. The fourth beast in Daniel 7

The beast out of the sea in 13:1 is the last and crucial part of the fourth beast in Daniel (Dan. 7:7-8, 19-26). Both in Daniel and in Revelation the beast out of the sea refers not only to the Roman Empire but specifically to Antichrist. Hence, eventually Antichrist is the beast out of the sea, the fourth beast in Daniel 7.

A. Dreadful and terrible

This beast is dreadful and terrible (Dan. 7:7, 19). In the past the Roman Empire did dreadful and terrible things. In the future Antichrist will also do terrible things to damage people. Both are cruel and dreadful.

B. Strong exceedingly

Daniel 7:7 reveals that the beast is “strong exceedingly.” The Roman Empire was the strongest heathen power in history, and Antichrist will also be extraordinarily strong, even strong in the power of Satan. As the Roman Empire conquered all the neighboring powers, so Antichrist will subdue and conquer all the powers around the Mediterranean Sea.

C. Having great iron teeth and brass nails

The beast also has great iron teeth and brass nails (Dan. 7:7, 19). The iron teeth are for eating or devouring, and the brass nails are for standing or treading.

D. Devouring the whole earth and breaking it in pieces

This beast devours the whole earth and breaks it into pieces (Dan. 7:7, 19, 23). Along with all the other aspects of the description of the beast, this applies firstly to the ancient Roman Empire with its Caesars and then to the coming Antichrist.

E. Stamping the residue with its feet

The fourth beast stamps the residue with its feet (Dan. 7:7, 19, 23). Whatever remains after the devouring and breaking will be stamped by the beast. This was true of the Roman Empire in the past, and it will also be true of Antichrist in the future.

F. Having ten horns

The beast also has ten horns (Dan. 7:7, 20, 24). These ten horns correspond to the ten toes of the great image in chapter two. According to the vision of the great image in Daniel 2, the ten kings represented by the ten toes are, in God’s view, the lowest part of the body. However, in the vision in Daniel chapter seven these ten kingdoms represented by the ten kings are exalted as the ten horns. In chapter two these kings are the lowest, and in chapter seven they are the highest. Whether these kings are the lowest or the highest depends upon our viewpoint. If we view them from the perspective of heaven, they will be the lowest. However, if we view them from a worldly perspective, these kingdoms will seem to be the highest. Furthermore, worldly politics and worldly kingdoms are, in the eyes of God, like wild beasts which do nothing except damage and devour people. But in the eyes of Nebuchadnezzar, that is, in human eyes, the worldly kingdoms seem to be a great and glorious image.

G. Having a little horn coming up among the ten horns

The fourth beast has a little horn — Antichrist — coming up among the ten horns (Dan. 7:8, 20, 24-26). Antichrist will bud out of one of the ten horns.

1. Having eyes like the eyes of man

This little horn will have eyes like the eyes of man (Dan. 7:8, 20). Here the eyes signify insight. That the horn will have eyes like a man indicates that Antichrist will be intellectually brilliant. He will be a man full of knowledge and will possess great insight. He may both know political science and be familiar with all the up-to-date scientific knowledge. Keep this in mind as you observe the world situation and read the newspapers. Not too long from now, such a man will rise up.

2. Having a mouth speaking great words against the Most High

This little horn will also have a mouth speaking great words against the Most High (Dan. 7:8, 20, 25). He will be arrogant in utterance and speak blasphemous words against God. Antichrist will be an eloquent speaker. Even today, any candidate for political office must be both intelligent and articulate. The greater words a candidate speaks, the more likely he is to be elected. When you see a brilliant and eloquent person speaking arrogant words and blaspheming God, you must take notice — he may be Antichrist.

3. Having an appearance more stout than his fellows

The little horn will have an appearance more stout than that of his fellows (Dan. 7:20). His appearance will be so strong, so stout, so imposing, and so attractive that he will be able to subdue many simply by the power of his presence. The Bible does not leave us in darkness. It not only reveals Christ, but also clearly describes Antichrist. When he appears, we shall be able to recognize him easily.

4. Making war with the saints and prevailing against them

Daniel 7:21 says, “I beheld, and the same horn made war with the saints, and prevailed against them.” Not only will Antichrist be arrogant and blasphemous, but he will also make war against the saints. He will persecute the God-fearing Jews and the Christ-believing Christians.

5. Wearing out the saints for three and a half years

Daniel 7:25 indicates that the little horn “shall wear out the saints of the most High.” Antichrist will put the saints under his hand and gradually wear them out. How he will do this I do not know. It is more difficult to endure this wearing out than to be put to death suddenly. Do not wait to experience this yourself. Rather, pray that you might escape it. The more we see someone arising who looks like this person, the more we need to pray, “Lord, if this is the one, take me away before he comes into power. I do not want to be under his hand.”

6. Attempting to change times and laws

Daniel 7:25 also reveals that the little horn will “think to change times and laws.” This changing of times and laws refers to changing the appointed feasts of the children of Israel. According to the book of Leviticus, God appointed at least seven yearly feasts for the Jewish people. Because these feasts are related to the worship of God, and because Antichrist will oppose any kind of religion, he will abolish all the feasts and change all the laws. These laws refer to the laws of God given to His people through Moses. Hence, Antichrist will alter the Jewish religion, abolish the feasts, and change the laws they have received from God through their forefathers.

7. His dominion to be taken away

Daniel 7:26 says, “But the judgment shall sit, and they shall take away his dominion.” The dominion of the little horn, Antichrist, shall be taken away.

8. Being consumed and destroyed

Verse 26 also reveals that Antichrist will be consumed and destroyed “unto the end.” Although Daniel does not specifically tell us how Antichrist will be destroyed, we know from other portions of the Word that he will be destroyed by the lake of fire (19:20).

II. The little horn in Daniel 8

Now we come to chapter eight of Daniel, where we see the little horn (vv. 8-12, 21-25). Antichrist will be the fourth beast in Daniel chapter seven and also the little horn revealed in Daniel chapter eight. The revelation in Daniel chapter eight is mainly of two things — the ram signifying Persia and the goat signifying Greece. In his book on the great prophecies, G. H. Pember says that throughout ancient Persia, especially in the capital, the symbol of a ram was found. Furthermore, in ancient Greece there were many symbols of goats. The Bible uses a ram to signify Persia and a goat to signify Greece. The goat in this chapter refers to Alexander the Great. Alexander was in power for approximately twelve years and died quite suddenly in his thirties. His strength was not like that of a ram, but like that of a goat. History tells us that when Alexander the Great came to Macedonia, he put on a crown of goat horns.

Daniel 8:8 says, “Therefore the he goat waxed very great, and when he was strong, the great horn was broken; and for it came up four notable ones toward the four winds of heaven.” Alexander the Great had four generals. After Alexander’s death, these generals occupied certain territories and out of them made kingdoms for themselves. Thus, after the death of Alexander, the ancient kingdom of Macedonia was divided into four kingdoms. As we read this prophecy, written long before Alexander’s time, we cannot help but believe that the Bible was inspired by God. When I was reading and studying these matters fifty years ago, I was fully convinced that the Bible is inspired by God. No human mind could ever have given us such a brief yet inclusive revelation.

A. Out of one of the four horns of the goat

The little horn in Daniel 8 comes out of one of the four horns of the goat, that is, out of one of the four kingdoms of ancient Macedonia and Greece (vv. 8-9, 21-23).

B. Growing exceedingly great toward the south, toward the east, and toward the beautiful land

Daniel 8:9 says, “And out of one of them came forth a little horn, which grew exceeding great, toward the south, and toward the east, and toward the beautiful land” (Heb.). “South” refers to Egypt, “east” refers to Asia Minor, and “the beautiful land” refers to the Holy Land. Knowing this will enable us to determine the region out of which the little horn will arise. He will come either from Greece or Macedonia, probably from Greece. This is the reason that he will be intellectually brilliant, for, since ancient times, the Greeks have been noted for their intellectual achievements.

However, the prophecies in the Bible are sometimes rather “sneaky.” For example, Micah 5:2 prophesied that Christ would be born in Bethlehem. Although this prophecy was fulfilled, it was difficult for anyone to trace Christ’s origin to Bethlehem. His mother Mary was impregnated in Nazareth, not in Bethlehem. Near the time of her delivery, she journeyed to Bethlehem and stayed there just long enough for the Lord Jesus to be born. Soon after His birth, Jesus was taken by His parents to Egypt and later to Nazareth, where He was raised (Matt. 2:19-23). Consequently, everyone knew Him as Jesus of Nazareth. Hardly anyone knew that, in a “sneaky” way, He had actually been born in Bethlehem.

Mr. Pember says that Napoleon was a descendant of the Greeks. Although it is difficult to be certain, I feel strongly that Antichrist will also be a Greek descendant. However, it is difficult to determine exactly where he will spring up. Nevertheless, he will undoubtedly be closely related to Greece in some way. This is not my guess or even my interpretation; this is the clear implication in Daniel 8:9. Antichrist will certainly come from one of the four kingdoms in the territory of the ancient empire of Macedonia and Greece under Alexander the Great.

At this point let us consider, as a parenthesis, the historical fulfillment of Dan. 2:31-33, 38-45, and Dan. 7:3-7. The head of the great image, the first beast, was the empire of Babylon (605 B.C. to 539 B.C.). The breast and the arms of the great image, the second beast, represent the empire of Medo-Persia (549 B.C. to 330 B.C.). Media and Persia were like two arms, but they were one empire. The belly and thighs of the great image, the third beast, signify the empire of Macedonia and Greece (336 B.C. to 323 B.C.). As we have seen, after the death of Alexander the Great, the empire of Macedonia and Greece was divided into four parts: the kingdom of Ptolemy in Egypt, Cyrene, Coelo-Syria, and parts of Asia Minor; the kingdom of Cassander in Macedonia and Greece; the kingdom of Lysimachus in Thrace, western Bithynia, Lesser Phrygia, Mysia, and Lydia; and the kingdom of Seleucus in the remainder of Asia Minor and in Syria (323 B.C. to 31 B.C.). Therefore, that the little horn will grow great toward the south, the east, and the beautiful land is a proof that Antichrist will arise from the source of Greece and Macedonia. The legs of the great image, the fourth beast, are the Roman Empire (30 B.C. to A.D. 476). The territories of the western Roman Empire included Gaul, Spain, Britain, Italy, and the western half of North Africa. The territories of the eastern Roman Empire included Macedonia, Greece, Thrace, Asia Minor, Syria, Judea, Egypt, and the eastern part of North Africa. After A.D. 476 the Roman Empire was suspended. During the time of this suspension, that is, during the interval after the two legs and before the ten toes, the Roman Empire has been replaced by the Roman Catholic Church.

C. Growing great even to the host of heaven

Daniel 8:10 says, “And it grew great, even to the host of heaven” (Heb.). The little horn will not only grow great to the south, to the east, and to the beautiful land, but even to the host of heaven. How proud he will be! We all know that man has succeeded in landing on the moon. This space technology may enable Antichrist to do something involving the host of heaven, including the planets and the stars. Antichrist will be so arrogant, great, and proud that he will even presume to touch the host of heaven.

D. Casting down some of the host and of the stars to the earth and stamping upon them

Daniel 8:10 also says that the little horn “cast down some of the host and of the stars to the earth, and stamped upon them” (Heb.). What a person he will be! Something will be developed in the scientific field that will enable Antichrist to bring down the heavenly host. Antichrist will be so proud that he will dare to do even this.

E. Magnifying himself even to the Prince of the host

Daniel 8:11 says, “Yea, he magnified himself even to the Prince of the host,” and verse 25 says, “He shall also stand up against the Prince of princes.” This means that he will exalt himself against God.

F. Taking away the continual sacrifice

The little horn will also take away the continual sacrifice (v. 11). This means that he will stop the worship of God by the Jews. We have seen that Antichrist will change the Jewish feasts and laws. Now we see that he will discontinue the daily, or continual, sacrifices. Verse 12 says, “And a time of trial was appointed unto the continual sacrifice by reason of transgression” (Darby). This means that the sacrifice will suffer a trial because of Antichrist’s interference. This trial will be due to the Jews’ transgression. The Jews who have returned to the land of their fathers are presently in a very poor situation, full of sins and transgressions. This condition will continue until the time of Antichrist. Although the Jews will worship God by offering sacrifices to Him, they will still be sinful. Therefore, God will be disgusted with their offerings, and, due to their transgression, He will allow Antichrist to cause the sacrifices to cease.

G. Casting down the place of the sanctuary of the Prince of the host

Antichrist, the little horn, will also cast down the place of the sanctuary of the Prince of the host (Dan. 8:11). This indicates that he will destroy the temple of God. It also implies that the temple will be rebuilt. If Antichrist would appear today, there would be no temple for him to tear down. I believe that the temple will be rebuilt before long. Soon after that, Antichrist will rise up and tear it down once again.

H. Casting down the truth to the ground

Daniel 8:12 also reveals that Antichrist will “cast down the truth to the ground.” This means that with Antichrist there will be no truth. He will abolish and tear down every truth. The tendency of the world situation today is like this. As far as international relations is concerned, there is very little truth. With regard to the renouncing of all truth, Antichrist will go to the farthest extreme.

I. Doing great things and prospering

Antichrist will do great things and prosper (Dan. 8:12, Darby; v. 24). The Hebrew word rendered did great things (Darby) is a specific word indicating a marvelous and wonderful practice. Antichrist will do great things, things which have never been done before, and he will prosper.

J. Having a fierce countenance

Daniel 8:23 describes Antichrist as “a king of fierce countenance.” As we have seen, Antichrist’s appearance will be stout, overpowering.

K. Understanding dark sentences

Antichrist will also understand “dark sentences” (Dan. 8:23). These dark sentences will be riddles, deceitful words of double and ambiguous meanings. It will be impossible to tell exactly what he is saying, because his words will have a double meaning.

L. His power being mighty but not by his own power

Daniel 8:24 says, “And his power shall be mighty, but not by his own power.” Antichrist’s power will be the power of Satan. Revelation 13:2 says, “And the dragon gave him his power and his throne and great authority.” In a sense, Antichrist will be the embodiment of Satan.

M. Destroying marvelously

We are also told that Antichrist will “destroy marvelously” (Dan. 8:24, Heb.). This indicates that Antichrist will destroy to an extraordinary degree. He will destroy cities and even nations in an unprecedented manner. I do not want to witness this on earth. I would rather observe it from the heavens.

N. Destroying the mighty and holy people

Antichrist will also “destroy the mighty and the holy people” (Dan. 8:24), the people of God.

O. Cunning and crafty

Daniel 8:25 says, “And through his cunning also he shall cause craft to prosper in his hand” (Heb.). This reveals that Antichrist will be cunning and crafty.

P. Destroying many in their security

Daniel 8:25 also says that “in security” Antichrist “shall destroy many.” When many are secure and at peace, Antichrist will come and destroy them.

Q. Being broken without hand

Daniel 8:25 also reveals that Antichrist “shall be broken without hand.” Eventually, Antichrist will be broken by Christ, not by any human hand.

All these points give us a complete picture of Antichrist as the little horn in Daniel chapter eight. Please remember that Antichrist is firstly the fourth beast of Daniel chapter seven and then the little horn of Daniel chapter eight.

The Beast Out of the Sea

(2)

III. The prince in Daniel

A. Both Titus and Antichrist Destroying Jerusalem and the temple

Antichrist is also the prince in Dan. 9:26-27. If you read this chapter carefully, you will see that the prince refers to two people. Firstly, it refers to Titus who, with the Roman army, destroyed Jerusalem in A.D. 70. That destruction was the fulfillment of the Lord's prophecy in Luke 21. In His last visit to Jerusalem, the Lord prophesied to His disciples that Jerusalem would be destroyed and that the temple would be torn down, with not one stone left upon another. That prophecy was fulfilled less than forty years after the Lord's death. According to history, that destruction was terrible. Titus, however, was a shadow of the coming prince, Antichrist, and the destruction of Jerusalem under Titus was simply a shadow of the coming destruction of Jerusalem and the temple under Antichrist. Between these two men who share one title, "the prince," there is an interval of approximately two thousand years.

B. Confirming the covenant with the Jews for one week

In Dan. 9:24-27 we have the prophecy concerning the seventy weeks. These seventy weeks are not weeks of days, but weeks of years. Daniel 9:25 says, "Know therefore and understand, that from the going forth of the commandment to restore and to build Jerusalem unto the Messiah the Prince, shall be seven weeks and threescore and two weeks." The seven weeks mentioned here are reckoned from the time the decree was issued by the Persian king to rebuild the city of Jerusalem. From the time this decree was issued until the rebuilding of the city was a period of forty-nine years. The sixty-two weeks are the period from the completion of the rebuilding of Jerusalem to the day of Christ's crucifixion. The crucifixion of Christ is referred to in Daniel 9:26, which says, "And after threescore and two weeks shall Messiah be cut off, but not for himself." Hence, from the completion of the rebuilding of the city to the crucifixion of the Messiah was four hundred thirty-four years. Therefore, of the seventy weeks mentioned in Daniel 9, only the last one remains.

After the crucifixion of Christ, Titus destroyed the city of Jerusalem. Between the time of the crucifixion of Christ and the beginning of the seventieth week is a gap of unknown duration. This interval has already been more than nineteen hundred years. This gap has encompassed the ancient Roman Empire, which expired in A.D. 476, and the Roman Church, which replaced the Roman Empire. It will also include the revived Roman Empire. The last Caesar of the revived Roman Empire will be Antichrist, who will make a covenant with the Jews for one week. Daniel 9:27 says, "And he shall confirm the covenant with many for one week." In this covenant Antichrist will promise the Jews the liberty to worship God according to their religion.

C. In the middle of the week stopping the sacrifice and the oblation

However, after three and a half years, Antichrist will change his attitude. Daniel 9:27 continues, "In the middle of the week he shall cause the sacrifice and the oblation to cease" (Heb.). This breaking of the covenant will occur at a crucial time, at the time Satan is cast down to earth and stands on the shore of the Mediterranean Sea to stir up Antichrist. Antichrist will then exalt himself above all gods. He may say, "You Jews must not worship your God anymore. I am God! I command you to stop your sacrifices and to abolish your religious feasts. Furthermore, I will change your laws. You must forget everything about your God, the law of your God, and your feasts and turn to worship me." At the time Antichrist exalts himself above all gods, he will also pollute the temple.

D. As the desolator setting up abominations in the temple

Daniel 9:27 also says, "And for the overspreading of abominations he shall make it desolate." The Lord Jesus referred to this when He said, "Ye therefore shall see the abomination of desolation, spoken of by Daniel the prophet, stand in the holy place" (Matt. 24:15). Antichrist will bring in both abominations or idols, and desolation or destruction, demolishing both the temple and the city of Jerusalem. This is the proper understanding of Daniel 9:25-27. If we have this understanding, we shall see how Antichrist will deal with the Jews.

When we come to Revelation chapter seventeen, we shall see that Antichrist will destroy Catholicism in addition to Judaism. Both Judaism and Catholicism have become abominable in the eyes of God. Although some of us were formerly in one or the other, we praise the Lord that we are no longer in these "isms." We are now in Christ. For centuries, these two "isms" have been abominable in the eyes of God. In Rev. 2:9 and Rev. 3:9 the Lord Jesus called the Jewish synagogues the "synagogue of Satan." Furthermore, the Lord Jesus revealed to the apostle John that Catholicism is the great prostitute (Rev. 17:1-6). Some may argue, "How can you call the Jewish synagogues the synagogue of Satan? In a synagogue the Jews worship God and study the Scriptures." But I was not the one who said that the synagogue is the synagogue of Satan — this was the word of the Lord Jesus to His church. It was no longer God but Satan who was in the synagogue. Others, defending Catholicism, may say, "Doesn't the Catholic Church preach Christ?" But Catholicism preaches Christ as the son of Mary. The worship of Mary comes from paganism. The Mary in Catholicism, who is called "the mother of God," is another form of the goddess, Venus. This is demonic. Christmas is also demonic, for December 25, the date of a pagan festival in honor of the birth of the sun, is said to be the birthday of Christ. What blasphemy! Although everything in Catholicism has a Christian appearance, its source is Babylonianism. For this reason, in God's eyes the Catholic Church is the great prostitute who enriches herself by committing spiritual fornication. Therefore, the Catholic Church is called the great prostitute. Both Judaism and Catholicism are Satanic. Under Satan's instigation, Antichrist will destroy Judaism and Catholicism. He will do this destroying work without realizing that he is doing it for God and for Christ. Over all this, God is sovereign. Antichrist will do all these things in the process of exalting himself above every kind of god, abolishing every religion, and making himself the sole object of worship.

E. Destroyed by God's wrath

Eventually, Antichrist will be destroyed by God's wrath (Dan. 9:27). This destruction will be carried out by Christ at the war of Armageddon, when Christ will utterly defeat Antichrist (Rev. 19:17-21).

IV. The king in Daniel 11

Antichrist is also the king in Dan. 11:36-45. We have already pointed out the two kings in Daniel 11, the king of the south and the king of the north. In Daniel 11 the south refers to Egypt and the north to Syria. At times, Egypt and Syria war against each other. The king of Syria, the northern king, has much to do with the coming Antichrist.

A. Typified by Antiochus Epiphanes

The king in 11:36-45 is typified by Antiochus Epiphanes in Dan. 11:21-35 (175-164 B.C.). Antiochus damaged the temple and polluted the sanctuary by putting a swine in the temple. Therefore, the Maccabees stood up to fight against him, as recorded in the two books of the Maccabees in the Apocrypha. Antiochus opposed the holy covenant God had made with His people (Dan. 11:28, 30) and took away the continual sacrifice (Dan. 11:31). Furthermore, Antiochus placed “the abomination (idol) that maketh desolate” in the temple (Dan. 11:31). As we have seen, Antichrist will do the same.

B. Exalting and magnifying himself above every God and speaking marvelous things against the God of gods

Daniel 11:36 and 37 reveal that this king, Antichrist, “shall exalt himself, and magnify himself above every god, and shall speak marvelous things against the God of gods.... Neither shall he regard the God of his fathers, nor the desire of women, nor regard any god: for he shall magnify himself above all.” Antichrist will do all this.

C. Honoring the God of fortresses

Daniel 11:38 says that Antichrist shall “honor the god of fortresses: and a god whom his fathers knew not shall he honor with gold, and silver, and with precious stones, and pleasant things” (Heb.). Antichrist will turn from God to worship his own idol.

D. Increasing with glory those who acknowledge him, causing them to rule over many and dividing the land for a reward

Daniel 11:39 says, “Whoso shall acknowledge him will he increase with glory: and he shall cause them to rule over many, and shall divide the land for reward” (Heb.). This indicates that Antichrist will promote those who acknowledge him. He will give them glory, authority to rule, and part of the land as their reward.

E. Entering into the countries, overflowing, and passing over

Daniel 11:40 says that Antichrist “shall enter into the countries, and shall overflow and pass over.” This means that he will take over the nations which he will invade.

F. Entering into the beautiful land

Antichrist will also enter into “the beautiful land” (Dan. 11:41, Heb.). The “beautiful land” is the Holy Land. This indicates he will also take over the Jewish nation.

G. Planting the tents of his palace between the seas and the beautiful holy mountain

Daniel 11:45 says, “And he shall plant the tents of his palace between the seas and the beautiful holy mountain” (Heb.). The “seas” here are the Mediterranean Sea and the Sea of Galilee. The “beautiful holy mountain” refers to Zion, where Jerusalem is. Between these two seas and Mount Zion Antichrist will erect the tents of his palace.

H. Coming to his end and none helping him

Eventually, “He shall come to his end, and none shall help him” (Dan. 11:45). This means that Christ will terminate him at the war of Armageddon and that no one will help him to escape.

As we consider all these points regarding Antichrist, we see what kind of person he will be and even where he will come from. I am quite certain that, according to the Bible, he will come either from Greece or from the territory of ancient Macedonia. Possibly, he will both be a descendant of the Greek nationality and come from that geographical region. The eastern Roman Empire included the four divisions of the empire of Alexander the Great. According to the prophecies, Antichrist will not come out of the western Roman Empire, but from one of the four kingdoms in the territory of the empire of Greece and Macedonia. These kingdoms all lie in the territory of the eastern Roman Empire. I say strongly that Antichrist will probably come from both the nationality and the territory of Greece. We need to be watchful and observe the events in Greece. The great part of the prophecies in Daniel chapters two, seven, eight, and eleven have been fulfilled. Since those that have been fulfilled have been fulfilled literally, so will the remainder. Antichrist will proceed from Macedonia or Greece to the south (Egypt), to the east (Syria), and to the Holy Land (the land of Israel). Today’s world situation is centered in the Middle East. We must believe that the time is near and that soon both Christ and Antichrist will come. However, we are not waiting for Antichrist — we are waiting for Christ. Daily, I am watching the situation in the Middle East and exercising my spirit concerning events in that region. We praise the Lord that we have the light of God’s word in His prophecy.

Through the study of the prophecies concerning Antichrist, we may conclude that he is the ultimate issue of the worldly powers. In God’s eyes, the worldly powers began with Babylon, which was followed by the empire of Medo-Persia, the Macedonian Empire, and the Roman Empire. The Medo-Persian Empire continued the Babylonian Empire, the Macedonian Empire continued the Medo-Persian Empire, and the Roman Empire continued the Macedonian Empire. By this we see that world power continued from one empire to another. Ultimately, out of the Roman Empire will emerge Antichrist as the consummate issue of these worldly powers. When Antichrist is defeated and cast into the lake of fire, worldly power will be completely terminated.

According to Daniel 2, a stone “cut without hands” will fall from heaven upon the ten toes of the image (v. 34). That stone will not only smite the ten toes, but also the entire image from the head to the toes. As we all know, the stone is Christ. Today, He is the building stone (Matt. 21:42; Acts 4:10-12), but in that day He will be the smiting stone (Matt. 21:44). To the church Christ is the building stone, but to the worldly powers He is the smiting stone which will smash the whole image to pieces.

We have seen that Antichrist will come out of one of the four kingdoms of the ancient Macedonian Empire, probably out of Greece. Greece, which was part of the Roman Empire, will also be one of the ten kingdoms, or the ten toes, of the image. According to the prophecy of the Bible, we can now definitely and clearly say that Antichrist will come out of the Roman Empire in the region of either Greece or Macedonia.

We also have seen what Antichrist will do. He will oppose God and persecute God’s people. He will annul everything pertaining to Judaism, persecute the Jews and the Christians who are left on earth, and destroy Catholicism. He will be intellectually brilliant, capable, and have the power to touch the host of the heavens. He will probably employ modern scientific inventions to probe into space. He will have an appearance that is stout, strong, fierce, and attractive. If you are left on earth at the time Antichrist appears, you will be able to recognize him by knowing all his characteristics as covered in these two messages. You will know who he is, and you will not be attracted to him.

The entire world today is looking for a strong leader. Although this is the age of democracy, many are tired of the shortcomings of democracy and are looking for strong leadership. When a powerful leader emerges, nearly everyone will look to him. Because this is the tendency of today’s world situation, it will be easy for Antichrist to attract many. But praise the Lord that we have the light of prophecy, and that we are not in darkness! We know what kind of person Antichrist will be. The Antichrist is the fourth beast, the little horn, the prince, and the king. When he appears, it will be easy to recognize him.

The Beast Out of the Sea

(3)

In the two previous messages we have seen that Antichrist is the fourth beast in Dan. 7, the little horn in Dan. 8, the prince in Dan. 9, and the king in Dan. 11. In this message we need to consider some other characteristics of Antichrist.

V. Like a leopard

Revelation 13:2 says, “And the beast which I saw was like a leopard, and his feet as those of a bear, and his mouth as the mouth of a lion.” It is very difficult to give a name to this beast because he has the characteristics of all the other beasts. In Rev. 13 he is simply called “the beast.”

A. The symbol of the third beast in Daniel 7

According to Dan. 7:4-6, the leopard, whose characteristic is swift and cruel movement, was the symbol of Alexander the Great, the king of Greece. In a sense, a leopard is more fierce than a lion. The fact that the beast which John saw “was like a leopard” confirms our saying that Antichrist will be a Greek. Alexander the Great was a leopard, and Antichrist will also be like a leopard.

B. His feet as those of a bear, the symbol of the second beast in Daniel 7

We are also told that the feet of the beast are “those of a bear.” The bear, whose characteristic is its destroying feet, was the symbol of the monarchy of Medo-Persia. A bear stamps and destroys with its feet. Antichrist will have this characteristic.

C. His mouth as that of a lion, the symbol of the first beast in Daniel 7

Revelation 13:2 says that his mouth was “as the mouth of a lion.” The lion, whose characteristic is its devouring mouth, was a symbol of Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon. Since this beast, Antichrist, is like the three other beasts and will have the characteristics of all three, as mentioned in Dan. 7:4-7, he will be the totality of all evil powers in human history. Antichrist will have the characteristics of Alexander the Great, Darius, and Nebuchadnezzar. Although he will look like a leopard, his feet will be those of a bear and his mouth that of a lion. All the characteristics of all the wild beasts will be synthesized in this one person, making him the all-inclusive beast. Hence, he will be the ultimate issue and totality of all the worldly powers. If you study world history, you will see that Nebuchadnezzar devoured people, Darius stamped upon them, and Alexander the Great moved swiftly, seizing the entire empire in a very short period of time. Furthermore, Alexander was exceedingly cruel. All these characteristics prefigure the various features of Antichrist, who will certainly be an extraordinary figure.

Do not think that Antichrist will be an ordinary person. No, he will be a very unusual man. Nearly forty years ago, some said that Mussolini was Antichrist. At that time, in 1936, I was already in my ministry and I was carefully observing the world situation. When we heard this claim, we immediately realized that Mussolini was not that powerful. Furthermore, he did not have the appearance of a leopard, but rather that of a frog. Whenever you hear a rumor that a certain man may be Antichrist, you must consider whether or not he possesses the characteristics of Antichrist. Ask whether he is like a leopard, a bear, and a lion. Inquire whether he is intellectually brilliant. Since we have seen the light in the Scriptures regarding Antichrist, no one will be able to cheat us with respect to him.

D. Coming out of the sea

1. Geographically, out of “the great sea,” the Mediterranean

Revelation 13:1 says that the beast will come up out of the sea. Geographically, this sea is the Mediterranean Sea, “the great sea” mentioned in Daniel 7:2.

In 9:11, 11:7, and 17:8 we are told that Antichrist will come up out of the abyss. But in 13:1 we are told that he will come up out of the sea, as also mentioned in Daniel 7:3. This indicates that Antichrist will come from two sources. His spirit, which has been kept in the abyss, will come up out of the abyss, and his body will come from one of the Gentile nations around the Mediterranean Sea. That Antichrist will come up out of both the abyss and the sea may also indicate that the sea is the mouth of the abyss, because the abyss is in the heart of the earth (Rom. 10:7; Matt. 12:40), and the sea is above the earth.

2. Symbolically, out of the Gentile world

In biblical figure, the land signifies the nation of Israel, and the sea signifies the Gentile nations (17:15; Isa. 57:20). This indicates that Antichrist will come out of the Gentile world. Some expect Antichrist to arise in the Jewish territory or out of the Jewish people. But, as we have seen, in the Bible the Jewish territory is signified by the land and the Gentile world is signified by the sea. Since Antichrist will not come out of the land, but out of the sea, he cannot arise in Israel. Furthermore, we know that he will appear out of one of the four kingdoms of ancient Greece (Dan. 8:8-9, 21-23). Because we have received this light regarding Antichrist, we should no longer listen to any loose interpretations.

E. Having ten horns and seven heads

Revelation 13:1 says that the beast, Antichrist, will have “ten horns and seven heads, and on his horns ten diadems, and on his heads names of blasphemy.” Here we see that this all-inclusive beast will have ten horns and seven heads. We all must pay attention to this.

1. The same as the dragon

Both the dragon in 12:3 and the beast in 13:1 have seven heads and ten horns. This emphatically indicates that the coming Antichrist will be one with Satan. He will actually be the embodiment of Satan. Satan will be embodied in him and expressed through him, for Satan’s seven heads and ten horns will be the seven heads and ten horns of Antichrist.

2. Ten horns

What are these ten horns? Firstly, they are the ten kings in 17:12 signified by the ten diadems on the ten horns. Secondly, they are the ten kingdoms symbolized by the ten toes of the great image in Daniel 2:42-44. Remember that the ten kings are equal to the ten kingdoms represented by the ten toes of the image. With the image there are ten toes, and with the beast there are ten horns. The ten horns of the beast are equal to the ten toes of the image. Moreover, these ten toes are simultaneously the ten kingdoms.

3. Seven heads

The seven heads of the beast are seven Caesars of the Roman Empire (17:10), signified by the seven diadems on the seven heads (12:3). Altogether, the Roman Empire had twelve Caesars, but only seven figure in the prophecy in Revelation. The other five are not much involved. The first Caesar was Julius, the fifth, Nero, and the sixth, Domitian, who was Caesar when John wrote the book of Revelation. The seventh Caesar, who will eventually suffer a death blow and be resuscitated with the spirit of Nero, the fifth Caesar, will be Antichrist. At the present, Nero’s spirit is being held in the abyss. After the seventh Caesar has been killed and is about to be resuscitated, Nero’s spirit will be released from the abyss and will enter into the body of the seventh Caesar, who will then be resuscitated to be the eighth (17:10-11). Although Antichrist will be the eighth, yet he will still be of the seventh and a part of the fifth. We shall consider this more thoroughly when we come to chapter seventeen.

The seven heads of the beast bear names of blasphemy. According to history, all seven Caesars claimed to be God, assumed deity, and forced their people to worship them as God. That was really blasphemous to God. This is what is signified by the names of blasphemy.

VI. The angel of the abyss

A. Coming up out of the abyss

Antichrist will also be the angel of the abyss (9:11), which is a deep shaft. We have seen that Antichrist will come out of the abyss (11:7; 17:8) and will possess the spirit of Nero. Some may wonder how we know that the resuscitated Antichrist will possess the spirit of Nero. On the one hand, as far as his physical origin is concerned, Antichrist will come from one of the four kingdoms of the empire of ancient Macedonia and Greece. On the other hand, the Bible clearly indicates that he will emerge out of the abyss. Furthermore, his name will have a number, six hundred sixty-six. According to the numerical evaluation of the Hebrew letters, the number of the name Caesar Nero equals six hundred sixty-six. This indicates that the coming Antichrist will be Caesar Nero. With the help of some of the foregoing teachers, we have seen that after Caesar Nero died his spirit undoubtedly went to the abyss for some future use. At a certain time, his spirit will be released from the abyss. We are told clearly in Revelation that the coming Antichrist will suffer a fatal blow. Although he will be killed, his fatal wound will be healed (13:3). This denotes resuscitation. When we come to chapter seventeen, we shall see that Antichrist will be resuscitated with the spirit of Caesar Nero. Antichrist will firstly be the seventh Caesar who will be assassinated, probably before the last three and a half years. Then the spirit of Nero will be released from the abyss to enter into the body of the seventh Caesar, who will then be resuscitated to become the eighth Caesar. This will be a counterfeit of the resurrection of Christ. Christians have been preaching that Christ was the only One to be crucified and resurrected. But the day is coming when another one will be killed and seemingly resurrected. Due to this counterfeit of the resurrection, the whole world will marvel after the beast (13:3), Antichrist, the counterfeit of Christ. He, the seventh, will become the eighth; yet he will have the body of the seventh and the spirit of the fifth. We all need the enlightenment of this proper understanding.

B. The king of the army of the demon-possessed locusts

As the angel of the abyss, Antichrist will be the king of the demon-possessed locusts (9:1-11). At the sounding of the fifth trumpet, Satan will fall to the earth and will be given the key of the shaft of the abyss (9:1). The star in 9:1 refers to Satan, who will be cast down from heaven to earth. After Satan has been cast down to earth, he will use the key of the shaft of the abyss to release an army of extraordinary, demon-possessed locusts. At the time these locusts are released from the abyss, the spirit of Nero will probably be released with them. They may all come out of the abyss together, and Antichrist will become the king of this army of locusts. As we have seen, these locusts will torment men for five months. Satan, the dragon, and Antichrist, the beast, will collaborate to torment and injure man whom God created for Himself. This will be the fifth trumpet, the first of the three woes, the beginning of the great tribulation.

C. Abaddon and Apollyon

Revelation 9:11 says that the name of the angel of the abyss in Hebrew is Abaddon and in Greek is Apollyon. Abaddon means destruction, and Apollyon means destroyer. Antichrist will be both the destroyer and the destruction. He will be consumed with rage, will be obsessed with a satanic hatred, and will bring destruction wherever he goes. Satan will realize that his time is short, that he has just three and a half years to act on earth. Hence, working through Antichrist, he will do everything possible to damage mankind.

VII. The man of sin

Antichrist will also be the man of sin (2 Thes. 2:3-10). When the apostle Paul wrote 2 Thessalonians, he must have been impressed regarding this man of sin from his knowledge of the book of Daniel. According to Daniel chapters eight and eleven, Antichrist will exalt himself above all gods and call himself God. Paul's word concerning this in 2 Thessalonians 2 must refer to the book of Daniel.

A. The lawless one

This man of sin is described as "the lawless one" (2 Thes. 2:8, Gk.). Antichrist will be a lawless person. The entire world today is heading in the direction of lawlessness. Lawlessness is everywhere. Because Antichrist will be the representative of lawlessness and even its totality, the Bible calls him "the lawless one."

B. The son of destruction

Antichrist, the man of sin, is also described as "the son of destruction" (2 Thes. 2:3). Because he will be so sinful and lawless, he will become "the son of destruction," who will perish in an extraordinary way. He will be defeated by the Lamb, seized, and thrown alive into the lake of fire. Therefore, in this short portion of the Word, Paul gives us three titles of Antichrist — the man of sin, the lawless one, and the son of destruction.

C. Opposing God and exalting himself above God

Second Thessalonians 2:4 says that Antichrist "opposeth and exalteth himself above all that is called God, or that is worshipped." We need to compare this verse with Daniel 8:11 and 25, 11:36 and 37, and Revelation 13:6. These portions all relate the same thing — that this man of sin will oppose God and exalt himself above God.

D. Sitting in the temple of God showing himself that he is God

Second Thessalonians 2:4 also says that Antichrist "seats himself in the temple of God, proclaiming himself that he is God." Paul went further than Daniel in relating this matter. Daniel did not say that Antichrist would sit in the temple, but Paul tells us clearly that he will sit in the temple as God and compel people to worship him.

E. Coming after the working of Satan with all power, signs, and lying wonders and with deceit of unrighteousness

In 2 Thessalonians 2:9 and 10 Paul says, "The coming of whom is according to the operation of Satan, with all power and signs and wonders of a lie, and with all deceit of unrighteousness among those who are perishing." The coming of Antichrist will be according to the working of Satan. In Christianity today there is a tendency to seek signs, wonders, and miracles. But we must be careful. According to John 2:23-25, the Lord Jesus had no confidence in those who were seeking signs. Do not seek signs. If you do, you may be cheated. Not only can the Spirit of God do wonders; the spirit of Satan can also perform them. Paul says that Antichrist, coming after the working of Satan, will perform lying wonders. Although they are wonders, they are a lie, a falsehood, and a deceit of unrighteousness. Do not care for wonders, but maintain the principles of righteousness. Anything unrighteous, even if it is miraculous, must be rejected. Do not accept miracles and forget righteousness. If we are strict to maintain the principles of righteousness, we shall be protected from being deceived.

F. The mystery of lawlessness now being restrained

Second Thessalonians 2:7 says, "For the mystery of lawlessness is already operating; only there is one who restrains now until he comes out of the midst." We all know that both Christ and the church are mysteries. But here Paul speaks of another mystery — the mystery of lawlessness. Antichrist will also be a mystery. According to Paul's concept, this mystery of lawlessness is already operating. However, there is someone who restrains it. It is difficult to say who is restraining this lawlessness. Nevertheless, there is some force, some strength, restraining lawlessness.

The hippy movement in the United States began in the early 1960's. Those years were years of lawlessness. But something restrained that lawless hippy movement, and it has passed away. If there were no restraint on lawlessness, the earth would no longer be habitable. We would have no peace to sleep at night. Today, there is a tendency toward lawlessness, but it is under restraint. Because God's purpose has not been fulfilled, that is, because the Bride has not yet been prepared, God exercises His control over lawlessness. Eventually, at the time of the last three and a half years, this restraint will be removed, and it will seem that God has said, "Let the world go." At that time, Antichrist, the lawless one, will be fully manifested, and the entire earth will be filled with lawlessness. This is a word of prophecy, and it does not seem to help us in the experience of life, which is our primary concern. Nevertheless, I hope that the young people in particular will be enlightened by all these points and say, "Praise the Lord that I am clear concerning the tide of the world. I know what is coming." Praise the Lord that in the midst of the dark night we have light!

G. Being consumed by the Lord with the breath of His mouth and destroyed with the brightness of His coming

Finally, in 2 Thessalonians 2:8, Paul says, "And then the lawless one shall be revealed (whom the Lord Jesus will slay by the breath of His mouth and bring to nothing by the appearing of His coming)." The breath of the Lord's mouth signifies the word. Revelation 19:15 says, "Out of His mouth proceeds a sharp sword, that with it He might smite the nations." This sharp sword, a two-edged sword (1:16), is the Lord's killing word. He will send out His word as the breath to slay Antichrist and to consume him. The Lord will also destroy Antichrist with the brightness of His coming. This brightness will be an intensified burning and a killing light. Christ will come with such a mouth and such light to deal with this man of sin. As a result, Antichrist will become the son of perdition and be the first to perish in the lake of fire. Along with the false prophet, he will perish in the lake of fire earlier than Satan will (Rev. 19:20; 20:10). When we come to chapter nineteen, we shall see that Antichrist will fight directly and personally against Christ and that, at His coming, Christ and His overcomers will fight directly against him.

Thus far, we have seen seven aspects of Antichrist: the fourth beast, the little horn, the prince, the king, the all-inclusive beast, the angel of the abyss, and the man of sin. In the next message we shall see even more regarding him.

The Beast Out of the Sea

(4)

When as a young man I studied the great image Nebuchadnezzar saw in his dream (Dan. 2:28-35), I became fully convinced that the Bible is a divinely inspired book. The parts of the great image — the head, the breast and arms, the belly and thighs, and the legs with the ten toes — match the development of the worldly powers throughout the centuries. Besides God Himself, who could have given us such an illustration? We must believe that God has been and still is sovereign over all the world powers, having sovereignly prepared them in a certain way. How wonderful it is to see the world powers represented by the image of a human body. It is foolish not to believe that the Bible is a divine book. If we would understand the prophecies of this book, we must have divine wisdom. The more wisdom we have and the more we get into these prophecies, the more nourishment we shall derive from them.

There is rich nourishment to be gained from the prophecies in the Bible. However, many studies of prophecy merely touch things such as the seven heads, the ten horns, the ten toes, the three and a half years, the forty-two months, and the twelve hundred sixty days. This is like being given a bowl of chicken bones without any meat. But we should receive nourishment from the divine Word. To say that all Scripture is God-breathed (2 Tim. 3:16) means every line of the Bible is the breath of God. In every line of Scripture, including these portions that are prophecies, there is some life element, some living nourishment. When we study prophecy, we should have meat as well as the bones.

We have seen seven significant aspects of Antichrist: the fourth beast, the little horn, the prince, the king, the all-inclusive beast, the angel of the abyss, and the man of sin. Now in this message we need to consider several other important aspects of this extraordinary figure.

VIII. Having the power and authority of Satan

Antichrist will have the power and authority of Satan. Revelation 13:2 says, “The dragon gave him his power and his throne and great authority.” In verses 4 and 5 we see that the dragon “gave authority to the beast” and that “authority was given to him to act forty-two months.” That the dragon gives his power, his throne, and great authority to the beast indicates that he makes the beast one with him. When the Lord Jesus was on earth, He was tempted in the wilderness by the Devil. Matthew 4:8 and 9 say, “Again, the Devil took Him to a very high mountain and showed Him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory; and he said to Him, All these will I give You if You will fall down and worship me.” The Lord Jesus refused, saying, “Go, Satan! For it is written, You shall worship the Lord your God, and Him only shall you serve” (Matt. 4:10). Since that day, Satan has been looking for someone to whom he could give all the power, authority, and glory of his satanic kingdom. He will find the one he has been seeking in the person of Antichrist. What the Lord Jesus rejected, Antichrist will receive.

Because Satan will give his power and authority to Antichrist, Antichrist will become an extraordinary person. His personality and character will be exceedingly strong.

IX. Being killed and resuscitated

A. Killed as the coming seventh caesar of the Roman Empire

Antichrist will be killed and resuscitated. Revelation 13:3 says, “And one of his heads was as if it had been slain to death, and his death stroke was healed.” Verse 12 says that his “death stroke was healed,” and verse 14 says that the beast “had the stroke of the sword and lived.” “One of his heads” refers to one of the Caesars who will be slain and resuscitated. The word about the healing of his death stroke refers to his resuscitation. After he has been resuscitated, the whole earth will marvel after him. Antichrist will probably be slain in the middle of the last seven years, perhaps about the same time Satan is cast down from heaven to earth. I say this because, according to Revelation 9:1, the angel of the abyss emerges shortly after Satan, as the star, falls from heaven to earth. About this time, the seventh Caesar of the Roman Empire will be killed.

B. Resuscitated with the spirit of the fallen fifth Caesar — Nero — to be the eighth Caesar

When Satan is cast down, the spirit of Caesar Nero will be released from the abyss and enter into the body of the slain seventh Caesar to resuscitate his corpse and to make him the eighth Caesar. This eighth Caesar will have the body of the seventh Caesar and the spirit of the fifth. This resuscitation will be a counterfeit of Christ’s resurrection. Anyone who does not have the faith of Christ will certainly be attracted by this miraculous occurrence. During the first half of the last seven years, the seventh Caesar will appear. After he has been slain and resuscitated, which will take place near the middle of these seven years, he will become the eighth Caesar. Hence, during the first three and a half years, he will be the seventh Caesar, and during the last three and a half years, he, as the resuscitated Antichrist, will be the eighth Caesar. The seventh Caesar will confirm a covenant with the Jews for seven years, and the eighth Caesar will persecute the Jews and exalt himself to be God. Thus the death and resuscitation of Antichrist will mark a great turn. In principle, it will almost be the same as with the death and resurrection of Christ. Before His death and resurrection, Christ was limited in His flesh, but after His death and resurrection, He was given all authority and power (Matt. 28:18). Satan will attempt to counterfeit this in order to prove to the world that his Antichrist is the same as Christ. Therefore, Antichrist will be two persons. During the time of his being the seventh Caesar, he will not be that marvelous, charming, and deceiving. But after his assassination and resuscitation, he will become a marvelous character. He will be charming, deceiving, alluring, and captivating. Only the saints who have the faith of Christ will be able to withstand his charm and deceitfulness. After his resuscitation, being indwelt by the spirit of Caesar Nero, he will become all the more capable, intelligent, and powerful.

We have seen that the slain and resuscitated Antichrist will have the name Caesar Nero. The false prophet will cause “all, the small and the great, and the rich and the poor, and the free and the slaves, to be given a mark on their right hand or on their forehead” (13:16), and no one will be able to buy or sell unless he has “the mark, the name of the beast or the number of his name” (13:17). Revelation 13:18 says, “Let him who has understanding calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a man; and his number is six hundred and sixty-six.” The false prophet will induce people to worship Antichrist. At the same time, he will devise a way to mark them either with the name of Antichrist or with the number of his name. This mark will be placed either on the forehead or on the right hand. Some students of the Bible have suggested that probably the men will be marked on their forehead and the women will be marked on their right hand. This mark will be the indication that the people bearing it belong to Caesar Nero. The number of the beast is “the number of a man,” Caesar Nero, the coming Antichrist. (See note Rev. 13:182, Recovery Version.) Because the book of Revelation was written during the time of the Roman Empire, John did not mention the name of Nero, but indicated it with a number. Therefore, there is the need of wisdom to understand it. With the wisdom given by God we can determine that the number six hundred sixty-six denotes Caesar Nero. No other name gives us the exact number of six hundred sixty-six.

While the unbelievers will bear the name of Nero on their forehead or on their hand, testifying that they belong to him, all the overcomers will have on their forehead the name of the Lamb and of the Father (14:1). There will be no neutrality. Either you will bear the name of God or the name of Caesar Nero, the embodiment of Satan. To bear the name of Caesar Nero means to belong to Satan, and to bear the name of God means to belong to God.

Anyone without the mark of the beast upon him will not be able to buy or sell. This will make it impossible to live. Conditions in some Communist countries today are heading in this direction. You must have a permit to buy things because the economy is under strict governmental control. During the kingdom of the eighth Caesar, everyone must bear the name of Antichrist as the permit to buy and sell. In today’s world situation the way is being prepared more and more for Antichrist. Five hundred years ago, the students of the Bible could not understand these things as easily as we can today. But recent world events have made it easier to understand what the prophecies are talking about.

X. Receiving the power, authority, and kingdom of the ten kings

Satan probably will give his power and authority to Antichrist before he is slain. But it may only be after Antichrist is assassinated and resuscitated that the ten kings will give their power, authority, and kingdom to Antichrist (17:12-13, 17). Then every power and authority will be concentrated in one person.

XI. Acting forty-two months

Revelation 13:5 says, “Authority was given to him to act forty-two months.” Forty-two months here and in 11:2 are the three and a half years in 12:14 and the thousand two hundred and sixty days in 11:3 and 12:6, which will be the time of the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21). At the end of this age Antichrist will make a covenant with the nation of Israel for seven years (Dan. 9:27). Three and a half years after the covenant is made, he will break it, terminate all Jewish worship and service to God (Dan. 9:27), persecute the saints (13:7), and destroy the holy city (11:2) for three and a half years. Once again, I say strongly that, contrary to what many think, the great tribulation will not last seven years; it will be three and a half years, or forty-two months, or twelve hundred sixty days. In these three and a half years Antichrist will do many things.

A. Speaking great things and blaspheming God, His tabernacle, and those who tabernacle in heaven

Revelation 13:5 says, “And there was given to him a mouth speaking great things and blasphemies,” and verse 6 says, “And he opened his mouth in blasphemies against God, to blaspheme His name and His tabernacle and those who tabernacle in heaven.” I do not know what great things Antichrist will utter. Undoubtedly, he will speak things that no one has ever imagined, things that will surprise people. He will blaspheme God, God’s tabernacle, and those who tabernacle in heaven. I believe that “those who tabernacle in heaven” are the overcomers who will be raptured to the tabernacle of God in heaven. Although I do not know what great things Antichrist will speak, in principle he probably will say, “You have heard that the so-called God has done this and that. Now let me tell you that I can do greater things than He.” In this way he will utter great things to blaspheme and insult God. At that time, probably a good number of the worldly people will know that the overcoming Christians have been raptured, for this will certainly be on the front page of the newspapers. Many will be saying things like, “My cousin has suddenly disappeared”; “My wife has been taken away”; or “My roommate was there last night, but when I woke up this morning he was gone.” Furthermore, the Christians remaining on earth will begin to preach. Antichrist may then rise up and use the mass media to give a lecture in which he will claim to do something greater. He may say, “Listen to me. I will do greater things than this.” It may be that he will use space technology to do certain outstanding things.

To repeat, before Antichrist is slain and resuscitated, the overcomers will be raptured to the heavens. When they arrive, they will command Satan to be cast down to earth. As soon as this word is pronounced, the archangel Michael will take the lead to fight against Satan. About this time, the seventh Caesar, Antichrist, will be slain. When Satan descends to earth, the spirit of Nero will be released from the abyss and enter into the assassinated seventh Caesar, resuscitating him to be the eighth. While all this is taking place, everyone on earth will be talking about the rapture, and the Christians still on earth will testify about it. Then this resuscitated eighth Caesar will speak great things to deceive the earth dwellers, promising to do greater things than those God has done. This will be the blasphemy he will utter against God, His dwelling place, and the overcomers who have been raptured to God’s dwelling place.

If the Christians remaining on earth during this time know about all these things, they will be greatly helped. If any of us are still on earth after the rapture of the overcomers, we would never be cheated by Antichrist. Perhaps we would recall what we have read in these life-study messages. These messages can help us become the firstfruits. But those who are not the firstfruits will not be left in darkness. After reading these messages, we are no longer in darkness about Antichrist. We surely have seen the light.

B. Fighting and overcoming the saints

Revelation 13:7 says, “And it was given to him to make war with the saints and to overcome them.” The saints here are the rest of the woman’s seed in 12:17, which consists of the God-fearing Jews and of the believers in Christ. This proves that in the great tribulation some believers will still be on the earth. Antichrist will persecute the God-fearing Jews and the Christ-believing Christians. He will war against God’s people on earth and overcome them. As chapters fifteen and twenty indicate, many will be martyred during this time.

C. Fighting and killing the two witnesses

Antichrist will also fight and kill the two witnesses (11:7). Our God knows the weakness of His people. Hence, during the last three and a half years, after the rapture of the overcomers, God will send back Moses and Elijah to strengthen His persecuted people. Antichrist will fight against these two witnesses and kill them. But, as 11:11 reveals, after three and a half days the two witnesses will be resurrected and raptured to the heavens.

D. Ruling over every tribe, people, tongue, and nation

Revelation 13:7 also says, “Authority was given to him over every tribe and people and tongue and nation.” Because Antichrist will receive the power and authority of Satan as well as the power, authority, and kingdom of the ten kings, he will certainly have the full authority to rule over every tribe, people, tongue, and nation.

E. Being marveled after by the whole earth and worshipped with an image by all those dwelling on the earth

Revelation 13:3 says, “And the whole earth marveled after the beast,” and 17:8 says, “And they who dwell on the earth, whose names have not been written from the foundation of the world in the book of life, shall marvel when they see the beast, how that he was, and is not, and shall be present.” Due to the healing of his “death stroke,” the whole world will marvel after the beast. Only those whose names have been written in the book of life before the foundation of the world will not marvel after him. All true Christians remaining on earth will have the faith within them. Many of them will receive the light from these printed messages, understand the features of Antichrist, and realize that they must not worship him. But “all those dwelling on the earth shall worship him, every one whose name has not been written in the book of life of the Lamb slain from the foundation of the world” (13:8). (“From the foundation of the world” may modify both “whose name has not been written” and “the Lamb slain.”) As we shall see in the next message, the false prophet will compel those who dwell on earth “to make an image of the beast” and to worship it.

F. Hating the apostate Roman Church, making her desolate, and burning her utterly

Antichrist will also turn his back on the Roman Church, hate her, and make her desolate. Revelation 17:16 says that the ten horns, which are the ten kings, will hate the prostitute and “make her desolate and naked, and shall eat her flesh and shall burn her utterly with fire.” After Antichrist has been resuscitated, he will persecute every kind of religion, including Judaism and Catholicism.

XII. Fighting the Lord and being defeated, destroyed, and cast into the lake of fire by the Lord

Ultimately, Antichrist will fight against the Lord and be defeated by Him. The Lord Jesus will destroy him and cast him into the lake of fire (Rev. 17:14; 19:19-21; 20:10). In the war at Armageddon Antichrist and his followers will fight directly against Christ, and Christ and His overcomers, the ones chosen to be His army, will fight directly against Antichrist. This will be an unprecedented war, a war in which Christ and Antichrist confront each other. We shall see more of this when we come to chapter nineteen. In the war at Armageddon, Christ will defeat Antichrist and the false prophet and will cast them alive into the lake of fire. That will be the final destiny of Antichrist.

The Beast Out of the Earth

In this message we come to the second beast, the beast out of the earth (Rev. 13:11-18).

I. Judas iscariot

Revelation 13:11 says, “And I saw another beast coming up out of the earth.” This beast is the false prophet (Rev. 16:13; 19:20; 20:10). Since the earth, the land, signifies the nation of Israel, this beast, the false prophet, will come out of the Jewish nation. Some students of prophecy believe that the false prophet will be Judas Iscariot. I believe this view is correct. According to Acts 1:25, after his death Judas went “to his own place,” rather than to “his people,” as was the case with others recorded in Scripture (Gen. 25:17; 35:29). Although there have been many false persons in history, no one was as filled with Satan as Judas was. Jesus said, “Did not I choose you, the twelve, and one of you is a devil? Now He spoke of Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot, for he, being one of the twelve, would betray Him” (John 6:70-71). Here we see that the Lord Jesus even called Judas a devil. Because Judas was filled with the Devil, he was one with the Devil. No one other than Judas matches the description of the false prophet.

Let us consider further the significance of Judas’ going “to his own place.” According to the record in the Bible, Elijah was raptured to God, and the body of Moses was kept by God for a specific purpose. In addition, we have seen that the spirit of Nero is being kept in the abyss. Undoubtedly, the spirit of Judas is also being kept in a particular place. Only when we come to the book of Revelation do we see why the Bible gives us this particular record of these four people.

During the time of the great tribulation, the Lord’s people on earth will need strengthening. Because God foreknew this, He has sovereignly kept Moses and Elijah for His testimony during that time. God is also keeping Nero and Judas, but, in contrast to Moses and Elijah, they are not in a pleasant place. One is in the abyss, and the other is in “his own place.” Although I do not know what this place is, I am confident that it is not a place of joy. Hence, two people have been kept by God for His positive purpose and two others have been kept for His negative purpose. The spirit of Nero is being held in the abyss until the time it will fully constitute the last Caesar of the Roman Empire as Antichrist. Judas is kept in his own place until he appears as the false prophet. By God’s sovereign keeping of these four people, we can see that the whole universe and the entire human race is under God’s sovereign hand. Nothing happens accidentally. Rather, everything takes place according to God’s sovereign arrangement.

Centuries ago, God prepared Moses and Elijah. As we have pointed out, Moses represents the law, and Elijah, the prophets. In ancient times, the Jews referred to the Old Testament as “the law and the prophets.” Because Moses and Elijah are two witnesses, they have been purposely kept by God. One day, after Satan has been cast down to earth and embodied in Antichrist, who will exercise satanic power to persecute God’s people, God will send these two witnesses back to strengthen His people. At that time, Satan will call out Judas to work for him as he did once before. Just as the spirit of Nero will emerge from the abyss to become Antichrist, so Judas will come out of his own place to become the false prophet. Therefore, during the three and a half years of the great tribulation, four special persons will be on earth — Moses, Elijah, Nero, and Judas. Probably all four will meet one another face to face. I wonder what Moses and Elijah will say to Judas. Moses and Elijah will be the anti-testimony to Antichrist and the false prophet. Imagine what a situation that will be when these four confront one another!

II. Coming up out of the earth

Revelation 13:11 says that the other beast, the false prophet, will come up out of the earth. Geographically, he will come from underneath the earth, and symbolically he will come from the nation of Israel. We have seen that the land signifies the nation of Israel. For this reason, the false prophet will certainly come out of the nation of Israel. He must be one of the Jewish people.

III. His falsehood

Revelation 13:11 says that the beast out of the earth “had two horns like a lamb, and he spoke as a dragon.” The false prophet looks like a lamb, but speaks like a dragon. This indicates his falsehood. In the Bible the lamb signifies Christ. The fact that the false prophet will have two horns like a lamb indicates that he will pretend to be the same as Christ. However, his speaking will be like the dragon, Satan. Although he will pretend to be like Christ, what he expresses will be like Satan. He will be an absolute falsehood.

Verse 13 says, “And he does great signs, so that he even makes fire come down out of heaven to the earth before men.” The false prophet will employ satanic power to perform great signs. In calling down fire out of heaven, the false prophet will do the same thing Elijah did. Elijah called down fire from heaven during the days of Ahab (1 Kings 18), and during the coming three and a half years of the great tribulation he will do this again. When Judas sees this, he may say, “If Elijah can do it, I can too.” Because the false prophet will perform great signs, it will be difficult for people to discern the real prophet from the false prophet. The false prophet will be able to do the same thing as the real one. As far as eloquence is concerned, Judas will likely be no less eloquent than Moses or Elijah because his speaking will be like that of the dragon.

If we have been enlightened, we would never pay attention to signs. According to the concept of the New Testament, the Lord does not intend for us to devote our attention to signs. Rather, we must concentrate our whole being on the matter of life. We should not care for what a preacher or minister can do in the way of signs; we must examine the kind of life he has. It is not a matter of the power we exercise, but of the life we live. If you care only for life, you will never be deceived. As far as signs are concerned, there is no way to discern the true from the false, for both Elijah and the false prophet will bring down fire from heaven. The only way to discern is by life. If both Elijah and Judas were standing before you, you could easily discern who is true and who is false by their very being. People may cheat others by their words, but they expose themselves by what they are. Do not care for what people can do — care for what they are. Today most Christians do not care for what people are, but for what they can do. They care for power, signs, and miracles. But those who exercise miraculous power to do signs may have a living and behavior that are deplorable. I am not saying that we should be concerned with our outward appearance. I am saying that we must be what we are. What we are in our living must express what we are in our life. The life we live out from within expresses, not what we can do, but what we are.

At the end time, the signs, powers, and miracles will come. In Matthew 24:24 the Lord Jesus said, “False Christs and false prophets shall arise and shall show great signs and wonders so as to lead astray, if possible, even the elect.” In 2 Thessalonians 2:9 and 10 Paul said the Antichrist, the man of sin, would come “according to the operation of Satan, with all power and signs and wonders of a lie, and with all deceit of unrighteousness among those who are perishing.” We must be warned not to look for signs and wonders. If you do, you may be deceived. Instead of seeking signs, we must care for Christ in the way of life. Do not expect miracles — give your attention to life, which is Christ Himself. When Judas, the false prophet, appears, he will deceive people by the signs he performs.

IV. Working for the beast out of the sea

The false prophet will not work for himself, but for Antichrist, the beast out of the sea. No one who speaks on his own behalf is respected or believed. It is much easier to praise others than it is to praise yourself. If I were to speak highly of myself, no one would want to listen to me. Everything Judas says and does will be on behalf of the first beast. I simply cannot understand why he will sell himself to Antichrist to such an extent that he will even go to the lake of fire with him. There seems to be no reason for this. Neither Satan nor Antichrist will promise Judas anything. Why then will he be so foolish as to sell himself outright? From the beginning Judas was caught by Satan and became a person under Satan’s evil instigation. As Satan controlled Judas in the past, so he will control him once again. This may be the reason Judas will completely sell himself to Antichrist.

Although none of us is like Judas, part of our natural being is in the principle of Judas at least to some degree. We also may sell ourselves to Satan for nothing. Whether you realize it or not, you have done this many times. Frequently we have betrayed the Lord Jesus or damaged the church life. We have done certain things that have frustrated the Lord's recovery. It seems that there was no reason for our doing these things. During the past fourteen years in this country, I have seen some cases of those who damaged the Lord's recovery, but who received nothing for it in return. Their acts were the result of the fact that Satan had occupied their natural being. When Satan gets into our natural being and possesses certain parts of it, we sell ourselves for nothing. This is the principle of Judas as well as the principle of the false prophet.

Not only will Satan give his power to the false prophet; the Antichrist will place his complete confidence in him. Hence, the false prophet will be authorized to represent Antichrist, the embodiment of Satan. Satan will be embodied in Antichrist, and Antichrist will be represented by the false prophet. Because of this, some Bible students call Satan, Antichrist, and the false prophet a satanic trinity. But I do not like to see the word trinity used in this way. Nevertheless, Satan, Antichrist, and the false prophet certainly will become one. Due to this union, the false prophet will be authorized to do whatever he desires.

A. Exercising the authority of the first beast

Revelation 13:12 says of the false prophet, "He exercises all the authority of the first beast in his sight." The false prophet will not only exercise the power of Antichrist, but also the authority of Antichrist.

B. Causing the earth and the earth's dwellers to worship the first beast

Verse 12 also says, "And he causes the earth and those who dwell in it to worship the first beast, whose death stroke was healed." The false prophet will cause the entire earth and the earth's dwellers to worship Antichrist. His ministry will be that of spreading the word that everyone on earth must worship Antichrist. He will do a great deal of preaching. By his preaching, which will be eloquent and powerful, he will convince people to worship Antichrist.

C. Deceiving the earth's dwellers to make an image to the first beast

Verse 14 says, "And he deceives those who dwell on the earth because of the signs which he was given to do before the beast, telling those who dwell on the earth to make an image to the beast, who had the stroke of the sword and lived." He will deceive people to such an extent that they will agree to make an image of the beast and worship him.

We have seen that Antichrist will be the totality of the characteristics of all the worldly powers. Throughout the centuries, people have been fond of erecting images of their heroes. Even today people make images of certain heroes. All this foreshadows what the false prophet will do for Antichrist. The false prophet will set up the image of Antichrist as an idol. Many argue that the images set up in various places today are not idols and that people are not required to worship them. Although this may be true, in principle to worship a hero is to worship an idol. We Christians must be careful never to stand before an image and pay respect to it. In principle, this is worshipping an idol. We should never stand before any image; we should stand only before our Lord. In the ten commandments God commanded us never to make an image. If you make an image, regardless of your purpose in doing so, people will eventually worship it, either in your generation or in a future generation. The desire for a hero will consummate in Antichrist, and the false prophet will convince the worldly people to worship their hero. Undoubtedly, Antichrist will be the hero of heroes, surpassing all the heroes of bygone generations. Through the release and distribution of this message, many Christians will be prepared for this. When that day comes for the image of Antichrist to be erected, they will be able to stay away from it.

Revelation 13:15 says, "And it was given to him to give breath to the image of the beast, that the image of the beast might even speak and cause that whoever would not worship the image of the beast should be killed." Here we see that the false prophet will actually be able to give the breath of life to the idol. The idol will thus be enlivened. No idol made by man has been able to speak (Psa. 115:5), but this last idol will be enabled to speak as a living image. This surely will be an astonishing sign to the earth's dwellers, causing them all to worship the image of Antichrist. Today's scientists can make many things, but they cannot give breath to anything they make. But the day is coming when Judas will be able to do this. An idol will be placed in the temple of God. This idol will speak and command that anyone who does not worship it should be killed. How difficult it will be for anyone not to be deceived by this devilish wonder! Who will be able to keep from worshipping Antichrist or his image? According to 13:8, "All those dwelling on the earth shall worship him, every one whose name has not been written in the book of life of the Lamb slain from the foundation of the world." Only those whose names have been written in the Lamb's book of life will not worship Antichrist and his image. They will refuse to worship him, even at the cost of their lives. As a result, a great many will be martyred.

If you are not a firstfruit, but are left on earth during the great tribulation, you may be martyred by Antichrist. But that martyrdom will quickly make you an overcomer. Although those who are martyred during the great tribulation will be the late overcomers, they will become overcomers very quickly.

Brother Nee spent more than fifty years to become an overcomer. For more than thirty years he suffered the persecution from Christianity by means of opposition, criticisms, and rumors. Nearly all the missionaries, especially those of the China Inland Mission, opposed him. After those years of opposition from Christianity, he was imprisoned for another twenty years. Although Brother Nee spent fifty years to become an overcomer, those who remain during the great tribulation will not have more than forty-two months. It will not be pleasant to be left to pass through the great tribulation, but it is a great deal better than dying today. If you die now, you will lose the opportunity to be an overcomer. Praise the Lord that we all have the opportunity to become overcomers, either the early overcomers or the late overcomers. I certainly want to be an overcomer, to remain alive until I see the Lord. But if we cannot be overcomers today, then, instead of dying, we should prefer to be left in the great tribulation, for then we shall have the opportunity to be late and quick overcomers. If you do not want to be an overcomer now, you will be forced to be an overcomer later. Although you may say that you do not care, the Lord has a way to make you care. Antichrist will come, and the false prophet will preach and erect an image that will be able to speak. What will you do then? You will have to counter-preach. But after preaching against Antichrist, you will be martyred.

If these messages do not help to make you an early overcomer, I have the assurance that they will prepare you to be a late overcomer. The Lord is now releasing all these messages. I have not touched this matter of prophecy for more than forty years. This is the first time since the early 1930s that I have dealt with prophecy in the way of life. I believe that in the not too distant future Antichrist will come and the false prophet will appear. This is a timely word for God's people. This word will either motivate them to be early overcomers, or it will strengthen them to be the late overcomers. The Lord has a way, and He will gain the victory. Hallelujah, our names have been written in the book of life! This is our predestination.

D. Causing all people to bear the mark

The false prophet will cause all "to be given a mark on their right hand or on their forehead" (13:16). The men will probably be marked on the forehead and the women on the right hand. This mark will indicate that they belong to Antichrist, the authority of the false prophet. Unless people are marked, they will not be able to buy or sell (13:17). As we have already pointed out, the name of the beast is Caesar Nero, and the number of his name is six hundred and sixty-six.

We have seen that two beasts are about to come, the first beast from the sea, from the Gentile world, and the second beast from the land, from the nation of Israel. It is unnecessary to remember all the details pertaining to these two beasts. When the time comes, you will remember the impression these messages have made upon you. Surely this is the Lord's purpose in releasing this word. As far as the beast and the false prophet are concerned, we cannot say that no impression has been made upon us. Rather, we have been deeply impressed, and this impression cannot be taken away. We know who we are, where we are, what we are doing, and where we are going. Praise the Lord that we also know what is coming. Hallelujah, we have been enlightened and impressed!

The Correspondence Between the Vision in Revelation 12 and the Book of Ephesians

In this message I would like to point out the correspondence between the vision in Rev. 12 and the book of Ephesians. In Revelation 12 we all have been impressed with the vision of the woman with her stronger part, the man-child, fighting against the enemy by means of the word. In the book of Ephesians we also have the woman. As we all know, Ephesians is a book on the church, which is the greater part of the woman in Revelation 12. In Ephesians this woman is the wife of Christ.

Strengthened to become the stronger part within the woman

In Eph. 3:16 Paul prayed that the Father would grant us, “according to the riches of his glory, to be strengthened with power through His Spirit into the inner man.” This strengthening takes place in our inner man, which is our regenerated spirit indwelt by the Holy Spirit. The more we are strengthened in our inner man, the more we become the stronger part within the woman. The key to becoming the stronger part within the woman is being strengthened in our inner man. In verse 18 Paul continues to pray that we would “be strong to apprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth.” Although the King James Version uses the word able, the Greek word translated able means to be strengthened with power. We must be empowered to know the dimensions of the riches of our Christ. In order to be the man-child, we must be not only strengthened in our inner man, but also nourished with all the riches of Christ. Furthermore, Ephesians 6:10 tells us to “be empowered in the Lord and in the might of His strength.” According to this chapter, the way to be strong is to put on the whole armor of God (vv. 11, 13), which is the all-inclusive Christ. To put on the whole armor of God is to put the all-inclusive Christ upon us. Every aspect of the all-inclusive Christ must become our covering. Thus, in Ephesians 3:16 and 18 and 6:10 and 11, we see that the way to become the stronger part within the woman is to be strengthened in our inner man, to be empowered to experience the riches of Christ, and to be strong through putting on the all-inclusive Christ as our armor. Hence, in the book of Ephesians we find the aspects of both the woman and the man-child.

Fighting the enemy by praying

In the book of Ephesians we also have the warfare against spiritual darkness, against the principalities and powers in the heavenlies (Eph. 6:12). These evil powers are, of course, the powers of the enemy, Satan. Therefore, in this book we see not only the woman and the man-child, but also the third party, Satan, the serpent. Ephesians reveals that a warfare is raging between the stronger part within the woman and the enemy and, furthermore, that this fighting is carried on by praying. The way the man-child fights against the enemy is by prayer. Eventually, the entire book of Ephesians brings us to one climactic point — watching and praying.

Taking the word by means of all prayer

At this point we need to present a literal translation of Ephesians 6:17 and 18. “And receive the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit which is the word of God, by means of all prayer and petition, praying at every time in spirit, and watching unto this in all perseverance and petition concerning all the saints.” According to these verses, the way to fight is to take the word of God by means of all prayer. We should not simply have one way of prayer, but every means of prayer, exercising our spirit to pray in various ways to take the word of God. This portion of the Bible speaks about pray-reading, about taking the word of God by means of all prayer. It is of no avail to fight against the enemy with our own thoughts and words. We cannot use our mind or utterance to do battle against him. The most effective way to war against the enemy is to pray-read the Word, and the best portion of the Word to pray-read is the book of Ephesians. If you pray-read this book in a concentrated way for a period of time, you will be strengthened. Instead of trying to understand the book of Ephesians, you should pray-read it, even covering the whole book in two weeks. If you do this, you will be able to testify that you are becoming the stronger part within the woman.

Killing our opinions and concepts

The word in John 6 is for nourishing. In John 6:57 the Lord said, “He who eats Me shall also live because of Me,” and in 6:63 He said, “The words which I have spoken unto you are spirit and are life.” The word in John 6 is for nourishing, whereas the word in Ephesians 6 is mainly for killing. The word in John 6 is bread, but the word in Ephesians 6 is a sword. A sword does not nourish; rather, it kills. But this sword does not kill you — it slays the enemy and all the negative things within you. If we would fight against the principalities and powers in the heavenlies, we must firstly kill all the “bugs” within us.

You may wonder what these “bugs” are. Speaking in terms of doctrine, you may say that these “bugs” are your mind, emotion, and will. But to be practical, the “bugs” that most need to be killed are our opinions. We need an intensified enlightenment to see that we are filled with opinions. When you listen to a message, fellowship with the saints, or read the Bible, you cling to many opinions and concepts. Nearly every saint holds on to some opinion or concept. My point here is this: If we would be the stronger part in the woman, fighting against the enemy by praying, we must take the word of God by renouncing every opinion. In other words, the way to take the word of God by pray-reading is to have our opinions slain. In message eighty-seven of the life-study of Genesis we pointed out that to keep the word of the Lord means to take in the Lord and to have all our opinions killed. If it were not for the Lord’s mercy, we would all frustrate the word of the Lord by our opinions. How we need to pray-read the killing word, the word that kills our opinions and concepts!

In my experience in the church life, many times I have frustrated the Lord by my opinions. The problem with everyone in the Lord’s recovery is this matter of opinions. I am not saying that we should be without feeling, like a wooden log. When you come to the Word, as a living person who is strong in thought, feeling, and judgment, you must ask the Lord to slay your opinions. Not many saints have prayed in this way. But we must say, “Lord, I am about to pray-read Your word. Lord, kill my opinions.” What has frustrated you from being built up with others is not mainly your weakness or even your worldliness — it is your opinions. We all have a heart to love the Lord and a desire to be built up into the church. Often, however, the outcome has not been according to our desire. Some have been in the church life for more than ten years, but they are still not a part of the actual building. Although they are very close to the building, they are detached from it. No matter how close they are to the building, they are not actually built into it. Their opinions have hindered them from being built up with others. Thus, we all must pray, “Lord, I want to be strengthened in my inner man; I want to be empowered to realize the riches of Christ; and I want to be strong by putting on the whole armor of God. But my problem is that I haven’t yet allowed Your word to kill my opinions.”

Occasionally, some friends have asked me why I receive so much light from the Word and why they receive very little. Although we read the same Bible, they do not receive much light. Here is the secret to receiving light from the Word: Allow the Word to kill your opinions. Many read the Word in a selective way, taking whatever matches their opinion and rejecting whatever does not match it. Genuine pray-reading, on the contrary, is taking the Word itself and letting it kill your opinions. Ephesians 6 does tell us the way to pray-read. It is to take the Word by means of all prayer. As we pray-read, the first thing the Word will do is kill our opinions. If you do not allow the Word to slay your opinions, you will not be able to reach the enemy in the air to do battle with him. Our experience proves that pray-reading does not firstly nourish us; it firstly kills our opinions. Every time we have some practical pray-reading, our opinions are put to death.

You may be wondering what your opinions are. The brothers hold on to one opinion, and their wives hold on to a different opinion. You may think that you are a good husband, but you do not realize how strongly you cling to your opinions in relation to your wife. You love her and you may rarely argue with her, but, deep within, you treasure opinions that differ from hers. Of course, the same is true with the wives. Therefore, the husbands and wives hold to different concepts. As a result, they have not only been hindered from being built up with the brothers and sisters in the church life, but they have not even been built up with each other in their married life. Although you and your wife may have been saved for many years and may have spent those years loving the Lord and seeking the truth, up until this very moment you may still be clinging to your opinions. You love the Lord, you love the church, and you love each other, but you still hold to your opinions. And these opinions hinder you from being built up in the church.

Every one of us is opinionated. I confess that I used to be very opinionated, but I praise the Lord that my opinions have undergone a good deal of killing. Although I do not boast that I do not hold on to anything, I can say that, by His killing, it is difficult for me to cling to anything. According to the implication of Ephesians 6, by pray-reading we take the killing word as the sword that is able to slay all our opinions.

The way to put on Christ as our armor

If we hold to our opinions, we shall not be able to put on Christ as our armor. In order to put on the whole armor of God, our opinions must be killed. Instead of having Christ as their armor, many have their various opinions. Their thinking, desiring, and choosing are governed by their opinions. Because they have all these opinions, they do not have the whole armor of God. They may have opinions in their mind, but they do not have Christ as their helmet covering their head. The only way to put on the helmet of salvation as our covering is to have our opinions and concepts subdued and killed. We need to pray, "O Lord, have mercy on me and slay my thoughts, opinions, and concepts." If we sincerely pray in this way, we shall be under the covering of the helmet. The same is true with respect to the breastplate. You may have your own tastes and choices, and you may be strong in certain likes and dislikes. But if this is your condition, you cannot put on the breastplate. Only when your choice is killed will you be able to put on Christ as your breastplate to cover your conscience.

Although I knew Ephesians 6 in a doctrinal way years ago, I thank the Lord that today I know this chapter in the way of experience. I have seen that, if we would put on the all-inclusive Christ as the whole armor of God, all our thoughts, concepts, opinions, affections, and choices must be put to death. Only then shall we be completely under the covering of the all-inclusive Christ. Having this armor upon us, we shall be able to fight the evil powers in the heavenlies.

Many are disqualified from fighting against the principalities and powers in the heavenlies because they are entangled by their concepts, opinions, and choices. The only fight they know is the fight within themselves, not the warfare in the air. They are not able to get out of themselves and penetrate into the enemy's territory in the air. They are like a fighter plane that is grounded because of bad weather. This "bad weather" is the self, full of opinions, choices, intentions, decisions, likes, and dislikes. Because many are entangled with these things and thus have not put on the all-inclusive Christ as the armor to cover and equip them, they cannot soar into the air to war against the enemy in the heavenlies. Rather, they are still enveloped in all their own opinions and concepts.

The practical way to come into the experience of the vision

In Revelation 12 we have the vision, and in Ephesians we have the practical way to come into the experience of this vision. Although Revelation 12 unveils the stronger part within the woman, it does not give us the way to become this stronger part. The way, unfolded in the book of Ephesians, is to be strengthened in our inner man, to be empowered to experience the riches of Christ, and to be strong through putting on the armor of God by pray-reading the killing word. The word we take in by pray-reading will kill every negative element in our being. The more these negative elements are killed, the more we shall be equipped with the armor of God. After we have been thus equipped, we shall be able to take off from the ground and fight against the principalities and powers in the heavenlies. Hence, the way to fight the battle as the man-child is found in Ephesians 6.

Because I realize that everyone in the churches in the Lord's recovery loves the Lord, I have been burdened to fellowship with you in this way. Although you love the Lord, you still have many opinions that need to be killed. The killing word must do its work within us. This cannot happen by teaching or by listening to messages; it is the result of a proper pray-reading of the Word. As word after word penetrates into our being, our opinions, concepts, desires, and choices are slain. I suggest that you take two weeks to prove this by pray-reading the entire book of Ephesians. This pray-reading will expose all your opinions and concepts, and it will bring you to the point where you will be willing to renounce them all. Then you will be able to say, "In the church life with the brothers and sisters and in my married life, I do not hold on to any opinions. Lord, because I am no longer entangled by anything on earth, at any moment I can take off from the ground and soar into the heavenlies to fight against the enemy. Nothing can hold me down." If you pray-read the book of Ephesians, you will see where you are and you will know what you need.

The Firstfruit

In chapter twelve we have seen a clear vision of a universal woman bearing a man-child and confronting a great dragon. We all have been deeply impressed with this sign. In chapter thirteen we saw two beasts — Antichrist and the false prophet, both of whom collaborate with the dragon, Satan, to oppose God and to hinder the completion of God's economy. Following this, we have more crucial matters in chapter fourteen. Here we not only see the firstfruit (Rev. 14:1-5), but the things that follow the rapture of the firstfruit (Rev. 14:6-13): the preaching of the eternal gospel (Rev. 14:6-7), the fall of religious Babylon (Rev. 14:8), the warning against the worship of the beast and his image and against the mark (Rev. 14:9-11), and the martyrdom during the great tribulation (Rev. 14:12-13). In addition, chapter fourteen covers the harvest (Rev. 14:14-16) and the great winepress (Rev. 14:17-20). Chapter fourteen has four main categories: the rapture of the firstfruit; the things following the rapture of the firstfruit; the harvest, which is the reaping of the majority of the believers; and the great winepress, which is the reaping of the evil people on earth. Thus, this chapter reveals how everyone living on earth at the end time will be dealt with.

Everyone on earth falls into one of two categories: those who are the people of God and those who are not the people of God. The people of God are composed of Christians and Israelites, the God-fearing Jews. Israel is not covered in this chapter, because it was already covered in chapter seven with the vision of the sealing of the one hundred forty-four thousand chosen Israelites. This chapter unfolds God's dealing with the Christian portion of His people. Among this part of His people, there are also two main sections: the firstfruit, those who ripen early, and the harvest, those who ripen later. Between the rapture of the firstfruit and the rapture of the harvest, four main things will occur: the preaching of the eternal gospel; the fall of Babylon the great, that is, religious Babylon, the Roman Catholic Church; the warning against the worship of the beast; and the great martyrdom during the great tribulation. After the harvest, the situation among the Christians will be cleared up. But those who are not God's people will still be on earth. They are not considered as the wheat in God's field, but as grapes in the evil field. These grapes will be gathered into the great winepress and trodden by the Lord Jesus (Rev. 14:19-20). At that time the whole earth will be cleared up. Thus, chapter fourteen is a very significant chapter, revealing how the situation of everyone on earth will be dealt with. God is wise, righteous, and sovereign. By His wisdom, righteousness, and sovereignty He will deal with everyone on earth in the proper way and at the proper time. Praise Him!

What is prophesied in the Bible is simply a principle. We do not have the details. If the Lord had given us all the details of the things to come, the Bible would have thousands of pages, and we would not be able to carry it around. We thank the Lord for His wisdom. We have pointed out that all the world powers from Babylon to the coming revived Roman Empire with the ten kingdoms are represented by the huge image Nebuchadnezzar saw in a dream (Dan. 2:31-33). The head signifies Babylon; the breast and arms, Medo-Persia; the belly and the thighs, Greece; and the two legs, the Roman Empire. It is a historical fact that the Roman Empire was divided into two sections signified by the legs of the image. The period indicated by the ankle is ambiguous. Presently we are living in this ambiguous period. A gap was created by the termination of the Roman Empire in A.D. 476, but during this time that gap is being filled in by the Roman Catholic Church. At the close of this long interval, the Roman Empire will be revived and consummate in the ten kingdoms signified by the ten toes of the image. According to Daniel 2, these ten kingdoms will be smashed by a stone cut without hands (vv. 34-35). This stone is Christ, who will come from the heavens to smite the entire image, including everything from Nebuchadnezzar to the last Caesar. In His wisdom God has used the image of the human body to give a clear picture of the various stages of the worldly powers. This is the way and the principle of prophecy in the Bible. In a sense, the prophecy in the Bible is very brief.

The principle is the same with respect to the rapture of God's people. There is a difference between the rapture of the overcomers and the rapture of the majority of the believers. We have covered this matter of the rapture in messages twenty-nine and thirty. Based upon the principle of these two kinds of rapture, we come now to the firstfruit.

I. The firstfruit

A. Firstfruit to God and to the Lamb

The firstfruit to God and to the Lamb mentioned in verse 4 are the ones of God's crop who mature the earliest. These early overcomers will be the first ripe ones in God's field. Hence, they will be reaped before the harvest as firstfruit to God and to the Lamb. According to verses 14 through 16, the harvest will be reaped later. This means that they will be raptured to the heavens before the harvest, just as the firstfruit of the good land was reaped and brought into the temple of God before the harvest (Lev. 23:10-11; Exo. 23:19). The events recorded in verses 6 through 13, all of which will transpire during the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21), indicate clearly and prove strongly that the first overcomers as the firstfruit in verses 1 through 5 will be raptured before the great tribulation and that the harvest in verses 14 through 16, which includes the majority of believers, will be raptured towards the end of the great tribulation.

B. A hundred and forty-four thousand

Verse 1 says, "And I saw, and behold, the Lamb standing on Mount Zion, and with Him a hundred and forty-four thousand." In the past many teachers have debated whether this number is literal or figurative. Some said that the number one hundred and forty-four thousand was not a literal number, and others said that just as the seven cities in chapters two and three are literal, so must the number one hundred forty-four thousand be taken literally. This number should no doubt be an actual number, but with a symbolic meaning. Although the number is literal, it has a spiritual significance. By applying a certain principle we can apprehend the spiritual significance of this number.

One hundred forty-four thousand is one thousand multiplied by twelve times twelve. Twelve is the number of completion in God's eternal administration. One hundred forty-four (21:17) is twelve times twelve, which signifies the completion of completions, the ultimate completion in the fullest way. Here it is one thousand times this ultimate completion.

The number twelve is not composed of six plus six, but of three times four. I do not say this lightly or without a basis. The biblical number twelve is composed of three times four. The New Jerusalem is a city of twelves — twelve foundations, the names of twelve apostles (21:14), twelve gates, twelve angels, the names of the twelve tribes of Israel (21:12), twelve pearls (21:21), twelve months, twelve kinds of fruit (22:2). The height of its wall is one hundred forty-four cubits (twelve times twelve, 21:17), and its dimensions are twelve thousand stadia (a thousand times twelve, 21:16). In every aspect the New Jerusalem is a city of twelves. That the number twelve in the New Jerusalem is composed of three times four we know by the fact that the city has three gates on each of its four sides (21:13). Undoubtedly, the number three signifies the Triune God. The portrait of the New Jerusalem in chapters twenty-one and twenty-two reveals the Triune God. In 22:1 we see the throne of God and the Lamb, out of which proceeds the river of water of life. Here we have the Father, the Son, and the Spirit dispensing Himself into the city. This is the Triune God. The city itself represents God's creature signified by the number four (four living creatures, 4:6). In the New Jerusalem it is not a matter of three plus four, but of three times four. Today our number is seven, as in the seven churches, the seven lampstands. But in eternity our number will be twelve, three multiplied by four, signifying the mingling of the Triune God with man. Hence, the number twelve signifies the mingling of divinity with humanity. How wonderful! This mingling is for the completion of God's economy, the completion of God's economic administration. Therefore, the number twelve indicates completion in God's administration for the fulfillment of His economy.

Here it is not simply the number twelve, but a thousand of twelve times twelve. Twelve times twelve means completion in God's administration for God's economy in completion in God's administration for God's economy. This is similar to the titles Song of Songs, Lord of lords, and King of kings. Twelve multiplied by twelve means completion of completions. This completion is not temporary, but eternal. It is the completion in God's administration for the fulfillment of God's economy. The New Jerusalem will declare to the whole universe that God's redeemed people will be twelve among twelve, completion among completions. When we are in the New Jerusalem, we will be the completion in God's administration for the fulfillment of God's economy for eternity. But in chapter fourteen we have a thousand of twelve multiplied by twelve, a thousand times of completion in completion. This is the significance of the number one hundred forty-four thousand. The one hundred forty-four thousand firstfruit are believers who are for the accomplishment of God's eternal purpose.

We are fortunate to be standing upon the shoulders of so many great teachers who have gone before us. We thank the Lord for them. What we have seen concerning the significance of this number is based upon their understanding. However, the Lord has shown us something more than He showed them. Although the number one hundred forty-four thousand is literal, it has a spiritual significance, indicating that every living overcomer is a part of the completion of God's administration in the fulfillment of His economy for eternity. To be a living overcomer is a great matter. To be a firstfruit is to be for the completion of God's administration to fulfill His economy for eternity.

C. Purchased from the earth

Verse 3 says that the one hundred forty-four thousand "have been purchased from the earth." This proves that they are no longer on earth, but had been raptured to the heavens. At the time of verses 1 through 5 the firstfruit are no longer on earth because they have been purchased "from the earth." They were purchased with the blood of the Lamb and have been taken away from earth to heaven.

D. Purchased from among men

Verse 4 says that the firstfruit "were purchased from among men." This indicates that they are no longer among men, but are in the heavens.

E. Standing with the Lamb on Mount Zion

The firstfruit stand with the Lamb on Mount Zion (v. 1). The Zion mentioned in verse 1 is not the earthly one but the Zion in the heavens (Heb. 12:22). Those who stand with the Lamb on Mount Zion are raptured to the heavens before Antichrist's persecution of religion. After this rapture, Antichrist will persecute people and compel them to worship him. By this fact we know that the living overcomers are raptured before the great tribulation.

F. Having the Lamb's name and the Father's name on their foreheads

Verse 1 also indicates that the one hundred forty-four thousand have the name of the Lamb and the name of His father written on their foreheads. This is the designation of their being one with the Lamb and with the Father and of their belonging to Them. The name of the Lamb and the name of the Father written on the foreheads of these early overcomers is in contrast to the name of the beast written on the foreheads of his worshippers (13:16-17).

G. Singing a new song

Verse 3 says, "And they sing a new song before the throne and before the four living creatures and the elders; and no one could learn the song except the hundred and forty-four thousand who have been purchased from the earth." The one hundred forty-four thousand sing a new song before the throne, the four living creatures, and the elders. Apart from the firstfruit, no one is able to learn this song, because no one else has the necessary experience. Songs always come out of experience. If you have no experience, you have nothing to sing about. Because the hundred forty-four thousand overcomers have specific and particular experiences of Christ, they can sing a song that others do not understand. Some Christians do not understand our songs. Although they may say that these songs are strange, we say that they are sweet and tasteful. Whenever we sing certain songs, we are beside ourselves. But those who do not have the experience do not understand what we are singing about. Only the experienced ones can learn to sing the song of the hundred forty-four thousand.

Verse 2 says, "And I heard a voice out of heaven like the sound of many waters and like the sound of loud thunder; and the voice which I heard was like the sound of harp-singers playing on their harps." The many waters signify the tumultuousness of the sound, the loud thunder signifies the solemnity of the sound, and the sound of harp-singers signifies the pleasantness of the sound.

The solemnity of the loud thunder will terrify Satan. Since the singing of the one hundred forty-four thousand will be noisy in that day, should not our singing be somewhat noisy today? The more noisy our singing is, the better. Of course, the religious ones will condemn this. The singing of the one hundred forty-four thousand sounds somewhat like the waters of Niagara Falls. In fact, I believe that it may be many times more noisy than Niagara Falls. Today's Christianity is dead and legal. But we must be noisy, not dead. However, our noisy singing should not be a performance; rather, it should issue from our spirit. At least eight times in the book of Psalms we are told to make a joyful noise unto the Lord (Psa. 95:1-2; 98:4; 100:1). This tumultuous, joyful noise should come automatically from our spirit. When we are filled with the sweet experience of the Lord, our spirit will be filled to the brim. The only way to express our joy is to make a joyful noise to the Lord. Because Niagara Falls is filled with water that has great impact, its sound is not a performance. This is the way we must be when we gather together. Only by experience can we understand this. I can testify that I have experienced this. Sometimes, as we are making a tumultuous noise in the spirit, singing and praising the Lord, sweet music comes forth from this tumultuous sound. If you have experienced this, you will be able to say "Amen" to what I am saying. But this has offended some who said that they were not able to bear the noise. However, this is not my way — it is the Lord's way, the biblical way. If you do not exercise yourself in this manner today, you will have to learn to do so later.

H. Not defiled with women

Verse 4 says of the firstfruit that they "were not defiled with women, for they are virgins." Just as there has been a debate about whether the number one hundred forty-four thousand is literal or figurative, there has also been a debate regarding the understanding of virginity mentioned in this verse. According to this portion of the Word, all the one hundred forty-four thousand living overcomers are virgins. Some say that this virginity is literal, and others say that it is spiritual. The virginity here should be the virginity mentioned by the Lord in Matthew 19:11-12. However, the same principle can be applied to the sisters (1 Cor. 7:7, 34, 37). The principle of virginity is that we should not be defiled by anything earthly. If we take this only literally, then all the sisters will be excluded. But it is not right to exclude the sisters from being among the living overcomers.

In order to be a living overcomer we must be kept by the Lord's grace from every defilement and pollution and live on earth like virgins. In the eyes of the worldly people it means little whether we go to the movies or not. But in the eyes of the saved ones it is serious for me to go to a movie theater. If I did, I would be defiled. We must live a life of virginity, a life of chastity. The reason I neither smoke nor drink is that I do not want to be defiled. On occasion some brothers have offered me a drink of beer. But I have always refused. The Lord's mercy and grace have preserved me for more than fifty years. I will not sell myself so cheaply as to be contaminated by drinking beer. Although it may not be sinful to drink beer, I will not allow the drinking of beer to defile my virginity. But do not be legal about things like this. I can sit in the presence of brothers who are drinking beer and not be bothered at all. It is absolutely not a matter of legality; it is a matter of our desire to preserve ourselves as virgins for the Lord. We all must say, "Lord Jesus, I love You. Because I love You, I will remain as a virgin for You. Lord, I don't want to be defiled or polluted by anything. Lord, I want to keep myself for You." As a young man, I prayed this way day by day. How I thank the Lord that He has truly answered my prayer.

In my travels throughout the years, I have found myself in many different situations. In these situations there have been a great many temptations. But I can testify, even before the accuser, that the Lord's grace has preserved me. Although there have been television sets in many of the hotel rooms, the Lord can testify for me that not once did I turn on the television. It would not have been sinful for me to watch television, but I would have been defiled. As I was in my room I said, "Lord, I don't want to be defiled. I want to be kept as a virgin for You. Lord, I did not come to this city for television, but for Your testimony. I know the brothers and sisters cannot see what I am doing in my hotel room, but the demons can see." If I had turned on the television set, my testimony for the Lord Jesus would not have had impact. But because my conscience testified that I was not defiled and that I was kept as a virgin for the Lord Jesus, my speaking had an impact.

It is deplorable to make the Lord's salvation a matter of legality. We should never say that we cannot do certain things because our church forbids us to do them. What a pitiful attitude! With us, it is not a matter of legality, but of a loving desire for the Lord. We love the Lord Jesus and earnestly desire to be preserved as chaste virgins for Him. Whenever I am in a department store, I look to the Lord that He would keep me from becoming defiled. This is what it means to be a virgin. Both the brothers and the sisters may be virgins for the Lord Jesus. If you pray to the Lord in this manner and desire to live like a virgin, all the "bugs" will be under your feet. This is the way to be a living overcomer, one of the firstfruit.

You may be wondering about the difference between the overcomers in chapter twelve and the overcomers in chapter fourteen. In chapter twelve we have the man-child, and in chapter fourteen we have the firstfruit. In the messages on chapter twelve we saw clearly that the man-child is for fighting and defeating Satan. Hence, the man-child deals with the enemy. The firstfruit is not for fighting; it is for the satisfaction of God and the Lamb. God and the Lamb need enjoyment. We, the living overcomers, shall be the firstfruit to satisfy Their need for enjoyment.

The enemy, the Devil, in heaven must be cast down by the man-child, who will execute the Lord's judgment over him. This is the function of the man-child. But there is another need in the heavens — God must be satisfied. God is hungry and thirsty. He desires some firstfruit to taste for His satisfaction.

Here again we see the sovereign wisdom of the Lord. The overcomers who have died throughout the centuries will be the man-child, the fighters. Although we who are living on earth must also fight against the enemy, there is no need to fight him all the time. After you have preached to Satan for a while, you should forget about him. The enemy is subtle. Once you begin to preach to him, he will attract you to preach to him constantly, saying, "My face has become very thick, and I have no sense of shame. I would like to hear you preach to me all the time." He would do this in order to distract you from loving the Lord. Therefore, after preaching to the Devil for a period of time, you should say, "Devil, I have no more time to preach to you. Rather, I would use my time to tell my Lord how much I love Him. I want to remain with my Lord in a loving way. Satan, you are the Lord's enemy and you are my enemy too. I have preached enough to you. Get away — now is the time for me to enjoy a honeymoon with my Lord." Learn this strategy. Do not preach to Satan for too long a time. After preaching for a certain period of time, you must stop and spend your time in loving the Lord, saying, "Lord, I enjoy looking at You and talking to You. Lord, I want to satisfy You, to be one with You, and to stay in Your presence." Learn to spend time loving the Lord Jesus in an intimate way. If you have never had such a time, you are short. It is not adequate merely to be sinless. It is not sufficient simply to be good or right. We must be in love with the Lord. Although I do not like the term in love, I am forced to use it. We all need to fall in love with the Lord Jesus, telling Him, "O Lord Jesus, I love You, and You know that I love You. Because I love You, Lord, there are certain things that I will not do." This is the way to be a living overcomer. Although the Lord certainly needs the man-child to fight against His enemy, He needs the firstfruit, His lovers, even more to be His satisfaction.

In type, the firstfruit were brought not to the farmer's home, but into God's house, the temple, for His satisfaction. This was even true of the Lord Jesus as the firstfruit (1 Cor. 15:20, 23). On the morning of His resurrection, the Lord did not allow Mary to touch Him. He said, "Do not touch Me, for I have not yet ascended to the Father" (John 20:17). The Lord seemed to be saying, "Do not touch Me, because I must present My freshness in My resurrection to My Father. My Father must be the first to taste the freshness of My resurrection." We all need to learn to present ourselves in a fresh, intimate, and loving way to the Lord for His enjoyment. If you decline to do certain things or to touch certain things simply because you are afraid of something, you are not on the high plane of being a lover of the Lord. Rather, you are down on the lowest level. We must be on the highest plane, refusing to do certain things, not out of fear, but out of love for the Lord. The sisters desire to be with their husbands instead of going home to their parents because they love their husbands. Likewise, because I love the Lord, I shall refrain from doing certain things. I may have the liberty to do them, and it may not be wrong to do them, but simply because of my love for the Lord Jesus, I would not do them. This is the true significance of this portion of the Word.

We need to follow the principle in verse 4. This principle is that we, sisters and brothers alike, must keep our virginity, looking to the Lord that, by His grace, He would preserve us for Himself. We should be not only fighters, but also firstfruit, those who ripen earlier for the Lord's satisfaction. We need to say, "Lord, for the sake of Your satisfaction, I want to ripen early. Lord, I don't care for my rapture — I care for Your satisfaction. I want to be taken to the heavens to satisfy You. Lord, as long as I can satisfy You, it makes no difference to me whether I am on earth or in heaven." This is the attitude of the living overcomers.

Because it does not matter to the firstfruit where they are, we are not told that they are caught up; instead, we are simply told that the one hundred forty-four thousand firstfruit are standing with the Lamb on Mount Zion. As we have pointed out, this surely is not the Zion on earth, but the Zion in the heavens. If you are one of the living overcomers, it will make no difference to you whether or not you are raptured. Because you are already in the Lord's presence, the rapture will not come as a surprise. It does not matter to you whether you are in His presence here on earth or there on Mount Zion. When you get there, you will not be surprised. It would be wrong to say, "Oh, I'm here with the Lord. I'm in His presence!" Those who will be raptured as the firstfruit will have no feeling of surprise. Rather, they will say, "Lord Jesus, I have been with you continuously for years. Lord, it makes no difference whether I'm in Anaheim or in the third heaven." To the outsiders, it will come as a surprise for you to be standing on Mount Zion, but it should not be a surprise to you. It should be a common experience. If you have been away from your husband for many years, you will be "crazy" with excitement when you see him. But if you are with him all the time, you will surely not be so "crazy." Are you truly loving the Lord? Are you in intimate fellowship with Him right now, being kept in Him as a virgin? If you are, then the rapture will not come as a surprise; it will be an ordinary experience.

Although these verses on the firstfruit point to one kind of rapture, they actually say nothing about rapture. We are told that the man-child is "caught-up," but we are told that the firstfruit are standing on Mount Zion with the Lamb. If you were to ask them when they got there, they might say, "We are simply here. We have no special feeling about being here because we have been in the Lord's presence for years. We have lived in this atmosphere for a long time." This is the rapture of the living overcomers. These are the firstfruit, those who satisfy the hunger of God the Father and the Lamb, the Redeemer. The earliest ones of God's crop to mature are not for fighting; they are for satisfaction.

I. No lie being found in their mouth

Verse 5 says of the firstfruit that "In their mouth no lie was found." Lies are the expression and representation of Satan. The Devil is the father of all liars, and lies come out of him (John 8:44). That no lie was found in the overcomers' mouth indicates that there is nothing of Satan in their expression. If we live a life of loving the Lord, then no lie or falsehood will proceed out of our mouth. Although I hate to say it, for years I have suffered the lies of genuine Christians. What a shame! In the Lord's recovery there should be no lies and no falsehood in our mouth. When we say "Yes," we mean yes, and when we say "No," we mean no. If we cannot answer with a clear yes or no, we should not say anything. In such a case we should exercise our wisdom to say nothing, so that no lies nor falsehood would come out of our mouth. We have nothing to do with Satan, the liar and the source of the lies.

J. Without blemish

Verse 5 also says that the firstfruit are without blemish. This indicates that they are without spot or wrinkle, but are perfect in the holiness of God (Eph. 5:27), absolutely sanctified to God and fully saturated with God (1 Thes. 5:23).

K. Following the Lamb wherever He may go

The one hundred forty-four thousand firstfruit "follow the Lamb wherever He may go" (v. 4). It is not that the Lamb follows us, but that we follow Him wherever He goes. We all must learn the lesson of following Him wherever He goes.

The Things Following the Rapture of the Firstfruit

In this message we shall cover the things that follow the rapture of the firstfruit (Rev. 14:6-13).

II. The things following

A. The eternal gospel

The first thing to follow the rapture of the firstfruit will be the preaching of the eternal gospel (vv. 6-7). Although you may have read Rev. 14 many times, perhaps you have never been impressed with the term eternal gospel in verse 6. Probably no preacher, minister, or pastor has ever told you that in the future, after the rapture of the firstfruit, there will be a gospel revealed as the “eternal gospel.” Most Christians know only the gospel of grace; they do not know that, in God’s economy, an eternal gospel will be proclaimed during the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21).

The eternal gospel differs from the gospel of grace (Acts 20:24) preached in the church age. The basic content of the gospel of grace is repentance toward God and faith in the Lord Jesus (Acts 20:21) that men may be forgiven of their sins and be born again as children of God (Luke 24:47; John 1:12); while that of the eternal gospel is that men should fear God and worship God that they may not be deceived to follow Antichrist, but be brought back to the genuine worship of God, “who has made the heaven and the earth” (v. 7). Only man is privileged to preach the gospel of grace on earth today (Acts 10:3-6). But the eternal gospel will not be preached by men on earth, but by an angel in mid-heaven at the close of this age.

All students and teachers of the Bible agree that God has various ways of dealing with people. These ways are called dispensations. Although the word dispensation includes the concept of time, it specifically denotes the various ways God uses to deal with people. For example, the dispensation of the law was that period during which God dealt with people by the law. God dealt with Israel through the dispensation of law. In every period of time God has had a particular way of dealing with certain people. After the dispensation of law came the dispensation of grace, the age in which we are now living. In this age God deals with the believers in Him according to grace, not according to law. Just as the dispensation of law was ended by the coming of John the Baptist, the dispensation of grace will be ended by the beginning of the great tribulation. John the Baptist introduced a new dispensation, the dispensation of grace. At the beginning of the great tribulation, when Satan is cast down to earth and the spirit of Caesar Nero emerges from the abyss, the dispensation of grace will be ended. During the three and a half years, the forty-two months, of the great tribulation, God will have another way to deal with people — the way of the eternal gospel.

If you read Revelation 14 carefully, you will see that the content of the eternal gospel is absolutely different from the gospel we preach today. The gospel we preach contains two main items — repentance toward God and faith in the Lord Jesus Christ. At the beginning of the dispensation of grace, John the Baptist appeared to preach repentance (Matt. 3:1-2). Following him, the Lord Jesus preached repentance and faith. John the Baptist said, “Repent” (Matt. 3:2), and Jesus said, “Repent and believe” (Mark 1:15). In Acts, the apostles followed the Lord Jesus to preach repentance and faith. Repentance means a change of mind; it is a change of concept and a change of the understanding of life. Men must have a turn because their life is far from God. Now they must turn toward God. This is what it means to repent. However, this is just a small portion of the gospel of grace. The greater portion of the gospel of grace is believing in the Lord Jesus Christ that we may be forgiven of our sins and have eternal life to become the sons of God. This is the content of the gospel of grace that we preach today.

The content of the eternal gospel is much different. In the eternal gospel there is no repentance nor faith. Rather, there is the commandment to fear God and to give Him glory and to worship Him “who has made the heaven and the earth and the sea and the springs of waters” (v. 7). The command to worship God as the Creator is in contrast to the worship of Antichrist and his image mentioned in verse 9. The command to fear God and to give Him glory is given to the earth’s dwellers countering the deceit of the false prophet that men should follow Antichrist and countering the threat of death for any who would not worship him during the great tribulation (13:14-15). The angel who preaches the eternal gospel will seem to be saying, “You must fear God. Because Antichrist is not God, there is no need to fear him. Antichrist cannot put you into the lake of fire; only God can. Although Antichrist may do certain signs, he did not create the heaven, the earth, the sea, and the springs of waters. God is the Creator. You must fear Him and give glory to Him as the Creator of the universe. Do not worship Antichrist and his image. You all must worship God.” This is the eternal gospel. Because we have a better gospel, there is no need for us to hear this gospel.

Verse 7 also says, “The hour of His judgment has come.” The judgment here is the judgment which Christ will execute over all the nations at His coming back to earth, as He predicted in Matthew 25:31-46. This judgment, which will be executed upon the living before the millennium, differs from the judgment of the dead after the millennium, as mentioned in 20:11-15. All the people of the nations who still remain at the Lord’s coming back will be judged according to the eternal gospel preached by the angel during the great tribulation. If, by fearing God and worshipping Him, they have treated God’s people well, that is, they have taken care of the Christians and Jews, the Lord’s brothers suffering poverty and imprisonment under Antichrist’s persecution during the great tribulation, they will be justified by the Lord so that they may enter into the earthly part of the millennium to partake of the kingdom prepared by God for them from the foundation of the world (Matt. 25:34). If they have ill-treated the Christians and Jews by following Antichrist and by worshipping his image, they will be condemned and cast into the eternal fire of the lake of fire prepared for the Devil and his angels (Matt. 25:41).

In Matt. 25:31 the Lord Jesus said that He would come in His glory and “sit on His throne of glory.” This verse does not speak of the judgment seat (2 Cor. 5:10), but the throne of His glory, because by that time the judgment of the believers at the judgment seat will be over. Firstly, the Lord will descend from heaven to the air. After all the saints have been raptured, He will judge them at His judgment seat. This will not be the judgment of the unbelievers; it will be the judgment of the believers to determine who will be rewarded and who will be disciplined. After this judgment has been carried out, the Lord will come in glory with His army of overcoming believers to defeat Antichrist and his army. After Antichrist and the false prophet have been cast alive into the lake of fire, and after the armies of Antichrist have been made a feast for the birds (19:11-21), there will still be many unbelievers, the nations, on earth. Then the Lord Jesus will set up the throne of His glory; all the surviving unbelievers, the nations, will be gathered before Him (Matt. 25:32); and He will exercise His judgment upon them. Acts 10:42; 17:31, and 2 Timothy 4:1 reveal that the Lord has been appointed by God to judge both the living and the dead. The Lord will judge the living after the defeat of Antichrist and the false prophet and after He has set up His throne of glory. When this judgment has been carried out, the millennial kingdom will begin. After the millennial kingdom, the Lord will judge the dead at the great white throne (Rev. 20:11-15).

According to what criterion will the Lord judge the living unbelievers at the throne of His glory? There is no hint that the Lord will judge them according to the law of Moses. Neither will He judge them according to the gospel of grace. The Lord will not say, “Those who believe in Me are sheep, and those who do not believe in Me are goats.” Rather, according to Matthew 25:31-46, the Lord will judge the living unbelievers according to the way they have treated His little brothers, the God-fearing Jews and the Christ-believing Christians. These are those who will pass through the great tribulation and who will be the object of Antichrist’s persecution. Thus, the Lord will consider them as His little brothers. During the great tribulation the God-fearing Jews and the Christ-believing Christians will be hungry, thirsty, naked, ill, and imprisoned (Matt. 25:35-39). The Lord will judge the living unbelievers according to their treatment of His brothers during that time. Some will treat them very well. Undoubtedly, they will be those who hear the eternal gospel preached by the angel while Antichrist and his people are persecuting the Jews and the believers. When they hear this gospel commanding them to fear God and to worship Him, their heart will be touched, and they will treat the little brothers of the Lord favorably.

Hence, Christ’s exercise of judgment upon the living unbelievers at the throne of His glory will be based upon the eternal gospel. Whoever heeds that gospel and treats His brothers well will be considered as “sheep.” The others will be considered as “goats.” The “goats,” those who follow Antichrist to persecute God’s people, will be put with Antichrist into the lake of fire. All the “sheep,” on the contrary, will enter into the kingdom prepared for them “from the foundation of the world” (Matt. 25:34), the earthly part of the millennial kingdom, but they will be the citizens of that kingdom, not the kings or the priests. In the millennial kingdom we, the overcoming Christians, will be kings; the God-fearing Jews, who will be preserved and saved, will be priests; and the “sheep” will be citizens. Therefore, by the dispensation of law God will gain the Jews to be the priests; by the dispensation of grace He will gain the believers to be the kings; and by the eternal gospel He will gain the God-fearing Gentiles to be the citizens of the millennial kingdom.

This clear picture is formed by properly fitting together various portions of the Word like the pieces of a jigsaw puzzle. I was exercised over this “jigsaw puzzle” for a good many years. How happy I was when I finally put all the pieces together! A large piece of this “puzzle” is Matthew 25:31-46. For years, I tried unsuccessfully to fit this piece in place. Although I tried to put it everywhere, it did not fit anywhere. Eventually, I found where this piece fits in. Now, instead of a puzzle, we have a vivid picture.

Because of God’s mercy, the preaching of the eternal gospel will follow the rapture of the firstfruit. After the firstfruit is raptured, Antichrist will persecute the God-fearing Jews and the Christ-believing Christians. Then God will send an angel to mid-heaven to preach the eternal gospel.

Twenty-five years ago, we knew hardly anything about space technology. I believe that Antichrist will use modern scientific technology to touch other planets, which in the Bible are called “the host of heaven.” Suddenly, through God’s mercy, an angelic preacher will appear in space to preach an eternal gospel, warning the earth-dwellers to fear God, to worship Him, and not to persecute God’s people. God knows that the persecution aroused following the rapture of the firstfruit will be so severe that apart from His mercy no one will be able to bear it. But many will hear the eternal gospel, believe it, and help the persecuted ones. In this way the suffering Jews and the persecuted Christians will be helped to gain the necessary food, clothing, and visitations. The Lord knows the deeds of those who have helped His people, and when He comes to judge the living, He will consider them as “sheep.” Although the eternal gospel will produce the citizens for the millennial kingdom, its purpose is also to reduce the suffering of God’s people during the great tribulation. God is merciful and cares for His people. How we thank Him for His mercy!

The “sheep” in the millennial kingdom will not be regenerated believers. Instead of being regenerated, they will simply be restored to their original, created condition. Acts 3:21 speaks of the time of restoration. At this time the sun, the moon, and the stars will be restored sevenfold (Isa. 30:26). The length of human life will also be restored. Anyone who dies at the age of a hundred will be considered as dying prematurely (Isa. 65:20). All the “sheep” will be restored to the Adamic situation, to man’s original condition at creation. They will be different from us. When we believed in the Lord Jesus, eternal life entered us. The “sheep,” however, will not have eternal life entering into them; rather they will enter into eternal life, into the realm of eternal life (Matt. 25:46). This means that they will only be restored. Although they will not be regenerated and have eternal life in their being to make them sons of God, they will be restored as proper human beings to live on earth as God’s people, the citizens of the millennial kingdom.

B. The fall of religious Babylon

The second event to follow the rapture of the firstfruit will be the fall of religious Babylon. Verse 8 says, “And another, a second angel, followed, saying, Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great, who has made all the nations drink of the wine of the fury of her fornication!” The modifying clause, “who has made all the nations drink...,” indicates that Babylon here refers to the religious, mysterious Babylon, which is the Roman Catholic Church, as in 17:2-6, not the material Babylon, as in 18:2. When Antichrist breaks the covenant with Israel in the middle of the last week (seven years, Dan. 9:27; 11:31), he will destroy every religion. This will mark the beginning of the great tribulation which will continue for three and a half years. Antichrist will exalt himself above all gods and compel people to worship him as God (Dan. 8:9-11; 11:36-37; 2 Thes. 2:3-4; Rev. 13:4-6, 12, 14-15). At that time, he will destroy religious Babylon, the apostate Roman Catholic Church (17:16). Hence, religious Babylon will fall at the beginning of the great tribulation, whereas material Babylon will fall after the great tribulation (18:2).

“The wine of her fornication” indicates the spiritual fornication of the Roman Catholic Church which she “has made all the nations drink of” (17:2-6; 14:8). While she commits her fornication, she is furious with the saints who do not consent to it. This is “the fury of her fornication.” Hence, “the wine of her fornication” is also called “the wine of the fury of her fornication.”

We have seen that in the middle of the last seven years Antichrist will be resuscitated. Prior to his resuscitation, he will be assassinated as the seventh Caesar of the Roman Empire. After the spirit of Caesar Nero emerges from the abyss and enters into him, he will be resuscitated to be the eighth Caesar, thereby becoming a supernatural being. After his resuscitation, he will destroy every religion and make himself the sole object of religious worship. He will not only abolish the Jewish sacrifices and destroy Judaism; he will also destroy the rider on the beast described in chapter seventeen. The “woman sitting on a scarlet beast” (17:3) is “the great prostitute” (17:1), the apostate Roman Catholic Church. The beast signifies the Roman Empire, especially Antichrist. According to this picture, an evil woman, the Roman Catholic Church, will be riding on the Roman Empire. Not long after the time of Constantine the Great, the church degraded to such an extent that it not only became apostate, but also worldly. It grew so powerful that it became a rider sitting on the Roman Empire. But in the middle of the last seven years, the beast, Antichrist, will revoke his covenant with the Jews, destroy Judaism, and no longer tolerate any religion, including Catholicism. He will turn his back on Catholicism and, with the ten kings, will utterly obliterate it. In this matter God is truly sovereign. Although Antichrist will exalt himself above God, actually he will be used by God to destroy two religions — Judaism and Catholicism.

This is similar to the destruction of religion under communism in China. Although the communists oppose God, they do not realize that they have been used by God to demolish so many different religions, such as Buddhism and Taoism. Prior to 1949, there were idol temples throughout China. Today these temples have been cleared away. Furthermore, although the communists are opposing Jesus Christ, they still use His calendar. According to history, the one whose calendar you follow is the one to whom you are subject. Because the communists use His calendar, even they are subjects of the Lord Jesus unconsciously. Actually, because Jesus is King of kings, the entire earth uses His calendar. All people are subject to Him. How sovereign is our Lord! He is sovereign over all those who oppose Him, even using their opposition to accomplish His will. When Antichrist exalts himself to be God, the Lord Jesus will use him to destroy Judaism and Catholicism. Antichrist will do a good cleaning job for the Lord, purging the earth of religion and making it ready for the coming of the Lord Jesus. Thus, when the Lord Jesus comes to defeat Antichrist, religion will have been cleared away.

C. The warning against the worship of the beast and his image and against the mark

After the rapture of the firstfruit, a warning will be given against the worship of the beast and his image and against the mark (vv. 9-11). Verses 9 and 10 say, “If anyone worships the beast and his image and receives a mark on his forehead or on his hand, he also shall drink of the wine of the fury of God which is mixed undiluted in the cup of His wrath; and he will be tormented in fire and brimstone before the holy angels and before the Lamb.” The fire and brimstone mentioned in verse 10 refer to the fire and brimstone in the lake of fire (19:20; 20:10, 14). Those who worship the beast and his image and who receive the mark of his name will be eternally tormented and have no rest day and night (v. 11).

Verse 12 says, “Here is the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus.” The saints who will remain in the great tribulation will need endurance to suffer the persecution by Antichrist. The saints in the great tribulation will be of two peoples: the Jews who keep the commandments of God and the believers who keep the faith of Jesus.

D. The martyrdom in the great tribulation

During the great tribulation many saints will be martyred. Verse 13 says, “And I heard a voice out of heaven, saying, Write, Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from this time forth. Yes, says the Spirit, that they may rest from their labors; for their works follow with them.” The dead here refer to the martyrs under the persecution of Antichrist during the great tribulation. This is proved by 20:4. In this verse we read of the blessing upon those who are martyred during the great tribulation. These martyrs will rest, and all they have done will follow them as a reward.

The book of Revelation, written under the degradation of the church, stresses the Spirit. Verse 13 does not say, “says the scripture,” but, “says the Spirit.”

The Harvest and the Great Winepress

This message includes two main subjects found in Rev. 14: the harvest (Rev. 14:14-16) and the great winepress (Rev. 14:17-20). The harvest will be the reaping of God's people, and the winepress will be the reaping of the evil-doers. There are three peoples on the earth today — the Jews, the believers, and the unbelievers. The Jews and the believers are God's people, but the unbelievers mainly are evildoers. The sealing of the Jewish remnant was covered in the vision in Rev. 7:1-8. Thus, in chapter fourteen there is no mention of the Jews, but only of the believers and the unbelievers. The firstfruit, those who ripen earlier, will be taken to Mount Zion in the heavens before the great tribulation. However, the majority of God's crop, that is, the majority of the believers, will still be on earth after the rapture of the firstfruit and will eventually become the harvest.

I. The harvest

Verses 15 and 16 say, "And another angel came out of the temple, crying with a loud voice to Him who sat on the cloud, Send forth Your sickle and reap, for the hour to reap has come, because the harvest of the earth is ripe. And He who sat on the cloud thrust His sickle over the earth, and the earth was reaped." The harvest of the earth is God's people on earth, the believers in Christ (1 Cor. 3:9). At His first coming to the earth, the Lord sowed Himself into His believers (Matt. 13:3-8, 24). All the believers since that time who have received Him as the seed of life have become the crop of God on earth. Those who ripen first will be reaped as the firstfruit to God before the great tribulation, as indicated in verses 1 through 5. The majority will ripen with the help of the sufferings in the great tribulation and will be reaped near the end of the tribulation. Hence, the reaping mentioned in verse 16 will be the rapture of the majority of the believers who will be left on the earth to pass through most of the great tribulation, because this reaping will transpire after Antichrist forces people to worship him and his image (v. 9).

The reaping of the crop depends upon its ripeness. Those who ripen earlier will be the firstfruit, and the majority who ripen later will be the harvest. In Matthew 13:39 the Lord Jesus indicated that the crop will be harvested at the completion of this age (Gk.). We have not yet reached the completion of the age; this age is still continuing. At the completion of the age, the field of God will be reaped. Before the time of this reaping, the firstfruit will be ripened and raptured.

According to the type in the Old Testament, the firstfruit was reaped and brought into the temple of God for God's enjoyment (Exo. 23:19). But when the harvest, the majority of the crop, was reaped, it was taken into the barn, between the field and the farmhouse. By this we see that the firstfruit will be taken to God's house — to Mount Zion in the heavens — and that the harvest will be taken to the air. Not long after the firstfruit is taken to the Lord Jesus in the third heaven, He will leave the heavens and descend to the air, where He will remain for a period of time. According to the prophecy in 1 Thessalonians 4, the harvest will be raptured to the air. Most Christians merely understand the rapture in a general way according to 1 Thessalonians 4. They do not see anything regarding the rapture of the man-child and of the firstfruit.

Revelation 14 covers two kinds of raptures, the rapture of the firstfruit and the rapture of the harvest. The picture in typology portrays this very vividly. In ancient times the early wheat, the firstfruit, was reaped first, and the harvest was reaped later. As everybody knows, a picture is better than a thousand words. In this picture there is no ambiguity and no ground for argument. We simply must take the pure word according to the picture of the firstfruit and the harvest. We are awaiting the rapture of the firstfruit. Those who do not share in this will probably be included in the harvest.

A. After Antichrist's persecution of religion, near the end of the great tribulation

According to chapter fourteen, the rapture of the harvest will take place after Antichrist's persecution of religion. After the rapture of the firstfruit, the beast, Antichrist, will compel people to worship him and his image. He will also persecute the believers. This will be the great tribulation. The rapture of the firstfruit will be prior to the great tribulation, whereas the rapture of the harvest will be toward the end of the great tribulation. Hence, all the saints included in the rapture of the harvest must pass through the greater part of the great tribulation.

B. By Christ like the Son of Man

Verse 14 says, "And I saw, and behold, a white cloud, and on the cloud One sitting like the Son of Man, having a golden crown on His head and a sharp sickle in His hand." The harvest will be reaped by Christ as the Son of Man. He came as the Son of Man to sow the seed, and He will come again as the Son of Man to reap what He has sown.

At His coming back, the Lord Jesus will still be the Son of Man. As the Son of Man He is qualified to execute God's judgment on everyone (John 5:27). At this time He will no longer be wrapped, or concealed, in the cloud, but will be sitting on the cloud. This means that He will no longer be hidden; His coming will be public. Prior to this, His coming was hidden, but now it will be open and visible. In 10:1 Christ was still clothed with the cloud, whereas here He is on the cloud. This corresponds to 1 Thessalonians 4:17 and indicates that the Lord's coming back is now made public.

Verse 14 also says that He will have "a golden crown on His head and a sharp sickle in His hand." The golden crown on His head indicates that the Lord is the One crowned with glory (Heb. 2:9). The sharp sickle in His hand indicates that He is the One who reaps God's field.

C. The harvest being ripe

Verse 15 says, "The harvest of the earth is ripe." To be ripe is to have all the earthly water dried out. The suffering of the great tribulation will be like the parching sun, drying the earthly waters from the believers who will be left on the earth in the great tribulation that they may ripen. Before this time, the harvest will still be green. No farmer would reap a green crop. All the field must ripen. When the field has ripened, the time of the harvest will come.

D. Reaped through the sickle

In verse 15 an angel says, "Send forth Your sickle and reap," and verse 16 says, "He who sat on the cloud thrust His sickle over the earth, and the earth was reaped." The sickle in these verses signifies the angels sent by the Lord to reap the harvest (Matt. 13:39). At the time of His coming, the Lord Jesus will send His angels to take the believers out of the field.

E. Rapture at the sounding of the seventh trumpet

The harvest will be raptured at the sounding of the seventh trumpet, the last trumpet (1 Cor. 15:51-52; 1 Thes. 4:15-17). The sounding of the seventh trumpet will last throughout eternity. This rapture will transpire near the beginning of this trumpet.

After hearing about the earlier overcomers and about the later, quicker overcomers, you may think that all the believers will be overcomers, and you may wonder who will be included in the harvest. Recently I heard that in the United States there are fifty million regenerated Christians. Thus in the United States alone there will be tens of millions for the Lord Jesus to reap.

It is not easy to understand the Bible. Do you believe that the whole earth, including Asia, Africa, North America, South America, Australasia, and Europe, will be under the rule of Antichrist? No, that certainly will not be the situation. Antichrist will be the Caesar of the Roman Empire, and the Roman Empire does not encompass the whole earth. It will probably include the greater part of western Europe and possibly a part of North Africa and eastern Asia. Surely Russia will not be under the rule of the Roman Empire; neither will Australasia, China, India, or the United States.

I am burdened to share with you some matters for which, strictly speaking, I can find no ground in the Bible. Although I do not like to say anything without having biblical ground, there are some things in my heart which I truly believe are of God, yet which are not mentioned in the Bible. According to biblical prophecy, Antichrist will have dominion over only the territories of Europe, Asia Minor, Palestine, and North Africa. Furthermore, Antichrist will not be a communist. One proof of this is in Revelation 18, which shows that Antichrist's capital, Rome, will be a center of capitalism. The record of that chapter, which even speaks of selling souls, or people, is a record not of communism, but of capitalism. The whole earth is under God's sovereign control. I believe that the United States will be fully preserved by God until the Lord comes back. As I have already mentioned, I believe that the United States will be the wilderness spoken of in Revelation 12. It will be a place of safety and shelter for so many refugees. Out of the tens of millions of Christians in the United States, not many will be overcomers. Certainly they will not be killed by Antichrist, because the United States will not be in Antichrist's territory. Since the United States will be a place of safety and refuge, the Christians in this country will not become the quick overcomers. Instead, they will be in the harvest.

When you hear this, you may wonder how the believers in America will ripen. You may think that because America is a safe place, the Christians here will continue to be loose and sloppy. Suppose you are a Christian living in the United States during the time of the great tribulation. If you are witnessing the fulfillment of the prophecies we have considered in these messages, will you still stubbornly and foolishly refuse to love the Lord? The firstfruit will have been raptured, and the report of this will make headline news. Antichrist will be persecuting the Jews and Christians in Europe. In the light of all this, will you still continue to take the United States as your merry land? Moreover, many European Christians will flee to the United States to escape the persecution of Antichrist. The wings of the great eagle will fly them into the wilderness. Those who do not escape will be martyred and thereby become the quick overcomers. Certainly by that time every Christian on earth will be sobered and stirred to love the Lord. Many who are criticizing us today may then receive the help of our present testimony.

At the end of this age a war will be fought at Armageddon. According to the prophecies relating to this war at Armageddon and according to the present world situation, there will be four sources of military might on earth: one from the north, Russia; another from the east, the land of the rising sun; still another from Europe, the territory of Antichrist; and the last from the United States. Armies from three sources of military power will gather at Armageddon, but the American forces may not be included. The tendency of today's world situation is preparing the way for the war at Armageddon. But America will be a safe place, a wilderness, for God's people.

During the great tribulation Christians will be persecuted, and many will be martyred. But a good number of God's people will flee to the United States and thus will be included in the harvest. The knowledge of fulfilled prophecies and the report of current events will motivate them all to seek the Lord and to love Him intensely. They will all realize that the Lord Jesus will come back in not less than three and a half years. Hence, everyone will grow in life and mature.

Revelation 16:15 says, “Behold, I come as a thief. Blessed is he who watches and keeps his garments, that he may not walk naked and they see his shame.” This word will be spoken close to the pouring out of the seventh bowl. Even at this late date, the Lord will issue a warning that He is coming as a thief. This proves that, even after the rapture of the harvest, which will be before the first six bowls, there will still be some believers on earth. These will be the gleanings (Lev. 23:22). According to the type in Leviticus, there are the firstfruit, the harvest, and a small quantity of the crop left in the field called the gleanings. The events in chapter sixteen take place after the harvest, which is in chapter fourteen. Chapter sixteen tells us that seven bowls will be poured out, mainly upon the kingdom of Antichrist. After the sixth bowl, the Lord will give a warning to the believers still on earth after the harvest to be watchful and to keep their garments. These will be that part of the crop which will still be left on earth after the harvest. Therefore, some Christians will be the firstfruit, the majority will be the harvest, and a small number will be the gleanings.

In order to know the Bible, we must put various portions of the Word together like the pieces of a jigsaw puzzle. When we do this, we see a clear and complete picture. The Bible uses certain symbols to represent nations. For example, Persia is represented by a ram and ancient Greece by a goat. Even the meaning of the Aegean Sea is the sea of goats. Ancient Babylon was symbolized by a lion. Recent archeological discoveries in Babylon have included ancient relics with figures of lions on them. Revelation 12 speaks of a great eagle. Based upon the fact that in the Bible animals are used to symbolize nations, we may ask what nation is symbolized by an eagle. The answer, of course, is the United States. This is no accident. Rather, it surely is God’s sovereign wisdom. In God’s sovereignty the forefathers of this country chose an eagle as the national symbol. Although there is not a verse in the Bible saying that the eagle symbolizes the United States, I believe that, in God’s sovereignty, the eagle in that chapter does refer to this country. This is the reason I believe that the United States will be the wilderness in Revelation 12 and serve as a refuge for God’s escapees.

It is much easier to understand biblical prophecy today than it was fifty years ago. Many years ago I studied the predicted re-formation of the nation of Israel. In 1948 I saw this take place with my own eyes. As we all know, in 1967 the city of Jerusalem was returned to the Jews. Today the world situation is focused on the Middle East. Now I am living in the country of the great eagle. Although there are many sinful things in the United States, nevertheless, with the exception of the nation of Israel, there is no other country that has been formed according to God’s Word. I have a copy of the first Constitution of the United States. It is composed of verses from the book of Exodus. Furthermore, each session of Congress opens with a prayer. I was present for such an opening prayer in 1958. Although that prayer was formal, it was still quite good. Moreover, the words, In God we trust, are engraved upon our coins. In the Bible, all the other nations are symbolized by beasts. But there is one country, the United States, that is symbolized by an eagle, not by a beast.

When we were on chapter eight, we saw that the third part of the earth will be damaged by a series of supernatural calamities (8:7-12). I do not believe that these calamities will affect the United States. The third part of the earth is that region wherein people blaspheme God and oppose Him the most. I mention this because I believe that God will use the United States to preserve His weaker people. How merciful He is!

How happy I am that the Lord has sent His recovery to this country! I believe that local churches will be established in the leading cities of all fifty states. These genuine churches will direct God’s people back to His economy. Firstly, the churches will produce the living firstfruit. Secondly, they will be used to care for the Christians during the great tribulation. Many refugees will flee to the United States. At that time, no one will oppose or criticize the local churches. Rather, many may come to the local churches.

Two matters are sovereign of the Lord. The first is that He has prepared the United States to be a great eagle, and the second is that He has sent His recovery to this country. During the great tribulation Christians certainly will no longer pay attention to the Catholic Church, to the denominations, or to the free groups. Rather, they will say, “There is no time to waste. Let us take God’s way.” God’s way is the local churches. Hallelujah, we are in the local churches! Hallelujah, we are in the United States! We are in the genuine church life and we are in the country of the great eagle. I was deeply saddened by the loss of mainland China. I truly loved the work there. But how I praise the Lord that He has brought me to the country of the great eagle and that I am in the genuine church life here. Praise Him for sending His recovery to this country!

II. The great winepress

Verses 18 and 19 say, “And another angel came out of the altar, having authority over the fire, and he cried with a loud voice to him who had the sharp sickle, saying, Send forth your sharp sickle and gather the clusters of the vine of the earth, for her grapes are fully ripened. And the angel thrust his sickle into the earth and gathered the vine of the earth and cast it into the great winepress of the fury of God.” In the Bible the Jews are likened to the fig tree (Matt. 24:32), the believers to wheat (Matt. 13:25, 30), and the wicked Gentiles to the grapevine (Rev. 14:19), which is a false vine, the counterfeit of the true vine made up of Christ and His members (John 15:1-6). The Lord Jesus said, “I am the true vine,” because the unbelievers are the imitation vine made by Satan.

We have seen that God uses the fig tree to symbolize the nation of Israel. Although the fig tree has no outward blossom, flower, or glory, it is full of nourishing fruit. This is what Israel should be in God’s economy. However, today Israel does not have any fruit. When the Lord Jesus went to Jerusalem the last time, He came to a fig tree. He was hungry and desired nourishment. Because He could receive no nourishment from the fig tree, He cursed it (Mark 11:12-14). That was a shadow of the Lord’s cursing the unfruitful Jewish nation.

In God’s wisdom wheat symbolizes the Christians, the church. Wheat seeds were sown into the earth directly by the Lord Jesus as the Son of Man. Wheat has a very small blossom, but when it is ripe, it is full of grain to produce fine flour for God’s meal offering to satisfy both God and man. Praise the Lord that we Christians are the wheat growing in the field!

A. At the end of the great tribulation

After the wheat has been harvested, the unbelievers, likened in the eyes of God to grapes, will be reaped. This will take place at the end of the great tribulation.

B. The judgment at the valley of Jehoshaphat

The great winepress will be the judgment at the valley of Jehoshaphat (Joel 3:9-16). The third chapter of Joel tells us clearly that the Lord will gather all the armies of the nations to the valley of Jehoshaphat (also called Kidron), which is joined by the valley of Hinnom and which is between Jerusalem and the Mount of Olives. In ancient times people buried unclean things there. King Asa of Judah burned his mother’s idol in that place (1 Kings 15:13). Hence, unclean and idolatrous things were buried in this valley.

C. The war at Armageddon

The great winepress of the fury of God (v. 19) will be the war at Armageddon (16:12-16), where all the worldly forces will be gathered and where the Lord with His army of overcoming saints will fight against them and destroy them (19:11-21; Joel 3:9-13; Isa. 63:1-6). The title Armageddon is composed of two words. The first, ar, means “mount” and the second, Mageddon, is the name of Megiddo, meaning “slaughter.”

We have pointed out that, according to the Bible and according to today’s world situation, armies from three sources will converge at the war of Armageddon. These sources are Europe, Russia, and the East. The sources of Russia and the East can already be identified, but the source from Europe and Asia Minor is not yet settled. The countries in this region are waiting for a strong leader, who may become Antichrist, to appear. I am assured by the study of prophecy that Antichrist will either come from the land of Greece and Macedonia or be of Greek descent. This powerful leader will move in the direction of Egypt, Syria, and Israel, the beautiful land. Due to the vast oil wealth in the Middle East, this area has already become the crucial focus of international relations. Under the Lord’s sovereign arrangement, this may be one of the causes of the war at Armageddon.

Zechariah 14 indicates that when the Lord Jesus comes back, He will set His feet upon the Mount of Olives, causing this mountain to split in half and providing a way for the besieged Jews to escape (Zech. 14:4-5). In Acts 1 we are told that the Lord Jesus, who ascended from the Mount of Olives, will return in the same way that He ascended. This means that He will come back to the Mount of Olives near the valley of Jehoshaphat. The gathering of the worldly forces is likened to the gathering of ripened grapes into the great winepress. When the Lord sees all the worldly armies gathered together at the war of Armageddon, that will be the time for Him to tread the winepress.

D. The grapes being fully ripened

Before the grapes are gathered into the great winepress, they will be fully ripened (v. 18). In order for wheat to ripen, its water content must be dried up. But the ripening of grapes is just the opposite: the grapes must be filled with water. Whether you are wheat or a grape depends upon whether you are dried up or filled with the earthly water. If your ambition is to gain more earthly water, then you are living like the grapes, not like the wheat.

E. The grapes being gathered and cast into the great winepress of the fury of the wrath of God

The grapes will be gathered and cast into the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God (v. 19; 16:12-16). The Lord will gather the evil worldly forces into one place for Him to tread this great winepress. By treading this great winepress, the Lord will destroy the evil worldly forces.

F. Trodden by Christ

The great winepress will be trodden by Christ (Isa. 63:1-6). Verse 20 says, “And the winepress was trodden outside the city, and blood came out of the winepress up to the bridles of the horses for a thousand six hundred stadia.” The city here is the city of Jerusalem, and the horses correspond to those in 19:18. The blood that comes out of the winepress will form a river one thousand six hundred stadia long (about one hundred eighty-two miles). This is the distance from Bozrah (Isa. 63:1) to Megiddo (Rev. 16:16). This river of blood will be so high that it will reach the bridles of the horses. The Hebrew word rendered blood in Isaiah 63:3 means juice. Even the garments of Christ will be stained with this blood. From Bozrah to Megiddo will be a long, bloody river. This treading of the winepress will be the judgment of the Lord Jesus exercised upon Antichrist and all his forces. Armies from the north, the west, and the east will be gathered like ripened grapes into the winepress. This is the clear word of prophecy.

G. The close of the great tribulation and of this age

This treading of the great winepress will close the great tribulation and also complete this age. This is a great matter.

The Late Overcomers and the Seven Bowls

(1)

The late overcomers

I. Having suffered and passed through most of the great tribulation

Revelation 15:2 says, “And I saw as it were a glassy sea mingled with fire, and those who had come off victorious from the beast and from his image and from the number of his name, standing on the glassy sea, having harps of God.” We may call those mentioned here the late overcomers, the believers who pass through most of the great tribulation and who overcome Antichrist and his worship. These are those referred to in Rev. 14:12-13, who will be martyred under the persecution of Antichrist, then resurrected to reign with Christ in the millennium (Rev. 20:4).

II. Having overcome the beast, his image, and the number of his name

The late overcomers will overcome the beast, his image, and the number of his name. Although they are slain by Antichrist, in the eyes of God they are victorious. Because they will overcome at a later time, we speak of them as the late overcomers.

III. Standing on the glassy sea

A. Resurrected from the dead

Verse 2 says that the late overcomers stand on the glassy sea. This firstly signifies that they have been resurrected from the dead.

B. Raptured to the heavens

Secondly, it signifies that the late overcomers have been raptured to the heavens. In 4:6 there were no people standing on the glassy sea, but the late overcomers will stand there after they have been raptured to the heavens.

C. Above God’s fiery judgment

In verse 2 the apostle John “saw as it were a glassy sea mingled with fire.” The fact that the late overcomers stand upon the glassy sea also indicates that they are above all the judgments of God, which have nothing to do with them.

This glassy sea is not of water, but of fire. According to the Bible, God exercises His judgment over the rebellious earth, angels, and mankind first by means of water and then fire. After God judged the rebellious angels and the earth with water, this judging water became the sea. The lake of fire will be the consummation of all the fires used by God to judge the rebellious things. Thus, the two means used by God to exercise judgment, water and fire, will be mingled together, firstly as the glassy sea and finally as the lake of fire. The glassy sea, the precursor of the lake of fire, will develop into the lake of fire.

Since the deluge, God, in accordance with His promise not to judge the earth and living creatures again with water (Gen. 9:15), always exercises His judgment upon man with fire (Gen. 19:24; Lev. 10:2; Num. 11:1; 16:35; Dan. 7:11; Rev. 14:11; 18:8; 19:20; 20:9-10; 21:8). God’s throne of judgment is like the fiery flame out of which a fiery stream issues (Dan. 7:9-10). The flame of God’s judging fire sweeps all negative things in the entire universe into this glassy sea, which eventually becomes the lake of fire (20:14), the aggregate of all God’s fiery judgment.

IV. Having harps of God

The late overcomers will have harps of God. They will not have any earthly musical instruments. God will prepare these harps for them that they might praise Him.

V. Singing the song of Moses and the song of the Lamb

Verse 3 says that the late overcomers “sing the song of Moses, the slave of God, and the song of the Lamb.” The song of Moses recorded in Exodus 15:1-19 praises God for victory over the forces of Pharaoh by His triumphant deliverance through the judging waters of the Red Sea. Moses and the children of Israel sang that song on the shore of the Red Sea. Now these late overcomers sing this song again on the glassy sea, indicating that they are victorious over the power of Antichrist, who is judged by God with the fire of the glassy sea (19:20). The song of Moses indicates God’s triumphant judgment over the enemy of His people, whereas the song of the Lamb indicates Christ’s redemption experienced by God’s people in the presence of their enemy. Thus, the song of Moses praises God for His judgment negatively, and the song of the Lamb praises Him for Christ’s redemption positively. The late overcomers are positioned to stand on the glassy sea because of God’s judgment over the enemy and because of Christ’s redemption of His people. In their praises to God, the late overcomers will declare to the whole universe that they are above God’s judgment on His enemies and that they have participated in the redemption of Christ. Their experience of these two things will become two kinds of songs.

VI. Praising God’s works and His ways

As the late overcomers sing the song of Moses and the song of the Lamb, they will say, “Great and wonderful are Your works, Lord God the Almighty; righteous and true are Your ways, O King of the nations. Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify Your name? For You alone are holy; for all the nations will come and worship before You, for Your righteous acts have been made manifest” (vv. 3-4). Here we see that the late overcomers will praise God’s works and His ways.

A. God’s works being His acts

Many are not able to differentiate God’s works from God’s ways. God’s works are His acts, which are great in manifestation and wonderful in nature. God’s works here mainly refer to His judgment upon Antichrist. All those judgments will be great in manifestation and wonderful in nature.

B. God’s ways being His governing principles

God’s works are His acts, whereas God’s ways are His governing principles. Moses knew God’s ways, but the children of Israel knew only His acts (Psa. 103:7). God’s ways are righteous in His principles and true in His promises. If you know God’s ways, you do not need to wait to see His works. Although His works have not yet come, you know that they will come because you know the governing principles by which God does things. We have pointed out that God’s ways are righteous according to God’s principles. As these martyrs undergo suffering and persecution, they will know that God is righteous and that according to His governing principle of righteousness, He will intervene one day to judge Antichrist and to avenge their blood. Although this judgment has not yet come, the martyrs know God’s principle and praise Him for His ways, for His governing principles in dealing with people. These principles are also true in God’s promises. God promises His people that He will judge the evildoers, vindicate His way, and avenge the blood of His people. Because the overcomers know God’s ways, they are assured that He will do what He has promised.

In verse 4 the overcomers praise God, saying, “For You alone are holy.” The Greek word rendered holy in this verse refers to the sum of the qualities which suit the divine character and form it. Hence, “holy” refers to God’s nature, whereas “righteous” refers to His principles.

VII. Reigning with Christ a thousand years

The late overcomers in Revelation 15 will be included among those who will live and reign with Christ a thousand years (20:4). Revelation 20:6 further indicates that the late overcomers will be with those who have “part in the first resurrection,” those who “shall be priests of God and of Christ and shall reign with Him a thousand years.” The late overcomers will be blessed and holy, and the second death will have no authority over them (20:6). They will be priests of God and of Christ and co-kings with Christ, reigning with Him over the nations in the coming kingdom.

In Revelation 14 and 15 we see God’s wisdom in dealing with various peoples and in caring for His people in different ways. The dead overcomers will be the man-child, the living overcomers will be the firstfruit, and those who are martyred during the great tribulation will be the late overcomers. Most of the believers who pass through the greater part of the great tribulation will be included in the harvest. After the rapture of the harvest, the Lord will still need to gather the gleanings, those who ripen after the harvest and who need more sunshine to burn them into ripeness. Finally, we have seen that the Lord will gather the grapes, the evildoers, into the winepress at the end of the great tribulation and will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God.

The seven bowls

(1)

Now we come to the seven bowls (Rev. 16:1-21).

I. The last seven plagues

In 8:13 an eagle flying in mid-heaven says, “Woe, woe, woe, to those who dwell on the earth because of the remaining sounds of the trumpet of the three angels who are about to trumpet.” The three woes of the last three trumpets (Rev. 9:12; 11:14) will be the woes of the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21). The first woe is the fifth trumpet in chapter nine, and the second woe is the sixth trumpet, also in chapter nine. The third woe (Rev. 11:14), part of the negative contents of the seventh trumpet, is the seven bowls. These seven bowls are the last seven plagues (Rev. 15:1). The sixth seal plus the first four trumpets of the seventh seal may be considered as a preliminary to the great tribulation, but the great tribulation itself is composed of the fifth trumpet, the sixth trumpet, and part of the negative contents of the seventh trumpet.

II. The scene in heaven before the outpouring of the seven bowls

The scene in heaven is revealed before the seven seals, again before the seven trumpets, and again before the seven bowls. Prior to the opening of the seven seals, we have the scene portrayed in chapters four and five. In this scene we see a throne set in heaven, One sitting on the throne, a rainbow around the throne, twenty-four elders sitting on twenty-four thrones, four living creatures, and the worthy Lion-Lamb (Rev. 4:2-8; 5:5-6). This scene indicates that God on the throne is administering His economy through the worthy Lion-Lamb, the One who is qualified to open God’s hidden economy. The throne of God’s administration in this scene is primarily for judgment.

In Rev. 8:3-5 we have the scene in heaven prior to the sounding of the seven trumpets. In this scene all heaven becomes silent for about half an hour (Rev. 8:1). Here Christ as another Angel comes to minister as the High Priest to God by bringing the prayers of the saints to God and by adding incense to them that these prayers might be acceptable to Him. Through His incense, the saints’ prayers become a sweet savor to God and bring in His judgment upon the earth. This scene reveals that God is about to answer the saints’ prayers, offered by Christ and with Christ, by the judgments of the seven trumpets.

In Rev. 15:5-8 we have the scene in heaven before the outpouring of the seven bowls. By this time many things have transpired: the sixth seal, the first six trumpets, and even a portion of the seventh trumpet. Now is the time for the fury of God to be finished (Rev. 15:1). The fury of God mentioned in Rev. 15:1, 7 and Rev. 16:1 indicates that God is angry with His enemy, especially with Antichrist and his kingdom. Although God has executed a great portion of His judgment and has accomplished nearly everything He must do, His fury has not yet been exhausted. The fury of His wrath remains to be poured out. Before this takes place, however, another scene in heaven is revealed. Now we need to consider the aspects of this scene.

A. The temple being opened

Revelation 15:5 says, “And after these things I saw, and the temple of the tabernacle of the testimony in heaven was opened.” It is somewhat difficult to understand the phrase “the temple of the tabernacle of the testimony” because historically the tabernacle preceded the temple and was replaced by it. Actually, the tabernacle and the temple are one. The Greek word for temple, naos, does not mean the general temple, but the inner temple, the Holy of Holies. Hence, the temple of the tabernacle means the Holy of Holies of the tabernacle. The tabernacle in the Old Testament was composed of the Holy Place and the inner part, the Holy of Holies. The temple in this verse is the inner part of the temple, the Holy of Holies, where the ark is. The testimony is the law of God which testifies God and which was put into the ark (Exo. 25:16). Because the ark was put in the tabernacle, the tabernacle was called the tabernacle of the testimony. Here we see that the temple of the tabernacle of the testimony in heaven was opened. It is no longer hidden, but unveiled for all the universe to see.

Verse 5 is the continuation of 11:19 and must be understood in relation to it. Revelation 11:19 says, “And the temple of God which is in heaven was opened, and the ark of His covenant was seen in His temple.” The throne with the rainbow in 4:2-3 is the center of all the judgment executed over the earth in chapters six through eleven, on the negative side; whereas the temple with the ark is the center of all God’s accomplishments in the universe carried out in chapters twelve through twenty-two, on the positive side. Hence, in the first section of the book of Revelation, chapters one through eleven, the center of the revelation is the throne with the rainbow. In the second section, chapters twelve through twenty-two, the center of the revelation is no longer the throne with the rainbow, but the temple with the ark.

The throne with the rainbow is mainly for God’s judgment on the earth, but the temple with the ark is mainly for God’s building to express Himself. In other words, the temple and the ark are for God’s testimony.

God’s testimony is God’s expression of Himself through His building. At the end of chapter eleven there is a great earthquake, probably the greatest earthquake in history. But at the end of the second section there is the New Jerusalem, which is God’s building, God’s expression, and God’s testimony. The entire New Jerusalem is the Holy of Holies. This city will be a cube twelve thousand stadia (approximately thirteen hundred miles, about the distance from Los Angeles to Dallas) in length, width, and height (21:16). This is the enlarged temple, the issue of the last eleven chapters of the book of Revelation. The first eleven chapters consummate with a great earthquake, and the last eleven chapters consummate with the New Jerusalem. What a contrast!

The earthquake at the end of chapter eleven comes from the throne with the rainbow. Although God will cause this tremendous earthquake, He will not destroy all mankind. Rather, the rainbow encompassing the throne reminds Him of His covenant. This rainbow is Christ. In 10:1 we are told that another strong Angel, who is Christ, will come down out of heaven clothed with a cloud and with a rainbow upon His head. Christ is the universal rainbow. As God in His fury is carrying out His judgment upon rebellious mankind, Christ in the cloud will be the rainbow to remind God of His covenant with Noah. It seems that, as the rainbow, the Lord Jesus will say, “God, I agree with Your righteous fury, but I remind You of Your faithfulness. You cannot forget the covenant You made with Noah. I am the rainbow in the cloud.” Eventually, God’s judgment, carried out with the remembrance of the rainbow, will spare those who become the “sheep” of Matthew 25, who will be the nations in the millennial kingdom. If it were not for this rainbow, none would survive to be the nations in the coming kingdom.

The temple with the ark is God’s expression with God’s Christ. The temple is God’s dwelling, God’s expression, and the ark is Christ as God’s testimony. Because the last eleven chapters of Revelation are for God’s expression and His Christ, the center of this section is God’s temple and God’s ark. Ultimately, the New Jerusalem will be the enlarged temple, and in it will be the ark, Christ, as the Lamb. Therefore, as the issue of God’s acts in chapters twelve through twenty-two, we see the eternal temple with the eternal ark.

In order to know the book of Revelation, we must have such an all-inclusive view. Only by having this view do we know where we are. The woman and the man-child are necessary for God’s temple and God’s ark. The bright woman is for the New Jerusalem. Eventually, that city will be the woman, for, as a city-woman, she will be the wife of the Lamb (21:9-10).

God will also use the dragon negatively to accomplish His purpose. When He has no further use for Satan, He will be ready to say, “Satan, go to the lake of fire.” God is great and He is sovereign. This book reveals that Satan is wholly in the hands of God. Do not think that it is unfair of God to use Satan. God is more fair, much fairer than you are. Who can presume to argue with Him? In Romans 9:20 and 21 Paul said, “But, O man, who are you that replies against God? Shall the thing formed say to him who formed it, Why did you make me thus? Or has not the potter authority over the clay, out of the same lump to make one vessel to honor and another to dishonor?” If you would dare to argue with God, He might reply, “I am the Maker, and you are the clay. Don’t you know that I have the authority to make anything I please? I have the power to make of you anything I want. Who are you to argue with Me?” God is sovereign. After reading the book of Revelation again and again, I can only say, “O God, I worship You for Your sovereignty. I worship You that You have chosen me to be one of Your children and even to be one of Your servants.” Oh, how we all must worship Him!

B. Seven angels coming out of the temple

Verse 6 says, “And the seven angels who had the seven plagues came out of the temple, clothed in pure bright linen, and girded around the breasts with golden girdles.” The seven angels are clothed like priests (Ezek. 44:17), not like soldiers. According to my opinion, the angels who are to pour out the seven bowls should be clothed in military uniforms. The fact that they are clothed in priests’ garments is very significant. This indicates that the outpouring of the seven bowls by the seven angels is the response to the praises of the late overcomers on the glassy sea mingled with fire. The late overcomers standing on the glassy sea will worship God with their praises. At that time, prayer will be over and praise will have begun. In the fifth seal we saw the cry, the prayer, of the martyred saints (6:9-11). But there is no cry or prayer in chapter fifteen; instead, there are praises. The late overcomers do not pray, saying, “O Lord, Antichrist has persecuted and martyred us. Now, You must come in to avenge our blood and to destroy his kingdom.” Instead of praying in this way, the late overcomers praise God. Immediately after the record of their praises, there is the unveiling of the scene in heaven before the outpouring of the seven bowls. Out of the temple of the tabernacle of the testimony in heaven come the seven angels with the seven plagues. These angels are not dressed as soldiers, but as priests who come to fulfill their ministry. It is no longer merely a matter of judgment, for here judgment is mingled with the accomplishment of God’s economy so that God may have His expression.

At this point we need to pay close attention to 16:17. This verse says, “And the seventh poured out his bowl upon the air; and a loud voice came out of the temple from the throne, saying, It is done.” Notice that in this verse two things are mingled — the temple and the throne. It is difficult to understand the grammatical construction of this verse. What does it mean to say that a voice came “out of the temple from the throne”? We have seen that God’s acts in the first section of this book come out of the throne and that His acts in the second section proceed from the temple. The book of Revelation firstly shows that the center of God’s judgment is the throne and then that the center of God’s testimony is the temple. In this verse the throne and the temple are combined. Now God’s judgment is mingled with God’s expression, with God’s testimony. In other words, God’s testimony comes out of God’s judgment, and God’s judgment is for God’s testimony. The temple comes out of the throne, and the throne is for the temple.

This principle is applicable to us today. If we would be for God’s temple, God’s expression, we must be judged. The central principle of the first eleven chapters of Revelation must be applied in our daily life, in our public life, and in our church life. How many things in us still need to be judged! There are many “scorpions,” “snakes,” and “frogs” in our lives. Many “scorpions” are still creeping in our family life and married life, and some “frogs” are still plaguing the church life. All these “scorpions” and “frogs” must be judged. The issue of this judgment will be the testimony “out of the temple from the throne.”

We have pointed out that the seven angels with the seven bowls are not soldiers, but priests, and that their outpouring of the seven bowls is in response to the praising of the late overcomers. God responds to the praising of the late overcomers, not just from the throne, but also from within the temple. This means that God’s answer is not merely for judgment, but even the more for His testimony and for His expression, His temple. Because the seven angels with the seven bowls are not merely for God’s judgment, but especially for God’s testimony, they come out of the temple. They do not proceed just from the throne of judgment, but also out of the temple for God’s expression. After the last bowl has been poured out, every negative thing will have been eradicated. Immediately after that, the Bride appears (19:7-9).

Chapter nineteen is the continuation of chapter sixteen. Chapters seventeen and eighteen are inserted to give further details regarding the two aspects of Babylon, religious Babylon and material Babylon. However, chapter nineteen is the actual continuation of the outpouring of the bowls in chapter sixteen. This is a further indication that the seven bowls are not simply for judgment from the throne, but even the more for God’s testimony out of His temple. This is the meaning of the phrase “out of the temple from the throne.”

C. Seven golden bowls given to the seven angels

Verse 7 says, “And one of the four living creatures gave to the seven angels seven golden bowls full of the fury of God, who lives forever and ever.” The seven bowls given by one of the four living creatures are full of the fury of God. The bowls, being small, signify limitation. Although the last seven plagues are the ultimate fury of God, His fury is nonetheless limited; otherwise, the entire earth and all its inhabitants would be destroyed. For the fulfillment of His eternal purpose, God still exercises limitations in His ultimate fury in judgment upon the earth. This outpouring of God’s wrath is extremely serious, but it is still limited. God is merciful. The beast, his citizens, and his entire kingdom deserve to be utterly destroyed without limitation, but God still limits the outpouring of His wrath to a small scale. Thank the Lord for this!

D. The temple being filled with the smoke from God’s glory and power

Verse 8 says, “And the temple was filled with smoke from the glory of God and from His power, and no one could enter into the temple until the seven plagues of the seven angels should be finished.” This means that no one can enter the temple to pray to appease the fury of God until it is fully poured out upon the rebellious people instigated by Satan and influenced by Antichrist.

The Seven Bowls

(2)

Before we consider the outpouring of the seven bowls, I want to say a further word concerning God on the throne and God in the temple. Most Christians, including many of us in the Lord's recovery, know God only as the God on the throne. They know little of God as the God in the temple. It is rather easy to know God as the One on the throne because this fits our natural concept. However, in order to know God as the God in the temple, we must have a heavenly vision.

In the Bible God is firstly revealed as God on the throne. Throughout the Old Testament, God's people gradually realized that God is the mighty One on the throne. God's throne is for His dominion. Eventually, the revelation in the Bible leads us from the throne of God's government to the temple of God's expression. In the Old Testament we see God in His temple. In the New Testament we also see God in His house, His temple, the church. Ultimately, in the consummation of the Bible, the book of Revelation, the throne and the temple are combined (Rev. 16:17). In Revelation we see God on the throne in the New Jerusalem (Rev. 22:1).

Most Christians today know God only as the God on the throne. In their prayers and praises they are conscious of God as the One sitting on His throne. They are assured that even if the world were flooded with water, God would still be on the throne. Although we have often heard prayers directed to God on the throne and although we have hymns concerning God's being on the throne, it is difficult to find a hymn saying that God is not only on the throne, but also in the temple. Few Christians have the vision of God as the One in the temple.

God is on the throne for His administration, but He is in the temple for His expression. God's eternal purpose is not to be on the throne — it is to be in the temple. Because the throne of God has been eternally established, existing from eternity to eternity (Psa. 45:6), there is no need for it to be built. However, God's temple requires a great deal of building work. God's desire is not simply to be on the throne. He has been on the throne since eternity past. God desires a temple, an expression. Although every Christian knows that God is the mighty One on the throne, not many Christians realize that God today needs a temple, a church, a building, for His expression. Thus, in this country we have been sounding the trumpet about this matter for more than fourteen years. However, even among us, not many in their praises speak of God's being in His temple. Rather, they praise God as the One on the throne. Have you ever praised God in the way of recognizing His desire to have the temple?

To repeat, the whole Bible firstly reveals God as the One on the throne. Gradually it reveals God's desire to have a temple. The ultimate and consummate temple will be the New Jerusalem. As we have pointed out, the New Jerusalem will not only be God's temple; it will also be the Holy of Holies. For eternity in the New Jerusalem, God will be in the Lamb on the throne. He will be the God on the throne in His temple, having His dominion with His full expression for eternity. Everything God is doing today is for this. This is the reason we say that we are not merely for individual salvation, but for corporate church building. Again I say that God's intention is to have this temple. God's throne is for His temple; that is, His administration is for His expression. Ultimately, in the New Jerusalem the river of water of life will flow from God's throne to supply the entire city. Therefore, the New Jerusalem will be the consummation of God flowing from the throne.

III. The outpouring of seven bowls

A. The first bowl

Revelation 16:2 says, "And the first went and poured out his bowl into the earth; and there came an evil and malignant sore upon the men who have the mark of the beast and worship his image." In His last fury God will mark the rebellious ones with a sore on their skin because they bear the mark of the beast. This mark will be like a malignant cancer. At that time God may seem to say, "Because you bear the mark of My enemy, the beast, I shall put a mark on you." I do not believe that this sore will come upon the Americans, but on the citizens of the Roman Empire under Antichrist, who bear the name of Antichrist or the number of his name.

B. The second bowl

Verse 3 says, "And the second poured out his bowl into the sea, and it became blood like that of a dead man; and every living soul that was in the sea died." I do not believe that this will include all the seas. Probably it will mainly affect the Mediterranean Sea, the sea enclosed by Antichrist's empire.

C. The third bowl

In verses 4 through 7 we have the outpouring of the third bowl. Verse 4 says, "And the third poured out his bowl into the rivers and the springs of waters; and they became blood." Verse 5 speaks of "the angel of the waters." In God's administration, an angel has been appointed to control the waters. This angel praises God, saying, "You are righteous, who is and who was, the holy One, because You have judged these; for they poured out the blood of saints and prophets, and You have given them blood to drink; they deserve it" (vv. 5-6). Both here and in 11:17 it does not say, "Who is coming," as in 1:8 and 4:8. This proves that the Lord's coming back must follow 4:8 and precede 11:17.

Not everyone dwelling on earth will deserve to be given blood to drink, for not all of them have poured out the blood of the saints. If Americans are those who pour out the blood of the saints, then they deserve to drink blood. I am assured, however, that such a thing will not take place in America. I believe that it will be mainly in the territory of Antichrist that the waters will turn into blood.

Before we go on, I need to insert a word regarding the extent of Antichrist's empire. Luke 2:1 is helpful in this matter. This verse says that a decree went out from Caesar Augustus "for all the inhabited earth to be enrolled." Certainly "all the inhabited earth" did not include ancient China; neither did it include America, which at the time was inhabited only by Indians. We must understand the Bible with its background and the circumstances in which it was written. According to the background, "all the inhabited earth" in Luke 2:1 refers to the world of the Roman Empire. Do not take this to mean every place on the whole earth. The earth-dwellers who will be punished by the seven bowls are mainly those who reside in the territory of Antichrist.

Verse 7 says, "And I heard the altar saying, Yes, Lord God the Almighty, true and righteous are Your judgments." This is the praise from the altar concerning God's judgments over Antichrist's territory, which are true in nature and righteous in principle.

D. The fourth bowl

Verses 8 and 9 say, "And the fourth poured out his bowl upon the sun; and it was given to it to burn men with fire. And the men were burned with great heat, and they blasphemed the name of God, who has the authority over these plagues, and they did not repent to give Him glory." The men who are burned with great heat, who blaspheme the name of God, and who refuse to repent must be mainly the citizens of the Roman Empire who follow Antichrist to persecute God's people and to rebel against God.

E. The fifth bowl

Verses 10 and 11 say, “And the fifth poured out his bowl on the throne of the beast; and his kingdom became darkened; and they gnawed their tongues for pain, and they blasphemed the God of heaven for their pains and for their sores; and they did not repent of their works.” Here we read that the fifth bowl is poured out upon the throne of the beast. This indicates that the seven bowls are for judging the beast, his kingdom, and his territory. This can be compared to God’s deeds through Moses upon Pharaoh and Egypt. When the land of Egypt was darkened, the whole earth was not darkened. The darkening of the kingdom of the beast will be exactly the same as the darkening of Egypt. Those in the kingdom of Antichrist will gnaw their tongues, blaspheme God, and refuse to repent.

F. The sixth bowl

Verse 12 continues, “And the sixth poured out his bowl upon the great river Euphrates; and its water was dried up, that the way of the kings from the rising of the sun might be prepared.” The plague of the second bowl is more severe than that of the second trumpet (8:8-9); the plague of the third bowl, more than that of the third trumpet (8:10-11); the plague of the fourth bowl, more than that of the fourth trumpet (8:12). The plague of the fifth bowl, the judgment upon the throne of Antichrist and his kingdom, is related to the fifth trumpet, in which Antichrist is the king of the demonic locusts tormenting men (9:3-11); and the plague of the sixth bowl is related to the sixth trumpet (9:14), because the plagues of both are related to the same river, the Euphrates. In 9:14 and 15 we read that the four angels bound at the great river Euphrates will be loosed to stir up the kings to send their armies, and in 16:12 we are told that at the outpouring of the sixth bowl the water of the Euphrates will be dried up that these kings and their armies may pass over it. Hence, the sixth trumpet and the sixth bowl are related to each other.

G. A vision inserted between the sixth and seventh bowls

Verses 13 through 16 are a vision inserted between the sixth and seventh bowls. This vision is of the gathering at Armageddon.

1. Three Unclean spirits like frogs out of the mouths of the dragon, the beast, and the false prophet

Verses 13 and 14 say, “And I saw, out of the mouth of the dragon and out of the mouth of the beast and out of the mouth of the false prophet, three unclean spirits like frogs; for they are spirits of demons, doing signs, which go forth to the kings of the whole inhabited earth, to gather them to the war of the great day of God the Almighty.” These unclean spirits are like frogs. As spirits, they should be in the heavenlies, but as frogs they can only move about on the earth. At that time Satan and his power to act will be limited to the earth. He will no longer have the right to maneuver in the air. Hence, the spirits that follow him will be like frogs.

By means of the signs they perform, these spirits of demons will gather together the kings of the inhabited earth for war. According to verse 16, “They gathered them to the place which in Hebrew is called, Armageddon.” At the end of the great tribulation, three unclean spirits out of the mouths of Satan, Antichrist, and the false prophet, will go forth to stir up the rulers of the whole inhabited earth and gather their forces, including the two hundred million cavalry mentioned in Rev. 9:14-16, to the war at Armageddon, which will be the last war among mankind before the millennium. In that war Satan’s intention will be to destroy Israel (Zech. 14:12) and to fight against Christ and His army. For this he will use all rebellious mankind (Rev. 17:12-14; Rev. 19:11-19). Christ and His chosen overcomers will defeat and destroy them all (Rev. 19:20-21; Zech. 14:3, 12-15; 12:4, 9) and save the nation of Israel (Zech. 12:3-8; 14:4-5; Joel 3:14-17). This is the treading of the winepress recorded in Rev. 14:17-20, Isa. 63:1-6, and Joel 3:9-14.

Armies from the west (Roman Empire), the north (Russia), and the east (“the rising of the sun”) will be gathered at Armageddon. Ezekiel 38 and 39 prove that Russia, called Gog and Magog, will be there. Revelation 9 also indicates that two hundred million cavalry troops from the east will be there. Although armies from the west, the north, and the east will gather at Armageddon, there is no hint that the armies from the United States will be there. God has sovereignly arranged for the United States to be one of the few countries that are pro-Israel. If it were not for God’s sovereignty, how could Israel, a country surrounded by hostile nations, be able to survive? Although all the worldly forces will be prepared to damage the little nation of Israel, the United States will not be included. Again, I ask you not to understand the Bible in a natural way, but in the way of enlightenment, with insight into the Word and into today’s world situation.

2. The Lord’s warning

Between the sixth and seventh bowls, the Lord issues a warning regarding His coming. Verse 15 says, “Behold, I come as a thief. Blessed is he who watches and keeps his garments, that he may not walk naked and they see his shame.” According to the context, this word is spoken by the Lord at the end of the great tribulation before the war at Armageddon. This proves that at that time there will still be some believers, the gleanings, left on the earth. To them the appearing of the Lord in His coming back will still be as a thief, in an hour unknown to them. This is a strong proof that even after the harvest there will still be believers on earth.

H. The seventh bowl

When the seventh bowl is poured out upon the air, a loud voice “out of the temple from the throne” will say, “It is done” (v. 17). This means that everything both for judgment and for God’s expression, God’s testimony, has been accomplished. Immediately after this word is spoken, there will be lightnings, voices, thunders, and the greatest earthquake that the world has ever seen (v. 18). This earthquake, the same as the one in 11:19, will cause the great city, Jerusalem, to be divided into three parts and the cities of the nations to fall (v. 19). Because Jerusalem will have become as evil as ancient Sodom, God will judge it by means of this earthquake.

Verse 19 also says, “And Babylon the great was remembered before God to give her the cup of the wine of the fury of His wrath.” The religious, mysterious Babylon in 14:8 is destroyed at the beginning of the great tribulation; therefore, Babylon the great here, which will be destroyed after, at, or before the war at Armageddon at the end of the great tribulation, must be the material Babylon, the city of Rome. The Babylon in 14:8 corresponds to that in chapter seventeen, while the Babylon in this verse corresponds to that in chapter eighteen. The sketches of the two Babylons are recorded in 14:8 and 16:19, the details are given in chapters seventeen and eighteen.

Verse 19 says that God will give her “the cup of the wine of the fury of His wrath.” Rome gave the wine of the fury of her fornication to the faithful saints among the nations (18:3). Now God in vengeance gives her the wine of the fury of His wrath.

Verse 20 says, “Every island fled, and mountains were not found.” Verse 21 concludes by saying, “And great hail, every stone about the weight of a talent [approximately one hundred pounds], comes down out of heaven upon men; and men blasphemed God because of the plague of the hail, for the plague of it is exceeding great.” Once again I say that this hail will not come down upon the people in America, but mainly upon the citizens of the empire of the beast. In the midst of the downpour of this great hail, those in the empire of Antichrist will continue to blaspheme God. This proves that they have no intention to repent. Rather, they will fight against God to the end.

The Great Prostitute Sitting on a Scarlet Beast

(1)

In this message we come to Rev. 17, where we see a woman sitting on a scarlet beast (v. 3). It is important that we all have a clear understanding of what is revealed here.

One of the seven angels who had the seven bowls spoke to the apostle John, saying, “Come here, I will show you the judgment of the great prostitute who sits on many waters” (17:1). In verse 3 the apostle John says, “And he carried me away in spirit into a wilderness; and I saw a woman sitting on a scarlet beast, full of names of blasphemy, having seven heads and ten horns.” Verse 1 speaks of the great prostitute, and verse 3 speaks of a woman. As the prostitute riding on a scarlet beast, this woman has power and authority. This beast, the same as that described in chapter thirteen, has seven heads and ten horns. All Bible students agree that the beast here refers to both the Roman Empire and to Antichrist, the last Caesar of the revived Roman Empire. However, there has been debate concerning the identity of the woman, the prostitute.

I. The great prostitute

Who is this great prostitute sitting on many waters? Before we answer this question, we need to say a word about the woman. According to verse 18, the woman is the great city, the city of Rome, which was built on seven mountains signified by the seven heads of the beast (v. 9). Although the woman is Rome, the prostitute cannot also be Rome, because the beast will eventually hate the prostitute, make her desolate, and burn her with fire (v. 16). Antichrist, the last Caesar of the Roman Empire, will certainly not burn his own capital. Therefore, that which is burned by the beast must not be the city of Rome, but something else. Now we must ask this question: According to the Bible and according to world history, who is the prostitute riding on the Roman Empire? Who is the one so intimately related to the Roman state? The prostitute is so closely related to the city of Rome that the two are almost identical. In verse 1 the angel called her the prostitute, and in verse 18 he called her a woman. The prostitute is the apostate Roman Catholic Church. History reveals that only one figure, one character, matches the description of the female in this chapter, and that figure is the Roman Catholic Church. A prostitute does not have a husband. This indicates that God has never admitted having any relationship with the apostate Roman Church.

In message thirteen of this life-study I gave a strong word concerning the Roman Catholic Church based upon this chapter. According to the Scriptures, the great prostitute in this chapter is the Roman Catholic Church. If the female in Revelation 17 is not the Roman Catholic Church, then who is she? Surely, according to history, only the Roman Catholic Church fits the description of the woman given here.

Eighteen years ago I spent some days in Rome for the specific purpose of seeing the Vatican. In order to have a full view of that apostate thing, I took eight tours. The more I saw, the more I was convinced that the Roman Catholic Church is the great prostitute in Revelation 17, about which I had studied years before. Revelation 17:4 says, “The woman was clothed in purple and scarlet.” The color red abounds in Catholicism. The cardinals, for example, are clothed in red robes. When many Catholics hear that the Roman Church is the great prostitute, they will be offended and not be able to believe it. Some may say, “How can you say that the Catholic Church is the great prostitute? Don’t we worship God and believe in Jesus? Don’t we also have the Scriptures?” The answer is in verse 4 of this chapter.

Notice that verse 4 says that the woman has in her hand “a golden cup full of abominations and the unclean things of her fornication.” In typology gold signifies the divine nature. Although this woman is called the great prostitute, she holds a golden cup signifying the nature of God. This gold, however, is merely the outward appearance of the cup, not its contents. Outwardly, it appears to be divine, but inwardly it is filled with abominations and uncleanness. Although the apostate Roman Catholic Church does have certain holy things, it adds filthy things to them. Consider, for example, the worship of Mary. The Mary in the Roman Catholic Church is actually the goddess Venus. Catholicism has absorbed from paganism the demonic legend of Venus. In his book, *The Great Prophecies*, G. H. Pember points out that even Buddha, under the name of Saint Josaphat, has entered into Catholicism. In the Catholic calendar there is a saint named Josaphat, whose story is actually that of Buddha. Babylonianism entered into Buddhism, and Buddhism, a further development of Babylonianism, was assimilated into Catholicism. Let us now read in full the relevant paragraph from *The Great Prophecies* (p. 104) by Pember:

In less than a century after the death of Belshazzar, a new...faith was spreading in India, the Buddhist religion, which is but a slightly changed Babylonianism....Indeed...Buddha himself is actually a saint in the Roman Catholic Calendar under the name of Saint Josaphat. For the story of Josaphat and Barlaam, which first appears in the works of John of Damascus, a theologian of the early part of the eighth century, and became extremely popular in the Middle Ages, has now been certainly identified with that of Buddha.

Thus, the story of Buddha was taken into Catholicism. This is one example of the assimilation of paganism into the Roman Catholic Church.

Another example is Christmas. Christmas is a blasphemy to Christ, and no Christian with a pure conscience should have anything to do with it. As the book, *The Two Babylons*, proves, Christmas originated from European paganism. Centuries before the Christian era, on December 25 the European pagans celebrated the birthday of the sun. When Constantine embraced Christianity, he encouraged the Roman citizens to become Christians, and he even rewarded many thousands for being baptized. Thousands who knew nothing of Christ were baptized and came into Christendom, bringing their pagan customs with them. Later, the name of Christ was attached to the birth of the sun god celebrated on December 25. In principle, the celebration of Easter is the same. Although some Christians in Orange County condemn us as heretical, they themselves still practice the pagan festival of Christmas. To be sure, during the three and a half years of the great tribulation all Christians will abandon such things as Christmas, Easter, the worship of Mary, and all paganism.

In message forty-eight I shared with you my belief that the United States is the nation of the eagle and that in the coming years the local churches will exert a positive influence among Christians. I further believe that the Lord’s recovery will spread to the leading cities throughout the world. Already there are some churches in Europe and at least seventeen churches in Brazil. Moreover, there are churches in Ghana, Nigeria, Australia, New Zealand, and many throughout all the countries in the Far East, including Taiwan, Hong Kong, Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore, Thailand, Korea, Japan, and the Philippines. The Lord’s recovery is spreading. In many leading cities the local church stands as a testimony to both believers and unbelievers. We must sound our trumpet and testify of Christ and the Body. Eventually, all the Christians in the world will be influenced. Presently, some argue with us, fight against us, and oppose us. But the day is coming when every mouth will be shut, for all we have been ministering will be fulfilled. The overcomers will be raptured, and Antichrist will be manifested. Furthermore, the Roman Catholic Church will be utterly burned and destroyed. As Antichrist and the ten horns are destroying the Vatican, do you think that people in the United States will still attend the Catholic Church? Certainly not! By that time many genuine Christians in Catholicism will turn to the way of the Lord’s recovery.

I strongly believe that the Lord is using His recovery to produce the living firstfruit. This is the first function of the Lord’s recovery. After the rapture of the firstfruit, the local churches will be used by the Lord to help all the remaining Christians. This will be the second function of the recovery. During the great tribulation, Christians will have a proper place to which they can go. Christmas, Easter, and all the traditional things of Christianity will be discarded. There will be no more arguments, all the divisive names of the daughters of the great prostitute will be abandoned, and the Lord will absolutely vindicate His way of the church.

No one can deny that there is something real in the Roman Catholic Church. She holds a golden cup in her hand, and she is gilded with gold, precious stone, and pearls (v. 4), the same materials with which the New Jerusalem is built. The outward appearance of the great prostitute and the New Jerusalem is similar. But there is a vast difference inwardly: the prostitute is filled with abominations, uncleanness, and spiritual fornication. This is the actual situation, and we need insight in order to perceive it. It is not a small thing for me to say these things. Oh, how we all need to have a clear view!

The more I have been with the Lord regarding this matter, the more burdened I have become to sound the trumpet so that the Lord’s recovery with the proper church life may spread throughout the world. Here and there, in all the leading cities, there needs to be a lamptstand shining in the dark night. If not today, then at least during the years of the great tribulation, whoever loves the Lord with a pure heart and seeks Him in sincerity will see this light. By that time a lamptstand will be shining brightly in every leading city. The rapture of the firstfruit will cause the local churches to shine more brightly than they do today. Suppose fifty-five brothers and sisters in the church in Anaheim were raptured first. Certainly all the remainder would be stirred up and seek the Lord desperately. This will take place throughout the world. When Christians begin to see prophecies fulfilled in front of their eyes, they will no longer care for the confusing divisions, the religious traditions, or all the sinful and worldly things. Rather, they will flee to the proper and pure church life. I am fully assured that this will take place.

We are not dealing with an insignificant matter, but with a matter that is very crucial for the coming age. We do not care for men’s arguments and opposition. The more they argue and oppose, the more our ministry is confirmed. Many times, after saying something uncomplimentary about Christianity in a message, I wondered why I was so strong, and I resolved to be a little softer. Nevertheless, what I say in the ministry is not my decision. It does not depend on me — it depends on the speaking Spirit. If in my ministry I do not speak boldly regarding Christianity, I have no peace, and I lose the anointing. If I fail to do this, my ministry will be weakened. When I do speak out, the opposition is aroused. But I am confirmed even by the opposition. The deeds and reactions of the opposers fully expose them. I am burdened that we would be enlightened, see through all the veils, and enter into the inner chamber to perceive the reality of today’s situation in Christianity.

It is not a matter of the doctrine of the Trinity or of the teaching concerning the local church. It is absolutely a matter of Babylon. To call a pastor “reverend” — that is Babylonian. To set up a Christmas tree and to honor Santa Claus — that is Babylonian. To call yourself by a denominational name, such as Lutheran, Methodist, or Episcopalian — that is Babylonian. All denominational names are Babylonian factors of division and confusion. When Christians see the destruction of the great prostitute at the hands of Antichrist, they will be convinced about the church. Then they will see what the church is and where the church is. They will realize that the church has nothing to do with anything Babylonian. Any group that still practices Babylonian things or holds them is not the pure church.

You must beware of divisions because divisions are another form of Babylonianism. It was at Babel, which means confusion, that the language of mankind was confused and confounded. Babel is the Hebrew term for Babylon. Anything divisive causes confusion, and confusion denotes Babylonianism. Today there are hundreds of free groups; they are everywhere. But what they are practicing is divisive and confusing; hence, it is Babylonian.

In 1957 a dear brother who was considered spiritual and as one having a rich ministry was invited to Taiwan. As the result of his visit, some young people, all of whom had been under my training, were influenced to care only for so-called spirituality, not for the practicality of the church. Eventually, they divided among themselves again and again, and the result was Babylonian confusion.

In the United States some have stayed for a while in the Lord’s recovery and have learned the practice of the church life. Then they went out on their own to set up an independent work for themselves. This also has caused divisions resulting in Babylonian confusion. Today some read Brother Nee’s books and learn what they think is the way to practice the local church. If they meant business with the Lord for the recovery of genuine oneness, they certainly would have fellowshiped with us. However, they refuse to fellowship with those who are already in the local churches. This also results in Babylonian confusion.

When the work of the Lord’s recovery began in the United States in 1962, I was very strong in this matter of the local church. Some warned me against speaking about the local church, saying that if I did so, people would be offended. I emphatically rejected their warning, saying that we are here for the recovery of the local churches. Less than ten years later, the term “local church” had become a popular item in the Christian marketplace. This term is even used by certain preachers on Christian radio stations. It seems that many, including pastors in denominations, want to say that they are the local church. This confusion is another form of Babylonianism.

When I consider a particular situation, I may not say anything to anyone, but I may say to myself, “This is false. It is not the genuine thing.” Neither the Catholic Church, the denominations, nor the divisive and confusing free groups can do any preparation of the Bride. In order for the Bride to be prepared, the Lord must recover the genuine church life, a church life without division, confusion, or anything Babylonian.

A. Her name

In verse 5 we see the name of the great prostitute: “Mystery, Babylon the Great, The Mother of the Prostitutes and the Abominations of the Earth.” The title “Mystery” here indicates that Babylon the Great in this chapter is not the material one in chapter eighteen, but the religious one. The religious Babylon, the apostate church, is truly mysterious in what she is, in what she practices, and in what she teaches.

B. The great prostitute being the mother of the prostitutes and the abominations of the earth

1. The prostitutes

The prostitutes are the denominations and groups in Christianity with the evil doctrines, practices, and traditions of the Roman Catholic Church. Since the “Mother of the Prostitutes” is the apostate church, the prostitutes, her daughters, must be all the different sects and groups in Christianity who hold to some extent the teaching, practices, and traditions of the apostate Roman Church. The pure church life has no evil transmitted from the apostate church. As we all know, the so-called charismatic movement has entered into the Roman Church. This movement has even been confounded with the worship of Mary and with the sacrifice of the mass. Although the cup is golden, the people drink the abominations. It is not the cup, but the contents of the cup that get into them. If it were not for this evil mixture, the pope, in his subtlety, would never allow the charismatic movement to go on in his church.

Every denomination must be examined to see whether or not it still has something of the great prostitute in it. To have a Christmas tree in your home is to practice something of the great prostitute. Probably you cannot find one Christian group that has not been influenced by the prostitute. Perhaps only in the local churches can you find a place that has nothing of the prostitute. We have seen that the daughters of the great prostitute are the Christian groups that hold the doctrines, practices, and traditions of the Roman Catholic Church. If a group holds any one of these things, that group is a daughter of the Roman Church.

Some may feel that it is too severe to say that the denominations and free groups are the daughters of the great prostitute. You may say, “Don’t those in the denominations and in the free groups believe in the Lord and love Him? Have they not also been regenerated? Don’t they have the divine life? How can you say that the denominations and free groups are the daughters of the prostitute?” Madame Guyon, a sister who was very deep in life, still worshipped at the image of Mary. Even she had been drugged by the Catholic Church. More than forty years ago, we translated most of Madame Guyon’s important writings. When I discovered that she went to worship at the image of Mary, I told the brothers that we had to include this in our translation of her works; otherwise, the brothers and sisters would think that she was entirely all right. But even she had been befuddled by the apostate Roman Church.

We may use the smell of garlic as an illustration. If we eat garlic all day long, our sense of smell will eventually be drugged. If someone with a fresh sense of smell comes into the midst of garlic eaters, he will immediately notice the odor of garlic and will not be able to tolerate it. However, the garlic eaters would have no awareness of this unpleasant odor. Madame Guyon could still worship before a statue of Mary because she had been born into the “garlic room” of the Roman Catholic Church.

One reason for saying that the denominations and most free groups are daughters of the prostitute is the presence of idols among them. Some may argue that the Lutheran Church has no idols. But the title of this denomination, Lutheran, is itself an idol. To whom do you belong — to Christ or to Luther? Is it not sufficient to call yourself a Christian? Why must you call yourself a Lutheran? These idolatrous names are abominations.

God has a governing principle of one church for one Christ, just as there is one wife for one husband. By their divisions, most of today’s Christians have violated this governing principle. Instead of following it, they practice fornication, which is confusion. Whoever breaks the governing principle of one husband for one wife commits fornication. Wherever we are, we must keep the principle of one wife for one husband, one church for one Christ.

Every division is a violation of God’s governing principle. To cause a division among Christians is to commit fornication. Anyone who does this does not care for the governing principle. Those who are divisive do not care for the one Body, the one church; they are not concerned about one local church for one city. They are like a woman who refuses to have only one husband. After she is tired of living with one man, she turns to another.

We need to see the difference between adultery and fornication. If a wife with a proper husband breaks the governing principle of marriage, she commits adultery. But a woman who has no proper husband and who breaks God’s governing principle commits fornication. The great prostitute is a fornicator; she has no husband. The situation among Christians today is filled with fornication. Many seem to say, “If I don’t like this meeting any more, I’ll go to another. And if I don’t like that one, I’ll form one of my own. Furthermore, if after a while I am no longer pleased with the meeting I have started, I’ll start still another one.” This is spiritual fornication.

If you have seen the vision, you will not dare to have any particular name, that is, any name other than the name of Christ. Moreover, you will not dare to have any division because our Husband is one, and we, His Bride, are also one. In every city there must be just one church. Wherever I go, the church is one. If our practice is otherwise, then we commit fornication. Most Christians today are committing fornication. The great prostitute in Revelation 17 is the mother of all fornication, confusion, and abominations.

If you are still wondering how Christians who truly love the Lord can commit fornication, I would point you again to the illustration of Madame Guyon, who was deep in life, yet was befuddled by the “garlic” of Roman Catholicism. Be sober, stay away from the “garlic room,” and remain in the fresh air twenty-four hours a day. If you do this, you will have a sensitive nose. I have kept myself away from all the “garlic rooms” for more than fifty years. For this reason, my spiritual nose is very keen. I simply cannot stand with any division, for I can immediately smell that it is fornication.

When some are confronted by the limitation of one church in one city, they may say, “We don’t have the freedom to release ourselves in your meeting. We want to have a meeting in our home where we can be released.” This is merely a subtle excuse for a divisive spirit. This divisive spirit is a source of fornication, division. There must not be any divisions among Christians because we are the wife of one Husband, the one church in a locality, maintaining God’s governing principle. When some hear that we are the church, they are unhappy and say, “Why do you say that you are the church and that we are not the church?” They are not the church because they are a prostitute, a woman who has a relationship with many men instead of a proper relationship with one husband. Who is your husband? If Christ is your husband, then why do you call yourself a Lutheran? If your name is truly Mrs. Smith, then why do you call yourself Mrs. Jones one day and Mrs. Harris another?

The apostate Roman Church is a prostitute, and all her daughters are also prostitutes. A prostitute is a woman who commits fornication for profit. Many of today’s Christian groups have been formed for man’s gain, empire, position, or title. This is prostitution.

Consider the entire situation regarding Christianity on earth today. Certainly the Lord needs a recovery. This recovery will produce the living firstfruit for Him, and during the three and a half years of the great tribulation, it will be a help to all the Christians still on earth. I believe that all the churches in the Lord’s recovery will serve these two purposes. The day is coming when the overcomers will be raptured and Antichrist will abolish Judaism and destroy Catholicism. Surely all Christians left on earth at that time will be revived. They will no longer attend the mass in the Catholic Church; neither will they still go to the denominations or free groups. Rather, they will say, “Years ago I heard about the church. Now I must go to the genuine church.” Although the Lord Jesus has a loving heart, as we shall see in the next message, He will use Antichrist to destroy the great prostitute, the Roman Catholic Church.

2. The abominations of the earth

The apostate church is also the mother of the abominations of the earth. These abominations are idols (Deut. 7:25-26), with which the apostate Roman Church is filled. These idols have been mixed in with the so-called service to God. When people go to a Catholic cathedral to worship, whom do they worship? Some purchase candles and stand before the idol of their choice. In Catholicism there is an idol market, and people can pray to any idol they choose. Although many pray to Mary, that actually is not Mary — it is Venus. The cathedrals in the Catholic Church are not different from idol temples. Not even in the idol temples in China did I see as many idols as there are in the Catholic cathedrals. Certainly, the apostate church is the mother of abominations.

C. In the wilderness

When the apostle John saw the great prostitute, an angel carried him away in spirit into a wilderness (17:3). A wilderness is a desert, a parched land. This indicates that the apostate church is in a desert, where there are no springs of water prepared by God. Certainly the apostate church cannot receive the water supply from God. In order to show the apostle John that the apostate church is in such a desolate place, the angel carried him there.

D. Sitting on many waters

Verse 1 says that the great prostitute sits on many waters, and verse 15 indicates that the waters “where the prostitute sits, are peoples and multitudes and nations and tongues.” These words are fulfilled in the fact that the apostate Roman Church rides on peoples and nations throughout the world. The Catholic Church actually numbers one third of the population of the entire earth.

E. Committing fornication with the kings of the earth

The kings of the earth have committed fornication with this great prostitute. This means that she has sinful religious relationships with the rulers of the earth. What the apostate church commits is not adultery, the sin of an unfaithful spouse, but fornication, the sin of a prostitute. This is more sinful than adultery. The fornication of the apostate church consists of her sinful relationships with the rulers of the earth for her profit, just as a prostitute commits sin for gain. The fornication committed by the apostate church is spiritual fornication. The Catholic Church is intimately involved with worldly politics, and the kings of the earth commit fornication directly with her. In the eyes of God, this is spiritual fornication.

F. Having made the earth-dwellers drunk with the wine of her fornication

This great prostitute has made those who dwell on the earth “drunk with the wine of her fornication” (v. 2). The wine here refers to the heretical doctrines in the sinful religious relationships of the apostate church. They confound as wine does those who become involved in her religion. This is the wine of her fornication. In an indirect manner those who dwell on the earth are made drunk with this wine.

The heretical doctrines of the apostate church are like drugs. They befuddle people, make them dumb, and cause them to lose their senses. I have talked with many Catholics, and I have found them to be completely drugged. The more you talk to them, the less they understand. This indicates that they have been made drunk with the wine of the great prostitute.

G. Clothed in purple and scarlet

According to verse 4, this woman is “clothed in purple and scarlet.” Purple signifies dignity with authority (John 19:2-3). This color is a blend of blue and red; it signifies the blending of heavenly things with earthly. This is the appearance of the apostate church. The woman is also clothed in scarlet, the characteristic of the apostate Roman Church. We have already pointed out that the color scarlet is found everywhere in the Vatican. The most striking use of scarlet is in the garb of the cardinals, who have red hats and red robes.

H. Gilded with gold, precious stone, and pearls

The woman is “gilded with gold and precious stone and pearls” (v. 4). Gold, precious stone, and pearls are the materials with which the New Jerusalem is built (21:18-19, 21). But the woman, the apostate church, is not solidly built with these precious things as the New Jerusalem is; she is only gilded with these treasures as an ornament for outward display. This is her deception to attract people. It is the prostitute’s false appearance.

I. Holding a golden cup

The prostitute holds in her hand “a golden cup full of abominations and the unclean things of her fornication” (v. 4). Gold in figure signifies the divine nature of God. Hence, the golden cup here means that the apostate church does have something of God in appearance. But within, her golden cup is full of abominations and the unclean things of her fornication, full of idolatry, pagan practices, and filthiness in a heretical, sinful, religious relationship.

J. Drunken with the blood of the saints and witnesses

Verse 6 says, “And I saw the woman drunk with the blood of the saints and with the blood of the witnesses of Jesus.” This indicates that the Roman Church has killed the saints and the witnesses of Jesus, having slain more of the saints than the Roman Empire did. The Roman Church does not kill the saints directly, but indirectly through the Roman Empire. Thus, she is drunk with the blood of the saints and with the blood of the witnesses of Jesus.

The saints are those who are separated, sanctified, unto God, living a holy life for God even unto death. The witnesses are those who are a living testimony of the Lord Jesus, faithful also unto death. The witnesses of Jesus are also the saints; however, the saints may just live a separated and holy life, not complying with the apostate church; yet they may not stand out to testify against the apostasy of the Roman Church as did witnesses like Antipas (2:13). The woman is drunken with the blood of both the saints and the witnesses.

K. Materially being the great city

The angel told the apostle John, “And the woman whom you saw is the great city, which has a kingdom over the kings of the earth” (v. 18). While the prostitute denotes the religious Babylon, signifying the Roman Church, the woman in this verse denotes the material Babylon, signifying the city of Rome. This is called the great city, which has a kingdom over the kings of the earth. When John wrote this book, Rome was the city that had a kingdom over the kings of the earth. What Antichrist and his ten kings will hate is the prostitute, the Roman Church, not the woman, the city of Rome, where their administration is based.

The Great Prostitute Sitting on a Scarlet Beast

(2)

In the previous message we considered the great prostitute. Now we shall consider the scarlet beast upon which the prostitute rides, as described in Rev. 17.

II. The scarlet beast

A. Coming up out of the abyss

We have seen that the rider is the Roman Church and that the beast is the Roman Empire, especially Antichrist, the coming seventh Caesar of the Roman Empire. Revelation 17:8 says, “The beast whom you saw was, and is not, and is about to come up out of the abyss and go into destruction.” The beast, who is Antichrist, “was” in the person of Caesar Nero before John wrote this book. He “is not” at the time of John’s writing, because Nero had died by that time. He “is about to come up out of the abyss.” This implies that Nero’s spirit is now in the abyss and, as indicated in Rev. 13:3, is about to emerge from it to take possession of the body of the slain and resuscitated Antichrist.

B. Its color

The beast is scarlet in color (Rev. 17:3). Scarlet, a dark red color, is the color of the great dragon (Rev. 12:3). The fact that the beast and the dragon are the same color indicates that Antichrist will be one with Satan in appearance.

C. Full of names of blasphemy

This beast is full of names of blasphemy (17:3). The seven Caesars, symbolized by the seven heads of the beast, called themselves god. This was sheer blasphemy against God. These Caesars assumed deity and called for their people to worship them. Those who did not worship them were persecuted.

D. Having seven heads

1. Seven mountains on which the city of Rome is built

Verse 3 also indicates that the beast has seven heads. Verse 9 says, “The seven heads are seven mountains on which the woman sits.” The city of Rome is built on seven mountains, signified by the seven heads of the beast on which the prostitute sits.

2. Seven kings

Verse 10, speaking of the seven mountains, which are the seven heads of the beast, says, “And are seven kings: five have fallen, one is, the other has not yet come; and when he comes, he must remain a little while.” The seven kings are seven Caesars of the Roman Empire. According to history, the Roman Empire had twelve Caesars; Antichrist will be the thirteenth. Out of the twelve Caesars, only six are included in the prophecy of Revelation. The first five have fallen; that is, they have died unnaturally (Judg. 3:25; 2 Sam. 1:10, 25, 27). They were Julius Caesar, Tiberius, Caligula, Claudius, and Nero, all of whom either were murdered or committed suicide before John wrote this book. The sixth one, Domitian, who was also murdered, was living when this book was written; therefore, it is said of him that he “is.” “The other,” the seventh, who will be Antichrist, had “not yet come” at that time. “When he comes, he must remain a little while” and then will be slain and resuscitated with the spirit of the fifth, Nero, to be the eighth.

Verse 11 says, “And the beast who was, and is not, he also is the eighth, and is of the seven, and goes into destruction.” Antichrist will be the coming seventh Caesar. But he “also is the eighth.” According to 13:3, Antichrist will be slain and resuscitated. In that resuscitation, the spirit of Nero, the fifth Caesar, which comes up out of the abyss, will animate the dead body of the seventh Caesar, Antichrist. This one, composed of the fifth and seventh Caesars, is the eighth. Hence, he “is of the seven.” It is no wonder people will marvel at the sight of such an extraordinary being (v. 8).

E. Going into destruction

Verses 8 and 11 indicate that the beast will go “into destruction.” This indicates that Antichrist will perish, as indicated in 19:20 and 20:10. He will be thrown into the lake of fire.

F. Having ten horns

Verses 12 and 13 say, “And the ten horns which you saw are ten kings, who have not yet received a kingdom, but receive authority as kings one hour with the beast. These have one mind, and they give their power and authority to the beast.” Ten kings will be raised up in the revived Roman Empire before the great tribulation. They will be one with Antichrist in opposing God and persecuting His people — the Jews and the believers. These ten kings, likened to the ten toes of the great image seen by Nebuchadnezzar in his dream (Dan. 2:42), will submit themselves and their kingdom to Antichrist (v. 17).

The ten kings will receive the kingdom within one hour with the beast. This will be miraculous. Many wonder whether the ten nations of the European Common Market will be the ten kingdoms referred to here. This view may not be accurate, because these kings will receive their kingdom within one hour. Before that time, no one will know who they are. Suddenly, within one hour, they will all receive the kingdom. These ten kings will receive authority within such a short period of time. This will be a miracle performed by Satan, and it will come as a great surprise to the people.

Verse 13 says that these ten kings have one mind and that they give their power and authority to the beast. They will fully submit themselves to Antichrist, who will be very intelligent, imposing, convincing, and subduing.

Along with Antichrist, the ten kings will eventually wage war directly with the Lamb. Verse 14 says, “These shall make war with the Lamb, and the Lamb shall overcome them, for He is Lord of lords and King of kings; and they who are with Him are called and chosen and faithful.” The war here is the same as that mentioned in 19:11-21, the war at Armageddon (16:14, 16). Those who are with the Lamb are called, chosen, and faithful. Notice that “chosen” is mentioned after “called.” To be called is to be saved, whereas to be chosen is to be approved by the Lord on the basis of an overcoming life. Many are called today, but few will be chosen in the future (Matt. 22:14). We all have been called. In order to be among the chosen in the future we need to live an overcoming life today.

Verses 16 and 17 say, “And the ten horns which you saw and the beast, these shall hate the prostitute and shall make her desolate and naked, and shall eat her flesh and shall burn her utterly with fire; for God has put it into their hearts to do His mind, and to come to one mind, and to give their kingdom to the beast until the words of God shall be accomplished.” That the ten horns and the beast will hate the prostitute and make her desolate means that Antichrist and the ten kings will destroy the apostate Roman Church. This will transpire at the beginning of the great tribulation. They will make the Roman Church desolate and naked, destroying her, robbing her of her riches, and exposing her; they “shall eat her flesh,” killing her members; and they “shall burn her utterly with fire,” annihilating her altogether. This also indicates that Babylon the Great mentioned in this chapter is the religious one. It will be of God that Antichrist and his ten kings destroy the apostate Roman Church. This should not be considered as martyrdom, but as the avenging judgment of God.

In 1929 Mussolini signed an agreement with Pope Pius XI making Vatican City an independent nation. Today the Vatican exercises power, authority, and influence over many nations, and ambassadors from other nations are sent to the Vatican. Probably this influence of the Vatican will arouse the hatred of the ten kings, and they will propose to the beast that they destroy the Roman Catholic Church. According to the picture in this chapter, the woman is riding upon the beast. Because the rider always controls the carrier, not the carrier the rider, this means that the prostitute controls the beast, not the beast the prostitute. For example, in driving your car, the car does not control you; you control it. Today, the Roman Catholic Church rides over politics. Eventually, this will stir up the ten kings to hate the prostitute, and together with Antichrist they will destroy her.

In their hatred for the great prostitute the ten kings will make her desolate and naked. The Roman Catholic Church today is far from being desolate; rather, it is flourishing. Recently I learned that the Roman Church owns one-third of the real estate in the city of Rome. Although the Roman Church is flourishing now, one day the Antichrist and the ten kings will make her desolate; that is, they will rob her of all her riches. Furthermore, they will make her naked. This means that they will strip off her covering and her pretensions and thoroughly expose her. Antichrist will be used by the Lord to expose this apostate church to the uttermost.

Today the Roman Catholic Church is covered, and we cannot see her real condition. We cannot see how filthy, sinful, worldly, devilish, demonic, and satanic are the things hidden within her. She not only engages in spiritual fornication, but in physical fornication as well. How terrible! Once I read an article saying that a certain dry well in Spain is filled with the bones of babies. We do not know how sinful, how evil, and how filthy are the things in this apostate church. One day, however, Antichrist and his ten kings will expose everything.

They will also eat the flesh of the prostitute, meaning that they will harm and even kill her members. Antichrist will devour and kill the members of the apostate church and burn her utterly with fire. If this word is not fulfilled in relation to the Roman Catholic Church, then on whom will this judgment come?

Some of those reading this message may be naturally kind and sympathetic, and they may think that my word regarding Roman Catholicism is too severe. If my word is too severe, I am not the first to speak such a word. The first is the Lord Jesus Himself, for the book of Revelation is His word. In 10:9 the Lord told the apostle John to devour the little scroll. He also said that the scroll would be sweet as honey in his mouth, but that it would make his stomach bitter. I cannot deny that I have seen the vision, and I have no choice but to speak the word of the Lord. The Lord must have a strong testimony today. I hope that you all will be stronger than I. But in order to be strong you must have a clear vision. In the Lord's recovery today the vision is clear, especially after the release of all these messages. We must press on to have a strong, fresh, living, up-to-date testimony of Jesus. I realize that not many will take this way. Nevertheless, a good number will turn and come into the Lord's recovery. The Lord will gather all His sincere and pure seekers to be His living, up-to-date testimony. This testimony will not only produce the firstfruit; it will also help the Christians still on earth during the great tribulation.

Verse 17 says that God has put it into the hearts of the ten kings to do His mind. I am glad that we have this verse. Antichrist and the ten kings will do certain things according to God's mind to terminate the apostate church and to fulfill God's will. How marvelous! God will put it into their hearts to destroy the Roman Church. Will you be kinder than God? God hates the apostate Roman Catholic Church. In His eyes it is a great prostitute, an abomination. One day, at the end of this age, God will cause the devilish rulers on earth to do His will to destroy this apostate church and to burn it with fire. Although many of us have had the Bible in our hands for years, we have never seen the significance of these two verses. Praise the Lord now so many of us have seen it! We are clear that the Roman Church will be burned. For this reason, we must tell our friends and relatives to come out of her.

If you want your relatives and friends to come out of the Roman Catholic Church, you must approach them in a proper way. Perhaps you are burdened for your mother. Do not say, "Mother, one day Antichrist will burn your church." Rather, you should speak to your mother in a wise yet frank way. At first, you may ask her to read the Bible with you. But do not start with Revelation 17. It is better to begin with chapter twelve and read about the universal bright woman revealed there. Surely your mother will be interested in this, and she may say, "During my whole life in the Catholic Church, I never heard about this." The next time you visit her, you may read chapter thirteen concerning the beast, Antichrist, and the time after that, chapter seventeen. Gradually you should help her to see that the woman riding on the scarlet beast is the Roman Catholic Church. However, do not tell her this directly. Instead, read the chapter with your mother and ask her to think about it. Eventually, she will conclude that the woman riding on the beast is the Catholic Church. She may even say, "It seems that this rider is my church." Let her come to this conclusion herself. Even after she reaches this conclusion, you should ask her if she is sure about it. We must learn the wisdom to talk to people without offending them. Do not directly tell people that the Roman Church is demonic.

The subtle, devilish Catholicism is rooted in the blood of its people, and it is not easy to turn them away from it. If you want your friends and relatives to come out of the Catholic Church, you must pray for them desperately, asking the Lord to have mercy and to open their eyes. At times you may be so burdened that you will pray to the Lord, saying, "Lord, I am desperate with You about my mother. I simply cannot go on unless she comes out of Catholicism. Lord, it is a matter of life and death. You must turn my mother." I assure you that the Lord will answer your prayer. But as you talk with her, be wise and be full of the anointing. Never argue.

As you contact those in the Catholic Church, do not be hard with them. Approach them in a sincere, honest, soft, and wise way. Furthermore, your contact with them must be supported by a great deal of prayer. Even as you are talking to your relatives or friends, you need to pray, "Lord, have mercy on them and open their eyes that they may see the great prostitute." If we do this, we shall be living witnesses to people. However, we have no intention of gaining increase by proselytizing. The increase is in the hands of the Lord. Although we do not proselytize, we are burdened to testify to all. As the living testimony of Jesus, we must learn how to express the Lord according to what we have seen. Do not argue with people or offend them — speak to them in a very pleasant way. The Lord will afford you the grace you need to be such a testimony.

The Material Babylon

In this message we shall consider the material Babylon (Rev. 18:1-24). The Bible reveals three aspects of Babylon: the literal, ancient Babylon, the religious Babylon, and the material Babylon. The site of ancient Babylon is in today's Iraq. I visited that region eighteen years ago and found it to be dusty and hot, like an oven. I could not stand to stay there. Before I visited that place, I had studied the curses pronounced upon Babylon recorded in the Bible. The Old Testament, especially the book of Jeremiah, contains many curses and condemnations pronounced by God upon Babylon. In my visit I saw that in every respect the word of the Bible concerning Babylon had been proved true.

The ancient city of Babylon is also the ancient Babel. Genesis 11 speaks of the tower and city of Babel. Both Babel, the Hebrew word, and Babylon, the Greek word, mean confusion. Babel was founded by Cush, the father of Nimrod. According to history, Nimrod invented the pagan, idolatrous system of worship. Many centuries later, Babel was enlarged by Nebuchadnezzar and became the Babylon known in the Old Testament. Babylon became an evil and devilish place because under Nebuchadnezzar the Babylonians destroyed God's temple and seized the holy vessels, the vessels for the service of God in the temple (Dan. 1:1-2; 2 Kings 25:8-9, 14-15). Furthermore, Nebuchadnezzar brought these vessels to Babylon and placed them in the temple of his idols (Dan. 1:1-2). That was an insult to God. At the time of the recovery in the Old Testament, Ezra brought these vessels back to Jerusalem and placed them in the rebuilt temple (Ezra 1:7-11; 5:14; 6:5). Therefore, Babylon became evil not only because of her idolatry, but also because she destroyed God's temple and carried away into captivity God's people and the holy vessels.

In the Bible we have two important lines — the line of Babel and the line of Jerusalem. The line of Babel is a counterfeit of the line of Jerusalem. Before God began the line of Jerusalem, Satan began his counterfeit. Thus, two cities, Babylon and Jerusalem, are opposed to each other. These two lines continue to the present day. The church is today's Jerusalem, and the Roman Catholic Church is today's Babel, Babylon. Furthermore, the daughters of the great prostitute, the denominations and groups which still practice some of the Babylonian traditions, also belong in the category of Babylon. Only the pure, genuine local churches are in the line of Jerusalem today.

Chapters seventeen through twenty-two are the ultimate conclusion of the whole Bible. In these chapters we also see two cities — Babylon and Jerusalem. Babylon will be utterly destroyed, and Jerusalem will be completely built up. This is the consummation of the Bible, the ultimate issue of the line of Babel and the line of Jerusalem.

The writings of G. H. Pember and Alexander Hislop's *The Two Babylons* say that, without exception, every pagan religion originated with Babylonianism. The religion invented by Nimrod has spread throughout the world, even to India, China, and Japan. Nimrod, for example, originated the picture of the Madonna and her child. The story behind this picture is an evil story of incest. Nevertheless, that picture has been taken into Catholicism and presented as a picture of Mary and Jesus. As a child, I saw this picture of the woman and her infant in the idol temples in China. Later I was surprised to see the same picture in a Catholic cathedral. Eventually, through study I learned that they were both of the same origin. The first Catholic missionaries to go to China found the image of the Madonna and child already in the Buddhist temples. It was also found in Japan and India. Although the same picture under different titles is found everywhere, its origin can be traced to Nimrod at Babel. This example illustrates that every religion is an outgrowth of Babylonianism. All religion comes from one devilish source — the ancient city of Babylon.

The second aspect of Babylon is religious Babylon. In the eyes of God the Roman Catholic Church, which perpetuates much of Judaism and has assimilated much from paganism, is Babylon.

The third aspect of Babylon is the material Babylon, the city of Rome.

At times it is difficult to distinguish these three aspects of Babylon because the Bible blends them together. For example, the Babylon in Revelation 18 is material Babylon. But when I was young, I was told by some Christian teachers that it is the literal Babylon. This chapter, however, does not refer to the literal Babylon; it refers to the city of Rome, which is Babylon in the eyes of God.

In Revelation 17 and 18 two aspects of Babylon, the religious aspect and the material aspect, are mixed together. On the one hand, the female in chapter seventeen is a "prostitute" signifying the apostate church; on the other hand, she is a "woman" signifying the city of Rome. Verse 1 speaks of the prostitute, and verse 18 speaks of the woman. Therefore, the female in this chapter has the aspect of the prostitute, the apostate church, and the aspect of the woman, the physical city of Rome.

It is not easy to understand the Bible. We need to pray over and ponder certain portions again and again. I do not know why the Lord in some verses mixes together the various aspects of Babylon. I only know that He has done so. Knowing the various aspects of Babylon is like knowing the prophecies regarding the two comings of Christ. In a number of places in the Old Testament Christ's two comings are mentioned together. It is like two mountain ranges that appear to be one when they are viewed from a distance. But as you approach them, you realize that there is a great gap between them. In reading the prophecies regarding the coming of Christ, we must know which refer to His first coming and which refer to His second coming. It is the same with the verses regarding Babylon. We must discern which refer to ancient Babylon, which to religious Babylon, and which to material Babylon. If we are clear about this, then we shall be able to understand Revelation 17 and 18. Years ago, I simply could not understand these chapters because I did not know the various aspects of Babylon. If we are clear about these aspects, then we have a solid foundation for understanding these two chapters, and we shall be able to discern which verses concern the religious aspect and which verses concern the material aspect.

I. The appearing of Christ

Christ will appear at the time of the destruction of material Babylon. Revelation 18:1 says, "After these things I saw another Angel coming down out of heaven, having great authority; and the earth was illumined with His glory." This Angel is Christ, coming down out of heaven, with whose glory the earth is illumined. In His appearing Christ will come as an angel sent by God. In the Old Testament several times Christ was the angel sent by God. In Gen. 22:11-12, Exo. 3:2-6, Jud. 6:11-24, and Zech. 1:11-12; 2:3, 8-11; 3:1-7, we read of the angel of the Lord. As we study the context of all these references to the angel of the Lord, we see that the angel of the Lord is actually the Lord Himself. In the book of Revelation Christ is revealed at least three or four times as an angel sent by God to fulfill God's commission (Rev. 7:2; 8:3; 10:1; 18:1). Here Christ appears in this way.

In Rev. 10:1 Christ was still clothed with a cloud, and in Rev. 14:14 He was sitting on the cloud, whereas His glory here in Rev. 18:1 shines over the earth, indicating that His coming back to earth is closer than the coming mentioned in 10:1 and 14:14. He will come down out of heaven firstly in the cloud secretly, then He will come on the cloud openly, and eventually He will shine over the earth to destroy Babylon the Great, the city of Rome, with great authority. At this time He will take full possession of the earth, and the earth will become His kingdom. Therefore, the fall of material Babylon will transpire at the appearing of Christ.

II. The two aspects of Babylon the great

In 18:3 the aspects of religious and material Babylon are both mentioned. This verse says, "For all the nations have drunk of the wine of the fury of her fornication, and the kings of the earth have committed fornication with her, and the merchants of the earth have become rich by the power of her luxury." "The nations have drunk of the wine...and the kings of the earth have committed fornication with her..." refers to the religious aspect, whereas "the merchants of the earth have become rich by the power of her luxury" refers to the material aspect. It is the Roman religion, not the Roman Empire, that has made all nations drunk with her religious, devilish wine. Likewise, it is the city of Rome, not the Roman Church, that has enriched the merchants of the earth by the power of her luxury. Therefore, in one verse the religious aspect and the material aspect are covered.

III. The call for separation

Verse 4 says, "And I heard another voice out of heaven, saying, Come out of her, My people, that you may not participate in her sins, and that you may not receive of her plagues." Since Babylon the Great is twofold, to come out of her means to come out of both religious Babylon and material Babylon. This is proved by the pronoun "her" in this verse. The antecedent of this pronoun is the Babylon of two aspects revealed in verses 2 and 3.

IV. Babylon's pride and destruction

Verses 6 through 8 speak of Babylon's pride and destruction. She prides herself on being a queen, not a widow. As such a one, she thinks she will never see sorrow. But when the time of judgment comes, the Lord will destroy her and give her much torment and sorrow. In one day her plagues will come, and she will be utterly burned with fire.

V. The fall of the material Babylon

In verse 2 we see the fall of material Babylon. This verse says, "And He cried with a strong voice, saying, Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great! And she has become a dwelling place of demons and a hold of every unclean spirit and a cage of every unclean and hateful bird." In 14:8 an angel said, "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great," and in this verse Christ cries out with the same words. This indicates that Babylon will have two falls, the fall of religious Babylon and the fall of material Babylon. The fall of religious Babylon will transpire at the beginning of the great tribulation, and the fall of material Babylon will transpire at the end of the great tribulation. Chapter eighteen relates the fall of material Babylon, not of religious Babylon.

Verse 2 says that Babylon has become “a dwelling place of demons and a hold of every unclean spirit and a cage of every unclean and hateful bird.” This verse contains references to the prophets Isaiah and Jeremiah and quotations from them. In condemning literal Babylon Jeremiah used expressions like this. Eventually, the city of Rome will be condemned and cursed just as ancient Babylon was. For this reason, the city of Rome will no longer be a fit dwelling place for human beings. Rome is a most interesting city, and tourists enjoy visiting there. However, the day is coming when no one will go there because it will be filled with demons, unclean spirits, and unclean and hateful birds. This is a sign that it will be ugly and abominable in the eyes of God. Material Babylon, the city of Rome, will become hateful in the eyes of God because it has been the source of both devilish politics and devilish religion. In the Roman Empire we see the devilish politics, and in the Roman Catholic Church, the devilish religion. These devilish things have been in power for at least two thousand years and have damaged and poisoned mankind throughout the earth. Therefore, God will intervene to judge the city of Rome and render it unfit to be a place for people to live in. As a result of the condemnation and curse pronounced upon ancient Babylon, it became unfit for human habitation. The same will be true of material Babylon.

VI. Weeping over Babylon

In verses 9 through 19 we have the weeping over Babylon. Verse 9 says, “And the kings of the earth, who have committed fornication and lived luxuriously with her, shall weep and wail over her when they see the smoke of her burning,” and verse 11 says, “And the merchants of the earth weep and mourn over her, because no one buys their cargo anymore.” The international merchants who have made great profit from this wealthy city will weep when they see it under God’s judgment.

Verses 12 and 13 list the cargo sold by the merchants of the earth. Since the cargo in these verses consists of various material things, Babylon the Great in this chapter is proved to be the material one. The cargo is of seven categories: from gold to pearls, ornament; from fine linen to scarlet, clothing; from thine wood to marble, furniture and decoration; from cinnamon to frankincense, spice; from wine to sheep, food; horses and carriages, transportation; and bodies and souls of men, employment. Of the cargo carried by Babylon, the first item is gold, and the last is the souls of men. Souls of men are men themselves sold for employment. This not only depicts the coming Babylon, but also today’s world. People sell their whole being to their employers. Many are selling their soul, their life, themselves, to their occupation, neglecting God and their eternal destiny.

This list of the cargo proves that the city of Rome will be a city of capitalism, not of communism. Capitalism will prevail in Rome until material Babylon is destroyed.

VII. Rejoicing in heaven over the judgment upon Babylon

Verse 20 says, “Rejoice over her, O heaven and saints and apostles and prophets, because God has judged your judgment upon her.” While many will weep over the destruction of Babylon, others will rejoice over it. Those on earth will weep, but those in heaven will rejoice. We shall certainly be among the rejoicing ones in heaven. Furthermore, I believe that we shall witness the destruction of Babylon. As her smoke goes up, we shall rejoice.

VIII. Declaration of Babylon’s absolute destruction

In verses 21 through 24 we find the declaration of Babylon’s absolute destruction. Verse 21 says, “And a strong angel took up a stone like a great millstone and threw it into the sea, saying, Thus will Babylon the great city be thrown down with violence and shall be found no more at all.” Perhaps the destruction of Babylon will be accomplished by a great earthquake that will cause the entire city to sink into the sea. Because this is the destiny of Babylon, you must advise your friends not to live there.

IX. Praise in heaven over the judgment upon the great prostitute

In 19:1-4 we have the praise in heaven over the judgment upon the great prostitute. In verses 1 through 3 we have a loud voice of a great multitude in heaven, praising God and saying, “Hallelujah!” Although chapter eighteen concerns the judgment upon material Babylon, the praise in these verses in chapter nineteen is not mainly related to material Babylon, but to religious Babylon. The reason for this is that throughout the centuries both aspects have been mingled together. Until A.D. 476 Rome was the center of politics. In the centuries following that time it has been the center of religion. The Roman Catholic Church came into power in the sixth century, and by the end of the sixth century the papal system was completely established. Of the past nineteen centuries, in the first five we see the predominance of the Roman Empire and in the last fourteen, of the Roman Catholic Church. When the time comes for the fall of Babylon, the religious aspect will be destroyed first and the material aspect later. The praise in heaven is not mainly related to the destruction of material Babylon, but to the destruction of religious Babylon, because in God’s eyes the religious aspect is more hateful than the material aspect. Today we care little for material Rome, but we are very troubled by religious Rome. How happy we shall be to see the fall of religious Babylon!

Revelation 19:4 says, “And the twenty-four elders and the four living creatures fell down and worshipped God, who sits upon the throne, saying, Amen, Hallelujah!” After the loud voice of a great multitude in heaven says, “Hallelujah,” the twenty-four elders and the four living creatures say, “Amen, Hallelujah!” The “Amen” comes first because some hallelujahs have been spoken already. The twenty-four elders and the four living creatures say “Amen” to these hallelujahs and then add more hallelujahs of their own. In 1967 the Lord showed us how to call upon His name. At the same time we began to see that we should praise Him continually. Our meetings in 1967 and 1968 were filled with amens and hallelujahs. Religious people condemned us for this, and a small part of religious Babylon rose up against us. I simply do not know why. They oppose our praising the Lord with amens and hallelujahs. But the book of Revelation indicates that praising the Lord in this way will be the practice in the future. What will be practiced in heaven in the future may also be practiced by us today on earth.

If we believe the Bible, then we must accept the book of Revelation. If we do not have this book, then the Bible has no conclusion. The Nicene Creed, formulated in A.D. 325 at a council convened under the authority of the Emperor Constantine, is widely accepted throughout Catholicism and Protestantism. At the time of this council seven books of the New Testament — Hebrews, James, 2 Peter, 2 John, 3 John, Jude, and Revelation — had not yet been fully recognized. They were officially recognized in A.D. 393 at the Council of Carthage. Hence, the Nicene Creed was probably formulated without the book of Revelation.

To many Christians, the book of Revelation is foreign. As far as many Christians are concerned, it is almost as if this book were not in the Bible. Even if they do read it, they cannot understand it. This is due to the subtlety of the enemy. No other book in the Bible has suffered as much from Christian opinion as the book of Revelation. For this reason, in 22:18 and 19 the Lord Jesus said, “I testify to every one who hears the words of the prophecy of this book: If anyone adds to them, God shall add to him the plagues which are written in this book; and if anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God shall take away his part from the tree of life and out of the holy city, which are written in this book.” We must be careful not to add anything to or take anything from the words of the prophecy of this book. Nevertheless, throughout the centuries most Christians have taken away from this book. Although the book of Revelation is printed in the Bible, in the experience of many, this book has actually been taken away from them. This is the reason so many Christians are missing God’s blessing. From the time the Lord first opened this book to us, what blessing there has been! I believe that all these messages will cause a great turn and a further step in all the churches. Great blessing will be bestowed upon the churches.

There are a number of expositions on the book of Revelation. Because most of these writings do not follow a sound principle in expounding this book, most of what they say is not accurate. In order to rightly interpret the book of Revelation we need to be familiar with the entire Bible. As we have pointed out, nearly every symbol in this book is a reference to a symbol in the Old Testament. Thus, we must know the origination of the symbol in the Old Testament and then trace the development of it in the New Testament. Take the example of the lampstand in Revelation 1. It is first mentioned in Exodus 25 and then in Zechariah 4. If we would know the significance of the lampstand in Revelation, then we must consult Exodus 25 and Zechariah 4. Furthermore, we also need to understand the development of this matter of the lampstand in the book of Revelation. This is the way to understand this book.

Another illustration of the proper way to understand Revelation is the matter of the beast in chapter thirteen. If we would know what this beast is, we must go to Daniel 7, for the beast in Revelation 13 is both a reference to the beast revealed in Daniel 7 and a development of that beast.

If we study the first mention of any symbol and then trace its development, we shall have the right interpretation of it. We must follow this basic principle in studying the book of Revelation. However, many expositions of this book violate this principle. Praise the Lord that He has shown us the basic principles. All the interpretations the Lord has given us are according to these principles and are fully supported by history. Therefore, for example, we have been made very clear about the Roman Empire, the Roman Church, and Antichrist. We have seen that Antichrist will be a double character; he will be both the seventh Caesar and the eighth Caesar. As the eighth Caesar he will have the body of the seventh and the spirit of the fifth. Thus, he will be an extraordinary figure. If we understand this clearly, then we shall know where we are and what will happen in the near future.

The Marriage of the Lamb and the Wedding Feast

After God's judgment upon all the negative things revealed in chapters sixteen, seventeen, and eighteen, we have the marriage of the Lamb and the marriage dinner (Rev. 19:5-10). Perhaps you have never realized that, as the Lamb, Christ needs a wedding. This concept is altogether unreligious. Who would ever think that the Redeemer needs a wedding? One day John the Baptist declared, "Behold, the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). This verse clearly reveals that Christ came as the Lamb to take away the sin of the world. Later, John the Baptist also indicated that Christ is the Bridegroom. John said, "He who has the bride is the bridegroom; but the friend of the bridegroom, who stands and hears him, rejoices with joy because of the bridegroom's voice" (John 3:29). Hence, in the Gospel of John, Christ is revealed both as the Lamb who came to take away sin and as the Bridegroom who came that He might have the Bride. Christ's goal is not to remove sin; it is to have the Bride. In the book of Revelation, also written by the apostle John, we see that Christ our Redeemer is the Lamb and the coming Bridegroom. Therefore, as the Bridegroom, He must have a wedding.

The wedding of the Lamb will be a universal wedding. It will be the marriage of the Redeemer and the redeemed. At the very end of the Bible we see a city, the New Jerusalem. This city is the wife (Rev. 21:2, 9-10), and the redeeming God is the husband. Although this concept of the marriage of God and man is foreign to religion, we emphasize it in the Lord's recovery in order to show that our position is that of the Bride, and that the position of the coming Christ is that of the Bridegroom. We are on earth being prepared to become the Bride to meet Him, and He is on the throne in the third heaven prepared to come as the Bridegroom to meet us. Thus, He is coming as the Bridegroom, and we are going as the Bride. The Bride and the Groom will meet, neither in heaven nor on the earth, but in the air. When we meet Him in the air, we shall have a wedding.

I. After the destruction of Babylon the great

The wedding of the Lamb will transpire after the destruction of Babylon the Great (Rev. 19:1-4). In this universe there is not only a pure, chaste Bride; there is also a counterfeit, the great prostitute. Even part of the Bride has been captured by the prostitute and involved with her. Take the example of Madame Guyon. Although she certainly was part of the Bride, she was involved with the prostitute. The prostitute, however, did not love Madame Guyon; rather, she had her cast into prison. Nonetheless, Madame Guyon clearly was involved with the prostitute. As we have pointed out, she even stood before the statue of Mary. Today's situation is very complicated. The Bible condemns the prostitute, and we also condemn her. But within the prostitute there are a good number of genuine believers, many of whom seek the Lord more diligently than those in the denominations. Because the situation is complicated, our vision must be clear. We must know where we should be and that we should never be involved with the counterfeit, the prostitute.

The Bible reveals that Satan is always trying to involve himself with the things of God. Satanic activities are always stirred up by God's move. According to the Bible, there is hardly one aspect of God's move with which Satan has not tried to interfere. Wherever God goes, Satan goes also. He is even active in the preaching of the gospel and even attempts to inject himself into the work of the building up of the church. On the day of Pentecost both God and Satan were active. The principle is the same in the Lord's recovery today, for Satan is still devising a counterfeit of what God is doing. Quite often, Satan's work will precede God's work. For example, before Jerusalem was built up by God, Satan erected the tower and city of Babel. Satan knows God's intention and attempts to produce a counterfeit before God carries out His plan. How subtle! We must clearly perceive Satan's counterfeit of the Bride and never be entangled with it. We are part of the Bride. How can we become involved with that prostitute?

Through the years many dear Christians have come to me, trying their best to argue with me and to subdue me. Some have said, "Brother Lee, don't you realize that I am a real brother in the Lord? Don't you know that there are many true believers in all the denominations? Why then do you renounce all of us?" Again and again strong Christians have confronted me with such questions. I have always answered by saying, "You are a dear brother, and I do not renounce you. However, do you know where you are? You are in a place condemned by God. Although you are right as a brother, you are still in the wrong place." We must see the difference between the person and the place. The person may be absolutely right, but the place where he stands may be altogether wrong.

In 1957 a dear servant of the Lord was invited to Taiwan. During his visit, the leading brothers had much fellowship with him. One of the brothers asked him, "Here in Taipei there are several Christian groups claiming to be nondenominational and meeting in the name of the Lord Jesus. Brother, please tell us which of these groups is right." He replied by saying that none of them was absolutely right and that all of them were relatively right. Shocked by this answer, the brothers immediately asked him by what standard these groups were relatively right. His reply was that they were relatively right according to the measure of Christ. He said that the greater our measure of Christ, the more correct we are in the matter of the church, and the smaller our measure of Christ, the less correct we are in this matter. During the first two meetings with this brother, I did the interpreting. But at this point I entered into the debate and said, "Now we are talking about the measure of Christ. Some say that the greater our measure of Christ, the more correct we are in the church matter. We would all agree that in the past three hundred years Madame Guyon was probably the one who had the greatest measure of Christ. Nevertheless, can we say that she was right with respect to the church? She was in the satanic Roman Catholic Church. Let us also consider the typology in the Old Testament. The children of Israel were captured and held in captivity seventy years. At the end of those seventy years God intervened to command them to return to Jerusalem. Suppose a preacher rose up and said, 'There is no need to return to Jerusalem. See how spiritual Daniel is, and he is still in Babylon. As long as we are spiritual, it does not matter where we are.' Do you agree with this? To be spiritual is one thing, and to be in the right place is another. You may be as spiritual as Daniel, but if you remain in Babylon, you are still in Babylon. Your condition may be spiritual, but you are still in captivity. Don't use Daniel as an excuse. Although he remained in Babylon, he opened his windows toward Jerusalem and prayed three times a day (Dan. 6:10). Daniel died in the very year the command came to the captives to go back to Jerusalem (Dan. 1:21; Ezra 1:1-3). If he had not died in that year, he probably would have returned. As long as you are alive, you must go back to Jerusalem. Do not disregard the matter of position. The Catholic Church and all denominations and divisive groups are condemned by the New Testament. Who can justify them? No matter how spiritual you are, as long as you are in the Catholic Church, in the denominations, or in the divisive groups, you are in a position condemned by the Scriptures."

Although some may justify themselves, deep in their conscience they know that they are in the wrong place. When some argued with me, often I simply smiled and said, "Although you are arguing with me, Someone within you agrees with me and disagrees with you. This inner One doesn't take sides with you; He takes sides with me." Many of us who turned to the way of the church did not see the vision immediately. Rather, we stayed where we were and tried to reconcile the situation. Eventually, the One within, who is much stronger than we are, captured us, and we had to come to the right place. Please be clear that to be the right person is one thing and to be in the right place is another.

We live in a day of complications and confusion. Both the Bride and the counterfeit, the prostitute, are here. Apparently, the prostitute is much more prevailing than the Bride. The Bride is just a small herb, and the prostitute is a huge tree (Matt. 13:31-32). If you merely look at the outward appearance, you will be deceived and distracted. It is difficult for most Christians to discern between them. The outward appearance of both is about the same—gold, pearl, and precious stone. They both have something of God, something of Christ, and something of the Bible. But in the Lord's recovery today the vision is clear, and the light is shining. This light exposes and discerns. By the light in the Lord's recovery we know what is real and what is false; we know what is the Bride and what is the prostitute, and we can easily discern the one from the other. Hallelujah, we are in the Bride and have nothing to do with the prostitute! Furthermore, we know that one day the Lord will intervene to judge this prostitute. Hence, the wedding of the Lord will transpire after the destruction of the prostitute.

Some of you may still feel sympathetic toward the prostitute. However, I am certain that when the marriage of the Lamb has come, none of us will sympathize with her any longer. Although you may argue on her behalf today, eventually she will be utterly burned and destroyed. The Lord hates the prostitute, and before He enjoys a pleasant wedding with His Bride, He will utterly get rid of the prostitute. No bridegroom would want some kind of triangular relationship, and the Lord as the Bridegroom surely would not tolerate such a thing. In the marriage of the Lamb and the Bride there will be no third party. The third party, the prostitute, will be completely burned. Praise the Lord for this! I shall rejoice to see the destruction of this counterfeit, Babylon the Great.

II. After the rapture of the majority of the believers

The marriage of the Lamb will come after the rapture of the majority of the believers (1 Thes. 4:15-17). There will be several raptures: the rapture of the firstfruit, the rapture of the man-child, the rapture of the overcomers on the sea of glass, the rapture of the two witnesses, the rapture of the majority of the believers, and the rapture of the gleanings. The wedding of the Lamb will follow all these raptures.

III. After the judgment seat of Christ

The marriage of the Lamb will also follow the judgment at the judgment seat of Christ (2 Cor. 5:10). After all the raptures and before the wedding, there will be the judgment at the judgment seat of Christ to determine which believers will be qualified for the wedding feast. If you are rewarded at the judgment seat of Christ, you will participate in the wedding feast. If you are not rewarded but are disapproved of by the Lord, you will not perish; yet you will suffer a loss like that described in 1 Corinthians 3:15. This verse, says, "If anyone's work shall be consumed, he shall suffer loss, but he shall be saved, yet so as through fire." The saved ones who suffer loss will certainly miss the wedding feast. According to Matt. 25:1-13, the five wise virgins will be admitted to the wedding feast, and the five foolish ones will be rejected.

The judgment at the judgment seat of Christ will not determine whether or not we shall be saved or perish; it will decide whether we shall receive a reward from the Lord or suffer a loss. Only the saved will appear before this judgment seat. As the Lord is coming down from heaven to earth, He will linger for a time in the air, where He will take care of certain matters. The judgment seat of Christ will be set up in the air, and the wedding will also take place there. After this judgment and after the wedding, Christ will descend with His chosen ones as His army to fight against Antichrist in the war at Armageddon. Hence, both the judgment seat and the wedding will take place in the air. Therefore, the wedding will take place after the destruction of the prostitute, after all the raptures, and after the judgment at the judgment seat of Christ. As we shall see, those who are chosen at the judgment seat will be the Bride and also the guests at the feast. The guests will be the corporate Bride.

IV. The marriage of the Lamb

A. The praise of a great multitude

In verses 5 through 7 we have the praise of a great multitude. Right after the destruction of Babylon comes the marriage of the Lamb. The judgment and destruction of Babylon the Great, both religious and material, bring in the marriage of the Lamb and the reign of God — the kingdom of God (v. 6). This is the reason the great multitude of the saved rejoice and praise with hallelujahs (vv. 1, 3, 6), and the twenty-four elders and the four living creatures join them in praising God (v. 4).

What an exciting event is recorded in these verses! At that time we shall have witnessed the destruction of the prostitute, we shall have passed the judgment at the judgment seat, and we shall be at the wedding. Hallelujah! How marvelous! I expect to be there, and I am eagerly waiting for that day.

Verse 6 describes the voice of the great multitude “as the sound of many waters, and as the sound of mighty thunders.” The praise as the sound of many waters proceeds continually, and as the sound of mighty thunders it displays solemnity.

B. The readiness of the Bride

Now we come to a very crucial matter, the matter of the readiness of the Bride. Verse 7 says, “Let us rejoice and exult, and let us give the glory to Him, for the marriage of the Lamb is come, and His wife has made herself ready.” “His wife” refers to the church (Eph. 5:24-25, 31-32), the Bride of Christ (John 3:29). However, according to verses 8 and 9, the wife, the Bride of Christ, here consists only of the overcoming believers during the millennium; whereas the Bride, the wife, in 21:2 is composed of all the saved saints after the millennium for eternity. The readiness of the Bride depends upon the maturity in life of the overcomers. Furthermore, the overcomers are not separate individuals, but a corporate Bride. For this aspect, building is needed. They are not only mature in life, but are also builded together as one Bride.

1. Christ lived out of the saints as their subjective righteousness

Verse 8 says, “And it was given to her that she should be clothed in fine linen, bright and pure; for the fine linen is the righteousnesses of the saints.” The word pure (or clean) refers to the nature; whereas bright refers to the expression. The Greek word translated righteousnesses may also be rendered righteous acts. The righteousnesses do not refer to the righteousness (which is Christ) we receive for our salvation (1 Cor. 1:30). The righteousness we receive for our salvation is objective, that we may meet the requirement of the righteous God; whereas the righteousnesses of the overcoming saints here are subjective (Phil. 3:9), that they may meet the requirement of the overcoming Christ. Hence, the fine linen indicates our overcoming life, our overcoming living. It is the very Christ whom we live out of our being.

2. The wedding garment in Matthew 22

According to the revelation of the whole Bible, we, the saved ones, need two garments — one for our salvation and one for our reward. For our salvation we need a robe to cover us. This robe is the robe put on the prodigal son in Luke 15. Upon his return, the prodigal son said to his father, “Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you; I am no longer worthy to be called your son” (Luke 15:21). He thought himself unworthy to be in the presence of the father. But the father said to his servants, “Quickly bring out the best robe and put it on him” (Luke 15:22). This robe is Christ as our righteousness. It is for us to be justified by God in His presence. We all have this robe, the first robe, which is Christ as our righteousness, our justification, that enables us to stand before the righteous God.

However, we also need the second garment, which is the wedding garment in Matthew 22:11 and 12. This garment is not for our salvation; rather, it is for our reward, qualifying us to attend the wedding feast of the Son of God. The first garment qualifies us to meet God for our salvation. The second garment qualifies us to meet Christ for our reward. The second garment is the work of the Holy Spirit within us. It is actually the very Christ by whom we live and whom we live out. It is the Christ expressed through us in our daily living. This is the righteousnesses of the saints in verse 8.

The second garment is also the righteousness spoken of in Matt. 5:20. In this verse the Lord Jesus said, “For I say to you, that unless your righteousness surpass that of the scribes and Pharisees, you shall by no means enter into the kingdom of the heavens.” This is a weighty word, and few Christians understand it. This verse clearly indicates that we must have a righteousness that surpasses the righteousness of the Pharisees. This righteousness is not the objective Christ we receive as our robe for our justification. Rather, it is the subjective Christ whom we live out as our daily living. It is not the justifying robe; it is the garment that qualifies us to receive the reward.

The wedding garment in Matt. 22:11-12 illustrates this. In this parable the Lord speaks of a man who comes into the wedding feast without a wedding garment. When the king sees him, the king says, “Friend, how did you come in here not having a marriage garment?” The guest is speechless. Then the king says to his servants, “Bind his feet and hands, and cast him out into the outer darkness; there shall be the weeping and the gnashing of teeth” (Matt. 22:13). The wedding garment is not the justifying garment; it is a very special garment. According to the custom of the ancient Jews, no one could attend a wedding feast without a special wedding garment. If we would be in the wedding feast of the Lamb, we must be clothed with such a garment. If you would be qualified to attend the wedding feast of Christ, you need to live by Christ and to live Him out in your daily living. This Christ, the subjective Christ, will be the wedding garment to qualify you to be admitted into the wedding feast. Therefore, we need both the justifying garment and the wedding garment.

The second garment is referred to in Rev. 3:4, 5, 18. In 3:4 and 5 the Lord told the church in Sardis that those who have not defiled their garments will walk with Him in white and that the overcomers will be “clothed in white garments.” This is the garment for the wedding feast. In 3:18 the Lord advised the church in Laodicea to buy from Him “white garments.” Thus, in the book of Revelation the matter of the second garment is stressed. If we do not have it, we shall miss the wedding feast.

3. The raiment of embroidery in Psalm 45

These two garments are also seen in Ps. 45. In this psalm the queen has two garments (Psa. 45:13-14): one corresponds to the objective righteousness for our salvation and the other to the subjective righteousness for our victory. The latter is equivalent to the wedding garment in Matt. 22:11-12. The queen in Psalm 45 signifies the church. Her first garment is of “wrought gold,” and her second is “raiment of embroidery” (Heb.). In the Bible gold signifies the divine nature of God. At the time of our salvation we received a golden garment that enabled us to be in the presence of God. In addition to this, we need another garment, a garment of embroidery. This embroidery signifies the transforming work of the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit today is working on us to transform us just like an embroiderer puts many stitches into cloth. Although we have the first garment, our second garment is now being prepared under the embroidering work of the Holy Spirit. This garment will qualify us to see Christ at His judgment seat. Day by day we are under the needle, the transformation, of the Holy Spirit. How we need this second garment! This is a serious matter.

However serious this matter may be, most Christians only care for the first garment. Some even say, “As long as we are justified, redeemed, and saved, everything is all right.” Do not listen to this. You may be all right as far as salvation is concerned, but what about the reward? You not only need justification — you also need approval. When you appear before the judgment seat of Christ, will He approve of you? Matt. 22:14 says very clearly that some will be chosen and not others. Only those who have the second garment produced by the embroidering work of the Holy Spirit will be chosen and qualified to attend the wedding feast of the Lamb.

C. Bringing in the reign of the Lord

In verse 6 the voice of the great multitude proclaims, “Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns!” The reign of God, the kingdom, is related to the marriage of the Lamb, and the marriage of the Lamb is the issue of the completion of God’s New Testament economy. God’s economy in the New Testament is to obtain for Christ the Bride, the church, through His redemption and divine life. By the continual working of the Holy Spirit through all the centuries, this goal will be attained at the end of this age. Then the Bride with the overcoming believers will be ready. Simultaneously, the kingdom of God will come. This corresponds to the Lord’s prophecy in Matthew 26:29.

The wedding will bring in the reign of the Lord, the kingdom, because all the guests invited to the wedding will be both the corporate Bride and the co-kings of the Groom. The Bridegroom, who will take the whole earth as His kingdom, certainly needs many sub-kings to be His co-kings. All His co-kings will be His corporate Bride.

I am not certain how long the wedding feast will last. The wedding itself, which will take place in the air, will last a short time. After the wedding, there will be the wedding feast. A wedding feast is always much longer than the wedding. Although I believe that the wedding feast will last a thousand years, the Bible does not give us the ground to say this with full assurance. To the Lord, a thousand years are as one day (2 Pet. 3:8). Matthew 22 indicates that the wedding feast will be the millennial kingdom. To us, the thousand years of the millennial kingdom will be a wedding feast. Everyone invited to the wedding feast will also participate in the thousand-year reign as kings. Our King will be the Groom; we, His co-kings, will be His Bride; and the thousand years will be our honeymoon. Christ’s thousand-year reign will be our feast.

I am quite certain that many Christians will not receive the reward of reigning with Christ in the coming kingdom. Although you may be saved, you must become an overcomer in order to receive the kingdom as your reward. For the overcomers, reigning with Christ in His kingdom will be the wedding feast.

V. The marriage dinner of the Lamb

Verse 9 says, “And he said to me, Write, Blessed are they who are invited to the marriage dinner of the Lamb. And he said to me, These are the true words of God.” The marriage dinner of the Lamb here is the wedding feast in Matthew 22:2 (Gk.). It will be a reward to the overcoming believers. Only the overcomers will be invited to it, not all the saved ones. The five foolish virgins in Matthew 25:8-13 will miss it. However, after being dealt with by the Lord in the kingdom age, they will participate in the New Jerusalem for eternity. Hence, to be invited to the wedding feast of Christ, which will usher the overcoming believers into the enjoyment of the millennium, is to be blessed. The overcoming believers invited to the marriage dinner of the Lamb will also be the Bride of the Lamb. The blessing referred to in verse 9 is the blessing of participating in the millennium.

Matthew 22:14 says, “For many are called but few are chosen,” and Revelation 17:14 says, “They who are with Him are called and chosen and faithful.” To be called is one thing, and to be chosen is another. Those who will follow the Lord to fight against Antichrist will not only be called, but also chosen. Although we have the assurance that we have been called, we do not yet have the assurance that we shall be chosen. This will be decided at the judgment seat of Christ. After we have been raptured, we shall stand before the Lord at the judgment seat, and He will decide whether or not we are qualified to be chosen. Only those who are chosen will be invited to the marriage feast of the Lamb.

VI. A testimony of Jesus

Verse 10 says, “And I fell before his feet to worship him. And he said to me, Don’t do that! I am a fellow-slave of yours and of your brothers who have the testimony of Jesus. Worship God! For the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of the prophecy.” This verse indicates that the Bride, the invited guests, are the testimony of Jesus. Although the church today should be the testimony of Jesus, some among us are below the standard of the testimony of Jesus. However, at the time of verse 10 all the invited overcomers will be fully up to this standard. After the Lord has gained His Bride, He will be able to boast to Satan and to the whole universe, saying, “This Bride is My testimony.”

Verse 10 says that the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of the prophecy. The entire book of Revelation has a spirit, and this spirit is the testimony of Jesus. The spirit of the prophecy is the reality, substance, disposition, characteristic, of the prophecy. Thus, the testimony of Jesus is the reality, substance, disposition, characteristic, of the prophecy of this book. Today, the testimony of Jesus is the church. However, not all the members of the church have reached the Lord’s standard. Therefore, the Lord must wait until He has the Bride before He can declare to Satan, “This is My testimony. It is perfect and complete to the uttermost.” Hence, the Bride is the reality, the substance, and the element of the prophecy of the book of Revelation. This book is for the church life, for the Bride.

The War at Armageddon

In this message we come to the war at Armageddon (Rev. 19:11-21). After His wedding feast, Christ will come as a fighting General with His Bride, the overcoming believers who are His army, to fight Antichrist, the kings under him, and their armies at Armageddon. Although the third party, the great prostitute, will have been annihilated, the Lord will still have three enemies: Satan, the dragon; Antichrist, the beast out of the sea; and the false prophet, the beast out of the land. These three will continue to oppose Him. Under the instigation of Antichrist, man will even wage war directly against the Lord of lords and the King of kings. Antichrist, the false prophet, and the ten kings and their armies will make war against the Lamb. How terrible! If this were not recorded in the Bible, I would not be able to believe that man could actually declare war on God.

In 19:11-21 we see that the Bridegroom comes to fight against His enemies with the help of His Bride. The Bridegroom is the Commander-in-chief, and the Bride is the army. What a honeymoon this will be! During His honeymoon Christ will clear up the universe. Antichrist and the false prophet will be cast into the lake of fire, and Satan will be bound and cast into the abyss. At that time Christ will be happy, and we, His Bride, shall also be happy as we enjoy a wonderful honeymoon with our Bridegroom.

Before the war at Armageddon, a number of important events will take place within a short period of time. These events will include the raptures of the firstfruit, the man-child, the late overcomers, the majority of the saints, and the gleanings; the destruction of Catholicism and the termination of Judaism; the judgment at the judgment seat of Christ in the air to determine who will be qualified to be the Bride during the millennium, to attend the wedding feast, and to fight with Christ against the enemy; the wedding in the air; and possibly the destruction of material Babylon. After all these things have been completed, one more thing will still remain — the war at Armageddon. Christ's enemies will become all the more evil, even declaring war against Him. Therefore, Christ, the Bridegroom, will come with His Bride to fight against them.

I. After the marriage of the Lamb

In chapter nineteen the wedding and the war are put together. We may even entitle this chapter, "The Wedding and the War." Immediately after the wedding, Christ will come to fight against the enemy. He will not wait even one day.

II. Before the millennium

The war at Armageddon will remove all the obstacles to the coming millennial kingdom. Before we can have a feast, we must clean up the feasting room. The entire universe will be the feasting room, and Christ and His Bride will work together to sweep away the dirt, which will be put into the "trash can," the lake of fire. God's sweeping in the universe began in Genesis chapter one. Firstly, God swept the dirt into the sea (Gen. 1:2); for at that time the sea was the "trash can" in this universe. Eventually, all the dirt will be put in the ultimate "trash can," the lake of fire. In Matthew 25:41 the Lord Jesus says, "Go from Me, you who are cursed, into the eternal fire prepared for the Devil and his angels." Because the "goats" followed the Devil, they will be cast into the lake of fire prepared for him and his angels. God has prepared the lake of fire as a "trash can" to dispose of all the trash in the universe. Antichrist, the false prophet, and their armies will be swept into the "dust pan" and then dumped into the lake of fire. After the millennium, Satan himself will join them there. After the judgment at the great white throne, all the dead unbelievers will also be cast into the lake of fire. From that time onward, there will be no more dust. In the New Jerusalem, there will be no dust; there will be only gold, pearl, and precious stones. The Lord's fighting in the war at Armageddon will actually be a sweeping of dirt into the universal "trash can." The Lord may say to Antichrist, "What are you doing here? Have you declared war on Me? This gives Me the perfect opportunity to sweep you away. My Bride will cooperate with me in doing this."

Praise the Lord that we are not trash — we are a treasure! Instead of being cast into the lake of fire, we shall be gathered into the New Jerusalem. In order for the Lord to enjoy a pleasant honeymoon and the thousand-year kingdom, all the trash must be swept away. I am looking forward to participating in this cleaning work. How pleasant it will be!

III. The warrior

A. Riding on a white horse

Verse 11 says, "And I saw heaven opened, and behold, a white horse, and He who sits on it called Faithful and True, and in righteousness He judges and makes war." Here Christ, the Bridegroom as the Commander-in-chief, appears riding on a white horse. The horse of the first seal is also white and signifies the preaching of the gospel (6:2). Thus, both Christ and the gospel ride on a white horse. In the book of Revelation, white indicates being pure, bright, justified, and approved. This is vastly different from what is indicated by the colors of the other three horses in chapter six — red, black, and pale green. Even today we are riding on this white horse. Our preaching of the gospel is pure, bright, justified, and absolutely approved by the Lord. Christ will ride on this horse as He fights against His enemy.

B. Called faithful and true

In verse 11 Christ is called "Faithful and True." Christ is faithful both to God and to those who believe in Him. In His faithfulness He defeats and destroys those who oppose God and persecute the believers. He is true in carrying out God's economy and in caring for those who believe in Him. He is trustworthy, and with Him there is no falsehood.

C. Judging and fighting in righteousness

Verse 11 also says, "In righteousness He judges and makes war." Christ will judge and fight in righteousness. He judges by fighting. It is true even today that no wrongdoers would accept the judgments of our courts if the government had no police force to back up these judgments. Judgment can only be executed by police power. When Christ comes to judge Antichrist, Antichrist will be utterly rebellious. Thus, there will be the need for Christ to fight to subdue this rebellion and to judge these rebels in righteousness. His judging by fighting is not only according to righteousness; it is also to maintain righteousness.

D. With eyes like a flame of fire

Verse 12 says, "And His eyes are a flame of fire." This signifies Christ's judging eyes. He will judge according to what He sees. His flaming eyes will carry out His judgment.

E. Crowned with many diadems

As the Warrior, Christ has many diadems on His head (v. 12). Every diadem is a kind of glory. Christ is crowned and glorified. Because He has been crowned with many kinds of glories (Heb. 2:9), He wears many diadems.

F. Having a name written, known only to Himself

As the One on the white horse, the Lord has "a name written which no one knows but Himself" (v. 12). The experience of Christ can never be exhausted. When we experience Him, we come to know a particular aspect of Him. However, there are certain aspects of Christ that will not be experienced by us. Only He Himself knows what these aspects are. This indicates that the Christ whom we experience is inexhaustible. Because we have experienced His redemption, we know Him as the Redeemer. Because we have experienced Him as light, life, manna, power, strength, holiness, and comfort, we know Him in all these aspects. We have experienced so many items of Christ's riches. But because there are some items which we have not experienced, He still has a name known only to Himself. Therefore, we do not know this name. No matter how much we have experienced Christ, there is still something about Him unknown to us because we have not experienced it.

G. With a garment dipped in blood

Verse 13 says, "And He is clothed with a garment dipped in blood." The garment of Christ is dipped in blood and becomes red by His treading the winepress of the wine of the fury of the wrath of God (v. 15; Isa. 63:1-3) at Armageddon (16:14, 16), where the blood will rise up to the bridles of the horses (14:20).

H. His name being called the Word of God

Verse 13 also says, "His name is called The Word of God." The Word of God is the definition, the explanation, and the expression of God. As the Word of God, Christ speaks for God not only by imparting life as grace to God's chosen people in the Gospel of John (John 1:1, 4, 14), but also by executing God's judgment upon the rebellious people in the Revelation of John. Even as the Lord fights, He speaks for God and expresses God. The fighting of Christ is the speaking of the Word of God. God is righteous and sovereign. He is also a God of order and He cannot tolerate disorder and rebellion. As Christ fights against the enemy, He will speak that God is sovereign, righteous, and orderly. He will declare that God is the God over everyone and that He does not tolerate rebellion against His authority. Hence, the Warrior is the Word. His fighting is the speaking of God's Word.

Suppose I come into the meeting hall and find everything is in a mess. Without saying a word, I begin to clean up the hall. My act of cleaning says that I am a neat person and that I cannot tolerate a messy environment. There is no need for me to say anything, because my cleaning speaks for me. Likewise, the Lord's fighting in the war at Armageddon will be a powerful speaking. It will tell Satan, Antichrist, the false prophet, and the entire universe that God is sovereign and that no one can rebel against Him. God is a God of order and He will sweep away all rebellion.

The Word of God is mentioned both in the Gospel of John (1:1) and in the Revelation of John. In the Gospel of John the Word of God does not speak anything related to fighting; rather, He speaks redemption, light, life, and building. In the Gospel of John the Word of God speaks life and building. In the Revelation of John the Word of God speaks not only life and building, but also fighting. Before God can have the building He desires, He must first clean up His universe. In this book Christ's fighting is also His speaking for God. As the Word of God, His fighting proclaims to the whole universe what kind of God He is. God is not a God of confusion — He is the sovereign God, a God of order who does not tolerate rebellion. By His fighting Christ declares this to the universe.

I. Out of His mouth proceeding a sharp sword

Verse 15 says, "And out of His mouth proceeds a sharp sword, that with it He might smite the nations." The sword, which proceeds out of the mouth of Christ, who is the Word of God, is the word which will judge the rebellious (John 12:48). When the Lord Jesus comes to fight against Antichrist, He will not need nuclear weapons. He will simply need to speak a word. If He were to say, "Antichrist, go to the lake of fire," Antichrist would immediately be cast there. The Lord's word is more powerful than a nuclear weapon. As the Lord is speaking, we who follow Him shall say "Amen." When the Lord says, "Antichrist, go to the lake of fire," we all shall say "Amen," and Antichrist will immediately be cast into the lake of fire. This is the Lord's way of fighting. Undoubtedly, Antichrist will use the most modern weapons, but Christ will defeat him with the sharp sword, the almighty word that proceeds out of His mouth.

J. Shepherding the nations with an iron rod

The Lord will not only smite the nations; He will also shepherd them with an iron rod (v. 15). To shepherd here means to rule, and the iron rod signifies strong power. Christ will firstly smite the nations with His judging word; then He will shepherd those who remain with His strong power. His ruling with strong power is His shepherding. He will rule over the nations by shepherding them. Today, the elders shepherd the church with love, not with a rod of iron. However, because the nations will still have the rebellious human nature, the Lord will shepherd them during the millennium with an iron rod. That the nations will still have a rebellious nature is proved by the fact that they will follow Satan to make war against Christ at the end of the millennium (20:7-9).

K. Treading the winepress of the wrath of God

Verse 15 also says, "And He treads the winepress of the wine of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty." The Lord's fighting in the war at Armageddon will be the treading of the great winepress. All the grapes, the Gentile military forces, will be gathered into the winepress and will be trodden by the Lord Jesus.

L. The name, King of kings and Lord of lords, written on His garment and on His thigh

Verse 16 says, "And He has on His garment and on His thigh a name written, King of kings and Lord of lords." The fact that Christ is King of kings and Lord of lords will no longer be hidden or mysterious. This name will be written upon His garment and upon His thigh; hence, it will be openly revealed and known by all. The garment signifies Christ's attributes, especially His righteousness in His humanity. And the thigh signifies Christ's standing strength, His stability. His title King of kings and Lord of lords is exhibited in His righteousness and stability.

IV. The armies

Verse 14 says, "And the armies which are in heaven followed Him on white horses, dressed in fine linen, white and pure." The armies here are the called and chosen believers in 17:14. They are also both the Bride and the guests invited to the marriage dinner of the Lamb (vv. 7-9). The guests invited to the wedding feast and the Bride are the same. The Bride consists of the invited guests, and the invited guests make up the Bride. After the wedding, all the guests will become the army.

Verse 14 says that the armies are dressed in fine linen, white and pure. In the previous message we saw that the overcoming saints have two garments, the one for salvation and the other for reward. The fine linen here is the second garment. This second garment of the overcomers qualifies them both to attend the marriage dinner of the Lamb (vv. 8-9) and to fight with the Lord against His enemy. Thus, the wedding garment becomes the fighting garment. The second garment qualifies us not only to attend the wedding, but also to join the army. As we have seen, this garment is Christ lived out of us to be our daily righteousness. Even today, we are fighting by Christ as our garment. Ephesians 6 indicates that the whole armor of God is Christ. Furthermore, the Lord's army will be on white horses. We shall not be guerrillas; we shall be a properly formed heavenly army. Hallelujah!

V. The great dinner of God

According to verses 17 and 18, an angel will cry out with a loud voice and say to all the birds that fly in mid-heaven, "Come, gather yourselves to the great dinner of God," and the birds will eat the flesh of kings, captains, mighty men, horses, those who sit on the horses, and the flesh of all, both free and slaves, small and great. The Lord's fighting in the war at Armageddon will prepare a great dinner for all the birds. The great dinner of God is in contrast to the marriage dinner of the Lamb. The latter is for the invited overcomers; the former is for the invited birds. Although the birds will feast on the flesh of kings, they will not eat Antichrist and the false prophet, because they will be cast into the lake of fire.

VI. The enemies

In verse 19 we see the Lord's enemies. This verse says, "And I saw the beast and the kings of the earth and their armies gathered together to make war with Him who sits on the horse and with His army." According to this verse, Christ's enemies are the beast, Antichrist (undoubtedly including his associate, the false prophet), and the kings of the earth and their armies. The kings of the earth (16:12-16) especially include the ten kings under Antichrist (17:12-14), and the armies include the two hundred million cavalry troops from "the rising of the sun" (9:16; 16:12).

VII. The defeat of antichrist and his armies

In verses 20 and 21 we see the defeat of Antichrist and his armies. Verse 20 says, "And the beast was seized, and with him the false prophet who in his presence had done the signs, by which he deceived those who received the mark of the beast and those who worship his image. These two were cast alive into the lake of fire which burns with brimstone." Antichrist and the false prophet will be the first to perish in the lake of fire. All the rest will be killed "with the sword which proceeds out of the mouth of Him who sits on the horse" (v. 21), and all the birds will be gorged with their flesh, devouring a great meal.

VIII. The war at the valley of Jehoshaphat

The war mentioned in this chapter is the war at the valley of Jehoshaphat (Joel 3:9-12; Zech. 14:2-3, 12-15). This will be very close to Jerusalem (message forty-eight, p. 560).

IX. The treading of the great winepress

The fighting of Christ in the war at Armageddon will be the treading of the great winepress. That will be the judgment on all the evil forces of the world, the death blow to all of them.

We need to view today's world situation in the light of the prophecy concerning the coming war at Armageddon. When I first studied these prophecies fifty years ago, the world situation was much different from today. At that time the nation of Israel had not been formed again, Jerusalem had not been returned to the Jews, and hardly anyone paid attention to the Middle East. After World War II, the nation of Israel was formed again in 1948, and people's attention began to focus on the Middle East. As I read about the re-forming of Israel in the newspapers, I was surprised and thrilled. In 1967, I was excited to hear the news that Jerusalem had been returned to the Jews. Today the Middle East is the center of the world situation.

The Soviet Union is secretly doing everything possible to defeat Israel. As we shall see in another message, this is according to the prophecies in Ezekiel 38 and 39. These chapters reveal that the Soviet Union will take the lead to destroy Israel. All the Arab countries surrounding Israel are plotting against her. Not one nation in the Middle East is for Israel. Almost everything is ready for the war at Armageddon. The European situation, however, is still ambiguous. But sooner or later something will take place there; for both in Europe and in the Middle East people are seeking a strong leader.

The Jews are also seeking the opportunity to rebuild the temple. Presently, the site of the temple is occupied by a Moslem mosque, their second most important religious shrine. The temple site is the exact spot where Abraham offered Isaac. Not very far from this mosque is the wailing wall, the only portion of the temple that still remains. We are eagerly expecting the return of the site of the temple so that the temple may be rebuilt. I believe that in not too long a time the site will be returned.

Today's world situation is without precedent. Even the problem over oil may be used by the Lord for the fulfillment of prophecy related to the war of Armageddon. Near the time of the war at Armageddon, two thirds of the Jews will be slaughtered. The one third that survives will be tested by fire and preserved (Zech. 13:8-9). At that juncture, the Lord will come down from heaven and put His feet on the Mount of Olives (Zech. 14:4). The Mount of Olives will split in two, and a valley will be produced into which the persecuted Jews will flee. Perhaps a great earthquake will occur at that time. According to Zechariah 14, the armies of Antichrist will be destroyed. "Their flesh shall consume away while they stand upon their feet, and their eyes shall consume away in their holes, and their tongue shall consume away in their mouth" (Zech. 14:12).

The Bible reveals the destiny of the nation of Israel. Because so many Israelites are still in unbelief, before the Lord comes back Jerusalem will be like Sodom in the eyes of God (11:18). Therefore, God will use Antichrist and the ten kings with their armies to purge and to purify the nation of Israel. Those who remain will be preserved by God for the millennial kingdom. As Isaiah 2:2-3 and Zechariah 8:20-23 clearly reveal, in the kingdom the saved and preserved Jews will be priests teaching the nations to know God and to serve Him.

The Millennial Kingdom

In this message we come to the millennial kingdom. In the Old Testament there are many verses concerning the millennial kingdom (Psa. 2:6, 8-9; Isa. 2:2-5; 11:1-10; 65:20-25; 30:26; Zech. 8:20-23; Psa. 72:1-17; Isa. 4:2-6; 9:7; 12:1-5; 16:5; 32:1-2; 40:9-11; 61:4-9; Zech. 14:16-21). The kingdom was the good news proclaimed to mankind through the prophets in the Old Testament.

Between the rapture of the overcomers and the beginning of the millennial kingdom, many things will take place. Immediately after the rapture of the man-child, a loud voice in heaven says, “Now is come the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God and the authority of His Christ” (12:10). Actually, however, the kingdom will not come at that time, for the three and a half years of the great tribulation are yet to come. Nevertheless, in the eyes of those who have been raptured to the heavens, the kingdom has already come. During the last three and a half years of this age, the following things will take place: the rapture of the majority of the saints; the destruction of religious Babylon, that is, the annihilation of Catholicism; the destruction of Judaism; and the fall of material Babylon. Following all this, there will be the war at Armageddon. The whole earth must be cleared up as a preparation for God’s kingdom to come. At the time of chapter twenty, nearly everything has been cleared up. Only one thing remains, and that is Satan, the source of all the problems. Therefore, the first item mentioned in chapter twenty, a chapter concerning the millennium, is the binding of Satan.

I. The imprisonment of Satan

In Rev. 20:1-3 we see the imprisonment of Satan. Following the defeat of Antichrist is the binding and imprisonment of Satan to clear up the rebellious earth that the kingdom of Christ may come (Rev. 20:4-6). Satan will be bound and cast into the abyss, which is in the heart of the earth. Satan will be imprisoned there for a thousand years. After that, “he must be loosed for a little time” (v. 3). The Lord Jesus will cast Antichrist and the false prophet directly into the lake of fire because He has no further use for them. However, even after the war at Armageddon, Satan will still be somewhat useful to the Lord.

After the war at Armageddon, the Lord will establish His throne of glory in Jerusalem and gather before Him all the nations still on earth. He will then execute His judgment upon them. As we have pointed out, this will be Christ’s judgment of the living carried out according to the eternal gospel preached by an angel in mid-heaven (Rev. 14:6). The “goats” will go to the fire prepared for the Devil and his angels, and the “sheep” will enter into the millennial kingdom as citizens (Matt. 25:34). Although these “sheep” will be restored, they will not be regenerated. They will still have a rebellious nature within them, and thus they will need a further test a thousand years later. Because the Lord will use Satan to test them, He will not cast Satan into the lake of fire at the beginning of the millennium. Rather, Satan will be kept in the abyss for a thousand years. When the thousand years are over, the Lord will release Satan from the abyss and use him to test the citizens who have been on earth during the millennium. In the next message we shall see that Gog and Magog, the Russians, will not pass the test. Under Satan’s instigation, they will once more rebel against God. In this we can see that Satan is still useful in God’s hands to purge mankind.

II. The millennium

Acts 3:21 refers to “the times of restoration of all things, which God hath spoken by the mouth of all his holy prophets since the world began” (Gk.). This restoration will affect not only man, but also the whole creation — the heavens, the earth, the animals, and even the trees. Everything that was cursed through the fall of man will be restored. Isaiah 30:26 says, “Moreover the light of the moon shall be as the light of the sun, and the light of the sun shall be sevenfold, as the light of seven days.” Today the sun and the moon are not normal because they have been cursed through the rebellion of Satan and the fall of man. As Genesis 3:17 and 18 indicate, the earth has been cursed because of man’s fall. Thus, the earth today is not normal.

When the children of Israel were about to enter into the good land, a land flowing with milk and honey, Moses sent twelve spies to search out the land (Num. 13:1-2). These spies brought back a cluster of grapes so large that it took two men to carry it (Num. 13:23). In 1958 I visited that region and I purposely tried to learn what kind of grapes those were. The guide brought me a cluster of tiny grapes. When I asked why they were so small, I was told that there was no fertile soil and very little rain. Throughout the centuries, the wind has blown away all the topsoil. For this reason, hardly anything can grow there. According to the prophecies in Deuteronomy, this land has been cursed because of the sinfulness of the children of Israel. Therefore, the land has become abnormal. Likewise, the entire universe is abnormal. However, when the millennium comes, everything will be restored.

There are many prophecies in Isaiah, in Zechariah, and in the Psalms regarding the millennium. At the time of restoration, not only mankind but also all of creation will be restored to its original condition. The beasts and the cattle will be restored to such an extent that the “wolf also shall dwell with the lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the kid” (Isa. 11:6). This will not be miraculous; rather, it will be normal and common. Isaiah 11:8 says, “And the sucking child shall play on the hole of the asp, and the weaned child shall put his hand on the viper’s den” (Heb.). Even the troublesome mosquitoes will be included in the restoration. When a mosquito bites me, I am reminded that the mosquitoes need restoration. After they have been restored, they will make musical sounds, but they will not bite. Do not hate creatures such as mosquitoes, flies, and gophers. Instead, you must blame Adam, for his fall brought about the curse on the creation. But when Christ comes again, everything will be restored. The trees will flourish, and the flowers will blossom abundantly. Isaiah 35:1 and 2 say, “The desert shall rejoice, and blossom as the rose. It shall blossom abundantly, and rejoice even with joy and singing.” Furthermore, “in the wilderness shall waters break out, and streams in the desert. And the parched ground shall become a pool, and the thirsty land springs of water” (Isa. 35:6-7). Also, “a highway shall be there, and a way, and it shall be called The Way of Holiness” (Isa. 35:8). The book of Isaiah is a full description of the millennium.

According to the prophecies of the Bible, the millennial kingdom is in two sections: the upper, heavenly, section and the lower, earthly, section. The upper section of the millennium is called the kingdom of the Father (Matt. 13:43), and the lower section is called the kingdom of the Son of Man (Matt. 13:41). The kingdom of the Messiah, or the Messianic kingdom, is another name for the lower section of the millennium.

In the millennial kingdom there will be three peoples. The first are the overcoming saints, including the overcoming saints of both the Old Testament and the New Testament. These overcoming saints will be co-kings of Christ. Christ is the highest King, and we shall be His sub-kings. Therefore, the upper section is the royal portion of the millennium.

The second group, found in the lower section, is the preserved and proper Jews, who will be saved at the time of the Lord’s coming back. According to Zechariah 12:10-14, these Jews will look on Him whom they have pierced, and then they will repent. These are the Jews who will be the third part who will pass through fire and be refined (Zech. 13:9). These saved Jews will enter into the millennium as priests and will teach the nations to seek God and to know Him. Isaiah 2:2-3 will be fulfilled at that time. Verse 3 says, “And many people shall go and say, Come ye, and let us go up to the mountain of the Lord, to the house of the God of Jacob; and he will teach us of his ways, and we will walk in his paths: for out of Zion shall go forth the law, and the word of the Lord from Jerusalem.” The nations will learn of God through the instruction of the Jews, who will be priests. Isaiah 61:6 clearly says, “But ye shall be named the Priests of the Lord: men shall call you the Ministers of our God.” This word will also be fulfilled during the millennium, when the nations will recognize the Jews as God’s priests.

Zechariah 8:23 says, “Thus saith the Lord of hosts; In those days it shall come to pass, that ten men shall take hold out of all languages of the nations, even shall take hold of the skirt of him that is a Jew, saying, We will go with you: for we have heard that God is with you.” This verse indicates that every Jew will be precious. At that time the number of the saved Jews will be so small that ten people out of one nation will take hold of a Jew and say, “Help us to know God. We want to be taught by you because we have heard that God has blessed you. We want to share your blessing. Tell us about God and teach us how to worship Him.” In those days the Jews will be warmly welcomed.

The third group of people in the millennial kingdom will be the “sheep” of Matthew 25. We have seen that these “sheep” will be transferred into the millennial kingdom to become the citizens there.

In the lower section of the millennium, called the kingdom of the Son of Man, Jesus as the seed of David will be King over the Jews and, through the Jews, over all the nations. He will be on the throne of David to be the King over all nations through the Jews. This is the kingdom of the Son of Man and the kingdom of the Messiah; it is also the tabernacle of David spoken of in Acts 15:16. The tabernacle of David has fallen. But when the millennium comes, Christ will again erect the tabernacle of David. The tabernacle of David is the kingdom of David. In 2 Samuel 7 God promised to establish David’s kingdom forever (v. 16). This everlasting kingdom will be the lower part of the millennium, the kingdom of the Son of Man and of the Messiah. The kingly overcomers will be in the upper part of the millennium, and the priestly Jews and the citizens will be in the lower part.

It is a great help to be clear about these matters. If you understand them, then as you read the Bible, you will know which verses refer to the upper part and which verses to the lower part. You will know which verses refer to the kings, which to the priests, and which to the nations.

A. The thrones and the judgments

Revelation 20:4 says, “And I saw thrones, and they sat upon them, and judgment was given to them.” The word they refers to the overcomers. They are now sitting upon thrones, and authority to judge has been given to them. To have the authority to judge means to have the kingdom (cf. Dan. 7:10, 18, 22). Therefore, this verse indicates that the overcomers have received the kingdom and are enjoying it.

B. The overcoming believers being the co-kings of Christ for a thousand years

Verse 4 also says, “And I saw the souls of those who had been beheaded because of the testimony of Jesus and because of the word of God, and who did not worship the beast nor his image, and did not receive the mark on their forehead and on their hand; and they lived and reigned with Christ a thousand years.” Those who have been “beheaded because of the testimony of Jesus and because of the word of God” are the martyrs throughout the church age, as mentioned in 6:9. Undoubtedly, Peter, Paul, James, Stephen, and the many others slain throughout the centuries will be included in this number. These saints, martyred for the testimony of Jesus and for the word of God, will be resurrected to be co-kings of Christ.

The martyrs in the great tribulation are those who do not worship the beast nor his image and do not receive the mark on their forehead or on their hand. After the rapture of the overcomers, many saints will be martyred because they refuse to worship Antichrist or to receive his mark on their forehead or on their hand. These martyred saints will also be resurrected to be co-kings in the millennial kingdom.

In principle, these co-kings must also include the raptured living overcomers. If those in the man-child will be among the co-kings, then certainly those making up the firstfruit will be also.

In both Matthew 25:21 and 23 the Lord said, “Well done, good and faithful slave; you were faithful over a few things, I will set you over many things; enter into the joy of your lord.” These verses refer to the enjoyment of the overcomers in the millennial kingdom. To the diligent servant the Lord will say, “Well done! Come into the joy of your Lord. I have some things I want you to rule over.” This will be the enjoyment of the overcoming believers in the millennial kingdom.

C. The first resurrection

1. The best resurrection

The overcomers will enjoy the best resurrection. Verse 6 speaks of “the first resurrection.” The Greek word translated first is the same word translated best in Luke 15:22, where the father said in relation to the returned prodigal, “Bring out the best robe and put it on him.” Hence, the first resurrection in verse 6 may actually be translated “the best resurrection.” The overcomers will enjoy this resurrection.

2. The ex-resurrection

The first resurrection is also the ex-resurrection, that is, the extraordinary resurrection which the apostle Paul sought for (Phil. 3:11). The Greek word may be translated as “the out-resurrection.” This means that it is the resurrection set apart from the common resurrection, the resurrection with honor, comparable to graduation with honors. This resurrection is a resurrection of kingship as a reward to the overcomers that they may reign as co-kings with Christ in the millennial kingdom. Hence, “Blessed is he who has part in the first resurrection” (20:6). Not only the resurrected overcomers, such as the man-child in 12:5 and the later martyrs in 15:2, but also the raptured living ones, such as the firstfruit in 14:1-5, have part in this resurrection.

3. The resurrection of life

When I was young, I thought that only believers would be resurrected and that unbelievers would not be resurrected. It seemed to me that resurrection was a special blessing granted to the believers. Eventually I learned that the unbelievers will also be resurrected. John 5:29 speaks of “the resurrection of life” and “the resurrection of judgment.” The resurrection of life is the resurrection of the saved believers before the millennium, and the resurrection of judgment is the resurrection of the unsaved after the millennium. The dead believers will be resurrected to enjoy eternal life at the coming back of the Lord Jesus. Hence, their resurrection is called the resurrection of life. But all the dead unbelievers will be resurrected after the thousand years to be judged at the great white throne (20:11-15). Hence, their resurrection is called the resurrection of judgment.

4. The resurrection of reward

The first resurrection will also be the resurrection of reward. Luke 14:14 says, “And you will be blessed, because they do not have anything with which to repay you; for it will be repaid to you in the resurrection of the righteous.” This resurrection is a resurrection with a reward.

Not all the dead saints will be resurrected at the same time. At least, the two witnesses in chapter eleven will be resurrected apart from the others. Three and a half days after their death, they will be resurrected (11:11). Moreover, the man-child, who will be raptured before the fifth trumpet, will be resurrected earlier than the majority of the believers, who will be resurrected at the seventh trumpet. We may use 1 Corinthians 15 and 1 Thessalonians 4 to speak of resurrection in a general way, telling people that the dead believers will be resurrected when the Lord comes back. Nevertheless, it is still necessary to know the details regarding the resurrection of the believers. For instance, the man-child will be resurrected before the great tribulation, and the majority of the dead saints will be resurrected toward the end of the great tribulation. Furthermore, the resurrection of the late overcomers who will stand on the glassy sea may be at still a different time. Certainly, they will not be resurrected with the man-child, for they will be martyred during the great tribulation. And it is doubtful that they will be resurrected along with the majority of the dead saints. Therefore, there will be three or four different resurrections of the believers: the resurrection of the man-child, the resurrection of the two witnesses, the resurrection of the late overcomers, and the resurrection of the majority of the dead believers. We should not be content merely to be in the general resurrection of the believers; rather, we should aspire to be in the best resurrection.

5. It being blessed to participate in this resurrection

Verse 6 says, “Blessed and holy is he who has part in the first resurrection.” This must be the highest blessing — to inherit the kingdom manifested on earth and even to be the kings within it.

6. The second death having no authority over those participating in this resurrection

Concerning those who participate in the first resurrection, verse 6 says, “Over these the second death has no authority.” This is difficult to understand. The lake of fire is called the second death (20:14). Some may say, “The believers will be resurrected before the millennium and will never be put into the lake of fire, the second death.” The Bible is not that simple. We have seen that Satan is useful in the hand of God. Likewise, death is also somewhat useful to Him. All negative situations are related to death. Take the example of weakness. All weakness — physical, mental, and spiritual — belongs to death. Weakness is a visiting card of death. When death is about to visit a person, it does not come directly. Instead, it firstly comes in the form of weakness. Weakness is followed by sickness, and sickness is followed by death. Thus, both weakness and sickness belong to death. Moreover, all the troubles and hardships we face in life also belong to death. When the overcomers enter into the upper section of the millennium to be the co-kings of Christ, they will have no weakness, no sickness, no trouble, and no hardship. In other words, they will no longer be bothered by death.

The death before resurrection is the first death, and the death after resurrection is the second death. The second death, the lake of fire, refers to death after resurrection. In the first death the spirit and soul leave the body, the body is buried, and the spirit and soul go to Hades — the spirit and soul of the believer to the section of comfort in Hades, and the spirit and soul of the unbeliever to the section of torment. The Lord Jesus will determine who among the dead will be resurrected before the millennium and who will be left in the tomb for another thousand years to be resurrected after the millennium. After the unbelievers are resurrected, they will be judged at the great white throne (Rev. 20:11-15). The dead unbelievers will be cast into the lake of fire, the second death. This means that even after their resurrection, they will still suffer the second death.

Do not think, as many Christians do, that after your resurrection everything will necessarily be all right. After our resurrection, we shall stand before the judgment seat of Christ (2 Cor. 5:10). If there is no possibility that we might still have a problem, why then will we be judged after the resurrection? When we are standing before the judgment seat of Christ, we shall be fearful and trembling, wondering what the Lord Jesus will say concerning us. Yes, you are saved, and you are saved for eternity. With this there is no problem. We do not believe that a saved person can be lost again. John 10:28 and 29 indicate that once we have received eternal life, we can never perish. However, in 1 Corinthians 3:15 Paul says, “If anyone’s work shall be consumed, he shall suffer loss, but he shall be saved, yet so as through fire.” Although we are saved, we may still suffer a loss; that is, we may still have a problem. Do not think that after you have been resurrected and raptured, you will immediately go to heaven. No, you must first be examined. Do not expect to go directly into the millennial kingdom to be a co-king of Christ. You must firstly stand before the judgment seat of Christ.

As we stand before this judgment seat, “each one of us shall give account of himself to God” (Rom. 14:12). Perhaps you will have to say, “Lord, after I was saved, I still drank and went to the movies. I was told that I should love You, but I simply didn’t have the heart to love You. I heard the messages about the kingdom, but I was just sloppy. Lord, please excuse me.” Although you may criticize others today, as you stand before the judgment seat, you will have to criticize yourself. The judgment at the judgment seat of Christ will determine whether we shall receive the reward to enter into His kingdom or receive some punishment. That punishment will be something related to the second death, just as weakness, sickness, trouble, and hardship are related to the first death.

Today God uses weakness, sickness, trouble, and hardship to discipline us and to chastise us that we may grow in life. If you die in your immaturity, do not think that you will suddenly become mature after your resurrection. No, you will be resurrected and raptured in an immature condition. You died in immaturity, and you will also be resurrected in immaturity. Take graduation from school as an example. If you leave school before you graduate and return some time later, you will still have to complete your schoolwork. You will have to continue your studies until you have finished your course for graduation.

We need to grow and mature quickly. Do not delay the process of growth and maturity. You must fear the prospect of dying in immaturity. If you die in your immaturity, after your resurrection you will stand in immaturity before the Lord’s judgment seat. There will be no need for the Lord to say anything. Rather, you will say, “Lord, I’m sorry. I died in immaturity, and I am still immature. Lord, have mercy on me and grant me more time to mature.” But the Lord may say, “The dispensation has changed. You must be put into a situation that will help you grow.” Be assured that this situation will not be very pleasant. Everyone in this situation will be dealt with by something related to the second death. This means that even after a believer’s resurrection, he may still be touched by something of the second death; that is, the second death may still have some authority over him. Only the over-comers, those who participate in the best resurrection, will not be subject to anything of the second death. They will have graduated from all weakness, sickness, trouble, hardship, and suffering. This is the proper understanding of verse 6.

Do not believe the inaccurate teachings which say that if you have been washed in the blood and regenerated by the Spirit, everything will be all right. Although you are saved for eternity, you still need to grow, to mature, and to be perfected so that you may be among the co-kings of Christ. If you do not mature, you will suffer loss. If you suffer loss before the resurrection, your loss will belong to the first death. But if you suffer loss after the resurrection, your loss will be related to the second death. Although you may be a resurrected believer, you will still be under the authority of the second death, and something of the second death will trouble you. This is the pure, enlightening, and sobering truth. Oh, we all need to be enlightened, sobered, and made serious!

What is your condition today? Are you still fleshly? Do you still love the world? Do you still fight with your wife or rebel against your husband? If this is your condition, what will you say to the Lord when you stand before the judgment seat of Christ after your resurrection? And what will He say to you? He will tell you that you need to suffer something in order to mature, that you need something of the second death to work on you. But praise the Lord for the overcomers who participate in the best resurrection and over whom the second death has no authority!

D. The enjoyment of the priesthood and the kingship in the millennium

Verse 6 also says that the overcomers “shall be priests of God and of Christ and shall reign with Him a thousand years.” The overcomers will be priests to contact God and co-kings with Christ to reign over the nations in the millennium (Rev. 2:26-27; 12:5). As priests they will bring man in his need to God and minister God to man, and as kings they will bring God in His authority to man and represent God to shepherd man. This is a reward to them. The believers who are defeated in this age will forfeit this reward. However, after being dealt with by the Lord in the millennium, they will participate in the service of God and in the kingship in the new heaven and the new earth for eternity (Rev. 22:3-5).

Today the proper Christians bring man and man’s need to God and Christ, and they also minister God and Christ to man. Also, they bring God’s authority to man and represent God to man. As we share in the upper section of the millennium, we shall be both priests and kings. We shall meet the need of both God and man, bringing man to God and God to man. Through our priesthood and kingship both God and man will be fully satisfied. We shall be a priestly and kingly people, a people far beyond anything of the second death. In this realm, there will be no weakness, no sickness, no trouble, and no hardship. How wonderful this will be!

The Last Rebellion of Mankind and the Judgment at the Great White Throne

In this message we shall consider the last rebellion of mankind (Rev. 20:7-10) and the judgment at the great white throne (Rev. 20:11-15). Both will take place after the thousand years and before the coming of the new heaven and the new earth. Although the condition of everything in the millennial kingdom will be wonderful, within mankind there will still be a rebellious nature. Because God foreknew that even restored mankind would still have this problem, He will keep Satan in the abyss during the millennium so that He may use him to test mankind after the thousand years are over. By means of this test man's rebellious nature will be exposed and purged. Thus, the first thing to be cleared away after the millennium will be the rebellious human nature.

Following this, there will be the clearing up of the situation of the dead unbelievers, who are awaiting the judgment at the great white throne. The judgment at the white throne will deal with the dead unbelievers, with death and Hades that hold the dead, and with the demons. Therefore, in this portion of the Word we see the final clearance in the universe as a preparation for the coming of the new heaven and the new earth.

Before the millennium, many things will be dealt with: the great prostitute, Antichrist, the false prophet, and the evil, worldly forces. During the millennium the Lord will deal with the immaturity of His people. If we are immature and imperfect in God's eternal life, we are a shame to God. The immaturity of God's people is truly a shame to Him, and during the millennium God will rid His people of this shame.

Many Christians hold the mistaken concept that the dispensation of the millennium will be absolutely perfect. Some Christian teachers have said that when the millennium comes, everything in God's economy will have been completed and perfected. We must strongly declare that this concept is inaccurate. The dispensation of the millennial kingdom will still take place in the old heaven and the old earth. God uses each dispensation to deal with people in a specific way. He uses the various dispensations to make His people perfect, complete, and mature, for the purpose of building up the New Jerusalem as His eternal habitation. All the dispensations are for this purpose. The millennium, the thousand years, will be the last dispensation. In this dispensation certain imperfections will still need to be dealt with. For this reason, the new heaven and the new earth will come after the millennium, not before it. Thus, the millennium will be also a dispensation used by God to perfect His immature people.

If you mature in the present dispensation, you will not need the next dispensation for your maturity. However, if you do not mature in this dispensation, you will have to mature in the next. In the present dispensation God gives us His life, He affords us His grace, and He also prepares the environment and circumstances we need to grow into maturity. He even uses items of the first death, such as weakness, sickness, trouble, and hardship, to help us grow. But if, in spite of the life, the grace, and the environment, we still do not mature in this dispensation, then, in His wisdom, God will use the last dispensation, the dispensation of the kingdom, to make us mature. To the mature and perfected ones, the millennium will be a reward and an enjoyment. But to the immature ones, it will be a loss and a dealing.

In the last dispensation God will even use the items related to the second death to discipline and to punish the immature believers. He will do this with the positive intention of forcing them to grow into maturity so that they may be prepared to enter into the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and the new earth. Thank the Lord that in the present dispensation God has already caused many of us to grow into maturity. In this present dispensation He will also deal with Catholicism, Judaism, Antichrist, the false prophet, and the evil, worldly forces. Then the millennium, the kingdom age, will come as a reward to the mature ones. During the millennium, the immature ones among God's people will be dealt with so that they may mature.

After the millennium, the rebellious nature of mankind will still be found in the citizens of the millennial kingdom and will need to be exposed and purged. Furthermore, the dead unbelievers, death and Hades, and the demons will all need to be dealt with. All these negative things still need to be cast into the "trash can." Therefore, during the millennium God will discipline the immature believers to rid them of their shame and to bring them into maturity. After the thousand years, Satan will be released and used by the Lord to test rebellious mankind and to purge out man's rebellious nature. After this, the dead unbelievers and the demons will be judged at the great white throne, and all these negative things, including death and Hades, will be swept into the universal "trash can," the lake of fire. At that time, everything negative throughout the whole universe will be in the lake of fire, and the new heaven and the new earth will come with the New Jerusalem.

I. The last rebellion of mankind

A. Satan loosed out of his prison

Verse 7 says, "And when the thousand years are completed, Satan will be loosed out of his prison." The abyss will simply be a temporary prison. As we have seen, after the thousand years, Satan will be released from his prison and used by God to test mankind.

B. Satan deceiving the nations to rebel against God

Verse 8 says that Satan "shall go out to deceive the nations which are in the four corners of the earth, Gog and Magog, to gather them together to war, whose number is as the sand of the sea." The nations will go up "over the breadth of the earth" and surround "the camp of the saints and the beloved city" (v. 9). Here we see that Satan will deceive the nations to rebel against God. It is difficult to believe that after the pleasant, thousand-year period, so many among the nations will rebel against God and go to war against Him. Nevertheless, it will be so. This war will be the last war on earth, the last rebellion of mankind. Although mankind will be restored for one thousand years, his rebellious nature will still remain. It will be exposed by Satan's last instigation and it will be purged away by the Lord's final judgment on mankind.

According to Ezek. 38:2-3 and Ezek. 39:1-2, Gog and Magog must be Russia. Ezekiel 38:2 (ASV) indicates that Gog and Magog are of Rosh, Meshech, and Tubal, answering to Russia, Moscow, and Tobolsk. Ezekiel 39:2 (ASV) refers to these places as "the uttermost parts of the north." What is mentioned concerning Gog and Magog in Ezekiel 38 and 39 will occur before the millennium, whereas the record concerning them in Rev. 20 will transpire after the millennium. Rev. 20:8 shows that Satan's deceiving of the nations which are in the four corners of the earth is his deceiving of Gog and Magog. This may indicate that in the last rebellion of mankind against God, Gog and Magog will take the lead and that the nations will follow.

Notice that Satan will "deceive the nations which are in the four corners of the earth, Gog and Magog." According to this verse, Gog and Magog equal the nations in the four corners of the earth. But are Gog and Magog actually the nations in the four corners of the earth? No. Therefore, this must indicate that Gog and Magog will take the lead among the nations to rebel against God under Satan's instigation. Consider today's world situation. All the communist countries are under the influence or control of Russia, that is, under Gog and Magog. When Satan instigates Gog and Magog to rebel, he will actually instigate the nations in the four corners of the earth to rebel, for all the communist countries will follow Russia. Thus, this verse indicates that, due to her powerful influence, Russia, a leading nation, will affect the other nations and lead them in rebellion. Because man's rebellious nature is so deeply rooted in his being, it will still be present even after the thousand years. In which part of the earth are people the most rebellious against God? The answer certainly is Russia. The Bible does not leave us in ignorance regarding this matter. If we read the Bible carefully in the light of today's world situation, we shall worship God. The Bible clearly indicates that the source of mankind's rebellion is in the uttermost part of the north, in the land of Gog and Magog, in Russia. The thought of rebellion against God is deeply rooted in the people in this part of the earth.

I believe that this part of the earth is what the book of Revelation calls "the third part" (8:7). Fifty years ago I became familiar with the biblical prophecies, but I did not see the fulfillment of very many of them. But today a number of prophecies have been fulfilled already. Perhaps after a short while, many more prophecies will also be fulfilled. According to my study of biblical prophecy, the earth today does have a part, the third part, that is very dark. Even after the thousand years the people in this part of the earth will join Satan to rebel against God. The number of those who rebel against God will be "as the sand of the sea." What country can raise such a large number of people? Certainly the answer is Russia and the communist countries under her influence. The communist countries have a way to stir up people, and they will gather their people together for this last war.

Verse 9 says that the nations will surround the camp of the saints and the beloved city. The camp of the saints is the lodging of the overcoming believers, who are the heavenly armies (19:14) camping on earth. We, the heavenly armies, will be there camping, and the nations under the influence of Gog and Magog will attack us. The beloved city is the city of Jerusalem, the dwelling place of the remnant of Israel. The overcoming believers and the remnant of Israel will be God's faithful people on earth in the millennium, standing with God and for God. At the end of the millennium, Satan will instigate rebellious mankind from the uttermost parts of the north to attack them. How Satan will hate these two places, the camp of the saints and the beloved city! However, fire will come down out of heaven and devour the rebels. Praise the Lord, He will easily defeat this attack!

C. Satan being cast into the lake of fire

Verse 10 says, "And the Devil who deceived them was cast into the lake of fire and brimstone, where also the beast and the false prophet were; and they shall be tormented day and night forever and ever." The lake of fire is prepared for the Devil and his angels (Matt. 25:41). However, the beast, the false prophet, and the "goats" in Matthew 25 will be cast into it a thousand years earlier than the Devil (19:20). After the thousand years, the Devil will be cast there also. After the millennium, the rebellious nature of mankind will be thoroughly purged, and Satan will be cast into the lake of fire.

Not all the nations will participate in the last rebellion. Those citizens of the millennial kingdom who do not rebel against God will be transferred into the new heaven and the new earth to become the nations there. Revelation 21:24-27 speaks of the nations around the New Jerusalem. These nations will be fully purged of their rebellious nature. What a great clearance this will be! At the end of the millennium the immaturity of God's people will be eliminated, the rebellious nature of mankind will be purged, and Satan will be cast into the lake of fire. Only the unbelieving dead, death and Hades, and the demons will still need to be dealt with. This will take place at the great white throne.

II. The judgment at the great white throne

A. A great white throne signifying that the judgment of the Lord there is righteous

Verse 11 says, "And I saw a great white throne and Him who sat upon it, from whose face earth and heaven fled away, and no place was found for them." White here signifies righteousness, indicating that the Lord's great throne for His judgment is righteous.

B. The one sitting upon the throne

Christ is the One sitting upon the great white throne. The "Him" in verse 11 must be the Lord Jesus. God the Father "has given all judgment to the Son" (John 5:22) and has ordained Him to be the Judge of the living and the dead (Acts 10:42; 17:31; 2 Tim. 4:1; Rom. 2:16). Matt. 25:31-46 speaks of the Lord as the Judge of the living before the millennium. Here, the Lord is the Judge of the dead after the millennium.

C. The earth and heaven fleeing away

Verse 11 says that earth and heaven will flee away from the face of the One on the throne and that no place will be found for them. The old heavens and the old earth will be changed (Heb. 1:11-12). The old heavens will pass away, the elements will melt, and the earth will be burned up (2 Pet. 3:10).

D. The dead unbelievers being judged

Verse 12 says, "And I saw the dead, the great and the small, standing before the throne, and books were opened; and another book was opened, which is the book of life. And the dead were judged by the things which were written in the books, according to their works." The word standing here indicates that the dead have been resurrected. This is the resurrection of the unbelievers, the resurrection of judgment, after the millennium (John 5:28-29; 1 Cor. 15:23-24). The unbelieving dead will be judged by the things written in the books, or scrolls (Gk.). These scrolls are the record of the works, the deeds, of the unbelievers, according to which they will be judged. The other book that is open, the book of life, is the record of the names of the believers (Rev. 13:8; 17:8; Luke 10:20). The unbelievers will be judged by the things written in the books, according to their works. All they have said and done is written in these scrolls. In Matt. 12:36 the Lord Jesus said, "And I say to you that every idle word which men shall speak, they shall render account concerning it in the day of judgment." Every idle word is recorded. The universal tape recorder records every word men say. At the great white throne the scrolls will be opened, and the Lord will say to the unbelieving dead, "This is what you have said, and this is what you have done." Every mouth will be shut. God is God; He will take care of everyone.

E. The demons being judged

Verse 13 says that "the sea gave up the dead which were in it." Since the dead unbelievers who were drowned in the sea are included among those in Hades, the dead given up by the sea must not be any unbelieving human beings; they may be the spirits of the living beings of the pre-Adamic age, the demons in this age (Matt. 8:31-32; 12:43). This may indicate that today's demons will be judged at the great white throne along with the unbelieving human beings.

You may be shocked to hear that not only human beings but also demons will be judged at the great white throne. Again I say that it is not a simple matter to know the Bible. Most Christian readers think that the dead given up by the sea are those drowned in the sea. But those who drowned in the sea are certainly included among those given up by death and Hades. Notice that verse 13 also says, "And death and Hades gave up the dead which were in them." By this we see that the dead given up by the sea must be another category of beings. In message two in our life-study of Genesis we pointed out that in the pre-Adamic age there were some living beings with spirits. After God's judgment upon Satan and those who followed him in his rebellion, these beings became demons, and the sea became their dwelling place. For this reason, the demons caused the swine to rush into the sea (Matt. 8:31-32). Thus, the sea will give up all the demons, who will then be judged at the great white throne.

F. Death and Hades being cast into the lake of fire

Verse 14 says, "And death and Hades were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death, the lake of fire." The lake of fire is the "trash can" for the entire universe, into which all negative things, including death and Hades, will be cast. Death will be the last enemy destroyed by the Lord (1 Cor. 15:26).

In the first death, the soul and spirit are separated from the body and, in the case of the unbelievers, are kept in the suffering section of Hades (Luke 16:22-24). In the second death, the soul and spirit of the unbelievers, after being rejoined to the body in resurrection, will be cast with the body into the lake of fire. This means that an unbeliever's whole being — spirit, soul, and body — will perish in eternal torment in the lake of fire.

G. Anyone not found in the book of life being cast into the lake of fire

Verse 15 says, "And if anyone was not found written in the book of life, he was cast into the lake of fire." The perishing unbelievers will be judged according to the books, which are a record of their works (vv. 12-13), but they will be cast into the lake of fire according to the book of life. This indicates that they are condemned by the Lord because of their evil deeds, but they perish because of their unbelief, not having their names written in the book of life. Not believing in the Lord Jesus is the unique sin that causes people to perish (John 16:9). The lake of fire is prepared for the Devil and his angels. Since the unbelievers have followed the Devil, they share the Devil's judgment (John 16:11) and will become joint-partakers of the Devil's eternal torment. The demons, also having followed the Devil, will share the same destiny.

The New Heaven and New Earth

Whenever we come to Revelation chapters twenty-one and twenty-two in our reading of the Bible, we immediately sense that we are entering another realm, another sphere. The reason for this is that in these chapters the entire universe is renewed. Not only the believers in Christ, but also the heaven and the earth are renewed. In this message we shall consider the new heaven and the new earth (Rev. 21:1-8).

I. The four dispensations in the old heaven and old earth

Because God's dispensations are not completed until chapter twenty-one, the new heaven and the new earth do not appear before that time. Before the end of chapter twenty God's dealing with His creatures is not completed. The coming of the new heaven and the new earth in 21:1 indicates that God's dispensations have been completed.

In eternity past God purposed to have a corporate expression that He might be fully expressed and glorified (Eph. 3:9-11; 1:9-11). For this, He created the heavens, the earth, and mankind. Since the creation of man, there have been four dispensations: the dispensation of the patriarchs, from Adam to Moses (Rom. 5:14); the dispensation of law, from Moses to Christ (John 1:17); the dispensation of grace, from Christ's first coming until "the restitution of all things" at Christ's second coming (Acts 3:20-21); and the dispensation of the kingdom, from Christ's second coming to the end of the millennium (Rev. 11:15; 20:4, 6). God has used these four dispensations to accomplish His purpose by perfecting and completing His chosen people that they may be His eternal corporate expression. All four dispensations belong to the old heaven and old earth. Although the dispensation of the kingdom will be the dispensation of restoration, it will still transpire in the old heaven and old earth, because God's perfecting and completing work in His chosen people will not be accomplished until the end of that dispensation. When God finishes this work, by the dispensation of the kingdom, the old heaven and old earth will pass away through fire and be renewed into the new heaven and new earth (2 Pet. 3:10-13), where the New Jerusalem will come for God's eternal expression.

A. The dispensation of the patriarchs

Let us consider these four dispensations in more detail. Most Bible teachers say that from Adam until the end of the thousand years there will be seven dispensations. I agree with this. However, these seven dispensations are somewhat of a man-made design. According to the Bible, there are not seven dispensations from Adam to the end of the millennium; there are four. The first dispensation is from Adam until Moses (Rom. 5:14). This is the biblical way of marking the first dispensation. Some divide the first dispensation into various other dispensations: the dispensation of innocence, the dispensation of conscience, the dispensation of human government, and the dispensation of promise. But all these should be treated as sections of one dispensation, not as four separate dispensations. In each dispensation certain people have been completed by God. In the first dispensation the patriarchs were completed. They are signified by the stars of the crown upon the head of the universal bright woman (12:1).

B. The dispensation of law

The second dispensation, from Moses to Christ, is the dispensation of law. "For the law was given through Moses; grace and reality came through Jesus Christ" (John 1:17). In the dispensation of law God produced the Old Testament saints and perfected a number of them, such as Moses, Joshua, Aaron, Samuel, David, and the prophets. These saints are signified by the moon under the feet of the bright woman in Revelation 12.

C. The dispensation of grace

The third dispensation, from Christ's first coming until the restoration of all things at Christ's second coming (Acts 3:20-21), is the dispensation of grace. In this dispensation God produces the New Testament believers and perfects many of them. They are signified by the sun which clothes the woman. Therefore, in the first three dispensations, God perfects the patriarchs, some Old Testament saints, and some New Testament believers.

D. The dispensation of the kingdom

The fourth dispensation is the dispensation of the kingdom, the dispensation of restoration. This dispensation will begin at Christ's second coming and last until the end of the millennium (11:15; 20:4, 6). During the dispensation of the kingdom, God will perfect the remnant of Israel and the immature believers. God is wise. In the second dispensation, the dispensation of law, He did not complete the perfection of the children of Israel because they did not give Him the opportunity to do this. They refused to allow God to perfect them. Thus, God has postponed the perfecting of the children of Israel until the fourth dispensation, at which time it will be fully accomplished. During the dispensation of the kingdom God will also complete the perfection of the immature Christians. Many Christians will not allow God to perfect them during the dispensation of grace. Therefore, the Lord will be forced to postpone their perfection until the next dispensation. Thus, one function of the dispensation of the kingdom is to complete the perfection of the children of Israel and of the immature Christians.

According to the Bible, these are the four dispensations in the old universe. After these dispensations, the perfection of God's people will be wholly accomplished, and God will have a perfect and complete universal woman, the New Jerusalem. How enlightening it is to see these dispensations!

II. The passing away of the old heaven and old earth

After these four dispensations, that is, after the absolute perfection and completion of God's people, God will have no further use for the old heaven and the old earth. At that time, the old creation will be over. God will use many things to perfect His people: Satan, Antichrist, the false prophet, weakness, hardship, and various other difficulties. After we have been perfected, God will no longer need the negative things of the old creation; therefore, He can say, "Satan, I don't need you any more. Go to the lake of fire. Sickness, sorrow, and tears, because My people have been perfected, I don't need you either. I don't need anything old. I don't need the old heaven and I don't need the old earth. All the old and negative things were instruments used by Me to perfect My people. Now that My people have been perfected, all these things may be put into the universal 'trash can,' the lake of fire."

In building our meeting hall in Anaheim we had a use for many different utensils. When I was about to throw some of these utensils away, the brothers asked me not to do it, because they still had a use for them. Unhappily, I agreed to keep them. One day, the building was completed, and all those old utensils were thrown into the trash can. In like manner, when God's people have been thoroughly perfected, He will have no further use for the old heaven and the old earth. Therefore, at that time, the old heaven and old earth will pass away, and the new heaven and new earth will come in. God will say to the old creation, "My people have been perfected. Because they are all matured, you need not remain any longer." Thus, the old heaven and the old earth will be put away.

A. Being burned to become the new heaven and new earth

There is one aspect of the putting away of the old heaven and the old earth that I find difficult to understand. According to Hebrews 1:11 and 12, the earth and the heavens will "become old as a garment," and the Lord "shall roll them up" and put them away. But 2 Peter 3:10-13 indicates that the heavens and the earth will be burned. According to these verses, the elements will burn and melt. Will the old heaven and the old earth be rolled up or will they be burned? Perhaps they will be rolled up first and then burned.

Another question I have concerns the nations on earth at the end of the millennium. When God rolls up the earth and burns it, where will the nations be? I cannot answer this question. My mentality, like yours, is too limited to know the answers to such questions. There are certain things we simply cannot figure out. Take, for example, the appearing of the resurrected Christ to His disciples on the evening of His resurrection (John 20:19). The disciples were in a room, and all the doors were shut. Suddenly, the Lord Jesus appeared in the room with a touchable, physical body. How did He get there? Furthermore, the prints of the nails were still in the Lord's body. Why did His resurrection body still have in it the marks of the nails? Just as we cannot explain this, neither can we explain the various matters related to the passing away of the old heaven and the old earth. Nevertheless, according to the Bible, the time is coming when the old heaven and the old earth will be rolled up and burned.

The old heaven and the old earth actually will be burned to become the new heaven and the new earth. By being burned, the old heaven and old earth will be renewed. Just as we have been renewed, so will the heaven and the earth be renewed. We are the new creation (2 Cor. 5:17). The fact that there will be a new creation does not mean that God will again create something out of nothing. Rather, it means that the old creation will be renewed to become the new creation. However, I cannot explain how God will do this. Nevertheless, we must believe in God's sovereignty.

Many scientists do not believe that God created everything. They say, "How could God just speak a word and cause something to come into being?" But the Bible says that God "calls the things not being as being" (Rom. 4:17) and that "the universe has been framed by the word of God, so that what is seen has not come into being from things which appear" (Heb. 11:3). God is the creating God. As the creating God, He does not need any material; He can create something out of nothing. Likewise, God has a way to make the new heaven and the new earth. Eventually, not only will we, the people of God who have been born again, be the new creation; the entire universe will be renewed and become the new creation. As we have seen, this will take place after God has completed the perfection of His people. Everything is waiting for us to be perfected.

Few Christians pay attention to the matter of perfection in life. But, under God's enlightenment, we have seen that unless we are perfected in life, God does not have a way to accomplish His eternal purpose. If you do not allow Him to perfect you today, He will be patient and wait until the next age, the dispensation of the kingdom, to complete His work in you. Do not think that when you die all your problems will automatically be solved. If you have problems when you die, you will also have these same problems when you are resurrected. You may be surprised and say, "Dear problems, I thought that by dying I had escaped from you. Now, after I have been resurrected, I must face you again." This is correct. We all must finish our lessons; otherwise, we cannot graduate. Nevertheless, many Christians still mistakenly think that by dying they will be rescued from their problems. But the truth is, once you die, you lose the opportunity to be perfected in this dispensation, and you will have to be perfected in the coming dispensation. We all must pray to the Lord, "Lord, I want to be perfected before I die. Don't let me die without this. If I die without being perfected, I am certain that I will be perfected in the next dispensation. Lord, keep me on earth and grant me the mercy and grace I need to give You the complete liberty to do everything necessary to perfect me today." We must be desperate to be perfected before we die and to give the Lord the full liberty to perfect us today. This is a matter of great significance.

According to the clear vision in the whole Bible, we not only need redemption, forgiveness, and regeneration; we also urgently need perfection. We need to be brought on to maturity. If we are not completed, perfected, and matured in this dispensation, we shall be dealt with in the next dispensation so that we might mature. This postponed perfection will not be very pleasant. We all need to place ourselves in the Lord's hand that we may be perfected today. As you find yourself in various circumstances, do not blame anyone or anything. Rather, you should say, "Lord, thank You for this situation. It is Your instrument and Your way to perfect me. Lord, thank You for the excellent wife and children You have given me. They are helping me to mature. Lord, I also thank You for the many peculiar, strange, and difficult brothers and sisters that surround me daily in the church life. O Lord, I know Your purpose. All these situations and all these brothers and sisters are helping me to be perfected. Lord, how I thank You!"

There is only one place where we can be perfected today, and that place is the church life. In other Christian groups, if you are not happy with those around you, you can easily leave them and go elsewhere. However, once we have truly come into the church life, there is no exit, no fire escape. There is no way to get out. Instead, we must stay here and be burned and dealt with for our perfection. Praise the Lord, we can be perfected in this age!

Every divorce is an escape from the limitations of married life. When the worldly people are unhappy with their marriage, they simply seek a divorce and run away from their problems. By doing this, they escape the dealing, the burning, and the perfecting. But we, the children of God, should never divorce ourselves from the church life. After we have entered into the marriage of the church life, we must stay in the oven until we have been completely baked. The day is coming when we shall no longer need the oven, for we shall be perfected, and everything will be new. At that time, all the old things of the first heaven and the first earth will be terminated. Today we have many ovens — our husband or wife, our children, and the brothers and sisters in the church. In the church life we are burning and baking one another. We shall not be released from this oven until we have been perfected. How we thank the Lord that He is using the church life to perfect us in life!

B. No more sea

Verse 1 also says, "And the sea is no more." The sea is the result of the waters of judgment, the waters which God used to judge the pre-Adamic world. (See Life-study of Genesis, Message Two.) The work of God's re-creation was to recover the land by restricting the waters which were the result of this judgment (Gen. 1:9-10; Jer. 5:22). The living creatures of the pre-Adamic world, after being judged by the waters, became the inhabitants of the sea. After they are dealt with by Christ and His believers (Matt. 8:29-32; Luke 10:17; Acts 16:16-18; 19:12) and the sea has given them up to the judgment of the great white throne (20:13), there will be no more need of the sea. From the time of God's work of re-creation, God has intended to abolish the sea by dealing with Satan and his demons. Hence, to say "the sea is no more" indicates that Satan and his evil followers have all been dealt with and will not be found in the new heaven and new earth.

III. Former things being not remembered

Isaiah 65:17 says, "For, behold, I create new heavens and a new earth: and the former shall not be remembered, nor come into mind." Here we see that the former things will not be remembered. God has a great ability to forget.

IV. Remaining forever

The new heaven and the new earth will remain before the eternal God, that is, remain forever (Isa. 66:22). To remain forever means to remain for eternity.

V. Righteousness dwelling in the new heaven and new earth

Second Peter 3:13 says, "But according to His promise we are expecting new heavens and a new earth, in which righteousness dwells." Here we see that righteousness will dwell in the new heaven and new earth. This means that everything will be right, proper, and fitting and that there will be no more friction.

VI. The New Jerusalem coming down to the new earth

Verse 2 says, "And I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband." The New Jerusalem will come down to the new earth. After all God's redeemed saints have been raptured to the heavens, they will be in the New Jerusalem, which will come down out of heaven from God. This indicates that our dwelling place for eternity will not be heaven, but will be the New Jerusalem on the new earth.

The New Jerusalem will come down as the Bride for Christ. This indicates that the New Jerusalem is not a material city; she is a corporate person, the Bride. This city will also be the tabernacle of God for His dwelling with man (v. 3). To Christ, this new city will be the Bride for His satisfaction; to God, it will be the tabernacle in which He will dwell and through which He will express Himself.

VII. The peoples on the new earth

Verse 3 says, "Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and He shall tabernacle with them, and they shall be His peoples, and God Himself shall be with them." The "peoples" in this verse will be "the nations" in verse 24. There will be several peoples, and each corporate people will be a nation on the new earth. These nations which will surround the New Jerusalem will be restored, but they will not be regenerated. At that time, their rebellious nature will have been purged away. As the restored and purged nations, they will live outside the New Jerusalem and they will enjoy the common blessings in the new heaven and the new earth.

These common blessings are mentioned in verse 4: "And He shall wipe away every tear from their eyes; and death shall be no more; nor sorrow, nor crying, nor pain — they shall be no more; for the former things have passed away." In the new heaven and new earth there will be no tears, no death, no sorrow, no crying, and no pain. In the new heaven and new earth there will be full satisfaction and rest; there will be no more cause for tears. Since death will be wholly swallowed up by life (1 Cor. 15:54) and cast into the lake of fire (20:14), in the new heaven and new earth there will be no more death. Death will be thrown into the "trash can," the lake of fire, and the elements of death — sorrow, crying, and pain — will be abolished.

VIII. The sons of God in the New Jerusalem

Verses 5 through 7 speak of the sons of God in eternity. Verse 7 says, "He who overcomes shall inherit these things, and I will be God to him, and he shall be a son to Me." The meaning of overcome here differs from its meaning in chapters two and three, where it is used seven times. Here it means to overcome by believing, as in 1 John 5:4 and 5. The overcoming in chapters two and three qualifies the overcoming believers for participation in the enjoyment of the millennial kingdom as a particular reward in God's dispensational administration, whereas the overcoming here qualifies all believers for participation in the New Jerusalem with all its enjoyment as a common portion of God's eternal salvation.

The "son" in this verse is the believer who will dwell in the New Jerusalem. The sons of God in the New Jerusalem are the constituents of the New Jerusalem. They are the regenerated believers who have the divine life and the divine nature. The New Jerusalem is constituted with all these saints who have been born of God. As we shall see, the New Jerusalem is a composition of all the reborn children of God. Every reborn child of God is a part of this living composition. Because the sons of God are the constituents of the New Jerusalem, they will also dwell in the New Jerusalem.

The sons of God will participate in all the enjoyment of the New Jerusalem, especially the enjoyment of the water of life (v. 6). Many Christians have confused the enjoyment of the nations with the enjoyment of the saints. The nations will enjoy the common blessing, but the saints will have a particular enjoyment. Mainly, we shall enjoy the life supply of the water of life (22:1). Furthermore, we in the New Jerusalem shall serve our God and the Lamb in His presence for eternity (22:3-4). This is one of the blessings of God's redeemed in eternity. At the same time, we shall reign forever and ever (22:5). We shall be kings not only for the thousand years; we shall be kings for eternity. All the saints will be matured, perfected, and qualified to enjoy the eternal New Jerusalem.

Revelation 22:3 says, "And the throne of God and of the Lamb shall be in it, and His slaves shall serve Him." Notice that the pronouns in this verse are singular, not plural. This verse says, "His slaves shall serve Him"; it does not say, "Their slaves shall serve Them." The singular pronoun, which refers to both God and the Lamb, proves that God and the Lamb are one. We should not consider Them as two.

IX. The perished in the lake of fire

Revelation 21:8 says, "But the fearful and unbelieving and abominable and murderers and fornicators and sorcerers and idolaters and all the false, their part shall be in the lake which burns with fire and brimstone, which is the second death." In the old heaven and old earth there was the sea of water to contain the result of God's judgment, whereas in the new heaven and new earth there will be the lake of fire to replace it. All negative and filthy things, after being judged by God, will be in the lake of fire for eternity. According to Rev. 22:15, the lake of fire will be outside the New Jerusalem, just as Tophet, where the filthy things were (Jer. 19:11-13), was outside the old Jerusalem (2 Kings 23:10; Isa. 30:33). The lake of fire is much more restricted than the sea of water. To suffer the second death, the lake of fire, is to be burned with fire and brimstone for eternity (Rev. 14:10-11).

The New Jerusalem

(1)

In this message and in the six following messages we shall consider the various aspects of the New Jerusalem (Rev. 21:9-27).

I. The way to see the vision of the New Jerusalem

Firstly, we need to know the way to see the vision of the New Jerusalem. One of the seven angels who executed the seven last plagues showed New Jerusalem to John (v. 9). This signifies that the judgment of the seven bowls is for New Jerusalem.

A. To be in spirit

Verse 10 says, "And he carried me away in spirit onto a great and high mountain and showed me the holy city, Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God." If we would see the vision of New Jerusalem, we must be in spirit. Before John saw the vision of the seven churches, he also was in spirit (Rev. 1:10). Chapter one not only tells us that John was in spirit; it also reveals that he was on the island called Patmos. If this were not important, it would not have been recorded in the Bible. By being on the island of Patmos and by being in spirit, John could see the churches, the seven golden lampstands. Although many read and study the book of Revelation and have even read our messages on the seven lampstands, they do not see anything. The reason is they are neither in the right position nor in the spirit.

In order to see anything we need the right standing with the correct angle, and we need the ability to see. Immediately before John saw the seven golden lampstands, he heard a loud voice and he turned to see the voice that spoke with him (Rev. 1:10, 12). I hope that as many in the denominations are reading these life-study messages they will hear a voice and turn to see. However, although many have heard the voice, they are not willing to turn. Even if they do turn to see the voice, they may lack the ability to see. Many denominational preachers have cataracts upon their spiritual eyes. They need to have a specialist remove these cataracts that they may see the vision of the church. When we have the proper position with the right angle and the ability to see, we are able to see the vision of the seven golden lampstands. This was John's situation on the island of Patmos. Because he was in the proper position and because he was in spirit, he saw the seven golden lampstands as soon as he turned to see the voice.

The principle is the same in seeing the New Jerusalem. In 21:10 John tells us that an angel carried him away in spirit. Never despise your spirit; it is capable of seeing New Jerusalem. The phrase "in spirit" is used four times in the book of Revelation (Rev. 1:10; 4:2; 17:3; 21:10). Each time this phrase is used it introduces one of the four main visions which compose this book. These visions are the vision of the church, the vision of the judgment upon the world, the vision of Babylon the Great, and the vision of New Jerusalem. These four visions are in two pairs. The church and the world are the first pair, and Babylon the Great and New Jerusalem are the second. The world is in contrast to the church, and Babylon the Great is in contrast to the New Jerusalem. The entire book of Revelation is constituted with the church, the world, Babylon, and New Jerusalem. Each time John saw one of these visions he was in spirit. In spirit John saw the churches; in spirit he saw the destiny of the world; in spirit he saw the Great Babylon; and in spirit he saw New Jerusalem. I can testify that even now I have before me a clear view of these four things. In the first chapter I see the seven churches and in the last chapter, the New Jerusalem. Between these chapters I see the world and Babylon the Great.

If you want to see these visions, you must be in spirit. Do not exercise your mind to think about the situation. Rather, turn to the spirit and stay there. If you exercise your mind instead of remaining in your spirit, these four visions will disappear from view. If we stay in our mind, we may not think that the world situation is that bad. But if we turn to our spirit and remain there, calling on the name of the Lord Jesus, we shall clearly see the seven lampstands and the fact that the whole world is under God's judgment. The longer we stay in spirit contacting the Lord, the clearer we shall become concerning the world situation. Furthermore, we shall see the prostitute and realize that she is destined for destruction. Although we may not understand all these things or be able to explain them to others, we shall certainly see them for ourselves. We shall also see New Jerusalem, including all the details, such as the twelve gates and the golden street.

Our need today is vision, not understanding. What value is there in understanding the city of Anaheim if you have never seen it? According to the book of Revelation, the apostle John saw many things, including New Jerusalem. Thus, his book of Revelation is not a lecture, a sermon, or even a message; it is a description and a declaration of what he saw. John was taken on a universal tour. After his tour, he seemed to say, "Oh, I have seen Satan cast into the lake of fire and I have seen the New Jerusalem!" We all need to get into our spirit and take this kind of sightseeing tour. After you have seen New Jerusalem, you will not be able to deny the fact that you have seen it.

B. To be on a great and high mountain

When John saw New Jerusalem, he was both in spirit and also carried away onto a great and high mountain. The great and high mountain is in contrast to the wilderness in 17:3. To see Babylon, the great prostitute, John was carried to the wilderness. To see the Bride, the New Jerusalem, he was carried to a great and high mountain. We need to be uplifted to a high mountain that we may see God's dwelling place for the fulfillment of His eternal purpose. In order for John to see the churches, it was sufficient to be on the island of Patmos. But the New Jerusalem is vastly higher than the churches, and in order to see it, John had to be carried to a high mountain. The New Jerusalem is a mountain city, and we must be on a mountain in order to see it. We need to be in the spirit and to get to a high mountain. This is the way to see the vision of the New Jerusalem.

We also need to know what the New Jerusalem is. The New Jerusalem is the ultimate consummation of God's building work throughout the centuries. Beginning with Adam and continuing for nearly sixty centuries, God has been doing a great deal of building. The issue of this work will be the New Jerusalem, God's eternal habitation.

We have seen that the time from Adam until the end of the millennium is divided into four dispensations: the dispensation of the Patriarchs, from Adam to Moses; the dispensation of law, from Moses to Christ; the dispensation of grace, from Christ's first coming until the restoration of all things at Christ's second coming; and the dispensation of the kingdom, from Christ's second coming to the end of the millennium. During these dispensations God has been carrying out His building work, and He will continue it. Most Christians, however, do not care for God's building; they care only for their human religion. Praise the Lord that we have been rescued from that pitiful situation! Now we are not in a human religion; we are in the building of God. Presently this building is the churches, and eternally it will be the New Jerusalem. We are in the churches and we are on our way to the New Jerusalem. Thank the Lord that we have such a clear view of the New Jerusalem, our ultimate destiny.

II. In the new heaven and the new earth

In verse 2 John says, "And I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband." The New Jerusalem is a living composition of all the saints redeemed by God throughout all generations. It is the Bride of Christ as His counterpart (John 3:29) and the holy city of God as His habitation. This is the city, the heavenly Jerusalem (Heb. 12:22), which God has prepared for us and which Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob longed after (Heb. 11:10, 16). It is also the Jerusalem which is above and which is the mother of us all (Gal. 4:26).

This New Jerusalem will come down out of heaven to earth. Verses 2 and 10 both say that New Jerusalem comes "down out of heaven from God." God's intention is not to have an eternal habitation in heaven; He desires to dwell on earth. Although religion dreams of going to heaven, God desires to come down to earth. Even today, God's best habitation is not heaven; it is the church on earth. Today God has two dwelling places — the heavens and the church. God dwells in heaven with His angels, and He also dwells on earth with His children. If you were the Father, would you prefer to stay with the angels, the servants, or with your children? If the servants lived in a mansion and the children lived in a poor cottage, would you prefer to live in the mansion or in the cottage? Certainly you would prefer to be with your children in the cottage. It is the same with God. How He desires to dwell in the church! Although the appearance of the church is not marvelous or splendid, the children of God are there, and God enjoys being with them. Eventually, the poor "cottage" of the church will be transformed into the New Jerusalem, which will be far more splendid than any mansion.

New Jerusalem will be an immense city, twelve thousand stadia in length, breadth, and height (v. 16). Twelve thousand stadia is approximately one thousand three hundred and sixty miles, the distance from San Diego to Seattle. The distance from the east coast of the United States to the west coast is about three thousand miles. Thus, the length of the New Jerusalem will be almost half that of the United States. What a tremendous city this will be! It will be about seven million feet high. This city, which is far more wonderful than we could ever imagine, will actually come down from heaven to earth. Of course, the earth at that time will be the new earth (vv. 1, 24, 26).

III. The holy city

The New Jerusalem is the holy city (vv. 2, 10). As the holy city of God, the New Jerusalem is holy, sanctified, fully separated unto God, and thoroughly saturated with God's holy nature to be His habitation. This holy city is thoroughly permeated and mingled with God. This great city, more than thirteen hundred and sixty miles in length, width, and height, will be utterly separated unto God and saturated with Him. One day, we shall actually be there. Today we see New Jerusalem in a vision, but the time is coming when we shall be in it. How excited we shall be! No doubt we shall recall the vision we saw of it when we were still on earth.

IV. The bride of Christ

Verse 2 says that the New Jerusalem is "prepared as a bride adorned for her husband," and in verse 9 one of the angels says, "Come here, I will show you the bride, the wife of the Lamb." In both the Old and New Testaments, God likens His chosen people to a spouse (Isa. 54:6; Jer. 3:1; Ezek. 16:8; Hosea 2:19; 2 Cor. 11:2; Eph. 5:31-32). The spouse is for God's satisfaction in love. As the Bride of Christ, New Jerusalem comes out of Christ, her husband, and becomes His counterpart, just as Eve came out of Adam, her husband, and became his counterpart (Gen. 2:21-24). She is prepared by participating in the riches of the life and nature of Christ.

Verse 9 speaks of the Bride and the wife. The Bride is mainly for the wedding day, whereas the wife is for the entire life. The New Jerusalem will be the Bride in the millennium for one thousand years as one day (2 Pet. 3:8) and the wife in the new heaven and new earth for eternity. The Bride in the kingdom age will include the overcomers (Rev. 3:12; 19:7-9), but the wife in eternity will include all God's redeemed ones (Rev. 21:9).

Since the New Jerusalem is the Bride, we should not consider her a material city. It is impossible for a material entity to be the Bride. God would never marry such a thing. He will only marry something living. The Bride will be composed of all the redeemed, regenerated, and transformed saints of God. In the New Jerusalem there will be no wood, bricks, or dust. Instead, there will be gold, pearl, and transformed precious stones.

V. The tabernacle of God

Verse 3 says, "And I heard a loud voice out of the throne, saying, Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and He shall tabernacle with them, and they shall be His peoples, and God Himself shall be with them." In both the Old and the New Testaments, God also likens His chosen people to a dwelling place for Himself (Exo. 29:45-46; Num. 5:3; Ezek. 43:7, 9; Psa. 68:18; 1 Cor. 3:16-17; 6:19; 2 Cor. 6:16; 1 Tim. 3:15). As the spouse is for God's satisfaction in love, so the dwelling place is for His rest in expression. Both aspects will be ultimately consummated in the New Jerusalem. In her, God will have the fullest satisfaction in love and the utmost rest in expression for eternity. As God's habitation, New Jerusalem will be the tabernacle of God with men for eternity. It will be God's dwelling place among men — the nations — to express Him. The tabernacle made by Moses was a type of this tabernacle (Exo. 25:8-9; Lev. 26:11). That type was firstly fulfilled in Christ as God's tabernacle among men (John 1:14), and eventually it will be fulfilled in the fullest way in the New Jerusalem, which will be the enlargement of Christ as God's dwelling place. This tabernacle will also be the eternal dwelling place of God's redeemed people. God will overshadow us with Christ. Hence, New Jerusalem will be a mutual habitation for both God and us.

A person's dwelling place expresses the person himself. In no other place are we as fully expressed as we are in our dwelling place. If you want to know a person, visit his apartment or house. If his home is not neat, then you know that the person himself is not a neat person. But if his home is very neat, clean, and orderly, then you know that the person who dwells there is that kind of person. Suppose I visit your apartment one morning and find that your bed is not made. No matter how many lectures you may give me on diligence and neatness, I shall know by your unmade bed that you are a sloppy person. Just as our home expresses us, so the New Jerusalem, God's tabernacle, will express Him. Every part of this city will be neat, clean, and properly built. Every aspect of it will express God. The church today as God's habitation is also His expression. The church is both for Christ's satisfaction and for God's habitation. In the church, a miniature of the coming New Jerusalem, Christ is satisfied and God is expressed.

Restored mankind, the nations, will live around the New Jerusalem as the tabernacle of God, and they will enjoy God there.

VI. The paradise of God

The New Jerusalem will also be the paradise of God. According to the Bible there is more than one kind of paradise. Many Christians consider the garden of Eden as a paradise (Gen. 2:8). However, the Bible does not call the garden of Eden a paradise. Thus, in the Bible, there are just two paradises, the paradise mentioned by the Lord Jesus in Luke 23:43 and the New Jerusalem.

To the thief who asked the Lord to remember him when He came into His kingdom, the Lord Jesus said, "Truly I tell you, today you shall be with Me in Paradise" (Luke 23:43). Only by studying a number of other verses can we locate this paradise. Luke 23:43 reveals that immediately after His death, the Lord Jesus went to paradise. Acts 2:27 and 31 reveal that after the Lord Jesus died, He went to Hades, and Matthew 12:40 indicates that Hades is in "the heart of the earth," where the Lord Jesus went for three days and three nights after His death. In Hades there is a pleasant section likened to Abraham's bosom, where Lazarus went (Luke 16:23). Thus, the paradise mentioned by the Lord in Luke 23:43 is the pleasant section of Hades. According to the Lord's word in Luke 16, there are two sections in Hades, and between these sections there is a great chasm. When Lazarus died, he went to the pleasant section of Hades, where Abraham was. But when the rich man died, he went to the section of torment.

Some Christian teachers, such as Dr. Scofield, believe that at the time of Christ's resurrection the pleasant section of Hades was transferred to the third heaven. The original Scofield Reference Bible has a note on Luke 16:23 to this effect. Second Cor. 12:2-4 is also used as a ground for saying this. Some interpret Paul's word in these verses to mean that paradise is now in the third heaven. However, if you read this portion of the Word carefully according to the Greek text, you will see that it proves the opposite. In this chapter Paul was testifying that he had received a complete vision of the entire universe, which is divided into three sections: the heavens, the earth, and the region under the earth (See Phil. 2:10). Paul had come to know the things on earth, the things in heaven, and the things in paradise. This is the correct understanding of 2 Corinthians 12:2-4. (See message twenty, pp. 242-245). Paradise, the pleasant section of Hades, is still in Hades underneath the earth.

The teaching that the Old Testament saints in paradise were transferred to heaven on the day of Christ's resurrection is not accurate. On the day of Pentecost, fifty days after the Lord's resurrection, Peter said, "David is not ascended into the heavens" (Acts 2:34). Even at that time, David was still not in heaven. Hence, the traditional teachings regarding this matter are neither accurate nor trustworthy. According to the accurate word of the Bible, there is a pleasant section in Hades, called paradise, where the disembodied spirits and souls of the saved presently are, waiting for the time of resurrection. In principle, for a soul to be disembodied means that it is naked, and no naked person can come into God's presence. Thus, the spirits and souls of the departed saints are in the pleasant section of Hades waiting for the day of resurrection that they may put on a glorious resurrection body and be clothed again.

The New Jerusalem as the paradise of God is different from the paradise in Hades. The paradise of the New Jerusalem, which is eternal, will be vastly superior to the paradise in Hades, which is merely a temporary lodging. The paradise of God in the New Jerusalem will be a reward to the overcomers in the kingdom age (Rev. 2:7) and a common portion to all God's redeemed in eternity (Rev. 21:7). All the dead saints will be resurrected, will put on a resurrection body, and eventually will enter into the New Jerusalem, which will be their paradise.

The New Jerusalem

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The meaning of Rev. 21 and Rev. 22 has been hidden from Christians for centuries. Many have understood these chapters in a very natural way and have considered them a description of a material city. When we were young, we heard gospel songs about the golden city and the golden street.

The first verse of the book of Revelation says that the revelation of Jesus Christ is made known by signs. If we would understand this book, we must know the meaning of all the signs. For example, the seven golden lampstands in chapter one and the universal bright woman in chapter twelve are signs. Furthermore, in this book Christ is called the Lion and the Lamb, terms which also are signs. In like manner, the entire city of New Jerusalem is a sign.

Throughout the centuries, what Christians have spoken about the church has come out of their mistaken concept of what the church is. When some talk about going to church, they refer to a bungalow with a high tower and a bell. In their concept, a certain kind of building is the church. Even some diagrams of the dispensations use the figure of a building with a steeple to represent the church. Although such a thing may be a chapel, it certainly is not the church.

The Brethren, who were raised up in the last century, have an improved understanding of the church. To them, the church is not a building; it is the gathering of the called ones. When believers meet together, their gathering is the church. Although this understanding is correct, it is rather shallow. The church is much deeper than this. Suppose a thousand regenerated Christians meet together; yet they quarrel, fight, criticize one another, and live in the flesh. Is that the church? No, it is neither the church nor a gathering of the saints; in the eyes of God it is a gathering of the flesh. In one meeting of a certain church board, one member of the board even threw a Bible at another. Such a gathering certainly is not a meeting of the church.

In the last book of the Bible the church is signified by a bright, pure, shining golden lampstand. The Lord uses a lampstand to symbolize the church because the church is deep and mysterious and cannot adequately be described in human language. Thus, the Lord was forced to use a sign, a symbol, to represent it. When you see that the church is a golden lampstand, you will know what the church is. However, if you are asked to define the church, you still may not be able to do it. The church is mysterious, divine, and pure, and human words cannot define it adequately. For this reason, nowhere in the New Testament do we find a full definition of the church. Eph. 1:22-23 say that the church is Christ's Body, the fullness of Him who fills all in all. But what does the word "fullness" mean, and what does it mean to "fill all in all"? It is difficult to understand the term church, much less the terms "Body," "fullness," and "all in all." Therefore, in the book of Revelation, the ultimate conclusion of the Bible, many signs are used to convey spiritual realities.

When we say that the church is a golden lampstand, we do not mean that the church is actually a stand with seven lamps. It is a mistake to understand the matter this way. It is the same with the description of Christ as the Lamb. Certainly our Lord is not literally a lamb with four legs and a tail. How wrong to understand biblical symbols in this way! The Lamb is a sign indicating something concerning the Lord. Therefore, when the book of Revelation pictures the church as the golden lampstand, it means that the church is divine and pure; the church also has a light that shines in the darkness. This is the significance and the true meaning of the church being a golden lampstand.

The city of New Jerusalem is also a sign, an all-inclusive sign. In order to understand this sign, our mind must be completely renewed and enlightened. We must not understand the New Jerusalem according to our natural concept. Some argue that New Jerusalem is actually a square, material city. If we have this kind of natural concept, we shall not be able to understand the New Jerusalem as a sign. The New Jerusalem is a sign signifying God's eternal building as His dwelling place. To be sure, God's eternal building is not a physical place; rather it is something living. Instead of being a material city, it is an entity constituted with His divine life. This is so mysterious, deep, and profound that human language cannot adequately describe it. Therefore, in His wisdom, God uses a picture, a sign, to reveal it to us. With this principle in mind, let us now consider the various details and aspects of the city of New Jerusalem.

VII. A living composition of all God's redeemed

The New Jerusalem is a living composition of all God's redeemed. The fact that it is such a composition means that it is a living building. The thought that God's people are a living building is not first found in the book of Revelation. In the Old Testament we see that God's people were considered material to be built together as His dwelling place.

The Bible covers two main things — God's creation and God's building. In the beginning of the Bible we have creation, and at the end we have the building. Between these two ends we have God's building work. In creation God produced the building materials. As He carries on His building work, He fits all these materials together into one unit, which is His building.

In Genesis 2 we have a garden created, and in Revelation 21, a city constructed. A garden is something natural created by God, and a city is something built up by Him. The New Jerusalem is not a natural garden; it is a built-up city. In the garden in Genesis 2 there is the tree of life, and near the tree of life there is a river flowing in four directions (Gen. 2:8-10). By the flow of this river we have gold, bdellium, and onyx, a precious stone. Bdellium here is a resin secreted by a tree that hardens to form a pearl-like substance. The first mention of stone in the Bible is not of ordinary, common stone, but of onyx, a type of precious stone.

What were the three precious materials in Genesis 2, gold, bdellium and onyx stone, used for? In order to answer this question we must read through the whole Bible.

In the breastplate of the high priest were set twelve precious stones (Exo. 28:15-21), the first of which was sardius and the last, jasper. Included among these twelve stones was an onyx. This indicates that the breastplate of the high priest is related to both Genesis 2 and Revelation 21, for in Genesis 2 we have onyx and in Revelation 21 we have jasper. In the description of the breastplate of the high priest and of the two onyx stones engraved with the names of the children of Israel (Exo. 28:9-12), we see a miniature of God's building. The precious stones of both the breastplate and the shoulder plates bore the names of the twelve tribes of Israel. This signifies that the redeemed Israelites are for God's building. The twelve precious stones on the breastplate were set in gold. The gold base held all the precious stones. Certainly this is a picture of God's building. This breastplate was a building that expressed God.

Upon the breastplate were also put the urim and thummim (Exo. 28:30). In Hebrew urim means light and thummim means perfection or completion. Many years ago I read an article by a Hebrew writer saying that thummim is a precious stone with four letters of the Hebrew alphabet carved upon it. Upon the breastplate of the high priest were the names of the twelve tribes of Israel engraved upon twelve stones. The names of these tribes contained only eighteen of the twenty-two letters in the Hebrew alphabet. Therefore, upon the breastplate of the high priest there was a shortage of these four letters. However, these letters were carved upon the thummim, and when this stone was put into the breastplate, there was completion and perfection. There were the full twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet. The urim was a stone put into the breastplate to give light. The writer of this article went on to say that when the high priest went before the Lord, certain stones upon the breastplate with their respective letters would shine, and at other times other stones with their letters would shine. The high priest took down all the letters from the various stones as they shone, and in so doing he formed words and sentences. Eventually he received a complete message or judgment from the Lord. Therefore, through the shining upon the breastplate, God expressed His thought, His mind, and His feeling, and the high priest could know God's mind in this way. This is a miniature of God's building today. Today we know God's will through the building, the church.

According to the record of Genesis 28, Jacob, a supplanter, had a divine dream in which he saw a ladder set up on earth and reaching to heaven. When he awoke from sleep, he called the name of that place the house of God (Gen. 28:17). Then he took the stone he had used for a pillow, set it up as a pillar, anointed it with oil, and called it the house of God (Gen. 28:18-19, 22).

The stone is also mentioned in the book of Zechariah. Zechariah 4:7 speaks of the headstone, and 3:9, the stone with seven eyes. The stone in Zechariah is neither the foundation stone nor the cornerstone; it is the topstone with seven eyes. These seven eyes appear again in the book of Revelation as the seven eyes of the Lamb (5:6). Thus, the seven eyes relate the stone to the Lamb, who is also the Lion (5:5). For this reason, we speak of the Lion-Lamb-stone.

When Peter first met the Lord Jesus, the Lord changed his name from Simon to Cephas, which means a stone (John 1:42). After Peter received the revelation that the Lord was the Christ, the Son of the living God, the Lord said, "And I also say to you that you are a stone, and on this rock I will build My church" (Matt. 16:18, lit.). In this one verse we have the stone and the rock. Later, in his first Epistle, Peter said, "To whom coming, a living stone, having been rejected by men, but with God chosen, held in honor, you yourselves also, as living stones, are being built up a spiritual house" (1 Pet. 2:4-5). Therefore, the concept that the believers are stones to be built up for God's habitation is not new in the book of Revelation. It is found elsewhere in the Old Testament and in the New Testament.

Paul had the same concept in 1 Corinthians chapter three, where he said that the church was God's farm and God's building and that he was a wise masterbuilder (vv. 9-10). In this portion of the Word Paul also warned us to be careful about the materials we use in our building work. We should not build with wood, hay, and stubble, but with gold, pearl, and precious stones (vv. 10, 12).

If we put together all the portions of the Word concerning the stone, we shall see that precious stones signify God's redeemed, regenerated, and transformed people. All the stones with which the New Jerusalem is built are God's redeemed, regenerated, and transformed saints. The apostle Peter has told us clearly that we are living stones. Now we are in the process of transformation and of being built into God's building. Firstly, God transforms us; then He builds us. Therefore, Jerusalem is not a pile of material; it is a composition of material that has been built up. The entire city of New Jerusalem is God's building, the living composition of all God's redeemed, regenerated, and transformed saints.

A. The Old Testament saints represented by the twelve names of the twelve tribes of Israel on the twelve gates

The New Jerusalem is composed firstly of the Old Testament saints. This is proved by 21:12, which says that the names of the twelve tribes of the sons of Israel are inscribed on the gates of the city. Every gate bears the name of one tribe. This is also a sign signifying that the gates of the city are living people. We have seen that the significance of the church as a golden lampstand is that it shines for enlightening. We need to know the true meaning and significance of these gates.

The gates firstly function as the means of propagation for the city and then as the entrance into the city. Before anything can enter in through the gates, something must first go out of them. What goes out of them will then bring something back in through them. Therefore, the gates first function as the way of propagation and then as entrances.

Please remember that the gospel was firstly preached and propagated by Jews. For example, both Peter and Paul were Jews. For this reason, the Lord told the Samaritan woman that salvation is of the Jews (John 4:22). In other words, the gospel, the glad tidings, came out of the Jewish people. Therefore, the Old Testament saints, the children of Israel, are the gates for the preaching and the spreading. All the Old Testament prophets, including Isaiah, Jeremiah, Daniel, Ezekiel, and the minor prophets, were preachers. Isaiah preached a great deal, even proclaiming the unique gospel message recorded in Isaiah 53. And John the Baptist and the apostles were all descendants of the twelve tribes of Israel. Thus, the twelve tribes of Israel are the gates through which the riches of the New Jerusalem are supplied to mankind.

The supply that has come out of these gates has had an issue, and this issue is that people have been brought in through the preaching of the gospel. We all have entered into the New Jerusalem through the Jewish gates. Although some may not appreciate this term, I certainly do. I did not enter through a Gentile gate; I entered through a gate that bears the name of one of the twelve tribes of Israel. We should never say that we came in through a gate that bears a British name, a German name, or any Gentile name. There are no such names in the New Jerusalem. As far as the gates are concerned, there are only the names of the twelve tribes of the children of Israel. They are the gates for propagation and for entrance. As we have seen, these names signify that the Old Testament saints are the constituents of that city.

B. The New Testament believers represented by the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb on the twelve foundations

Verse 14 says, "And the wall of the city had twelve foundations, and on them twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb." The fact that the names of the twelve apostles are on the twelve foundations of the wall indicates that New Jerusalem is not only composed of the Old Testament saints, represented by Israel, but also of the New Testament saints, represented by the apostles. The New Testament believers are not for the gates; they are for the wall. The gates are for propagation and entrance, but the wall is for separation and protection. In another message we shall cover the gates and the wall in detail.

VIII. Built with treasures

The city of New Jerusalem is built with treasures. It is built with three kinds of precious materials, signifying the building by the Triune God. Firstly, the city proper with its street is of gold (vv. 18, 21). Gold, the symbol of the divine nature of God, signifies the Father as the source, producing the element for the substantial existence of the city. Secondly, the twelve gates of the city are pearls, which signify the Son's overcoming death and life-imparting resurrection, through which entrance to the city is gained. Thirdly, the wall of the city and its foundation are built of precious stones. This signifies the Spirit's work of transforming the redeemed and regenerated saints into precious stones for the building of God's eternal habitation that they may express God corporately in His permeating glory. In the garden of Eden these three kinds of treasures were merely materials (Gen. 2:11-12), whereas in the city of New Jerusalem these precious materials are built up for the fulfillment of God's eternal purpose, His corporate expression.

A. Gold for the city proper

The New Jerusalem is a mountain of gold. As a golden mountain, New Jerusalem is the ultimate, unique, and eternal golden lampstand. In typology gold signifies the divine nature. Therefore, this city is absolutely composed of God's divine nature. This gold is pure and transparent. If we see the vision of the New Jerusalem built with God's divine nature, we shall renounce everything that does not belong to God's nature and reject anything that does not match it. The church today must also be built with God's nature, not with brick, clay, or wood.

B. Twelve precious stones for the twelve foundations

In verses 19 and 20 we see that the foundations of the wall of the city are adorned with precious stones. This indicates that the twelve apostles have been transformed into precious stones to be the twelve layers of the foundation of the city.

C. Jasper for the wall

Verse 18 says, "And the building material of its wall was jasper." Jasper is the appearance of God (4:3). Hence, the jasper wall signifies that the whole city, as the corporate expression of God in eternity, bears the appearance of God. When we are in New Jerusalem, we shall marvel to see that the whole city has the same appearance, the appearance of jasper. This means that we all must speak the same thing, express the same thing, and have the same appearance. Today's Christianity, however, is much different, for there everyone has his own color and his own opinion and speaks his own mind. But New Jerusalem has one appearance, one expression, and one color.

D. Twelve pearls for twelve gates

Verse 21 says, "And the twelve gates were twelve pearls; each one of the gates was, respectively, of one pearl." Thus, even the gates of the city are built with treasures.

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In this message we shall consider some further characteristics of New Jerusalem, namely its measurements and its wall.

IX. Its measurements

A. The measuring instrument

Let us firstly consider the measurements of New Jerusalem. Revelation 21:15 says, “And he who spoke with me had a golden reed as a measure, that he might measure the city and its gates and its wall.” The reed is for measuring, and measuring signifies taking possession (Ezek. 40:5; Zech. 2:1-2; Rev. 11:1). Notice that the measuring instrument is a reed, not a rod. A rod signifies or implies judgment, discipline, and punishment. According to 11:1, “a reed like a rod” was used to “measure the temple of God and the altar and those who worship in it.” Because a rod implies punishment (Prov. 10:13; Isa. 10:5; 11:4), a reed like a rod indicates measuring with punishment. In 21:15, however, we have the reed, but no mention of the rod. Here there is no implication of judgment, discipline, or chastisement, for in every respect New Jerusalem is complete and perfect. This city has already passed every test. The universal bright woman, whose consummation is New Jerusalem, has passed through many kinds of dealings and has been measured by many rods in each of the four dispensations. Even today the church is being measured by a rod, not by a reed. When the four dispensations are over and the new heaven and new earth have come, there will be no further need for measuring with a rod.

The fact that New Jerusalem is measured with a reed means that it is measured for possession. Suppose you intend to purchase some property. Firstly you measure it, and then you take possession of it. Women do the same thing when they purchase material in a fabric store. The amount of material they measure out is the amount of material they purchase and possess. Likewise, the New Jerusalem, which will be measured by a golden reed, will be fully possessed by the Lord in a very positive way.

Notice that the reed is a golden reed. Since gold signifies the divine nature of God, “golden” here signifies that the measuring of the city, its gates, and its wall is according to God’s divine nature. Anything that does not match the nature of God does not belong to the New Jerusalem. God cannot possess anything that does not match His nature. The whole city, with its gates and wall, can pass the measuring and testing of the nature of God; hence, it is qualified to be possessed by God.

Even today God measures the churches by the golden standard of His divine measurement. When God measures a church, He is not concerned with our intelligence, activities, or ability to speak. But He is very concerned about how much of His nature has been wrought into us. Is the divine gold the solid substance of the church? Is the church constituted with God’s divine essence? The church must be substantially divine; that is, the divine substance must be wrought into the very being of the church life. Thus, the standard of measurement is not our human nature, but God’s nature.

When we are about to express our love for one another, we must determine what kind of love is being expressed, whether it is human or divine. The same is true with respect to humility and goodness. Although we must be humble and good, we must check whether our humility and goodness are human or divine. This principle applies to every aspect of our humanity. We need to be divinely human; that is, we must have the divine nature wrought into us. Please keep in mind that God’s measurement of the church is according to the divine nature. The golden nature of God is the unique standard.

B. Of the city proper

In verse 16 we have the measurements of the city proper. “And the city lies foursquare, and its length is the same as the breadth. And he measured the city with the reed, at twelve thousand stadia; the length and the breadth and the height of it are equal.” When I was young, I was troubled by the fact that the height of the wall was a hundred and forty-four cubits and that the height of the city was twelve thousand stadia. The measurements of the city imply that the city proper is like a mountain with the height of twelve thousand stadia, whereas the wall itself from the foundation to the top is a hundred forty-four cubits. Twelve thousand stadia are more than seven million feet, or more than one thousand three hundred sixty miles.

Another thing that troubled me about the city was that it has just one street. I wondered how this one street could serve all twelve gates. According to my opinion, there should have been at least twelve streets, one for each gate. One day, during my stay with Brother Nee in Shanghai, he pointed out that New Jerusalem is a mountain, and that the one street spirals down the mountain from the throne and passes by all twelve gates. No matter which gate we enter, we find ourselves on the same street. Because the street is a spiral, it is impossible for anyone to get lost in this city. Even if you walk blindly along this street, you will never lose your way.

Verse 16 says that “the city lies foursquare.” The length is the same as its breadth. The fact that New Jerusalem is square signifies that it is perfect and complete in every way, absolutely straight and not in the least oblique.

The length, breadth, and height of New Jerusalem are equal; it is twelve thousand stadia in each dimension. Twelve thousand is one thousand times twelve. Since twelve signifies absolute perfection and eternal completion in God’s eternal administration, twelve thousand signifies a thousand times this.

According to its measurements, New Jerusalem is a cube. The dimensions of the Holy of Holies, both in the tabernacle and in the temple, are equal in length, breadth, and height (Exo. 26:2-8; 1 Kings 6:20). The Holy of Holies in the tabernacle was a cube measuring ten cubits in each dimension, and the Holy of Holies in the temple was a cube twenty cubits in each dimension. That the length, breadth, and height of New Jerusalem are equal signifies that the entire New Jerusalem is the Holy of Holies. Therefore, New Jerusalem is the Holy of Holies enlarged to the uttermost.

In the Life-study of Hebrews we pointed out that our experience of the Holy of Holies must be constantly increasing (see message fifty-two, pp. 238-239). This means that in our experience the Holy of Holies must be continuously enlarged. Firstly, we have the smaller Holy of Holies in Exodus; then we have the larger Holy of Holies in 1 Kings; and ultimately we have the largest Holy of Holies in the book of Revelation. Eventually, our Holy of Holies will be more than one thousand three hundred sixty miles in length, width, and height.

Now we need to see what the principle of the Holy of Holies is. The principle of the Holy of Holies is that man can live and walk directly in the presence of God. According to the Old Testament, only the high priest was allowed to enter into the Holy of Holies. But the book of Hebrews reveals that through the redeeming blood of Christ, the Holy of Holies is open to all those who believe in Him (Heb. 10:19-22). All the redeemed ones may enter into the presence of God, live there, and remain there, enjoying fellowship in oneness with God. The coming New Jerusalem will be such a place. Everyone in it will see God, touch God, worship God, serve God, and even live and dwell in the presence of God. The church life today must be a Holy of Holies. The church must be a cube, and its nature must be utterly holy.

C. Of the wall

Verse 17 says, "And he measured its wall, a hundred and forty-four cubits, a measure of a man, that is, of an angel." A hundred and forty-four is twelve times twelve. Twelve times twelve signifies absolute perfection and eternal completion of absolute perfections and eternal completions. How perfect and complete is the wall of the holy city in God's eternal administration! This verse says that the wall is the measure of a man, "that is, of an angel." It is in resurrection that man will be like the angels (Matt. 22:30). Hence, "a measure of a man, that is, of an angel" signifies that the wall of the city is not natural, but in resurrection.

X. Its wall

A. Built with jasper

Verse 18 says, "And the building material of its wall was jasper." Jasper is a transformed precious stone (1 Cor. 3:12) that bears the appearance of God. This stone is crystal clear and dark green. Revelation 4:3 says, "He who was sitting was like in appearance to a jasper stone and a sardius." According to this verse, the appearance of God on the throne is like jasper and sardius. The dark green color of jasper signifies life in its richness. Green grass, green fields, and green mountains all testify of the richness of life. If a lawn or field is brown, we have the impression that there is no life there. But dark green signifies the richness of life. God as the One on the throne in chapter four also has the appearance of a sardius, a most precious stone in the color of red, which signifies redemption. While jasper indicates God as the God of glory in His rich life, sardius signifies God as the God of redemption. Our God today is the God of life and the God of redemption. However, when we enter into the New Jerusalem, we shall have no further need of redemption. Thus, the color of the wall of the city will be jasper, dark green, expressing life in its richness.

B. A hundred and forty-four cubits high

We have seen that the wall is a hundred and forty-four cubits high, and that this measure is the measure of a man, that is, of an angel. We have pointed out that this signifies that the wall of the city is not natural, but in resurrection. This is a very important matter. Everything we say, everything we do, and everything we are in the church life today must be in resurrection. The principle of resurrection is that the natural life is killed and that the divine life rises up in its place. This is resurrection.

A number of times, as I was about to lose my temper, I exercised my spirit to crucify my natural man. Whenever I did this, I was in resurrection. We must not only practice this with our temper, but even with our love. Do not love others in a natural way. Love them in resurrection. Natural love is like honey. Instead of a "honey" love, we need a love that is in resurrection, a love that has been killed by the cross and resurrected with the divine life. There is no honey in such a love. In place of honey, there are frankincense and salt. According to Leviticus 2, the meal offering could have frankincense and salt, but not honey. The love among most Christians today is rarely the love in resurrection, which is the real love. Mostly, it is not only like honey, but also full of leaven. Although many Christians talk about love, this love may not be a love that has been dealt with by the cross and resurrected with the divine life. What we need is a resurrected love, a love which is in the divine life.

I like to see the brothers and sisters growing in life and experiencing the building, but I do not like to see any natural love. It is better to keep a distance between yourself and others. Do not wear their clothes; do not even use their Bibles. If your natural life has been dealt with, you will not want to use a Bible that belongs to someone else. Using another's Bible does not indicate that you love him in the spirit; rather, it proves that you love him according to your natural taste. You spend so much time with that particular brother because he matches your taste. You may think that you are growing in life as you fellowship with him. Actually, because your love for him is natural, you are not growing at all. The more we love others, the greater should be the distance between ourselves and them.

In the church life, we must learn to do everything in resurrection, not in our natural life. If you are not certain whether a thing you are about to do is in resurrection, please do not do it. Pray and wait until you have the assurance that you are in resurrection. The fact that the wall of the city of New Jerusalem is measured with the measurement of a man, that is, of an angel, means not only that it is measured according to the divine nature, but also that it is according to resurrection. You must love me and I must love you, not in our natural life, but in the divine life. Never yield an inch of ground to the natural life. No matter how much you love others, keep a distance between yourself and them. If you do this, you will be kept from the natural life, and you will love others in resurrection, according to humanity, but in angelic likeness.

In 1932, the year I came into the church life, I had my first lesson in learning how to do things in resurrection, not in my natural life. There was a certain sister who always helped others, but who did not have enough money to buy a good Bible for herself. She spent her money on the needy ones, not on herself. I came to know her situation and noticed that she had to use a very old Bible. Spontaneously I was burdened to buy her a good, leather-bound Bible and to give it to her anonymously. As I went to the Lord about this, I said, "Lord, I am about to buy a Bible for this sister. Am I doing this in my natural life or in Your resurrection life?" By inquiring of the Lord in this way, I learned a great deal. Because I was not certain that I was acting according to resurrection life, I was not able to buy the Bible immediately. I waited for a period of time until I was sure that I was not acting according to my natural life, but according to Christ's resurrection life. One day I purchased a Bible for her and gave it to her anonymously. Through receiving this gift of a Bible, her faith was confirmed, and she grew in the matter of believing the Lord. If I had given her a Bible a few weeks earlier, she would have not been helped in this regard. The very day I had the assurance that I could give her a Bible in resurrection was the exact day she needed to receive it.

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This message is the continuation of the previous one.

C. Unified in appearance on all four sides

As we have already pointed out, jasper is the appearance of God. The fact that the building material of the entire wall is jasper indicates that New Jerusalem, as the corporate expression of God in eternity, bears the appearance of God. This city is unified in appearance on all four sides. This indicates that all differences have vanished and that the city is the unique expression of the Triune God. This is vastly different from the concept of many Christians, who think that we all should be different and express Christ in different ways. According to this concept, you express Christ in your way, and I express Christ in my way. In the past I was taught that both the individual believers and the churches should be different from one another and that no church should be the same as others. I was not only taught this way, but I also preached it myself. I said that we should not imitate or copy others. Using our faces as an illustration, I said that every face is unique. But by studying the book of Revelation again, I saw that the seven lampstands are exactly the same. If all seven were placed on the table in front of you, you would not be able to tell them apart. Each lampstand would lose its identity. When I saw that, my point of view was radically revolutionized, and I said to myself, "What a mistaken concept I received from those who foolishly said that the seven churches are different! Yes, they are different in the negative aspects. Certainly the church in Philadelphia did not have the idols found in Thyatira. But on the positive side, they are all the same. They have one God and one Christ." I had truly been enlightened.

From that day onward, the Lord has pointed out this matter to me again and again, eventually showing me the four sides of the wall of New Jerusalem. Each side is the same in appearance. Although perhaps millions of jasper stones have been fit together to form the wall, every side of the wall has the same expression. Each side is the same in material, in substance, in color, and in appearance. Hence, we all must be alike. I must be like you, and you must be like me. Ultimately, we shall be so much like one another that we shall lose our identity. Seeing this enables us to understand Paul's word in 1 Corinthians 1:10: "But I beseech you, brothers, through the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that you all speak the same thing, and that there be no divisions among you, but that you be attuned in the same mind and in the same opinion." We must say the same thing and be attuned to the same opinion. This does not mean that we are controlled by anyone. None of the jasper stones built into the wall of New Jerusalem is controlled. They are the same in substance, in color, in appearance, in brightness, and in glory because they have been transformed by the same life. Thus, we all must imitate one another and copy one another. The sisters must imitate the brothers, and the brothers must copy the sisters. This does not mean to copy the natural characteristics of others. It means to copy the jasper, to copy the substance, the color, and the appearance.

Jasper is not a substance that was merely created by God. First it was created, and then it was transformed. All precious transparent stones, especially diamonds, are transformed substances. Diamond is carbon that has been transformed through heat and pressure into a pure crystal. None of us was created jasper. Rather, we were created clay (Gen. 2:7). Praise the Lord that we have been regenerated and that we are being transformed! Many of us are daily undergoing the process of transformation. Eventually, we shall be precious stones. We shall be jasper, possessing the life of God and bearing the appearance of God. We shall have the very element of God and the same appearance as He. God looks like jasper, and we also shall look like jasper. When we look at one another, we shall see in one another the appearance of God. Even the least one among us will look like God.

Do you think that, after we all have the substance, color, and appearance of jasper, we shall still debate or hold differing opinions? Certainly not! The New Jerusalem may be called a jasper city; it is not a city of wood. One day this city will appear bearing a bright green color to express God. In New Jerusalem we shall not express a German character, a British character, a Chinese character, an American character, or any other human character. Instead, we shall express the unique character, the divine character, which is God Himself in His appearance. The church today must also be like this. In such a church we all express God.

We have seen that the city of New Jerusalem is solidly and substantially golden. This indicates that the whole church should be solidly and substantially of the divine nature. This is the content of the church. The church must not have anything other than God Himself in His nature as its substance and content. Now we also see that the wall of the city bears God's appearance. To all people and to the whole universe the church must express God Himself.

The building of the church depends upon the substantial content of the church life. If the content is not God Himself, it will be impossible to have the genuine and proper building. But if our content is the divine nature, this content will transform us and even conform us to His image. Through this transformation, all our different concepts, views, and opinions will be swallowed up. This is what it means to be transformed by the renewing of our mind, as mentioned in Romans 12:2. The mind is renewed by the content of the church, the divine nature. When the divine nature occupies the inner part of the church and becomes its content, it will renew our mind and swallow up our different understandings, concepts, views, and opinions. The more the divine nature fills us from within, the more our concepts and opinions are spontaneously laid aside. As a result we no longer have a natural understanding of things. Rather, our concept is according to the divine nature. Hence, spontaneously we become of the same mind and opinion, we speak the same thing, and we have the unique expression, the appearance of God, and we are built up in this expression.

Suppose you cling to your natural concept, and I hold to my natural view. Both your concept and my view may be very good, not at all sinful. But because our concepts are different, they cannot be of the same jasper. However, when we are both filled with the divine nature and swallowed up by it, our concepts will be changed, and we shall all be of the same jasper. Then we shall have one mind, one concept, and one opinion. This is the way to be built into the church. We must drop all our different expressions that we may be built into the same wall and may all have the unique expression of God.

The church cannot be built through our efforts to be kind and patient with one another. Building is not a matter of my giving a little ground to you and of your giving ground to me. That is ethical behavior, something like the teaching of Confucius; it is not the teaching of the Bible. Genuine building is to be swallowed up by the divine nature and occupied, filled, saturated, and permeated with the divine nature. For this to take place, we must love the Lord and consecrate ourselves to Him without reservation, telling Him, "Lord, I don't want to keep anything of myself. I want to give my whole being to You and let You take full possession of me and occupy me to the uttermost. Lord, fill me with Yourself." This is the right way. Being built up in the church is not a matter of trying to love different kinds of people, or of trying to enlarge our heart to include those of a different disposition. This is a natural concept. What is needed is to have our disposition, whether it be American, Chinese, British, or German, swallowed up and replaced by the divine gold. If you are filled with the divine gold, your heart will be larger than Solomon's (1 Kings 4:29), because it will be as big as God's heart. When we are filled and permeated with the divine nature, we all have the same expression and appearance, for we all have the same opinion and speak the same thing. When we all have the same expression, we have the appearance of God, symbolized in the book of Revelation by jasper. This is the expression of the church life.

D. For separation and protection

Although the wall is mainly for expression, spontaneously it also becomes a separation and a protection. It separates us from everything common (Rev. 21:27), protects us, and keeps us in the realm of God's appearance. Anything that is separated is also preserved and protected. In the church life we must have God's expression. This divine expression is our separation, and this separation is our protection and preservation. If we all express God, we shall be separated from anything worldly. This is not a mere doctrine. If you live in this manner, you will have the full experience of what I am saying. If I express God in the appearance of jasper, I shall be completely separated from the world. Then I shall be protected, preserved, and kept in the expression of God. Some are captured by the distractions of the world because they do not express God in the appearance of jasper. Instead, they express something else. When we lose the divine expression and express something of ourselves in its place, our separation disappears, and we are no longer protected. As a result, we have no wall. Then there is no expression, no separation, and no protection. Praise the Lord that in the church life today our protection is the expression of God as our separation!

XI. Its foundations

A. A city of foundations

Now we come to the foundations of the city. This is very important. Hebrews 11:10, speaking of Abraham, says, “For he waited for the city which has the foundations, whose Architect and Maker is God.” The city of foundations, the New Jerusalem, was designed and made by God.

The Lord’s recovery has a solid foundation. From the time the Lord’s recovery was raised up among us more than fifty years ago, this testimony has been more and more solidly founded. During my life I have seen many Christian groups come and go. They were raised up and formed, and then they disappeared. Many of the free groups that began in this country some years ago are no longer in existence because they did not have a solid foundation. The church, a city of foundations, is not designed by man. It is both designed by God and built by Him. All the churches in the Lord’s recovery have been designed and built by God, not by man. Because we have such a solid foundation, the more we are opposed and attacked, the more solidly founded we become.

B. Of the apostles, no longer of the prophets

Verse 14 says, “And the wall of the city had twelve foundations, and on them twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb.” These foundations are not the foundation, which is Christ, according to 1 Corinthians 3:10-11. They are the twelve apostles of the Lamb. Today the church is built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets (Eph. 2:20). Since in eternity there will be no further need of the prophets, the foundations of the holy city will consist only of the apostles. When we enter into the new heaven and the new earth, all the four dispensations will have been completed, and there will be no need for prophecy. Everything will have been accomplished and fulfilled.

The twelve apostles here represent the grace of the New Testament, signifying that the New Jerusalem is built upon the grace of God. The entrance to the holy city is according to the law of God, and the city is built upon the grace of God.

C. Built with twelve precious stones

Verse 19 says, “The foundations of the wall of the city were adorned with every precious stone.” This verse and the next list the names of twelve precious stones, which are the twelve apostles of the Lamb, each of whom is signified by a precious stone. When Peter, the first of the twelve apostles, was brought to the Lord, the Lord changed his name to Cephas, which means “a stone” (John 1:42). Later, the Lord called him by this name when He spoke concerning the building of His church (Matt. 16:18). Precious stones are not created, but are transformed from something that has been created. All the apostles were created as clay, but they were regenerated and transformed into precious stones for God’s eternal building. This regeneration and transformation is required of every believer who will be a part of the New Jerusalem.

The foundations of the wall of the city are of twelve layers. Once again, the number twelve shows the completion in God’s eternal administration. The first layer is jasper, indicating that the likeness of God is the predominant appearance. The first layer of the wall’s foundation, as well as the entire wall of New Jerusalem, is built with jasper. This indicates that the main material in the building of the holy city is jasper. Since jasper signifies God expressed in His communicable glory, the main function of the holy city is to express God in bearing His glory (v. 11).

Now we must consider a very important matter regarding the twelve foundations. Although the entire wall is jasper, the twelve foundations are different stones with various colors. Each layer is different from the others. The reason for this is that the apostles had different ministries. Paul’s ministry was different from Peter’s, and Peter’s was different from John’s. However, these twelve foundations are not laid side by side; rather, they are laid one on top of another. The top layer, the layer that met the bottom of the wall, was jasper, the same color as the wall. Thus, all the work of the apostles issued in the same appearance, jasper. All twelve layers lead to and support the unique testimony in the unique expression.

The work of many so-called Christian workers leads to an individualistic appearance. But the work of the apostles led to one appearance. Today’s Christian workers not only have different colors; instead of being one on top of another, they are side by side. Thus, they have an individualistic expression, sometimes even with competition and striving with one another. The work of the apostles, on the contrary, was layer upon layer and led to the unique appearance of jasper, the appearance of God in Christ.

If you examine the ministries of the apostles in the New Testament, you will see that each ministry was upon the top of another, not side by side. In his book, *What Shall This Man Do?* Brother Nee describes the various ministries of the apostles. Peter, a fisherman, brought in the fish, the material. Paul, a tent maker, built up the tent with the materials brought in by Peter. Eventually, after the tent had been torn, the apostle John came in to mend it. Thus, Peter’s ministry was a fishing ministry, Paul’s was a building ministry, and John’s was a mending ministry. These three apostles worked one on top of the other. Paul’s work was upon Peter’s, and John’s work was upon Paul’s. As a result, they produced one building, not three distinct houses. Unlike Peter, Paul, and John, today’s so-called Christian workers all build up their own houses, each with its own design, shape, color, and expression. Therefore, in Christianity there are thousands of different houses. But in the entire universe there will only be the unique New Jerusalem, built upon the foundation of many ministries laid one on top of the other. May this matter become crystal clear to us.

By the Lord’s mercy, I can testify that I worked with Brother Nee for many years, but I do not bear an appearance different from his. I have the assurance and the boldness to say that my ministry is the same in appearance as Brother Nee’s ministry. No matter how much the enemy uses the opposers to attempt to separate me from him, I am now standing upon his shoulders. For this reason, in our ministries there was no division or differing opinion. But this does not mean that my ministry is exactly the same as Brother Nee’s ministry. If the Lord delays His coming back, I hope that some of the young brothers among us will be the continuation of the Lord’s recovery. However, we must realize that it is absolutely wrong to have another, side-by-side work. Your work must be a layer laid upon the present layer, and it must produce the same appearance.

Sooner or later, many of the Lord’s seekers who have been in His work for years, including some who are quite popular, will turn to the way of the Lord’s recovery. But we do not believe that the Lord will raise up any side-by-side work. Although there will be different ministries, they will be layer upon layer, and they will lead to the one appearance of God in Christ. No matter how many ministries we may have in the recovery, we shall have the same mind, the same concept, and the same opinion, and we shall all speak the same thing. However, this does not mean that all the ministries must be the same. We need different ministries, yet they must be layer upon layer. All the ministries must lead to one appearance — the appearance of today’s church and of the coming New Jerusalem.

Only recently did I see this matter of the twelve layers of the foundations being placed one on top of the other and bringing in one building with one appearance. All these ministries support and bear the same unique testimony. However, the situation of Christianity today is that of many different testimonies. The testimony of one group, for example, may be the washing of feet and the testimony of another group, the speaking in tongues. But we are not here for these things. We are for the unique expression of the Triune God, not for any specific practices or particular doctrines. Although our ministries may differ, our expression, our testimony, is just one. We are not building side by side; we are building one on top of another to bring forth the unique testimony of God in the universe.

D. The appearance in color like a rainbow

The colors of the twelve precious stones of the foundation, which signify the twelve apostles, are as follows: the first is green, the second and third are blue, the fourth is green, the fifth and sixth are red, the seventh is yellow, the eighth is bluish-green, the ninth is yellow, the tenth is apple-green, the eleventh and twelfth are purple. The twelve layers of the foundation in the above colors give the appearance of a rainbow, signifying that the city is built upon and secured by God’s faithfulness in keeping His covenant (Gen. 9:8-17). Because the foundation is built upon the very faithfulness with which God keeps His covenant, it is trustworthy and reliable.

The New Jerusalem

(5)

In this message we shall cover two very crucial aspects of New Jerusalem — its gates and its street. Undoubtedly, the city proper, the wall, and the foundations are very important. However, if the New Jerusalem had no gates, there would be no way to enter into it. In that case, this city would not be at all practical; it would be good only for exhibition. But because the New Jerusalem has twelve gates, it is very practical.

Some ministries are good. However, because these ministries have no gates and no streets, there is no way to actually enter into what they have to offer. The special character of Brother Nee's ministry is that whenever he ministered a particular matter, he always gave you a clear view of the way to enter into it. Many talk about Romans chapters five, six, seven, and eight. But no matter how much they talk about these chapters, they do not give you the way to get into them. Brother Nee's book, *The Normal Christian Life*, on the contrary, shows us the gates and a definite way to practice what this book describes. The more you read this book, the more you can see the gates it provides for you. Although I appreciated certain other ministries in the past, I eventually discovered that there was no way to enter into what was being presented. The ones who had those ministries could show me a beautiful building in the air that I could admire, but they provided no practical way for me to enter into it. The ministry in the Lord's recovery today continues the principle of Brother Nee's ministry. Everything we minister is presented in a practical way. Hence, you have a way to enter into what the ministry provides you. Likewise, New Jerusalem is practical. Its practicality is seen in its gates and in its street. No matter from what direction you approach this city, you have a way to enter into it.

This matter of practicality has caused me to lose a number of good, intimate friends in the Lord. Once I was invited to England to stay with a brother who had an outstanding ministry. While I was there, this brother and I had a number of long conversations lasting two to three hours each. All our conversations concerned the practicality of the Body of Christ. We both had seen the Body, God's present testimony, and the principle of resurrection life. I could echo what this brother had seen, and he could echo what I had seen, especially regarding the Lord's Body. However, there was a difference between us. Through the help of Brother Nee, I had seen the practicality of the Body and was burdened to take care of this. But those related to this ministry in England did not care for the practical aspect. Eventually, through our lengthy conversations, I learned that this brother had only the view of the Body, but no practical way to experience it. He neither saw this practicality nor was willing to see it. I made it clear to him that we wanted not only the vision of the Body, but also the practicality of the Body. In my concern for the practicality of the church, I have published the book entitled, *The Practical Expression of the Church*. Although I have lost some dear friends over the matter of the practicality of the church, the way is still the way. During the more than eighteen years since my visit with this brother in England, the Lord has vindicated the practicality of the church.

XII. Its gates

Let us now devote our attention to the gates of New Jerusalem. The significance of the gates is not less profound than that of the foundations. It is crucial to grasp the significance of these twelve gates.

A. Three on each of the four sides

Revelation 21:13 reveals that in New Jerusalem there are three gates on the east, three on the north, three on the south, and three on the west. Thus, the city lies square (v. 16), with three gates on each of its four sides. The east side at the front, toward the glory of the sunrising, ranks first; the north side at the top ranks second; the south side at the bottom ranks third; and the west side at the rear ranks fourth. The gates on the four sides are toward the four directions of the earth, signifying the availability of the entrance of the holy city to all the peoples on earth. (Compare with the four heads of the river in Genesis 2:10-14.)

1. The Triune God being available to all people

The three gates on each side signify that the Triune God — Father, Son, and Spirit — work together to bring people into the holy city. This is indicated in the three parables in Luke 15 and implied in the Lord's word in Matthew 28:19. The three parables in Luke 15 concern the shepherd and the lost sheep, the woman and the lost coin, and the father and the returned prodigal son. The shepherd refers to the Son; the father, of course, to the Father; and the woman signifies the Spirit. In order for a sinner to be brought back to the Father's house, there is the need of the Son, the shepherd, to bring back the lost sheep; there is the need of the Spirit to enlighten the hearts of people that they may repent; and there is the need of the Father to receive the returned and repentant prodigal son. Hence, the Triune God is the entrance into the New Jerusalem.

The fact that the Triune God is working to bring people into the holy city is also implied in the Lord's word in Matthew 28:19. To be baptized into the Father, the Son, and the Spirit is the entrance into the holy city. Thus, the Father, Son, and Spirit are the three gates on each side of the city. The three gates are not on three sides respectively; rather, there are three gates on each of the four sides repeatedly. The gates on any one of the sides are exactly the same as the gates on the other three sides. This indicates that the Triune God is available to people in all four corners of the earth.

The three gates indicate that the Triune God has come to reach us and to bring us into His eternal economy. The three in the Godhead, the Father, the Son, and the Spirit, have come out in God's economy to reach us and to bring us back to His economy. A number of verses in the New Testament speak of the Triune God. For example, in Ephesians 3:14 through 17 Paul said, "I bow my knees unto the Father... that He would grant you, according to the riches of His glory, to be strengthened with power through His Spirit into the inner man; that Christ may make His home in your hearts through faith." In these verses we see the Father, the Spirit, and Christ, the Son. Second Corinthians 13:14 also unfolds the Triune God: "The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all." In this verse the three of the Godhead are for His dispensing, for His going out and coming in, that is, for His spreading out and our entering in.

The first mention of man in the whole Bible speaks of him in relation to the Triune God. Genesis 1:26 says, "And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness." The "us" in this verse refers to the Triune God. Thus, in the verse where man is first mentioned, God is alluded to as being triune. If God were not triune, He would not be able to dispense Himself into us, to work Himself into us, and to mingle Himself with us. But because God is triune, He can enter into human beings. The Father is the source, the Son is the course, and the Spirit is the flow. In this way, the Triune God comes into us.

2. The mingling of the Triune God with His creature, man

Three gates on each of the four sides, constituting the number twelve, also imply the mingling of the Triune God with man, God's creature. The number four signifies the creature (4:6), and the number three, of course, signifies the Triune God. The number twelve does not denote addition but multiplication. Three times four indicates that the Triune God mingles Himself with His creature, man, to produce a composition, a compound.

B. Every gate being a pearl

Verse 21 says, "And the twelve gates were twelve pearls; each one of the gates was, respectively, of one pearl." We have seen that gold signifies the divine nature and that the precious stones signify what is produced by the transforming work of the Spirit. The significance of the pearl is found in the way it is produced. Pearls are produced by oysters in the waters of death. When the oyster is wounded by a particle of sand, it secretes its life-juice around the sand and makes it a precious pearl. This depicts Christ as the living One coming into the death waters, being wounded by us, and secreting His life-juice over us to make us precious pearls for the building of God's eternal expression.

We must admire God's wisdom. Nearly everything in His creation is an illustration of an aspect of His economy. When the Lord Jesus was on earth, He used many of the things found in nature as parables. Light, wheat, food, and even pearl-producing oysters are parables. Christ, the living One, entered into our death situation and lived in it. Through living in the waters of death, He was wounded by us. After wounding Him, we remained near His wound. This means that we repented, believed in Him, and received Him. How deeply we appreciate the wounds He suffered in His crucifixion! As we stay near His wounds, He secretes the life-juice of His resurrection life, and this life-juice envelops us and eventually transforms us into pearls. By staying at Christ's wound, we receive His life and are regenerated. By remaining there after our regeneration, we are also transformed and become pearls.

That the twelve gates of the holy city are twelve pearls signifies that regeneration through the death-overcoming and life-secreting Christ is the entrance into the city. This entrance meets the requirement of the law as represented by Israel and as observed by the guarding angels (v. 12). Hence, the pearl is the entrance into the city. How did you enter into the New Jerusalem? Did you climb over the wall? This would be impossible because the wall is too high. The only way to enter into the New Jerusalem is through the pearl gates, through the gates constituted with the overcoming death and the life-imparting resurrection of Christ. Praise the Lord, we have all entered the New Jerusalem in this way! We confessed, we repented, we appreciated His death, and we enjoyed staying at His wounds. Immediately, we received the life-secretion that regenerated us and that is now transforming us. Through our experience of the death and resurrection of Christ, we have passed through the pearl gates and are now within the city. Hallelujah!

The fact that each one of the gates is, respectively, of one pearl indicates that the entrance into the city is unique and once for all; that is, it is only through the once-for-all regeneration by Christ's overcoming death and life-imparting resurrection.

C. Bearing the names of the twelve tribes of Israel

The names of the twelve tribes of the sons of Israel are inscribed on the twelve gates of the city (v. 12). Israel here represents the law of the Old Testament, indicating that the law is represented at the gates of New Jerusalem. The law watches and observes to insure that all the communications, the comings in and the goings out, of the holy city meet its requirements. Thus, all the communications of this city are according to the law of God.

The apostles represent grace, whereas the twelve tribes of Israel represent the law. The twelve gates were produced according to the law. Christ died for our sin according to the law and, in a very positive sense, He was also resurrected from among the dead for the complement of the law. Even our repentance was according to the law, for we repented because we had violated the law, and we confessed our sins according to the law. Thus, the law was the basic factor in Christ's death and in our repentance and confession. This means that the twelve pearl gates are absolutely according to the law and have fulfilled the requirements of the law. Our entrance into the holy city did not break the law; rather, it was according to the law and even a fulfillment of the law. Whatever the law required was fulfilled in our entering into the city. In other words, we entered into New Jerusalem according to the law. Our entrance was altogether legal and lawful because by His death and resurrection Christ had completely fulfilled the requirements of the law. This matter is quite deep.

Because our entrance into the New Jerusalem through the pearl gates had to be according to the law, we all had to repent, confess our sins, and say "O Lord Jesus, You not only died for my sins; You also died for me. Lord, I confess that I am sinful, that I have committed a great many sins, and that I am worthy of nothing but death. Lord, how I thank You for dying for me." This kind of repentance and confession fulfills the requirement of the law and makes our entrance into the city lawful.

D. Having twelve angels at the twelve gates

The middle part of verse 12 says, "Having twelve gates, and at the gates twelve angels." The twelve gates of the city are for communication, for coming in and going out. Twelve is the number of absolute perfection and eternal completion in God's administration. Hence, twelve gates indicate that the communication in the New Jerusalem is absolutely perfect and eternally complete for God's administration.

Verse 12 tells us that at the gates of the city there are twelve angels. In God's eternal economy, angels are ministering spirits rendering service to those who inherit salvation and participate in the eternal blessing of the New Jerusalem, the center of the new heaven and new earth. The angels will be the gatekeepers of our possession, while we shall be the ones enjoying the rich inheritance in God's eternal economy. This is all in the significance of the number twelve.

The angels at the twelve gates observe the enjoyment of those who enter in. In Luke 15:10 the Lord said, "In the same way, I tell you, there is joy in the presence of the angels of God over one sinner repenting." Whenever a sinner repents, the angels in heaven are happy. When you repented and received the Lord, did you notify the angels of this fact? Of course not. Long before you were ever saved, the angels were observing you all the time, realizing that you had been chosen and predestinated, pre-marked by God. Due to your stubbornness, it might have taken you more than fifteen or twenty years to repent. But on the day you repented and called on the name of the Lord Jesus, the angels who were watching you rejoiced. Your angel might have said, "The one whom I have been observing for more than twenty-five years has finally repented. Hallelujah!"

The angels observe us according to the law to see whether we have truly repented and confessed our sins to God and whether we have entered into the holy city according to the law of Israel. The children of Israel represent the law, and the angels, "ministering spirits, sent forth for service for the sake of those who are about to inherit salvation" (Heb. 1:14), are gatekeepers. Firstly, the angels watch at the gates to see how we repent. Then, after we have repented and entered into New Jerusalem, the angels become our servants. We are the heirs, owners of the universe, and the angels are our servants. According to the ancient custom among the Jews in Palestine, the servants were concerned that the heirs would receive their portion and inheritance. Likewise, the angels, the servants of our Father's family, are very concerned about our inheritance and about the fact that the heirs have been lost and have fallen away. Thus, the angelic gatekeepers are waiting for us to come back. When they see us returning, they rejoice and immediately begin to minister to us, gladly helping the repentant heirs enjoy their legal inheritance. By this brief consideration of the angels, we see once again that in order to understand any point in the book of Revelation, we must trace the development of this matter throughout the Scriptures.

Psalms 34:7 says, "The angel of the Lord encampeth round about them that fear him, and delivereth them." According to this verse, angels even camp around us to protect us. Many nights I have said, "Lord, exercise Your authority to send a camp of angels to protect my house." I have especially prayed this way when I was traveling and spending a night in a room on the upper floor of a hotel. Being concerned about the possibility of fire, I asked the Lord to send the angels to camp around me. The angels are truly the servants of the legal and genuine heirs of the riches of God.

E. Being open all the time

Verse 25 says, "And its gates shall by no means be shut by day, for night shall not be there." The wall of the city will separate it from the nations, but the gates will keep it open to them continually.

XIII. Its street

Verse 21 says, "And the street of the city was pure gold as transparent glass." The gates are for entering into the city, whereas the street is for the daily walk, the daily living. The entering into the city is through Christ's death and resurrection, whereas the daily walk, the daily living in the city, is according to the divine nature, signified by the street being pure gold. Following the entrance of regeneration, the daily life and walk of the saints must be in the way of the divine nature. The divine nature is their way.

The Bible is different from the natural human concept. According to the human concept, we firstly walk on the street and then enter the gate. But in the Bible we firstly enter the gate and then walk on the street. In Catholicism people are told that they must first work and then receive salvation. This thought is devilish. In God's economy we receive salvation first, and then we work. Firstly, we enter into grace; then we walk in grace. Never think that by walking or working you will eventually be qualified to receive grace. No, grace is free. After you have entered in through the gates by grace, you will begin to walk, and you will need to walk a long way.

It is a very long way from the gates to the top of the golden mountain where the throne of God is. Recall that the New Jerusalem, a golden mountain, is twelve thousand stadia high (more than thirteen hundred and sixty miles). Furthermore, the golden street is a spiral, and this makes the way a great deal longer. Nevertheless, we have no choice except to walk on this street. I have been walking on this street for more than fifty-one years, and I am still on the way. Although I may desire to walk faster, sometimes the brothers drag me back, and I am forced to wait for them.

A. Uniquely one

The street in New Jerusalem is uniquely one. There is no maze, no leading astray, and no getting lost. This street is unique. No matter through which gate you enter into the city, you will find yourself on the same street. In the New Jerusalem there is no such thing as a Baptist street, a Presbyterian street, a Methodist street, or a Lutheran street. Neither is the street in New Jerusalem related to any "ism." The street is God's divine nature. In this divine nature we are one.

B. Being pure gold

Verse 21 says that the street of the city is pure gold. We have seen that gold signifies the divine nature. After we are saved and enter into New Jerusalem, we must walk on the divine nature as our way. The divine nature is our way and our strength. Suppose a sister says to me, "Brother Lee, I love the Lord and I want to live in the New Jerusalem. Can you tell me the style of clothing I should wear and how I should fashion my hair?" I would tell this sister that she should choose her clothes and fashion her hair according to the divine nature within her. The style, color, material, and design of her clothing should be according to the divine gold within. The divine nature is our street, our way, and we all must walk according to it. Today, our way is not that of regulations; it is the divine nature. Do you not have the gold nature within you? Then walk according to it. Since you have the divine life with the divine nature, why do you not walk upon it? Is your speaking according to the divine nature or according to your muddy human nature? May we all see that today the nature of God is our street.

We in the Lord's recovery are walking in the divine nature. As many of the leading brothers can testify, I do not tell others what to do. Rather, I encourage them to walk according to the divine nature within them. Because the divine nature is our golden street, in the church life we have no need for regulations. The street itself is our regulation, for nothing regulates people more than a street. Every driver of an automobile is spontaneously regulated by the street on which he drives. In the New Jerusalem everyone is regulated by the unique street, by the golden nature of God within us.

C. As transparent glass

The pure gold, which symbolizes both the street and the city proper of New Jerusalem, is as transparent glass (v. 18), signifying that the whole city is transparent. The golden street is crystal clear, without any opaqueness. Although the pearls may be opaque, every one of them is a great open gate, which will not be shut by day or by night.

D. A spiral, coming down from the throne of God

The street of New Jerusalem is a spiral, coming down from the throne of God to reach all God's chosen ones. Hence, this street reaches every gate. It also leads us from the gates to God's throne.

E. One street serving twelve gates in four directions

The one street serves all twelve gates in four directions. On this street all God's redeemed walk in absolute oneness as they are led by the street to the throne of God. Hence, in New Jerusalem there is one street leading to one goal.

F. With the life supply

Revelation 22:1 says, "And he showed me a river of water of life, bright as crystal, proceeding out of the throne of God and of the Lamb in the middle of its street." This verse reveals that the river of water of life is flowing in the middle of the street. Therefore, in this street is the life supply. Furthermore, as 22:2 says, "And on this side and on that side of the river was the tree of life, producing twelve fruits, yielding its fruit each month." Here we see that the tree of life, which is in the river, grows on the two sides of the river along the street. Thus, all the life supply is related to the street. The more we walk, act, and have our being according to the divine nature, the more of the life supply we shall receive. However, if you do not care for the divine nature within you, but do things according to your taste, you will immediately lose the supply of life. But if you take care of the divine nature within you in a practical way in your daily life, you will enjoy the rich life supply found along the golden street.

The New Jerusalem

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XIV. Its temple

In previous messages we have considered the city proper, the foundations, the wall, the gates, and the street. Now we come to the temple, a very significant topic in the Bible.

A. The Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb

Revelation 21:22 says, "And I saw no temple in it, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb." This verse clearly says that in New Jerusalem there will be no temple. The Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb are its temple. In the Old Testament the tabernacle of God was the precursor, or the forerunner, of the temple of God. New Jerusalem as the tabernacle of God (v. 3) will be the temple of God. This indicates that in the new heaven and new earth the temple of God will be enlarged into a city. The three equal dimensions of the city (v. 16) indicate that the whole city will be the Holy of Holies, the inner temple. Hence, there will be no temple in it.

The Greek word for temple in verse 22, naos, does not denote the whole temple in a common way including the Holy of Holies and the Holy Place. Rather, it denotes the inner temple, the Holy of Holies. This inner temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb, signifying that God and the Lamb will be the place in which we serve God. The holy city as the tabernacle of God is for God to dwell in, and God and the Lamb as the temple are for us to dwell in. In the new heaven and new earth, the New Jerusalem will be a mutual dwelling place for both God and man for eternity.

The entire city of New Jerusalem is the Holy of Holies, and God and the Lamb are the temple in this city. If we put these two points together, we shall realize that this city is God and the Lamb. Because the whole city is the Holy of Holies and because the inner temple is God and the Lamb, the city is God and the Lamb.

Furthermore, the whole city is called the tabernacle (v. 3). Just as a boy is the precursor of a man, so the tabernacle is the precursor of the temple. Before the temple appears, there is the tabernacle. But when the tabernacle comes into its fullness, it becomes the temple. Therefore, we need to keep three points before us: that the whole city is the Holy of Holies; that the temple is God Himself and the Lamb; and that the whole city is the tabernacle. When we put all these points together, we see that God Himself is the whole city of New Jerusalem.

However, as we have pointed out elsewhere, the whole city of New Jerusalem is also a living composition of all God's redeemed ones. On the one hand, God is the entire city; on the other hand, the city is a living composition of the redeemed. If you find this difficult to grasp with your natural mind, let me ask you this question: Do we not say that the church today is Christ, and do we not also say that it is a composition of all the believers? On the one hand, the church is a composition of all the believers; on the other hand, Christ is both the Head and the Body. Hence, we have the term, the Body-Christ. First Corinthians 12:12 indicates that Christ is not only the Head, but also the Body: "For as the body is one, and hath many members, and all the members of that one body, being many, are one body: so also is Christ." The principle in both the church and New Jerusalem is the same.

The church is the enlargement of Christ. Christ Himself is the individual Christ, but the church is the corporate Christ, Christ enlarged and expanded. Therefore, the church is Christ's expansion, Christ's enlargement. In like manner, New Jerusalem is the enlargement and the expansion of the Triune God.

Many religious people will not agree with such a statement because they lack experience. Some would even slander us, saying that we teach evolution into God. Although we repudiate this slanderous accusation, we do say that we are the expansion of God and the enlargement of God. After those who oppose and criticize us today are perfected, they may say, "Brother Lee, you were right. We apologize for opposing you. When we were in the dispensation of grace, we did not have the experience. For this reason, we were so foolish as to oppose you. But we were dealt with during the dispensation of the kingdom, and we have been perfected. Now that we are together in eternity, we want to be reconciled to you and ask you to forgive us." If any will say this, I will tell them that I forgave them already in the dispensation of grace. Sooner or later, in this age, in the next age, or in eternity, those who are opposing us will have to admit that the ultimate revelation of the Bible portrays the New Jerusalem as the enlargement of God.

The New Jerusalem is both the temple and the tabernacle. This means that New Jerusalem will not only be the enlargement of God, the temple, but also the tabernacle, God and the Lamb overshadowing His redeemed with Himself as the tabernacle. Revelation 7:15, speaking of the great multitude serving God in the heavenly temple, says, "Therefore they are before the throne of God, and serve Him day and night in His temple; and He who sits upon the throne shall spread His tabernacle over them." God shall overshadow His redeemed ones by spreading Himself over them. In Psalm 90:1 Moses said, "Lord, thou hast been our dwelling place in all generations." Moses knew that God Himself is our eternal dwelling place, our eternal habitation. Psalm 90 is a prophecy of this. I do not care to live in a heavenly mansion. I prefer to dwell in God, even in the enlargement of God. Our natural mind would never think that we could dwell in God. Nevertheless, the entire city of New Jerusalem will be God Himself as our habitation. The expansion and the enlargement of God will be our eternal city in which we shall dwell for eternity. All of God's redeemed will serve and dwell in God and the Lamb as the temple.

In both the Old Testament and the New Testament, the tabernacle was the precursor of the temple. When the Lord Jesus was incarnated, He tabernacled among us (John 1:14) and He was also the temple (John 2:19-21). Today, the church is the temple (1 Cor. 3:16). These two terms, tabernacle and temple, are used again and again in the Bible. Hence, if we would know the New Jerusalem, we must study all the portions in the Old Testament and the New Testament concerning the tabernacle and the temple. Strictly speaking, the tabernacle was not mainly for people to dwell in; it was for God's habitation. Eventually, New Jerusalem will be the habitation of both God and man. This means that it will be a mutual habitation. God will be our dwelling place, and we shall be His dwelling place.

We have a miniature of this mutual habitation in the Lord's word, "Abide in Me, and I in you" (John 15:4). To abide in the Lord means to take Him as our dwelling, as our habitation. When we take the Lord as our dwelling, He abides in us. This abiding is mutual, for we abide in the Lord, and He abides in us. There is no need to wait until the coming New Jerusalem to abide in the Lord and to have Him abide in us. I can testify strongly that many times I know that I am truly in the Lord and that He is actually abiding in Me. Even this morning I abode in Him and He abode in me. Although this is difficult to explain, it is nonetheless a fact in our experience. We all can testify that whenever we abide in Him, we immediately sense that He is abiding in us. If you say, "Lord Jesus, how I thank You that right now I am abiding in You," you will immediately have the deep sense that He is abiding in you. Wherever you are, at home, at work, or at school, you can say, "O Lord Jesus, I am abiding in You right now," and something within you will say, "And I am abiding in you." This is a miniature of the coming New Jerusalem, which will simply be a mutual abiding place for us and for God and the Lamb.

On the one hand, we shall be the New Jerusalem; on the other hand, it will be God and the Lamb. It is the same in principle with the church today. On the one hand, we are the church, and on the other hand, the church is Christ. This matter of the mutual dwelling place is deep and profound. The new city will be our dwelling place, and it will also be God's dwelling place. It is similar to the temple, which was firstly God's dwelling place and then the place where the priests served God. This new city will be God Himself. We shall dwell in God to serve God. The very God whom we serve will be the temple in which we serve Him. How wonderful! May we all experience Him in such a deep way.

XV. Its light

Verse 23 says, "And the city has no need of the sun nor of the moon that they should shine in it, for the glory of God illumined it, and its lamp is the Lamb." In the millennium the light of the sun and the moon will be intensified (Isa. 30:26). But in the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and the new earth there is no need of the sun nor of the moon. The sun and moon will be in the new heaven and new earth, but they will not be needed in New Jerusalem; for there God, the divine light, will shine much more brightly.

The temple of the city is God Himself, and the light is also God Himself. Apart from God and the Lamb, there is nothing in this city. In the New Jerusalem, God is everything.

The Lamb as the lamp shines with God as the light to illumine the city with the glory of God, the expression of the divine light. Since such a divine light will illumine the holy city, it has no need of any other light, whether created by God or made by man (22:5). There will be no need of natural light. Although the sun and moon will be in the new heaven and new earth, we shall have no need for them because our dwelling place will be much brighter than either of them. Man-made light will not be needed either. God Himself will be the light in the holy city. Because Christ is the light in the church, it is the same today in the church life.

Verse 23 says that the Lamb, Christ, is the lamp. God is the light, and Christ is the lamp. The light needs the light-bearer. We should never separate Christ from God or God from Christ. Actually, God and Christ are one light. God is the content, and Christ is the light-bearer, the expression. This affords us an understanding of the Trinity that is different from the traditional teaching. This verse describes God as the light and Christ, the Son, as the lamp. As the light is in the lamp to be its content and to be expressed through the lamp, so God the Father is in the Son to be expressed through the Son.

In New Jerusalem there will be no night, for "night shall be no more" (22:5). In the new heaven and new earth there will still be the distinction between day and night, but in the New Jerusalem there will be no such distinction. Outside the city there will be night, but within the city there will be no night because we shall have an eternal divine light, God Himself.

Verse 24 says, "And the nations shall walk by its light." In the millennium the light of the moon will be as the light of the sun, and the light of the sun will be intensified sevenfold (Isa. 30:26). I believe that in the new heaven and the new earth the light of the sun will even be brighter than this. Nevertheless, verse 24 says that the nations will walk in the light of the city. This proves that the light in the city will be stronger than the natural light. God will shine through the city, and this shining will be brighter than either the moon or the sun. Actually, the nations will not need to walk in the sunlight or in the moonlight, for they will walk in the shining of New Jerusalem.

The church should be such a shining light today, and all our neighbors should walk in the light of our shining. Today the church is the light-bearer, bearing Christ as the light shining to this generation. We need to be such a shining church. I am sorry to say that there is very little shining in Christianity. Due to this lack of shining, it is difficult to distinguish Christians from non-Christians. With the church people, there should be a difference, a difference not of some man-made designation, but a difference because of our shining. We must shine so that the nations may walk in our light.

XVI. Its glory

In verse 11 we have a description of the glory of New Jerusalem, "Having the glory of God. Her light was like a most precious stone, as a jasper stone, clear as crystal." The glory of God is the expression of God, God expressed. When God is manifested, that is glory. We have been ordained for this glory and called to this glory (1 Cor. 2:7; 1 Pet. 5:10; 1 Thes. 2:12). We are being transformed into this glory (2 Cor. 3:18), and we shall be brought into it (Heb. 2:10). Eventually, we shall be glorified with Christ (Rom. 8:17, 30) to bear the glory of God for God's expression in the New Jerusalem.

The Greek word translated light in verse 11 means "luminary" or "light-bearer." Today the believers as children of light (Eph. 5:8) are the light of the world (Matt. 5:14), shining in the midst of a crooked and perverse generation (Phil. 2:15). Eventually, New Jerusalem as a composition of all the saints will be the light-bearer, shining forth God as light over the nations around her.

The brightness of the glory of New Jerusalem is like a most precious stone. This precious stone is not the light, but the light-bearer. It does not have light in itself, but the light, which is God, has been wrought into it and shines out through it. This indicates that as a part of the coming New Jerusalem, we must be transformed into precious stones with God wrought into our being as the shining light that we may be the light-bearer to shine as God's expression.

XVII. Its appearance

The appearance of the city is "as a jasper stone, clear as crystal" (v. 11). Jasper is the appearance of God (Rev. 4:3). The light of the New Jerusalem is like jasper stone, bearing the appearance of God to express God by her shining.

The whole city of New Jerusalem is just God. The light is God, its glory is the expression of God, and its appearance is God Himself revealed to the nations. This is wonderful. All this should be found in the church life today. The church is God's temple. God Himself in the church is our dwelling place, and He is also the light which shines out through us to all our neighbors and which is also the glory and appearance of the church. This is the church life.

The New Jerusalem

(7)

XVIII. Its center

Every nation has a center. The center of a nation is its capital, the place where the central government is located. The New Jerusalem also has a center, which is the throne of our redeeming God, the throne of God and of the Lamb (Rev. 22:1).

We have pointed out that in the first section of this book (1:1—11:19) the throne of God is the center and that in the second section (12:1—22:21) the temple of God is the center. We have also considered the phrase “out of the temple from the throne” (Rev. 16:17, see messages forty-nine and fifty). At the end of the book of Revelation, the throne of God is in the temple. Thus, the throne and temple have become one.

Our God is not only the God on the throne for His administration, nor only the God in the temple for His expression. He is the very God on the throne in the temple for His expression through His administration. God’s throne is for His administration, and God’s temple is for His expression. The fact that the throne is in the temple means that God’s administration is for His expression. All that God administrates is that He might be expressed. In eternity future God’s throne will be in the center of New Jerusalem, and His expression will extend to the circumference. Therefore, our God is both the God of administration and the God of expression.

A. The throne of God and of the Lamb

Revelation 22:1 says, “And he showed me a river of water of life, bright as crystal, proceeding out of the throne of God and of the Lamb in the middle of its street.” The throne of God and of the Lamb, one throne for both God and the Lamb, signifies that God and the Lamb are one — the Lamb-God, the redeeming God, God the Redeemer. In eternity, the very God who will sit on the throne is our redeeming God, from whose throne proceeds the river of water of life for our supply and satisfaction. This depicts how the Triune God — God, the Lamb, and the Spirit, symbolized by the water of life — dispenses Himself into His redeemed under His headship (implied in the authority of the throne) for eternity.

Notice that there are not two thrones, one for God and another for the Lamb. According to the traditional terms used in Christianity, the reference to God and the Lamb means that two distinct Persons, God and the Lamb, are on one throne. How could God and the Lamb sit on one throne? Do they sit side by side? In 21:23 we find a clue to the correct answer to these questions. In this verse God is likened to light and the Lamb is likened to a lamp. The light and the lamp cannot be separated; neither can they stand side by side. Rather, the light shines out from within the lamp. Therefore, God as the light is in the Lamb as the lamp. God and the Lamb are not sitting side by side; rather, the very God is within the Lamb as the lamp and shines out through Him.

I would like to see how those who use the traditional teachings of the Trinity to oppose us would explain how God and the Lamb are on the same throne. It is better not to use the term person; for by using it we become entangled and are not able to understand the Bible thoroughly according to the pure Word. The Bible reveals that God is the light and that the Lamb is the lamp. Eventually, because the light is in the lamp, these are not two entities; they are one entity in two aspects. It is very difficult to explain the Trinity in human language because we simply do not have the vocabulary or the terminology to express it adequately. Although we do not have the proper words, we do have a picture of God as light and of Christ, the Lamb, as the lamp. The fact that both are sitting on one throne indicates that They are not two, but one.

The One on the throne is both the God who created and the Lamb who redeemed. Hence, we may call Him the Lamb-God. This means that He is the redeeming God. This redeeming God is on the throne of His administration that He may dispense Himself into all His redeemed.

B. On the top of the golden mountain

The throne in New Jerusalem is on top of the golden mountain. The one street in this city eventually leads to the throne. The Lord Jesus came down to earth from His throne that He might bring God into man. This is the Triune God coming out of Himself to reach mankind. When we received Him into us, we were baptized into Him. Baptism is the real entrance into the Triune God (Matt. 28:19, Gk.), and the entrance into the Triune God is the initial entrance into New Jerusalem. Immediately after we pass through the pearl gates, we find ourselves on the golden street that leads us upward to the throne of God.

C. As the unique source of the life supply

The throne of God in the center of New Jerusalem is the unique source of the life supply. It is by His administration that God dispenses Himself into us as life, as the life supply, and as the eternal, absolute, all-inclusive grace. His dispensing of Himself into us depends upon His administration. For this reason, in the church life today there is divine authority and church government. There is a divine government in the church life today, and this government comes from the throne of God. The divine authority in the church is for God to dispense Himself into us as life, as the life supply, and as the all-sufficient grace. Only by submitting ourselves to God’s authority, God’s government, can we share in His all-sufficient grace.

D. With the divine authority of the headship

The throne of God and of the Lamb in the center of New Jerusalem symbolizes the divine authority of God’s headship in Christ. The life supply flows out of this authority, and the enjoyment of the life supply brings us under this authority. The flow of the water of life not only affords us the life supply, but also brings to us the divine authority. In the flow of the water of life there are the life supply and the divine authority with the fellowship in life. When we participate in the life supply, we are brought under God’s authority in the fellowship of life.

I am sorry that some Christians utilize Brother Nee’s book, *Spiritual Authority*, to make themselves an authority over others. This kind of authority is self-assumed. Genuine authority comes from the throne of God’s administration in the center of New Jerusalem, through the enjoyment of the life supply in the fellowship of life with God.

XIX. Its life supply

A. The river of water of life

Now we must consider how the redeeming God sitting on the throne dispenses Himself into all His redeemed. God dispenses Himself into us by means of the river proceeding out of the throne. According to verse 1, this river is called “a river of water of life.” The river, as typified by the rivers in Gen. 2:10-14, Psa. 46:4, and Ezek. 47:5-9, signifies the abundance of life in its flow. It is one river, flowing through the four directions of the holy city like the four heads of the one river in Genesis 2:10-14. This one river with its riches becomes many rivers in our experience, as indicated in John 7:38.

The water of life is a symbol of God in Christ as the Spirit flowing Himself into His redeemed people to be their life and life supply. It is typified by the water that came out of the riven rock (Exo. 17:6; Num. 20:11) and is symbolized by the water that flowed out of the pierced side of the Lord Jesus (John 19:34). Here, this water of life becomes a river, proceeding out of the throne of God and of the Lamb to supply and saturate the entire New Jerusalem. Thus, it is filled with the divine life to express God in His glory of life.

We need to see this river in more detail. Genesis 2:10 says, “And a river went out of Eden to water the garden; and from thence it was parted, and became into four heads.” According to this verse, the one river eventually became four heads reaching the four directions of the earth. There are many other references to this river in the Old Testament. Psalm 46:4 says, “There is a river, the streams whereof shall make glad the city of God.” In Ezekiel 47 the water that issues out from under the threshold of the house becomes “waters to swim in, a river that could not be passed over” (v. 5). Verse 9 of the same chapter says that “every thing shall live whither the river cometh.”

This river is also mentioned in the New Testament. Speaking of the children of Israel and their wandering in the wilderness, 1 Corinthians 10:4 says, “And all drank the same spiritual drink; for they drank of a spiritual rock which followed them, and the rock was Christ.” When the children of Israel murmured because of their thirst, God told Moses to smite the rock and that water would come out of it for the people to drink (Exo. 17:1-6). Moses did so and the Lord “brought streams also out of the rock, and caused waters to run down like rivers” (Psa. 78:16). The water that came out of the smitten rock was a type of the life-giving Spirit. The Lord Jesus spoke of this Spirit in the Gospel of John. In John 4:10 the Lord indicated to the Samaritan woman that He was the giver of living water, and in verse 14 He said, “Whoever drinks of the water that I shall give him shall by no means thirst forever; but the water that I shall give him shall become in him a spring of water welling up into eternal life.” Moreover, in John 7:37 and 38 the Lord Jesus said, “If anyone thirst, let him come to Me and drink. He who believes in Me, as the Scripture said, out of his innermost being shall flow rivers of living water.” Here we see that the one river becomes many rivers. The rivers of living water are the many flows of the different aspects of life of the unique river of water of life, which is God’s Spirit of life (see Rom. 15:30; 1 Thes. 1:6; 2 Thes. 2:13; Gal. 5:22-23; Rom. 8:2). Thus, if we would understand the meaning of the river of water of life mentioned in 22:1, we must trace the origin and development of this matter of the river throughout the Scriptures.

1. Proceeding out of the throne of the Lamb-God

We have seen that the river of water of life proceeds out of the throne of the Lamb-God. This river is nothing less than the flowing Spirit of God as the life-giving Spirit. In 22:1 we see the Triune God — God, the Lamb, and the river. God, the Father, is the source; the Lamb, the Son, is the Redeemer; and the river is the Spirit. Hence, we have the Father as the source, the Son as the course, and the Spirit as the flow. Therefore, in 22:1 we see the flow of the Triune God. This is a picture of the Triune God dispensing Himself into us. He is flowing Himself out of Himself into His redeemed ones. This dispensing of the Triune God into us comes out of God’s administrating throne. This means that God’s dispensation depends on His administration. This is true in the church life today. The dispensing of the life supply and of God’s all-sufficient grace issues out of the throne of God’s administration. Eventually, in the New Jerusalem this dispensing will reach every part of the city, and the entire city will be filled, saturated, and permeated with the Triune God. In this way the city will express God.

When I was young, I could not understand Revelation 22:1. I read about a throne and a river, but I had no idea what these things meant. At that time I did not even realize that the river was a spiral. Because I did not see anything, I could not understand anything. Gradually, through the experiences of more than forty years, I have come to understand the meaning of the river of water of life proceeding out of the throne of the redeeming God. Through my experience I saw that whenever I submitted to my redeeming God, willing to take Him as my head, I immediately sensed something living flowing within me. This was not a teaching or an interpretation; it was altogether an experience. One day I could say, “Now I understand Revelation 22:1. I do have a throne within me. Because I submit myself to the authority and headship of this throne, I have something flowing within.” This picture of the river of water of life flowing out of the throne of the redeeming God shows us that we must take our redeeming God as our head and as our authority and submit to His headship. If we do this, His throne is established in our spirit and even throughout our entire being. Out of this established throne, the life-giving Spirit flows within us. This throne is the center of God’s administration with His headship for the dispensing of Himself into all His redeemed that we may be saturated and permeated with Himself to be His very expression.

2. Flowing in the middle of its street

This river of water of life flows in the middle of the street of New Jerusalem. The street of the holy city is gold (21:21), which symbolizes the divine nature. The river of water of life proceeding in the middle of the street signifies that the divine life flows in the divine nature as the unique way for the daily life of God’s redeemed people. Where the divine life flows, there is the divine nature as the holy way by which His people walk; and where the holy way of the divine nature is, there the divine life is flowing. The divine life and the divine nature as the holy way always go together. Thus, the river of water of life is available along this divine way, and we enjoy it by walking in the divine way.

3. Bright as crystal

Verse 1 also says that the river of water of life is bright as crystal. The fact that the water of life is bright as crystal means that it has no dimness or opaqueness. When this water of life flows in us, it purifies us and makes us transparent. Nothing is more clear than the flow of life within us. Suppose you are shopping in a department store. Whenever you say “Amen” to the inner regulation of the divine life, you will not only be strengthened, watered, and refreshed; you will also become crystal clear. You will be clear not only about one item, but about virtually everything.

The more the water of life flows within us, the more it carries away those things that veil our sight. It gives us clear insight, and it makes our being, our situation, and everything related to us crystal clear. Many Christians have been told that they can know God's will by reading the Scriptures. In the past I tried to know God's will in this way. But the more of the Scriptures I read, the more blind I became, because in my reading of the Bible I exercised my mentality to analyze what the Scriptures were saying or what they were telling me to do. A great many of us have had the same kind of experience. The more we analyzed the Bible, the more blind we were. Instead of trying to know God's will by analyzing the Scriptures, we should say, "Lord Jesus, I love You and I submit myself to Your headship and authority. Lord, establish Your throne in my entire being." If you do this, you will immediately enjoy the inner flow, and this flow will make you crystal clear in the divine life. Everything related to you, your situation, and your condition will become transparent. Our experience testifies that this is true.

Many young people are very concerned about the matter of marriage and want to know the Lord's will regarding this matter. Firstly, they pray about it, asking the Lord to show them the one He has prepared for them. Then they come to the elders for fellowship. The elders may give them a number of principles regarding age, education, race, family background, disposition, and spirituality. More than forty years ago, I was an expert in giving out principles such as these. Whenever a young person consulted me about marriage, I always pointed out these matters for his consideration. If he were from the north, I would even advise him not to marry a person from the south because of the differences between them. Furthermore, I would encourage him to marry a person with a similar disposition. If he had a quick disposition, I would tell him not to marry a sister with a slow disposition. In the past, I was rather persuasive, and the young people agreed with me. However, when we were in the actual situation, we found that analyzing merely according to the principles did not work. The more we analyzed merely according to age, education, race, disposition, and spirituality, the more veiled we were. After a number of years, the Lord showed me that the way to know His will concerning marriage is not to analyze in this way. Rather, it is simply to submit yourself to His headship and let His flow move within you. The more His flow moves within you, the more crystal clear you will become. We all must submit ourselves to the Lord and walk the golden way of the divine nature. There is only one way — the golden way. We must submit to the headship of Christ and say, "Lord Jesus, You are my head and my sovereign Lord. I submit myself to You." What an inner flow there is when we do this! And what an inner supply! Immediately, the flow makes us clear, and we are assured of the Lord's will. When we do this, we shall be able to say, "There is no veil upon my eyes. Every veil has been taken away, and I am clear. The whole situation is crystal clear to my sight." This is not a teaching; it is an experience. Only by experience can you understand this.

4. Absolutely free

The water of the river of water of life is absolutely free (Rev. 22:17; 21:6). There is no need for us to pay anything in order to drink of it. Although the water of life is free, it is free only on the divine way. It is not available anywhere else. Thus, we must come to the divine way in order to partake of the living water. Although you do not need to pay anything for the water of life, you do need to get on the golden street. Therefore, whoever desires to receive this free gift of the water of life must repent. To repent means to change your mind, to have a change in concept regarding your life. Even Christians need to have a change in their concept regarding their Christian walk. We must turn from everything that is not the golden street and come to the golden street. This is the true meaning of repentance. After we have turned from everything else to the golden street, we can take the water of life freely. We all can testify from our experience that this is so.

B. The tree of life

Verse 2 says, "And on this side and on that side of the river was the tree of life." The one tree of life growing on the two sides of the river signifies that the tree of life is a vine, spreading and proceeding along the flow of the water of life for God's people to receive and enjoy. It fulfills, for eternity, what God intended from the beginning (Gen. 2:9). The tree of life was closed to man due to his fall (Gen. 3:22-24), but opened to believers by the redemption of Christ (Heb. 10:19-20). Today the enjoyment of Christ as the tree of life is the believers' common portion (John 6:35, 57). In the millennial kingdom the overcoming believers will enjoy Christ as the tree of life as their reward (Rev. 2:7). Eventually, in the new heaven and new earth, for eternity, all God's redeemed will enjoy Christ as the tree of life as their eternal portion (Rev. 22:14, 19).

1. Christ as the life supply

The tree of life is Christ as our life supply. Firstly, Christ was the Lamb of God for our redemption (John 1:29) and then the tree of life for our life supply (John 6:35). Christ's redemption is for imparting Himself into us as the life supply. He is not only the Lamb of God, but also the tree of life.

2. Growing on the two sides of the river of life

The tree of life grows on the two sides of the river of life. It does not go up, but spreads like a vine. Hence, it is available along the flow of the water of life. Christ, as the tree of life, is the life supply available along the flow of the Spirit as the water of life. Where the Spirit flows, there the life supply of Christ is found. This is all in and with the divine nature as our holy way, as signified by the street. This is both the supply of the holy city and the way the city is supplied.

It took me years to understand three things mentioned in verses 1 and 2: the street, the river, and the tree of life. In the midst of the street is the river; hence, the street spontaneously becomes the two banks of the river. The tree of life grows as a vine on the banks of the river. Only when I had the adequate experience was I able to understand these things. The street, the river, and the tree are all interrelated. After you enter through the pearl gate and get on the golden street, you immediately have the flowing river. Along the flow of the living water is the tree of life. This picture is very clear.

Let us now apply this picture to our daily living. Suppose a certain sister goes shopping in a department store. Even before she enters the store, the divine nature as the inner street begins to regulate her. There is no word, just an inward regulating. The sister enters the store and picks up a certain item. The inward regulating says, "Drop it," but she excuses herself, telling herself that it is all right to buy that article this time and that she will not do it again. However, from that moment, the inner flow stops. After the sister comes home, she finds that she is not able to pray. Although she tries to open her mouth and say something to the Lord, no words come out of her inward being. This is a negative illustration of what happens when we do not follow the inward regulation of the divine nature.

Let us now consider a positive illustration. Suppose when the inward regulation tells this sister not to buy that particular article, she says, "Amen, Lord, amen." Immediately, she will find herself walking on the golden street. At the same time, she will sense that the inner flow is intensified and strengthened. She will also sense that the inner flow brings her the rich supply of life. This is the enjoyment of the tree of life. After that, she probably will have no further desire to stay in the store. As she leaves the store, she may even feel like singing or shouting hallelujah. This is what it means to walk on the golden street, to partake of the flowing river, and to enjoy all the riches of the tree of life.

It is difficult to understand the golden street, the water of life, and the tree of life if we approach them in a doctrinal way. But if we consider our experience, it is quite easy to understand them. Whenever we submit our entire being to the headship of the redeeming God, His throne is set up within us. Out of this throne flows the river of life. This river of life flows in the midst of the golden street, and along this flowing river there is the tree of life, which is a vine growing along the river as our rich life supply. The throne is here, waiting for us to submit to the headship and authority of the redeeming God. As soon as we submit to this headship, the life-giving Spirit immediately flows within us, and we find ourselves on the golden street. As we walk along the golden street, we find that the inward flowing of the life-giving Spirit is marvelous, refreshing, satisfying, and supplying. It would take a great many words to adequately describe this flow within us. Along this flow of the living water there are the riches of the tree of life that grows by the flow of the river. This means that where the flow of the river is, there is the tree of life to supply us. In my experience I have a throne, the flowing of the water of life, and Christ as the tree of life growing within me in a very practical way. This is not a doctrinal understanding; it is absolutely a matter of experience in life.

3. Producing twelve fruits

Verse 2 also says that the tree of life produces twelve fruits, yielding its fruit each month. The fruits of the tree of life will be the food of God's redeemed for eternity. They will be continually fresh, produced every month, twelve fruits yearly.

The fact that there are twelve fruits means that the fruit of the tree of life is rich and sufficient for the completion in God's eternal administration. Remember the significance of the number twelve: it is completion in God's administration for His economy eternally. Thus, the twelve fruits are for the eternal completion in God's administration for His economy.

The mention of "each month" indicates that in the new heaven and new earth the moon will still be there to divide the twelve months. The sun will also be there to separate day and night into periods of twelve hours each. Although the number which represents the church is seven, signifying that God is added to man, His creature, in His present dispensation, twelve is the number of the New Jerusalem, signifying that God is mingled with man in His eternal administration. In the New Jerusalem are the twelve foundations with the names of the twelve apostles, twelve gates which are the twelve pearls with the names of the twelve tribes, and twelve fruits of the tree of life. As far as space is concerned, the city proper is twelve thousand stadia, one thousand times twelve, in three dimensions, and its wall is one hundred forty-four cubits, which is twelve times twelve. As for time, in the new heaven and new earth, there are twelve months yearly, twelve hours daily, and twelve hours nightly.

4. Enjoyed by all God's redeemed

All God's redeemed will enjoy the tree of life for eternity (22:14). Our enjoyment of the tree of life is for God's administration. God redeemed us to enjoy the tree of life, and this enjoyment is for God's administration of His eternal economy.

5. Its leaves being for the healing of the nations

Verse 2 also says, "And the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations." In the Bible, leaves are a symbol of man's deeds (Gen. 3:7). According to the record of the Bible, the first time man used leaves was to make a covering for himself. The leaves of the tree of life symbolize the deeds of Christ. The regenerated believers eat the fruit of the tree of life, receiving Christ as their life and life supply inwardly, that they may enjoy the divine life for eternity; whereas the restored nations are healed by the leaves of the tree of life, taking the deeds of Christ as their guide and regulation outwardly, that they may live the human life forever. When the nations look at the way the Lord Jesus does things and behaves Himself, His deeds will become a source of healing to them, and this healing will maintain their human life forever.

XX. Its reign

Those in New Jerusalem "shall reign forever and ever" (22:5). The New Jerusalem will reign over the nations under its shining. Revelation 21:24 says, "And the nations shall walk by its light." At the end of this age a great part of the inhabitants of the earth will be killed during the time of the sixth and seventh trumpets. The rest will be judged by Christ at the throne of His glory when He comes back to earth. The condemned ones, the "goats," will be cursed to perish in the lake of fire, while the justified ones, the "sheep," will be blessed to inherit the kingdom prepared for them from the foundation of the world (Matt. 25:31-46). They will not be saved and regenerated as the New Testament believers; they will only be restored to the original state of man as created by God. They will be the nations as citizens of the millennial kingdom, in which the overcoming believers will be kings (20:4, 6) and the saved remnant of Israel will be priests (Zech. 8:20-23). After the millennial kingdom, a part of these nations, deceived by the Devil, will rebel against the Lord and will be consumed by fire from heaven (20:7-9). The rest will be transferred to the new earth as the nations, living around the New Jerusalem and walking by its light. They will be the peoples mentioned in 21:3 and 4. They, as the created but unregenerated man, will be maintained to live forever in their created state by the healing of the leaves of the tree of life. Even to them there will be no more death (21:4). Under the shining of the New Jerusalem with the divine glory, neither will they be in darkness.

Revelation 21:24 also says of New Jerusalem that "the kings of the earth bring their glory into it." The kings of the earth here are the kings of the nations in the new earth. The redeemed and regenerated saints will be kings over these kings (22:5), and Christ will be the King of kings for eternity. The glory of the nations will be their choice produce (Gen. 31:1, 16; Esth. 1:4), and their honor will be their preciousness in condition and their dignity in position.

The Enjoyment and Blessing of God's Redeemed in Eternity

The basic numbers in New Jerusalem are the numbers twelve and one. One is the unique number. There is one God, one city, one throne, one street, one river, and one tree of life. Hence, the number one is the basic number of the church and of God's building in His economy. This is not my concept; it is Paul's concept in Ephesians 4:3-6, where he speaks of one Body, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, and one God and Father. We have just one God, one throne, one administration, one authority, one flow, one way, and one tree. If we have seen this, we shall be kept forever in this oneness.

This oneness issues from the unique God, the One who is the source of everything. The throne, the river, the street, and the tree all issue out of Him. He is the unique source of everything to produce, support, sustain, and keep the unique building of the one God.

The situation of today's Christianity is vastly different from this. Christianity is filled with confusion and division. There are thousands of divisions in today's Christianity. No one knows how many divisions have taken place in the so-called free groups. In the free groups nearly everybody claims to be something. How we thank the Lord that He has opened our eyes and shown us His unique way! We have nothing other than the unique God on the unique throne with the unique flow with the unique life supply. Therefore, we have one testimony and we are in one church.

The church is constituted of both divinity and humanity; it is one corporate entity of both God and man. This entity is both God's dwelling and our abode, for now we abide in God, and God abides in us. The church life today is a miniature of the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and new earth. We in the church can testify that we are truly one. We are one in God, one in His authority, one in His expression, one in the flow, one in the life, and one in the tree. In this oneness we abide in God, God abides in us, and thus we become His testimony.

I. The holy city

In this message we shall cover the enjoyment and blessing of God's redeemed in eternity. The first crucial item of our enjoyment in eternity will be the holy city (Rev. 22:14, 19). Revelation 22:19 says, "And if anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God shall take away his part from the tree of life and out of the holy city, which are written in this book." This indicates that having a part in the holy city means a great deal to us.

The holy city in which we shall participate and which we shall enjoy is God mingled with all His saints. In this one entity, the holy city, we shall not only enjoy God; we shall also enjoy God in all the saints. We shall enjoy God in one another, and we shall enjoy one another in God. I shall enjoy you in God, and you will enjoy me in God. Although this enjoyment is rather mysterious, we have a foretaste of it in the church life today, where we enjoy God in one another and one another in God. What a divine, heavenly communal life this is!

Man was created by God with the desire for a communal life. Our human nature longs for a community life. In order to fulfill this desire, people attend nightclubs and parties. However, nightclubs and parties cannot meet this need. Although people hunger and thirst for a proper communal life, they are poisoned by the clubs and parties of the world. Instead of receiving the proper drink to quench their thirst, they are poisoned. There is only one kind of party that is pure, happy, nourishing, enlightening, satisfying, and edifying, and that is the church. Day after day, we in the church life are attending a heavenly party. This party is holy, divine, and spiritual. It is the party of God mingled with man. What an enjoyment it is to attend this party!

Through my experience in the church life of nearly fifty years, I have come to know the disposition of the young people. Young people are sharp and quite demanding, and they can pierce into the hearts of their parents or of the elders in the church. All the elders are targets for the arrows of the young people. Often I have said to some of these sharp young people, "If the church and the elders are not pleasant in your eyes, why don't you go off somewhere, to the mountains, perhaps, and live by yourselves? Then you will no longer be troubled by the church or the elders." They replied that because they enjoy the fellowship in the church life, they would never leave the church.

Our desire for a communal life cannot be fully satisfied even by our married life or family life. You may have many brothers, sisters, cousins, nieces, nephews, and other relatives, but they cannot satisfy your inward desire for a community life. This desire, a desire for the church life and a desire created by God, can be satisfied only in the church.

We Christians are like sheep flocking together. Years ago I observed some flocks of sheep in Scotland. I noticed that the sheep enjoyed flocking together. They traveled together, ate together, and lay down together. They were always together as a flock. We Christians also have such a desire, the desire for the church life.

How we enjoy God in the church life! Some may say, "God is omnipresent, and I can enjoy Him anywhere. I can enjoy Him at home or on the street. I don't need the church life to enjoy God." We can testify that there is no comparison between the enjoyment of God in the church and the enjoyment of God apart from the church. Yes, you may enjoy God anywhere, but not in the way we enjoy Him in the church. In the church life we are beside ourselves with the enjoyment of the Lord. The church life is a life of God mingled with man. In this wonderful mingled life, we daily enjoy God in all the dear saints, and we enjoy the dear saints in God. This enjoyment is the first aspect of our eternal portion in the holy city. The enjoyment of this city, which is a composition of God mingled with all the saints, is our eternal portion. In this holy city God and the Lamb will be our dwelling for rest (21:3). In the holy city we also enjoy God and the Lamb as our temple for serving and worshipping God (21:22).

II. The tree of life

The second item of our enjoyment in eternity is the tree of life (22:14, 19). The tree of life is nothing less than Christ, the Son of God, the redeeming Lamb, as our life supply. This tree is rich, fresh, and refreshing. We have been redeemed that we may have the right to come to the tree of life.

Revelation 22:14 says, "Blessed are those who wash their robes, that they may have right to the tree of life, and may enter by the gates into the city." This verse may be considered a promise for the enjoyment of the tree of life, which is Christ with all the riches of life; and the second half of verse 17 may be considered a call to take the water of life, which is the life-giving Spirit. Thus, the book of Revelation ends in a promise and a call, both of which are for eating the all-inclusive Christ and drinking Him as the life-giving Spirit.

After his creation, man was put before the tree of life (Gen. 2:8-9), indicating that he was privileged to partake of it. But due to the fall of man, the tree of life was closed to man by God's glory, holiness, and righteousness (Gen. 3:24). Through Christ's redemption, which has fulfilled all the requirements of God's glory, holiness, and righteousness, the way to the tree of life is opened again to believers (Heb. 10:19-20). Hence, the believers who wash their robes in the redeeming blood of Christ have the right to enjoy the tree of life as their eternal portion in the holy city, the paradise of God in eternity (2:7).

In this verse, robes symbolize the conduct of the believers. To wash our robes is to keep our conduct clean through the washing of the blood of the Lamb (7:14; 1 John 1:7). This gives us the right to participate in the tree of life and to enter into the city. To enter in by the gates into the city is to enter into the New Jerusalem as a realm of God's eternal blessing by regeneration through the death-overcoming and life-imparting Christ. Both the tree of life and the city will be our enjoyment in eternity.

III. The water of life

Another aspect of the enjoyment and blessing of God's redeemed in eternity is the water of life (22:17; 21:6). The water of life is the life-giving Spirit as our eternal drink. We need both to eat and to drink. It is not so pleasant to eat without having anything to drink. Hallelujah, in eternity we shall have food, the tree of life, and drink, the life-giving Spirit! Remember, the life-giving Spirit is actually the Triune God Himself flowing Himself out to be our drink.

Because many Christians hold a mistaken concept derived from traditional teachings, they think that the Spirit is separate from the Son and the Father. To them, the Spirit is merely the Spirit. But John 15:26 says, "But when the Comforter comes, whom I will send to you from the Father, the Spirit of reality who proceeds from the Father, He will testify concerning Me." The sense of the Greek preposition translated "from" is "from with." The Spirit of reality is sent by the Son not only from the Father, but also with the Father. Hence, the Comforter comes from the Father and with the Father. The Father is the source. When the Spirit comes from the source, He does not leave the source; the source comes with Him. The Spirit comes from the Father, and the Father comes with the Spirit. This Spirit, sent by the Son and coming with the Father, testifies concerning the Son. Therefore, His testimony concerning the Son is a matter of the Triune God.

Although this is difficult to explain, it is easy to understand if we consider our experience. When we call, “O Lord Jesus,” we receive the Spirit. But when the Spirit comes, we have the deep sense that the Father and the Son have also come. This indicates that this Spirit is the all-inclusive Spirit. When He comes into us, He comes with the Son and the Father. Therefore, our eternal drink, the life-giving Spirit, is nothing less than the Triune God. What an enjoyment this is! If we devote our attention to mere doctrinal understanding, we shall miss this enjoyment. But if we care for the genuine experience in our spirit, we shall say, “Now I understand that the very drink I enjoy is the Triune God flowing into my being.”

This eternal drink is bright as crystal (22:1). In the life-giving Spirit there is nothing opaque. As we drink of this eternal Spirit, everything becomes crystal clear.

IV. The throne of God and of the Lamb

In eternity we shall also enjoy the throne of God and the Lamb (22:3). It is difficult to determine whether the throne of God in Revelation 21 and 22 is the throne of authority or the throne of grace. In Hebrews 4 the throne is the throne of grace, but in Revelation 4 the throne is mainly the throne of authority. At the end of the Bible, the throne is both the throne of authority and the throne of grace. We know this by the picture in chapter twenty-two. Here the throne of God and the Lamb is certainly for God’s divine administration. Thus, it is the throne of authority. However, proceeding out of the throne is not authority, but the river of water of life, with the tree of life as the life supply. This is not authority; it is grace.

We should never separate authority from grace or grace from authority. Grace and authority are one. If we have grace, we are under authority, and if we are under authority, we are surely partaking of grace. Although it is true that, as Christians, we need to reign, we should not reign by authority. Rather, we should reign through the flow of life. The elders should not exercise their eldership by means of authority. The eldership, that is, the representation of the headship, must be exercised through the flow of life. Although the throne is the throne of authority, the throne of headship, out of the throne flows the river of water of life. When you look at the throne, you see authority and headship. But when you look at the river, you see the water of life and the tree of life. This indicates that proper eldership is not the exercise of authority over others; it is the flowing of life into them. We are reigning, but we do not reign by authority; we reign through the flowing of the inner life.

Today the Lord Jesus does not reign merely with authority. He is reigning in the church, among the churches, and over all the churches through the flowing of His life as grace. The more we partake of His life, the more authority we have. The ones whom you respect in the church life are those who are mature in life. However, no one who assumes authority will be respected. Deep in the spirits of the saints there is no respect for that kind of eldership. Life is the very expression of authority. Instead of assuming authority, we need to live out Christ. The very Christ whom we live out will be our authority over others. We shall enjoy this kind of authority for eternity. The throne, the source of the life supply with the divine authority, will be our eternal enjoyment.

V. No more curse

In eternity “there shall no longer be any curse.” Instead of the curse, the throne of God and the Lamb will be our eternal portion. The curse came in through Adam’s fall (Gen. 3:17) and was dealt with by Christ’s redemption (Gal. 3:13). Since in the new heaven and new earth there will be no more fall, there will no longer be any curse.

Not many Christians understand all that the curse includes. Things such as hatred, criticism, and gossip are included in the curse. If anyone in the church in Anaheim still gossips, this means that the church is still under a small, subtle curse. If the brothers and sisters criticize one another, that also is a sign that the church is under the curse. Furthermore, if some saints are weak to the extent that they are deadened, that is a mark of the curse. For there to be no more curse means that there is no longer any gossip, hatred, criticism, weakness, or deadness. When there is no curse, everything is smooth, pleasant, strong, and living.

I do not like to be present in any home where a husband is exchanging words with his wife. Whenever I overhear such an argument, I flee because I do not want to share in the curse. I do not want to see the curse, touch the curse, or be under the curse. If I witnessed such an argument, it would be difficult to forget the impression it made on me. Each time I saw that brother and sister I would be reminded of their quarrel. A number of times, as I was approaching the home of a brother and sister, I overheard an argument between them. Immediately, I turned away and did not come back until everything had become silent. Then I knocked on the door and was greeted with a pleasant, “Praise the Lord! Amen!” This is wonderful. I certainly enjoy being with a husband and wife who are praising the Lord. I would like the impression made by their praises to linger with me forever.

Have you ever realized how much the curse includes? Have you ever thought that “no more curse” includes no more exchange of words? When there is no curse, everything is smooth, pleasant, living, bright, pure, and perfect. When we are in New Jerusalem, we shall participate in this great blessing. However, we all long to be able to say that in the church life today there is no longer any curse. May this be the situation in all the local churches.

VI. Serving God and the Lamb

Revelation 22:3 also says, “His slaves shall serve Him.” To serve God and the Lamb will also be a blessing to God’s redeemed in eternity. The pronoun “Him” in this verse refers to God and the Lamb; God and the Lamb are one in eternity. It is the same with “His” in the next verse.

Although God’s redeemed will serve God and the Lamb in eternity, they will not serve Him as priests. Strictly speaking, in the new heaven and new earth there will be no priests. There will be service, but there will be no priesthood. Priestly service always includes the aspect of redemption. Because in the new heaven and the new earth there will no longer be the problem of sin, there will be no need for any redeeming work. Hence, there will be no priestly service there. Nevertheless, we shall still be the servants of God and of the Lamb, and we shall serve Him for eternity.

VII. Seeing the face of God

Verse 4 says, “And they shall see His face.” This also is a blessing to God’s redeemed in eternity. The “His” in this verse refers to both God and the Lamb. Seeing His face means seeing the face of God and the Lamb.

VIII. Having the name of God and the Lamb on their forehead

God’s redeemed will have the name of God and the Lamb on their forehead (v. 4). This is still another blessing of God’s redeemed in eternity. We shall not have two names; we shall have just one name, the name of God and the Lamb. This is similar to Matthew 28:19, which speaks of being baptized into the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. In eternity both God and the Lamb will have one name. Because we belong to Him, this name will be written on our foreheads forever. Not only shall we belong to Him; we shall also be one with Him.

IX. God illumining them

Verse 5 says, “And night shall be no more; and they have no need of the light of a lamp and the light of the sun, for the Lord God shall illumine them.” Being illumined by the Lord God is another blessing to God’s redeemed in eternity. We shall have no need of a lamp, the light made by man, nor of the sun, the light created by God. God Himself will shine upon us, and we shall live under His illumination.

X. Reigning forever

Verse 5 also says, “And they shall reign forever and ever.” To reign forever will be the final blessing to God’s redeemed in eternity. These are the blessings we shall enjoy for eternity in the new heaven and the new earth.

The Conclusion

Rev. 22:6-21 is the conclusion of this book. In this message we shall consider the various items found in this conclusion.

Verse 6 says, "And he said to me, These words are faithful and true; and the Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, sent His angel to show to His slaves the things which must swiftly take place." The Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, who sent His angel to show the things in this book, is the Lord Jesus (Rev. 1:1; 22:16). Verse 16 says, "I Jesus have sent Mine angel to testify to you these things for the churches." The testimony of this book was given by the Lord Jesus for the churches. Hence, to comprehend and keep it, we need to be in the churches and for the churches.

In this book the Lord God is called the God of the spirits of the prophets. This indicates that all the prophecies in this book are inspired by the very God who inspired the spirits of the prophets in both the Old and New Testaments. It also indicates that these prophecies are related to those in the Old and New Testaments, all of which were spoken by the prophets in their spirit under the inspiration of God. Hence, to comprehend these prophecies, we also need to be in our spirit under God's anointing.

I. Warning that the Lord is coming soon

In verses 7, 12, and 20 we have the warning that the Lord is coming soon. In each of these verses the Lord Jesus said, "I come quickly." This is the Lord's warning. If we take heed to this warning, we shall be blessed; otherwise, we shall forfeit the blessing. Do not think that because the Lord has been tolerating the situation for more than nineteen centuries, He is slow to come back. Look at the world situation today. We do not know what will happen within the next few days. In this age, things happen very quickly. Therefore, we must pray and be watchful. We must also be prepared in spirit and in our daily life. May the Lord cover us that we may be a watchful, praying, and prepared people.

II. Blessing of keeping the words of the prophecy of this book

In verse 7 the Lord also says, "Blessed is he who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book." Here the Lord tells us clearly that if we keep the words of this prophecy, we shall be blessed. The Lord spoke a very similar word in 1:3. There He said, "Blessed is he who reads and those who hear the words of the prophecy and keep what is written in it." This book was written mainly for the blessing of God upon His people. Whether or not we shall share in this blessing depends upon how we deal with the words in this book. We must take these words and keep them. Those who do so will be blessed.

III. Warning not to seal the prophecy of this book

Verse 10 says, "And he said to me, Do not seal the words of the prophecy of this book, for the time is near." Daniel's prophecies were sealed, because they were given long before the time of the end, whereas the prophecies of this book should not be sealed because the time is near. Instead of being sealed, the book of Revelation should be constantly open to us and to others. For centuries, however, this book was closed and, along with the rest of the Bible, kept away from the people by the Roman Catholic Church. Through Martin Luther the Bible was made available to the people, but not much of it was opened to them. Having read through all the messages of this life-study, we can no longer say that the book of Revelation is closed to us. This book has truly been opened to the saints. Therefore, do not let this book be sealed to you or to others. Rather, you must keep the book open by plunging into every aspect of this prophecy and by diving into the flow. The more we live in the word of this book, the more open it will be to us. If we do this, the book of Revelation will be kept open to us, our family, and all the people around us.

Verse 11 says, "He who does unrighteousness, let him still do unrighteousness; and he who is filthy, let him still be made filthy; and he who is righteous, let him still do righteousness; and he who is holy, let him still be made holy." Whether anyone is unrighteous or righteous, filthy or holy, is a serious matter in the age of this book. To be righteous is to walk according to the righteous ways of God outwardly, whereas to be holy is to live according to the holy nature of God inwardly. In the age of this book, we must walk and live in this way that we may receive the reward; otherwise, we shall be condemned as unrighteous and filthy and receive punishment at the Lord's coming back (v. 12).

Anyone who hardens himself and who does not keep this book open to himself or himself open to this book will remain in his pitiful condition. If he is unrighteous and filthy, he will remain unrighteous and filthy. However, if you are righteous and holy and keep yourself open to this book and this book open to you, you will continue to be righteous and holy. This means that if you keep this word open to you, you will continually become more holy and righteous. But if you do not keep it open, you will become more unrighteous and more filthy, remaining in that pitiful situation until the time of judgment comes.

IV. Warning concerning the Lord's reward

Verse 12 says, "Behold, I come quickly, and My reward is with Me to render to each one according to his work." "I come quickly" is the Lord's repeated warning that we may consider His reward at His coming back. The Greek word translated reward means "wages." At the Lord's coming, this reward will be rendered to each one of the believers, after their rapture, at the judgment seat of Christ (2 Cor. 5:10; 1 Cor. 4:5; Rom. 14:10; Matt. 16:27).

Verse 13 says, "I am the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the beginning and the end." This is the Lord's declaration at the close of this book, corresponding to what God declared in the opening of this book (1:8). This indicates that the Lord Jesus is the very God. The very Lord whom we serve is the Alpha and the Omega. He is the first letter, the last letter, and all the letters in between. This means that He is able and qualified to accomplish all that is spoken concerning Him in this book. We should not excuse ourselves and say, "This vision is marvelous, but it is too high for me. I cannot attain it." The Lord is the Alpha and the Omega to back up and to carry out His word. We must exercise our entire being to believe in His word. Do not look at yourself, reckon on yourself, or consider yourself. We all are nothing. If we look at ourselves, we shall not be able to do anything. Therefore, we must turn our eyes to Him, set our eyes upon Him, and believe in His word. No matter how far beyond us His word is, we must say "Amen" to whatever He says. Whenever we say "Amen" to His word, we are strengthened and we have a living faith. Faith is not derived from us; it originates with Him. If we look away from all things unto Him, we shall enjoy Him as our Alpha, as our Omega, and as our everything. And He will certainly accomplish everything He has promised in this book. All we need to do is exercise faith in Him.

According to verse 13, the Lord Jesus is not only the First, but also the beginning, not only the Last, but also the end. The first indicates that none is before Him, and the last, that none is after Him, whereas the beginning means that He is the origination of all things, and the end, that He is the consummation of all things. Hence, the indication here is not only that there is nothing before or after the Lord Jesus, but also that there is neither origination nor consummation without Him. This assures us that the Lord is strong to promise, encourage, and strengthen us. He will accomplish whatever He has spoken in this book.

Because the Lord is everything to us and because He is so strong, we should not excuse ourselves and say, "Oh, I am weak, my family situation is difficult, and my environment is against me." The more difficult our environment, the richer the Lord will be to us. The more trying our circumstances, the stronger the Lord will be to us. We must exercise our faith in this all-inclusive One, the One who is the Alpha, the Omega, the First, the Last, the beginning, and the end. With Him, there are no problems. Thus, we need to dive into Him, believe in Him, and rest in Him.

V. Giving promise concerning the tree of life and the holy city

In verses 14 and 19 we have the Lord's promises related to the tree of life and the holy city. The tree of life is for life supply, and the holy city is for dwelling and serving.

VI. Warning concerning the perdition of the sinners

Verse 15 says, “Outside are the dogs and the sorcerers and the fornicators and the murderers and the idolaters and everyone who loves and makes a lie.” “Outside” means outside the city, where the lake of fire keeps all the perished sinners. All the filthy, sinful persons will be cast into the lake of fire, the universal “trash can.” We all must be warned by this.

VII. Testifying that the Lord is the Root and Offspring of David and the bright morning star

In verse 16 Jesus says, “I am the Root and the Offspring of David, the bright morning star.” In His divinity, Christ is the Root of David, his source; in His humanity, He is the Offspring of David, his issue. Hence, He is both the Lord as the Root and the seed, the branch of David, as the Offspring (Matt. 22:42-45; Rom. 1:3; Jer. 23:5).

At His coming back, Christ will be the Sun to His people generally (Mal. 4:2), but the morning star to His watching lovers particularly. This will be a reward to the overcomers (2:28). Christ as the Root and Offspring of David is related to Israel and the kingdom, whereas His being the bright morning star is related to the church and the rapture. The morning star appears before the darkest hour, prior to dawn. The great tribulation will be this darkest hour, after which the day of the kingdom will dawn. In the kingdom, the Lord will appear publicly to His people as the Sun, but before the great tribulation, He will appear privately to His overcomers as the morning star.

VIII. The Spirit and the bride responding to the Lord's word

Verse 17 says, “And the Spirit and the bride say, Come! Let him who hears also say, Come! Let him who is thirsty also come; he who wills, let him take the water of life freely.” In chapters two and three it was the Spirit speaking to the churches; here, at the end of the book, it is the Spirit and the Bride, the church, speaking together as one. This indicates the improvement of the church in experiencing the Spirit.

“Come” is the response of the Spirit and the Bride to the Lord's word in verse 16 and His repeated warning in verses 7 and 12. It is the desire for the Lord's coming. Whosoever hears this response should also say, “Come,” thus expressing a joint desire for the Lord's coming. All believers who love the Lord's appearing (2 Tim. 4:8) should express such a joint desire.

In the verses prior to verse 17 we have the Lord's word. Now in verse 17 the Spirit and the Bride respond to His word. Their response is the desire of their heart for the Lord's coming. The word “Come!” spoken by the Spirit and the Bride is certainly spoken to the Lord. The fact that the Spirit and the Bride speak as one indicates that they have become one. In chapters two and three the Spirit is the speaker, and the churches were the receivers of the speaking of the Spirit. But at the end of the book the Spirit and the Bride, the Bride and Spirit, have become one. The church is no longer merely the receiver of the divine oracle; she has also become one with the divine Speaker.

The word come is found three times in this verse. The first occurrence of this word refers to the coming back of the Lord Jesus. As we have seen, this is uttered by the Spirit and the Bride. However, the one who hears the Spirit and the Bride say this joins in saying, “Come!” The Spirit and the Bride, on the one hand, desire that the Lord will come, and on the other hand, yearn that the thirsty sinner will also come to take the water of life for his satisfaction. When we have a sincere desire for the Lord's coming, we also have an earnest concern for the sinners' salvation. Therefore, the third mention of “come” in this verse refers to the coming of the repenting sinners. Whoever is thirsty, let him come to take the water of life freely. Hence, this verse covers three matters: the response of the Spirit and the Bride; the word of the one who hears the declaration of the Spirit and the Bride; and the desire for the thirsty sinner, the unsaved one, to come and drink of the water of life.

Verse 17 strongly implies that if we have a desire for the Lord's coming back, we shall be very concerned for others' salvation. Do you desire the coming back of the Lord Jesus? If you do, this desire will stir up a concern within you for the salvation of others. As you are saying, “Come, Lord Jesus,” a burden may rise up within you for your parents, your cousins, your neighbors, your schoolmates, and your friends. After you have read all these messages, you may have a strong desire for the Lord's coming back. I am fully assured that this desire will cause you to be concerned about others' salvation. You will say to the Lord, “Come,” and you will turn to the unbelievers and say, “The Lord Jesus is coming. Will you not come also? Come and be saved. Come to receive your salvation that you may be prepared to meet the coming Savior.” Our experience testifies that this is the proper understanding of verse 17.

IX. The call concerning the water of life

Verse 17 also says, “He who wills, let him take the water of life freely.” This is a call to the thirsty to drink freely of the water of life. If we compare this verse with verse 14, we shall see that in verse 17 we have a call and in verse 14, a promise. Thus, the book of Revelation is concluded with a promise and a call. The promise is the promise of the tree of life, and the call is the call to the water of life.

X. Warning not to take away from the word of the book of this prophecy

Verses 18 and 19 say, “I testify to every one who hears the words of the prophecy of this book: If anyone adds to them, God shall add to him the plagues which are written in this book; and if anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God shall take away his part from the tree of life and out of the holy city, which are written in this book.” The “I” in verse 18 should be the Lord Jesus, according to verses 16 and 20, or it could refer to John, according to 1:2. In any case, John was one in spirit with the Lord in this solemn warning.

The first aspect of this warning is not to add anything to the words of the prophecy of this book, and the second aspect is not to take away anything from the words of the prophecy. Those who add will receive the plagues that are spoken of in this book, and those who take away will have their part in the tree of life and the holy city taken away from them. The main items of the plagues unveiled in the book of Revelation are the three woes of the great tribulation and the second death, that is, the perishing of the whole man — spirit, soul, and body — in the lake of fire.

The outstanding features of the blessing revealed in the book of Revelation are the tree of life and the holy city. Whether one will suffer the plagues or share in the blessing depends upon how he deals with the prophecy of this book. We should neither add to it nor take away from it. We must receive it as it is written. Do not add your concept, your thought, your idea, your opinion, your doctrine, your teaching, or your theology to this book. Neither should you take anything away from it. If you add to the book, you will suffer woe; and if you take away from it, you will lose the blessings, mainly the blessing of the tree of life and of the holy city. This is a serious warning. If we hear this warning, we shall take the word in this book exactly as it is written.

XI. The writer's desire and prayer concerning the Lord's coming

Verse 20 says, “He who testifies these things says, Yes, I come quickly, Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!” The first part of this verse is the Lord's third warning in this chapter regarding His soon coming. The last part is the apostle John's prayer and response to the Lord's warning. It is also the last prayer in the Bible. After reading this book, we should have such a prayer and response — “Come, Lord Jesus!” This was John's desire expressed as a prayer. Therefore, the whole Bible is concluded with the desire for the Lord's coming expressed as a prayer.

XII. The writer's blessing to all the saints

After this concluding prayer, the writer gives the readers a blessing, saying, “The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all the saints. Amen.” We need this grace in order to receive this book, to keep it, and to live in it. After seeing all the visions and hearing all the prophecies of this book, we still need the Lord's grace. Only the grace of the Lord Jesus can enable us to live and walk according to these visions and prophecies. Not only this book, but also the entire Bible, closes with this grace, the grace to experience the all-inclusive Christ and to participate in the Triune God that we may become His eternal corporate expression for the fulfillment of His eternal purpose, that He and we may enjoy absolute satisfaction and complete rest mutually for eternity.

Experiencing the Seven Lamps, the Seven Eyes, and the Seven Spirits

God's building, the New Jerusalem

In eternity past, the unique Triune God, the Father, the Son, and the Spirit, existed by Himself. Gen. 1:26 reveals that God came in to create man in His image. Although man was created in the image of God, at the time of creation, man did not have the life of God in him. As we read through the entire Bible from Gen. 1 to Rev. 22, we see that after many dispensations, generations, and centuries have passed, God will still be there in eternity future. However, He will no longer be by Himself. Although He will still be the Triune God, pictured in 22:1 as God, the Lamb, and the flowing river (the symbol of the Spirit), at that time He will be the center of the New Jerusalem. In eternity past, God was by Himself, but in eternity future, the Triune God will be the center of the New Jerusalem and will saturate the whole city. The portrait of the New Jerusalem in chapters twenty-one and twenty-two is a sign signifying that God will be mingled with His redeemed people as His enlargement. Eventually, this people will be a building. This building, constituted with divinity and humanity, will be a mutual habitation of both God and man. This is the transparent revelation of the Holy Bible.

This revelation includes three main items: the unique God, the created man, and the builded New Jerusalem. These three items cover the whole Bible. When God comes into man, regenerates him, and transforms him, He mingles Himself with man. By mingling Himself with man, God becomes enlarged. The issue of this mingling is the building, the New Jerusalem. Thus, the New Jerusalem as God's building is the mingling of God with the created, redeemed, and regenerated man. We all need to have a vision of this marvelous building.

Brought into God's unchanging building

Recently, a brother testified that since the time he was saved, he has undergone many changes. For a while he would be happy, and then there would be a change. At one point he thought he had come into the victorious life, but then things changed once again. But consider how many changes there have been and will be from the time of Adam until the time of the New Jerusalem. The reason you have experienced so many changes is that you have not yet been brought into God's unchanging building. Until we all have been brought into God's building, we all shall continue to change. Only after we have come into His building will there be no further change. Revelation 3:12 says, "He who overcomes, I will make him a pillar in the temple of My God, and he shall by no means go out anymore." This indicates that only after we have been built into the temple of God shall we cease to change. In the meantime, the more we change, the closer we are to the building. Our eternal destiny is to be in God's building. However, among most Christians today there is no building. Instead, there is continual wandering and shifting.

Thirteen items

In the book of Genesis there are eight important men: Adam, Abel, Enosh, Enoch, Noah, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Eventually, these eight men issued in God's building. In the Old Testament this building was typified by the tabernacle and the temple. In the New Testament we have the reality of the building. Jesus is the tabernacle (John 1:14, Gk.), the church is the temple (1 Cor. 3:16), and the New Jerusalem is the ultimate consummation. Altogether there are thirteen items: the eight men in Genesis, the tabernacle and the temple in type, Jesus and the church in reality, and the New Jerusalem.

The lampstand and the seven lamps

The lampstand was a very crucial item in the tabernacle because it directed people to the ark in the Holy of Holies. Consider the arrangement of the furnishings in the tabernacle and the outer court. Firstly, in the outer court there were the altar and the laver. Then, in the Holy Place, there were the showbread table and the lampstand with seven lamps. The lampstand directed people into the Holy of Holies; it pointed the way to the law of life in the ark of testimony.

If we had only the book of Exodus, we would not be able to understand the significance of the lampstand and its seven lamps. But in Zechariah 3 and 4 the lampstand with its lamps appears again as a development of the lampstand in Exodus 25. In Zechariah 3:9 we have the seven eyes on the stone, and in 4:10 we see that these seven eyes are the eyes of the Lord "which run to and fro through the whole earth." When we put Zechariah 4:10 with Zechariah 4:2, we see that the seven lamps of the lampstand are also the seven eyes of the Lord. Thus, in Zechariah the seven lamps in Exodus are developed into the seven eyes of Jehovah, the Lord. Furthermore, these seven lamps are the seven eyes of the stone. Therefore, in Zechariah the seven lamps are developed into seven eyes, and the lampstand is developed into the stone and into Jehovah, the Lord. Hence, the seven lamps are the seven eyes, and the lampstand is the stone, Jehovah, the Lord. Here we have not only the seven lamps, but also the seven eyes; not only the lampstand, but also the stone, Jehovah. This implies that the seven lamps are the seven eyes and that the lampstand is Jehovah.

The stone in the New Testament

As we have pointed out a number of times, the matter of the stone is developed in the New Testament. In Matthew 16:18 the Lord Jesus said, "And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church." Here the Lord refers to Himself as the rock. In Matthew 21:42 He said, "Have you never read in the scriptures, The stone which the builders rejected, this has become the cornerstone; this was from the Lord, and it is marvelous in our eyes?" The stone referred to here is the very stone with the seven eyes in Zechariah 3:9. Peter spoke of the Lord as this stone in Acts 4:11, where he said, "This is the stone which was despised by you, the builders, which has become the cornerstone." Peter was telling the religionists that they rejected not only their Redeemer, but also the cornerstone of God's building.

A further development of the seven lamps

In Revelation 4 and 5 we have a further development of the seven lamps. According to 4:5, the seven lamps of the lampstand are seven lamps of fire burning before the throne of God. The seven lamps on the lampstand were for enlightening, but the seven lamps before the throne of God are both for enlightening and for the carrying out of God's administrative government. Revelation 5:6 indicates that the seven lamps burning before the throne are also the seven eyes of the Lamb. Thus, the seven eyes are the seven eyes of the stone, the seven eyes of the Lord, and the seven eyes of the Lamb. These seven eyes combine the stone, the Lord, and the Lamb. This indicates that the Lamb is the stone and that the stone is the Lord. Moreover, 5:6 reveals that the seven eyes of the Lamb are the seven Spirits of God. On the one hand, there is a line containing six items: the lampstand, the stone, Jehovah, the Lamb, the throne of God, and God. On the other hand, there is another line with three items: the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits. The lampstand signifies shining, and the stone refers to God's building. Jesus, our Savior, is Jehovah, and the Redeemer is the Lamb. The throne of God indicates God's government, God's administration.

Seven lamps for carrying out God's administration

The lamps are for enlightening, searching, exposing, judging, and burning. All this is for the carrying out of God's administration. Today, God is administering His government by means of enlightening, searching, exposing, judging, and burning. Anything that does not correspond to God's nature will be burned by His fire. Although we have been saved and have undergone some amount of transformation, our work will be burned if it is wood, hay, and stubble and not gold, silver, and precious stone (1 Cor. 3:12-15). Any fleshly work, work done in the name of the Lord but actually having nothing to do with Him, will be burned. Everything that is not of God or according to God, whether it be a so-called church, a Christian work, or even gospel preaching, will be counted by God as wood, hay, and stubble, and it will be burned by fire. This burning is the carrying out of God's administration. The Bible reveals that God is the burning One (Deut. 4:24; Heb. 12:29). All things outside of Him or that do not correspond to His nature will be burned.

Although the seven enlightening, searching, exposing, judging, and burning lamps will burn all that does not correspond to God, they will refine those things that are truly according to His nature. Instead of being burned away, those things will be refined. The dross will go to the lake of fire, but the refined gold will go to the New Jerusalem.

We may be able to hide things from one another, but when the seven lamps shine on us, we are utterly naked and exposed. Then it is no longer possible to hide or cover ourselves. All that we are, do, say, and think is exposed, judged, and burned. If your talk corresponds to God's nature, it will be refined gold. If not, it will be dross. This is the experience of the seven lamps.

Seven eyes for infusing and transfusing

The seven lamps are simultaneously the seven eyes of the Lamb and the stone. The lamps are for enlightening and burning; the eyes are both for watching and observing and also for infusing and transfusing. The seven eyes transfuse all that the Lamb-stone is into our being so that we might be made the same as He. First Peter 2:4 and 5 say, "To whom coming, as unto a living stone, disallowed indeed of men, but chosen of God, and precious, ye also, as living stones, are being built up a spiritual house" (Gk.). The way for us to become living stones is to come to Him and to be seen by Him. As the Lord enlightens and judges us, He looks at us, and His seven eyes transfuse Himself into us. In this way we are transformed.

If we were not saved, it would be a dreadful experience to be enlightened in this way by the Lord's seven lamps. But, as saved ones, it is wonderful to be enlightened in this way. However, if our work and our living are fleshly, not in the spirit, but according to the self, it would be terrifying to be enlightened by the seven lamps, for our living and our work would be exposed and burned by fire. But if we live in the spirit and according to God's nature, the more the seven lamps enlighten us and the more the Lord looks at us, the more we shall be transfused and infused with all He is. This is confirmed by our experience.

Seven Spirits for imparting life

When the seven eyes look at us, transfusing and infusing us with all the Lord is, the seven eyes immediately become the seven Spirits imparting life into us. As the eyes infuse us, the seven Spirits impart life into our whole being. Therefore, the lamps are for enlightening and judging, the eyes are for transfusing and infusing, and the Spirits are for imparting life so that we may be transformed into His image. The more we experience this, the more we are built up together. For this reason, the book of Revelation, which covers God's building in an ultimate way, includes these two chapters unveiling that God's building is accomplished through the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits. We all need to be under the enlightening of the seven lamps, under the beholding of the seven eyes, and under the imparting of life of the seven Spirits. In these days many of us are under the seven lamps, the seven eyes, and the seven Spirits. Praise the Lord for this! I can testify that day by day I am being exposed. Is this not your experience also? But we are also being transfused. I can testify that every day something of the Lord is transfused into me. The issue of this is more growth in life. Do not think that only the young people are growing in life. Although I am an older one, I am still growing because I am daily receiving more life through the life-imparting work of the seven Spirits.

The seven lamps becoming the river of life

Eventually, the seven lamps before the throne become the river of life proceeding out of the throne. In chapter four we have the seven lamps burning before the throne of God, and in chapter twenty-two we have the river of water of life proceeding out of the throne of God. Thus, the seven lamps become one river. According to our experience, the seven Spirits of God are firstly the seven burning lamps. After we receive the burning of the seven lamps, the seven Spirits become one flow. In chapter four we do not yet have the New Jerusalem, for with only the seven lamps there is no building. However, when we see the river proceeding out of the throne to replace the seven lamps, we know that the building has also come. Perhaps yesterday you were under the enlightening and the burning of the seven lamps. But this morning you are in the flow of the water of life. With only the lamps, there was no building; but with the flow, there is the New Jerusalem. When we are in the flow, we are a part of God's building.

According to the book of Revelation, the seven Spirits of God are firstly the lamps burning before God's administrative throne. Eventually, in God's building, these seven Spirits of God become the river of water of life proceeding from the throne. Now this throne is not only the administrative throne, but also the supplying throne. In this way we have the building. The more we are enlightened and receive the burning, the more we are in the flow of life, and the more we are in the flow of life, the more we are built up. This is the way to experience the building. Praise the Lord!